

A SEARCY FAMILY HISTORY

I AM COMING

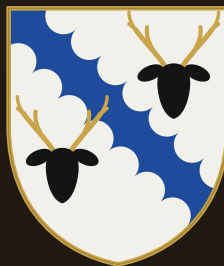


THE COMPLETE TRILOGY

Volume I · England, 1490–1714

Volume II · Virginia and Carolina, 1742–1794

Volume III · She Held the Line, 1832–1920



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DeWayne Lee Searcy

2026

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Prologue

A preface to all three volumes.

Mountain Brook, Alabama — 2026

This book is three books, and it is one book, and the reason it is both is a thing the family did for four hundred and thirty years without ever quite having a word for it.

I began, as the first volume will tell you at length, with a single wrong sentence in a genealogy printed in New York in 1925 — a sentence that gave a woman named Barbara the wrong father and sent everyone who came after looking in the wrong county. I set out to correct one sentence. I ended with this. That is the way of the work: you pull a thread to see where it is anchored, and the whole cloth comes up in your hand, and by the time you have followed it back you are holding not a corrected sentence but a line of people running from a Tudor priory in Hertfordshire to a cleared ridge in north Mississippi, and every one of them, in their own country and their own century, doing the same plain thing.

The plain thing is this. Someone in each generation kept the record. Not the great record — not the one the counties and the colleges of arms and the census marshals kept, though those are in here too, and I have read them until my eyes gave out. The small record. The one on the fly-leaf of the family Bible, written in the hand of whoever was keeping the book that year: a birth, a death, a marriage, set down in the place kept for it and not embellished. The book changed hands and it changed countries and eventually it changed languages, because the first person to keep it wrote his entries in a formal French that no one in the line could read within three generations. But it did not stop. Someone always held it. And when the Bible itself was finally gone — lost, or divided among heirs, or simply worn past use — the keeping went on in the things keeping becomes when no one is trained to it anymore: a box of photographs, a story told once at a kitchen table, a chart somebody started and did not finish. I am the one holding it now. What holding it has come to mean, for me, is these three books.

The three books are three countries and three centuries, and I have let each one find its own shape, because the people in each one lived a different life and the record keeps them a different way. **Volume One** is England, from about 1490 to 1714 — the priory house at Little Wymondley, the surveyor who rose out of a carpenter's trade into the king's service and back into the gentry, the heralds and the visitations and the long slow coming-apart of a Hertfordshire seat, and at the end of it a woman named Barbara standing at the rail of a brigantine as Charleston comes up out of the February haze, going to marry a man she has agreed to across an ocean. **Volume Two** is Virginia and Carolina, from 1742 to 1794 — the line come across the water and pushing south into the tobacco country, a colonel's daughter married and buried young, a man who rides out on his place's business in the autumn of 1775 and does not come back, and his

fifteen-year-old granddaughter at a writing-desk on a winter night, finding at the foot of a letter that the family's long going-on had wanted a name all along. **Volume Three** is Mississippi, from 1832 to 1920 — a girl at a loom on a ridge three miles north of the post road, who will watch slavery arrive on her father's place and then be swept off it, who will marry late and out of a dead father's house, who will take a farm and hold it through a war and a widowhood and sixty more years of a world that would not stop moving under her, and who will die at last under a homemade coffin her sons made with their own hands.

Three women anchor the three books, a century apart, and each of them, without knowing the others' words, said the same thing in three words or fewer. Barbara, coming down the gangway at Charleston to a man who has waited on a bench for thirty-five days, and who years later writes under her name in the Bible, in a hand still swollen with feeling: *She came*. Her great-granddaughter Mary Baker, at the desk on that November night in 1779, closing a letter to a brother at the war with two words she then wrote a second time in the book that stayed in the house: *we continue*. And Mary Baker's line, carried down through the daughters — Johnson to Hubbard and on through the marriages, the name going sideways into other names the way it always did — reaching at last a woman named Mary Jane, on a ridge in Mississippi, of whom the truest thing anyone ever said is the thing this last book is named for: *she held the line*. One keeping. Three refrains. The same act.

I have tried, across all three volumes, to hold to one rule, which is the rule the family itself seems to have held: set the known thing down, in the place kept for it, and do not invent to fill the silence. Every date in these pages that could be checked against a calendar has been checked. Where two records disagree — and they disagree about the day a woman died, and the year a man died, and a good deal in between — I have put both readings on the page and let them stand rather than choose the tidier one. Where the record simply stops, as it stops on the question of where one man died and when, I have said so and left the silence open, because closing it would have meant writing fiction and calling it history. And where the record is not empty but was made empty — where a probate book that should name three enslaved people on a Mississippi farm names no one, because the estate that would have listed them was never opened — I have said that too, as plainly as I know how, because a silence that was made is a different thing from a silence that merely fell, and the people inside it are owed the difference.

So this is my entry on the fly-leaf. It is longer than any of theirs, and it is in English, and it has footnotes they would have found strange. But it is the same act they performed, one keeper at a time, for four hundred and thirty years: setting the names down so that whoever breaks the book open a long way off and a long time from now will know whose hands carried the words this far.

Each volume opens in its own place and its own year, and you may read them straight through or one at a time as the mood takes you. But they are one line, and

one keeping, and I have put them under one cover at last so that the whole of it can be held the way it was always meant to be held — together, in one pair of hands.

Here they are. Here we are.

I am coming.

Part One — Volume I: England, 1490 to 1714

Prologue

There is a sentence in a book published in New York in 1925 that I have been arguing with for almost two and a half years.

The book is called *History of the de Graffenried Family from 1191 A.D. to 1925*, written by Thomas P. de Graffenried, a New York lawyer who spent decades collecting the genealogy of his family. On page 149, near the bottom of the page, in the dignified language of a family history that was sent to subscribers in a printed binding with marbled endpapers, he wrote that on the twenty-second of February 1714, at Charleston, South Carolina, Christopher VI de Graffenried married a young Englishwoman — Barbara Tempest (née Needham), daughter of the distinguished Sir Arthur Needham of Wymondsley, Hertfordshire, England. She was born in 1688, her mother's maiden name being Wingate.

That sentence is the only documentary trace of Barbara's parentage that the de Graffenried family preserved into the twentieth century. It is the sentence from which everyone who has tried to find her has worked. And it is wrong about the central fact.

There was no Sir Arthur Needham of Wymondsley, Hertfordshire. There never was. Thomas P. de Graffenried, writing in his Manhattan study in the early 1920s, was working from imperfect family papers and from a 1735 letter by Baron Christoph V de Graffenried to his grandson Tscharner — a letter in which the Baron describes Barbara only as Madame Needham an English gentlewoman and then concludes, with disarming honesty, You may put here the Genealogie of your spouse yourself. The grandson never did. Two centuries later, his great-great-grandson in New York filled in the blank with the wrong name.

It took me a long time to figure that out. I started this work in the late winter of 2024, looking up an old family story about a great-aunt's research into our line, and discovered within the first month that no one in the family had ever quite known who Barbara was. We knew she had crossed the Atlantic. We knew she had married a Swiss baron's son in Charleston. We knew our line descended from her. We did not know who her father had been, or where she had grown up, or what her life had looked like before the wedding. The 1925 book was the closest thing we had to an answer, and the 1925 book was wrong about the central fact.

So I started looking.

There is no particularly dramatic story about how I found her. I subscribed to genealogy databases. I read the old wills at the National Archives at Kew in transcribed form. I learned to read Tudor secretary hand well enough to puzzle through a 1572 visitation pedigree, and then well enough to read it cleanly, and then well enough to recognize the handwriting of the College of Arms clerks across half a century of records. I built a workbook in Excel that grew to thirty sheets. I built a master report that grew to fifty thousand words. I corresponded with researchers in Hertfordshire, in London, in Derbyshire, in North Carolina.

By the end of the first year I knew her grandfather. By the end of the second year I knew her great-great-grandfather. By the spring of 2026 I knew the name signed at the bottom of a 1572 visitation pedigree — not Barbara's, but her great-great-great-grandfather's, a man named John Nedham, who had ridden in from Wymondley to register his arms with the Clarenceux King of Arms in the seventeenth year of Elizabeth's reign.

Her father turned out to be Maurice — the fourth son of a Hertfordshire priory house, a man who held a £500 portion under his father's will and never inherited the priory itself, who was living down in London in the lawyers' parish at St Bride's when he married, and who died in November 1712, fourteen months before his daughter wrote a three-word letter that crossed the Atlantic and changed our family's geography forever.

So the 1925 source was wrong about the father. Sir Arthur never existed. Maurice did.

And I spent two and a half years being wrong about the mother.

The 1925 sentence gave her a maiden name — Wingate — and there was a Chancery suit at Kew that seemed to prove it. Filed in 1684. Maurice Nedham, Esq., and his wife Lettice, joint plaintiffs, suing Sir Francis Wingate of Harlington, knight, for a parcel of London-suburban land that was part of Lettice's own marriage settlement and that Sir Francis was holding back. A woman named Lettice, suing a Wingate, for her marriage portion. What would you conclude? I concluded what anybody would conclude, and I wrote it down, and I built a chapter on it, and I would have gone to press on it.

Then, in May of this year, I was looking at a photograph of two facing pages of a seventeenth-century London marriage register — St. James Duke's Place, in Aldgate, the parish that claimed exemption from the Bishop of London and sold something like forty thousand marriages by licence between 1661 and 1691 to people who had no parish of their own — and about two-thirds of the way down the right-hand page, between a marriage of the fifth of June and a marriage of the second of September, in a clerk's flat working hand, I read this:

Mauris Nedham of S[ain]t Brides London & Letisia Bowyer of Wymondley in Hertford-sheire weare married y[e] 21[s]t of June 1684 by Licence Her name was not Wingate. Her name was Bowyer.

The Chancery suit had never said otherwise. It said that Maurice had a wife called Lettice, and that a Wingate was holding land out of her settlement, and both of those things are still true, and neither of them makes her a Wingate. I had a blank where a maiden name should be, and I had a plausible name standing near the blank, and I put it in.

Which is exactly what Thomas P. de Graffenried did in his Manhattan study in the 1920s. He had a blank too. The Baron had left it for him — You may put here the Genealogie of your spouse yourself, he wrote to his grandson in 1735, and the grandson never did, and the blank came down through two hundred years to a lawyer in New York who filled it with a knight who had never lived.

The blank does not stay blank. That is the whole lesson of this book, and I did not learn it by reading about it. Somebody always fills it — an antiquarian, a herald, a grandson, a family story, me — and the only thing that empties it again is the primary source, and the primary source is almost never where the argument is. It is two lines in a parish clerk's hand in a register nobody thought to open.

So here is what I can tell you about Barbara's mother, which is all I can tell you.

Her name was Letisia Bowyer. In the summer of 1684 she was living at Wymondley in Hertfordshire, and she had not been born there. No Bowyer ever held a manor in either Wymondley parish. No Bowyer child was baptized at either Wymondley church. In the whole county of Hertfordshire, across sixty-five years and something like fifty thousand baptisms, the parish registers record exactly one Bowyer, and he was a boy named Beniamine at Little Hadham, twenty-five miles off, and he is nothing to us. She came into that county from somewhere and nobody wrote down where. She married the priory's fourth son in a City church that neither of them belonged to. She bore a daughter the following August. She was widowed at fifty-six in the cold week before Advent of 1712, and where she went afterward is not recorded either.

She comes into the record from nowhere and she goes out of it the same way. She is the first unwritten line in this family's book — a woman with a name, a wedding, a child, and no people.

And her daughter got on a ship.

Eight generations. From John in 1572 to Barbara in 1714 is one hundred and forty-two years, four wives, six wills, two heralds' visitations, one civil war, one regicide, one Restoration, one Great Plague, one Great Fire, and one dissolved Augustinian priory in north Hertfordshire that the family had been given by Henry VIII in 1538 and held for almost two hundred years.

This book is the story of that house and the people who lived in it. It begins in the 1490s with a Derbyshire younger son named James Nedham, who walked south to seek his fortune at the Tudor Court and ended up serving Henry VIII as Surveyor of the King's Works, building the king's palaces from Hampton Court to Whitehall to Windsor. It ends in February 1714 on a wooden dock in Charleston, South Carolina, with a twenty-eight-year-old woman stepping off a ship she had boarded against the advice of every person she loved, including the man waiting for her on the dock.

* * *

My younger daughter, the romantic one, reads fantasy novels by the stack. She likes heroines with sharp tongues and stubborn hearts and the willingness to defy a kingdom in service of a private commitment. My older daughter likes them too. I do not read those books myself, but I have watched my girls put them down with the kind of expression a reader gets when she has been somewhere real.

That is what I want this book to do. I want it to be the kind of book my daughters can read on a Saturday afternoon and close at five and want to talk about over dinner. I want them to feel Barbara. I want them to feel her decision. I want them to understand that she is the reason they exist and that what she did in the autumn of 1713 took a kind of courage that the family has never quite named because the family didn't, until now, even know her name.

So the book is for them. And for the daughters they will have, and for the daughters those daughters will have, and for as many generations of Searcy women as want to know who they came from.

It is also, of course, for everyone in the family who is not a daughter. But the dedication page is to my girls.

* * *

One last thing before we begin.

The book moves between two voices. Most of it is in what I will call the historian's voice — the voice in which we walk through the priory in 1538 and watch James Nedham convert a former monastery into a country house; the voice in which we sit through a herald's visitation in 1572 and watch a man sign his name to a vellum book; the voice in which we follow Eustace through the Civil War and George Senior through the Restoration. That voice is mine. It is careful, it is sourced, it is grounded in what the documents say, and it stays a respectful distance from the people it describes.

But there is a second voice, and it belongs to Barbara. It is closer than the historian's voice. It is inside her head. It feels her body in the cold of an October night and the heat of a Carolina February. It hears her think. It is the voice the book reaches for when Barbara is on the page — first quietly, as a child in the last sections of Chapter 4, and then fully, beginning in Chapter 5, when the love story starts.

I have permitted myself this second voice because the book cannot do its work without it. A family history that keeps its distance from its protagonist is a chronicle. A family history that goes inside her is a book.

Barbara has been waiting three centuries for someone to go inside her. I am going to.

* * *

We begin seven generations before her, in the year 1538, in a converted Augustinian priory in north Hertfordshire that a man named James Nedham has just been given by the king.

Chapter 1 — The Surveyor's Priory

In the summer of 1541, in a Hertfordshire field three miles south of the market town of Hitchin, a crew of carpenters was raising the timber frame of a great barn.

It would be a hundred feet long when they finished. Nine bays on either side. The principal posts were oak, brought down out of a wood the master of the works had bought four years earlier in South Mimms across the Middlesex border; the rafters and the wall plates and the tie beams were the standard sizes a working carpenter knew by sight. The frame would carry a tiled roof. The walls below would be timber-framed with brick infill, the brick coming from a kiln nearby. The barn was being built to hold the grain tithes of the manor of Little Wymondley, the lord of which had been, since the spring of 1538, a man named James Nedeham.

James was not at the worksite that summer. He was probably in London, or at one of the half-dozen royal building projects that he ran simultaneously as Surveyor of the King's Works under Henry VIII. He had hired master carpenters to build his barn the way he had hired master carpenters all his life to build the king's palaces, and he trusted them to do it. The frame went up. The roof went on. The barn was finished and standing by the end of 1541, or possibly in the spring of 1542. James lived two more years.

The barn is still there.

It is standing today, four hundred and eighty-five years after the carpenters finished it, in the same field three miles south of Hitchin, on the same priory grounds, at the same address — Priory Lane, Little Wymondley, Hertfordshire, SG4 7HD. It is now licensed for civil weddings. Up to two hundred and twenty guests can be seated under its hammer-beam roof. Brides and grooms have exchanged vows in it more than two thousand times since 1992. The current owners are a couple named Michelle and Bill Bacon, who took over the property at the beginning of 2026 and who would, almost certainly, be glad to know that a descendant of the man who commissioned the barn in 1541 is writing about him in Alabama in the spring of the same year.

This is the story of how the man who built that barn got there, and of the eight generations of his family that lived in the buildings he made before, in the autumn of 1713, a young woman named Barbara Tempest Needham walked out of the priory yard for the last time and rode east toward London and the Atlantic.

* * *

The London Carpenter's Son

James Nedeham was born about 1490 in London.

His father was Christopher Nedeham, citizen and carpenter of London — the phrase that appears in the formal Bodleian Library biographical note on his son,

and that fixes Christopher's place in the City of London's social order with precision. He was a citizen, meaning a freeman of the City, sworn into the liberties of London with the right to trade within the walls; and he was a carpenter, meaning he practiced the woodworking trade. Behind him stood a third detail that the Tudor heralds, sixty years later, would record at the top of his grandson's pedigree: Christopher's father — James's grandfather — was John Needham of High Needham in Derbyshire, an obscure Peak District landholder whose family had been at a place called Needham Grange since at least the late fourteenth century.

One thing to clear before the rest of the story can run. James was the first Nedham at Wymondley. He was not the first Nedham in Hertfordshire. Two and a half centuries before him, a man named Luke Nedham of St Albans witnessed John of Langley's foundation deed for the St Albans Grammar School — the deed is undated, but the related case in the Court of King's Bench is dated to 1286 — and was named, twenty-two years later, as one of four citizen-sufferers in Abbot Hugh's long handmill dispute with the borough, which ran from 1308 to the abbot's death in 1326. Luke is in the *Gesta Abbatum Monasterii Sancti Albani* at the back of volume two, on page 154 of Riley's Rolls Series edition, and in William Urwick's *Nonconformity in Hertfordshire* at page 43. Whether he is a forebear of the Derbyshire line that produced James, or a separate Hertfordshire-rooted Nedham family entirely, the documentary record does not say. The surname's presence in the county, however, runs deeper than the chapter would otherwise suggest.

The three generations form a recognizable Tudor social arc. A Derbyshire gentry family, modest but armigerous, sends a younger son south to London to learn a trade. The son joins the Carpenters' Company, marries, takes up the freedom of the City, becomes a citizen and a tradesman. He raises his own son to follow him into the craft. The third generation — James, our man — rises out of the trade and into the king's service, and from the king's service back into the gentry his grandfather had quietly belonged to. By the end of his life he will style himself, in formal legal instruments, James Nedeham of Wymondley, Esquire.

He will hold a former Augustinian priory by letters patent from Henry VIII. His son will sign a herald's pedigree to register the family's arms in the fourteenth year of Elizabeth's reign.

The arc takes three generations to complete, but it is a single movement. The Nedeams of London were not strangers to the gentry; they were a junior cadet line that had taken thirty years away from land to make money in trade, and that returned to land when the chance came. James was the chance.

He grew up in a house in London — the exact parish is not recorded, but probably one of the carpenters' parishes north of the Thames, in the cluster of working-trade neighborhoods between St Paul's and the eastern wall. His father worked with timber. His childhood was spent in the smell of sawdust and pitch and oak. He would have learned to handle a chisel before he could read; he would

have known the names of the tools by sight before he was eight. By the time he was fourteen or fifteen he was apprenticed, almost certainly to his father or to one of his father's colleagues in the trade. The apprenticeship would have run seven years.

In 1514, when he was about twenty-four, he was sworn into the freedom of the Worshipful Company of Carpenters, the London livery company that regulated his craft. The Carpenters' Company in 1514 was one of the senior twelve City companies, with a hall, a livery, a master and wardens, an annual feast, and the authority to inspect work done within the City walls. To be sworn into the Company was to acquire the right to trade as a carpenter in London. James was now, formally, what his father had been: a citizen and carpenter of London.

Within a year he was a warden of the Company. The wardenship was an annual office, elected by the membership, and a young man elected to it at twenty-five — a year out of his apprenticeship — was a man being recognized by his peers as exceptional. James would be warden again in 1533, and he would serve as Master of the Company three times: in 1534, 1535, and 1542. The Company stayed close to him for the rest of his life. He died still a freeman of it.

The first project recorded under his name is in 1521, when he was about thirty-one years old. The Mercers' Company — a richer and more politically connected City company than the Carpenters', representing the import-export merchants in luxury textiles — hired him to design and build a louvre for their hall. A louvre, in Tudor English, was a roof-vent: a small turret built into the roof of a great hall to allow smoke from the central fire to escape, while also providing decorative finish above the gable. Building a louvre required a carpenter who understood roof framing, ventilation, and architectural ornament simultaneously. The Mercers' commission, given to a young man only seven years out of his apprenticeship, established him.

Between 1522 and 1525 he was abroad as a military carpenter. The exact projects are not entirely clear from the surviving record, but he is documented as having served at Calais — the English-held enclave on the French coast that was the kingdom's permanent military outpost on the Continent. Calais was a fortress town, fortified continuously by the English from the fourteenth century onward, and its defensive works required constant maintenance and improvement. A military carpenter at Calais worked on gun platforms, ramparts, gates, drawbridges, and the timber components of the curtain walls. James spent three years there, in his early thirties, learning how to build for war.

In 1525 he came home to England and was appointed a gunner at the Tower of London. The position was a Crown salary — modest, but secure, and tied to the central armaments establishment of the realm. The Tower in the 1520s was both a working arsenal and the symbolic heart of the Crown's military power. A gunner was a senior artilleryman with responsibility for the maintenance and operation of the Tower's cannon, and within a year James had been promoted to senior

gunner. He was, by the late 1520s, a man with a foot in two professions: master carpenter in London, and senior gunner at the Tower.

It was the Tower posting that put him within reach of the men who would change his life.

The Road to Court

Cardinal Thomas Wolsey, in 1529, was the most powerful man in England below the king.

He was Archbishop of York, Lord Chancellor, Cardinal of the Roman Church, and the chief minister of Henry VIII's government. He held more offices simultaneously than any English subject had ever held. He lived in extraordinary splendor at his great house at Hampton Court on the Thames, which he had built or rebuilt over the previous decade with the resources of his ecclesiastical and political revenues. He also held York Place at Westminster — the London residence of the Archbishops of York — which he had begun to rebuild as a second great house. Both houses required ongoing construction. Wolsey kept a building staff.

Sometime in the late 1520s, James Nedeham was hired by Wolsey to work on York Place.

The exact circumstances are not recorded — we have no contract, no warrant, no payment record from the Wolsey period — but the fact is documented in the working biographical traditions and confirmed by what happened next. Wolsey fell from power in October 1529. He was stripped of the chancellorship, banished from the king's presence, and ordered to surrender his properties. York Place was taken from him; the king began rebuilding it as his own residence, which would become Whitehall Palace. The building staff that Wolsey had assembled was largely retained by the king. James Nedeham, who had been working for Wolsey, was now working for Henry.

This was the transitional moment. James was about thirty-nine years old. He had spent fifteen years in the City as a working carpenter, three years in Calais as a military carpenter, four years at the Tower as a gunner. He had built a louvre for the Mercers and galleries for the Marquess of Exeter at the great man's London garden. He had worked at York Place under one of the most demanding patrons in England. He was now working directly for the king.

In March 1531, by royal warrant, he was appointed Master Carpenter of the King's Works. The office was the senior craftsman position in the royal building establishment, with authority over all carpenters working on Crown projects. It was a major promotion. It came with a fee — a daily wage of twelve pence, which was twice the day-rate of an ordinary working carpenter — and with the right to oversee subordinates across multiple royal sites simultaneously.

In June of the following year, 1532, James executed a sealed bond in favor of Thomas Cromwell.

Cromwell in June 1532 was Master of the King's Jewels — a Crown office that gave him control of the royal treasury of plate, jewels, and ceremonial objects — and was rising rapidly toward the chief ministership that he would consolidate over the next eighteen months. He was, in the summer of 1532, the man you needed if you wanted Crown advancement. The bond James gave him was for two hundred pounds. The amount is striking. In 1532, two hundred pounds was the annual income of a substantial country gentleman. It was four years' wages for a master craftsman at the king's day-rate. The bond was a formal financial obligation — a sealed instrument, conditional on some performance, by which James bound himself to pay Cromwell two hundred pounds if certain unspecified conditions were not met. The endorsement that would have specified the condition does not survive in full.

What survives is the bond itself, in the National Archives at Kew, catalogued as E 40/5944, dated 11 June 1532, and described in the catalog as the obligation of James Nedeham, the king's master carpenter, to Thomas Cromwell, master or treasurer of the king's jewels, for two hundred pounds. Whatever the specific condition, the document marks James as a man in Cromwell's circle in the most consequential summer of Cromwell's rise. Four months later, on 1 October 1532, James was appointed Surveyor of the King's Works — the office at the head of the royal building establishment, above the Master Carpenter and the Master Mason, with overall administrative responsibility for every Crown construction project in the realm.

The succession of dates is too tight to be coincidence. June 1532: a £200 bond to Cromwell. October 1532: appointed Surveyor. James owed his promotion to Cromwell, in some part. He had been in Cromwell's pocket, financially and politically, for at least four months when the appointment came through.

This was the deal he had made. It bought him the office that would define the rest of his life.

The Works in the 1530s

The English royal building program in the 1530s was the largest construction enterprise in northern Europe.

Henry VIII had inherited from his father a half-dozen working royal residences — the Tower of London, Westminster, Greenwich, Richmond, Windsor, Hampton Court. He would add to them, over the course of his reign, more royal residences than any English king before him had owned. He bought Hampton Court from the falling Wolsey in 1529 and made it his own. He took York Place from the fallen Wolsey and rebuilt it as Whitehall. He acquired or built or substantially expanded properties at Bridewell, St James's, Nonsuch, Oatlands, Hatfield, Hunsdon, Enfield, Eltham, Woodstock, Dover, Leeds Castle, Ampthill, Grafton, the Manor of the More, Woking, and a dozen others. By the end of his reign, the Crown held more than fifty houses scattered across the south and

midlands of England, and every one of them required maintenance, expansion, or active rebuilding.

All of this passed through the office of the Surveyor of the King's Works.

On 1 October 1532, when James took up the post, the Surveyor's office was a small administrative bureau with a clerk, a few subordinate craftsmen, and a permanent staff of perhaps a dozen people. By the time James died twelve years later, the office had grown to oversee a working roster of hundreds of named artificers and laborers active across two dozen sites simultaneously, with annual budgets in the thousands of pounds. The Victoria County History of Hertfordshire, in its volume on the Hundred of Broadwater, gives his style in its fullest three-fold form — accountant, surveyor-general and clerk of the king's works. The accountantship was the financial spine of the office, which is what the eleven-volume Rawlinson series itself preserves; the surveyor-generalship was the architectural and engineering oversight; the clerkship was the administrative headship. He was all three at once. The growth was driven by Henry's appetite. The administration was driven by James.

He kept a clerk named Antony Pontesbury, who described himself in the books as "clerk to the said accomptant." Pontesbury wrote out the fair copies of every pay tally for the duration of James's surveyorship. His handwriting fills the surviving pay-books — a careful, looped, slightly inclined hand that you can pick out across eleven volumes at the Bodleian Library at Oxford. Pontesbury was, in effect, James's working partner. He sat at a desk somewhere in the King's Works office — probably at Westminster, possibly at Whitehall once the rebuilding allowed it — and produced the documentary backbone of the royal building program for ten consecutive years.

Of the twelve annual pay-books that James and Pontesbury compiled between Michaelmas 1532 and James's death in September 1544, ten survive. Eleven are at the Bodleian Library at Oxford, in the Rawlinson collection, shelfmarks D. 775 through D. 785; one further volume is at the National Archives at Kew, shelfmark E. 101/504/2; and a twelfth volume was rediscovered as recently as 2008, when it surfaced in the Foljambe family library at Osberton Hall and was acquired by the Bodleian at a Christie's sale, where it is now MS Don. c. 206. Three additional volumes are held by the University of Nottingham. Across these volumes, the daily working life of the King's Works in the 1530s and early 1540s is recorded with a level of administrative completeness that almost no comparable Tudor government office can match.

They are extraordinary documents. They record, by the four-week period, the names and wages of every workman — master carpenter, sawyer, bricklayer, scaffold-maker, common labourer, tiler, plumber, ditcher, carter — employed on every project. They record the days each man worked, the days he did not work, the feast days he kept, the half-days he put in. They record the purchases of materials — lime by the cwt, tile by the thousand, brick by the load, lead by the fother, timber by the foot, paper and ink for the clerk by the quire. They record

the carriage costs — every cart-load of sand and brick and tile, every horse and wagon and widow with a cart hired by the day to move material from one place to another. They form, taken as a whole, a portrait of how the king's England was physically built.

The first volume — MS Rawlinson D. 775, covering the year from Michaelmas 1532 to Michaelmas 1533 — opens with the work at Greenwich and the Old Court, runs through Windsor Castle and the arbours in Windsor Park, takes in Woking and Dover Castle and the Palace of Westminster, and culminates in a set of accounts under a heading that is one of the most striking single entries in the entire corpus.

The heading reads: Ageynst the coronacion of the Quene. The Quene is Anne Boleyn. The folios are 173 to 201 of MS Rawlinson D. 775. They record the carpentry and joinery work done at Westminster Hall in May and June of 1533 in preparation for the coronation of Henry VIII's second wife. Pews. Galleries. Hangings. The whole apparatus of a state ceremony, prepared for a queen whose coronation Henry had moved heaven and earth to bring about, and whose execution he would order three years later.

Anne Boleyn was crowned at Westminster Abbey on 1 June 1533, in Whitsun week, with the realm in a state of barely-suppressed political tension over the king's break with Rome to enable the marriage that had produced her. James Nedeham, eight months into his surveyorship, ran the works that made the hall ready for her. He would have been at Westminster in those weeks. He would have seen the new queen — perhaps from a distance, perhaps not — as she processed through the hall his men had prepared.

Three months earlier, in the spring of 1533, James had also been at the Tower of London. The Tower in 1533 was the customary point of ceremonial departure for an English coronation procession; the queen would lodge at the Tower the night before the coronation and process the next morning to Westminster. James's men had been there in the spring to restore the timber framing above the great water-gate that opened onto the Thames — the gate known then and now as the Traitors' Gate — in preparation for her arrival. The gate's grim later name comes from its later use to admit Tudor prisoners to the Tower for execution. In 1533 it was the queen's gate. James's carpenters made it ready for her.

It was also the gate she would pass through on her way out, three years later, on her way to the scaffold.

The pay-books document, year after year, the buildings James worked on. In 1533-34, the second volume — MS Rawlinson D. 776 — records work at Greenwich, Eltham, the Tower of London, Bridewell, Richmond, Windsor, Woking, the Manor of the More, Chobham, Ampthill, and Bishop's Hatfield. Twelve royal sites in a single year. In November 1534 one of the entries reads: The Kyngys greatt barge, callyd the Lyon — ayenste the commynge of the Frenche ambassitour beyng the hyghe Admyrall off Fransse. The king's great barge, called the Lion, refitted against the coming of the French ambassador,

who was the High Admiral of France. James's men were working on the king's ceremonial water-transport for a diplomatic visit. They worked on everything.

In 1535-36 he completed the new roof of the Great Hall at Hampton Court Palace.

This is the work that survives most visibly. The Great Hall at Hampton Court is the largest and most architecturally significant interior space in any of the surviving Tudor royal palaces. Henry VIII had acquired Hampton Court from Wolsey in 1529 and had begun an aggressive program of expansion almost immediately. The Great Hall, completed in the mid-1530s, was the formal dining and ceremonial chamber at the heart of the palace. It is one hundred and six feet long, forty feet wide, and sixty feet high to the roof apex. The roof is a hammer-beam roof, the most complex and structurally demanding form of medieval and early Tudor English timber roofing, with carved oak beams and pendant decorative work that has been called one of the finest surviving examples of its kind in England.

James designed it. He drew the architectural plans — the platts and molds by which the carpenters would frame the structure. The roof was completed under his supervision in 1535. It has held up the ceiling for four hundred and ninety-one years. It is, today, one of the most visited interiors in any English royal palace: a public space open to the public throughout the year, walked under by tourists and schoolchildren and visiting heads of state. If you have ever stood in the Great Hall at Hampton Court and looked up, you have looked at a thing made by James Nedeham.

Other work in those years had less of a future. The Tower of London received continuous attention through the 1530s — the Jewel House, the rebuilding of which is documented in MS Rawlinson D. 778 from January 1534-35 to April 1536, was a major project; James also restored the framing above the Traitors' Gate. At Windsor Castle he built a new terrace on the north side, supported on brick vaults that drained the castle gutters, where Henry VIII could practice with his hand-guns — a private royal shooting range, with benches, sixty feet above the river. The terrace is still there, though the king's hand-guns and his benches are not. At Greenwich he extensively prepared the site for the arrival of Anne of Cleves, the king's fourth wife, in late 1539 and early 1540 — a project whose joyless aftermath was the king's immediate aversion to his new bride and his arrangement of her annulment within six months. James also built, at Greenwich, a cockpit for cock-fighting, with custom seating for Catherine of Aragon — a detail that places him chronologically before the king's first divorce, since Catherine was banished from Court by 1531.

He worked on Westminster Hall, where he managed extensive repairs and reinforcement of the medieval hammer-beam roof, the structural guttering, the King's fish house, and the office of the Exchequer. He worked at Calais on the English fortifications. He converted dissolved monasteries into royal palaces — sections of St Augustine's Abbey at Canterbury, the priory at Rochester, the

nunnery at Dartford, and others. He was the man who turned, by physical labor, the bones of the old Catholic England into the residential infrastructure of the new Tudor state.

The Surveyor's Hand

The volumes have come down to us because they stayed in the family.

This is one of the small wonders of the record. The pay-books that James and Pontesbury wrote, or had written, or oversaw the writing of, between 1532 and 1544, were the working papers of the Surveyor's office. They should, by the ordinary administrative logic of the Tudor state, have stayed with the office — passed to James's successor at his death, kept in the Works office's central files at Westminster, eventually transferred to the Crown archives where they would have been catalogued in the Pipe Office or the Exchequer of Receipt. That is what happened to most surviving administrative records of the Tudor government. They went into the central archive, where they survive in the State Paper classes of the National Archives at Kew.

But James's pay-books did not. They went home with him.

They stayed at Wymondley Priory — his country house, which he had received from the king in 1538 — from the year of their compilation in the 1530s and 1540s until at least the early 1770s, when the priory was finally sold out of the family. That is roughly two hundred and thirty years of continuous private custody. For most of that time the books sat on shelves in the priory house, in the rooms where James himself had lived and where his son John had signed the herald's pedigree in 1572 and where his grandson George had baptized children in the chapel and where the line continued down through Eustace and George Senior and Maurice and Maurice's daughter Barbara.

The proof that they were at Wymondley sits inside the books themselves. On the fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 776 — the pay-book for the year 1533-34, the volume that opens with the Greenwich works — are two pasted fragments of private accounts in 1655, kept by Mr. Nedham of Wymondley Priory, i.e. George Needham.

This is George Senior, the man baptized at Little Wymondley church on 16 August 1618, the writer of the 1666/67 will, the lord of the priory through the entire Civil War and Restoration period, the great-great-grandson of James, and the man whose great-granddaughter would marry Christopher VI de Graffenried in Charleston in 1714.

On the fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 778 — the pay-book for the Tower of London works of 1535-36 — are memoranda by the same George Needham, dated 1643-44, recording taxes paid for his lands at Graveley and Little Wymondley in Hertfordshire and at Wilshamstead in Bedfordshire. He was twenty-five years old when he made those notes. The Civil War was raging. Charles I would be executed in five years.

On the fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 782 — the pay-book for the demolition of Barking Abbey in 1541-42 — are still further accounts by the same George, this time from 1668. He was fifty years old by then, and the war had been over for nearly two decades, and the Restoration had brought Charles II back to the throne, and George was still using his great-great-grandfather's working papers as scratch paper for the running of his estate.

Three volumes — D. 776, D. 778, and D. 782 — physically preserve handwriting from both ends of the family. James Nedeham's clerk Antony Pontesbury wrote the pay tallies. James authorized the accounts. The books stayed at Wymondley for a hundred and twenty years. George Senior, in the priory house, picked them up across multiple decades of his adult life and wrote his own life on their margins. The first hand is from the 1530s. The second is from the 1640s, 1650s, and 1660s. The same paper carries both.

This is the physical link between Chapter One of this book and Chapter Four. It is the documentary thread between the man who built Wymondley and the great-grandfather of the woman who left it. The Bodleian Library, where the books have rested since the middle of the eighteenth century, preserves a tangible piece of inheritance that no will or pedigree could capture quite this way: a working ledger that two ancestors of the same Alabama descendant, four generations apart, both wrote in.

That fact is part of why this book can be written. The other part is that James's books are unusually detailed even by the standards of Tudor administrative records. The Bodleian's published catalog of the Rawlinson manuscripts, compiled by W. D. Macray and printed at the Clarendon Press between 1862 and 1900, gives the volume-by-volume contents of the entire eleven-volume Nedeham run. Volume One: the works of 1532-33, including the coronation preparations for Anne Boleyn. Volume Two: 1533-34, including the King's barge the Lion. Volume Three: 1534-35, with substantial accounts for Windsor and Greenwich. Volume Four: 1535-36, the Tower of London. Volume Five: 1535-37 with a summary of the year's total spending across sixteen royal sites — a single figure preserved at the back of the volume, the total amount for the king's buildings in 1535-1537: two thousand six hundred and thirty-six pounds, seventeen shillings, ten pence half-penny. That is the annual royal building budget at the height of Henry VIII's program, in the hand of James Nedeham's clerk.

Volume Six: 1536-37 and 1540. Volume Seven: 1541-42, including Enfield and the Canterbury works. Volume Eight: 1541-42, the demolition of Barking Abbey. Volume Nine: 1541-42, the manor of Dartford. Volume Ten: 1543-44, Dartford continued. Volume Eleven: 1541-42, the manor of Rochester. The structure of James's life from 1532 to 1544 — month by month, project by project, name by name — is laid out across these eleven volumes.

Two volumes of the original twelve are missing. Neither has been recovered. The years not covered are 1537-38 and 1540-41. The year of the Wymondley grant is one of the missing years. The pay-book that would have recorded James's

activity in the spring of 1538, when the priory came into his hands, is one of the two volumes that have not survived.

The Grant of Wymondley

He was at Wymondley before the grant.

Sometime in December 1537, four months before the formal Crown grant by letters patent, James obtained a lease of the priory site from the Court of Augmentations. The lease was the mechanism by which the Crown allowed him initial possession; the grant of the freehold came afterward. This is the careful order of Tudor real-estate transactions when the Crown was disposing of dissolved monastic property: lease first, to put a man in occupation and let him begin work, then formal grant of the fee simple. James had been quietly placed at Wymondley before the world knew it was his.

On 12 April 1538, by letters patent issued under the Great Seal of England, King Henry VIII confirmed his title. The grant is recorded in the published calendar of Letters and Papers, Foreign and Domestic, of the Reign of Henry VIII, volume thirteen, item 887, sub-grant thirteen. The 1538 grant carried with it the priory's lands in the manor of Little Wymondley, a scattering of outlying parcels in the parish, the rectory and tithes of Wilshamstead in Bedfordshire — which the priory had held by appropriation since the medieval period — and the buildings themselves: the priory church, the cloister, the chapter house, the prior's lodging, the refectory, the kitchens, the dormitory, and the outbuildings.

That this was a Crown grant and not a commercial purchase is established at primary-source level by the Elizabethan Chancery testimony of James's son. Sometime between 1558 and 1603 — the exact year is not recorded — John Nedeham, James's son and heir, filed a Chancery suit against one William Clarke over some matter involving the Wymondley property. In the bill of complaint, John described the property's history: "Wymondley, Hertfordshire, formerly belonging to the priory of Little Wymondley, and since the dissolution of the said priory granted by King Henry 8 to James Nedeham, esq., plaintiff's father." The phrasing is sworn testimony in the Court of Chancery. The case is catalogued at the National Archives at Kew as C 2/Eliz/N5/46. The Wymondley priory was a grant, by King Henry the Eighth, to James the father. That is John's own statement.

The grant was a substantial reward. The lordship of a small Hertfordshire manor was worth, in the cash terms of the late 1530s, perhaps thirty to fifty pounds a year in net annual income. The tenure form mattered as much as the income. James held Wymondley of the king in chief by the service of a tenth part of a knight's fee — a military tenure, not free socage, the formal dignity of which by 1538 was largely symbolic (the service had long since been commuted to a small money payment) but the symbolism of which was the point. A Crown grant by knight-service was the gentleman's holding. A grant in free socage would have

been the lesser thing. The buildings themselves represented a windfall — though not, as it turned out, a pristine windfall. James Nedeham, on 12 April 1538, became overnight one of the new Reformation gentry of England: a Crown servant who had received, as direct reward for his service to the king, a former monastic house and the lordship of the parish around it.

This is the founding act of the Wymondley Nedhams. Every generation of the family that this book is about, down to Barbara Tempest Needham who married Christopher de Graffenried in Charleston in 1714, descended from James and from the priory he received in April 1538. The line could not have existed in Hertfordshire without the dissolution of the monasteries. It is, in the most literal sense, a Reformation family.

It is worth pausing for a moment on the strangeness of that.

The priory at Little Wymondley had been founded around the year 1200, by a Norman lord named Richard de Argenton, as a house of Augustinian canons regular. It was small — never more than twelve or fifteen canons at its medieval height, with the usual establishment of a prior, a sub-prior, a sacristan, a cellarer, an almoner, and lay servants. It served the parish church of Little Wymondley. The canons sang the offices day and night across three and a half centuries. They copied manuscripts. They kept the lamps lit. They said masses for the souls of the founders and the benefactors, of the local Argyll family and the surrounding gentry, of the men and women who had given the priory its land or its money or its candles. They buried their dead in the cloister. They tended the fish in the priory pond. They kept the bells.

By the time James inherited it, the priory was not pristine. The 1537 visitation by the Bishop of Lincoln — conducted only weeks before the suppression — found the priory's buildings "greatly ruined," and recorded that the prior, John Atow, had recently spent £5 on repairs with a further £15 4s 8d set aside for ongoing maintenance. The east end of the priory church appears to have collapsed shortly before the suppression. The 1537 inventory of the priory's possessions, taken when the canons were dispersed, does not list the chancel or the bell tower at all; the rooms listed are the hall, kitchen, brewhouse, bakehouse, buttery, pantry, and the prior's chamber. James was inheriting a half-ruined complex whose west end — the cloister and the western claustral ranges — had been recently patched and was at least habitable; whose east end was wreckage.

The 1536 Act of Suppression dissolved the smaller monasteries — those with annual incomes under two hundred pounds — and Wymondley fell well below that line. The canons were dispersed in 1537, given small pensions or moved to surviving houses. The priory church and the conventual buildings were taken into the king's hands by his commissioners. The site sat in Crown ownership for about a year while the Court of Augmentations — the new administrative office set up in 1536 to handle the redistribution of dissolved-monastery property — worked out what to do with it.

In December 1537 it was leased to James. In April 1538, eight years and six months into his surveyorship, the Court of Augmentations passed the priory to Henry VIII to be granted as a Crown reward, and the king gave it to James outright. The man who was building the king's palaces, restoring his castles, melting the lead from his dissolved abbeys, was given a dissolved abbey of his own — one whose recent damage would require him to do the very kind of repair-and-conversion work that he had been overseeing for the king for half a decade.

He was about forty-eight years old. He was at the peak of his career. He had a wife named Alice, the daughter (her son John would later swear to it, in the Heralds' Visitation pedigree he signed at Wymondley in the summer of 1572) of a Merry of Hatfield in Hertfordshire — the marriage may have been the connection that brought him to Wymondley in the first place. They had seven children, five sons and two daughters. The eldest was that same John, who would later sign the Visitation and who would later swear in Chancery that the priory had come by Crown grant from Henry. By the spring of 1538 John would have been somewhere between fifteen and twenty years old; he was old enough by April 1544 to be a named joint grantee with his father in a Hertfordshire land purchase.

The family came up to Wymondley. What James did with the buildings is one of the most carefully studied questions in the architectural history of Hertfordshire's post-Dissolution monastic conversions, and the answer is not what the v1 of this chapter assumed. He did not convert the prior's lodging into the family hall and keep the church as a private chapel. He did something more striking. He kept the western nave of the priory church itself as the principal hall of his new house. He inserted floors. He cut Tudor mullioned-and-transomed windows into the medieval lancet openings of the south wall. He converted the refectory and the western claustral ranges as ancillary domestic space. The eastern end of the church — the chancel, the crossing, the transepts, the bell tower — he left in the ruined state in which he had found it, or partly demolished it for stone. The cloister became an enclosed inner courtyard. The kitchens stayed in use. The fish pond stayed stocked.

This sounds, perhaps, harder than it was. The Augustinian canons had been gone for less than a year. Their church had been a working stone building when James obtained the lease in December. He kept the parts that were sound. He used the parts that were defensible to a working country gentleman's domestic life. The Nedeham family ate their dinners in the converted nave of the priory church. They walked, in their cloister-yard courtyard, on the stones the canons had walked. The wall paintings of the late medieval cloister walks were whitewashed over or replaced, but a fragment of late-sixteenth-century work survives in the north-east corner of the former cloister walk — a section of figural painting depicting armoured soldiers, possibly executed by James's son John or his grandson George later in the century, that was rediscovered during an architectural survey of the building in the 1990s and remains in situ. The chapel that the family used for baptisms and burials — the consecrated space in which

Barbara would be baptized in 1685 — was almost certainly a small consecrated portion preserved within the converted hall, possibly the area marked by a traceried recess that survives in the south end of the building and may once have been a piscina or the indication of a small private oratory. (The architectural-historical study of the priory by Nicholas Doggett, completed in 1997, is the authority for all of this, and the source on which this paragraph leans.)

The house became a house. The smell of incense, where it had lingered for three hundred and thirty-eight years, faded into the smell of cooking and woodsmoke and the press of household life.

What He Did at Wymondley

Four months before the priory grant, James had already begun building his Hertfordshire estate.

On 19 December 1537, by a legal instrument called a final concord — the standard Tudor mechanism for conveying real property through a fictitious lawsuit — he acquired from Francis Goodyere, esquire, of Hadley, a wood called Cattall Grove and adjoining land in South Mimms, Middlesex. South Mimms is about fifteen miles south of Little Wymondley, between Wymondley and London, on the Hertfordshire-Middlesex border. The wood was a working asset — standing oak, coppice, underwood for fuel and fencing. The conveyance is preserved at the Somerset Heritage Centre in the Walker-Heneage and Button family papers, catalogued as DD/2628.

This was a carpenter's purchase. A man of James's trade and life knew the value of having his own timber. The Cattall Grove wood gave him a private source of building material that he could draw on for his own works at Wymondley, or for projects elsewhere, or simply for the household use of a country gentleman. In December 1537, ten months before he took possession of the priory itself, James Nedeham bought a wood. The order of operations is itself revealing. He bought the materials first, and the seat second. The instinct of the working craftsman remained, even as the office of Surveyor was elevating him into gentry status.

Once the priory was his in April 1538 — or, properly, from December 1537 onward, when the lease put him in possession — he set about making it habitable and productive. The conversion was substantial. As described above, the western nave of the priory church became the hall of the new house; the refectory and the western claustral ranges were converted as ancillary space; the eastern end of the church was left ruined or partly demolished. The cloister became an inner courtyard. The kitchens, brewhouse, and bakehouse — still listed in the 1537 inventory as serviceable — stayed in use. James added at least two further structures outside the moated enclosure of the priory: a conduit to the north-east, bringing piped water from a higher point on the property down to the house, and a dovecote to the north-west, providing pigeons for the household table and as a sign of his new gentry status. (Dovecotes in Tudor England were a manorial

privilege; only lords of manors could legally keep them. James's dovecote was the architectural assertion of his having become one.) Both structures are dated by Doggett to the mid-sixteenth century, almost certainly during James's tenure or that of his son. The conversion would have taken two or three years. The main work was probably substantially complete by the early 1540s.

In 1541 he built the tithe barn.

This was the most substantial new structure he added to the property. The tithe barn was a separate building, set apart from the priory's domestic ranges, designed to hold the grain tithes that came in from the parish and the priory's outlying landholdings. The barn measured one hundred feet long, with nine bays on either side of a central threshing floor. It was timber-framed in oak, the principal posts and the tie beams quite possibly brought down out of the Cattall Grove wood that James had bought four years earlier in South Mimms — although the documentary trail does not survive to confirm the timber's origin. The frame was brick-infilled, with a tile roof. The interior was lit by small windows under the eaves; the floors were rammed earth or stone-flagged.

It is one of the finest surviving examples of an early Tudor timber-framed agricultural building in England. It is now operated as a working wedding and events venue, hosting up to two hundred and twenty guests for civil ceremonies under James Nedeham's roof. It is the most authentic surviving piece of his domestic architecture anywhere — his country buildings, made for his own estate, in the year of his own choosing, with timber from his own wood and at his own cost. The tithe barn is the home he made.

He continued to add land. On 22 April 1544 — or, more precisely, sometime during the regnal year that ran from that date to 21 April 1545 — he and his son John, described in the indenture as "James Nedeham of Wymondley, esquire, and John Nedeham, gentleman," purchased messuages and land in Bygrave next Baldock from one Thomas Myldemaye, esquire, of London. Bygrave is about ten miles east of Little Wymondley, in the same Hertfordshire countryside. The indenture is at the National Archives at Kew, catalogued among the Land Revenue records as LR 14/468. This is the documented moment at which James Nedeham styles himself, in a formal legal instrument, of Wymondley, Esquire. The Esquire status is recognized in a Crown-related land record. The six-year arc from London carpenter's son to Hertfordshire gentleman has formally completed.

It is also the last property record of his life. The Bygrave indenture covers the year that ran from April 1544 to April 1545. James died on 22 September 1544. The transaction may have been negotiated before his death and completed posthumously by John; or it may have been finished in the spring or early summer of 1544 before James embarked for the Continent. Either way, in the last months of his life he was still adding to the family estate.

Boulogne, and the Lead

The 1540s in James Nedeham's life have a particular weight.

By the spring of 1540 he was approaching fifty. He had been Surveyor for eight years. His patron Thomas Cromwell was beginning to lose the king's favor; on 28 July 1540 Cromwell would be executed on Tower Hill, on the same day Henry married his fifth wife Catherine Howard. James kept his office. He continued his work. Catherine Howard would be executed in turn in February 1542, on the same scaffold; James was still Surveyor. The king married his sixth wife Catherine Parr in July 1543; James was still Surveyor.

In these years he was running, simultaneously, the largest set of monastic conversions in the kingdom. The pay-books document, between 1540 and 1544, the demolition of Barking Abbey for stone to rebuild the king's manor at Dartford, the conversion of Rochester Priory into a Crown college and then into a Crown manor, the demolition of buildings at St Augustine's Canterbury — where, in January 1542, the great Norman steeple of the abbey came down with such force that it broke a section of the king's garden wall — and the redistribution, through his office, of the lead stripped from these and other dissolved religious houses to the roofs of the king's palaces.

The lead account survives, in the State Papers at the National Archives, catalogued as SP 5/4/196. It covers the period from 22 April 1542 to 21 April 1544 — the regnal years 34 and 35 of Henry VIII, James's last two full working years. The account is described in the catalog as London and Home Counties Monasteries: account of lead by James Nedeham, clerk of the King's Works, 34-35 Hen. VIII, giving destinations of the lead.

This is an inventory of stripped monastic lead and its redistribution. The lead from the roofs of the dissolved abbeys and priories of London and its surrounding counties — Barking, Canterbury, Dartford, Rochester, and others — was measured in fother (about a ton each), melted, recast in sheets, and laid down again on the king's palace roofs at Greenwich and Whitehall and Hampton Court. The man who oversaw this process across the entire London region for the last two years of his life was James Nedeham.

It is the hardest detail to write about. The administrative neutrality of the account — the columns of weights and destinations and prices in pence per pound — cannot quite obscure what the work meant. The lead that had covered the cloisters of the canons regular and the friars and the nuns for hundreds of years was being reweighed and recast and laid down again on the roofs of the king's residences. James, who in those same years was living in his own former priory at Wymondley, was the executive in charge of physically dismantling other people's former priories so their metal could go onto the king's palaces.

The Reformation, in the documentary record of his life, is not a single event of 1536 or 1539. It is the ongoing job of his last decade. It is the demolition of Barking Abbey in the summer of 1541, paid by the four-week period to a crew of

named workmen — Robert Carterwryght, William Tompson, Reynold Newcome, Phillip Salamond — whose tallies survive in MS Rawlinson D. 782 at the Bodleian Library. It is the cleanup of the fallen Norman steeple at St Augustine's Canterbury in early 1542. It is the redistribution of monastic lead across the Home Counties in 1542-44. It is the work of a man who has benefited materially from the dissolution and who is, by the office he holds, an active executor of its physical violence.

This is part of who he was. The book does not flinch from it. It also does not impose modern judgment on it. He was, by the standards of his own time, doing a job that was within his office and within the law as Parliament had framed it. He was not unusual in doing it; thousands of English Crown servants and gentry families benefited materially from the dissolution. But to write his life honestly is to name the work he did, including the work whose moral weight does not soften under any later light.

In July 1544 Henry VIII led an English army across the Channel to besiege the French port of Boulogne, on the Pas-de-Calais coast about a hundred miles south of the English-held enclave of Calais. The campaign was the latest episode in the long Tudor war with France. The English laid siege to Boulogne through the summer; the city surrendered on 14 September 1544. The king entered in triumph. The army began the work of fortifying the captured city as a permanent English possession, which it would remain until 1550.

James Nedeham was with the king's army on that campaign. He was almost certainly there in his capacity as Surveyor, responsible for fortifications and military construction — the same kind of work he had done as a young military carpenter at Calais twenty years before. He was now about fifty-four years old. He had been at war before, but not for two decades. He had a wife in Hertfordshire and a country house and a tithe barn that was three years old and seven children growing into their own lives.

He died at Boulogne on 22 September 1544 — eight days after the city fell. The cause is not recorded in the surviving documentation. Tudor military camps were lethal places even in victory; dysentery, plague, and gangrene from minor wounds killed more soldiers than the fighting did. He was buried in the church of Our Lady at Boulogne.

The family commemorated him in Hertfordshire sixty-one years later. In 1605, his grandson George Nedeham — the lord of the manor by then, son of John, the same George who would later impropriate the rectory and pay the parish curate out of the tithes — dedicated a monument to his father and grandfather in the chancel of the parish church at Little Wymondley. The inscription, transcribed by Sir Henry Chauncy when he wrote his county history a hundred years afterward and preserved in print at page 362 of *The Historical Antiquities of Hertfordshire* (1700), reads in his transcription: James Needham, of the ancient Family of the Needhams in Derbyshire, came into this County of Hertford, in the year of our Lord, 1536. He was advanced by King Henry the

eight, for his Service in England and France, and lyes buried in our Ladies Church in Boloigne; he had issue John, who had George, who dedicated this Monument to their Memory, Anno 1605. Beneath, a single line of Latin: *Satius est mortis quam Natalis dies*. Better is the day of death than the day of birth. Ecclesiastes 7:1.

The inscription is the family's own statement of itself. It names Derbyshire as the place the line came from; it names 1536 as the year James came into Hertfordshire — one year before the lease and two before the patent, which fits the pattern of his service on the dissolution-survey commissions before he was personally rewarded with the property. It names the king he had served. It names the church across the Channel in which his body lay. And it names his grandson as the one who, in the year the King James Bible was a project five years from completion, set the stone to keep all of this in view of the parish.

What James Means

Three things, before this chapter closes.

First, the family seat is not an inheritance. It is a reward. The priory was a gift from the king to a man who had earned it by twelve years of running the king's building program. This will shape everything that follows. The Wymondley Nedhams will be careful with the Court, because their seat came from the Court. They will avoid open political conflict. They will keep the priory through Mary, Elizabeth, James I, Charles I, the Commonwealth, Cromwell, Charles II, James II, and William and Mary — eight monarchs and one republic — by being unobtrusive, and the unobtrusiveness begins with the founder. James knew what he owed the king. His descendants would know it too. When the Civil War came, ninety-eight years after the grant, his great-grandson Eustace would survive it by keeping his head down. The strategy started with James.

Second, the family's records survived. The pay-books that James and Antony Pontesbury wrote stayed at Wymondley for two hundred and thirty years. They passed, through the family's careful keeping of its papers, into the antiquarian collection of Richard Rawlinson in the eighteenth century, and from Rawlinson at his death in 1755 to the Bodleian Library at Oxford, where they have been for two hundred and seventy-one years. The Bodleian preserves James Nedeham's working life in a level of documentary completeness that almost no comparable Tudor administrator can claim. His life is recoverable because his descendants kept the papers. The chapter you have just read could not have been written without those volumes. The volumes survived because the family stayed at Wymondley long enough to preserve them, and because when Wymondley was finally sold, the books went with the daughter who carried them out.

Third — and this is the one the rest of the book is going to lean on — the buildings James made are still standing.

The Great Hall at Hampton Court Palace is still standing. The hammer-beam roof he designed in the early 1530s and finished in 1535 has held up the ceiling,

without major reconstruction, for four hundred and ninety-one years. Anyone can go and look at it. The palace is open to the public throughout the year.

The framing above the Traitors' Gate at the Tower of London is still standing. The Jewel House he built is still part of the Tower's standing fabric. The north terrace at Windsor Castle, with its drainage vaults, is still there. The repairs and reinforcements he made to the medieval hammer-beam roof of Westminster Hall are still holding up the roof. The conversions he oversaw at St Augustine's Canterbury are still in part visible at the site, which is now an English Heritage property open to the public.

This needs a small honest correction, because Wymondley is not quite like Hampton Court.

The priory house at Little Wymondley is still standing. The west range and the converted nave that James turned into his hall are still on the same footprint they have occupied since the late 1530s. But a restoration of the building carried out in 1973 and 1974 — by a private owner, under no architectural-historical supervision worth mentioning — destroyed almost all the surviving sixteenth-century datable features of the interior. The Tudor mullioned-and-transomed windows James cut into the medieval lancets, the original panelling, the early fireplaces, the carpentry detail of his hall: virtually all of it was lost, replaced with twentieth-century approximations of what the work had been. The current priory house is, in physical terms, a post-1974 reconstruction over a medieval shell. The building James lived in survives as a footprint, a set of walls, and a few fragments — the wall-painting in the cloister walk, the traceried recess, the conduit and dovecote outside the moated enclosure. The interior he actually lived in has, for the most part, not survived the twentieth century.

This is painful. It is also why the tithe barn matters as much as it does.

The tithe barn at Little Wymondley — the building he commissioned for his own estate in 1541, with his own money, on his own land, three years after he received the priory and three years before he died at Boulogne — is still standing in essentially the form he commissioned it. The oak frame is the oak frame. The hammer-beam construction is the construction his carpenters set up under his direction in the summer of 1541. The barn was not part of the 1973-74 restoration; it was already operating as an agricultural building outside the residential complex, and its agricultural use into the late twentieth century meant that its working fabric was left largely alone. By the time it was adapted for civil-ceremony use, beginning in the 1990s, the bones of the building had survived essentially intact. The tithe barn is the most authentic surviving piece of James Nedeham's domestic architecture anywhere on earth. It is the only structure of his own that you can walk into today and touch the timber he commissioned. The current owners use it for weddings. They market the venue on the strength of its 1541 date. The building's history page reads, in part: At the heart of the estate stands the magnificent tithe barn, built in 1541 by James Needham, a master

carpenter to King Henry VIII. Rich in history and craftsmanship, it is widely regarded as one of the finest timber barns in England.

Eight generations later, in late October 1713, a young woman who had grown up in those buildings — the chapel where she was baptized, the cloister yard she had played in as a child, the tithe barn that stood at the eastern edge of the priory grounds and that she had walked past every day of her life — would put a small trunk on a cart and ride out the priory gatehouse onto the Hitchin road for the last time. She would be twenty-eight years old. She would be carrying a letter she had written in August saying I am coming. She would be sailing, before the end of the year, for a country that had just had a war.

James could not have imagined her. He was a fifty-four-year-old Surveyor of the King's Works dying at Boulogne in September 1544, with a tithe barn finished three years earlier and seven children growing into a new and unprecedented family standing in Hertfordshire and a king who would outlive him by two years and four months. He had no idea that his great-great-great-great-granddaughter would carry a small piece of his work and the memory of his house across an ocean. He had no idea that the priory he had been given by the king would pass out of the family in 1733, two hundred and seventy-one years after his death; or that his pay-books would outlast the family's tenure of the priory; or that a descendant in Alabama in 2026 would be reading them in a digitized image on a laptop screen and writing this paragraph.

He had a barn to finish.

It is, for now, the last thing he made that we know of for certain. The Cattall Grove wood likely gave at least some of the timber. His own carpenters — men whose names are not recorded but who would have come up from London or from one of the king's work-sites — framed the roof. The tile came from a local kiln. The brick came up from the brickfields north of the priory. The frame went up in the summer of 1541 and the roof went on by the autumn and the barn was substantially complete by the end of the year, or shortly into 1542. James lived less than three years after it was finished.

The barn is still standing in Hertfordshire.

So is the family.

* * *

On the night of 22 September 1544, in the church of Our Lady at Boulogne, James Nedeham was buried. He was fifty-four. He had been Surveyor of the King's Works for twelve years all but eight days. He left a wife in Hertfordshire, seven children, two hundred and forty-six pay-books and account-books and working ledgers documenting his administrative life, a country house that had been a priory, a tithe barn three years old, a wood in South Mimms, a recent property in Bygrave, and a legal style of Esquire of Wymondley that he had earned by service to the Crown across the span of the most consequential decade of the Reformation.

He also left a son named John, then about twenty, who would inherit the priory — though not, in the strict legal sense, in 1544. James had taken the precaution, before he sailed for Boulogne, of obtaining a licence to entail the manor on John. The entail had to be executed through the Court of Wards before John could enter the freehold, and the year between James's death in September 1544 and John's succession in 1545 is the year that mechanism took to grind through. In 1545 John entered. He would go on to defend the priory in Chancery against William Clarke in the Elizabethan era, marry twice, sign the Heralds' Visitation pedigree at Wymondley in the summer of 1572 by signing his own name at the bottom of the page, and raise the next generation of the family who would carry the house forward through the wars and revolutions of the next two centuries.

That signature is in the next chapter.

Chapter 2 — Signing the Pedigree

In the summer of 1572, in a Hertfordshire field three miles south of Hitchin and a hundred and twenty paces east of the chapel that had once been the priory church, a man named John Nedham sat down at a trestle table that a herald's clerk had set up that morning under an awning, and signed his own name at the bottom of a folio of vellum.

He was about forty-eight years old. He had been lord of the manor of Little Wymondley for twenty-seven years. He had married twice, had buried one wife and was living with the second, and had twelve children — five sons and seven daughters — across the two marriages, of whom the eldest was a boy of sixteen who would, nine years later, ride into Kent to marry a Beckenham heiress, and the youngest were not yet out of leading-strings. He held a former monastic house and a working estate that produced rents in coin and tithes in kind from arable land in Hertfordshire and parsonage tithes from a parish in Bedfordshire. He held the rectory of Wymondley Parva by lay impropriation. He was, by every visible measure, what the herald in front of him had ridden up from London to verify. He was a gentleman. He was the right kind of gentleman to be one.

The herald in front of him was Robert Cooke, Clarenceux King of Arms.

Cooke had taken up the Clarenceux office five years before, in 1567, and would hold it until his death in 1593 — a quarter-century of riding from county to county auditing the gentry of half the realm. Clarenceux had jurisdiction over the southern province of England, every county south of the River Trent; the northern counties were the province of Norroy, his colleague. The two of them, between them, were the Crown's working census-takers of the English gentry class. They came armed with letters patent under the Great Seal of Elizabeth I and with the authority to summon every man in the realm who called himself a gentleman, and to demand that he prove, in writing and to the herald's satisfaction, his right to do so.

The proof was a pedigree. Drawn out on paper or vellum, prepared in advance by the gentleman himself or by a kinsman or by a clerk he had retained for the purpose, the pedigree was a written genealogy showing the gentleman's descent through the male line back as far as the evidence permitted, with marriages noted, daughters' alliances recorded, and children's ages given. It listed the coat of arms the family had borne and any earlier coat it had borne before. It was sworn to by the head of family in front of the herald and signed by him as a statement of truth. The herald either confirmed it under his own hand and seal — meaning he accepted it as good — or rejected it as false or unfounded, in which case the gentleman's children would be disclaimed at the next visitation as not gentry at all.

The legal stakes were substantial. A family disclaimed by the heralds lost the right to call its head an Esquire, to bear arms over a door or on a seal or on a

tomb, to take precedence in church, and — at the more punitive edge — to be admitted to certain professions and to certain levels of office in the county. The visitation was the gentry's own audit, conducted on the gentry's behalf, by their fellow gentlemen working under royal warrant.

John Nedham had prepared his pedigree carefully.

The clerk had written it out on the page in front of him in the formal hand the heralds used for fair copy. At the top, anonymous and unornamented, the dynastic anchor: Nedam of Darbishire. The name with which the family had begun and to which it still looked. Below it, the first named man: James Nedam of Chislest in Kent, married to Alice, daughter of Merry of Hatfield. James was John's father — the Surveyor of the King's Works under Henry VIII, the man who had received Wymondley from the Crown in 1538, the man who had built the tithe barn three miles down the road in 1541 and had died at Boulogne in 1544. The clerk had recorded him with his Kentish residence as Chiselhurst, where James had held a house before Wymondley was granted; the Wymondley seat itself was not noted in the 1572 pedigree, presumably because the herald already knew where he was sitting that afternoon. The pedigree was a record of antecedents. The present was what the herald could see for himself.

Below James and Alice came John, the man at the table.

He was recorded with both his wives. Ann, daughter of William Coppin of Canterbury, 1 wife.

Jane, daughter of Weldishe of Cranbroke in Kent, 2 wife. The first wife was named with her father's full name and the Canterbury seat; the second with her father's surname and the Kent town. The first wife was dead by 1572 — Anne Coppin had given John five or six of his children and had died sometime in the 1560s; the chapter cannot precisely date the death because the Little Wymondley parish register before 1583 has not survived. Jane Weldish was alive that summer, somewhere in the priory house, possibly with the younger children. She would outlive John by several years and would die a widow at Wymondley in the early seventeenth century, after raising not only her own children but her stepchildren as well.

A note in the right-hand margin of the pedigree recorded the existence of John's younger brother William Nedam of London, draper — a man who had taken his portion in trade rather than in land, joined the Drapers' Company in the City, and lived out his life in the cloth trade in the capital. William was not at Wymondley that summer. He was at his counting-house in London and would not be summoned by the Clarenceux herald, because the City of London was its own jurisdiction and its gentry were registered under separate visitation arrangements. He was named in the pedigree as a courtesy to the documentary record. The two brothers had remained in contact across the divide between county and capital — gentry and trade — that ran through every Tudor family with a younger son.

Below John and his two wives came the twelve children, listed by the clerk in two clusters separated by their mothers, with the boys' ages noted because boys' ages mattered for inheritance. By the first wife Anne Coppin: George the eldest, sixteen years old, son and heir; then in tangled order Coppin Nedam aged thirteen, Thomas aged eleven, John the younger aged seven; and the daughters Anne, Gilian, Bridgett, Mary, Elizabeth, the second Anne, Margaret, Jane. Daughter Anne — the eldest — had already been married, to a Thomas Pole, younger son of one of the Poles of London; her marriage had taken place before the visitation and had brought the family its first London-merchant alliance. The other seven daughters were not yet married. Some were children. Some were on the cusp of marriageable age. All of them would, in the next twenty years, be matched to gentry families of the home counties — Bedfordshire, Northamptonshire, Hertfordshire, Kent — in the pattern that minor county gentry used to extend their kin-network outward without dispersing the family seat.

The arms came next. The clerk had drawn them in pen-and-ink trick — the heraldic shorthand by which an artist of small skill but precise hand could indicate the tinctures of a coat without needing to apply color. Azure, on a chevron between three escallops Argent as many acorns Vert, on a chief crenellée Or three martlets Gules. In plain English: a blue shield, charged with a silver chevron on which sat three green acorns; on either side of the chevron, silver escallop shells; and across the top of the shield, an embattled gold border on which stood three red martlets, the small heraldic birds with no feet, traditional emblems of the younger sons of an armigerous house. The crest, drawn in a wreath above the shield: a dolphin naiant Or, a gold dolphin swimming horizontally. The arms were the family's identity in visible form. They would appear over doorways, on seal-rings, on plate, on the cover of books, on funeral hatchments, on tomb stones for the next three and a half centuries.

A small note, in Cooke's own hand or in his clerk's, was appended at the head of the entry: *Vide Cla. Cook's guift for another coat. See Clarenceux Cook's gift for another coat.* The herald had brought with him, in his saddlebags, a separate document — a draft grant of arms in his own name, ready for the family's eventual taking-up. The acorns-and-martlets coat was the family's older blazon, the one James had used or that James's son Christopher had used before him. Cooke was offering a second coat, fresh and distinct, granted on the family's contemporary standing rather than confirmed on its inherited claim. The second coat would not be formally registered for another fourteen years; in the summer of 1572, Cooke recorded only the intention. The family declined to take it up immediately. The reason for the fourteen-year delay is not preserved in any surviving record. It may have been money: a grant of arms cost a fee, sometimes a substantial one, and a man with twelve children and a recently-rebuilt parish church was a man whose ready cash was committed.

It may have been deliberation: the older coat was the one Cooke was confirming on the day of the visitation, and the family may have wanted to think before changing its visible identity.

Whatever the reason, in the summer of 1572 the family carried the acorns and the martlets. The dolphin swam above the shield. The shield went up at the gable end of the priory house and was carved in stone above the principal door. The same arms were impressed in the wax of John's seal whenever he sent a letter or witnessed a deed.

At the bottom of the page the clerk stopped writing.

He turned the vellum across the trestle so the writing faced the man on the other side. He set a quill across the inkstone, and he set the inkstone — a small flat stone of black slate, refilled that morning from a clay bottle — within John's right hand's easy reach. He stood back a half-step. The herald, sitting just behind the clerk on a stool brought out from the house, said the words the heralds said at this point in the procedure — that the pedigree as written was the petitioner's own statement, given under his own hand and seal, and that the petitioner now subscribed it as the truth. The petitioner picked up the quill. He dipped it. He set the tip to the vellum.

By me JOHN NEDHAM.

He signed it in the careful late-Tudor hand his father had taught him forty years earlier in a London schoolroom and that he had been practicing on accounts and indentures and parish-vestry minutes ever since. The capital letters had a small finishing flourish; the m of me and the e of NEDHAM descended slightly below the line. The signature occupied an inch and a quarter of the bottom edge of the page. The ink was the standard iron-gall mixture every clerk used in 1572: it would still be legible on the same page four hundred and fifty years later, when his nine-times-great-grandson's nine-times-great-grandson sat in a house in Alabama and read it on a screen. There was no way to know that. He sealed the entry by pressing his ring into a small puddle of red wax — the dolphin-and-chevron seal, the family's old blazon — and waited while the clerk dusted the ink with pounce and folded the vellum back to its register-place.

The herald accepted the entry. The visitation court moved on to the next family.

John Nedham stood up. He thanked Cooke for his attention, with the courtesies that the gentleman-class used to its own working professionals. He walked back across the priory yard toward the house. His eldest son George, sixteen, met him at the chapel door and asked, in the manner of a son who had been waiting for an outcome, whether everything had gone as expected. It went, John said. We are recorded.

It went, indeed. The signature he had set on the page that afternoon was the family's documented existence beginning at primary-source level. Everything in this book that comes before that signature is reconstructed from older traditions, from his father's surviving pay-books, from the architectural fabric of the priory,

from the wills that survive of his more distant cousins. Everything that comes after the signature, every birth and marriage and death and inheritance and quarrel and emigration that this book is going to follow across the next hundred and forty-two years, sits inside a documentary frame that begins, in concrete public record, on a Hertfordshire summer afternoon in 1572 with a man pressing a quill to vellum at a trestle table in his own priory yard.

This is his story, and what came of it.

* * *

James to Christopher to John: the inheritance generation

John Nedham was born in or about 1524 in London.

The date is inferred. No baptismal record survives — the parish register of any London church that might have recorded a London-born Nedham child of the early 1520s has either been lost or has not been searched, and the project's working hypothesis rests on the documented chronology of his father's career and his own subsequent life. James Nedeham, John's father, was in London continuously from about 1517, when he completed his Carpenters' Company apprenticeship, through 1532, when he was appointed Surveyor of the King's Works. James married Alice Merry of Hatfield in Hertfordshire sometime in the 1510s or early 1520s — the 1572 pedigree names her father's surname as Merry, the 1634 pedigree as Goodere, a discrepancy that may reflect a remarriage on her mother's side or a simple sixty-year-later misremembering and that the project flags as an open documentary question. John was the eldest surviving son. He was old enough by April 1544 to be named as a joint grantee with his father in a Hertfordshire land purchase at Bygrave (TNA LR 14/468), which placed him at about twenty in that year. Working backward from twenty, he was born about 1524.

He spent his boyhood in London. James's working life through the 1520s and the early 1530s was a London life — a London carpenter's-yard life through his twenties, a London royal-buildings life from 1531 onward. The Nedeham household was somewhere in the City. The exact parish is not preserved in the surviving record. John would have been baptized at a London church on the eighth day after his birth, in the standard Tudor practice, and he would have learned to read at a London grammar school in the late 1530s. The grammar in question is not documented, but two plausible candidates exist: St Paul's, the elite Mercers' school refounded by Dean Colet in 1509, where the sons of City freemen and rising royal servants alternated on the benches; or the Carpenters' Company school, which the Company operated for the apprentices and the sons of its members. James was a Carpenters' Company member, a warden in 1515 and 1533 and a Master in 1534, 1535, and 1542. If the Company school took the sons of senior wardens, John may have been there.

What is documented is that by 1538, when his father was granted Wymondley Priory and the family began to make the priory into a country seat, John was about fourteen — old enough to ride out to Hertfordshire with his father and to begin to think of the priory as the family's eventual home rather than as one of his father's many working projects. He may have spent the years 1538 to 1544 dividing his time between London and Wymondley: at the City house with his mother and the younger children when his father was in town; up at the priory in the long Hertfordshire summers when the works at Westminster slackened and the household decamped to the country. He may, at fourteen or fifteen, have ridden over from Wymondley to Hitchin on market days to look at the cattle and the cloth-stalls and the gathered farmers of the Broadwater Hundred. He may have stood in the south doorway of the priory chapel — the chapel that was, in James's hands, becoming the family's burial church — and watched his father's masons cut Tudor windows into medieval lancets. The project record does not preserve these things specifically; the boy's life inside the man's working life is one of the silences in the documentary record. What can be said is that John spent his late boyhood and early adolescence in the transition between his father's London identity and the family's Hertfordshire one. He came of age, in the most literal sense, at the moment the family was changing what kind of family it was.

His father died on 22 September 1544.

James was at Boulogne with Henry VIII's army, in the camp outside the recently-captured French city, eight days after the city had fallen. The cause of death has not been recovered from the surviving record. Tudor military camps were lethal places even in victory; dysentery, plague, gangrene from minor wounds, and the typhus that travelled in army cloth all killed more soldiers in the 1540s than the fighting did. James was buried in the church of Our Lady at Boulogne, in a foreign country, on a campaign his eldest son had not been able to follow him on because the eldest son had been left in England as the family representative for the interim. He was fifty-four. He had been Surveyor for twelve years all but eight days. The news of his death travelled back from Boulogne by Crown courier to London and from London by household messenger to Wymondley.

John, twenty years old, heard it sometime in the first week of October 1544 in the great hall of the priory.

The succession was not automatic. James had foreseen this and had taken precautions. Before he sailed for France he had obtained a royal licence to entail the manor of Little Wymondley on John — meaning that the estate was settled by deed to descend to John and his heirs, rather than passing under the ordinary rules of inheritance through the Court of Wards. The Court of Wards was the Crown agency that supervised the inheritances of men who held land of the king by knight-service, which James's Wymondley grant had been; without the licence to entail, the Court would have taken John as a Crown ward (he was an under-age heir at his father's death, by the operative definition of under-age in the Court's

procedure, which counted men under twenty-one) and would have administered the estate during the minority. The licence sidestepped that. It allowed John to enter the freehold once the Court of Wards had verified the entail's terms — a process that took the better part of a year, between September 1544 and the summer of 1545.

In 1545 John entered.

He was twenty-one, possibly twenty-two, depending on which month the entail-execution ran through. He had a stepmother in the household — Alice Merry, James's widow, who was probably still alive in 1545; her death is not documented and may have come at any point between 1545 and the 1570s. He had at least four younger siblings: his sister Mary, whose marriage to John Parker, Counsellor at Law of Radwell, would in due course be a marriage of legal and gentry significance; his brother William, the future London draper; and at least two other siblings, whose names and life-courses are obscured by the gaps in the documentary record. The household at Wymondley in the autumn of 1545 was a household in transition. The Surveyor was dead. The young heir was the head. The country was at war with France and with Scotland simultaneously. The king on the throne would be dead in two years. The young heir would have to make every decision about what kind of country house Wymondley would now be — what kind of household, what kind of estate, what kind of family standing — without the man whose office and reputation had made the family's standing possible in the first place.

He was, suddenly, the inheritance generation.

He had not asked for it. He had inherited a working priory, a working tithe barn (then four years old), a working set of agricultural lands, the rectory and tithes of Wilshamstead in Bedfordshire, a wood in South Mimms, a recent property in Bygrave, and the legal style of Esquire of Wymondley. He had inherited his father's reputation — both the favorable side of it (the man who had built the king's palaces and had been a household name in the King's Works office) and the more complicated side (the man who had been close to Cromwell in the consequential summer of 1532, the man who had personally overseen the stripping of the lead from the dissolved monasteries, the man whose Wymondley priory had until eight years earlier been a working Augustinian house with its own canons singing the offices). The inheritance was unambiguous as a matter of property and ambiguous as a matter of public character. John would have to decide, over the next four and a half decades, what to keep and what to set aside.

What he kept, mostly, was the property. What he set aside, mostly, was the dust of his father's career as a Crown servant. He did not himself enter Crown service. He did not, so far as the record shows, seek office at Court. He did not ride to musters or sit on commissions of the peace at the highest county level; he served, when he was called, on more local instruments — parish vestry, hundred boards, the occasional commission. He set the family's center of gravity firmly in Hertfordshire, in the priory, in the parish, in the surrounding gentry. He was, in

the modern phrase, the man who took the founder's gains and put them on a steady track.

He also got married. Twice. — — —

The two wives

The first wife was Anne Coppin of Canterbury.

She was the daughter of William Coppin, gentleman, of the parish of St Margaret in Canterbury — a member of the small Kentish gentry circle that the Coppins inhabited in the middle decades of the sixteenth century, neither at the level of the great Kentish houses (the Sidneys at Penshurst, the Wyatts at Allington) nor down among the yeoman freeholders, but in the comfortable in-between in which a gentleman held a town house, a small country property, and a body of leases in the cathedral city's prebendal estates. The Coppins of Canterbury were a Kentish merchant-gentry family of the kind that had risen during the dissolution of the cathedral monastery in 1540 to take up some of the secular tenancies that the monks had previously held. They were not a great catch in the high-Tudor marriage market. They were, however, a perfectly respectable one for the heir of Wymondley.

The marriage took place sometime in the late 1540s. The exact date has not been recovered; no record of it survives in the Canterbury cathedral or parish archives that have been searched at the present writing. The marriage was very probably arranged through the Kent connection that James Nedeham had maintained from his pre-Wymondley years — James had held a house at Chiselhurst in Kent in the early 1540s, and the 1572 pedigree records his Kent residence rather than his Hertfordshire one, suggesting that the Kent connection had remained operative until the end of his life. James, before he died, may have proposed the Coppin match for his eldest son. Or the match may have come about through John's own visits to Kent in his early twenties, perhaps at his father's surviving connections. The mechanism is recoverable only by inference; what is documented is that the bride was Anne Coppin and that John acquired through her a small dowry, a Kentish connection, and a wife.

Anne brought him five or six children. The 1572 pedigree, drawn up after her death, divides John's twelve children into two clusters by their two mothers and gives the first cluster as the elder. George Nedam, son and heir, then sixteen; born therefore about 1556. Coppin Nedam — named for his mother's family, in the Tudor practice of carrying the maternal surname forward as a child's Christian name — then thirteen, born about 1559. Thomas Nedam then eleven, born about 1561. The other named child of the first marriage is Anne, the eldest daughter, who had already been married off to Thomas Pole of London by the time of the 1572 visitation. There may have been additional children of Anne Coppin who died in infancy and who are not in the pedigree's roster because the pedigree recorded only the survivors. The infant mortality of mid-Tudor England

was substantial. It would have been remarkable for a marriage of ten or twelve years' duration to produce only the four children the pedigree records as Anne Coppin's; the working assumption of family historians of the period is that one in three children born did not reach their seventh birthday. The Coppin-Nedham line probably ran to seven or eight births of which five or six survived to be named in 1572.

Anne died sometime between 1561 (the birth of Thomas) and 1565 (when the second-wife cluster begins). The probable midpoint is about 1563. The cause of her death is not preserved. Childbirth was the most common single cause of death for women in their thirties in Tudor England — the puerperal fevers, the obstructed labors, the slow blood-loss of a poorly resolved pregnancy all killed a substantial fraction of married Englishwomen between the ages of twenty-five and forty. The likelihood is that Anne died in or shortly after childbirth, possibly carrying a child who did not survive her. She was buried at Little Wymondley parish church, in the chapel that had been the priory church, in the cloister or under the chancel; the exact spot is no longer marked, the priory church's interior having been substantially refigured in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries and again in the nineteenth, with any surviving Tudor monuments either re-set, plastered over, or removed. The 1605 monument that John's son George I would erect in the chancel commemorates James and John but not Anne; the family's pre-1605 dead remained unmemorialized, in the post-Reformation Protestant convention of avoiding monumental display for the soul's benefit and reserving it for posterity's instruction.

The second wife came two or three years later. She was Jane Weldish of Cranbrook in Kent.

Cranbrook is a small Wealden town in southwest Kent, about thirty miles south of Canterbury and forty south of the priory at Chiselhurst. The Weldish family — sometimes spelled Welbish or Welbisshe in earlier records — were minor Cranbrook gentry of the cloth-making class. The town of Cranbrook in the sixteenth century was at the heart of the Kent broadcloth trade, the high-end of the English cloth industry that produced the best lengths of dyed-in-the-wool fabric for the European market. The Weldish family had risen through cloth, like several Wealden families before them, and held property in and near the town. They were not Canterbury-gentry; they were Wealden cloth-gentry; the distinction was small but real. Jane was probably a generation younger than Anne Coppin had been; she may have been a young woman of twenty or twenty-two when John married her in the mid-1560s.

The two Kent marriages, taken together, made the Nedhams a Kent-Hertfordshire family in a particular and specific way. Their first three marriages — James to Alice of Hatfield, John to Anne of Canterbury, John to Jane of Cranbrook — had all been into the home counties broadly, with a marked preference for Kent.

James's hand was probably in the first two; the third was John's own choice, perhaps using the Kent contacts his father and his first wife had bequeathed him. The Kent connection persisted into the next generation. It would not, however, become the family's defining feature; the next-generation match (George the heir's marriage at Beckenham in 1581) would be a Kent marriage too, but after that the family would turn inward toward Hertfordshire and Bedfordshire, marrying its neighbors rather than its more distant correspondents. The Kent phase of the Wymondley Nedhams was a function of James's pre-Wymondley life, carried over into John's first two marriages by the inertia of established contact, and quietly dropped after George.

Jane Weldish gave John his second cluster of children. By the 1572 pedigree's roster: a son named John the younger, then seven years old — born therefore about 1565, very close to the start of the second marriage — and a daughter named Mary, plus the additional daughters Elizabeth, the second Anne, Margaret, Jane. Gilian and Bridgett may also have been Jane's; the pedigree's ordering of the daughters does not perfectly disambiguate them by mother. The 1634 visitation, drawn up sixty-two years later when the herald's clerk no longer had John or Jane to consult, would record the children of John's marriages in a different order and would name a son James who is not in the 1572 list, along with the now-famous Sir John of Lichborough — both apparently of the second marriage. The 1634 list has the structural defect of being drawn from family memory rather than from John's own deposition; the 1572 list, signed by John himself, is the primary anchor.

What needs to be noted, even at the risk of getting ahead of the narrative, is one specific child of the second marriage. The 1634 pedigree, identifying the brothers of the 1581 Beckenham groom (the heir George), names Sir John Needham of Lichborough, co. Northampton, Kt., Pensioner to Q. Elizabeth, as one of John of Wymondley's children. The 1572 pedigree lists a John Nedam, is 7 yeres old — born about 1565 — among the children of the second marriage; but the 1572 pedigree does not name a son James, who appears in the 1634 list as another of John's children. The two pedigrees disagree on the exact roster. The most economical reconciliation is that the 1572 list is incomplete (very young children sometimes were not listed if they had just been born, or if they were felt to be unlikely to survive) and that James and the second John of the 1634 list are the same generation but were either born very late in the 1572 visitation year, after the herald had recorded the roster, or in the late 1570s. Sir John of Lichborough must have been one of these. He grew up to be the family's only courtly figure; he was knighted by Elizabeth I; he became one of Her Majesty's Gentleman Pensioners; he married a sister of Sir Lewis Watson of Rockingham, the future Baron Rockingham. He is the topic of §2.6.

For the present, the central fact about Jane Weldish is simply that she was the second wife and that she carried, through her remaining children, half of the next generation of the family. She would outlive John, who died in 1591 or 1592 — the

exact date is unrecovered; he was buried at Little Wymondley at some point in the early 1590s — and she would die at Wymondley sometime in the next decade. She would have lived to see George marry at Beckenham in 1581. She would have lived to see Sir John knighted at Court. She would have lived to see the Spanish Armada and to hear of its defeat. She would have lived to see at least three of her stepdaughters marry into Bedfordshire houses (the Mordaunts of Northill, the Pigotts of Gravenhurst, the Langhorne of Bedfordshire). She would have died sometime around 1600 — old enough to be a grandmother several times over, by then with grandchildren growing up in the same priory house in which she had raised her children.

There was also the third connection. The marriage of the eldest daughter, Anne.

Anne Nedham, John's eldest daughter by Anne Coppin, had already been married off to Thomas Pole, 2 son of Thomas Pole of London, by the time of the 1572 visitation. The marriage had taken place perhaps in 1569 or 1570 — Anne would have been about fifteen or sixteen, the standard upper age for a first gentry marriage of a daughter without an estate to inherit. Thomas Pole was a younger son of the Pole family of London, a minor branch of the much larger Pole connection that had stood at the highest levels of mid-Tudor politics until the executions of the elder Plantagenet Poles in 1538 and 1539. The London Poles of the 1570s were a respectable merchant-gentry line, second cousins or further removed from the great Poles, with the political stain of the older generation receding into the past. Anne Pole was the first Nedham daughter to be married off in the new generation. Her marriage settlement is not preserved. The Pole connection is recorded in both the 1572 and the 1634 visitations and seems to have been a settled, working alliance; the line continued forward into the early seventeenth century, after which the project record loses track of it.

Anne's marriage was the first piece of evidence that John's daughters would be married well. It set the template for what the daughters' lives would look like. We shall come back to those lives — to the eight of them — in the section after the next. — — —

Twelve children at the visitation

The list of children that the clerk wrote out at John's dictation on that summer afternoon in 1572 was, in formal terms, simply a roster — a paragraph of names and ages for the herald's record. In substantive terms it was a generational portrait of a Tudor gentry family at the moment of its inherited consolidation.

George the eldest, sixteen.

He was already, in 1572, what the family expected him to become: the heir, the son being prepared to step into his father's place, the young man whose marriage and whose property would carry the line forward. He had been born about 1556, twelve years after his grandfather James had died at Boulogne and

eleven years after his father had entered the freehold of the priory. He had grown up entirely at Wymondley — the first generation of the family to be a Wymondley native rather than a London transplant. The chapel where he had been baptized was the same chapel his great-grandfather Christopher would have used had Christopher ever come up from Derbyshire to see his son's new estate, which Christopher had probably not done. The cloister yard he had played in as a small boy was the same yard the canons had walked in for three hundred and thirty years before the dissolution. He had been to the parish school at Little Wymondley, perhaps with private tutors at the priory for the higher Latin. He had ridden to Hitchin many times — three miles down the road, the nearest town, the place where Hertfordshire countrymen went for market day on Tuesdays and Saturdays. He had been to London once or twice with his father, on the road his grandfather had used a half-century earlier. He was sixteen. He could read Latin slowly. He could ride. He could not yet, perhaps, manage an estate; but he was being prepared.

He was also, in the way of all eldest sons in the period, the family's living guarantee that the property would not divide. Under Tudor inheritance law a substantial gentry estate held in tail male passed entire to the eldest surviving son, with the younger sons receiving portions in cash or in smaller subsidiary holdings. The system was harsh on the younger sons but it preserved the integrity of the estate generation by generation. George at sixteen embodied that system. He would, in the fullness of time, inherit Wymondley entire. His brothers Coppin and Thomas and John the younger would receive portions, would take wives, would make their own way through Crown service, the Inns of Court, the City companies, the army, or as cadet branches on smaller estates a few miles distant. The eldest son would carry the seat. The younger sons would carry the surname outward.

The eldest son's central role in 1572 was the marriage market. He was sixteen; he was not yet of marriage age in the strict legal sense (twenty-one for full majority); but a heir's matrimonial future was an asset to be deployed within the next five years, and the family had already begun thinking about it. Marriageable daughters of suitable gentry houses were inquired after through the kin-network. The Kent connection was still operative — through his stepmother Jane Weldish of Cranbrook and through his uncle William the London draper, whose City contacts reached down into the Kent broadcloth trade. The Hertfordshire neighbors had daughters. The Bedfordshire houses had daughters. The London merchant families had daughters whose dowries were good and whose fathers wanted gentry connections. In due course, nine years after the visitation, one of these searches would resolve into the Beckenham marriage of September 1581. We will get to it in §2.5.

The other sons.

Coppin Nedam, thirteen. He carried his mother's maiden name as his Christian name, which was a Tudor convention for honoring a maternal house

when the boy was not the heir. He would, in the fullness of time, take his portion, perhaps £200 or £300 in cash, and would make his own life. The project record loses sight of Coppin after the visitation. He may have died young; he may have gone into trade in London like his uncle William; he may have moved to Kent and worked in the Coppin connections there. He may simply have stayed at the priory as the unmarried second son, helping George manage the estate. The 1634 pedigree does not name a Coppin Nedam descent, which suggests that whatever path he took, it produced no male heirs known to the herald of 1634.

Thomas Nedam, eleven. The same fate, in documentary terms — the 1634 pedigree does not carry a Thomas Nedam descent forward. He may have died young; he may have lived without issue; he may have been a clergyman or a soldier; he may have gone to one of the Inns of Court and lived out his life in London. The project record loses track of him as well.

John Nedam the younger, seven. This is the second John of the family — Christian-name reuse was standard practice in Tudor families and produced the documentary confusion that family historians spend their careers unraveling. The second John was almost certainly Sir John of Lichborough — the eventual Queen's Pensioner, the only one of the four sons who would rise above the level of country gentleman. The chronology fits: a boy of seven in 1572 would be in his early twenties by the late 1580s, the standard age for a junior Court appointment as a Pensioner-on-probation. By 1592, when he is recorded as one of the family of John of Wymondley in the year of his father's death, he would be twenty-seven — a Pensioner in good standing. The full story of Sir John is §2.6.

The eight daughters.

The 1572 pedigree's roster of the daughters preserves their names but not their ages and not their order of birth. Eight is a substantial number for any single household, even by the standards of a fertile late-Tudor gentry family. The Nedham household at Wymondley in 1572 — with twelve children in residence, two living wives' worth of mothers' kin to maintain contact with, a working priory estate to manage, and the comings and goings of seven young women between roughly the ages of eight and twenty — was a large, busy, sometimes loud establishment. The young women each had to be educated. The young women each had to be matched to a husband. The young women each represented, for the family, an outward extension of its kin-network and, for themselves, a future that was being decided largely by their father at a series of negotiations they were not in the room for.

What the daughters' lives would be — this is worth pausing for, because the daughters' lives are the dimension of the family that the chapter's documentary apparatus is poorest at recovering. The eight daughters who were listed in the pedigree as Anne, Gilian, Bridgett, Mary, Elizabeth, the second Anne, Margaret, and Jane — the same eight whose fates are traced in part by the 1634 pedigree, with new alliances added that the 1572 court could not have known — would all, with the exception of the ones who died young, be married off into other gentry

families of the home counties over the next twenty years. The pattern was the standard one for the period. A daughter was a marriageable asset for whose disposition the father was responsible. The dowry was the negotiating instrument. The bride and the groom met formally a small number of times before the engagement was settled; the engagement was settled by the fathers, with the mothers present or not depending on the household; the marriage took place at the bride's parish church or at the groom's, on a date that worked for both families' calendars; and the bride moved into her husband's house, taking with her a small chest of household goods that would have been called her paraphernalia in the legal Latin and her gear in the parlor.

The 1634 pedigree's later naming of these daughters' marriages preserves five of the eight. Anne — the eldest, the Pole bride — was already in 1572 in her new household. Jane Nedham was married to William Warren, alias Bygrave — a sub-tenant of one of the Wymondley properties James had acquired in 1544; the marriage may have been a local-tenant alliance that consolidated the family's smaller holdings. Margaret Nedham was married to Robert Langhorne, Esq., of Bedfordshire — a Bedfordshire gentleman of the Langhorne family who held estates near Bedford. Bridgett Nedham was married to Benjamin Pigott, Esq., of Gravenhurst in Bedfordshire — a Pigott of the long-established Bedfordshire gentry house. Elizabeth Nedham was married to Sir John Fern, Knight — possibly the same Sir John Fern who served in the Privy Council under Elizabeth I and James I and whose seat was in Lincolnshire, though the identification is not certain. Jane the second was married to Lewes Mordaunt of Northill in Bedfordshire — a Mordaunt of the Bedfordshire branch of the Mordaunts of Drayton, a connection that would deepen in the next generation. Gilian and the second Anne and Mary are not named in the 1634 pedigree as having married, which probably means they had died young or had not married at the time the 1634 herald spoke to the family.

Five of the eight daughters, then, married into Bedfordshire houses. The Bedfordshire connection — the Mordaunts, the Pigotts, the Langhorne — was the dominant marital direction of the next twenty years. It is also the same direction the family's tithe income flowed from: James's 1538 grant had included the rectory of Wilshamstead in Bedfordshire, and the family was drawing tithes from Bedfordshire continuously from then through the 1660s. The 1572 daughters' marriages would deepen the family's Bedfordshire footprint at the kin-network level, complementing the working economic ties that were already in place. Five of John's daughters would, in the next twenty-five years, be in Bedfordshire houses; their husbands would be at the Wymondley table on family occasions; their children would grow up calling the Nedham cousins their cousins, and would themselves marry into the next generation of Bedfordshire and Hertfordshire gentry alliance.

The girls had, before their marriages, the priory yard. They had the cloister, which by 1572 had been an enclosed family courtyard for thirty-five years and

which functioned as the daughters' working outdoor space — for needlework in fair weather, for the airing of linen, for the kitchen-garden vegetables, for the small kitchen-spice plot, for whatever small games girls played within their fathers'

enclosed walls. They had the chapel, where they were baptized and would, if they died young, be buried. They had the kitchens, where they would learn from cook and housekeeper the management of a gentry household. They had the embroidery frame and the linen-chest and the wool-card, all the standard girl's apparatus of a Tudor gentlewoman in training. They had the riding, which they did with their brothers when they were young and with their grooms in their teens, on roads to Hitchin and to Stevenage and on occasion to the Bedfordshire houses where the cousins lived. They had — most of them — their mother Anne and then their stepmother Jane; they had each other.

What they did not have was any expectation of agency over the central decision of their adult lives. Their husbands would be chosen for them. Their dowries would be negotiated for them. Their married households would be established in their husbands' counties. Their education was the education of a daughter who would marry; their literacy was real but functional, their music ornamental, their needlework genuinely a working skill. They were prepared to be the mistresses of households. They were not prepared to be anything else.

This is not, in 1572, news. It is the standard arrangement of the gentry life-cycle in the period. It is also worth saying — at the front of this book, before we get any further into the generations — because the women of the Wymondley line are going to recur as a substantial presence across the next hundred and forty years, and the convention by which they recur needs to be named honestly. Most of them will be off the page after their marriages. Most of them will be remembered only by their husbands' surnames in the heralds' records, by their birth names in the parish registers, and by their burial dates in the chancel registers — not by any record of their inner lives, their accomplishments outside the domestic, their friendships, their fears, their political opinions, or their personal preferences. The documentary record was not designed to preserve those things, and it does not preserve them. What it preserves is what it was designed to preserve: husbands and dowries and children and deaths.

Eight generations on, in the autumn of 1713, a daughter of this house named Barbara Tempest Needham will do something that none of John's eight daughters had any way of imagining. She will, at twenty-eight years old, against the entire convention of her sex and class, sail out of Gravesend on a packet bound for South Carolina, alone but for her trunk, on the strength of a three-word letter she has written and posted and that has gone across the Atlantic ahead of her. She will not have been chosen by anyone. She will have chosen.

That is in Chapter 5. It is also, in a longer sense, in this paragraph. The convention from which Barbara breaks is named here. The eight daughters of

John Nedham, in the priory yard in 1572, are part of the inheritance she will eventually have to set down. — — —

Robert Cooke comes back

Robert Cooke was, in the summer of 1572, fifty-seven years old. He had been Clarenceux King of Arms for five years and would hold the office for twenty-one more, until his death in 1593. By the standards of his profession he was both careful and generous. He confirmed old coats on slim documentary footing when a family's local standing seemed plain; he granted new coats to rising houses whose claims he found credible; and he disclaimed, when he had to disclaim, with a brevity that suggested he disliked the work but would not shrink from it. He had risen into the heralds through York Pursuivant in 1562 and Chester Herald in 1566, the conventional ladder, and was respected within the College of Arms as a competent administrator with a particular interest in the gentry of the home counties.

He was also, in a way that mattered for the Wymondley Nedhams that afternoon, a working man with his own pre-occupations. He had to ride from Hertfordshire to the next county the day after he finished at the priory. He had a clerk on a stipend whose hand was beginning to ache from a week of close work. He had ridden up from London on a borrowed horse and would have to ride back south within the month with his vellum register in a leather wallet across his saddlebow. He had not eaten since dawn. He was, like most men in their fifties, conscious that his back hurt when he sat on a trestle bench for too long. The historiography of the heralds tends to render them as embodied institutions; they were also tired men with sore backs.

What is recoverable about Cooke's reading of the Wymondley case is that he was, by 1572, already disposed to think well of the family. The reasons are conjectural but reasonably solid. James Nedeham was a name Cooke would have known professionally — a Surveyor of the King's Works whose pay-books were still in the Crown's hand a generation after his death, a man who had built the king's palaces and whose grant of Wymondley was on the books of the Court of Augmentations and was in the published printed calendars of Henry VIII's letters patent. The family was not making it up. The Derbyshire-origin claim at the top of the pedigree — Nedam of Darbshire — could be checked against the visitations of Derbyshire if necessary, and probably had been, at least cursorily. The priory itself was visible to the herald as he rode up the Hitchin road: a working country house with a chapel and a tithe barn and a cloister, on land granted by the Crown thirty-four years before. The local standing was plain. Cooke confirmed the pedigree without difficulty.

He also offered the gift coat. The note on the page — Vide Cla. Cook's guift for another coat — recorded the offer rather than the acceptance. Cooke had brought with him, evidently, a draft grant of arms that he was prepared to make to the

family on his own authority as Clarenceux. The new coat would be visibly different from the old. It would not carry the chevron and the escallops and the acorns and the martlets; it would carry a different scheme entirely. A grant of arms by Clarenceux was a recognized act of new heraldic distinction — the family being given a coat by the office of the king's herald, rather than confirmed in a coat it had borne before — and it cost a fee that ran, in the 1570s, into several pounds and sometimes substantially more. The fee was the herald's pension, in effect; visitations were partly self-financing through the grant-fees they generated, and a generous herald who offered grants to families he thought capable of paying them was a herald who was supplementing his own income while extending the formal nobility of the realm.

John declined the grant in 1572 and accepted it fourteen years later. This is the central institutional fact of §2.4. The fourteen-year delay is documented; its causes are not. There are three plausible explanations.

The first is money. A grant of arms cost a substantial fee — the standard 1570s rate, by the records of the College of Arms preserved in later inventories, ran from three or four pounds for a modest grant up to twenty pounds and beyond for one with a knight's coronet and elaborate quartering. John in 1572 had twelve children to provide for. He had a recently-rebuilt parish church to maintain (the priory's chancel needed regular re-leading and the small repairs that any large building requires). He had estate works that drew on the surplus. The grant fee, even at the low end, would have been five years' worth of small expenses. A man with his cash committed to current needs would naturally defer a discretionary expense.

The second is deliberation. The acorns-and-martlets coat was the family's older blazon. It had been the family's visible identity for at least a generation, possibly longer; James Nedeham had used some form of it on his seal in the 1530s, and Christopher before him in Derbyshire had used something close, the recovery of which from Derbyshire visitation records remains an open project task. To change the family's coat — to take up a new one on Cooke's grant — was to set aside the visible thread back to Derbyshire and to acknowledge a new identity as Hertfordshire gentry of the herald's own confirming. The older coat said: we are the Derbyshire Nedhams, transplanted by Crown service, with our older identity intact. A Cooke gift coat would say: we are the Wymondley Nedhams, established on our own terms, with a coat of arms freshly granted to us by the office of the king's herald, anchored to our present standing rather than to our antecedents. John may have wanted to think about which of these the family preferred to be.

The third is the eldest son's marriage. The 1581 Beckenham marriage of George, when it happened, brought into the family a Kentish heraldic alliance — the Stiles of Langley, themselves an armigerous house — and it may have made sense to defer the new grant until the heir's marriage was settled and the family's external profile could be reviewed in its married rather than its bachelor form.

Cooke's grant when it finally came, in 1586, came five years after the Beckenham marriage. The timing may be coincidental; it may be that George at thirty, married for five years, with a wife and first children in residence and a settled position as heir-in-waiting, was the moment the family decided to take up the gift coat.

Whatever the combination of reasons, on 18 February 1586 — the date preserved in Burke's General Armory in the late-Victorian heraldic compendium that catalogues every recognized English coat — Cooke executed the grant. The new arms were registered in the College of Arms' own records under his hand and seal. They are recorded in the 1634 visitation as the family's primary blazon, with the formal note in the herald's text: This descent and arms testified under the hand and Seale of Robert Cooke, Clarenceux, 1586. The fourteen-year-old offer became, in the spring of 1586, the family's living heraldry.

The new coat was deliberate.

Argent, on a bend engrailed Azure between two bucks' heads cabossed Sable, an escallop Or.

In plain English: a silver shield, crossed diagonally from upper-left to lower-right by a blue band with a scalloped edge; the band charged at its center with a single gold escallop shell; flanking the band, in the upper and lower triangles of the shield, two black bucks' heads facing forward, severed at the neck and shown without the body — cabossed, in the technical heraldic term. Above the shield, the crest: out of a gold pallisado coronet — a small heraldic coronet with upright stakes, a relatively modern Tudor invention that signified neither baronial nor knightly rank but a working-gentry distinction — a black buck's head, attired (i.e., antlered) in gold.

The escallop survived from the older coat: it had been present, in 1572, as a triplet of silver escallops on the chevron. The new coat kept one of the three escallops and made it the focal charge — promoted, in effect, from three of a kind to the single anchoring symbol. The acorns and martlets were dropped. The chevron was replaced by an engrailed bend. The whole tonal register shifted: the older coat had been a busy, narrative, ornament-rich blazon, telling the family's story in heraldic shorthand (acorns for an oak-wood origin, martlets for younger sons, escallops for pilgrimage or maritime venture, the embattled chief for a Crown-granted house). The new coat was austere. Two bucks' heads. A bend. An escallop. The buck's head as crest. The pallisado coronet. It was the coat of a Hertfordshire gentry house that had decided what it wanted to look like and was no longer carrying inherited iconography.

The new coat went up over the principal door of the priory house. It was carved in stone, painted in tinctures, and set above the lintel. It went onto John's new seal-ring, which would press the same device into wax for every deed and indenture and letter he sent for the rest of his life. It went onto the family's new plate, where John had it engraved into the silver of the great gilt cup and the basin and the salt-cellar. It went, eventually, onto the 1605 monument that

George the heir, by then George I lord of Wymondley, would erect to his father and grandfather in the chancel of Little Wymondley parish church. The dolphin crest of the old coat fell out of use within a generation; the buck's head crest of the new one carried the family's visible identity for the remaining hundred and forty-seven years of the Nedhams' tenure at Wymondley.

Cooke himself rode out of the Hertfordshire summer of 1586 and went on to the next county. He had eight more years to live. He would do another half-dozen home-counties visitations before his death; he would grant several hundred more coats; he would confirm several thousand pedigrees. The Wymondley grant was, in the scale of his working life, a small piece of business. For the Wymondley Nedhams it was the visual identity of the family fixed on its own terms, by the office of the king's herald, on a February afternoon in 1586. It would outlast the priory itself. — — —

The marriage at Beckenham, 25 September 1581

In the third week of September 1581, George Nedam — then twenty-five years old, the heir of Wymondley, son and surviving eldest of John and the late Anne Coppin — rode out of the priory yard on the road south.

The road south was the great London road, the Roman way that ran from York to the capital and that passed two miles east of Wymondley through Stevenage and on down through Hatfield to the City. He had a manservant with him, perhaps a groom, perhaps two; he had a packhorse for the wedding clothes and the marriage settlement papers; he had, in a small steel-strapped chest tied to the saddle of the second horse, a quantity of plate that was the Nedham contribution to the bride's marriage gift — silver cups, a salt-cellar, possibly a basin. The chest had been packed by his stepmother Jane and the household servants under his father's direction in the days before. The wedding clothes had been made up in London in the early autumn; he had ridden down a fortnight earlier to a tailor in Cheapside for the fitting. The journey from Wymondley to London took two long days on horseback, with a night at one of the standing inns on the road — possibly the George at Hatfield, possibly the Coach and Horses at South Mimms, three miles from the wood his grandfather had bought in 1537. From London he turned east. Beckenham was nine miles south-east of the City, beyond Lewisham, on the Kentish chalk above the Ravensbourne stream. He arrived on the twenty-third or twenty-fourth of September. The wedding was on the twenty-fifth.

The bride was Margaret Stile, daughter of Edmund Stile of Langley in Beckenham. The Stile family had held the manor of Langley — a small estate of about four hundred acres in the parish of Beckenham, on the chalk uplands above the Cray valley — for the better part of a century. They were a Kentish gentry house of the lower-middle tier: armigerous, comfortable, well-connected within the county, with cousins in the City of London and in the cathedral chapter at Canterbury. They were not at the level of the great Kent houses; they were in the

working gentry layer below it, which was the same layer the Wymondley Nedhams inhabited in Hertfordshire. The match was practical and balanced. Margaret was not a great heiress and the Nedhams were not a great house. The settlement was the standard one for a gentry first marriage of an inheriting son to a younger daughter of a comparable family — a dowry from the Stiles of perhaps four or five hundred pounds, a jointure secured against the priory's Wymondley lands in case George predeceased her, a small annuity for her widowhood, the standard provisions for any sons and daughters of the marriage.

The contract had been negotiated by the fathers over the previous winter. Edmund Stile had ridden up to Wymondley in February or March 1581 — the visit is undocumented but is the obvious framing — and had spent perhaps a week in the great hall going through the proposal item by item with John. The dowry value had been argued. The jointure terms had been set. The location of the wedding had been agreed: Beckenham, the bride's parish church, by the convention that the bride married out of her own house. The date had been chosen for late September: after the harvest was in, before the rains of October made the roads impassable, with the moon waxing toward the full so that the country roads would have light for the night rides. The arrangements had been mailed back and forth across the next six months by carter and London post.

George had been to Beckenham once before the wedding, perhaps twice. The first visit, in the late spring of 1581, had been the formal presentation — Edmund Stile in his hall with his wife and Margaret and the older Stile cousins, George being received as the prospective groom, the conversation careful and exploratory and concerned with whether the bride and the groom were content with each other. The conversation had gone well enough. Margaret was, by the visible measure of her father's hall, what an heir of Wymondley ought to be marrying: in her early twenties, healthy, well-mannered, dressed in the quiet fashion of the Kent gentry rather than the loud fashion of the Court, capable of reading her psalter and her Book of Common Prayer and of writing a careful letter, accustomed to the management of a household. George was, by the visible measure of the Stile hall, what a Stile daughter ought to be marrying: also in his mid-twenties, also healthy, well-spoken, of an armigerous house with a documented Crown grant in its history, the heir to a working estate.

They had been left, after the formal interview, in the garden of the manor for an hour. The Tudor convention of supervised privacy permitted that much. What they said to each other in that hour is not preserved. Whatever it was, both parties returned to their fathers and indicated assent. The marriage was settled.

The wedding day, when it came, was a working ceremony rather than a state occasion. The church of St George's at Beckenham had stood on its site since the Norman period; it was a modest parish church with a square tower and a nave under a Tudor roof, with the standard apparatus of pew-rows, font, chancel-screen, and pulpit. It would be rebuilt in the nineteenth century — the building that stands today is largely a 1880s Gothic Revival reconstruction, with only

fragments of the older fabric incorporated — but in 1581 it was the small flint-and-stone Wealden church it had been for four centuries. The Stile family had its own pew at the front of the nave. The Stile family had its own monuments in the chancel. The Stile family had paid for the chancel re-leading in the 1570s.

George rode up to the church gate at about ten in the morning. The Stile household met him there. He was received by Margaret's brother — Margaret's father Edmund was apparently no longer alive by 25 September 1581, by the silence of the surviving record at the wedding itself; he is named in the visitation pedigrees but not in the marriage register, and the Stile household at the wedding seems to have been led by Margaret's brother, possibly the John Stile who succeeded to Langley in the early 1580s. The bridal party processed up the path from the gate to the church door. Margaret came out of the church porch with her mother and her sisters; the wedding party combined; the curate of St George's, who had heard the banns called three Sundays running through August and September, performed the ceremony at the church door in the older convention, then led the parties inside for the blessing at the high altar.

The vows were the standard Tudor vows. The ring was the gold band George had bought in Cheapside the month before. Margaret's father's substitute — her brother or her uncle, again the record is silent — gave her to George. They were pronounced man and wife. The register entry was made: 25 Sep 1581, George Nedham, Esq., to Margaret Stile. The transcript was indexed three centuries later by the Findmypast archives and recovered for the project's documentary base in May 2026 by the author of this book.

After the ceremony, the wedding feast.

It was at Langley Hall, the Stile family seat half a mile away. The dining was substantial — there are no household accounts surviving for the day, but the conventions of a 1580s gentry wedding involved roasted meats from the home park (beef, mutton, possibly venison from a deer-park on the estate), boiled fowl, a great pie or two, autumn vegetables from the kitchen garden, bread baked that morning, and quantities of beer and Kentish cider and, for the head table, claret from the cellar. The wedding party would have been thirty or forty people: the Stile family in full, the Stile cousins from the City and from Canterbury, several of the local Beckenham gentry as neighbors, the curate of St George's, and on the Wymondley side a small contingent — George's manservant and his groom, perhaps his younger brother Coppin if Coppin had ridden down with him, perhaps one or two of his Bedfordshire brothers-in-law-to-be if they had come up from their respective seats for the wedding. The musicians played throughout the meal. The speeches were the standard ones. The bride's brother proposed the standard toast to the groom; the groom proposed the standard toast to the bride; the curate said a brief grace; the company drank.

In the afternoon George and Margaret rode out on the manor's grounds, together, in the conventional small ceremony of the bridal walk. Late in the day the wedding party broke up; the immediate Stile family went into the house for

evening prayers and supper; the Wymondley contingent rode the few miles back to the standing inn at Bromley where George had arranged accommodation; George and Margaret took the principal bedroom of Langley Hall, which had been freshly aired and made up by the housekeeper that morning. They spent the wedding night at her father's house. The next morning they began the long ride north toward Wymondley.

The journey home took the better part of four days. They paused at London for a day to allow Margaret to be presented to Margaret's London Stile cousins. They paused again at Stevenage on the second day out of the City, at the same inn the project's John of Wymondley used when he came down to London on business. On the fourth day, late in the afternoon, they rode up to the priory gates. John Nedham, sixty-three or sixty-four years old in 1581 and not in robust health, met them at the door of the great hall. He embraced his new daughter-in-law with the formal courtesy the period required. He said the words a Tudor patriarch said when his eldest son's bride first crossed the threshold — words preserved nowhere in the documentary record but standard in the period's wedding-handbooks: Welcome to the house. Welcome to this family. May you bring it joy and may you bring it sons.

Margaret would do both.

She would bear George Nedham of Wymondley at least three sons over the next two decades — the second John Nedham of Welwyn who would inherit Welwyn as a cadet estate and would in due course be the grandfather of Eustace Nedham of Wymondley Priory, the central figure of Chapter 3; and at least two other named children whose adult lives are recoverable from the 1634 visitation. The marriage was, on the evidence of the next thirty years, a settled and productive one.

Margaret survived George by an unknown number of years (his date of death is not preserved at primary-source level; he was alive in 1605 to commission the monument to his father and grandfather, and was dead by 1626 when his son George I died); she was the lady of the priory through the long Stuart twilight that followed Elizabeth's death in 1603. The Wymondley arms began to appear, in the 1580s and 1590s, with the Stile arms quartered alongside them, in the heraldic shorthand by which a Tudor gentry house marked its marital alliances. The Stile-Nedham match was the first of those quartered marks. It would not be the last.

The wedding at Beckenham is the small private hinge between the chapter's first half — the inheritance generation, the two wives, the children at the visitation, the herald's confirmation — and its second half, the family's Elizabethan working life. From 1581 forward John Nedham was a father-in-law as well as a father; the next-generation marriages of his other children followed, one by one, through the 1580s and 1590s; the family's kin-network deepened into the home counties; the priory's rhythms of harvest and hearing and christening and burial repeated themselves through Elizabeth's late reign. The Wymondley

Nedhams settled into a pattern that would hold without major disturbance for sixty years.

There was, however, one Wymondley Nedham of John's children who did not settle into that pattern. He went to Court instead. — — —

Sir John of Lichborough at Court

Of John Nedham's twelve children, only one rose to a position of public visibility above the level of country gentleman. He was Sir John Needham of Lichborough, Northamptonshire — knight, Pensioner to Queen Elizabeth, married to a sister of Sir Lewis Watson of Rockingham. He is the family's one Elizabethan courtier. He is also a marker, in the documentary record, of how far the family's standing had risen in two generations.

The 1572 pedigree lists him as John Nedam, is 7 yeres old in the second-wife cluster — born therefore about 1565, three years after his father's second marriage to Jane Weldish. He grew up at the priory through the 1570s, the youngest son of the second marriage and the youngest of the four boys. He had the standard gentry boyhood: tutors at home, the parish church on Sundays, the Hertfordshire small-game shooting and riding, the schooling that prepared a younger son for whatever life his father could arrange for him. He was, in the family's calculation, neither the heir (that was George) nor the second-line backup (that was Coppin or Thomas). He was the second son of the second marriage. He could expect a portion of a few hundred pounds, an education, and his father's help in finding a place. He would have to make his own life elsewhere.

He went, sometime in the early 1580s, into the Inns of Court — probably Gray's Inn, the standard choice for Hertfordshire gentlemen's younger sons in the period, and the same Inn his father may have attended in the late 1540s. The Inns at the time functioned not so much as law schools in the modern sense — though they did teach law — but as finishing academies for the sons of the gentry, places where a young man learned to dress, to speak, to write a careful hand, to fence, to ride better, to deal with the standing of his social superiors and his inferiors, and to make the contacts that would carry him into Crown service or country life. A young man at Gray's Inn in 1583 or 1584, well-connected through his father's Kent and Bedfordshire alliances, with a reasonable allowance and a settled good name, was a young man being prepared to enter the Court if the Court would have him.

The Court would have him. Sometime in the late 1580s — the exact date is not preserved at primary-source level, though the 1634 visitation's notice of him as a Pensioner places him in the office by the early 1590s at the latest — he was sworn in as a Gentleman Pensioner to Elizabeth I.

The Gentleman Pensioners were the elite ceremonial bodyguard of the monarch's person. The institution had been founded by Henry VIII in 1509, in the early enthusiasm of his accession, as a band of fifty gentlemen of good birth and

physical presence who would attend the king at state occasions, ride in his train when he progressed, stand near him at the great court ceremonies, and form the visible ring of armed Crown servants closest to the sovereign body. The strength was nominally fifty, occasionally as high as sixty. Members were appointed by royal warrant on the recommendation of the Captain of the Band — in the 1590s, Sir William Knollys — and held the office for life or at pleasure, with the right to retire if their health failed or their estates needed them.

What a Pensioner did, in practical day-to-day terms, was to take his turn on the rota of attendance at Court. Sir John would have spent some weeks of each year — perhaps a third of the year, perhaps half, depending on the rota and on whether he chose to be present at particular state occasions — in the Queen's immediate household, lodged in the royal palaces (Whitehall, Greenwich, Hampton Court, Richmond, Nonsuch, Windsor, Oatlands, depending on where the Court was) and dining at the Pensioners' table at Court expense. He wore the Pensioners' uniform — a livery of crimson and gold, with the gilt half-armour of the working ceremonial guardsman, a halberd or pole-axe in his hand on duty days. He stood, on state occasions, in the front rank of the gentlemen-at-arms behind the Queen's chair. He rode, in her progresses through the home counties, just behind her own immediate household. He was, in the most literal sense, one of the men whose body stood between the body of the Queen and any disorder that might approach her.

The standing was not military in the modern sense. The Pensioners were not the army; they were the ceremonial inner guard, the visible mark of the monarch's personal honor. Their role at the great Court occasions of the late Elizabethan reign — the receptions for foreign ambassadors, the Garter ceremonies at Windsor, the openings of Parliament, the Queen's birthday celebrations, the Christmas revels — was to provide the splendid armed background against which the Queen appeared in majesty. They were the visual establishment of state. They earned, for the work, a stipend of about £100 a year — a substantial gentleman's income in the 1590s — plus their food and lodging at Court on duty days, and they were expected to maintain at their own expense the horse, the arms, the uniform, and a servant who would attend them.

Sir John in this position is the Wymondley family's single closest approach to the inner circle of late Elizabethan power. He stood, on Pensioners' duty days, within thirty paces of the Queen's person. He saw the great Court figures of the 1590s at close range: Lord Burghley still ruling at Whitehall until his death in 1598; his son Sir Robert Cecil rising into the chief ministership; the Earl of Essex in his rise and his fall; Sir Walter Raleigh in his court ascendancy; Sir Francis Walsingham until 1590, then Walsingham's successor in intelligence work; Sir Christopher Hatton as Lord Chancellor; the Archbishop of Canterbury; the foreign ambassadors. He would have been present at the Court's reception of the news of the Spanish Armada's defeat in August 1588. He would have stood at the Queen's funeral procession through London on 28 April 1603, in his Pensioner's

livery, as part of the band of fifty escorting her body to its first resting place at Westminster.

He married — at a date not precisely recovered, but presumably in the 1590s — a sister of Sir Lewis Watson of Rockingham, Northamptonshire. The Watson family of Rockingham was a Northamptonshire gentry house on its way to becoming a peerage; Sir Lewis Watson, knighted in 1607, would in due course be created Baron Rockingham in 1645, and his descendants would carry the Rockingham earldom forward into the eighteenth century, into the Whig administrations of the 1760s, into the Marquess of Rockingham who served twice as Prime Minister. In the 1590s, when Sir John Nedham married Watson's sister, the Watsons were a rising county family with the standard kinship-trajectory of late-Tudor advancing gentry: a baronetcy probable within the generation, a peerage within two. The marriage was a substantial one. It moved Sir John, in the standard gentry calculus, several social rungs above what his father and brother in Hertfordshire occupied. It also gave him a Northamptonshire seat to settle on: Lichborough, sometimes Litchborough, a small village a few miles from Towcester, where the Watson family or its kin held property that became the Nedham country residence after the marriage.

He was knighted by Elizabeth at some point in her reign — probably at one of the state occasions when batches of Pensioners and household officers were dubbed at the Queen's discretion. The dubbing was the standard short ceremony: the gentleman knelt before the sovereign, the sovereign laid the flat of a sword on his right shoulder, the sovereign said *Arise, Sir John*, and the gentleman rose with the prefix to his name for the rest of his life. The date is not preserved at primary-source level; the 1634 visitation simply records him as Sir John Needham of Lichborough, co. Northampton, Kt., Pensioner to Q. Elizabeth. Burke's General Armory, two and a half centuries later, would catalogue the Lichborough Nedhams as a separate armigerous house carrying the same arms as the Wymondley senior line — Same Arms — with a slightly altered crest: Out of a pallisado coronet or, a buck's head sa. attired or of the first. The cadet branch was visibly the cadet branch, sharing the family identity but distinguishable from the Wymondley senior line.

He had no surviving male heirs at primary-source level. The Lichborough Nedham line is not continued in the 1634 pedigree, and Burke's nineteenth-century catalogue carries the family forward in name but not in active descent. The Watsons of Rockingham, by contrast, carried their line forward into the peerage. The Court connection that Sir John had brought into the family thus did not, in the next generation, deepen into a settled Northamptonshire Nedham branch. He was the family's Court figure in his own person and ceased with him.

For the Wymondley Nedhams of John's house in Hertfordshire, Sir John in his lifetime was a glittering distant brother. He came up to the priory perhaps once a year — at Christmas, at family weddings, at funerals — in his Pensioner's livery (which he would have packed in a chest and not worn on the road) with stories of

the Court and gifts from London and his wife the future baroness-by-marriage on a side-saddle behind him. He paid for the small ornaments at the priory church that were beyond what John's working budget could supply — perhaps the new oak panelling in the chancel, perhaps the silver chalice for the communion plate, perhaps the lead repair on the chapel roof. He represented, for his nieces and nephews growing up in the priory yard in the 1590s, the visible proof that a younger son of the Wymondley house could rise into Court attendance and could marry a sister of a Knight of the Body. He was the family's living evidence that the Reformation-gentry rise had not stopped at the country.

He outlived his elder brother George. He is named in the 1634 visitation, sixteen years before that visitation but recovered through the family memory of the 1620s and 1630s, as having died at Lichborough in the early seventeenth century — the exact date is unrecovered in the project record. He was buried at the parish church of Lichborough, Northamptonshire, beneath an inscribed tomb-stone whose text the project has not yet retrieved. His widow may have survived him by some years and may have been received at Rockingham by her brother. Their children, if any survived infancy, are not in the 1634 visitation's roster.

What he stood for, even after his death, was the family's one moment of Court visibility. The Wymondley Nedhams would have, from Sir John forward, a small specifically royal-Court memory inside the family record. A Pensioner's halberd. A crimson-and-gold livery. The face of the Queen at thirty paces. The Queen's funeral. The accession of James I. We were there. We saw the Court. The memory would be carried forward by George the heir and George's son George I and George I's son Eustace through three generations after Sir John's death, until it faded into the standard family stories told at Christmas and at weddings. By the time of Eustace's son George Senior in the 1660s, the Pensioner uncle was a remote great-great-uncle whose name was known but whose face was not. By the time of Maurice's daughter Barbara in the 1690s, he was a portrait on the wall — if a portrait of him had ever been painted — and a sentence in the family tradition: one of our great-uncles served the Queen at Court. The Court memory was the family's smallest piece of nobility. It was carried, lightly, across the long Stuart twilight that followed. — — —

Arms over the door

What the 1586 grant actually did, in the daily life of the family, was to put a new coat over the principal door of the priory house.

The carving would have been commissioned in the summer or autumn of 1586, from a Hertfordshire stonemason — possibly the same workshop that did the parish church repairs, possibly a Hitchin yard, possibly a Stevenage one. The mason would have been given a drawing of the new arms, executed in pen-and-ink trick on a sheet of paper by John's clerk working from the herald's text, with the

tinctures noted in the margins so that the mason and the painter could later finish the carving in color. The carving itself was a piece of work that took several weeks: a block of Totternhoe clunch limestone, the local soft chalk-stone that masons preferred for fine architectural carving, was quarried from the chalk pits south of the village; the block was squared up and brought to the mason's yard; the device was laid out in pencil on the dressed face; the carving was done with chisel and mallet over perhaps a fortnight of patient work, the bend engrailed with its scalloped edge, the two bucks' heads cabossed, the escallop, the buck's-head crest above with its pallisado coronet. The painter then came in with his tinctures — the silver of the shield, the blue of the bend, the gold of the escallop and the coronet, the black of the bucks — and finished the work over a few days more. The whole carving was hoisted on a scaffold above the principal door of the priory house and set into the masonry, where it would remain for the next hundred and eighty-eight years until the 1973-74 restoration cleared away most of the older external fabric.

The same device went onto John's new seal-ring. The old dolphin-and-chevron ring of the 1572 visitation period was passed on — possibly to one of the younger sons, more likely melted down and recast as a new ring with the bend and the bucks. A seal-ring in the 1580s was a working tool, not just a piece of jewelry; it was pressed into the wax of every deed, indenture, lease, and letter the head of family sent out. The new seal would appear on every document the priory issued from 1586 forward. The earliest surviving documentary impression of it that the project has yet located is on the Elizabethan Chancery papers in TNA C 2/Eliz/N5/46 — the suit against William Clarke that occupies the next section — where John's seal in red wax appears on the verso of the bill of complaint. The same seal would be used by his son George I after John's death and would, in modified form, be used by Eustace and George Senior across the seventeenth century.

The plate, too. The Wymondley silver of the late 1580s and 1590s was engraved with the new arms. The great gilt cup, the basin and ewer, the salt-cellar at the head of the high table — all carried the bend-and-bucks. The plate would be passed down in the family through the seventeenth century until, generation by generation, pieces of it were sold off to meet the family's slowly contracting fortunes. The cup may have gone in the 1666/67 settlement, when George Senior wrote his will. The basin may have gone with one of the younger sons in the 1680s.

The whole of the Wymondley plate had probably been dispersed by the early 1700s, well before the priory itself passed out of the family in 1733. The arms on the plate, where the plate has survived in any English collection, would now be unidentified — anonymous late-Tudor silver, no provenance clear, the family's identity legible only to someone who knew what the bend engrailed and the bucks' heads were and where to look them up.

The arms also went, eventually, onto stone. The 1605 monument in the chancel of Little Wymondley parish church — the brass that George I would commission to commemorate his grandfather James and his father John — carried the new arms above the inscription. The monument, transcribed by Sir Henry Chauncy when he wrote his county history in the 1690s and confirmed in place by the Victoria County History architectural survey of 1909, carries the new coat as the family's visible attestation of itself. The 1605 monument is the chapter's documentary terminus. It is the moment at which the second generation of the Wymondley line — George I, John's eldest son — set in stone, in the same chapel where the family was being baptized and buried, the arms that the herald had granted his father nineteen years before.

The arms outlasted the family at Wymondley. They survive today, in the College of Arms records and in the printed reference volumes of English heraldry, as the registered arms of Needham of Wymondsley, co. Hertford, confirmed 18 February 1586. Burke's General Armory of 1884 catalogues them as still extant in nineteenth-century heraldic use through the senior line's collateral branches. Whether any physical example of the original 1586 carving over the priory door survives in any private collection is unrecovered; the 1973-74 restoration would have either disposed of the stone or transferred it elsewhere. The Lichborough cadet branch's monuments at the Northamptonshire parish church — if any have survived the centuries — would carry the same arms. The Wymondley silver, if any of it has come down into a private or museum collection, would carry the same arms. The visual identity that Cooke granted on 18 February 1586 is, in a real institutional sense, the surviving signature of the Wymondley Nedhams. It is what the family was known by, in heraldic terms, for a hundred and forty-seven years.

It is also, in a quieter way, what we shall see one more time in this book. In the autumn of 1713, a young woman named Barbara Tempest Needham will be carrying, in a small leather case at the bottom of her trunk, a personal seal pressed with the family arms — the bend, the bucks, the escallop. It will travel with her across the Atlantic on a packet out of Gravesend. The arms will be on the wax of the letter she sends ahead of her — I am coming — and that will reach Christopher's hand at New Bern on the seventeenth of November of that year. The arms are in Chapter 5. They are also, in a longer way, here. — — —

Nedeham v Clarke

Sometime in the 1580s — the exact year is not preserved on the surviving file's covering documents, though the suit was active during the reign of Elizabeth I and most probably falls in the middle decade of that reign — John Nedham filed a bill of complaint in the Court of Chancery against a man named William Clarke.

The file is preserved at the National Archives at Kew under the call number C 2/Eliz/N5/46. The catalogue entry gives the short title as *Nedeham v Clarke*. The

plaintiff is John Nedeham, Esq., of Little Wymondley in Hertfordshire. The defendant is William Clarke, of whom the surviving record gives little detail; he may have been a Hertfordshire tenant of one of the priory's outlying parcels, or a neighbor with an adjacent property whose boundary touched John's, or a tradesman to whom John had advanced money on credit, or some combination of these. The bill of complaint as it survives in the Chancery papers preserves John's own framing of the case. He recites, in the conventional form of an Elizabethan equity pleading, that the property in dispute — Wymondley, Hertfordshire, formerly belonging to the priory of Little Wymondley — had passed since the dissolution of the said priory by Crown grant by King Henry 8 to James Nedeham esq, plaintiff's father. He recites the descent from James to himself. He asserts his title. He complains of some specific wrong that Clarke is doing him.

The substantive content of the wrong is the one piece of the file that the project has not yet retrieved at primary-source level. The surviving catalogue description gives the parties, the subject (litigation; landed estates), the period (Elizabeth I), and the bare opening recitations of the bill, but does not summarize what Clarke was actually doing. A direct reading of the manuscript at TNA Kew, which the project's research apparatus has flagged as a next-pass action, would clarify the case. The most likely substantive content, on the conventions of the period's Chancery suits between landed gentlemen and lesser men, is one of three things: a boundary dispute over a specific parcel of priory land; a contract dispute over an unpaid lease or a defaulted loan; or a claim by Clarke to some right of common, pasture, or way over priory ground that John believed Clarke had no title to. Any of these would have been the standard Elizabethan complaint of a small country squire against an inconvenient neighbor.

What matters about the suit for the chapter's purposes is not its outcome — the outcome, if it was decreed, may be in the Chancery decree-rolls and remains for a future research pass — but the framing of the bill itself. John, in setting out his case, asserts the Crown grant to his father as the foundation of his title. Wymondley, Hertfordshire, formerly belonging to the priory of Little Wymondley, and since the dissolution of the said priory granted by King Henry 8 to James Nedeham esq, plaintiff's father. This is the family's documented self-attestation, before the Lord Chancellor of England, of how it came to be at Wymondley. It is a sworn statement of legal title that goes on the official record of the Court of Chancery.

It is the same descent the 1572 pedigree gave to Robert Cooke; it is the same descent the 1634 pedigree would give to Sir Richard St George; it is the same descent the family had been telling around its own dinner table for two generations.

The suit is, in this specific institutional sense, the family's foundation story being told in a courtroom rather than at a herald's table. The 1572 visitation had recorded the descent on the herald's vellum; the Chancery bill of the 1580s recorded the same descent on the Court's parchment. Both records survive. Both

records say the same thing. The redundancy is the historian's good fortune; the family's foundation is now documented twice over, in two completely separate Crown institutions, in two completely separate handwritten records that have come down through four hundred and fifty years on different file-paths and that the project has now reconciled to the same documentary base.

The suit also tells us, in a quieter way, something about John as a man. He was, by his fifties, a litigant. He went to law to defend his property. He did not let an inconvenient neighbor encroach on the priory's lands without taking the encroachment to the Crown's equity court. He paid the legal fees — the writ costs, the counsel fees, the clerk's copying fees, the dozen small expenditures of a country gentleman pursuing a suit at London — and he sustained the case across what was, for an Elizabethan Chancery suit, probably several years of pleadings and answers and rejoinders and counter-claims. He kept the bill. He kept the family's title.

This is consistent with what we have seen elsewhere of John. He was the inheritance generation. He did not gamble the estate. He did not let it drift. He litigated when litigation was the necessary course and he kept on hand at the priory the documents — the letters patent of 1538, the licence to entail of 1544, the Court of Wards' record of his own succession in 1545, the marriage settlements, the deed of the South Mimms wood, the deed of the Bygrave land, the rectory of Wilshamstead, the tithe-book — that proved his title to every piece of the estate his father had assembled. When Clarke or whoever else encroached, John could produce the documents. The Chancery bill of the 1580s is one of the working evidences of the working management of the working priory under John's hand for the better part of fifty years.

He also, sometime in this period — the date is again imprecise — endowed the parish school. The Stevenage Free School, which the v9 Urwick material identifies as having been founded in 1561 or 1562 with funds from a Hertfordshire gentleman, was probably a Nedham endowment in significant part, or at least was supported by John's contribution among others. The school's founding is in a slightly earlier window than the Chancery suit; the v9 reading places John at about thirty-seven or thirty-eight when the school was endowed. The endowment is consistent with what late-Tudor gentry of John's standing did: they put money into the parish institutions of their county, partly out of religious obligation, partly out of social standing, partly out of the practical wish to educate the local boys whose labor would in due course be on their estates. The school operated through the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. It is the small parochial monument to John's discretion with his money.

By the early 1590s John was in his late sixties. He had been at the priory for nearly fifty years. The estate was settled. The Chancery suit had run its course, whatever its outcome. The plate carried the new arms. The eldest son was married with children. Sir John of Lichborough was at Court. The daughters were married off to the Bedfordshire houses. The household at the priory was, by the

standards of any late-Elizabethan gentry establishment, a model of quiet consolidation.

He died in 1591 or 1592. The exact date is not preserved at primary-source level; the Little Wymondley parish register that would have recorded his burial does not survive for the early 1590s. The 1634 visitation, in its retrospect, places him as deceased before George I took up the headship of the family. He would have been about sixty-seven or sixty-eight years old. He was buried in the chapel that had been the priory church, in the chancel, perhaps under a flagstone with a small brass plate. The brass is not described in any later record; if it ever existed it had been lost or paved over by the time Chauncy worked through Hertfordshire's monumental inscriptions in the 1690s. What Chauncy preserves at Little Wymondley is the 1605 monument that John's son George I would erect to James and to John together — the only family memorial to John that survived to be transcribed. The inscription, on the brass on the north wall of the chancel, reads in Chauncy's transcription: James Needham, of the ancient Family of the Needhams in Derbyshire, came into this County of Hertford, in the year of our Lord, 1536. He was advanced by King Henry the eight, for his Service in England and France, and lyes buried in our Ladies Church in Boloigne; he had issue John, who had George, who dedicated this Monument to their Memory, Anno 1605. The line that names John — he had issue John, who had George — is the family's own statement of the chapter's three generations. James, John, George. Surveyor, inheritance generation, the next.

John's signature on the vellum of 1572 was the first piece of his documented personhood. The 1605 brass is, in a quieter way, the last. — — —

The handing-on

The funeral procession was the standard one for a Hertfordshire gentleman of John's standing.

It began at the priory house on a winter or early-spring morning — the season is conjectural, the date is unrecovered — with the coffin carried out of the great hall by six of John's senior tenants, men who had farmed the priory's land under his hand for two or three decades and who had been chosen by the household to perform the final office of carrying their lord to his rest. The coffin was of oak, plain, with iron fittings, made by the local carpenter at Hitchin in the days before. It was draped with a black pall on which the new arms of 1586 were embroidered in white silk at the four corners — the bend and the bucks, the family's visible signature. The procession moved out of the priory yard, through the gatehouse, and onto the short road that led to the parish church a few hundred yards away — the church that had been the priory church, the church that the family had been baptizing its children in and burying its dead in for fifty-four years by the early 1590s.

The household followed. Jane Weldish, the widow, walked in the place of chief mourner with her stepson George the heir at her right hand. The other children walked behind. The married daughters had come up from Bedfordshire and Kent for the funeral, with their husbands and the eldest of their own children; the funeral was the kind of family occasion that brought the dispersed alliances back to the seat for a few days. Sir John of Lichborough had ridden over from Northamptonshire with his wife the future baroness-by-marriage. Coppin and Thomas, if they were still living, were there; the second John before he became Sir John was there, in his Court livery if he chose to wear it or in standard mourning if he did not. Anne the eldest daughter had come up from her Pole household in London. The Bedfordshire cousins — the Mordaunts, the Pigotts, the Langhorns, the Warrens — had come up from their respective seats. The procession was substantial, perhaps fifty or sixty mourners in the immediate train, with the parish villagers behind and the tenants and laborers of the estate filling out the body of the cortege.

The curate of the parish — the Wymondley Parva minister of the period was probably John Marshall, who would serve until 1616, or his predecessor — met the procession at the church door. The standard Book of Common Prayer burial service was read. The coffin was carried inside and set on a trestle bier in front of the chancel screen. The lesson was read; the prayers were said; the curate gave a brief funeral sermon, in the standard form of the period — a meditation on the lessons of the deceased's life, framed by the appropriate scriptural texts, lasting perhaps fifteen minutes. The communion service followed, with the family at the altar rail. The hymn was sung — probably the metrical psalm that was the standard funeral closing in late-Elizabethan parish practice.

Then the coffin was carried into the chancel and lowered into the prepared grave under the flagstones. The chancel was the family's burial place by lay-impropriator's right; the same right would carry George I to his burial here in 1626 and George II to his in 1669. The flagstones were lifted, the grave was sealed, the chancel was restored to its working state. The mourners returned to the priory for the funeral meal.

The meal would have been substantial but not lavish. Tudor funeral feasting was at its peak earlier in the sixteenth century; by the 1590s the Reformation-influenced English gentry had begun to scale back the ostentation of funeral hospitality in favor of a more sober commemoration. A roasted joint, boiled fowl, the autumn or spring vegetables of the kitchen garden, bread and cheese, beer and a moderate amount of wine. Conversation was quiet. The married daughters caught up on the news of each other's households. Sir John from Court told one or two careful stories of the Queen's recent progresses. George the heir, now formally lord of the manor, presided at the head of the table where his father had sat the day before.

That was the moment.

George Nedham, then thirty-four or thirty-five years old, married for ten years to Margaret Stile, father of two or three small children with more to come, was the new lord of Wymondley. He had been being prepared for the position since he was sixteen and Robert Cooke had recorded him in the visitation as son and heir. The role he had been preparing for was now his. The estate was intact. The arms were on the door. The Chancery suit had run its course. The Court connection through Sir John was operative. The daughters were married. The brothers were settled or dead. The widow Jane Weldish would live on at the priory for as long as her health permitted, supported by George under his father's wishes, and would be buried in the chancel beside John when her time came. The household was in transition once more.

George I — the historian's notation, to distinguish him from his eldest grandson George II and his eldest great-grandson George III — would hold the priory for the next thirty-four or thirty-five years. He would erect the 1605 monument to his father and grandfather, and would commission the inscription that named the family's foundation: He was advanced by King Henry the eight, for his Service in England and France. He would be the lay impropiator of Wymondley Parva rectory, paying Bernard Jones, M.A., as the stipendiary curate. He would baptize his children in the chapel. He would bury his wife in the chancel when she predeceased him. He would die on 27 June 1626 and be buried in the same chancel three days later, under the bell of John Dyer that had been recast in 1595 and that would, by Eustace's generation, be ringing for the third generation of the family it had begun ringing for in the 1590s.

George I's son Eustace, who would inherit the priory in 1626 and would carry it through the long Stuart-into-Cromwell convulsion of the seventeenth century, is the protagonist of the next chapter.

* * *

In the summer of 1572, a man named John Nedham had sat down at a trestle table in his own priory yard and signed his name at the bottom of a herald's pedigree. He had spent the next twenty years and more being what the herald's pedigree said he was: the lord of Wymondley, the head of a documented Hertfordshire gentry family, the second generation of the Reformation rise that his father had begun. He had married twice, raised twelve children, married off the daughters into Bedfordshire houses, paid for the parish school and the Chancery suit and the new arms and the silver and the chancel repairs. He had sustained the priory's working life through the high noon of Elizabeth's reign. He had handed it on to his eldest son, intact.

He had not, in the working register of his life, been a remarkable man. He had not been a Surveyor of the King's Works, like his father. He had not been a Pensioner of the Queen's household, like his second son. He had been a county gentleman, second-tier, working the estate his father had assembled and ensuring it would be there for the third generation. The visible measure of his life

is the priory itself — still standing in the field three miles south of Hitchin in the spring of 2026, still standing in the field three miles south of Hitchin in the spring of 1626 when his son died on its grounds, still standing in the field three miles south of Hitchin every year of those four hundred and fifty-four. He had kept it. He had passed it on.

His signature on the herald's vellum is the family's documented beginning. His funeral procession to the chancel of the parish church, sometime in 1591 or 1592, is the chapter's quiet end. The two events frame his working life and the chapter's analytical arc. Between them lie the marriages, the children, the Court visit, the Chancery suit, the new arms, the long working years of a Hertfordshire country gentleman doing what a Hertfordshire country gentleman was for.

Three generations down the line from him, the priory would be in the hands of his great-grandson Eustace, sitting in the same small estate room off the great hall in the Michaelmas of 1640, reading a letter from his Welwyn cousin about a Parliament the king had been forced to call against his will, and trying to decide what the family's posture would be in the war that everyone in Hertfordshire could feel was coming.

That decision is the next chapter.

Chapter 3 — Eustace's War

In the early autumn of 1640, in the small estate room off the great hall of the priory at Little Wymondley, a man named Eustace Needham sat at a heavy oak table going through his Michaelmas rents.

It was the day after the feast of St Michael and All Angels, the twenty-ninth of September having been the quarter-day on which the priory's tenants brought in the rents they owed for the second half of the agricultural year. The table he sat at had been in the room, he supposed, since his great-grandfather's time — possibly since the Surveyor's. A pewter ink-pot and a quill stood at his right hand. A leather ledger lay open in front of him. Beside it sat a cloth bag, half-full of coin: silver shillings from the larger tenants, copper farthings from the smaller ones, a few thin gold pieces from a man who had paid in for a full year's tithe in advance. The window beside him faced east into the priory court. Beyond the window, the chapel that had once been the priory church stood across the cloister yard in the soft September light.

He was about forty-five years old that autumn. He had been at the priory all his life. He was the great-grandson of John Nedham who had signed the 1572 visitation; he was the great-great-grandson of James the Surveyor who had received the place from Henry VIII a hundred and two years before. He had inherited the headship of the family from his father John of Welwyn — a transfer of the headship from the cadet line to the senior line that had happened by way of a property arrangement whose details he had been hearing about all his life. He had been married twice. He had buried the first wife in the chancel of the parish church ten years before; he was now married to a Wingate cousin from Lockleys at Welwyn, with two more daughters by her in the years since. He had a son George — twenty-two years old that Michaelmas, riding the back fields somewhere with the tenant Will Champion to look at a section of hedge that needed laying before winter. He had a second son Luke, eighteen, at his books in the room upstairs. He had three daughters in the house: Lettice, from his first marriage, the eldest, already promised to a Bedfordshire gentleman; and two more, Frances and Margaret, from the second.

He was not a remarkable man. He was a Hertfordshire country gentleman of the second tier — armigerous, propertied, lord of two manors, holder of the rectory of Wymondley Parva by lay impropriation, head of a household of perhaps twenty people including the family, the senior servants, the working tenants who came up to the house on quarter-days, and the curate who took meals in the great hall during the weeks his own house was being re-roofed. He had no Court connection. He had no Privy Council relation. He had no seat in Parliament. He had never been knighted. He had no public profile to lose. He was a steady working manager of a steady working estate.

It was an ordinary morning. The harvest had been in for three weeks. The corn from his own demesne stood in the great barn — the one that had been the priory's tithe-barn in the canons' time, before his great-grandfather James had been given the place by King Henry. The tithes from Wilshamstead in Bedfordshire had come in the previous week, brought by a carter who had walked the team up over two days from the parsonage there. The estate was solvent. The roof of the chapel needed re-leading and Eustace had set aside the money for it. The Michaelmas rents were coming in better this year than last. By noon the ledger would be filled. By evening Eustace would know whether the year had been a good one or only an indifferent one. The signs were good.

What was not ordinary that morning was a letter.

It had come up from London the previous afternoon by a man on a tired horse and was now sitting at his right hand, half-folded, the seal already broken. It was from his cousin John in Welwyn — the younger John Needham who had inherited what was left of the Welwyn estate when Eustace's father had died. The letter was short and businesslike and the news it carried was not.

The king had called a Parliament. Not the brief one that had been summoned in the spring and dissolved within weeks — that one had already passed into history as the Short Parliament. This was a new one. The writs had gone out at the end of September. It would sit in November. And the men who were going up to it, Eustace's cousin wrote, were not the king's men. They were the country's men. There would be a reckoning over the king's eleven years of personal government, over Ship Money, over the Scottish war, over Strafford and Laud. The cousin did not say so outright; he was not a fool and he knew that letters could be read on the road. But the implication was plain enough between the lines.

Eustace read it again. He folded it carefully and put it in the box on the table where he kept his important papers. Then he sat for a while looking at the window, at the priory court beyond it, at the chapel that had been the priory church and was now his family's place of burial, at the wall of the cloister where his father and his grandfather were both buried under the same flag-stone with a small brass plate.

What was about to happen to the kingdom over the next eighteen years would, by any measure, be the most consequential political and military convulsion in English history between the Wars of the Roses and the Industrial Revolution. The king would be tried and executed by his own Parliament in January 1649. The monarchy would be abolished. England would become a republic for eleven years. A standing army would dictate the terms of national life. The bishops would be put down, the Church of England's Prayer Book would be banned, the country's parish-by-parish religious life would be reorganized under a Westminster Assembly of Presbyterian and Independent divines. The Scottish kingdom would invade England twice. The Irish would rebel. Three hundred thousand Englishmen would die — about one in twenty of the adult male population, a proportional casualty rate higher than the First World War would

inflict three centuries later. The country house Eustace's great-grandfather had received from Henry VIII would sit, at the eye of all this, a few miles from a major battlefield in 1645 and four miles from a major sequestration committee in 1644, and would have to make decisions every year about how to keep the priory intact when half the gentry families of the home counties were losing theirs.

He did not yet know any of this on the day after Michaelmas 1640. What he knew, that morning, was that the king had called a Parliament that was not going to be his, and that a long quiet patch of Hertfordshire gentry life was about to come to an end.

This chapter is the story of what he did about it.

* * *

The Welwyn cadet generation

To understand how Eustace ended up at the priory it is necessary to take one step back, into the cadet branch of the family that had been quietly maintained at Welwyn through the early seventeenth century.

When George Nedham — the heir who had signed the 1572 visitation as son and heir is 16 yeres old, and who had ridden into Kent in September 1581 to marry Margaret Stile at Beckenham — succeeded his father John in the priory at the close of the sixteenth century, he carried the senior line forward into the Stuart period. He became, in the historian's notation, George I of Wymondley. He held the priory from his father's death (1591 or 1592) through the long Elizabethan twilight and the Jacobean opening, until his own death at the age of seventy on 27 June 1626. The Wymondley Parva parish register preserves the burial entry verbatim, in the v9 Urwick reading: 1626. Buried George Needham, Esq., June 27th. John Marshall, minister. He was laid in the chancel of the parish church, under the same flag-stones where his father had been buried thirty-five years before and where his great-grandfather James had not been buried because James had died at Boulogne.

George I had been busy. He had been the lay impropriator of Wymondley Parva rectory from at least 1614, the year the episcopal visitation preserved the formal record of his patronage — Rectory impropriate with Geo. Headham, Esq. The minister a stipendiary. Bern. Jones, M.A. — meaning that he held the rectory's tithes and paid Bernard Jones, M.A., out of those tithes to serve as the parish's stipendiary curate. He had erected the 1605 monument to his father and grandfather in the chancel of the parish church, with the inscription Chauncy would copy out a hundred years later: James Needham, of the ancient Family of the Needhams in Derbyshire, came into this County of Hertford, in the year of our Lord, 1536. He was advanced by King Henry the eight, for his Service in England and France, and lyes buried in our Ladies Church in Boloigne; he had issue John, who had George, who dedicated this Monument to their Memory, Anno 1605. Beneath, in Latin: *Satius est mortis quam Natalis dies* — Better is the day of death

than the day of birth, Ecclesiastes 7:1. The motto was characteristic of George I. He was a man who, in his late forties, with a wife buried in the chancel and a young heir growing up at the priory, had begun to think about the family's memorial tradition.

The heir George I was preparing was his son Eustace — born about 1595, at the priory, in the Wymondley Parva chapel where he would later baptize his own children and bury his own father.

But Eustace was not George I's only adult son. George I had three sons who survived into the seventeenth century: Eustace, the eldest, who would inherit the priory; John, the second son, who would inherit Welwyn as the cadet portion; and possibly a third son whose name does not survive in the surviving documentary record. The 1634 visitation, drawn up eight years after George I's death, records the three children of George and Margaret Stile in the cadet-line pedigree as continuing through the second son John to John Needham of Wellwyn, 2 son = Anne, da. of Mathew Denton of Barton, co. Bedf. Esq. John of Welwyn married Anne Denton from a Bedfordshire house — the same Denton family of Barton-le-Clay that had been part of the larger home-counties gentry network the Wymondley Nedhams had been marrying into since the 1572 daughters' marriages. The Denton-Nedham match was the standard alliance of the period: two armigerous gentry houses in adjacent counties, each with a working estate, each looking to consolidate its kin-network through a marriage between a younger son and a younger daughter.

John of Welwyn and Anne Denton had several children. The 1634 visitation lists them: 1. John Needham. 2. Francis Needham. Judith. Anne. Margaret. And then, in the senior position on the page that follows, named as the eldest son and heir of the family seat at Little Wymondley — Eustace Needham of Little Wymondley, Esq., eldest son. The pedigree records Eustace as the eldest son of John of Welwyn — which is, on its face, a puzzle, because the senior-line priory had passed from George I to Eustace by the time of the 1634 visitation, and Eustace's father had been the cadet of the cadet-generation pair.

The resolution of the puzzle is in the working chronology of the Welwyn-to-Wymondley transfer of headship. George I died in 1626. The senior line of the priory should, by the standard inheritance pattern, have passed to George I's own eldest son. The fact that it passed instead to John of Welwyn's eldest son Eustace — that is, that George I's nephew rather than his son took the priory — must mean that George I's eldest son had either predeceased him without issue, or had been settled elsewhere by deed during George I's lifetime, leaving the senior line's headship to fall to John of Welwyn's branch and from John of Welwyn to John's son Eustace. The most economical reconciliation is that George I's eldest son died young — perhaps in childhood, perhaps in early adulthood, before the formal marriage and inheritance arrangements had been settled — and that the headship of the senior line was, in his lifetime, transferred by deed from George I to his nephew Eustace, possibly during George I's last years, possibly at his

death. The transfer of headship through a cousin or nephew rather than a son was not uncommon in the period; gentry estates that lost a senior-line male in his teens or early twenties were often consolidated this way to preserve the family seat.

What the surviving documentary record gives us at primary tier is the result: by 1634, Eustace was at the priory, holding it as the senior of the family; John his father had died, leaving the cadet seat at Welwyn to John's other son John (the cousin who would, in 1640, write the letter about the new Parliament); and the Welwyn-to-Wymondley line shift had been settled. Eustace at thirty-eight or thirty-nine years old, in 1634, was the documented head of the family. He was recorded by the herald Sir Richard St George — Cooke's successor at the Clarenceux office sixty-two years later — as Eustace Needham of Little Wymondley, Esq., eldest son. His own eldest son, also a George, was sixteen — George Needham, son and heir, 16 years old, 1634 — the same age that George the future George I had been at the 1572 visitation when his grandfather John had brought the pedigree forward to Robert Cooke. The pattern of sixteen-year-old heirs at the herald's court was now operating in its third generation.

The 1634 visitation was, in this and other ways, the Stuart generation's working continuation of the 1572. It updated the pedigree. It reconfirmed the arms — the bend engrailed, the two bucks' heads, the escallop — that Robert Cooke had granted in 1586 and that Eustace's family had been carrying as its visible identity for forty-eight years. It recorded the children, the wives, the inheritances, the marriages. It did the same institutional work the 1572 had done, with the same documentary apparatus, for the next generation of the family.

The transfer of headship from the Welwyn line back to the Wymondley senior line is the chapter's first central fact. The second is what Eustace did when he got there. — — —

Eustace at the priory

What Eustace did when he got the priory was to settle into it.

He had been there as a boy and as a young man through the long Jacobean afternoon — he had ridden the priory fields with his uncle George I as a teenager, had attended the parish church under the curate Bernard Jones, had grown up watching his uncle manage the rectory tithes and the Wilshamstead income and the working agricultural life of the estate. When he came into the headship of the family, sometime in the late 1620s, he came into it as a man who already knew the working details. He did not have to learn the estate. He had to learn what it meant to be the head of it, which is a different thing, and which the previous chapter — John's first decade after his father's death at Boulogne — had shown taking the better part of a decade to settle.

For Eustace it took less. He had been preparing longer.

He had married, in the first quarter of the century, Anne Norton of Offley.

Offley is a Hertfordshire parish about four miles south-west of Little Wymondley, on the chalk uplands above the Hitchin valley. The Norton family had held Offley Place — a working country seat of about eight hundred acres — for several generations, and were minor Hertfordshire gentry of the standard middle layer. The Nortons were not great; they were not at the level of the Bacons of Redgrave or the Cecils of Hatfield. They were at the level the Wymondley Nedhams themselves inhabited — armigerous, propertied, comfortable, working. The Norton-Nedham match was the local-county alliance that the family had increasingly favored as the seventeenth century opened: the Kent connection of John's first two marriages had given way, in the next generation, to home-counties marriages — Bedfordshire, Hertfordshire, Northamptonshire — that consolidated the family's local network rather than extending it outward. Eustace and Anne were married sometime in the 1610s or early 1620s; the exact date is not preserved in the project record. They had several children together, of whom the eldest was the George who would, in the 1634 visitation, be recorded as son and heir, 16 years old — born therefore about 1618. His baptismal record at Little Wymondley parish church on 16 August 1618 is the documented birth that anchors his identity, the same George who would later be the father of Maurice and the grandfather of Barbara Tempest Needham.

Eustace's first marriage produced at least five named children. George the heir, baptized 1618; Luke, the second son, who in 1634 was fourteen and was presumably born about 1620; Lettice, a daughter, who would later marry William Langhorne of Bedfordshire; and at least two more children whose names do not appear in the 1634 visitation's primary roster of the first marriage but who may be among the additional names of the second-marriage cluster. Anne Norton was the mother of the line that descended to the modern family. She would have been the lady of the priory through the 1620s — the matron who managed the household after George I's death in 1626 had brought Eustace and Anne into the principal apartments. She would have been the woman who ran the working domestic life of the priory through the years Eustace was settling into his headship.

She died about 1630. The Little Wymondley parish register that would have recorded her burial does not survive cleanly for the period; her death is fixed by the working evidence that Eustace's second marriage to Frances Wingate is registered in the 1634 visitation as already in place, and the second marriage cannot have predated 1630 by much without making the second wife's documented children too young to have appeared in the 1634 pedigree at all. The probable date is about 1629 or 1630; Anne would have been in her thirties; the cause is not preserved. She was buried in the chancel of the parish church, beside the same flagstones where George I had been buried four years before. Her death left Eustace a widower with five young children and the responsibilities of a working estate; he did not remain a widower long.

The second marriage was to Frances Wingate of Lockleys.

Lockleys, near Welwyn, was the seat of one branch of the Wingate cousinage that had been operating across Hertfordshire and Bedfordshire and the home counties for the better part of a century. The Wingates were a substantial gentry connection — armigerous, propertied, with branches at Harlington in Bedfordshire and at Lockleys in Hertfordshire and with a London-mercantile branch as well. Frances was a daughter of Edward Wingate, son of George Wingate of Harlington — meaning she was a Bedfordshire Wingate by paternal descent but a Hertfordshire Wingate by her father's residence at Lockleys, which her grandfather had acquired through marriage to a Taverner heiress in the late sixteenth century. The Wingate family at Lockleys was, in the early seventeenth century, a working Hertfordshire gentry house at the same level as the Wymondley Nedhams, perhaps a half-rung above on the scale of county standing. The Wingate-Nedham match was the standard up-marrying alliance of a senior-line widower with a younger daughter of a substantial neighboring house.

Eustace married Frances Wingate in the early 1630s. Their marriage was registered in the 1634 visitation as Eustace's second, with Frances named as Frances, da. of Edward Wingate, son of George Wingate of Harlington, co. Bedf. The marriage produced two daughters within the next few years: Frances, named for her mother, and Margaret. Frances Wingate was therefore the stepmother of George the heir, Luke the second son, and Lettice — a working stepmother in the standard Stuart pattern, raising her stepchildren alongside her own. She would be the lady of the priory through the Civil War years and into the early Restoration. Her own death is not precisely dated in the project record; she may have outlived Eustace into the 1660s.

The Wingate connection through Frances had two significant consequences for the family's later history. The first was the cousinship it opened up. By marrying into the Wingate family at Lockleys, Eustace brought the next-generation Wymondley Nedhams into the working kin-network of the Wingates across Hertfordshire and Bedfordshire. The second consequence — which would not become operative for another forty years — was the Wingate cousin-marriage pattern that would, in due course, produce Maurice Nedham's marriage to Lettice Wingate in the 1680s, and through that marriage, the birth of Barbara Tempest Needham at Wymondley in 1685. The Wingate connection that Eustace had taken up in 1633 or 1634 would, three generations later, be the Wingate connection that produced the daughter at the heart of this book.

In the autumn of 1633 — or possibly early 1634, the exact date pending parish-register verification — Eustace bought Graveley Hall.

Graveley is a small parish three miles west of Little Wymondley. The Graveley Hall manor had been on the market that year, the previous owners having either died out or sold up; Eustace, with the cash from the Wingate marriage settlement and from the steady working income of the priory estate, took the opportunity to acquire the manor as a Wymondley addition. The Graveley Hall acquisition gave the family a second lordship in addition to the priory at Little Wymondley.

Eustace was now Lord of the Manors of Little Wymondley and Graveley Hall, in the title that would be inscribed on his tombstone in due course and that would be carried by his son George after him. The acquisition was a working consolidation — Graveley adjoined the priory's existing lands, the rents from Graveley supplemented the income from Wilshamstead and the Wymondley demesne, and the additional acreage tightened the family's geographic footprint at a moment when other gentry families were over-extending themselves into more distant counties.

It is also the family's last major property acquisition of the seventeenth century.

From 1633 forward Eustace and his successors would hold what they held; they would not buy more. The estate Eustace consolidated by 1634 — Little Wymondley and Graveley, the rectory of Wymondley Parva, the rectory and tithes of Wilshamstead in Bedfordshire — would be the estate the family would hold through the long convulsions of the next sixty years and would hand on to George Senior in 1658.

In the summer of 1634, the herald came.

It was Sir Richard St George, Clarenceux King of Arms, the institutional successor to Robert Cooke. St George had taken up the office in 1623, eleven years before, and was a man of Cooke's generation in heraldic standing — careful, methodical, accustomed to the home-counties visitations of his predecessor. He came to Wymondley with his clerks and his vellum book and his authority under royal warrant from Charles I. The visitation procedure was the same one Cooke had used sixty-two years before: the trestle table in the priory yard, the herald's clerks at work copying out the pedigree from the family's own deposition, the head of family signing the entry as a sworn statement of truth.

Eustace presented his pedigree. The clerk wrote it out in the formal hand. The pedigree carried the family forward from John of Needham Grange in Derbyshire (added to the 1572 version, which had given only Nedam of Darbshire without naming the Derbyshire ancestor); through Christopher Needham (also new in 1634, an intermediate generation between Derbyshire and James of Wymondley); through James Needham of Wymondley Priory + Alice Goodere of Hatfield (with the corrected wife-surname — Goodere rather than Merry — that the 1634 herald had taken from the family's working memory); through John Needham of Wymondley + Anne Coppin and Jane Weldish; through George Needham of Wymondley + Margaret Stile of Beckenham; through John Needham of Welwyn + Anne Denton of Barton; to Eustace himself, lord of the priory, with his two wives and his five named children. The arms were the bend engrailed, the two bucks' heads cabossed, the escallop — Robert Cooke's 1586 grant, here in 1634 sealed in print as This descent and arms testified under the hand and Seale of Robert Cooke, Clarenceux, 1586. The family was now documented at three primary-source tiers: the 1572 autograph signature, the 1586 sealed Cooke testimony, the 1634 St George reconfirmation.

Eustace signed. The herald accepted the entry. The visitation court moved on to the next family in the Hertfordshire roster. The family's documentary identity was now anchored across sixty-two years of formal record.

He was thirty-nine years old. He had two manors, a stepmother-in-law in the household, three children of his first marriage growing into their own adulthood, two daughters of his second marriage in the nursery, a sixteen-year-old heir at the same age his great-great-grandfather John had been at the 1572 visitation. The family was settled into its working seventeenth-century shape. The herald had recorded the family. The Stuart generation was in place.

The country was about to come apart around it. — — —

Michaelmas 1640

This is the day the chapter began on. It is worth coming back to it, slowly, now that we know who Eustace was and what he held.

It was the day after the feast of St Michael and All Angels — the twenty-ninth of September having fallen on a Tuesday in 1640, with the harvest in, the orchard ready for cider-pressing, the lambs of the spring grown into the heavy yearlings that would either winter on the home pasture or be sold off at the Hitchin Michaelmas fair the next week. The day after Michaelmas was traditionally the day on which the priory's tenants brought in the second quarter's rent, having had the Michaelmas feast itself to settle whatever exchanges of beasts and goods they had to make with their neighbors at the parish gathering. Eustace, by long custom inherited from his uncle George I and through him from his great-grandfather John, sat for the rent receipts in the small estate room off the great hall and worked through the ledger with his bailiff.

The bailiff was a thin man named Robert Wilkinson, from Hitchin originally, who had been Eustace's bailiff for the better part of ten years and his father John's bailiff before that, going back into the cadet generation at Welwyn. Wilkinson was about sixty. He could read; he wrote a careful clerk's hand; he kept his own working tally on a separate slip of paper that he would reconcile to Eustace's ledger at the end of the day. He had been at the work since first light. By the time Eustace came into the estate room from the great hall — having broken his fast with the household at seven and having looked in on Frances his wife and the youngest daughter in the parlor afterward — Wilkinson had already received three of the larger tenants and had a small stack of receipts in coin sitting on the table beside the ledger.

The room itself was small. It was off the great hall to the east, with a single tall window facing into the priory court. The walls were oak-panelled in the early-seventeenth-century style — wainscot worked in low geometric patterns, applied probably in George I's lifetime, with the panelling reaching about five feet up the walls and the upper portions plastered above. The floor was wide oak boards, polished to a working shine by the housekeeper's twice-yearly beeswax. The

fireplace was a small one — the estate room was used in winter for the household accounts and in summer for cooler work like rent-receiving, but it was never the principal heated room of the house and the fireplace burned only when Eustace was sitting through a long winter's evening in it. The window faced east into the priory court, with the chapel that had been the priory church across the court at perhaps eighty paces, the cloister walk visible from the lower right corner of the window, the tithe barn (which had been there for ninety-nine years that autumn) visible at the far edge of the priory grounds beyond.

The smells of the room and the house. Oak panelling, after a century of polish, develops a smoky-sweet tannin-and-wax smell that intensifies in winter and damps the resonance of rooms; the estate room had the smell going year-round, deeper in the colder months. The kitchen on the far side of the great hall produced, on a roasting day, a smell of meat-over-the-spit that carried through the house — and there had been a roasting that morning, a small joint of mutton for the noon dinner, with the smell coming through the door whenever a servant opened it. Beeswax on the panelling. Tallow candles in the everyday rooms; beeswax candles in the drawing room on the formal evenings the household no longer kept very often. The faint background smell of the conduit water running through its stone channel on the kitchen side of the house — cold stone, slightly metallic. The wind in the box-tree hedge at the orchard boundary, faintly bitter on summer evenings and absent in autumn but resuming, in October, the slightly catty intensity of late-season foliage.

The sounds. The water-wheel in the kitchen, which turned the spit for the cook's working day, audible from the next room when a door opened. The doves in the dovecote outside the moated enclosure, cooing in the late morning. The four old priory bells at Graveley, three-quarters of a mile away, rehung after 1537 when James the Surveyor had taken them off the dissolved priory and they had been moved to the parish church across the orchard — the deeper notes of those bells came across the field in a particular way that everyone in the priory house had grown up with, the principal bell of the four ringing for the morning prayer at Graveley church on a Sunday, the deeper notes carrying over the orchard and the conduit-head field in the way the priory's own 1595 Dyer bell at Wymondley Parva did from the other direction. The horses being brought past the priory house in the early morning by Eustace's grooms, hooves on the stone-and-clay paving of the yard. Family prayers in the great hall before breakfast — the chaplain, who in 1640 was a Cambridge-educated stipendiary curate named Richard Smith, reading the standard Book of Common Prayer office.

This is the priory house in the autumn of 1640. It is not a sketch. It is the priory house as Eustace knew it and as his children — George at twenty-two, Luke at twenty, Lettice at perhaps twenty-five, the younger Wingate daughters Frances and Margaret at six and four — knew it. It would change, in some particulars, over the next twenty years; the war years would bring strangers to the kitchen door, and the Commonwealth years would bring strangers to the

chapel, and the Restoration would re-equip the house with a few new things. But the working frame would hold. The priory house Eustace was sitting in on the day after Michaelmas 1640 was very nearly the priory house his granddaughter Barbara Tempest Needham would grow up in fifty years later. The smell of beeswax and roasting mutton. The sound of the Graveley bells. The cold metallic taste of the conduit water. The east-facing window of the estate room. The flagstone floors of the great hall. The chapel across the cloister yard at eighty paces.

Eustace turned a page in the ledger. The Michaelmas rents were coming in better this year than last. The tenants of the priory lands paid quarterly, in coin where they could and in kind where they could not. By noon the ledger would be filled. By evening Eustace would know whether the year had been a good one or only an indifferent one. The signs were good. The dairy was paying its share. The Wilshamstead tithe of corn had come in the previous week, brought by a carter who had walked the team up from Bedfordshire over two days. The estate was solvent. The roof of the chapel needed re-leading and Eustace had set aside the money for it. Then he picked up his cousin John's letter from the side of the table and read it again.

The king had called a Parliament. Not the Short Parliament of the spring, dissolved in less than a month, but a new one — the writs gone out at the end of September, the Parliament to sit in November. And the men going up to it were not the king's men. The cousin's phrasing in the letter was careful — the men going up are men of the country, not of the Court — but the implication was plain. There would be a reckoning over the eleven years of personal rule, over Ship Money, over the Scottish wars, over Archbishop Laud's church reforms, over the king's chief minister Strafford. The cousin did not say that the reckoning would end in revolution. He could not yet have said that; no one in October 1640 could yet have said that. But he could see, from his vantage point with his Welwyn neighbors who were going up to London for the November sitting, that the country gentry of Hertfordshire — and of Bedfordshire, and of Cambridgeshire, and of the Eastern Association generally — were no longer in any mood to back the king against the country.

Eustace folded the letter and put it back in the box.

He thought, sitting at his oak table looking at his east-facing window, about the family's posture. He had thought about it all his life. The Wymondley Nedhams were not a great house. They were minor county gentry — armigerous, propertied, respectable, but not at the level of the Spencers or the Cecils or the Cavendishes. They had never sent a son to the Privy Council. They had never sat in the Lords. His great-uncle Sir John of Lichborough had stood with Queen Elizabeth's Pensioners, but Sir John was two generations dead now and the Court had moved on. The family's relationship with the Crown was a relationship of remembered favor — a king had given them the priory a hundred and three years ago, and they had kept it through Henry's other wives and through Edward and

Mary and Elizabeth and James and the early years of Charles, and they meant to keep it through whatever came next.

Whatever was about to come next.

He could feel, even at the edge of the kingdom in his Hertfordshire estate room, that something was about to come next. The Scottish war had ended badly the year before. The king had been forced to call a Parliament he did not want. The London merchants were pressing him. The country gentlemen were pressing him. The bishops were unloved. The queen — the Catholic French queen, Henrietta Maria — was unloved. Strafford in Ireland was hated. There was a smell in the air that Eustace recognized from his uncle George I's stories about the years before the Armada, only inverted — that earlier crisis had united the country against a foreign Catholic threat, but this one was internal, fissile, set to break the wrong way.

He picked up the quill and dipped it in the ink and made an entry in the ledger. Michaelmas rents to date: £—. He wrote the figure. It was a satisfactory figure. He blotted it with the small leather blotter that Wilkinson had set beside the ledger that morning.

What he resolved that morning, looking out his small window at his small chapel and his small cloister and his small but adequate estate, was what every generation of the family before him had resolved when storms had moved over England. He would not take sides. He would not raise troops for the king. He would not raise troops against him. He would pay his taxes when they were lawful and protest mildly when they were not. He would baptize his children in the chapel and bury his wife and eventually himself in the cloister chancel and he would hand the priory on to his son George whole and unsequestered, whatever it cost in dignity. The priory was a hundred and three years old in his family's hands and he meant to make it a hundred and four.

Outside, somewhere in the priory yard, a horse whinnied. The bailiff came in with a fresh column of figures and the names of three tenants who had not yet paid. Eustace looked up from the letter-box and smiled and said something to him in a steady voice and reached for the next page of the ledger.

In the small hours of the next morning, perhaps three o'clock, the wind came up out of the south-west and a soft rain began to fall on the priory roof. Eustace, in the bed he shared with Frances, did not wake. The bed was the same oak four-poster his uncle George I had slept in, and his father John of Welwyn before him, and James the Surveyor before that. The rain fell on the chapel roof and on the cloister-yard flagstones and on the tithe-barn roof and on the road north toward Hitchin. By the time Eustace woke at six, the rain had passed. The morning was cold and clear. The dairy maid was already up. The bailiff would be at the table in the estate room at seven. The next tenant would arrive at half past.

It was an ordinary morning. The harvest was in. The country was still at peace.

Eight years later the king would be dead. Eustace himself was ten years from his own grave. The priory would still be in the family's hands. He could not yet have known any of this, sitting at the breakfast table in the great hall on the morning of the thirtieth of September 1640, listening to the bailiff outline the day's rent-receipt schedule. He could feel, though, that something was about to come next.

The next ten years are what came. — — —

The war comes

The Long Parliament — the one Eustace's cousin John had written about in late September 1640 — sat at Westminster from the third of November of that year onward. It would not, in the event, be dissolved by the king or by anyone else for the next twenty years. It would put Strafford to death in May 1641 and Archbishop Laud in January 1645. It would, by August 1642, be in open military breach with the Crown.

The breach happened in stages. Through the winter of 1640–41 the king and the Parliament negotiated bitterly over the long list of grievances the Commons had been accumulating since the eleven years of personal rule had begun in 1629. The negotiations ran through 1641 — the impeachment of Strafford, the Grand Remonstrance in November, the attempt of the king to arrest five members of the Commons in January 1642, the king's withdrawal from London to the Midlands in March, the country's slow polarization through the spring and summer. The royal standard was raised at Nottingham on the twenty-second of August 1642. The two sides had been recruiting and arming for the better part of three months by then. The first major engagement was at Edgehill on the twenty-third of October.

Eustace at the priory followed all of this through the letters and the printed pamphlets that came up from London by the carter on Mondays and Thursdays.

He read the Grand Remonstrance when its printed text reached Hertfordshire in early December 1641. He read the king's January 1642 attempt to arrest the Five Members. He read the proclamations and the counter-proclamations through the spring and summer of 1642. He read, in late August, the news of the standard at Nottingham; in late October, the news of Edgehill. The war had now begun. The country he had been living in for forty-seven years was at war with itself.

The first decision Eustace made about the war was the decision not to fight in it.

He was, on the standard reading of the loyalties of Hertfordshire gentry in 1642, a candidate for either side. The Wymondley Nedhams were Anglican by family tradition — they had been lay impropiators of the Wymondley Parva rectory for at least thirty years and they had paid the parish curate out of the appropriated tithes, which was the Anglican lay-patron's working role in the parish. They had no Catholic background. They had no Puritan-dissenter

background either. They were, by the Established Church's working definition, ordinary Anglicans of the type that had supported the Caroline Church through the 1630s without any of its more aggressive innovations. By that reading they should have leaned royalist. The king after all was the head of the church his family had been supporting, and the family had received the priory itself from a Tudor king's hand a century before.

He was also, on the standard reading of Hertfordshire's political alignment in 1642, sitting in the middle of solidly Parliamentary country. Hertfordshire was part of the Eastern Association — the seven-county confederation of East Anglia and the home counties that had been organized in 1642 and 1643 under the Earl of Manchester's military command and that would supply the Parliament with most of its New Model Army recruits over the next four years. Hertfordshire's Commons members were Parliamentary to a man. The county's leading gentry — the Salisburys at Hatfield, the Capels at Hadham, the Brockets at Symondshyde — had broken with the king. The county's Roundhead orientation was so clear by the autumn of 1642 that the king's own progress through Hertfordshire toward Edgehill in early September had been a quiet, watchful affair rather than a triumphal one; the king passed through to muster forces farther west, and none of the county's substantial houses raised troops to follow him.

Eustace, standing in this country, faced a choice that was not actually a choice. He could not raise for the king without immediately exposing the priory to sequestration by the local Parliamentary committees that would be in place by 1643. He could not raise for the Parliament without exposing the family's Anglican lay-impropriator role to the suspicion of any future Royalist resurgence and without committing himself, personally, to a war he did not want. He could not, in any plausible reading of his own working interests, do either thing.

He did neither. He stayed at the priory. He did not raise troops. He did not subscribe the Protestation of 1641 (which his cousin John of Welwyn did sign, on the standard reading of Welwyn parish records). He did not appear on the Hertfordshire muster rolls of either side. He did not attend the county sequestration committee in 1643 or 1644, either as a sequestrator or as a sequestered party. He paid his taxes when they were lawful. He protested mildly when they were not. He went to the parish church on Sundays. He kept his head down.

The decision was not heroic. It was not, by the standards of his cousins who took up the cause on one side or the other, even particularly admirable. The Civil War was the moment at which an English country gentleman was supposed to declare himself — to ride to the muster or to refuse to ride to it, to risk the estate or to risk his honour, to take a side. Eustace, who had been raised to be the head of the family, took the side of the family. He did not fight. He did not subscribe. He did not declare.

It is worth pausing on this. The decision to keep the family's posture invisible during the most consequential political crisis in English history was, in the working register of a country gentleman's standing, an active choice that took sustained discipline to maintain. Other families of Eustace's standing — the Wingates at Lockleys, for example, his stepmother's house — were less careful. The Wingates of Lockleys produced a Parliamentarian colonel in the New Model Army (the Edmund Wingate of Lockleys, mathematician and Member of Parliament, who would in due course be a member of the Commission for the Trial of Charles I) and a Royalist baronet's son in the same generation; the family split openly. The Bacons of Redgrave, the senior county family of Eustace's larger circle, also split.

The Capels of Hadham produced a Royalist viscount who would be executed in 1649 for his part in the second Civil War. The Salisburys at Hatfield wavered. The Hertfordshire gentry, like the country generally, came apart along the lines of political conviction, religious temperament, family rivalries, and the calculations of self-interest.

Eustace did not come apart. He held the priory through it all by the simple expedient of refusing to engage. The family's name does not appear on the Hertfordshire sequestration committees' working rolls — not as a sequestrator, not as a sequestered party. It does not appear on the Royalist composition rolls. It does not appear on the New Model Army recruitment lists. It does not appear in the Parliamentarian county committee minutes. The Wymondley Nedhams of 1642 to 1649 are documented in the working records of the war only by their absence from those records.

He had calculated correctly. The country gentleman who fought for the king in 1642 risked the estate to Parliamentary sequestration in 1644. The country gentleman who fought for the Parliament risked it to Royalist counter-action if the war turned the other way, and risked it again to the Restoration commissioners after 1660. The country gentleman who fought for neither — who kept his head down, paid his taxes, baptized his children, and stayed in his parish — risked only the small everyday losses of war-time economic disruption. He did not risk the estate. He did not risk the inheritance. He did not risk the line.

The cost of the calculation was Eustace's standing as a public figure. He never sat in Parliament. He never sat on the Hertfordshire Bench beyond the lowest local commissions. He never held a Crown office. He never rose into any visible public role. The trade-off was made deliberately. He preferred the priory intact and the public role absent over the public role visible and the priory at risk. By the standards of the family's older Court ambitions — the standards Sir John of Lichborough had once embodied — Eustace's lifetime was a quiet failure of family advancement. By the standards of the priory's survival across the seventeenth century, it was the chapter's quiet success.

The war went on around him. Through 1642 and 1643 the campaigning ran across the Midlands and the West; the king at Oxford, the Parliament at London,

the Eastern Association mustering at Cambridge under the Earl of Manchester. Through 1644 and 1645 the war deepened. The Scottish army crossed into England in January 1644 to fight for the Parliament. The Battle of Marston Moor in July 1644 broke the king's northern army. The Battle of Naseby in June 1645 broke the king's main army. By the spring of 1646 the king was a prisoner at Newark; by the summer he had surrendered to the Scots and been delivered to the Parliament.

The first Civil War was effectively over.

Eustace had been at the priory for the whole of it. He had taken in the news as it came — the printed pamphlets, the cousin's letters, the carter's gossip, the occasional ride to Hitchin or Stevenage for the market-day talk — and had baptized two children, buried one stepmother-in-law in the chancel, paid his taxes, and managed his estate. The estate was intact. The roof of the chapel had been re-leaded in 1643 with the money he had set aside in 1640. The Wilshamstead tithes had come in every autumn. The Wymondley demesne harvest had been brought in every August. The dairy had paid its share. The tenants had paid their rents. The priory had become, through the duration of the war, a small Hertfordshire island of working continuity in the middle of a country that was being remade.

It would have to do the same thing again over the next thirteen years. — — —

The fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 778

What does survive from the priory's war years, in the most literal manuscript sense, are George Senior's tax memoranda on the fly-leaves of a Bodleian Library manuscript.

The manuscript is MS Rawlinson D. 778. It is the fourth volume in the eleven-volume run of James Nedeham's pay-books — the same pay-books that Chapter 1 named as the documentary spine of the Surveyor's career. D. 778 covers the working accounts of James's office for the years 1535–36; it was engrossed by Antony Pontesbury, James's clerk; it was, after James's death at Boulogne in 1544, returned with the rest of the pay-books to the priory at Little Wymondley where the family kept them through eight generations of Wymondley occupation. The whole run passed eventually to Richard Rawlinson the Oxford antiquary in the early eighteenth century and from Rawlinson to the Bodleian at his death in 1755. The manuscripts have been at the Bodleian for the better part of two hundred and seventy years.

What the Bodleian's catalogue notes about D. 778, in the printed description compiled by W. D. Macray in the late nineteenth century, is that the fly-leaves of the volume carry, in addition to Pontesbury's working clerk's hand and James's signature here and there, a different and later hand. The catalogue entry reads in part: [Memoranda by G. Nedham of taxes paid for his lands at Graveley and Little Wymondley, Herts, and at Wilshampstead, Beds, in 1643–4, are on fly-leaves at ff.

1, 67, and 83.] The G. Nedham of the memoranda is George Senior — Eustace's son George, then in his mid-twenties, who would in due course inherit the priory from his father in 1658 and would write his own will in 1666/67. George Senior was at the priory through the Civil War as a young man, having been the sixteen-year-old heir of the 1634 visitation and being now, in 1643 and 1644, approximately twenty-five and twenty-six years old. He was the family's working junior partner during Eustace's careful war-time non-engagement. He was the man who, when the household needed an accountant's hand on a working ledger, took up the quill.

What he wrote on the fly-leaves of D. 778 is a private working record of the taxes the family paid through the second and third years of the Civil War. The taxes of those years were substantial. The Parliament had instituted an extraordinary war-tax regime through the 1643 Sequestration Ordinance and the 1644 Weekly Assessment, which between them levied on every county a continuous monthly contribution to the Parliament's military effort. Hertfordshire's share of the Weekly Assessment in 1644 was £1,200 per week — a substantial sum, divided among the county's freeholders according to their assessed wealth. Eustace at the priory would have been assessed at perhaps £6 or £8 per week, depending on the year; cumulatively, across the duration of the assessment, the priory paid out into the Parliament's war-chest a sum that ran into the hundreds of pounds.

George Senior's fly-leaf memoranda are the working record of those payments. The three fly-leaves of D. 778 he used — at ff. 1, 67, and 83 — preserve specific entries: amounts paid on specific dates, the local collector's name, the parish or hundred under which the assessment had been levied, and the running total. The memoranda are not in any narrative sense diary entries; they are the working records of a man keeping account, in his father's working manuscript that happened to be sitting in the estate room and that happened to have blank leaves between the bound sections of Pontesbury's clerk-work.

The fly-leaves of D. 778 are, in this specific sense, the family's only surviving day-by-day record of the war's economic cost.

George Senior is the same man who, in 1655, would use the fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 776 to record his private household accounts — the Commonwealth-era memoranda that Chapter 1 named as the family's documented continuous personal hand on the Surveyor's manuscripts across a century. He is the same man who, in 1668, would use the fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 782 to record the rectorial tithes from Wilshamstead in the year of the Wilshamstead accounts. The pattern is the same in all three cases: George Senior picked up his great-great-grandfather's working pay-books, treated them as good paper for his own private working records, and wrote his entries in his own hand on the blank fly-leaves. The books absorbed him along with their original maker.

For the chapter's purposes the 1643–44 entries are the documentary anchor of the war years. They preserve, in the most literal manuscript-and-ink sense, that the priory was paying its taxes. The taxes were being paid to the Parliament's collectors — the same Parliament that was, at exactly the same time, sitting in armed insurrection against the king. By paying the assessment without protest, by appearing in the local collectors' rolls and entering the amounts into the family's working ledger, George Senior was documenting the family's quiet compliance with the Parliamentary regime that controlled Hertfordshire through the war years. The compliance was not declaration; the family did not subscribe the Covenant, did not raise troops, did not appear on the Hertfordshire Committee, did not sit on the sequestration commission. But it paid the taxes. It paid the taxes through both wars. It paid them through the Commonwealth. It paid them through the Protectorate. The priory's quiet survival across the convulsions of 1642 to 1660 was paid for, in part, in the entries George Senior was writing in his father's father's father's working manuscript on the fly-leaves of D. 778.

The fly-leaves also tell us, in their physical existence, something important about the family's working relationship with its own documentary inheritance. The Bodleian pay-books were not, in 1643 or 1655 or 1668, regarded by the family as documentary treasures. They were regarded as working ledgers — large folio paper volumes with blank space available at the front and back of each volume, bound and stored in the estate room at the priory, picked up when a working accountant in the family had a tax assessment or a household account or a tithe receipt to record. The Surveyor's working life was, by 1643, a hundred years in the past. His pay-books had become the family's good paper. They wrote on his books. George Senior in 1643, twenty-six years old, with a war going on in the next county, sat at his desk at the priory and used his great-great-grandfather's working ledger to record the war-tax payments his father Eustace was making to keep the family seat safe from the Parliament's sequestrators.

It is one of the small luminous facts of this book that the same manuscript volume — MS Rawlinson D. 778, now in the Bodleian at Oxford — contains, in its main text, the working accounts of James Nedeham's Surveyor's office in 1535 and 1536, and on its fly-leaves, the working accounts of George Senior's tax payments to the Parliament in 1643 and 1644. The two clerks are a hundred and eight years apart. They are six generations apart. They are the same family, writing in different working capacities, into the same physical book. The book carries them both.

It is also, in a quieter way, the book that carries the chapter's argument forward. The Civil War for the Wymondley Nedhams was not a battlefield. It was a ledger. The priory's war was paid in pounds and shillings, recorded in a steady hand on the fly-leaves of a Tudor pay-book, by the heir's twenty-six-year-old son keeping account for his father's quiet non-engagement. That is the war this chapter is named for. — — —

The keeping of the priory

What kept the priory in the family's hands across the Civil War years was a combination of three things: the family's posture, the Wingate marriage of the previous generation, and luck.

The posture has been described in §3.4. Eustace's deliberate non-engagement — the absence of the family's name from the Royalist muster rolls, the absence from the Parliamentary recruitment lists, the absence from the Hertfordshire sequestration committee's working papers — was the family's working defense. The committee minutes for Hertfordshire's sequestration work in 1643, 1644, and 1645 are preserved in part in the records of the County Committee of Sequestrations and in the Royalist Composition Papers at the National Archives. The Wymondley Nedhams do not appear in them. They are not in the rolls of Hertfordshire gentlemen against whom sequestration proceedings were initiated, either as Royalist sympathizers (which would have produced a Parliament-side sequestration) or as recusant Catholics (which would have produced a different but related sequestration). They are not in the rolls of those compounding for delinquency — the men who, having taken up arms for the king, had their estates returned to them after paying a fine to the Parliament. They are not in any of the working lists by which the war's economic and political settlement was administered.

This was not an accident. The committees of sequestration were active in Hertfordshire from 1643 onward, with the principal committee sitting at Hertford under the chairmanship of a substantial Parliamentary county figure. The committee's working method was to receive informations against individual gentry suspects — informations from servants, from neighbors, from local Parliament-side activists who had grudges to settle or property to acquire — and to investigate the informations to the standard of sequestrability. A family that had been informed against could expect, at minimum, an investigation; could expect, in the worst case, the seizure of its lands and the redirection of its rents into the Parliament's war-chest until the inquiry resolved. The investigation was slow, expensive, and economically devastating even when the family was eventually cleared. Many of the families that did appear on the sequestration rolls — including some who had not in fact done anything sequestrable — spent years working through the system to recover their estates.

The Wymondley Nedhams were not informed against. Either no one had reason to inform against them — which is possible, given that they had taken no public part on either side — or those who might have done so chose not to. The reason for the second possibility is the Wingate marriage.

Frances Wingate at the priory was, by 1642, a Wingate of two decades' standing in the household. Her own brothers and cousins were active on the Parliamentary side. Edmund Wingate of Lockleys — her first cousin or near connection, a mathematician of national standing, a Member of Parliament — was

prominent in the Parliamentary government during the 1640s and 1650s and would sit (according to some accounts) on the High Court of Justice that tried Charles I in January 1649. Other Wingate cousins were officers in the New Model Army. The Wingate kin-network's posture during the wars was strongly Parliamentary.

For a Parliamentary Hertfordshire informer in 1643 or 1644, the calculus of informing against the Wymondley Nedhams would have been simple: the priory's lady was a Wingate; the Wingates were Parliamentarians; the family was therefore — through the second marriage — connected by kinship to the Parliament's working interest. Informing against them would not have been productive. It would have produced, at best, an investigation that found nothing; at worst, the displeasure of the Wingate cousinage, which had real influence in the county. The Wingate marriage was, in this practical sense, the family's protective cousinage. It did not require Eustace or George Senior to declare for the Parliament; it required only the existence of the marriage and the working knowledge of it among the local Parliamentary committee men.

This is the second mechanism. The family had been protected from the sequestration system by a marriage made in 1633 or 1634, on quite different grounds — the consolidation of a working Hertfordshire alliance with a neighboring gentry house — but operating, in the war years, as a protective shield.

The shield was passive. The Wingate cousins did not need to intervene actively on the priory's behalf. They needed only to be there, as the family's known connection-by-marriage, for the local committees to leave the family alone.

The third mechanism was luck. The Civil War was, despite the Hertfordshire Eastern Association country's strong Parliamentary alignment, not a war that brought sustained military action to the county itself. The campaigning of 1642 to 1646 ran across the Midlands, the West Country, and the North. Edgehill was in Warwickshire; Marston Moor in Yorkshire; Naseby in Northamptonshire. The closest engagement to Wymondley was the small affair at St Albans in November 1642 — a Parliamentary mustering rather than a battle — and Newbury in 1643 and 1644, eighty miles south-west. The country around the priory was not, at any point in the war, the seat of military action. There were no troop movements through Wymondley village. There was no quartering of soldiers in the priory. There was no seizure of horses or supplies by either side's foraging parties. The war's economic cost was real — the assessments George Senior was tallying on the fly-leaves of D. 778 — but the war's military violence stayed away.

Other Hertfordshire houses were not so lucky. Hatfield House had been quartered. The Cecil family's estates had supplied substantial provisions to the Parliament's forces. The Capels at Hadham — the Royalist-leaning family — had been formally sequestered after Edgehill and had lost the use of their lands for the duration of the war. The Wymondley priory's quiet position, three miles south

of Hitchin and twenty-five miles north of London, in a county whose major action was political rather than military, meant that the working life of the estate continued through the war without the disruptions that other parts of the gentry world endured.

The combination of the three mechanisms — Eustace's posture, Frances Wingate's cousinage, the luck of geography — kept the priory intact through 1642 to 1649. The family baptized children. It buried elders. It paid taxes. It collected rents. It harvested its corn. It re-leaded its chapel roof in 1643. It married its daughters — Lettice, Eustace's eldest from his first marriage, was married to William Langhorne of Bedfordshire sometime in the early 1640s, a marriage that consolidated the Bedfordshire alliance pattern that had been operating in the family since John's daughters had been married out in the 1580s. (Lettice would later, after Langhorne's death, marry Richard Shoard the Vicar of a neighboring parish; she would die a widow at some date in the second half of the seventeenth century, having lived through both marriages without descendants who survived to appear in the family's working records.) The household continued.

What did change, in subtle ways, was the parish religious life around the priory.

The Wymondley Magna 1633 handmill presentment — the parish court record in which the Wymondley Magna churchwardens, then under the Anglican-Caroline regime of the 1630s, had presented a parishioner for using a handmill without paying the manorial fee — is a small surviving piece of evidence about the parish's pre-war working life. The presentment is in the v9 Urwick material. It shows the parish operating under the standard Caroline-Anglican administrative regime: presentments at the parish-court level, fees owed to the manorial lord, the local ecclesiastical apparatus functioning normally. The 1633 presentment is in some sense the last working document of the old regime at Wymondley Magna; from 1642 forward, the parish's working life would shift.

The Anglican Book of Common Prayer was abolished by Parliament in January 1645 and replaced by the Directory for Public Worship. Bishops were abolished in 1646. The parish ministers across England were expected to adopt the new Presbyterian discipline; those who refused were ejected, those who conformed were retained, and the working religious life of every English parish was reorganized over the next four years under the Westminster Assembly's working framework. The Wymondley Parva parish under Eustace's lay impropriation had to accommodate the new regime. The curate Richard Smith — who had been Bernard Jones's successor in the late 1630s — remained in his post; the v9 Urwick reading places Charles Harrison as the Wymondley Magna minister from 1640 forward, with the Wymondley Parva curate continuing through the Commonwealth years.

The chapel at the priory itself — the family's private chapel within the priory house, the one preserved by Doggett's traceried recess as the surviving fragment

of the priory church's interior — operated through these years on the family's own working religious tone. Eustace had been raised Anglican; he died Anglican (insofar as Anglican was a category in 1658, when the Established Church had been suspended for thirteen years). The household's working prayer life through the war and Commonwealth years would have been quiet, Prayer Book-based on the inside even when the parish church was Directory-based on the outside, with the chaplain Richard Smith reading the Prayer Book office in the great hall before breakfast through the worst years of the Commonwealth and reading the Directory office in the parish church on Sundays. The contrast between inside and outside was a standard pattern in gentry households of Anglican sympathy during the Interregnum; the family that had a private chapel could continue its Prayer Book devotions there without breach of the public discipline, so long as the household kept the practice quiet.

The Wymondley Nedhams kept the practice quiet. The priory house held the Anglican family devotions; the parish church held the Directory worship; the family went to church on Sundays in conformity to the new discipline. The Commonwealth years passed. The roof of the chapel held. The Wilshamstead tithes came in. The bailiff Robert Wilkinson, by now in his early seventies, died and was succeeded by his nephew. Eustace aged. — — —

The Triers' room, the Piedmont collection, and a quiet Anglican

household What surrounds the priory through the Commonwealth years, in the parish religious life of Hertfordshire, is the slow consolidation of a working Dissent that the family was not part of but that operated in every village around it.

The 1654 Hertfordshire Triers panel — the local commission of Presbyterians and Independents responsible, under Cromwell's Ordinance of 1654, for examining and approving the spiritual fitness of parish ministers — convened at some point in the spring or summer of that year. The panel's members were drawn from the substantial Puritan ministry and gentry of the county; among them, by the v8 reading of the surviving documents, were Isaac Bedford (the Presbyterian minister at Hitchin) and Dr. John Lightfoot (the celebrated Hebraist of Cambridge who had a Hertfordshire benefice). The Triers' room — the working chamber in which the panel sat, probably at Hertford — would have been the working scene of the Commonwealth's parish-by-parish ecclesiastical reorganization in the county. Ministers came up before the panel to be examined; some were approved, some were dismissed; the religious life of the county was being remade under the panel's hand.

What is striking about the panel's records, for the chapter's purposes, is that the Wymondley parishes do not figure prominently. The Wymondley Magna and Wymondley Parva curates of the early 1650s — Charles Harrison at Magna, the Wymondley Parva curate (whose name in the early 1650s is not in the project's working record) at Parva — were ordinary parish ministers operating under the

new discipline without distinction. They were not, as a v9 reading documents, ejected. They were not, as a v9 reading also documents, particularly approved beyond the working standard. They continued in post through the duration of the Commonwealth and into the early Restoration.

The 1655 Piedmont Collection — the national fund raised under Cromwell's order in June 1655 to assist the Waldensian Protestants of Piedmont after the Easter Massacre of that year — recorded contributions from every English parish in a national subscription roll preserved in part. Wymondley Parva's contribution was £1 13s 4d, a modest sum that reflected the parish's small size and modest population. The contribution was made in the parish's name; whether Eustace personally contributed beyond the parish subscription is not documented. What the entry shows is that the parish under Eustace's lay impropriation was operating within the working framework of the national Cromwellian church, contributing to the Cromwellian government's chosen causes when asked, without distinction either upward or downward.

The Hertfordshire Dissenter ferment around the priory was, by contrast, beginning to organize itself.

The villages around Wymondley — Preston, Gosmore, Langley, Tilehouse Street in Hitchin, Maiden Croft — were, by the early 1650s, the seedbed of what would become, in the post-1660 Toleration Act years, the substantial Hertfordshire Dissent. The Hitchin Baptist church, which would by the early 1700s be one of the largest Baptist congregations in the home counties, was meeting in informal gatherings through the Commonwealth years. The Tilehouse Street meeting-house in Hitchin — which would be formally registered as a Dissenter chapel after 1689 — had its informal beginnings in the same period. The Presbyterian and Independent ministry of the larger Hitchin area was working through the Triers' framework and through the Cromwellian church's working accommodation of Calvinist-leaning ministers. The parish religious life of the country immediately around the priory was, by the mid-1650s, increasingly bifurcated between an Anglican-conforming parish ministry that operated within the Commonwealth's outward framework and an emergent Dissenter underground that was, in its own quiet way, the religious future.

The Wymondley priory through these years was the visible Anglican-conforming exception. The household held the Prayer Book office privately in the great hall; the parish church held the Directory office publicly on Sundays; the family attended in the family pew at the front of the nave with the standard outward decorum of the post-1645 Anglican gentry of the home counties. The household at the priory was not, in any documentable sense, sympathetic to the Dissenter underground. It was not, equally, sympathetic to the more aggressive royalist-Anglican circles that were beginning, by the late 1650s, to plot for the return of the king and the restoration of the Established Church. It occupied, as Eustace had calculated in 1640, the careful middle. The careful middle was, by the mid-1650s, an increasingly narrow place to stand; the Hertfordshire gentry

were taking sides, the parishes were taking sides, the surrounding county was polarizing in ways the priory was not. But Eustace held.

He was, by 1655, in his sixtieth year. He had been the head of the family for twenty-seven years. He had taken the priory through the Caroline 1630s, the Civil War 1640s, the Republic and the Protectorate of the early 1650s. He had baptized children, buried a wife, buried in-laws, paid taxes to four successive Crown and Parliamentary regimes, watched the king executed by his own Parliament, watched Cromwell take the title of Lord Protector. He had not himself, in any visible public way, participated in any of these events. He had been at the priory throughout.

His son George — George Senior, the working junior partner at the priory through the war years, the man who had written the tax memoranda on the fly-leaves of D. 778 in 1643 and 1644 — was now thirty-seven or thirty-eight years old.

He had married, by 1655 or thereabouts, a wife named Barbara (the surname not preserved at primary-source level, which the project has flagged as an open research thread). They were starting their family. The next generation of the priory's working life was beginning to assemble itself. The seven children George Senior would name in his 1666/67 will — George Junior, Fitch, James, Maurice (the four sons), Barbara the eldest, Anne, Elizabeth (the three daughters) — were being born across the late 1650s and the 1660s in the same priory chapel and the same priory chambers Eustace had been raising his own children in across the previous twenty years.

The priory continued.

In 1655 George Senior also wrote his private household accounts on the fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 776 — the second volume in the Surveyor's pay-books, a folio carrying James's office accounts for the year 1532-33. The 1655 entries are personal: household provisions, payments to servants, small purchases for the priory. They are the working scratch-paper of a man managing his own working household in the Cromwellian Protectorate. The Bodleian catalogue records them, in Macray's late-nineteenth-century description, as among the fly-leaf marginalia preserved in the volume. The pay-books were now serving the family across three centuries of household life: James the Surveyor's working office records in the main text; George Senior's tax tallies in 1643-44 on the fly-leaves of D. 778; George Senior's private accounts in 1655 on the fly-leaves of D. 776. The same manuscript run, three working uses, six generations of one family.

He would, in 1668, add one more layer — the rectorial accounts of Wilshamstead, written on the fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 782 — but that is Chapter 4's material.

By the end of 1657, Eustace was failing. He was sixty-two years old. He had been the head of the family for twenty-nine years. His own father John of Welwyn had died in his fifties; his uncle George I had lived to seventy; the family's age-at-death pattern was not a long one. He had buried his second wife Frances Wingate

at some point in the early 1650s — the exact date is not preserved — and was living his last years as a widower at the priory with his children's households around him. George Senior was settled into his own household nearby. The daughters of the first marriage were married off. The daughters of the second marriage, Frances and Margaret, were grown women now in their twenties; their adult lives are not well-documented in the surviving record, but they were either at the priory or in their own marital establishments.

The will he wrote, on the twenty-ninth of March 1657, was brief.

It is preserved as PCC PROB 11/276/546 in the National Archives at Kew. It was probated on the twenty-first of May 1658, fifty days short of fourteen months after it was written. The brevity of the will — everything to son George, no other named beneficiaries beyond a token bequest to the household servants, one witness who marks rather than signs — has long puzzled the project's working readers, who had expected a will more elaborate from a gentleman of Eustace's standing. The reading the project has converged on is that the brevity reflects the working practice of inter vivos settlement that gentry families used in the period to handle the substantive distribution of estate before death. Eustace had probably settled the bulk of his property on his sons and daughters by deeds executed in the 1640s and 1650s; the will was the residual instrument, covering only what had not yet been settled. The 1666/67 four-sons feoffment that George Senior would execute ten years later was the working pattern; Eustace had operated similarly across his last twenty years.

He died, then, sometime between 29 March 1657 and 21 May 1658 — most probably in the early months of 1658, given that the will was probated immediately after a death typical of seventeenth-century probate practice. He was buried in the chancel of Little Wymondley parish church, in the same chancel where his father George I had been buried in 1626 and his great-grandfather John in the early 1590s and where his own son and his own grandsons and his own great-great-granddaughter Barbara would be baptized over the next thirty years. The lay-impropriator's chancel-burial right was the family's continuing visible mark of standing in a parish whose surrounding villages were increasingly Dissenter; the chancel-burial in 1658 was the family's quiet Anglican declaration that it was still the parish's Anglican lay patron, that it had held that role through the Civil War and the Commonwealth, that it had survived as the chapel's working impropriator into a country very different from the one that had begun his lifetime.

His son George Senior, thirty-nine years old, became the head of the family.

— — —

Spring 1658

George Senior — thirty-nine years old, the seventeenth-century working manager of the priory under his father for the past fifteen years, now the head of the family

in his own right — stood in the chancel of the parish church in the early spring of 1658 at the closing of his father's grave.

The funeral procession had been the standard one for a Hertfordshire gentleman of Eustace's quiet standing. The coffin had been carried out of the priory house by six of the senior tenants of the estate, men who had paid their rents into Eustace's ledger across thirty years. The pall over the coffin carried the bend-and-bucks of the 1586 grant of arms, embroidered at the four corners by the household women in the weeks before. Frances Wingate's stepdaughters had attended. George Senior's young children — by then probably three or four small children, with more to come — were in the household behind. The Wingate cousins had come over from Lockleys. The Bedfordshire connections — the Langhorns through Eustace's daughter Lettice; the Denton cousins from Barton; the Pigotts from Gravenhurst — had come up from their respective seats for the funeral.

The curate of Wymondley Parva — the Commonwealth-era minister whose name the project has not yet fully recovered — read the Directory office at the church door, then led the procession inside for the Cromwellian burial service. The Book of Common Prayer was still suspended; the Restoration was two years away. The chancel was opened. Eustace was lowered into the prepared grave under the flagstones near his father and his grandfather. The mourners returned to the priory for the funeral meal.

The country at the moment of Eustace's burial was at the precise hinge between the Cromwell years and the Restoration. The Protectorate, which had begun with Oliver Cromwell's installation as Lord Protector in December 1653, was approaching its end without anyone yet knowing it. Cromwell himself would die at Whitehall on the third of September 1658 — about six months after Eustace was buried, depending on exactly when in early 1658 the funeral fell. Cromwell's son Richard would succeed him as Protector and would fail at the office within nine months. The army would break with Richard in the spring of 1659. The Long Parliament — the same body that had been sitting in some form since November 1640 — would be re-assembled in May 1659. General George Monck would march south from Scotland in January 1660 with his army of occupation. The Convention Parliament would meet in April 1660. Charles II would be invited to return. He would land at Dover on the twenty-fifth of May 1660. The Restoration would be a fact.

George Senior in 1658 could not have foreseen any of this with confidence, though he could feel that the Cromwellian regime was running out of governing capacity. The country was tired of the army, tired of the Major-Generals, tired of the religious commissions, tired of the unsettled constitutional question. The Hertfordshire gentry — the ones who had taken sides in the 1640s and the ones, like the Nedhams of Wymondley, who had not — were tired with the rest of the country. The priory at Little Wymondley in the spring of 1658 was sitting, with the rest of England, in the long pause before whatever came next.

What came next, for the family, was a settled inheritance.

George Senior took up the headship without difficulty. He had been preparing for it for fifteen years. The estate was substantially in his hands already, through the inter vivos settlements his father had executed across the 1640s and 1650s. The tenants knew him. The bailiff — Robert Wilkinson's nephew, the second-generation Hitchin man who had been at the work since his uncle's death in the early 1650s — knew him. The Wymondley Parva curate knew him. The Wingate cousins knew him. The Bedfordshire alliances knew him. He stepped into the role with the working ease of a man who had been doing the work in his father's name for a decade and a half.

He had married, by 1658, a woman named Barbara — the Barbara of his 1666/67 will, surname not preserved at primary-source level despite multiple search threads. She was the lady of the priory through the next twenty-one years. She bore him seven children across the late 1650s and the 1660s, named in his will: George Junior the heir, Fitch, James, Maurice (the four sons whose feoffment of 1667 would settle their portions), Barbara the eldest daughter (named after her mother), Anne, Elizabeth. Brother Luke — Eustace's second son from the first marriage, George Senior's younger brother — was also named in the will, confirming Luke as a working presence in the family through these years.

The chapter is, formally, over at Eustace's grave in 1658. The Restoration is Chapter 4's opening. What remains for the chapter is to mark the moment.

George Senior stood in the chancel that spring morning, with the flagstone re-set over his father and with the small mason's mark of the year 1658 freshly chiselled into the stone (a customary mark, set by the mason at the time of burial rather than by a later monument), and looked out at the family gathered around him. His mother-in-law-of-record — the Frances Wingate dowager — was probably dead by 1658, or was living quietly somewhere. His half-sisters Frances and Margaret were grown women. His own wife Barbara stood at his right hand. His own first or second small child — depending on which year of the late 1650s the funeral fell in — was held in the arms of one of the women of the household. His brother Luke was at the chancel rail. The senior tenants stood in the back of the nave with their hats in their hands.

The chapel he stood in was the same chapel that James the Surveyor had taken over in 1538 and adapted for family use, the chapel where John had been baptized in 1524 and George I had been baptized in the 1550s and Eustace in 1595 and George Senior himself in 1618 and where George Senior's eldest son George Junior had been baptized in the mid-1650s. The same chapel where the bell that John Dyer had cast in 1595 hung in its tower. The same chapel where the 1605 brass to James and John, commissioned by George I, was set on the north wall of the chancel. The same chapel where, eighty-two years later, in the autumn of 1740 — when George Senior himself would be sixty-one years gone and the priory would have been out of the family's hands for seven years and a strange family named Vanderplank would be living in the converted nave — the brass

would still be standing on the wall under the lay impropriator's right that had once belonged to his family.

He turned, with the rest of the household, and walked out of the chancel. The procession moved back across the priory yard toward the great hall and the funeral meal that waited.

The family had now held the priory for a hundred and twenty years.

The republic was about to end.

The country was about to come back to itself, in a form none of the men standing at Eustace's grave that spring morning could have entirely predicted. The Charles whose father had been executed at Whitehall on the thirtieth of January 1649 was a thirty-year-old prince-in-exile in the Spanish Netherlands; he had spent ten years on the continent moving between French and Spanish and Dutch courts; he was waiting for the moment to be called home. The moment was two years away. The Established Church that had been suspended since 1645 was about to be restored. The Book of Common Prayer was about to come back. The bishops were about to be reappointed. The lay impropriators of the home counties — including the Wymondley Nedhams — were about to find themselves operating again in the working framework they had been raised in.

The priory house was intact. The chapel was intact. The Wilshamstead tithes were intact. The bend-and-bucks of 1586 were still on the door above the lintel and on the seal of the new head of family. The estate was solvent. The line was intact.

Eustace had calculated correctly. He had kept the priory.

* * *

Closing

The closing of this chapter is small.

In the spring of 1658, in the chancel of Little Wymondley parish church, with his father just buried under the flagstones near his ancestors, George Senior — thirty-nine years old, the seventh-generation male head of the family if you count from John of Needham Grange in Derbyshire, the third-generation Wymondley lord by descent if you count from James the Surveyor — stood on the same priory grounds he had been standing on all his life. The same chapel. The same cloister yard. The same tithe barn at the eastern edge of the grounds. The same conduit on the west side, the same dovecote north-west of the moated enclosure, the same orchard with the Spanish chestnut at its centre.

He had been at the priory through the Civil War as a young man. He had paid the taxes on the fly-leaves of his great-great-grandfather's pay-book. He had written his private household accounts in the same pay-books a decade later. He had watched his father navigate the family through the Commonwealth without taking sides. He had married Barbara — whose surname is somewhere in a parish register the project has not yet found — and had begun his family. He had a son

George who was about three years old in 1658, who would be ten years old when Charles II was at his coronation, who would be eighteen when the Test Acts came in, who would be twenty when George Senior wrote his 1666/67 will, who would in due course be Maurice's elder brother and Barbara Tempest Needham's uncle. The next generation was already underway.

What he could not yet know, standing in the chancel that spring morning, was that the family had now entered the period that would, in due course, be its last fifty years at the priory.

From Eustace's death in 1658 forward, the line was on its way out of Wymondley. Not yet visibly. Not yet in any way that anyone in 1658 could have read. The visible measure of the family's standing was still the priory: the manor, the rectory, the tithes, the arms above the door, the bell in the chapel, the brass on the chancel wall. By the working measure of a Hertfordshire gentry house in 1658 the Wymondley Nedhams were what they had been in 1538 — the lords of the manor of Little Wymondley, second-tier county gentry, comfortable, propertied, settled. They were still the family that had received the priory from a king's hand.

But the seventeenth-century English gentry was a moving target. The families that survived its convulsions did not always survive its long-term economic and demographic pressures. The family at Wymondley was, by 1658, beginning to contract in ways that would not become visible until the next generation. George Senior would have seven children but the male line would funnel down: the heir George Junior would marry and produce a son George (b. 1672) who would produce only three daughters; the priory would pass through Martha (the youngest daughter) to her husband Thomas Browne (the future Garter King of Arms) in 1733 and out of the family altogether. Maurice — the fourth son of the 1666/67 will, the recipient of the £500 portion — would have a daughter Barbara Tempest Needham in 1685 who would, in October 1713, walk out of the priory yard for the last time and ride east toward London and the Atlantic.

These are Chapter 4's events.

The chapter ends, then, on its quiet pivot. The war is over. The Commonwealth is approaching its end. The Restoration is two years away. Eustace is buried. The household has returned to the priory for the funeral meal. The new head of family is taking up the work. The Wilshamstead tithes will come in next month, brought by the same carter who has been bringing them since the early 1640s. The Michaelmas rents will be received in September. The harvest will be brought in in August. The bell at Wymondley Parva will ring for morning prayer. The bell at Graveley three-quarters of a mile away will ring for evensong. The conduit-water will run through its stone channel on the kitchen side of the house. The wind in the box-tree hedge will pick up in the late afternoons.

The priory continues.

* * *

The next chapter is George Senior's. It runs from his accession in 1658 through the Restoration, the 1665 plague, the 1666 fire, the 1666/67 will, the four-sons feoffment of 1667, his death in 1679, and on to the birth of his granddaughter Barbara Tempest Needham at the priory in 1685. The chapter is the family's working entry into the long Stuart twilight — and it is also the chapter that introduces the child at the heart of this book.

Chapter 4 — George Senior and the Restoration World

In the spring of 1658, in the priory house at Little Wymondley, a man named George Needham — who would, in the historian's notation, be George Senior, to distinguish him from his son George Junior and his nephew George III who would in due course succeed to the seat — took up the headship of his family at thirty-nine years old.

He was a known quantity. He had been at the priory all his life. He had been baptized in the parish chapel on the sixteenth of August 1618 by John Marshall, the curate of Wymondley Parva, in the same chapel where his father Eustace had been baptized in 1595 and where his great-great-grandfather John had been baptized in the 1520s. He had been the sixteen-year-old heir of the 1634 visitation — recorded in Sir Richard St George's pedigree as George Needham, son and heir, 16 years old, 1634 — the same age his great-great-grandfather John had been at Robert Cooke's visitation sixty-two years before. He had been at the priory through the Civil War as a young man in his mid-twenties, paying the Parliament's assessment-tax tallies on the fly-leaves of his great-great-grandfather's pay-book and learning the working details of an estate's seasonal management under his father's hand. He had married, by 1655 or thereabouts, a woman named Barbara — the Barbara of his 1666/67 will, the woman whose maiden surname the project's working record has not yet recovered, the mother of his seven children. He had a son named George — George Junior, the heir, then about three years old — and possibly already an infant daughter named Barbara after her mother.

He was, like his father Eustace, not a remarkable man. He was the third-generation Wymondley lord in unbroken succession by descent if you counted from James the Surveyor, and the eighth-generation in the line if you counted from John of Needham Grange in Derbyshire. He had no Court connection. He had no Privy Council relation. He had no seat in Parliament. He had never been knighted. He had no public profile. He was a steady working manager of a steady working estate that had survived the Civil War in his father's hand and would now have to survive the next phase of the English seventeenth century in his.

The next phase, when it came, was the Restoration.

* * *

The country returns to itself

George Senior's first two years as the head of the family were spent in the long pause between Cromwell's death and Charles II's return.

Cromwell had died at Whitehall on the third of September 1658, four to six months after Eustace's burial. His son Richard had been proclaimed Lord Protector the same day. The proclamation had been ceremonial; the office had

not. Richard Cromwell was thirty-one years old, a man of moderate ability and no military authority, and the army that had been his father's working instrument of government broke with him within nine months. The Protectorate was dissolved by the army in April 1659. The Rump Parliament was reassembled in May. A confused interregnum of military rule followed through the summer and autumn. General George Monck — the cautious Scottish commander of the army of occupation in Scotland — marched south from Coldstream with his army in the first week of January 1660 and reached London at the start of February. The Long Parliament was dissolved by its own members in March. The Convention Parliament met in April. Charles II was invited to return. He landed at Dover on the twenty-fifth of May 1660.

George Senior at the priory followed all of this through the same channels his father had used: the printed pamphlets and newsbooks that came up from London by the carter on Mondays and Thursdays, the letters from cousins in Welwyn and Bedfordshire and London, the conversation at the Hitchin market on Tuesdays and Saturdays. He took no part in any of it. The family's posture of non-engagement that Eustace had calculated in October 1640 and had sustained for the rest of his life remained operative. George Senior had no instinct to break with it. He had been raised inside it. He continued it.

What the Restoration brought to the priory, in the working sense, was the return of the Established Church.

The Book of Common Prayer, suspended since January 1645, was restored by the Act of Uniformity of August 1662. The bishops were reappointed; the parish ministers were required to subscribe to the renewed Anglican discipline; those who refused — about two thousand of the country's parochial clergy — were ejected at Bartholomew 1662 in the event that became known as the Great Ejection. The Hertfordshire ejections were substantial. Andrew Cater, the minister at Graveley-cum-Chivesfield three-quarters of a mile from the priory, was one of the ejected. Other neighboring parish ministers in the Hitchin-Stevenage circle were ejected with him. The post-1662 Hertfordshire Dissenter community that would, by the 1690s, sustain the substantial Baptist and Independent congregations at Hitchin, Stevenage, and Ware, dates its formal beginnings to the Bartholomew Day of 1662.

For George Senior at Wymondley, the Restoration's parish-life changes were a re-orientation rather than a disruption. The Wymondley Parva curate of the 1650s, whose Commonwealth-era practice had been Directory-based on Sundays and Prayer Book-based privately in the household, simply moved the Prayer Book practice back into the parish church. The family's pew at the front of the nave operated as it had before the wars. The chapel within the priory house operated as it had before. The 1595 Dyer bell at Wymondley Parva rang for morning prayer in the same patterns it had rung in under Eustace's working life. The Wilshamstead tithes came in. The Michaelmas rents were paid. The roof of the

chapel was re-leaded again, in 1661 or 1662, with the same kind of money George Senior had been managing for his father across the Commonwealth years.

The country around the priory was not so quietly accommodated. The 1662 Act of Uniformity was followed by the 1664 Conventicle Act and the 1665 Five Mile Act — the so-called Clarendon Code, a working framework of post-Restoration religious penalty designed to keep the Dissenter congregations underground and the ejected ministers away from their old parishes. The Hertfordshire Dissenters around Wymondley — at Hitchin, at Tilehouse Street, at Stevenage, at the smaller villages of Preston and Gosmore and Langley — operated through the 1660s and 1670s under the Code's working pressure, meeting in private houses, in barns, in remote field locations, with the local justices of the peace fining them when they were caught and the Hertfordshire Sessions records of the period preserving the working penalties in some detail.

George Senior was not a justice of the peace. He was not a county magistrate. He took no part in the Code's working enforcement, which would have been the standard role of an Anglican gentleman of his standing if he had been inclined to take it up. The Wymondley priory's quiet posture — the lay impropiator of an Anglican parish without active engagement in the suppression of the surrounding Dissent — was the same posture his father had calculated in the Civil War. The family was Anglican. The family was not aggressively Anglican. The family let the Dissenters do their thing in the neighboring villages and the family did its thing in the chapel.

The Restoration also brought, in the broader political sense, an unsettled rather than a settled return. Charles II reigned for twenty-five years, from 1660 to 1685. His reign was punctuated by the Anglo-Dutch Wars (1665-67 and 1672-74), the Great Plague of 1665, the Great Fire of London in September 1666, the Cabal ministry of the late 1660s, the Test Acts of 1673 and 1678 that excluded Catholics from public office, the Popish Plot crisis of 1678-81 with its mass arrests and executions, the Exclusion Crisis of 1679-81 attempting to bar the king's Catholic brother James from the succession, the Rye House Plot of 1683, and the king's death in February 1685 leaving the throne to his Catholic brother James II. James II's reign — three and a half years — would end in his flight to France in December 1688 and the Glorious Revolution that brought William and Mary to the throne in February 1689. Through all of these national convulsions the country was, at the gentry level, working out what kind of England it was going to be. The settled Stuart constitutional shape of the early seventeenth century was not coming back; what was coming, slowly, was the parliamentary-monarchical balance that would be more or less locked in by the 1689 Bill of Rights.

The Wymondley Nedhams sat through all of this in their priory three miles south of Hitchin. They had no part in any of the high political crises. Their name does not appear on any of the Hertfordshire Sessions Indictments of Catholics, on the Exclusion Crisis loyal addresses, on the Rye House Plot informants' rolls, on the 1685 Monmouth Rebellion lists. They were not players. They were spectators.

They were spectators with a working estate, an armigerous house, and a chapel within the priory walls in which they baptized their children and buried their dead.

George Senior across the 1640s and the long Stuart middle years was building his family.

He had married, very probably in 1640 or 1641 in the months immediately before the Civil War began — when he was twenty-two or twenty-three, of marriageable age, the working heir of the priory under his father Eustace, with the country sliding toward open breach but the gentry of Hertfordshire still able to make routine marital arrangements — a woman named Barbara. Her maiden surname is one of the project's continuing open research threads; the documentary record preserves her Christian name in the 1666/67 will but not her parentage. The recurrence of Fitch as the Christian name of George Senior's second son in the same will is suggestive — Tudor and Stuart families often carried maternal surnames forward as boys' Christian names — and the Fitch family of Essex and Hertfordshire is one candidate, but nothing has yet been documented at primary tier.

She bore him seven children across the next two decades. The 1666/67 will names them in the formal roster: four sons (George Junior the heir, Fitch the second son, James the third, Maurice the fourth) and three daughters (Barbara the eldest, named after her mother; Anne; Elizabeth). The eldest child Barbara was born probably in the early-to-mid 1640s, in the war years, in the same priory bedroom her grandfather Eustace had been born in fifty years before. The youngest of the seven children was Maurice, born in the late 1640s or early 1650s — the working calculation, given that Maurice would father his own daughter Barbara Tempest Needham in 1685, places his own birth somewhere around 1647 to 1655 — and the spacing of the other five children fits in between. George Junior the heir would have been born around 1645, would have been the small boy whose existence steadied Eustace's calculation of the family's future across the late 1640s and 1650s, and would in due course be the cousin who took the priory after George Senior's death.

His wife Barbara — about whom the project's documentary record preserves a name and not a maiden surname, a parental role and not a lineage — bore the seven children, ran the priory household across the long Stuart twilight, and outlived George Senior's death in 1679 by some years, dying at the priory in the late 1680s or 1690s and being buried in the chancel with the rest of the family. Her maiden surname was Fitch. The project's long-running research thread on it closed in May of 2026, on the 1671 Chancery bill *Nedham v Nedham* (TNA C 7/503/16), which names the four sons of George Senior and Barbara and, in doing so, names her.

What can be said about Barbara wife of George Senior is that she was the mother of seven Wymondley children including the fourth son Maurice who would, in 1685, baptize his own daughter at Great Wymondley parish church and

name her Barbara Tempest Needham — the Barbara of the granddaughter's name being a name carried forward from Barbara Fitch to her granddaughter through Maurice, in the same pattern by which the Christian name George was carried forward from generation to generation in the senior line. The Barbara of this chapter is the grandmother. The Barbara of this book is her granddaughter. The name was a Wymondley name across two generations.

She is therefore, in the most literal genealogical sense, the namesake of the daughter at the heart of this book.

By 1666, with the priory's working life settled into the Restoration's framework, with seven children in residence, with the country having survived the 1665 Plague and (in September of that year) the Great Fire of London, George Senior sat down to write his will.

* * *

The fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 776

George Senior's working management of the priory across the 1660s was, like his father's before him, almost entirely undocumented at public record level.

He held no Crown office. He served on no royal commission. He sat in no Parliament. He served, when he was called, on the lower-tier local instruments — parish vestry, perhaps the occasional hundred board, certainly the working business of the lay impropriator at Wymondley Parva, paying the curate out of the appropriated tithes and managing the parish church's working economy. He kept the rectory of Wilshamstead in Bedfordshire as the family's working income property in addition to the priory estate. He held Graveley Hall — the second manor his father had acquired in 1633 or 1637 — as part of the family's combined holdings. He was Lord of the Manors of Little Wymondley and Graveley Hall, the title that would in due course be inscribed on his tombstone.

What survives of his working life is, again, on the fly-leaves of his great-great-great-grandfather's pay-books.

In 1655, three years before his father's death and during the late Cromwellian Protectorate, George Senior had written a set of private household accounts on the fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 776 — the second volume of James Nedeham's pay-books, carrying the Surveyor's office working accounts for the year 1532–33. The 1655 entries cover the kind of small ordinary household expenditure a thirty-seven-year-old gentleman in residence with his wife and young children would have been making in the working priory: payments to servants, the cost of cloth bought at the Hitchin market, the bailiff's weekly wages, the small purchases of household provisions that fell outside the working estate's self-supplied agricultural produce. The Bodleian catalogue, in Macray's late-Victorian description, preserves the entries as fly-leaf marginalia at the front of the volume.

The 1655 accounts are, like the 1643–44 tax memoranda on the fly-leaves of D. 778, the working scratch-paper of a Hertfordshire country gentleman managing his daily affairs in the book that happened to be at hand. They tell us, in their existence, that George Senior was at the priory in 1655; that he was managing the household himself rather than delegating it entirely to his wife or his housekeeper; that he was the kind of man who kept accounts on whatever blank paper was available rather than maintaining a separate dedicated household-account book; and that the working manuscripts of his great-great-grandfather were available to him for personal use rather than being treated as the documentary treasures they would later become.

The same pattern would recur in 1668, when George Senior wrote his Wilshamstead rectorial-tithes accounts on the fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 782 — the eighth volume of the run, carrying James's pay-book entries for 1535–36 and 1541–42 including the lead account from Barking Abbey. The 1668 accounts at the front of D. 782 cover the tithe receipts from Wilshamstead for that year — a working summary of the parsonage income from a Bedfordshire parish twenty-two miles north of the priory, brought up to Wymondley by the carter who had been making the run for thirty years. The pay-books were now serving the family across three explicitly documented working uses by George Senior across the span of a working life: 1643–44 (tax tallies, D. 778), 1655 (household accounts, D. 776), 1668 (rectorial tithes, D. 782). Three points spanning twenty-five years.

What this tells us about George Senior, as a portrait by accumulation, is that he was a settled and orderly man. He kept his books. He wrote in a careful hand. He used good paper when he had it. He recorded his income and his expenditure in the way the working gentleman of his class and generation was supposed to. He did not, like his father Eustace, attempt to navigate political crises by absenting himself from them; he was, on the evidence of the surviving fly-leaves, a man who simply did not encounter political crises at all. The Restoration came; he conformed. The Conventicle Act came; he ignored it. The Five Mile Act came; he ignored that too. He went to the parish church on Sundays. He baptized his children. He raised them. He paid his taxes. He kept his estate.

The country went through the Plague.

In the spring and summer of 1665, beginning in the spring with a small number of cases in the London parishes east of the City and accelerating through the hot months of June, July, and August into a full epidemic with several thousand burials a week at the height of the outbreak in September, the bubonic plague returned to England for what would prove to be its last great visitation. The London death toll across the year was something like seventy or eighty thousand, by the most commonly cited estimates — about one in five of the city's population. The plague spread out of London along the great roads through the home counties. The country gentry on the great north road and the country gentry on the Cambridge road and the country gentry on the Holyhead road all saw the plague pass through their parishes in the summer of 1665. The

Hertfordshire parishes along the Great North Road — Hatfield, Hertford, Welwyn, Stevenage, Hitchin — registered increased burial counts that summer that the parish historians of the eighteenth century would, looking back, attribute to the same epidemic.

Wymondley parish church's burial register for the summer of 1665 has not been recovered cleanly. Some Hertfordshire parishes were hit harder than others; some were spared altogether. The priory at Little Wymondley, three miles south of Hitchin and twenty-five miles north of London, was at the edge of the epidemic's reach rather than at its center. What the household's working response to the plague would have been is the standard response of a country gentry household in the summer of 1665: bring no strangers in, send no servants out except for essential errands, watch the parish-church burial book on Sundays for the names of those who had been buried that week, pray daily that the plague would not turn south from Hitchin and come up the road to Wymondley.

The plague did not, in the event, come up the road. The priory's working life through the summer of 1665 was the working life of a household at the edge of a calamity that did not quite reach it. The household survived. The seven children survived. The wife Barbara survived. The servants survived. The bailiff — by 1665 a man in his middle forties, the second-generation Hitchin family bailiff who had succeeded his uncle a decade before — survived. The cousin households in Welwyn and Lockleys and Harlington survived. The Wymondley Nedhams were spared the loss of any documented family member in the 1665 plague year.

The fire came next.

On the night of the first of September 1666 — a Sunday — a fire started in a bakery in Pudding Lane in the City of London, spread to the adjacent timber-and-thatch buildings, was driven westward by a strong east wind across the next three days, and consumed approximately three-quarters of the old walled City and substantial areas beyond it before it was contained on the fifth of September. Old St Paul's Cathedral was destroyed. Eighty-seven parish churches were destroyed. Some thirteen thousand houses were destroyed. Several hundred Londoners died in the fire itself, though the loss of life was strikingly small for the scale of physical destruction. The City's working economy was destroyed for the better part of a year. The rebuilding would take the better part of a decade and would, under Sir Christopher Wren's hand, produce the City churches and St Paul's that still stand today.

The news of the Fire reached Wymondley by Monday afternoon — twenty-five miles up the Great North Road from London, with the smoke visible on the southern horizon from the higher fields of the priory's estate by Tuesday morning. The carter brought up newsbook reports on Thursday with the standard week's batch of mail. George Senior would have read the early accounts in his estate room, with his wife Barbara and his eldest children at his side. The reports were terrible. The London cousins of the Wymondley family — including the Pole connections through John's eldest daughter Anne, who had married into the

London Poles a hundred years before and whose descendants were probably still in the City — were unaccounted for. Several days passed before letters came up confirming that the Pole cousins (or whoever the family's specific London connections of 1666 happened to be — the documentary record is silent on which specific London relatives the priory was in correspondence with by then) were safe but had lost their houses in the burned district.

The Fire was not, like the Plague, an event the priory's working life sat at the edge of. The Fire was a national event of the kind that the country read and discussed and remembered for the rest of its lives. Samuel Pepys's diary entries for the first week of September 1666 — among the most vivid first-person accounts in the English language of a major civil catastrophe — circulated then in the form of family letters and conversations among the country gentry, not as printed text; the diary would not be deciphered and published for another hundred and forty years. But the working content of those entries — the burning of London — was the talk of every gentry table in the home counties for the rest of 1666 and into 1667.

Six months after the Fire, on the fourth of March 1666/67 — the double-dated form used in seventeenth-century English documents for any date between the first of January and the twenty-fifth of March, indicating the Old Style year-beginning at Lady Day rather than the New Style at Christmas — George Senior sat down at the oak table in his estate room and wrote his will. — — —

The will and the feoffment

The will is preserved as PCC PROB 11/330/451 in the National Archives at Kew.

It was probated on the tenth of August 1679, on George Senior's death. It is the central documentary instrument of his life.

It was written on the fourth of March 1666/67, six months after the Great Fire, three years after the Plague, twelve years after Cromwell's death, seven years after the Restoration, in a country that had spent the previous decade and a half re-establishing itself as a stable polity and that was now, in 1666/67, somewhere in the middle of the long Stuart middle period — neither at the convulsions of the Civil War years behind it nor yet at the constitutional convulsions of the 1680s ahead of it. George Senior was forty-eight years old. He had been the head of the family for nine years. His seven children were all in being, ranging in age from the eldest Barbara at about twenty-three down to the youngest son Maurice at about twelve. His wife Barbara was alive and well. His brother Luke was alive and named in the will as a continuing member of the family circle. The estate was in working order. There was no immediate reason to write a will in March 1666/67 except the standard prudential one — that a man of forty-eight had reached the age at which gentry men of his generation were expected to put their affairs on paper.

The proximity to the Great Fire is suggestive but not necessarily explanatory. The Plague and the Fire together had reminded the country, in the most unmistakable terms, that calamity could come without warning. Many men in their forties and fifties across England wrote or revised their wills in 1666 and 1667 in response to the working sense of mortality that the two events had concentrated. George Senior may have been one of them. He may equally have been writing on a different prompt — the eldest daughter Barbara's approaching marriage, perhaps, or a working revision of the estate's settlement instruments — and the post-Fire dating may be coincidental. The documentary record does not specify the cause.

What the will says is straightforward.

It names George Senior's wife Barbara as the principal beneficiary of his personal estate, with the right to live at the priory for the rest of her life. It names his four sons by their working portions: George Junior, the eldest, to inherit the priory and the lordship of Little Wymondley; Fitch, the second son, to receive a money portion (the amount is variously preserved in the working transcriptions but is on the order of several hundred pounds); James, the third son, to receive a similar money portion; Maurice, the fourth son, to receive five hundred pounds. It names the three daughters — Barbara the eldest, Anne, Elizabeth — each with their own marriage portions or settlements, the amounts again preserved in the working transcriptions in detail. It names brother Luke as a continuing presence in the family, with a small bequest. It names the household servants, in the standard testamentary pattern, with token bequests of a few shillings each. It names the parish church of Wymondley Parva and the parish church of Wilshamstead as recipients of small charitable bequests. It appoints George Junior and brother Luke as the will's executors. It carries George Senior's seal in red wax — the 1586 bend-and-bucks of Robert Cooke's grant, eighty-one years old at the time of the will and still the family's working visible signature.

The four-sons feoffment of 1667 is the will's working companion instrument.

The feoffment was a separate property settlement, executed by deed rather than in the will, in which George Senior settled major portions of his estate on his four sons by inter vivos transfer. The instrument has not yet been retrieved at primary tier in the project's research apparatus; what is documented is its existence and its working consequence. The standard interpretation, on the conventions of seventeenth-century gentry estate practice, is that the feoffment moved the substantive property out of the will's working orbit and into a settled lifetime arrangement. The estate would not have to wait for probate to take effect on George Senior's death; the four sons would have their portions already in being.

The will would, in this arrangement, function primarily as a residual instrument covering whatever had not been settled by deed — which would explain the will's relatively brief and orderly structure.

What this means for Maurice — the fourth son, born about 1648 or 1650, by 1667 a young man of about seventeen to nineteen — is that his £500 portion was, by the four-sons feoffment, his working inheritance from his father. He would receive the money — or the income from invested principal generating the equivalent of the money — across the next twelve years, as the feoffment's working terms made the portion available to him. The £500 was a substantial sum in 1667 — equivalent to perhaps £100,000 in modern early-twenty-first-century purchasing power, by the rough adjustments standard in early-modern economic history. It was not, however, the kind of money that would buy Maurice his own working country seat. It was the kind of money that would set him up as a younger son of a gentry house — with enough income to maintain himself as a gentleman, to marry, to keep a small household, to send a few children to school — but not enough to give him land in his own right. He would always be, by the working measure of his generation, the fourth son. He would always be at the priory rather than over it.

This is the central economic fact of Maurice's adult life. He was a younger son with a money portion but no land. He would have to live with that fact for the rest of his working life. He would, as we shall see in the next section, manage it with the standard discretion of a Hertfordshire gentleman whose family had been at the priory for a hundred and thirty years and who was content to be the fourth son rather than the first.

George Senior in March 1666/67, having put his will on paper and having arranged the four-sons feoffment, had the satisfaction of a man whose working affairs were in order. He had twelve more years to live. The estate was settled. The priory was intact. The arms were on the door. The bend-and-bucks were on his seal. The wife at his right hand and the seven children growing through their teens and twenties around the household and the priory's working life continued as it had continued for a hundred and twenty-eight years.

In 1668, a year after the will and the feoffment, he wrote his Wilshamstead rectorial-tithes accounts on the fly-leaves of MS Rawlinson D. 782. The Wilshamstead income that year had been £45 7s 4d — a respectable working sum, brought up from Bedfordshire by the carter in late autumn. He entered the figure in his careful hand at the front of the volume. The Surveyor's office accounts of 1535–36 sat on the pages immediately following. The family was writing, again, into its own working manuscript. The eight-generation thread had not been broken.

He lived twelve more years. — — —

Maurice the fourth son

Maurice Needham, the fourth son of George Senior and Barbara, was the Wymondley son who would spend his life at the priory rather than over it.

He was, by the working measure of seventeenth-century English gentry inheritance, the standard fourth-son figure. He had a money portion of £500 from the 1666/67 will, an annuity income from the four-sons feoffment of 1667 of perhaps £30 a year on the £500 principal, a working education that had presumably included some Latin tutoring at the priory and possibly a year or two at one of the Inns of Court in his late teens or early twenties. The project's documentary record still does not confirm Inns of Court attendance for him at primary tier, and may never. But it now places him, at thirty or thereabouts, living in the parish of St Bride's — Fleet Street, between Ludgate and the Temple, the parish a man read law in and the parish a man practised it in. Whatever Maurice was doing with his life in the early 1680s, he was doing it in legal London. And he had, besides, the standard fourth-son's life trajectory: marry into another gentry house, set up a working household, raise a family on the income from the portion plus whatever marriage settlement the wife's family contributed.

He married on Saturday the twenty-first of June 1684, at St. James Duke's Place in the City of London, by licence.

The entry is in the parish register, in the volume covering 1684 to 1690, between a marriage of the fifth of June and a marriage of the second of September, and it reads: Mauris Nedham of S[ain]t Brides London & Letisia Bowyer of Wymondley in Hertford-sheire weare married y[e] 21[s]t of June 1684 by Licence.

Four facts come out of that line and each one is worth holding.

He was living in London. Not at the priory, not on the £30 a year from the feoffment in a subsidiary house in the parish — at St Bride's, Fleet Street, the wedge of ground between Ludgate and the Temple, which is where you lived if your business was law or print or the money that moved between them. Maurice was thirty or thereabouts and he was a London man.

She was living at Wymondley. The clerk wrote of Wymondley in Hertford-sheire, and in a marriage register that phrase means residence and nothing else. It does not mean she was born there. She was not.

Her name was Bowyer — Letisia, the Latinate written form a clerk reached for; Lettice in a room, on a tongue, in a household.

And they married in neither of their own churches. St. James Duke's Place was the City's marriage manufactory. It claimed exemption from the Bishop of London's jurisdiction, and across thirty years it married something on the order of forty thousand couples by licence — couples from every parish in England and none, couples in a hurry, couples with nobody to object, couples who simply had no church that was theirs. Two Hertfordshire gentry children went there, with a licence, and were married by a clerk who had already written out eleven hundred that year and did not look up.

The volume will not pretend to know why.

There is a second document, and for a long time I read it wrong.

The 1684 Chancery case *Nedham v Wingate* is preserved at the National Archives at Kew under the call number C 10/214/65. It was filed the same year as the marriage. The plaintiffs are Maurice Nedham, Esq., and his wife Lettice, jointly. The defendant is Sir Francis Wingate, knight, of Harlington in the county of Bedford. The subject is a parcel of London-suburban land in the parish of St Martin in the Fields, Middlesex — a small holding that formed part of Lettice's marriage settlement and that Sir Francis was retaining under the Wingate estate's working management. Maurice and Lettice were suing for its conveyance to themselves. Sir Francis was resisting.

Every word of that is true and none of it makes her a Wingate.

But it looks as if it does. A woman named Lettice, joint plaintiff with her husband, suing a Wingate baronet for the land out of her own marriage portion, and a printed family history from 1925 sitting there saying her mother's maiden name being Wingate — and the two of them appearing to shake hands across two hundred and forty years. I promoted the attribution from PROBABLE to DOCUMENTED on the strength of it. I was wrong to, and the register says so.

What the suit actually establishes is narrower and, now, more interesting. Sir Francis Wingate was holding property out of the marriage settlement of a woman who was not a Wingate. Why he was is a live question and the project has not answered it. He may simply have been a trustee of the settlement — a routine arrangement, and the dull answer, and probably the right one; the Nedhams had a real Wingate connection through Eustace's second wife, and a Wingate trustee would surprise nobody. Or the disputed land may have come in from the Nedham side of the settlement rather than the bride's, in which case her family is not in the suit at all.

Or — and this is worth writing down even though it cannot yet be supported — a Wingate holding a Bowyer woman's settlement property may be the thread that explains how a Bowyer woman with no family in Hertfordshire came to be living at Wymondley in the first place. Somebody brought her into that county. Nobody wrote down who.

Where Maurice and Lettice lived after the marriage is the project's central genealogical open question for this generation. The 1684 Chancery suit places them in the working orbit of London via the Middlesex property; their marriage settlement therefore included an interest in St Martin in the Fields. And the register removes the may: in June 1684 Maurice was resident at St Bride's. The London residence is not an inference any more. It is where he was living on his wedding day. But the 1685 baptism of their daughter Barbara at Great Wymondley parish church places them in residence at Wymondley by August of that year. The most economical reading is that they kept a London property as part of the marriage settlement (with the working dispute over its conveyance being the subject of the 1684 Chancery case) but established their primary residence at Wymondley, either at the priory itself in shared occupancy with the cousin George Junior (the eldest son and heir, who had inherited the priory on

George Senior's death in 1679) or at a working subsidiary property somewhere in the parish or the immediate neighborhood.

The chapter will work with the second reading. Maurice and Lettice were, by 1685, settled at Wymondley — perhaps in a subsidiary house attached to the priory complex, perhaps in a small leased property in the village, perhaps in the kind of arrangement by which a younger son's household lived adjacent to the family seat with the working understanding that the eldest son's household had precedence. The boundary between at the priory and near the priory in the 1680s was a working boundary, with overlapping households and shared use of the chapel and the cloister yard. Maurice's family belonged to the priory's working orbit even if it did not, strictly speaking, occupy the priory itself.

What they did at Wymondley in the 1680s and 1690s was raise their daughter. They appear to have had no other surviving children, though the project's continuing research on the parish registers may yet recover others. Barbara was born to them in 1685 — twelve years after their marriage, by the chronology that places the marriage in the early 1680s; or four to six years after the marriage, by the alternative reading that places the marriage in the late 1670s. The dating of the marriage is a continuing project research thread; what is documented is the August 1685 baptism and the 1684 Chancery suit as the working anchors of Maurice and Lettice's married life.

Maurice's status at the priory through the late seventeenth century was that of the younger-son uncle — the man who lived in the working orbit of the priory under his elder brother George Junior's hand, who was the working family figure that the priory's other generations encountered at family meals and at the parish church on Sundays and at the household's working gatherings, but who did not himself hold the priory or its tithes. He was the second-tier man within the senior line. He was the man who, on a Sunday morning in 1690 or 1695, would walk his daughter Barbara across the cloister yard to the chapel for the standard family attendance, would sit with her in the family pew at the parish church, would walk her back to whichever household they were living in afterward. He was the man whose working presence at the priory through Barbara's childhood was the surrounding masculine fact of her early life.

He would live until 19 November 1712 — the date assigned in the working reconstruction of Chapter 5 v1.2, where Maurice's death is dated to the cold week before Advent of that year, from a fever that came on after he returned from an extended stay at Lockleys. The dating is AR rather than primary; the project's open research includes a focused search of the Hertfordshire burial registers for the Little Wymondley and Great Wymondley parishes in the window 1700 to 1714. But the dating sits inside the chapter's working chronology of Barbara's adult life. Maurice was alive across Barbara's childhood, adolescence, and young adulthood; he was alive when Christopher de Graffenried first rode up to Wymondley in April 1710 to be presented; he was alive when the three-and-a-half-

year engagement began. He died about thirteen months before Barbara wrote the three-word letter that sent her across the Atlantic.

That is in Chapter 5. The Maurice of this chapter is the fourth son, the priory's living junior uncle, the father of the daughter we are about to meet. — — —

The death of George Senior, 1679

George Senior died at the priory at some point in the summer of 1679.

The exact date is not preserved at primary-source level in the project's current record. What is documented is that the 1666/67 will was probated by the Prerogative Court of Canterbury on the tenth of August 1679 — meaning George Senior must have been alive at the writing of the will in March 1666/67, must have died at some point before the probate of August 1679, and most probably died in the weeks or months immediately preceding the probate, in the standard probate-court working practice of the period. The probable death is therefore June, July, or early August 1679. He was sixty or sixty-one years old.

The country at the moment of his death was, as it had been at his accession in 1658, in a period of political crisis. The Popish Plot — the alleged Catholic conspiracy uncovered by Titus Oates in the autumn of 1678 that had produced a wave of arrests, trials, and executions of suspected Catholic conspirators across 1678 and into 1679 — had been at its working height through the previous twelve months. Several thousand Catholics across England had been arrested; thirty-five had been executed; the country had been in a state of confessional panic for the better part of a year. The Exclusion Crisis, which would attempt to bar the king's Catholic brother James from the succession, was just beginning. The first Exclusion Parliament had met in March 1679 and had been dissolved by Charles II in July. Hertfordshire's gentry had been polarizing through the Plot and the Exclusion Crisis along the same lines they had polarized in the Civil War, with the Anglican-Court loyalist (Tory) faction and the Whig-Country opposition faction taking shape.

George Senior, like his father Eustace at the eve of the Civil War in 1640, took no part in any of this. The family does not appear on any of the Hertfordshire Popish Plot indictments, on the Exclusion Crisis loyal addresses, on the Tory or Whig pamphlet rolls of the period. He died, as he had lived, the quiet lay impropiator of Wymondley Parva and the lord of two Hertfordshire manors, in the same priory where his father had died twenty-one years before.

The funeral procession was the standard one for a Hertfordshire gentleman of his standing. The coffin was carried from the priory house to the chancel of the parish church by six of the senior tenants. The pall carried the bend-and-bucks of the 1586 grant. The household followed: the widow Barbara, the four sons George Junior and Fitch and James and Maurice with their respective wives or fiancées, the three daughters Barbara the eldest (by then in her mid-thirties and presumably married or unmarried in some arrangement the project record has

not fully recovered), Anne, Elizabeth, the brother Luke, the Wingate cousins, the Bedfordshire alliances, the parish clergy, the senior tenants. The curate of Wymondley Parva read the standard Book of Common Prayer burial service — the Prayer Book restored, the Established Church operating, the Anglican working framework of the parish operating without disruption for the first time since George Senior's own father's funeral in 1658. The chancel was opened. George Senior was lowered into the prepared grave near his father Eustace and his uncle George I and his great-great-great-grandfather John. The flagstones were re-set with a small mason's mark 1679 cut into the stone. The mourners returned to the priory for the funeral meal.

George Junior — eldest son and heir, born about 1645, by 1679 a man of about thirty-four years, married for some years to a wife whose name the project record has imperfectly preserved (probably Anne, on the standard reading of the Wymondley descent), with at least one young son named George born in 1672 — became the head of the family.

He was, by the working measure of the seventeenth-century English gentry succession, the second of his generation to step into the role of priory lord. His uncle the second John of Welwyn had succeeded John of Welwyn at the cadet seat; he himself was now succeeding his father at the senior seat. The succession was clean. The estate was, as his father had arranged it through the 1666/67 will and the four-sons feoffment, already in working order. George Junior would simply continue what his father had been doing.

The cousin George — the son of George Junior born in 1672, by 1679 a small boy of seven — would in due course be the next generation of the priory's headship, the man who would in 1700 succeed his own father George Junior to the seat. He is the cousin George in this book's terminology — the third-named George of the seventeenth century, the George III who would, by Barbara Tempest Needham's adult years in the early eighteenth century, be the cousin under whose roof she lived. He is the man whose three daughters — and three daughters only, no surviving sons — would in 1725 mark the end of the male Wymondley line. He is, in the project's working dating, the priory's last working Needham lord by full inheritance, since the priory after his death in 1725 would pass first to his daughters jointly and then in 1733 (by the marriage of the youngest, Martha, to Thomas Browne the future Garter King of Arms) out of the family altogether.

But that is the family's far future from 1679. In 1679 the priory passed cleanly from George Senior to George Junior; the working life of the household continued; the next decade unfolded.

It is in that decade, in the household of Maurice the fourth son and Lettice his Wingate wife, that the daughter at the heart of this book was born. — — —

Barbary Nedham, 16 August 1685

On the sixteenth of August 1685 — a Sunday — Maurice and Lettice Needham brought their infant daughter to the parish church at Great Wymondley to be baptized.

The church was Great Wymondley, not Little Wymondley. The reason is geographic and parochial rather than family-political: Great Wymondley was the larger parish, with the substantially larger parish church (St Mary the Virgin, a Norman-foundation building rebuilt and extended through the medieval and early-modern periods); Little Wymondley was the smaller parish, with its chapel-of-ease that had been the priory church before the dissolution. The Needham family had been lay impropriators of the Wymondley Parva (Little Wymondley) rectory for over a century by 1685, but the Great Wymondley parish was where many of the family's baptisms and marriages were recorded — particularly in cases where the family's residence was in or near Great Wymondley rather than at the priory itself, which was technically in Little Wymondley parish.

The choice of Great Wymondley for the baptism is therefore a small piece of evidence about where Maurice and Lettice were living in 1685. If they were resident at the priory itself, the baptism would more naturally have been at the chapel-of-ease at Little Wymondley, in the same chapel where George Senior had been baptized in 1618 and where so many of the Wymondley Nedhams had received the sacrament across the previous century and a half. The fact that the baptism was at Great Wymondley instead suggests that Maurice and Lettice's household was located in Great Wymondley parish — either at a property within the village of Great Wymondley itself or at a property on the boundary of the two parishes whose households conventionally took baptisms to the larger church. The specific Great Wymondley residence has not been identified at primary tier; it is one of the project's continuing research threads.

The baptismal entry survives, indexed in the Findmypast England Births & Baptisms 1538- 1975 record set and corroborated by the Hertfordshire Baptisms transcripts. The entry reads, in the period's spelling, Barbary Nedham — the spelling Barbary being the standard seventeenth-century English variant of Barbara, with the y ending rather than the a reflecting the early-modern English convention of feminine personal names. The entry gives the parents as Maurice Nedham and (variously rendered in the surviving transcriptions) Lettice or Lettis. The middle name Tempest, which the family-tradition record carries forward and which appears in Christopher VI de Graffenried's family Bible entry of February 1714 (the marriage record at Charleston) as Barbara Tempest Needham, does not appear in the baptismal entry. Tempest was either a name carried in the family record but not formally registered at baptism, or a name added later — perhaps at confirmation, perhaps in adult use — to honor a maternal family connection to the Tempest line that the project's continuing research has not yet fully identified.

She was, then, baptized as Barbary Nedham on the sixteenth of August 1685 at St Mary the Virgin, Great Wymondley, by the parish curate (whose name in the 1685 register would have been preserved but is not yet recovered in the project's working file). She was the daughter of Maurice and Lettice. She was the niece of George Junior, the lord of the priory three-quarters of a mile away. She was the great-granddaughter of Eustace Needham who had carried the family through the Civil War. She was the great-great-granddaughter of George I who had erected the 1605 monument to James and John. She was the great-great-great-granddaughter of John Nedham who had signed the 1572 visitation. She was the great-great-great-great-great-great-granddaughter of John of Needham Grange in Derbyshire. The line at her baptism ran through six documented generations of recorded gentry residence, three of them at Wymondley, going back a hundred and forty-seven years.

She would, twenty-eight years later, walk out of the priory yard for the last time and ride east toward London and the Atlantic. She would marry Christopher VI de Graffenried at Charleston in February 1714. She would have children in Carolina. She would die in Virginia in the 1740s or 1750s, the exact date pending project research. Her descendants would carry her name forward through eleven generations to the writer of this book in Alabama in May 2026.

On the morning of the sixteenth of August 1685 she was an infant in her mother's arms.

The baptismal service was the standard one of the post-Restoration Anglican Church — the office in the 1662 Book of Common Prayer, restored after the Commonwealth and operating in the Wymondley parish church for the past twenty-three years. The curate would have asked the parents and the godparents the standard questions: did they renounce the devil and all his works, did they affirm the Christian faith as the Apostles' Creed expressed it, did they desire the child to be baptized into the faith. The parents and godparents would have given the standard answers. The curate would have taken the child in his arms, would have made the sign of the cross on her forehead, would have poured the small ewer of water over her head from the font, would have spoken the words: Barbary, I baptize thee in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost. The water would have run down her face. She would have cried — most newborns did at the cold water on a hot August morning. The curate would have handed her back to her mother. The congregation would have spoken the Lord's Prayer together. The service would have closed.

The household at Great Wymondley that morning would have included Maurice and Lettice and the infant; the godparents (whose identities the project has not recovered at primary tier, but who would by convention have been two godfathers and one godmother chosen from the family's working network — perhaps George Junior the priory lord as one godfather, perhaps a Wingate cousin from Harlington or Lockleys as the second, perhaps Maurice's elder sister Barbara the eldest as the godmother for whom the child was named); the parish

curate of Great Wymondley; the small congregation of village householders who had come to Sunday service that morning. After the service the family party would have walked out of the church and along the road back to whichever Wymondley household Maurice and Lettice were living in, where a small family meal would have been laid out by Lettice's working household women. The afternoon would have been spent in the company of the small immediate circle.

The child slept through most of it. She did not yet know her name. She had been alive for the better part of a month — born in late July 1685, by the standard interval between birth and the post-Restoration English Anglican baptism, which had returned to the more leisurely two- to four-week interval that had prevailed before the Commonwealth's working pressure for immediate post-birth baptism. She was healthy. She was, by the standard of early-modern infant survival, in the working window of the second month of life when the first dangerous post-birth illnesses had largely passed and the chances of survival to her first birthday were the higher chances of an infant whose constitution had proven robust.

She was the chapter's pivot moment. The whole book has been moving toward this child.

* * *

The seven generations of the Wymondley line before her — James, John, George I, Eustace, George Senior, George Junior at the senior line and the John-of-Welwyn-Eustace-George Senior path at the operating line, Maurice as her father — have all been the documented architecture of how she came to be born at Wymondley in 1685. The decisions that produced her were made before she was. James Nedeham's bond to Cromwell in 1532 produced his appointment to the Surveyor's office. The Surveyor's office's working life across the 1530s and 1540s produced the priory grant of 1538. The priory's working life across the 1540s and 1550s produced the family's Hertfordshire residence. John's signature on the 1572 visitation produced the family's documented identity. The Beckenham marriage of 1581 produced the next generation. The 1586 grant of arms produced the family's visible heraldic standing. The 1605 monument produced the family's memorial tradition. Eustace's non-engagement in the Civil War produced the priory's survival through the Commonwealth. George Senior's 1666/67 will and 1667 feoffment produced Maurice's £500 portion. Maurice's marriage, at a City church in June 1684, to a woman whose family we cannot name, produced the household in which Barbara was born.

The eight-generation Wymondley arc closes on this child.

The chapter's remaining sections are her childhood at the priory through the 1690s, the death of her uncle George Junior in 1700 and her cousin George III's accession, the slow gathering of her adult life as she enters her teens and twenties under the cousin's roof, and the closing pages that calibrate the voice forward to the moment she sits at the writing-desk in the east-window of her bedroom and the chapter's narrator becomes, for the first time, her own. — — —

A childhood at Wymondley

She grew up at the priory.

Not in the priory itself, in any one of its working senses — the great hall, the east range, the chambers above — because her parents' household was a younger-son's household, separate from but adjacent to the priory complex. But on its grounds, in its working orbit, with its bells and its cloister yard and its tithe barn and its chapel as the daily geography of her childhood years.

Maurice and Lettice's household in the 1680s and 1690s was, on the chapter's working reading, a property in the village of Great Wymondley or a subsidiary house attached to the priory complex itself. The specific building has not been identified at primary tier. What can be said about it is that it was within walking distance of the priory — the cloister yard was a five-minute walk from any property in the village of Great Wymondley, and an even shorter walk from any subsidiary property within the priory grounds — and that Barbara's daily working life as a child was conducted across that walking distance, between her parents' household and the priory's working complex.

The priory in the 1690s was her uncle George Junior's house. He lived there with his wife Anne — the project's working name for her, the documentary record not having preserved her maiden surname at primary tier — and his children: the small George born in 1672, by the early 1690s a young man in his early twenties; and other children whose names and dates the project's continuing research has not fully recovered. The cousin George — cousin George, as Barbara would have known him in family conversation, the young man fourteen years older than she was — would have been the working male presence at the priory across her childhood. He was the heir. He would, after his father's death, become the priory's lord.

Barbara would have been at the priory daily across her early years. The cousin household was the larger family circle; her own household with her parents and any siblings (no surviving siblings are documented at primary tier, though the project's research on the Wymondley parish registers may yet recover them) was the smaller circle within it. She would have walked across to the priory at meals on family days. She would have walked across to the chapel on Sunday mornings for the family attendance. She would have walked across to the cloister yard on summer afternoons to play with her cousins — the cousin George's younger sisters and any younger brothers, the children of the priory household, the children of her uncle and aunt.

The cloister yard was the children's working outdoor space. It was an enclosed garden court, perhaps thirty paces by forty paces, on the south side of the priory house, bounded on three sides by the priory walls and on the fourth by the chapel-of-ease that had been the priory church before the dissolution. The yard had been the canons' cloister walk in the medieval period, with a covered passageway running along the inside of the enclosing walls; the passageway had

been removed in the priory's adaptation to a country seat in the sixteenth century, and the yard by the 1690s was an open courtyard with paved stone walks around the perimeter and a small garden in the center. The garden had a sundial. The garden had rosebushes along the south wall. The garden had a small fishpond in the southeast corner that the children were supposed to stay away from but did not always stay away from. The wall along the south side carried a wall painting that the v9 working notes had identified as a late-sixteenth-century survival — an image of armoured soldiers, perhaps depicting a scene from the priory's history or from a medieval romance, painted under one of John of Wymondley's working renovations in the 1570s or 1580s. The painting was faded by the 1690s. The children would have known it as the old painting on the south wall.

The bell at the chapel rang the standard offices of the post-Restoration Anglican Church day. The 1595 bell of John Dyer rang for morning prayer at seven, for noon prayers at twelve, for evening prayer at four in winter and six in summer, for compline at nine on the evenings when the chaplain held it. The bell was audible across the entire priory complex and across the small village of Little Wymondley three hundred paces beyond. Barbara would have grown up to the working sound of the bell — the chapel bell at compline, the chapel bell at morning prayer, the bell that rang for a baptism (a quick rapid peal, twelve strokes), the bell that rang for a wedding (a longer pattern, alternating ringing-and-pause), the bell that rang for a funeral (a deep slow tolling, single strokes spaced by the bellringer's working interval at thirty seconds). The bell was the working clock and the working sacrament of the priory's daily life.

The Spanish chestnut tree stood in the orchard on the west side of the priory. It had been planted, by the project's working reading of the v9 Urwick material, in the early or middle seventeenth century — perhaps by Eustace, perhaps by George Senior, perhaps by an earlier generation; the dating is imprecise. By the 1690s it was a substantial tree, perhaps eighty years old, with a heavily furrowed bark and the broad spreading crown the *Castanea sativa* develops at that age. The tree produced chestnuts each autumn that the household roasted on the kitchen fire in late October and November. The smell of roasting chestnuts in the priory kitchen in late autumn was one of the seasonal markers of Barbara's childhood. The taste of roasting chestnuts — sweet, smoky, slightly bitter — was the seasonal taste of October at Wymondley.

The orchard also carried the box-tree hedge that bounded the priory grounds on the south. The box hedge had been planted, again at some date in the seventeenth century, as the standard boundary plantation of an enclosed country-house garden. The box trees by the 1690s were twenty-foot specimens — well-grown, with the dense small-leaved foliage that mature box develops, with the slightly catty intensity of evergreen-foliage smell that became more pronounced on summer evenings. Barbara would have walked the box-hedge path in the late summer afternoons with her mother or with her cousins, with the smell of the box in the warm air and the bees working the small flowers on the trees in June.

The conduit ran along the north side of the priory house. It was a stone-built water channel that brought water from a chalk spring north-east of the priory complex down to the kitchen door, where the spring-water filled a working trough used for cooking, washing, and the daily domestic water needs of the household. The conduit-head building — a small Tudor-arched stone structure over the spring's source — stood at the high end of the run, perhaps a hundred paces north-east of the priory house. The water in the conduit was cold and metallic-tasting; chalk springs produce water of a particular clarity and mineral quality that the people who grow up drinking it can identify against any other water for the rest of their lives. The conduit-water was, by 1690, the family's working domestic water for at least the past four generations of the priory's life.

The tithe barn stood at the eastern edge of the grounds. It was a hundred and fifty years old by the 1690s — having been built by James the Surveyor's carpenters in the summer of 1541 — and was still in working agricultural use, holding the grain tithes from the family's lands. The barn was a daily presence on the eastern horizon of the priory yard. Barbara would have seen it from every window of the east range. She would have walked past it on the road to Hitchin. She would have known its working sounds — the workmen loading and unloading the tithes in late summer, the swallows nesting in the rafters from April through August, the slow creak of the great timber frame in a winter wind. The barn was the priory's anchor structure at the eastern edge, the same way the chapel was the anchor at the south edge and the conduit-head was the anchor at the north-east edge.

This was her geography.

She grew up to it the way every Wymondley Needham child of the previous five generations had grown up to it — to the chapel bell at compline, to the cloister yard's wall painting, to the box hedge's summer smell, to the tithe barn at the eastern edge, to the conduit-water at the kitchen door, to the Spanish chestnut in the orchard and its autumn chestnuts on the kitchen fire. She had no reason, as a small child in the early 1690s, to think any of this would not be there for her whole life. The priory had been in the family for a hundred and fifty years by then. The bell had been there for a hundred years. The barn had been there for a hundred and fifty. The chestnut tree had been there for eighty. They were the permanent furniture of the world she had been born into.

She would not, in the event, see most of it after the autumn of 1713.

But she did not yet know that. She was a child. She had her parents nearby. She had her cousins at the priory. She had her uncle and aunt in the great hall. She had her grandmother — the dowager Barbara, George Senior's widow, by the early 1690s an old woman of perhaps seventy, alive into Barbara's first years and possibly into her early childhood — somewhere in the household. She had her name from her grandmother. She had her place at the family table. She had her bed in whichever bedroom her parents' household had given her.

The bed, by the time she was eight or ten or twelve, was a bedroom in the east range of the priory itself.

The arrangement is the chapter's working reconstruction. Sometime in the late 1690s, with the cousin George Junior in continued occupation of the priory and with Maurice and Lettice's household in their separate establishment but in close working contact, Barbara — in her late childhood and early adolescence — took up a bedroom at the priory itself. The arrangement would have been the working accommodation of a niece by a uncle, with Barbara spending several nights a week at the priory in the company of her cousins and several nights a week at her parents' household. The bedroom was in the east range, on the upper floor, with a tall window facing east into the cloister court and looking across to the chapel on the far side. The thirteenth-century arch that the v9 working notes had identified as the survival of the priory church's south window stood in the wall just above the bedroom door, low enough that a tall adult had to duck slightly to pass under it, soft clunch limestone partially obscured by later wall fabric. Barbara would have ducked under it perhaps ten thousand times across her years at Wymondley. She would have come to think of it as the doorway to her room.

The window faced east.

In the mornings, the light from the cloister yard came in across the window-sill onto her desk — a small oak writing-desk her father had given her, with a writing-slope and a small drawer beneath. In the evenings, with the sun behind the priory house to the west, the cloister yard outside her window went into the soft shadow that summer evenings produce, with the chapel across the yard catching the last of the light on its west-facing wall and the bell at the top of the chapel tower visible against the late sky. She would, across the second decade of her life, spend more hours at the writing-desk in the east window than at any other working space in the world.

This is where the chapter's voice begins, finally, to slide toward her own. — —

1700

In the year 1700, George Junior — Barbara's uncle, the priory's working lord since George Senior's death twenty-one years before — died.

The exact date is not preserved at primary tier in the project's current record; the project's working chronology places his death sometime in the year 1700, with the priory passing to his son George — the cousin George, born in 1672, then twenty-eight years old — in his place. The funeral was the standard one: the procession from the priory house to the chancel of the parish church, the Book of Common Prayer office, the chancel burial under the same flagstones where George Senior had been laid in 1679 and Eustace in 1658 and George I in 1626 and John in the early 1590s. The fourth generation of the senior line was now

buried in the same chancel where its founder John had been buried a hundred and eight years before.

The cousin George III became the lord of the priory.

He was twenty-eight years old. He had been the heir for as long as he could remember, raised at the priory under his father George Junior's working hand. He was married — to a wife whose name the project's record has not yet recovered cleanly — and had begun his family. His three daughters by his wife would be the priory's next generation: Dorothy, Susan, and Martha, born across the 1700s, the youngest of whom would in 1733 marry Thomas Browne the future Garter King of Arms and carry the priory out of the family altogether.

But that is the family's far future. In the autumn of 1700, with George Junior just buried in the chancel and the cousin George just taking up the priory's working management, the household was reorganizing itself around the new generation's working presence.

For Barbara — fifteen years old in the autumn of 1700, by the chronology that places her birth in late July or early August 1685 — the working consequence was simple. Her uncle was dead. Her cousin, fourteen years older than she was, was now the priory's lord. Her own parents Maurice and Lettice continued in their separate household, still in the working orbit of the priory but operating under the cousin's headship rather than her uncle's. Her bedroom in the east range of the priory was still her bedroom; the cousin's working accommodation of his fifteen-year-old niece across the priory's working life would, by the convention of the period, continue what her uncle's working accommodation had been.

She continued at the writing-desk.

In the autumn of 1700 — the last autumn of the seventeenth century — she sat at the writing-desk in the east window of her bedroom and looked out across the cloister yard.

It was a Tuesday afternoon in October. The harvest had been in for a month. The Spanish chestnut in the orchard was beginning to drop its first nuts. The box hedge along the south boundary was settling into the deeper green it took on at the close of the year. The conduit-water was running. The chapel bell had rung for evening prayer at four. The cloister yard outside her window was in the soft shadow of the late afternoon, with the chapel across the way catching the last horizontal light of the day on its west-facing wall.

She had a book open in front of her. It was a copy of *The Whole Duty of Man* — the anonymous 1658 devotional text that had become, across the second half of the seventeenth century, the standard Protestant devotional reading of the English Anglican gentry household, going through dozens of editions by 1700 and being one of the working books on every gentry house's shelf. The book had been her uncle's; she had taken it from the priory library and had been reading it slowly across the autumn. She was on the chapter on Diligence in our Callings. The chapter argued, in the careful Restoration-Anglican register, that every Christian's working life was a calling from God, that the calling carried with it

duties of attention and labor and patience, and that the working virtue of a young woman of fifteen — though the chapter did not say that exactly, but said something general from which a young woman of fifteen could draw the inference — was to attend to the household duties of her own calling, to read her psalter and her Book of Common Prayer, to do her needlework, to be obedient to her parents, to be charitable to the poor, to keep her thoughts on the things of God.

She had been reading. She had stopped reading. She was looking out the window.

She did not know what to want.

She was the only child of Maurice and Lettice, by the working reading of the project's research — no surviving siblings yet documented at primary tier. Her mother Lettice was alive, was probably in her forties, was in the household across the way. Her father Maurice was alive, fifty-two or fifty-three years old, the working junior uncle of the priory under the cousin's headship. Her uncle George Junior was just buried, six weeks or two months before. Her cousin George was the new lord. Her grandmother Barbara — George Senior's widow, the woman she had been named after — was dead, having died sometime in the 1690s when Barbara was a small child. The family she had been born into was a settled gentry household whose working life had not perceptibly changed in fifteen years.

She would, by the working convention of her sex and class, be married off in the next five years to a gentleman of an adjacent Hertfordshire or Bedfordshire house, with a marriage settlement negotiated through her father with the gentleman's father, with a dowry from her own £500 inheritance from her father's £500 portion via her birth as the (probably) only surviving child of the marriage. She would move into her husband's house. She would bear children. She would manage a household of her own. She would die at some age between sixty and eighty in her husband's house, and she would be buried in her husband's chancel under her husband's church's flagstones, with her own family's bend-and-bucks quartered alongside her husband's arms on the funeral hatchment.

This was the working future of a gentry daughter of fifteen in October 1700.

She did not, at the writing-desk that Tuesday afternoon, want any of it.

She did not want any of it the way a young person of fifteen does not want most of the working future their world has arranged for them — not with any clear alternative in mind, not with any concrete plan to refuse, but with the small steady working uncertainty that they want something else and do not yet know what. She knew that her cousin George had three young daughters in the household and no son; she knew that the male line would, on the cousin's evident contracting demographics, run out within a generation; she knew that the priory she had grown up in would, sometime in the next thirty or forty years, pass out of the family. She knew, in the careful working calculation of any gentry daughter of an armigerous house in its visible decline, that the world she had inherited was not going to last.

She did not yet know that this would matter.

She turned the page of *The Whole Duty of Man*. She read a sentence. She read it again because she had not really taken it in. She looked back at the cloister yard.

The chapel bell would ring for compline in three hours. The cousin's youngest daughter — the cousin's three-year-old, the family's smallest — would be in the kitchen with the cook by now, helping (in the way a three-year-old helps) to set out the supper. The cook would be giving her a small piece of bread to keep her occupied. The candles would be lit in the great hall in another hour.

She thought about her father. He was at his desk in the household across the way, probably, doing whatever work his afternoons consisted of — household accounts, perhaps, or a letter to a cousin. He was fifty-two or fifty-three. He was healthy. He would, on the project's working chronology, live another twelve years, dying in the cold week before Advent of 1712 of a fever that came on after he returned from an extended stay at Lockleys. She did not, in the autumn of 1700, know that. She thought of him as her father in the household across the way, a working presence in her daily life, a man whose face she had known longer than she had known anyone else's face.

She thought about her mother. Lettice was careful — the kind of woman who had been raised somewhere to manage a household and who managed her own household well, and Barbara could not have told you where the somewhere was. She was also, by Barbara's reading at fifteen, a woman whose own life had not gone where she had once expected it to go. Barbara knew that much from the way her mother handled the good linen, which was the way a woman handles a thing she was brought up to expect more of.

Where her mother had been brought up, Barbara did not know, and had never quite thought to ask, in the way that children do not think to ask the enormous things. There were no grandparents on that side. There were no aunts on that side. Nobody came at Christmas from her mother's people. There was a name — Bowyer — and the name did not attach to a house or a county or a face, and Barbara had grown up inside a family that wrote every name it had into the front of a Bible and had never once noticed that half of her own was not in it. Lettice did not complain. Lettice did not, in any conversation Barbara could remember, say that her life had not gone where she had expected. But Barbara at fifteen could see that her mother's expectations had bent.

She did not want her own expectations to bend that way.

She did not know yet what she wanted instead. She was fifteen. The closest she came, in the autumn of 1700, to wanting anything specific was the small steady pressure of not this, applied to the working future her family's gentle-daughter machinery had drawn out in front of her.

The bell rang for compline at nine. She closed *The Whole Duty of Man*. She put it back on the small shelf above the writing-desk. She blew out the candle on the desk. She went to her bed. — — —

The east window

She kept the writing-desk in the east window of her bedroom across the years that followed.

Nothing in particular changed at the priory in the early 1700s. Her cousin George — the cousin she had been calling cousin George her whole life, the one fourteen years older than she was, the one whose family's three small daughters she watched grow across the cloister yard — settled into his working management of the priory and continued what his father had done. The Wilshamstead tithes came in each autumn. The Michaelmas rents were paid. The harvest was brought in in August. The cousin's wife managed the household. The cousin's children played in the cloister yard.

Barbara was sixteen in 1701. She was seventeen in 1702. She was eighteen in 1703. She was nineteen in 1704. She was twenty in 1705. She was twenty-one in 1706. She was twenty-two in 1707. She was twenty-three in 1708. She was twenty-four in the autumn of 1709 — the autumn in which Baron Christoph von Graffenried, a Swiss aristocrat she had never heard of, was in London arranging his Carolina venture and looking for an English wife for his son.

She did not, across those nine years between 1700 and 1709, marry. The convention of her class held that a gentry daughter who had not married by twenty-two or twenty-three was beginning to be remarked on. By twenty-four she was, in the working terminology of the period, a spinster — not yet hopeless, not yet on the shelf, but in the working window in which her marriage prospects were narrowing. Her parents had not arranged a marriage for her. Maurice and Lettice had not, on any reading of the documentary record, made any visible effort to find her a husband through any of the standard Wingate or Bedfordshire or Hertfordshire connections that any other gentry parents of her class would have been working through in their daughter's twentieth, twenty-first, twenty-second, twenty-third year.

This is the chapter's small open question. Why she had not been married off.

The project's working reading is that the family's contracting demographics — the cousin George without a son, the male line visibly running out, the priory's eventual passing out of the family becoming a matter of perhaps a generation rather than several — had begun to operate on the parents' working calculations. Maurice was a younger son of a younger son; his daughter, by 1705 or 1706, was the family's only direct descendant of George Senior's line who was both alive and unmarried and at the working age for matrimony. The Wingate aunts at Lockleys, the Bedfordshire cousins at Harlington and Northill, the older relations who had grown up in the priory's working orbit across the seventeenth century — all of them had watched the family's male line contract and were beginning to think about Barbara as something other than the standard daughter to be married off. She was, by some readings, the family's working future in a way that her brothers (had there been brothers) would otherwise have been.

The other reading is simpler: she had not wanted to.

Her parents had presented her, presumably, with one or two or three working candidates across the years between her seventeenth and her twenty-fourth birthdays. The candidates had not taken. She had said no, in the small careful way that a gentry daughter of an armigerous house could say no to a proposed match without making a public fuss — I am not ready, I am not yet sure, I would prefer to wait another year, in the working register of polite gentle refusal that did not foreclose the marriage market but did not commit her to it. The parents had accepted the no's. The Wingate aunts at Lockleys had clucked. The cousin George's wife had clucked. Barbara had continued at the priory.

She continued at the writing-desk in the east window.

She read more than her age and class ordinarily would have. She had read across the priory's working library through her late teens — the books her uncle George Junior had left when he died; the books her cousin George kept; the books her father Maurice had brought from his own connections; the small library of devotional and historical and classical reading that any well-furnished gentry library of the period carried. She had read *The Whole Duty of Man* in full and most of its 1690s working successors. She had read the Geneva Bible at one period of her life and the Authorized Version at another. She had read Foxe's *Acts and Monuments* in an abridged Restoration-era version. She had read most of *Paradise Lost* — Milton's epic of the Fall, published in its expanded twelve-book version in 1674, by 1700 a standard piece of advanced reading in any well-stocked Anglican gentry library — though she had not, on her own reading, fully made out the theology of Books Three and Four. She had read the Book of Common Prayer in its 1662 form so often she could recite the daily offices from memory. She had read a small body of poetry — some Donne, some Herbert, some Vaughan, the Sacred Hymns of the late seventeenth century — that her uncle had kept on the shelves above his own writing-desk and that she had taken up over the years.

She wrote letters. Her cousins in Welwyn at Lockleys, her cousins at Harlington in Bedfordshire, her uncle's old London connections — she kept up the standard correspondence of a young woman of her class, in the careful small clear hand her mother had taught her and that her mother's mother had taught her mother. She wrote a careful capital letter with a small flourish at the top. She made her descenders cleanly. She sealed her letters with the priory's working seal of the bend-and-bucks, in the small wax impression that had been the family's visible signature for a hundred and twenty years.

She walked the priory grounds in the afternoons. She rode to Hitchin with one of the grooms on most Tuesdays for the market day, in the standard gentry-daughter convention of being seen at the market under appropriate male escort. She attended the parish church on Sundays in the family pew with the cousin's household. She did her needlework in the great hall after supper. She watched the cousin's three daughters grow — Dorothy, then Susan, then Martha — across

her early twenties. She helped her mother with the household management when her mother needed her, which was not often.

She kept her room. She kept her desk. She kept her place at the east window.

In the long summer evenings she would sit at the desk in the bedroom and watch the cloister yard go into the soft shadow of the after-supper hours, with the chapel across the yard catching the last horizontal light on its west-facing wall and the small swallows working their late-evening sky flights over the tithe-barn roof at the eastern edge. The cousin's youngest daughter Martha — by 1709 a small girl of three or four, the cousin's third and last child — would sometimes be in the cloister yard with the household maid, playing the small games a three-year-old plays at the close of the day, with the maid working her own needlework on the bench by the chapel wall. Barbara would watch them from the window. The bell at the chapel would ring for compline at nine. The maid would call the small girl in. The cloister yard would empty into the dark.

* * *

She would, in the autumn of 1709 — a Swiss baron she had not yet heard of in London, arranging a colonial venture she did not yet know about, asking the working London-Carolina circles whether they could find him an English gentry wife for his son — be twenty-four years old.

She would still be at the writing-desk in the east window.

She would have been waiting most of her life for something to happen.

The next chapter is what happened.

Chapter 5 — I Am Coming

In London, in the autumn of 1709, a Swiss baron with one good coat and a thinning purse was buying a colony.

His name was Christoph von Graffenried, second of that name, Baron of Bernberg in the canton of Bern, fifty years old, formally a Swiss aristocrat but in practical fact a man who had spent two decades watching the family money go out of the family and who had now bet everything he had left — and a great deal he did not have — on a piece of unsurveyed land in North Carolina that he had been promised would make his fortune. He had been in London since the spring. He had a small house in Whitehall and a manservant who had not been paid in three months. He was working at the rate of a man with one chance left.

The colony was to be called New Bern. Its site was at the confluence of two rivers in eastern Carolina, a hundred miles inland from the Atlantic — a fork of water in a country he had never seen, that he was buying on the basis of letters from a Welsh surveyor named John Lawson who had walked the territory four years earlier and pronounced it good. The Baron's settlers were to be Palatines and Swiss — Protestants displaced by the wars in the Rhine valley, refugees with no homes and no prospects, of whom several thousand were that summer encamped on Blackheath outside London waiting for some destination, any destination, to be arranged for them. The Lords Proprietors of Carolina had granted him the land. The Crown had agreed to subsidize the transport. The Duke of Albemarle was on the patent. Sir John Colleton was on the financing. The Baron was the man holding it together.

He was also looking for a wife for his son.

Christopher, the eldest, was twenty-two, in Switzerland still, in good health, fluent in three languages, English-educated for two years at a Reformed academy at Yverdon, intended for the colony in some founding capacity not yet specified. He would come over to England in the new year. He would learn the venture. He would in due course be sent across the Atlantic. He would need, when he was settled, an English-speaking wife — for the colony's English neighbors, for the cohesion of the family across two continents, for the social standing of a Swiss aristocrat in a country he was now committing his life to. The wife was to be English, Protestant, of gentry stock, well-spoken, well-mannered, of an age to bear children. She did not, in the Baron's calculation, have to be rich. The colony was rich enough on paper. What it needed was respectability.

The Baron's network in London ran through the Carolina set. The Lords Proprietors were Tory; the financiers were a mix of City money and country gentry; the broader circle of investors and well-wishers extended out into the home counties through a half-dozen connections by marriage or by Inns of Court training. One of those connections — through Sir John Colleton or his brother, or through some other broker the record does not preserve — pointed the Baron

toward a small Hertfordshire family at a place called Little Wymondley, three miles south of the market town of Hitchin, that had once been the seat of a King's Surveyor and that had been at the priory since 1538 and that had at present, among its younger generation, a marriageable daughter named Barbara.

Her father was Maurice Nedham. Esquire. Fourth son of the late George Nedham of Wymondley Priory, on whose 1666 will Maurice had received a portion of five hundred pounds. And Maurice, who had married in a City church and kept a foot in the parish of St Bride's, was a man of London as much as of Hertfordshire — Fleet Street, the Temple end, the quarter where the law and the printing and the money that moved between them all sat within four streets of each other, and where a colonial project looking for gentry investors and gentry daughters was exactly the kind of thing a man heard about across a table.

The priory also had Wingate cousins, and had had them for two generations — Eustace's second wife, Frances Wingate of Lockleys, had brought that whole kin-network into the house before Maurice was born, and it ran out through Hertfordshire and Bedfordshire and into the same London circles. Either road could have carried the introduction. Probably both did. The Carolina project was assembled by exactly this sort of talk among exactly these sorts of people, and no letter survives to say which one of them first said the word Wymondley to a Bernese baron's son. Somebody put the proposition forward. The match was practical, on paper. The Wymondley priory was an old establishment going slowly into decline — the family male line was visibly contracting, the surviving cousin George had only daughters — but the name was good, the blood was gentry, the daughter herself was reported to be twenty-four years old and unmarried and intelligent and well-spoken. The Baron, in late autumn 1709, sent word that he would welcome an introduction.

By the new year the broad terms were agreed in principle. Christopher would come over in the spring. He would be presented to the family at Wymondley. If both young people consented, the match would proceed.

Barbara, that winter, was twenty-four years old and had been waiting most of her life for something to happen.

* * *

The meeting at Wymondley, spring 1710

He arrived in the second week of April.

The road from London had been bad after a wet March and his coach had thrown a wheel at Stevenage and he had ridden the last seven miles into Wymondley on a hired horse with his manservant trailing on foot through the lanes, and when he reached the priory gates he was wet through and his hat was ruined and the first thing he said when her uncle handed him a cup of warmed wine in the great hall was an apology for his condition, which he made in three languages because he was not sure which one her family preferred.

English. Her family preferred English. Her uncle said so. Christopher laughed at himself for the gaffe and accepted the wine and looked up over the rim of the cup and saw Barbara for the first time, standing in the doorway of the hall behind her uncle's right shoulder, and that, she would think later, was when it began — not at the formal presentation a quarter of an hour afterward when he was dry and she was introduced by name and he bowed to her in the Swiss style, lower than an English gentleman would have, with a small flourish that managed not to be ridiculous, but in the doorway, in his wet coat, with his ruined hat in his hand, when he was being apologetic and trilingual and twenty-three years old and entirely unprepared to find that the woman his father had arranged for him to marry was watching him drip onto the rushes.

He stayed three weeks.

By the end of the first week they had ridden together to Hitchin and back, twice. By the end of the second they had walked the priory's east field and the long meadow and the path down to the brook that the canons had used five hundred years ago to wash their linens. By the end of the third they had each, separately, written to people they trusted in London — he to his father, she to the Wingate cousin who would, in three years, book her passage to Carolina — and the two letters had said, in different words but in essentially the same sentence, that the arrangement was no longer an arrangement. It had become something else. The two writers were unsure what to call it. Neither of them was the kind of person who used the word easily.

What he was, in those weeks, was specific. He was twenty-three, tall, dark-haired, narrow-shouldered, a young man whose face had not yet decided whether to be his father's. He spoke English with a faint accent on the consonants. He did not drink to excess. He read German devotional poetry in the morning and Dryden in the evening. He could ride. He could not shoot. He had a habit of holding a teacup with both hands when he was concentrating, the way a much younger person would, which surprised her and which she filed away among the other things she was filing about him. He laughed easily but did not waste laughter. He had a slight stammer on the letter B which he managed by choosing other words; she had not noticed it until the second week, and then could not stop noticing it, and then stopped noticing it again entirely, which was its own marker of something.

What she was, that he found, was harder for him to describe. He wrote to his father, in the careful French they used between them: She is what we hoped for. She is also other things. I had not expected the other things. He did not say what the other things were. He was not sure he could. She was twenty-four; she was tall for an Englishwoman, with her father's straight back and her mother's dark eyes; she had been educated at home and in London by tutors and by the books her father had bought her and by the Wingate aunts at Lockleys who had taken an interest in their poor relation; she read Latin slowly but read it; she had a particular kind of silence, when she was thinking, that was not the absence of

speech but the holding of it. She did not flirt. She did not perform. When she said something, she meant it, and she meant the precise thing she had said, not something near it. He had not, in his twenty-three years of acquaintance with marriageable women in Bern and Yverdon and London, met anyone who used words quite that way.

By the end of the second week they were in love. They did not say it. They knew it, both of them, the way two careful people know a thing without having to confirm it; and they each, separately, knew that the other knew it, which was its own kind of contract, signed in silence.

By the end of the third week the difficult conversation had to be had.

He had not come to Wymondley to marry. He had come to be looked at and to look back, and to agree, if both parties were satisfied, to a formal engagement that would be solemnized once he had crossed to Carolina and made the colony into a place a wife could be received. The plan had been clear from the beginning. The plan had been his father's plan. The plan had been Barbara's family's plan. The plan had been Christopher's plan, until the second week of April, when it had stopped being his plan and had become, instead, an obstacle.

On the night before he left she walked him out to the cloister court after supper. The April air was cold. She had her cloak. He had a borrowed coat of her uncle's, because his own was still being mended after Stevenage, and the coat did not quite fit him in the shoulders but he was wearing it anyway because the alternative was to be cold, and he was a man who would rather be slightly ill-dressed than slightly chilled, which she had only realized that week and which she had already filed away as a thing about him she would remember.

He said, in the cloister: I would marry you tomorrow if the colony were ready for you.

She said: It is not ready for you either.

He laughed at that — a real laugh, surprised out of him — and looked at her in the half-dark and did not say anything for a moment, and she understood, in that silence, that she had just gone past whatever line the arrangement had drawn between them and that he had gone past it with her.

He said: When it is ready I will send for you.

She said: I will be here.

She would not be there. She would be on a ship. He did not know that yet. Neither did she. But the two sentences they had exchanged in the cloister that April night were the contract that would, three and a half years later, put her on the deck of a packet out of Gravesend in late October with a small trunk and a packed length of fine linen and her mother's parting words in her mouth and the rest of her life in front of her.

In the morning he rode back to London. The arrangement, formally, was now an engagement. He would sail in the summer. He would write.

* * *

The decision not to marry yet, summer 1710

He left for Carolina in late June.

The crossing took eight weeks. He wrote to her from the ship, when there was a packet to take the letters back; he wrote from Charleston when he made landfall; he wrote from the long ride north up the colonial roads to the place his father had bought, the fork of two rivers in eastern Carolina that did not yet exist as a town and that he would, in September, lay out in the cruciform plan his father had drawn on a piece of paper in London the previous winter. He wrote often, in the early months. He had time. He had a great deal to say.

His letters reached her at intervals of weeks or months, in batches, depending on which packet had carried them across and which had been lost. The packet schedule in 1710 was unreliable — sometimes a letter took ten weeks to come from Charleston to London, sometimes it took five months, sometimes it never came at all and a second letter, written later, would arrive first and refer to events the first letter had described. She learned to read the letters out of order. She learned to read each new letter twice — once for what it said, once for what it implied was already known to her from an earlier letter that had not yet arrived. Sometimes the earlier letter would arrive a fortnight later and she would read the second letter again in light of the first. Sometimes the earlier letter would never arrive at all and she would have to reconstruct it from what the later letter took for granted.

He wrote about the founding of New Bern. The Palatines had landed in April, well ahead of him; the Swiss had come over with him; the site at the river-fork was being cleared. The town would be laid out in the shape of a cross — two main avenues meeting at a central square, building lots assigned by lottery to the families, the river-frontage reserved for warehouses and a small wharf. The land was good. The soil was rich. The climate, in late summer, was hotter than anything he had imagined; the air was heavy with insects he did not have names for; there was a kind of small biting fly that came up from the marshes at sundown and that he had learned to outrun by riding inland for the last hour of daylight. The Palatines were homesick. The Swiss were holding up better. The Tuscarora and the Coree people of the country were polite at present and were trading with the settlers for skins and corn and pots. The Welshman Lawson had been at the site for several weeks helping with the survey and was now gone south to attend to other Lords Proprietors' business. The colony was, in its first weeks, what they had hoped it would be.

He wrote about himself. He was lonely. He was tired. He missed the cloister. He missed her.

He wrote about the colony's future and about hers in it. In a year, perhaps a year and a half, I will have a house standing. I will have the road from the town finished. I will have neighbors of substance — there are several families I am cultivating already, Carolina English and Carolina Swiss together, the kind of

people you will not find tedious. I will send for you the moment it is fit. In a year, perhaps a year and a half. The phrase recurred in his letters through the autumn and into the winter. She marked it. She did not press him on it. She trusted, with the trust of a young woman in love with a man she has not seen in months, that the year-and-a-half would come and would resolve into a ship's berth out of Gravesend with her name on it.

She wrote back. She told him about Wymondley. About her mother. About the rains in November and the early frosts in December. About her cousin George's daughters, the youngest of whom had begun to walk that autumn. About the Wingate aunts at Lockleys, who were watching her closely and who had begun, gently, to suggest that the engagement was a long one and that engagements that went on too long sometimes ended in nothing. About her father, who was well, who sent his regards, who was already speaking of Christopher as a son rather than as a future son-in-law. She did not tell him about the nights she lay awake. She did not tell him about the small careful ways she was beginning to arrange her life for a departure she did not yet know how to imagine. She thought he would think she was being dramatic. He would not have. But she did not yet know that about him.

The winter of 1710 went by.

* * *

Wymondley without him, autumn 1710 to summer 1711

The first year of separation was the easy year. She did not know that at the time.

She rose at six. She dressed. She helped her mother with the household account-book in the mornings; she walked in the priory grounds in the afternoons; she read in the evenings. She wrote her letters on the desk in her bedroom, by the window that looked east toward the cloister yard, in the small clear hand she had learned from her mother's mother. She sealed each letter with the wafer her father bought in Hitchin by the box. She gave the letters to the carter who came up from the village on Mondays and Thursdays and who took them down to Hitchin where they joined the London post.

She received his letters in batches, as they came. Sometimes a packet of three would arrive on a Tuesday morning, all written in the same week in October but having travelled by different routes; sometimes there would be nothing for forty days and she would convince herself, against her own better sense, that he was dead or had forgotten her or had decided, on second thought, that the engagement had been an enthusiasm of April that the long Atlantic had cooled out of him. Then a letter would arrive, addressed in his hand, and she would carry it up to her bedroom and read it twice and put it in the small wooden box at the bottom of her trunk and go back down to the household and the day would continue.

She knew his handwriting now better than she knew her own. He wrote a quick sloping hand with the loops of his y's and g's reaching down into the next line; he abbreviated freely; he made his capital letters with a small flourish at the top that she had decided, after the third letter, was a Swiss thing rather than a personal thing. She had begun to imitate the flourish in her own writing, very slightly, and then had stopped, because she did not want to be a woman who imitated her fiancé's handwriting.

She was twenty-five in the summer of 1711. The age came and went. The cousin George who would inherit the priory was forty-two; his wife had given him three daughters in a row and now appeared to be done; the family male line at Wymondley would, barring a son not yet conceived, end with George. Everyone in the house knew this and no one said it aloud. Barbara, twenty-five and engaged to a man across an ocean, was the family's other open question. If the engagement held, she would go to Carolina and the priory line — the one that came down through her father — would continue there. If the engagement broke, she would be a poor relation at Wymondley for the rest of her life, the spinster daughter of the younger son, kept on out of kindness in a house that was sliding toward its own dissolution.

She did not, in 1711, allow herself to think about the second possibility.

In June a letter came from Carolina that had taken almost six months to cross. He had written it the previous December. I have your letter of August, he wrote, the one about the cousin's youngest beginning to walk. I am glad. I am thinking of her this morning because we had a Swiss child here at the colony who began to walk yesterday and the mother was crying and I was crying with her, which I did not let the father see. We have not had so many easy things here that the easy ones do not get noticed.

It was the first letter he had written in which he had cried.

She did not, when she read it, think anything was wrong. She thought it was a letter from a man who was tired and far from home and who had begun, after eighteen months, to feel the weight of his project. She put it in the box with the others.

In late July a second letter came, which had taken only three months — the packet schedule had improved that summer — written from New Bern in early May. The tone of this letter was different. We have had two deaths, he wrote, both Swiss, both old men, both of fevers I cannot identify. My father is concerned. We have begun to dig a second well at the higher ground; the lower well has been bad since the spring rains. He did not say that the colony was in trouble. He said that two old men had died and that they were digging a new well. He closed the letter as he closed all of them: I think of you every day. I will send for you when it is fit. C.

She put it in the box.

In August a third letter came, written in late June. More fever, he wrote. I am not yet alarmed but I am vigilant. Do not, when you read this, think that the

colony is in any present danger; by the time this reaches you the season will have turned and the fever will have passed. But I want to be honest with you. I am writing to my father separately about the same matter. He said again that she should not, for the time being, plan to come.

She had not been planning to come. She had been waiting for him to send. But the sentence — do not plan to come — rang in her ear in a way the earlier I will send for you when it is fit had not. The earlier sentence had been a promise. The new sentence was a warning. She did not yet understand the difference. She would understand it by Christmas.

* * *

The news turns, summer 1711

She did not get the worst news from him.

She got it, in mid-October, from a London newspaper her uncle brought up from town — a printed sheet of small dense type, four columns to a page, with a short notice on the second page under a heading about American intelligence. The notice said that letters from Charleston of the late summer reported a fever epidemic in the new colony at the river-fork; that Baron de Graffenried's settlement of Palatines and Swiss had been afflicted with the bloody flux and with what the writer called a Carolina fever; that an undetermined number had died; that the colony's chief surveyor, the Welshman Lawson, was missing in the woods; and that the Lords Proprietors had been informed.

Her uncle read the notice aloud at the table after supper, the way he read all the colonial intelligence, and Barbara sat very still in her chair and did not interrupt and waited for him to finish. When he had finished she asked him for the paper. She took it up to her bedroom. She read the notice four times. She lit a second candle. She read it a fifth time.

Then she went down to the kitchen, where the cook was scouring pots, and asked for a cup of warm milk, and the cook gave her one without asking why, and she carried the cup back up to her bedroom and sat on the edge of her bed with the cup in her hands and watched the candles burn down. She did not cry. She did not, that night, allow herself to think about what fever in October meant for a young man in eastern Carolina who had last written to her in June. She thought instead about the cup of milk, which was cooling, and about the cook, who had not asked.

The next morning she wrote to him. She kept the letter short. I have seen the notice from London concerning the fever at New Bern. I am writing to ask only that you tell me, when next you write, that you are well. I do not need any other thing. Only that. — B.

She gave the letter to the carter on Monday.

His next letter, when it came in early December, had been written in early September. It was short. The fever, he wrote, had been bad. They had lost eleven

Swiss, four Palatines, and three of his father's servants, including the old man Hans who had been with the family for thirty years and whom Barbara had heard about in earlier letters. His own household had been spared. He himself had been ill briefly in early August but was now recovered. His father was well. The Welshman Lawson had reappeared from the woods and was at Bath. The autumn rains had come and the fever had abated. He was, he wrote, as well as a man can be who has spent a summer burying people he had hoped to grow old beside. He closed: I do not yet say do not come. I do not yet say come. I am waiting to see what the winter brings before I decide which letter to write you. Forgive me. C.

She read it twice and put it in the box.

A week later, on a cold morning in mid-December with a frost on the cloister grass, she came down for breakfast and found her uncle standing in the great hall with a different newspaper in his hand and a particular look on his face that she had not seen since the day, two years before, when her grandmother had died.

He gave her the paper without speaking. She read the notice.

The Tuscarora, the notice said, had attacked the settlements on the Neuse River in eastern Carolina at the end of September. The casualties were extensive. The Welshman Lawson was confirmed dead, executed by the Tuscarora at a place called Cotechney. Baron de Graffenried was taken prisoner and his fate unknown. The Swiss-Palatine colony at New Bern was reported destroyed. The notice gave no names of survivors. It did not, anywhere in its three printed paragraphs, mention Christopher VI by name.

She read it three times.

Her uncle said, Barbara.

She said, Do not.

She gave him back the paper. She walked out of the hall and across the cloister yard, in her morning gown and no cloak, and stood by the chapel door and looked at the chapel for what felt like a long time and was actually a minute and a half. Then she went back to the house and went up to her bedroom and closed the door and sat on the edge of her bed and waited for whatever was going to happen next inside her chest to happen.

It did not happen, exactly. What happened instead was that she became, for a period of approximately six weeks, a person who got out of bed in the mornings and went down to breakfast and sat through the day and went to bed at night, but who was not present in the house in any way that the household could reach. Her mother spoke to her; she answered. Her uncle put a hand on her shoulder at supper; she felt it. Her cousin George brought the new baby in to be admired; she admired it. Inside, she was waiting. She was waiting for a letter in his hand. She was waiting for the second printed notice that would either name him among the dead or name him among the survivors. She was waiting to know whether the rest of her life was the life that began with a wedding in Carolina or the life that began with widowhood-without-marriage in a Hertfordshire priory whose male line was running out under her feet.

The letter came on the fourth of February, 1712.

It was in his hand. The wax was his wax. The seal was his seal. She carried it up to her bedroom before she opened it because she did not want to be watched while she read it.

I am alive, it began. I was not at New Bern when the attack came. I was south, at Bath, with Lawson, the day before he started up the Neuse to his death. I have been in Virginia these three months with Governor Spotswood, who has been negotiating my father's release. My father is alive but ill, and is now with me at Williamsburg. The colony is destroyed. The Palatines who survived are scattered. I do not yet know what we can save. — I will write you again when there is news that is not all of it bad. I am sorry to have made you wait so long for this letter. There was no way to send it sooner. C.

She read it twice. She put it on the desk under the candle. She put her head down on her arms on the desk and for the first time since October she cried — not for him, because he was alive, but for the previous six weeks and the woman she had been during them, who had become someone she did not entirely recognize and who, she suspected, would never entirely go away.

When she had stopped crying she put the letter in the box at the bottom of her trunk with the others. The box was getting full.

She did not yet know that the worst news of the engagement was still ahead of her. She thought, that February morning, that the worst was behind. She would have, in the spring, two more relatively easy months — months in which she wrote to him often, in which his letters from Williamsburg arrived with reassuring regularity, in which the family at Wymondley began cautiously to speak again of the eventual marriage as something that might still happen — before the second blow fell, this one from inside the house.

* * *

The Tuscarora aftermath, spring 1712

The spring of 1712 was, in its surface details, a normal spring at the priory.

The lambs came in March. The orchard flowered in April. The cloister grass came up green. The chapel bell, which had been recast in 1595 and had hung over six generations of Wymondley Nedhams, rang at compline through the lengthening evenings. Barbara wrote letters in the mornings and walked in the priory grounds in the afternoons and sat with her mother in the evenings, and the household around her began, slowly, to lower its voice when speaking of Carolina, the way a household lowers its voice around a convalescent.

The letters from Christopher came more regularly that spring. He was at Williamsburg, in the Governor's circle, working with Spotswood on the practicalities of what could be salvaged from the colony. His father was recovering from the captivity but was not himself. The Baron had been held by the Tuscarora for several weeks in difficult conditions, had watched Lawson executed

in front of him, had been released only when Spotswood had threatened reprisals against the Tuscarora settlements in Virginia; he had come out of the captivity an older man than he had gone in. Christopher wrote about him with a tenderness Barbara had not seen in the earlier letters. He is sixty-one and looks seventy. He sleeps badly. He does not eat. He is going home to Switzerland in the spring of next year, I think, as soon as we can get the colony's accounts in a state he can leave behind. I will stay. There is no one else to stay.

He stopped, in the spring letters, telling her not to come. He also stopped, in the spring letters, telling her when he would send for her. The phrase in a year, perhaps a year and a half had vanished from the correspondence sometime in the summer of 1711 and had not returned. What had taken its place was a careful silence — long descriptions of the practical work, of the people he was meeting at Williamsburg, of the small recoveries the colony was making — and around the silence, the unspoken thing, which was that the colony was not going to be a place for a wife in 1712 or 1713 or possibly ever.

She read the silence. She did not press him on it. She trusted that he would tell her, when he could, what came next.

What came next, she did not yet know, was nothing — or rather, was an extension of the not-yet that had been the engagement's whole condition since the cloister conversation two years before. He would not, in 1712, write the letter telling her to come. He would not, in 1713, write it either. He would write love letters; he would write practical letters; he would write descriptions of Williamsburg in autumn and of the Carolina coast in winter and of the Tuscarora prisoners coming through on their way to be sold south to the Charleston traders; he would write about everything except the one thing she was waiting to be told. The Baron sailed for Switzerland in April 1713. Christopher stayed. The colony continued in its half-life. The letters continued to come.

She was, in the summer of 1712, twenty-six years old.

In June her aunt Margaret, the elder of the two Wingate aunts at Lockleys, came up to Wymondley for a fortnight. She brought a proposal with her. There was a widower in Bedfordshire — a Cordwell of Sandy, fifty-three years old, three grown children, a comfortable competence, recently bereaved and looking — who had let it be known through the Wingate cousinship that he would receive favorably an introduction to Miss Nedham of Wymondley. The aunt put it forward with the careful neutrality of a woman who was not herself proposing the match but who was, in her own quiet way, very strongly proposing the match.

Barbara listened. She thanked her aunt for the consideration. She said no.

The aunt said: Think about it for a week.

Barbara said: I have thought about it for two years. The answer is the same.

The aunt did not press further. She left Wymondley after the fortnight without raising the subject again. But Barbara understood, watching the aunt's chaise turn out of the gatehouse, that something had shifted in the family's calculation. The aunt had not come up of her own initiative. The aunt had been sent. Someone

— possibly her uncle, possibly her cousin, possibly the Wingate aunts collectively — had decided that two years was long enough and that the engagement to a colonial widower-in-waiting was, after the Tuscarora War, no longer a credible plan. The Cordwell of Sandy had been the family's first move. There would be others.

She wrote to her father in Bedfordshire — Maurice was visiting his Wingate-side relations at Lockleys that month — and told him about the conversation. She asked him to write to the aunts. She asked him to make it clear, in his own hand, that the engagement to Christopher held and that the family was not to make further such proposals.

He wrote the letter. He wrote it in his careful old-fashioned hand, with the long s's that he still used at sixty-three. He sent it to Lockleys and a copy to her uncle at Wymondley. The aunts received it. Her uncle received it. The proposals stopped, for the rest of the summer.

In November Maurice came home from Lockleys for the winter. He had been at Lockleys longer than usual that year — almost five months — because there was sickness in the house at Lockleys and he had stayed to be useful, as he always did, for people who were not quite his own and had never quite been anyone else's either. He arrived at Wymondley on the third of November in a hired chaise, looking, Barbara thought, smaller than she remembered. He had been thinning for several years; she had not allowed herself to notice. That November she noticed.

He took to bed on the seventh. The fever came on the tenth. The Hitchin physician was sent for and pronounced the case difficult but not desperate. The fever stayed for nine days. He died on the cold week before Advent, on the nineteenth of November, with Barbara holding his hand and her mother on the other side of the bed and her uncle standing in the doorway because the room was too small for three watchers and he could not bring himself to leave.

He was sixty-four years old. He was buried in the chancel of the priory church, four days later, in the same row where his father George Senior had been buried in 1679 and his grandfather Eustace in 1658. The chapel was full. The Hitchin curate read the burial service. Barbara stood at the front of the family party, in the black gown that had been her grandmother's and had been altered for her, and did not weep at the graveside, because she had wept the previous night and had decided, against her own grief, that she would not weep where the household could see her.

She wept again that night in her bedroom, with the door closed, until the candle burned down and the chapel bell rang midnight and she could not weep any longer.

The next morning she came down to breakfast and the household went on.

* * *

After Maurice, December 1712 into 1713

The household went on, but the household was different.

Her mother, widowed at fifty-six, did not stay at the priory.

The Wingate aunts came up from Lockleys before Christmas to fetch her down, and it is worth being exact about who they were, because Barbara had never once been exact about it and neither had anyone else in that house. They were not Lettice's aunts. They were not Lettice's anything. They were the Lockleys women — the kin of Frances Wingate, who had been Eustace's second wife and Maurice's step-grandmother and had been dead for forty years — and their claim on the widow of Maurice Nedham was a claim of no blood whatsoever. They came because there was nobody else to come. Lettice had no people. She had never had any people. In thirty years at Wymondley not one soul had ever arrived at that gatehouse asking for her by her own name, and now that her husband was in the chancel floor the women of her husband's step-grandmother's family got into a chaise and drove up from Welwyn to collect her, because a gentlewoman of fifty-six with no jointure and no natal cousinage cannot simply be left in a house that belongs to her nephew.

She would live at Lockleys the way widowed gentlewomen in this country had always lived — with kindness, in a back bedroom, useful where she could be useful, deferring on questions of the household to a woman younger than herself, kept by family because she had nowhere else to be kept. Except that it was not her family. It was the family of a woman who had married into the priory eighty years before and had no more to do with Letisia Bowyer than the road between the two houses did.

Lettice did not want to go. Lettice went. The Wingate aunts took the matter into their own hands with a firmness that did not, in the moment, brook discussion, and there was no one on the other side of the question to discuss it with.

Barbara watched her mother get into the chaise on the morning of the twenty-third of December with the small trunk that contained the things she had decided to keep and the larger box that contained the things she had decided to send on ahead of her, and the chaise turned out of the gatehouse and down toward the Welwyn road, and Lettice was gone.

Barbara stood in the arch until it was out of sight. She was twenty-seven that December. It did not occur to her, then, to wonder why her mother was being taken in by her father's people, and it would not occur to her for a long time afterward, and by the time it did she would be on the other side of an ocean and there would be no one left to ask.

Barbara, twenty-seven that December, was now a woman without a father in a house that belonged to her cousin.

The cousin George was a good man. He had always been a good man. He had treated Barbara, since she was a child, as something between a younger sister

and a fond niece; his wife Anne had been kind to her in the practical ways the wives of householders are kind to unmarried female relations. None of this changed. The cousin's kindness did not change. The cousin's wife's kindness did not change. What changed was that Barbara's position in the household, which had been the position of daughter of the late Maurice, fiancée to the Swiss baron's son, future mistress of a Carolina estate, was now the position of poor relation in someone else's house, engaged for two and a half years to a man who has not sent for her, of an age at which the engagement may not resolve.

The cousin did not say this. The cousin's wife did not say this. The household did not say this. It hung in the air around Barbara, that winter and the following spring, in the way unspoken things hang in households — in the slight adjustment of who was seated where at dinner, in the gentle inquiries from the aunts about whether she might consider a season in London, in the way the family began, slowly, to speak of the Carolina engagement in the past tense without quite using the past tense, as if it had become something that had happened to her once rather than something that was still happening.

In March a second proposal came. This one through her uncle, from a connection of his own — a merchant in London, widowed twice, fifty-eight years old, well established in the Levant trade, with a house in Cheapside and a settlement that would have made Barbara a woman of substance for the rest of her life. The uncle put it forward at the supper table one evening, in front of the cousin and the cousin's wife, in the manner of a man who expected the matter to be discussed seriously.

Barbara refused at the table. She did not raise her voice. She did not weep. She said only that her engagement to Christopher held; that she had given her word in April 1710 and would not, in March 1713, take it back; that she would consider no other proposals until and unless the engagement was, by Christopher's own letter, dissolved.

Her uncle said: Barbara. He has not sent for you in three years.

She said: He will when he can.

The uncle did not press further at the table. But that night, after the household had gone to bed, Barbara heard the uncle and the cousin in the cousin's office, with the door closed, talking for what must have been an hour. She did not eavesdrop. She did not need to. She knew what they were saying. She knew also that whatever they decided in that conversation, she would not be able to refuse a third proposal as easily as she had refused the first two. The family was running out of patience with her. The family was running out of patience because the family had begun to believe that she was running out of time.

She wrote to Lockleys the next morning. She wrote to her mother.

The letter was short. She told Lettice about the merchant proposal and about her refusal. She told Lettice about the conversation in the office. She asked her mother to come up to Wymondley, for a fortnight if no longer, because there were

things that needed to be said in a room with the door closed and there were not, at present, three people in Hertfordshire who could say them with her.

Lettice came up at the end of March.

* * *

The mother's visit, April 1713

She came in a hired chaise. She arrived on a wet Tuesday afternoon. She did not bring much with her. She had been at Lockleys five months; she had been a widow five months. She looked, Barbara thought, neither older nor younger than she had looked at her husband's funeral, but she looked smaller, the way Maurice had looked smaller when he came home in November. The Wingate aunts had not aged Lettice. The Wingate aunts had concentrated her.

They sat in Barbara's bedroom — the one Barbara had grown up in, with the writing-desk in the east window — because it was the only room in the house where they could be sure of not being heard. Lettice took the chair by the desk. Barbara sat on the bed. The April rain ran down the diamond panes.

Lettice said: Tell me.

That was all she said. Barbara had been ready for the strategist — the older woman who had lived through her own difficult marriage and her own widowhood and the long cousinage politics of the Wingate aunts and who would, in her quiet way, present Barbara with a reasoned analysis of what to do. The older woman she had been ready for was not the one in the chair. The one in the chair was someone else: a woman with her hands folded in her lap who had said one word and who was now waiting, with the kind of stillness Lettice had used at Maurice's bedside in November, for Barbara to fill the room with her own voice.

Barbara filled it.

She started with the proposals. She told her mother about the Cordwell of Sandy, about the merchant in Cheapside, about the supper-table conversation in March and the night-time conversation in her uncle's office afterward. She told her about the cousin's wife's small adjustments at dinner. She told her about the aunts'

Lockleys campaign that had run all winter and that Lettice had only this morning at the chaise told her about in any detail. (She had not meant to start there. She had meant to start with Christopher. The proposals came out first because the proposals were the surface; she would, in a moment, get to what was underneath.)

She said: They are not wrong, Mama. The cousin is good. The uncle is good. The aunts have meant me kindly in their way. Two years is a long time. Three years is a longer one. The merchant is a respectable man with a settled situation. The Cordwell of Sandy probably is also. If I marry one of them, I will have a life. I will have a house. I will have children. I will have the dignity of a married woman,

which a woman of twenty-seven who has been engaged for three years to a man across an ocean does not, at present, have.

The rain ran down the diamond panes. Lettice did not say anything.

Barbara said: And if I wait. If I keep refusing them. They will keep coming. There will be a third proposal in the summer and a fourth in the autumn and the autumn after that one, and at some point I will be too tired or too lonely or too afraid, and I will accept one of them, and I will write Christopher a letter that begins with the small words a woman uses when she is breaking her word, and I will marry the man and I will live the life. I will be respectable. I will be a Mrs. Somebody at Cheapside or at Sandy and I will have children and I will keep house and I will read the gazettes from Carolina sometimes when the news from there reaches London, and I will know, every time, what the news is costing me, because I will have paid for it already.

(She had not known she had been thinking this. She had been thinking it for two years. She had been keeping it under a stone in the part of her own mind she did not visit.)

Lettice did not say anything.

Barbara said: That is one ending. There is another. He will not send for me, Mama. He has stopped saying he will. He has not said the words I will send for you in any letter since the summer of 1711. The phrase used to be in every letter. It has been gone from every letter for almost two years. He is not going to send. He loves me. He loves me. But he is, in his own mind, protecting me, and he is wrong, and the colony is never going to be ready in the way he means, because the way he means it would require Carolina to be a different country. He is twenty-six years old. He is going to spend the rest of his life there. If I wait, I will wait until he marries some Carolina English girl with a name I will never learn, because he will have finally decided, five years from now, that I have refused him by my silence the way he has refused me by his caution. And I will be at Cheapside.

Her hands were on her knees. She did not remember having put them there.

Lettice did not say anything.

Barbara said: Neither of those is the ending.

(There. She had said it. She had not known she was going to say it; she had said it; she was hearing herself say it; the sentence had come up out of her like a thing that had been growing in the dark for two years and that had now broken the surface of the water, and she could not, having said it, unsay it, and did not want to.)

She said: I am going to him.

The rain on the panes. Lettice's hands in her lap. The candle was lower than it had been a quarter of an hour ago.

She said: I am not going to wait for him to send. He is not going to send. I am going to write him a letter in the summer that says I am coming, do not write back to tell me not to, by the time you read this I will already be at sea. I am going to

give the letter to your London cousin and she is going to put it on the next packet for Charleston. I am going to take a passage out of Gravesend in October. I am going to be at Charleston in February. I am going to find him at Williamsburg or at New Bern or at wherever he is. He will marry me there or he will not. If he marries me, I will have the life I have wanted for three years. If he does not, I will come home and I will take the merchant and I will be no worse off than I am right now. I am going.

(She was speaking faster than she was breathing. She did not stop.)

I am going because I cannot stay. I am going because if I stay I will rot. I am going because I have been waiting for him to be ready and he is not going to be ready and the waiting is going to kill the woman I am before it kills me, and I would rather lose him in Carolina than lose myself in Cheapside, and if he sends me back I will at least know. I am twenty-seven. I have been engaged to him for three years and three months. He told me he would send for me when the colony was ready. The colony is not going to be ready. I am going to make it ready. I am going to be the part of it that is ready. I am going.

She stopped.

She had not known, until she had said it, that the sentence I am going to be the part of it that is ready had been the sentence the last two years had been writing inside her. She heard it after she had said it, the way one hears a bell a second after it has rung. She put a hand briefly to her own mouth. She did not weep. She had wept enough about Christopher already; she would not weep about herself.

Lettice had not moved.

After what may have been a minute and may have been longer, Lettice unfolded her hands. She did not get up from the chair. She did not lean forward. She did not put a hand to her own face or to Barbara's. She looked at her daughter across the small distance of the bedroom — the distance that had been twenty-eight years of mother and daughter, of teaching and watching and hoping and worrying, and that had now, in the last quarter of an hour, become something else, the distance between a woman and another woman who has just become herself — and Lettice said three sentences.

She said: You are not fine here.

She said: He is not fine there.

She said: Go and find out.

That was all. It was the blessing. It was the thing Barbara had not, until this moment, known she had still been waiting to be given, and that Lettice had not, until this moment, known she had still been waiting to give. Barbara understood, hearing it, that her mother had been waiting longer than she had been waiting — that Lettice had been waiting since the cloister conversation in April 1710, waiting for her daughter to come to her own decision so that she, Lettice, could finally release her to it. The waiting was over for both of them at the same moment.

The candle was burning down. Lettice got up from the chair. She put a hand briefly on Barbara's shoulder. She went to the door of the bedroom and turned, with her hand on the latch, and looked back at Barbara on the bed.

She said: Do not believe him when he says he is fine. He is not fine. None of them are. Go and find out.

Then she went out, and down the corridor to the guest room where the cousin's wife had laid out a fire for her, and she did not speak of the conversation again for the rest of her visit.

Lettice went back to Lockleys after a fortnight.

Barbara stayed.

She did not write the letter at once. She thought about it for two months. She walked the priory grounds in April and May; she sat at the writing-desk in the east window of her bedroom; she watched the cloister grass green again; she watched her cousin's youngest daughter, the one she had described to Christopher three years before as having begun to walk, now run across the cloister yard with a stick and stop and turn and run back. She read Christopher's letters out of the box in her trunk, in order this time, from April 1710 forward, all of them, all forty-one of them as they had come to her in the three years since the cloister conversation. She read them slowly. She read them again. She put them back in the box.

She wrote the letter in the first week of August.

* * *

The letter, August 1713

She wrote it in the morning, at the desk in the east window, on a clean sheet of the good paper her uncle bought in Hitchin. She did not draft it. She did not need to. She had been composing it in her head for three months and what was left to do, that August morning, was only to put it down.

She had, in her head, written it long. She had composed paragraphs. (She had composed, in the small hours of the previous nights, a careful explanatory letter — three pages of it — that began with a salutation and laid out the reasoning and named the ship and gave the date of expected arrival and closed with a courteous and explanatory and apologetic and loving signature, and that did, in the composition, all of the work a letter of this kind was conventionally required to do.)

She uncapped the inkwell.

She picked up the quill.

She dipped it.

She held it over the paper for what may have been ten seconds.

(The three pages were in her head. She knew them. She could have written them out without thinking. What stopped her, the quill in her hand and the morning light on the paper and the cloister visible through the window-glass

green with August, was that the three pages — the explanations, the apologies, the careful naming of the ship — were the same three pages that the Barbara of the previous April would have written. The Barbara of the previous April had not yet been in the room with her mother. The Barbara of the previous April had still been a woman who owed Christopher an explanation. The Barbara who was now sitting at the desk in the east window did not owe Christopher an explanation. She owed him an arrival.)

She wrote three words.

I am coming.

That was all.

She did not sign it. She did not date it. She did not write a salutation. She read the three words on the page and they sat in the centre of the otherwise blank sheet, in her own small clear hand, with no flourishes and no underlines, and she understood — the way she had understood the day before yesterday at the writing-desk that I am going to be the part of it that is ready had been the sentence the last two years had been writing inside her — that the three words were what the three pages had been trying to say all along. The three pages had been the surface.

The three words were what was left when the surface burned off.

She folded the page once.

She folded it once more.

She sealed it with the small Wymondley seal her father had given her on her sixteenth birthday — the one with the priory tower and the date 1700 — and she pressed the seal carefully so that the priory tower came out clean. She put the letter in her pocket.

Two days later, when the carter came up from the village on Monday, she gave him the letter and a half-crown and asked him to take it to the London road and to put it into the hand of the next coach guard headed south, with the half-crown for the man's trouble, and to tell the guard that it was to go on the Wingate packet for Charleston — the next one, whichever one — and not to wait. The carter took the letter and the half-crown and asked no questions, because the carter had been carrying her letters for three years and had long ago decided that whatever was in them was none of his business.

The London cousin had been told to expect it. She had been told by Lettice in May, in the careful way Lettice told things, that a letter might come that summer and that if it came it was to go on the next Charleston packet without waiting and without inquiry. The London cousin received Barbara's letter at her house in the Pool of London on the morning of the seventh of August. She read it in five seconds. She put it into a fair-paper envelope addressed to a captain of her husband's acquaintance who was loading for Carolina that week, and she sent it down to the Customs House by her own boy, and the letter sailed out of Gravesend on the tenth of August on a brigantine called the Mary Anne and was,

by the end of that day, in the Channel, headed west on a freshening wind toward the Atlantic.

The London cousin did not write to Barbara to confirm. She wrote, instead, to Lettice at Lockleys. The letter has gone, she wrote. Tell her, when next you see her, that her passage on the packet Hopewell, out of Gravesend on the twenty-eighth of October, has been booked under her own name. The captain is a man my late husband sailed with twice and is a person I trust with this. The fare is paid. She is to be at the Pool of London by the twentieth, at my house, and I will see her down to Gravesend myself. Tell her also that I am glad. — Anne Lettice carried the letter up to Wymondley the next week. She read it aloud to Barbara in the bedroom. Barbara nodded. She did not say anything for a moment. Then she said: Thank her, when next you write.

Lettice said: I will.

Barbara said: Tell her also that I am glad.

Lettice did. The letters of the late summer of 1713 between Wymondley and Lockleys and Cheapside contained, by the standards of the eighteenth-century English provincial post, an unusual proportion of single-sentence acknowledgments. None of the three women felt the need to elaborate. They had been waiting three years for something to happen. Something had now happened. There was very little, between them, that required further explanation.

The packet Hopewell was a hundred-and-seventy-ton brigantine, eight years old, with a regular Charleston run and a captain — a Mr. Eldridge — who had been at the trade since the South Sea fever and who was, the London cousin reported, sober and competent and trustworthy with female passengers. The ship would sail on the tide of the twenty-eighth of October. Barbara would board on the twenty-seventh, in the late afternoon, after a night's rest at the London cousin's house in the Pool. She would be in Charleston, weather permitting, by the early days of February.

She had ten weeks to pack.

* * *

The night before

She had packed the trunk twice.

The first time was for the practical winter at sea — the two wool gowns, the linens, the shoes with the buckles that would not rust through, the small things her cousin's wife had given her without being asked because her cousin's wife, at least, had not tried to stop her. The second time was after the house had gone to bed, when she opened the trunk again in the candlelight and took out the heavier of the two gowns and put in instead a length of fine linen her mother had folded into a press fifteen years ago for the trousseau Barbara had not yet had.

Her father was eighteen months in the chapel floor.

She closed the trunk and sat on the edge of her bed and put her hands flat on her knees and listened to the priory at night. The chapel below her was silent — compline had been an hour ago. The wind was in the cloister, the way it always was in October. Somewhere in the east range her cousin George's youngest was crying again, the autumn fever still not broken. She had grown up inside the sound of that wind and the sound of the chapel bell and the sound of children sick in the east range, and after tomorrow she would never hear any of it again.

She thought of the letter.

Not the one she had written to him in August, the one in her own bad handwriting — she had cried while writing it and the page was buckled — the one she had folded and sealed and given to the carter the next morning saying I am coming. Three words. No salutation. No signature. No date. That letter was somewhere west of the Azores by now, riding the gulf stream toward Carolina in the hold of a packet she would never see. She did not know if he had read it. She did not know if he was alive.

She thought instead of his last letter, the one she had received in late August, the one she had read eleven times — she had counted, the way she had counted everything for three years, the weeks, the ships, the silences — the letter in which he had told her again, with the patient gentleness she had come to hate because it was the only thing standing between her and him, that the colony was not yet safe and that he loved her and that he would send for her and that he begged her to wait.

She would not wait.

She was twenty-eight years old. She had been engaged to him for three years and six months. The Wymondley male line was failing — her cousin George had three daughters and no son, the priory would be out of the family within a generation, everyone in the house knew it and no one said it out loud — and she herself had become, in the long aftermath of her father's death the autumn before last, a woman with no place. Her aunt had offered her a Bedfordshire widower the summer before. Her uncle had offered her a London merchant in March. She had refused them both with a kind of cold serenity that had frightened her aunt and outraged her uncle and that she herself had not quite understood until the night she sat down at the writing-desk in this room with a clean sheet of paper and wrote I am coming, and understood, as she sealed it, that the decision had been made for two years and that she had only been waiting for her own permission to act on it.

The candle was burning down. She did not light another.

She thought of her mother. Lettice was at Lockleys, among her husband's Wingate cousins, where she had gone after Maurice died — widowed at fifty-six, taken in by a family that was not hers the way widowed women in this country were always taken in by family, which is to say with kindness and with a hundred small reminders that the kindness was a gift. Lettice had not tried to stop her. Lettice had said, in the April week when she came up from Lockleys to say what

she had come to say, only one thing of any real weight: do not believe him when he says he is fine. He is not fine. None of them are. Go and find out.

That had been the permission Barbara had been waiting for, though she had not known it at the time.

In the morning the carter came for the trunk and she went down to the priory yard and her cousin's wife handed her a small parcel — what was in it has not survived but Barbara would carry it for the rest of her life — and she got into the cart and she did not look back at the priory as it rode away from her and she did not cry until the cart was past the gatehouse and out on the Hitchin road.

Then she cried for the length of the road to Hitchin.

She stopped before the cart entered the town, because she would not be seen weeping by strangers, and she pressed her hands flat against her face until the heat in her eyes went down, and she sat up straight and she put her hands back in her lap and she did not weep again until she was on the open ocean three weeks later and the English coast was a thin gray line behind her and the wind smelled of salt and she understood, for the first time, what she had done.

She was on the London road by nightfall.

She slept at an inn at Welwyn that she had not slept at before and would not sleep at again, and rose at six and was at the Pool of London by mid-afternoon on the twenty-fifth of October, in the rain, and the London cousin met her at the dock with an umbrella and a small dry warm voice that was the first kindness Barbara had received from a stranger in some weeks and that made her, briefly, want to cry again. She did not cry. She thanked the cousin. The cousin took her up to the house in Wapping. The two of them sat together in the small parlor by the river and ate a supper of cold chicken and apples and very weak wine, and the cousin told her what she would need to know about Mr. Eldridge and the Hopewell and the Channel crossing and the open Atlantic and what to ask the captain for and what not to bother the captain about, and Barbara listened and made small careful notes in the back of her commonplace book in pencil, and at nine o'clock the cousin took her up to the small front bedroom on the second floor and pointed out the bell-pull and the chamber-pot and the basin and the candle and the spare blanket, and went back downstairs, and Barbara sat on the edge of the bed in the spare bedroom of a London house she had never been in before, in the middle of the city she had not lived in since a brief stretch as a girl, and put her hands flat on her knees, the way she had sat on the edge of her own bed at Wymondley two nights before, and listened to the city outside the window — the boat-bells, the rain, the men on the river, the things she had not grown up inside the sound of — and understood that the priory was now behind her in a way that it had not been in any of the previous twenty-eight years of her life.

She slept for six hours. She did not dream.

On the twenty-seventh in the late afternoon she went down to Gravesend in the cousin's hired chaise and boarded the Hopewell, with her trunk and her small bag and her commonplace book and the parcel her cousin's wife had given her in

the priory yard three mornings before. Mr. Eldridge met her at the rail. He was a square-built man of fifty-some, weathered, sober, courteous in the careful way provincial sea-captains were courteous to passengers above their station. He showed her the cabin she would have — a small one, eight feet by six, with a fixed bunk and a narrow table and a sea-chest under the bunk — and told her the tide would turn at first light and that she should sleep if she could and that they would be in the Channel by midday. He left her alone with her trunk and her bag.

She did not unpack. She sat on the bunk with her hands flat on her knees and listened to the brigantine creak around her and the river slap against the hull and the voices of the watch on the deck above, and she did not, in that moment, think of Christopher, or of Wymondley, or of her mother at Lockleys, or of the letter that was somewhere off the coast of Carolina by now riding south on the gulf stream. She thought, instead, of nothing — a careful, deliberate nothing, the way she had thought of nothing on the morning after the Tuscarora notice in December 1711, the way she had thought of nothing on the morning after her father's funeral in November 1712. It was the kind of thinking she had learned to do when she was waiting for the next thing to happen.

In the morning the tide turned and the Hopewell dropped down the river on the ebb and stood out into the Channel by midday, and Barbara stood at the stern rail in her wool cloak with her hood up and watched the English coast move from a near thing to a middle thing to a distant thing, over the course of three days, and on the third afternoon, in a freshening westerly off the Lizard, the coast became a thin gray line and then it became nothing at all, and the wind smelled of salt, and she understood, for the first time, what she had done.

She stood at the rail until the cold drove her below. She did not weep. She had wept enough for one autumn. She went down to the cabin and lit the small lamp and opened her commonplace book and wrote, in pencil, at the top of a fresh page: Hopewell at sea, off the Lizard.

The English coast gone behind us. The wind westerly and stiff. Mr. Eldridge says ten weeks to Charleston if the weather holds. I have begun.

She put the book away. She blew out the lamp. She lay down in the bunk and pulled the blanket over her and listened to the Atlantic begin under her.

Three weeks ahead of her, four thousand miles west across the same water, the letter she had written in August was riding the gulf stream south-by-southwest in the hold of a brigantine called the Mary Anne, in a small leather pouch lashed to a beam beside the captain's berth, the priory seal still warm-coloured on the reverse where the page had been folded against itself since the seventh of August. The letter would reach Charleston in mid-November. From Charleston it would be carried inland by a runner named Wilkes who had been paid in advance by the de Graffenried factor for any de Graffenried correspondence that wanted carrying inland. The letter would arrive in Christopher's hand on the seventeenth of November at New Bern, on a Tuesday,

in the late afternoon, with the cold light already going out of the river behind his half-built house.

He would open it.

He would unfold the sheet.

He would read what she had written.

I am coming.

Chapter 6 — Two Letters Crossing

New Bern, mid-November 1713

The letter came on the seventeenth of November, on a Tuesday, in the late afternoon, with the cold light already going out of the river behind the half-built house.

It came in a leather pouch with three other letters and a small canvas-wrapped packet from his father in Switzerland, brought up the Neuse from Bath by a runner who had been paid in advance by the Charleston factor for any de Graffenried correspondence that arrived on the Mary Anne or her sister packets and that wanted carrying inland. The runner was a thin man named Wilkes who had done this kind of work for the colony since its founding, who had watched the Tuscarora War unfold from a distance of fifty miles south and had not himself been touched by it, and who handed the pouch to Christopher's manservant Hans at the kitchen door of the half-built house and asked, in the practical way of men who get paid by the delivery, whether there was a reply to be carried back.

Hans took the pouch. He thanked Wilkes. He gave the man a cup of cider from the jug on the kitchen table and told him there would be no reply at present and that Mr. Christopher was at the river-end of the south field looking at the new survey-stakes the chainmen had set that morning, and that if Wilkes wanted to wait an hour the master would surely come back for supper and might have a reply by then. Wilkes shrugged in his careful way and said he had two more deliveries on the upper Neuse and would not wait. He drank the cider in three swallows. He set the cup down. He went.

Hans put the pouch on the table in the room Christopher used as his office — the one with the wide window facing south toward the river and the small writing-desk Christopher had built himself the previous spring out of pine from the south timberlot — and went back to the kitchen to set out the supper. He did not open the pouch. He never opened the pouch. The pouch was Mr. Christopher's.

Christopher came in from the south field at half past five.

He was tired. He had been on his feet since first light. The chainmen had set the survey-stakes in the wrong line by about thirty feet and the whole afternoon had been spent walking the line back to the river-bank with the senior of the two chainmen and a length of marked rope, finding the original stake from August that had been knocked down by a fallen oak in the storm of October, and re-setting the survey from there. The error was the chainmen's; the consequence was Christopher's. He would have to write to his father about the delay. He would have to write to the Carolina Land Office about the revised plat. He would have to ride to New Bern town in the morning to get the assistant surveyor to come up and witness the new line. (Three letters and a ride. The price of one fallen oak in October. He filed it, in his practical mind, alongside the other prices the colony had charged him over the past year, and he did not, walking up from the field with

his coat over his arm, allow himself to be discouraged by the running total. He had stopped allowing himself that particular indulgence in the spring of 1712. The colony cost what the colony cost. He paid.)

He came up to the house through the kitchen yard. Hans had a cup of warmed cider waiting for him at the kitchen door, the way Hans always did when he had been in the cold field after sundown. Christopher took it. He thanked Hans in German because his mind was still in the field and Hans's German was the language he could think in when he was tired. Hans said: Mr. Wilkes came from Bath. There is a pouch in your office.

Christopher said: From Charleston?

Hans said: From Charleston.

Christopher took the cider with him into the office.

The pouch was on the desk where Hans always put pouches, square in the middle of the worn pine surface, the leather a little damp from the autumn ride. Christopher set the cider down on the corner of the desk and untied the cord and took the contents out one by one and laid them in a row across the desk, the way he had been taught at Yverdon to handle a quantity of new correspondence — most pressing first, least pressing last, the row arranged so that you could see at a glance the whole day's work.

The packet from his father went on the far left. He knew his father's hand at twenty paces; he did not have to read the direction. The packet was thick. It would be the November accounts and a letter and probably an enclosure or two; he would open it last, when he had eaten, because his father's letters required a quiet head.

Three other items remained. A folded sheet from the Lords Proprietors' Carolina office at Charleston — a printed circular, by the look of the seal — went next. He did not need to open it tonight. A letter from Spotswood at Williamsburg, in the Governor's careful upright hand, went third. That one he would open after supper. It would be about the Tuscarora prisoners or about the boundary commission or about money, and any of those could wait an hour.

The fourth letter he did not recognize.

It was a single folded sheet, sealed with red wax, the seal a small device he had to angle to the window-light to read — a tower, and a date. 1700. He turned it over and read the direction. Christopher de Graffenried, Esq., at New Bern in Carolina, by the hand of the Charleston factor. The hand was a woman's. It was a hand he had not seen on the outside of a letter in nearly three months, because the last letter from her had come at the end of August, and he had assumed the next would not come until December. (He had been keeping the count, the way he kept the count of everything. Forty-two letters in three years and seven months. The forty-third had been due, by his rough estimate, somewhere in the first half of December. This one was three weeks early.)

He sat down on the chair behind the desk.

He did not, at first, open it. He looked at it for what may have been thirty seconds. (Something in the leather pouch had bothered him as he had laid the items out and he had not, in the moment, identified what it was; now, looking at the letter in his hand, he understood. The letter was thin. Barbara's letters had never, in three years, been thin. They had always been three pages or four or five, written close in her small clear hand, sometimes with crossings on the back of the last page because she had had more to say than the paper would hold. This letter was one sheet folded once. The folded sheet had a weight to it that suggested almost nothing inside. Something was wrong.)

He broke the seal.

He unfolded the sheet.

The light from the window was getting low and he had to turn the page slightly to catch what light there was.

There were three words.

That was all.

The three words sat in the middle of the otherwise blank page, in her small clear hand, with no salutation and no date and no signature, the wax of the priory seal still warm-coloured on the reverse where the page had been folded against itself for the three months it had been crossing the Atlantic.

I am coming.

He read them.

He read them again.

He read them a third time because his mind had not yet decided what the three words meant and his eyes were running over them looking for the rest of the letter that was not there.

(There was no rest of the letter. The three words were the letter.)

He sat very still in the chair behind the desk.

The first thing he felt was not joy. The first thing he felt was a kind of cold all the way down the front of his body from his throat to his stomach, the cold a man feels when something he has been bracing for has arrived and he is, in the first instant, not yet able to identify whether the thing that has arrived is what he feared or what he hoped. He could not tell. He sat with the page in his hand and the cold going down through him and waited for his mind to catch up to what his hands already knew.

Then the joy came.

It came up from somewhere in his chest he had not known about, a place that had apparently been there for three and a half years waiting for a sentence to arrive that would unlock it, and the place opened, and the joy went up through him in a single wave that reached his throat and stopped there. He did not weep. He did not laugh. He sat with the page in his hand and the joy in his throat and the cold still on the front of his body and the two sensations did not contradict each other; they sat together, in the same chair, in the same man, in the same minute. He understood — sitting there, holding her three words — that he had been

refusing to let himself want her to come for three years, and that the refusal had been a kind of dying he had not registered as dying, and that what was happening now in his throat was not an emotion that had been waiting to happen but an emotion that had been preventing itself from happening, and that the prevention was now over, and that the joy underneath the prevention had three and a half years of compression in it, and that this was why his throat could not contain it.

He let out a breath he did not remember having held.

(She had said it. She had said the thing he had been telling himself, in his more honest moments since the summer of 1711, that she would never say. She had said it the way she would say it. Three words. No salutation. No argument. The seal of her father's priory on the reverse. He could see her at the writing-desk in the east window of her bedroom. He could see her hand. He could see the small flourish she always made on the I. She had written the words in the morning probably; the ink had set clean; the page was unblotted. She had written them and folded them and sealed them and given them to the carter on the same day. He knew her well enough to know all of this from the page in his hand.)

She had said it. Then — (Then came the second thing.)

— and the cold on the front of his body, which had been receding, came back and went all the way down through him and into the chair, because his practical mind had now caught up to his throat and his practical mind was asking, in the precise voice it used when it had identified a problem he had not yet seen, when did she write this?

He looked at the page.

There was no date.

He looked at the page again.

There was no date.

(There was no date. The letter had no date. The letter had no salutation, no signature, no closing — and no date. He had three words on a page in his hand and he did not know whether she had written them four months ago or four weeks ago.

The seal was warm-coloured on the reverse the way wax is warm-coloured after a few months in a leather pouch, but he could not, with the precision a practical man wanted, distinguish three months from five months from seven from the colour of the wax. The letter could have been written in July or August. The letter could have been written in September. The letter could have been written in October — although October was unlikely because the Mary Anne sailed in August and the next packet had been the Hopewell in late October and if she had taken passage on the Hopewell then the letter would have come with her rather than before her, unless she had sent it ahead, which she might have done if —) He stopped.

He put the page flat on the desk.

He put both hands flat on either side of the page.

He looked at the page and he did the calculation aloud, in the careful French he used when he needed to think with his father even though his father was four thousand miles away on the other side of an ocean and an alpine range.

Si elle a écrit ceci au début d'août, he said, in the room with no one in it but Hans's small grey cat watching from the door, — et si le bateau était la Mary Anne, qui a navigué le dix août — alors la lettre est partie d'Angleterre il y a trois mois et demi. Le voyage prend dix à douze semaines. La lettre est donc arrivée à Charleston vers la mi-novembre. C'est aujourd'hui le dix-sept novembre. La lettre est arrivée. Cela est cohérent.

Mais — Mais si elle a écrit cela en août, alors elle a sans doute pris la Hopewell qui a quitté Gravesend fin octobre. Et donc elle est en mer en ce moment. Elle est en mer en ce moment. Elle est en mer maintenant. Cela fait — trois semaines. Trois semaines en mer. Elle a encore — sept, huit, neuf semaines de mer devant elle. Elle arrivera à Charleston vers la mi-janvier. Vers la fin janvier. Au début de février au plus tard.

He stopped speaking.

(He had calculated. The calculation was the kind of thing his mind did with the materials it had. The calculation was almost certainly right. She had written the letter in early August. She had given it to her London cousin. The cousin had put it on the Mary Anne. The Mary Anne *had sailed on the tenth. The letter had crossed in three months. Meanwhile Barbara herself had spent September packing. Meanwhile she had spent October travelling to London and to Gravesend. Meanwhile she had boarded the Hopewell in the last week of October. Meanwhile she had stood at the stern rail off the Lizard sometime in the first week of November and watched the English coast become a thin gray line and then nothing. Meanwhile he had been at the south field of his colony, walking the survey line, thinking she was at Wymondley.*) (She had been on the water for three weeks. She had eight weeks more.)

(He had eight weeks.)

He stood up from the chair.

He sat back down.

He stood up again because the chair was no longer the right place to be sitting in.

He went to the window and looked out at the south field, which was now in full dark, and put a hand on the cool pane and stayed there for what may have been a minute. (Eight weeks. Eight weeks to do what. Eight weeks to ride to Charleston. Eight weeks to arrange lodging. Eight weeks to send a letter to his father that could not possibly reach Bern before — could not reach Bern at all, in any practical sense, before the marriage. Eight weeks to write to Spotswood at Williamsburg requesting leave. Eight weeks to settle the colony's affairs at New Bern. Eight weeks. Eight weeks.)

The grey cat came in and sat on his foot.

He picked it up. He held it against his chest the way he had held the teacup with both hands when he was twenty-three at Wymondley and Barbara had filed the gesture away as a thing about him she would remember. He did not know she had filed it away. He did not know she had remembered. He held the cat in the dark room with the three words on the desk behind him and his father's unopened packet next to the three words and the unread circulars from Charleston next to that, and he thought, in a voice that was no longer the practical French of the calculation but the smaller and older German of the kitchen at Yverdon when he had been a small boy listening to his nurse, *sie kommt. Sie kommt. Sie kommt.*

She is coming.

He went back to the desk. He sat down. He put the page back in the centre of the desk. He put his elbows on either side of it. He put his face in his hands.

He did not weep, because the joy and the panic had cancelled each other out and what was left was a kind of clear cold attention that he recognized from the months after the Tuscarora attack, the attention he used when something very large had to be done and there was no one else to do it.

He stayed like that for some minutes.

Then he got up. He picked up the page with the three words. He folded it. He put it in the inside pocket of his coat. He went out of the office and down the corridor to the kitchen, where Hans was setting out the cold supper, and he said, in German, very calmly, *I am going to Charleston. I am going on Friday. We have three days. Pack me for ten weeks.*

Hans put down the bread.

Hans said: Yes, Mr. Christopher.

Hans did not ask why. Hans did not ask whether the master was well. Hans had been with Christopher for six years; Hans had watched Christopher walk into a Tuscarora ambush and walk out alive; Hans knew the difference between an emergency and a decision, and Hans knew that the master's voice was the voice of a decision.

Christopher said: And Hans — Hans said: Yes.

Christopher said: — she is coming.

Hans looked at him for a moment. Then Hans smiled, which was something Hans almost never did, and said: Well. It is about time.

Christopher went back to the office.

He sat down at the desk.

He took out a clean sheet of paper. He uncapped the inkwell. He picked up the quill. He held it in his hand for a moment and looked at the blank page and did not yet know what he was going to write or to whom, because there were perhaps fifteen people he needed to write to in the next three days and the question was which of them came first.

His father came first.

He dipped the quill.

He wrote: Père — and then he stopped, because his eyes had gone wet without his permission and the Père on the page in front of him was already blurred at the edge, and he had to put the quill down and put both palms flat on the desk and wait for the wet in his eyes to recede before he could continue.

(She is coming. She is coming. Père, she is coming. The woman I have been refusing to want for three years and seven months is on the water. She will be at Charleston in eight weeks. I am leaving on Friday. I do not yet know what I am going to do when she lands, but whatever it is, I will be there to do it.)

He did not write any of that.

He waited until his eyes were clear and he wrote, in the careful French he used with his father, the practical letter the practical man was capable of writing tonight, which began with the date and the place and the apology for the unexpectedness of the news and which laid out the calculation he had done aloud to the grey cat ten minutes earlier and which closed with the request for his father's blessing on the marriage that would, if all things held, take place at Charleston in February. The letter took him forty minutes to write. It was the longest letter he had written in nine months. By the time he sealed it the candle had burned down nearly two inches and the grey cat was asleep on the corner of the desk and the three words from Barbara were folded against his ribs inside his coat where he would carry them, by his own quiet decision made over the course of the writing, for the rest of his life.

He went to bed at midnight.

He did not sleep until almost three.

When he slept he dreamed of the cloister at Wymondley in April with the rain on the cloister stones and Barbara in her cloak with her hood down saying something to him he could not, in the dream, quite hear, but which he knew in the dream he would understand if he could only get a little closer to her, which in the dream he was trying to do but could not, because the cloister floor under his feet was the deck of a brigantine and the brigantine was moving and Barbara was on a different brigantine and the two boats were moving in opposite directions across the same gray water.

He woke at six on the eighteenth.

The three words were still in his coat.

She was still on the water.

He had seven weeks and four days.

— — — ## §6.2 — Hopewell, off Bermuda, late November 1713 She was a different woman at sea.

She had not known this about herself until the third week out, when she sat down to write in her commonplace book one morning in the cabin and discovered, looking at the previous week's entries, that the handwriting was different. The letters were rounder. The pressure on the quill was lighter. The hand was the hand of a woman who had not, in twenty-eight years of writing at desks at Wymondley and at Lockleys and at the small school-table her tutor had set up in

the gallery, had a hand quite like this one. The hand at sea was the hand of someone she had not previously been.

She did not know who that woman was.

She was learning.

(She had thought, before sailing, that the crossing would be eight weeks of suspended life — a kind of long held breath between the woman she had been at Wymondley and the woman she would be at Charleston. She had thought she would arrive at Charleston the same person who had left Gravesend, only with the Atlantic crossed and her hair a little flatter from the salt air. She had not anticipated that the crossing itself would be a thing that would happen to her.

The crossing was happening. She was, three weeks in, no longer the woman who had stood at the rail off the Lizard.)

It was late November.

The Hopewell was somewhere north and east of Bermuda — Mr. Eldridge had told her, the previous afternoon, that they had passed the longitude of the island three days ago but had not seen it, the weather having pushed them slightly to the north. They were three weeks out of Gravesend, with seven weeks of open ocean ahead and the Atlantic in the kind of late-autumn mood that the captain described, in his careful provincial way, as unsettled but not contrary. The wind had been from the south-southwest for four days. The sea had been moderate. The mornings had been gray and the afternoons had been a paler gray and the evenings had been the gray of the inside of an oyster shell. There had not been a storm. There had not been any sun. There had been, in their place, the consistent and unspectacular and entirely unfamiliar conditions of a brigantine on the open ocean in late autumn, which she had not in her twenty-eight years of life been prepared for by anything anyone had ever told her about anything.

The other passengers were five.

A Mr. Pelletier from Bristol, going to Charleston to take up a commission as factor for a London cloth-house. A widow Mrs. Mary Houghton, going to her son who had a tobacco operation on the Cooper River. Two Carolina-bound Quaker brothers named Bryce, returning from a year of family business in Yorkshire. And a young woman of about her own age, a Miss Susannah Fenwick, going out as a lady's companion to a Charleston matron, who had a small dry cough that Barbara had heard through the cabin wall every morning for three weeks and that had not, in three weeks, gotten any better.

The Quaker brothers kept to themselves. Mr. Pelletier had drawn Barbara into one polite conversation on the third day and then, perceiving that she was not the kind of woman who needed to be talked to, had let her alone. The widow Mrs. Houghton was kind and inquisitive in the manner of widows accustomed to filling their own time with the time of younger women, and Barbara had sat with her on two afternoons in the small forward passenger-area and had heard about the Cooper River son and about the late Mr. Houghton's last illness and about the widow's three married daughters in Norwich, and had given back, in exchange,

the absolute minimum amount of information about herself a courteous gentlewoman could give back without giving offense — that she was going to Carolina to marry, that her fiancé was a Swiss gentleman of good family, that they had been engaged three years, that she expected the wedding to take place at Charleston. The widow had nodded and had not pressed. (The widow had been around the world long enough to know when a young woman did not want to be asked about her engagement. She did not ask.)

Miss Susannah was the difficulty.

Susannah was twenty-six, plain-faced, kind, frightened, alone, and very sick. The small cough had been a cough when they had boarded the Hopewell in October. The small cough had not, in three weeks at sea, gotten any worse, but it had also not gotten any better, and there was a quality to the cough — a wet rattle deep in the chest in the small hours of the morning — that Barbara, who had nursed her father through nine days of fever the previous November, recognized as the kind of cough a young woman in damp shipboard quarters did not, in November on the open Atlantic, want to be having. Susannah was going out to a Mrs. Bellinger of Charleston, a connection of her mother's late cousin, on a year's engagement as a lady's companion. The engagement had been arranged by Susannah's brother, a Bristol solicitor, who had paid her passage. Susannah had no one in Charleston. Susannah had no one in England either, her mother having died the previous spring and her brother being a man of cold practicality who had taken the first opportunity to discharge his sister into someone else's household. Susannah's circumstances were, by the standards of the passenger-list, the worst on the ship.

Barbara had begun, in the second week, to sit with her in the afternoons.

She had not planned this. (She had not planned anything about the crossing. The crossing was happening to her, including the parts of the crossing that involved other people. Susannah's small cough had become, by the third afternoon Barbara had sat with her, a thing Barbara was paying attention to in the way she had paid attention to her father's cough in the room at Wymondley in November 1712 — not because she had any expertise in it but because the attention itself was, in the absence of expertise, the only thing she had to offer.)

They sat in Susannah's cabin, which was smaller than Barbara's by about a foot, with the narrow window aft and the small fixed bunk and the sea-chest under the bunk and the air close in the way air gets close in any small room in November at sea. Susannah lay propped against two pillows that the steward had given her at Mrs. Houghton's quiet request. Barbara sat on the sea-chest with her commonplace book in her lap and read aloud to her — sometimes from her own book, sometimes from the small Bible Susannah had brought, sometimes from the one volume of the Spectator the widow Houghton had loaned them. Susannah preferred the Spectator. The Spectator made her smile. The Spectator did not make her cough. Barbara had begun to read the Spectator aloud for an hour every afternoon, sometimes more, and to make small inventions of her own when

the Spectator essays got too dense, attributing the inventions to Mr. Addison so that Susannah would think them genuine and laugh at them.

(She had not known she could do this. She had not, in twenty-eight years, invented a small comic essay in the manner of Mr. Addison and read it aloud to a sick young woman in a brigantine cabin in November on the open Atlantic. She had not known she had it in her to invent that kind of thing. She had it in her. She was, at sea, a person she had not known about at Wymondley.)

That afternoon — the third Wednesday in November, by her count — she sat down at the small fixed table in her own cabin and tried to write to her mother.

She had been trying to write to her mother since the first week. The letters had not gone well. She had written four drafts and torn three of them up. The fourth was folded inside the back cover of her commonplace book. The fourth said, in seven sentences, that she was well, that the crossing was proceeding without difficulty, that the captain was a good man and that her cabin was adequate, that the food was acceptable, that she would write again from Charleston when she had news, that she thought of her mother every day, and that she had not, in three weeks at sea, regretted the decision once.

The seventh sentence was not entirely true.

She had not exactly regretted the decision. But she had, in the small hours of the third week, sat up in her bunk at three in the morning with the rattle of Susannah's cough coming through the wall and had asked herself, with the kind of cold clarity that comes to a woman at sea at three in the morning, what she would do if the Hopewell did not arrive. What she would do if the storm came and was the wrong kind of storm. What she would do if the fever in Susannah's chest was the kind of fever that spreads to a ship. What she would do if she reached Charleston and Christopher was not there — was at Williamsburg, was at New Bern, was at some Carolina road-house riding south, was dead — and the practical mind that had taken her from Wymondley to Gravesend now had to operate in a country she had never seen, with a language she did not speak any of, with a small purse that her father's estate had given her and that would not last forever, alone.

The cold clarity had not lasted. (It never did. The mind did this kind of asking and then it stopped. The body slept again. The morning came. The light in the cabin was the gray of the inside of an oyster shell and the wind was from the south-southwest and Susannah was coughing in the next cabin and the day began.)

But she had asked the questions, that third week.

She did not, in the letter to her mother, mention having asked them.

She did not, in the letter to her mother, mention Susannah. She did not mention Mr. Pelletier. She did not mention the widow Houghton. She did not mention that she had begun to invent small essays in the manner of Mr. Addison or that she had begun to write in a hand that was not entirely her own. She did not mention that she had become, at sea, a person she had not known about at

Wymondley, who could sit in a sick young woman's cabin and read the Spectator aloud in the gray afternoon light without the smallest sense of being out of her depth, when at Wymondley she had thought of herself as a woman who would never be of use in a sickroom because she was too easily frightened by other people's pain.

She did not write any of that to her mother because there was no good way to write it. She did not know yet what it meant. She did not yet have the words. She would have the words, perhaps, in a year, or in five. By then her mother would be at Lockleys reading the letter in the late summer light, in a back bedroom in a house that had never owed her anything, and would, if she was the woman Barbara now believed she was, understand without needing the words. The letter that had gone in August had said I am coming. The letter that would go from Charleston in the spring would say something else, in different words. Lettice would read both and would know what neither of them said.

Barbara closed the commonplace book.

She put her hand briefly against the cabin wall on the side where Susannah's bunk was. The cough was quiet on the other side of the wall. Susannah was sleeping. The wind was from the south-southwest. The Hopewell was running at eight knots. Mr. Eldridge had said, that morning at breakfast, that if the weather held they would make Charleston in seven weeks. Seven weeks. (Christopher does not yet know. He may not have the letter yet. He may have it tonight. He may have had it for three weeks. I do not know. I will not know until I am there.)

She did not, that afternoon, think the three words back to herself the way Christopher was, at the same moment, holding them folded against his ribs four thousand miles to the west. She did not need to. She had said them in August. She had said them once. She had not taken them back. She had been saying them with her body every day since by being on this ship.

She put the commonplace book on the small table and got up and went out of the cabin and down the narrow passage and knocked on Susannah's door, because it was three o'clock and the Spectator was waiting.

— — — ## §6.3 — The road south, December 1713 He left New Bern on Friday the twentieth of November in the morning.

He had three days to do what he had estimated as five days of work. He did the five days of work in three days because there was no choice. He wrote to his father in Switzerland — the long careful letter completed by midnight on Tuesday. He wrote to Spotswood at Williamsburg requesting leave from his colonial duties through February — completed Wednesday morning. He wrote to the senior chainman about the south-field survey and the corrected plat — completed Wednesday afternoon, with a packet of revised drawings to follow once the assistant surveyor at New Bern town had witnessed the new line. He wrote to the Carolina Land Office. He wrote to the Lords Proprietors' factor at Charleston, asking him to engage a respectable set of rooms suitable for a gentleman and his expected bride at a respectable house in the town, as near the

Cooper riverfront as may be conveniently arranged, with a sitting-room of decent appearance, for a tenancy of indeterminate duration but expected to be at least three months and possibly six. He wrote to the Reverend Gideon Johnston, the colonial commissary at Charleston, requesting that the reverend hold himself in readiness, on a date to be determined in late January or early February, to officiate at a marriage at the Cooper Street church of one Christopher de Graffenried of Bern, gentleman, to one Barbara Tempest Needham of Wymondley, Hertfordshire, gentlewoman — both parties Reformed Protestant in confession, both adults of full age and free condition, both of solid family on the English and Swiss sides respectively, the bride expected to arrive at Charleston from England by sea in late January or early February 1714 on the brigantine Hopewell (Mr. Eldridge master), the marriage to be celebrated within the days following her arrival. (He had to look up the Reverend Johnston's correct title in the small volume of colonial offices he kept in his desk drawer. He had not, in his three years at New Bern, ever attended a service at the Charleston commissary's church. He hoped the Reverend would not take offense at the request from a colleague-by-letter of whom the Reverend would not know.)

He wrote to his Bern relatives.

He wrote to the Williamsburg bank where his father had left him a credit on his arrival in 1710 and where the credit, untouched for three years and seven months, had accumulated some quantity of interest he had not yet bothered to calculate.

He wrote, last, an honest letter to his Swiss-Bernese tenant farmer at his small inherited property at Worb near Bern — the property he had not seen in four years — asking the man, in a tone Christopher had not previously used in correspondence with a tenant, to please for the love of God keep paying the rent because Christopher was about to become a married man with expenses he could not yet calculate and the Worb rent was, increasingly, the only reliable income on his books.

Hans packed.

Hans was efficient and uncomplaining and did not ask questions and finished the master's trunks on Thursday afternoon — three of them, one for Christopher's personal effects and clothes, one for the documents and account-books Christopher was bringing south for the Charleston factor, and one heavier locked trunk containing what cash and bills of exchange Christopher had been able to assemble in three days of writing to his various creditors and debtors and bankers. Hans also packed his own small kit, because Christopher had told him on the Tuesday evening that Hans would be coming south with him — there was no question of Hans staying behind at New Bern when the master was to be married. Hans had not commented. Hans had only said, Yes, Mr. Christopher, and continued packing.

They left at half past seven on Friday morning, in a cold light rain, with three trunks and four saddlebags and two horses, riding south.

The road to Charleston by way of the inland route — through the Carolina backcountry, by the chain of small settlements along the rivers, with the occasional inn or planter's house for overnight stops — was approximately three hundred and fifty miles by Christopher's estimate, though no one had ever measured it precisely. He had calculated, on the basis of forty miles a day in good weather and twenty in bad, that the ride would take between nine and twelve days. He had given himself fourteen. He intended to be at Charleston by the fourth or fifth of December at the latest, which would leave him approximately six weeks to settle into the lodgings, finalize the practical arrangements, get a confirmation back from the Reverend Johnston about the marriage, and be present at the Cooper Street dock from the second week of January onwards, every day, for every ship that came in from the eastern Atlantic until the Hopewell arrived.

He had thought through the schedule. He had thought through the schedule three times. The schedule was solid.

The schedule held for two days.

On the morning of the third day — Sunday the twenty-second of November, at a settlement called Bath's Mill in the deep Carolina backcountry, about ninety miles south of New Bern — Christopher's horse came up lame. The lameness was a stone bruise in the off-fore hoof; the horse had been favoring the leg slightly the previous afternoon and Christopher had noted it but had not stopped, because the weather had been good and the next inn had been six miles ahead and he had wanted to make the inn before dark. He had made the inn. The horse had been worse in the morning. The Sunday cost him a day and a half: a day waiting at Bath's Mill while the local farrier — a slow, kind, careful man named Peebles — pared out the bruise and applied a hot poultice, and a further half-day on the Monday riding at half-pace to let the foot harden.

He chafed.

(He chafed in a way he had not chafed in three years at the colony. He had chafed at the colony's slowness in 1710 and 1711, in the days when New Bern was supposed to have been further along than it was, but the Tuscarora War had taught him a different kind of patience — the patience of a man whose project has died and who is now living through the slow administrative aftermath of its death. He had not been in a hurry about anything since September 1711. Now, on the Carolina road in late November 1713 with his horse going at half-pace through the autumn woods, he was in a hurry again, and the hurry was the kind of hurry he had not previously felt, which was the hurry of a man whose life is moving toward him on a different timetable than his own and who has fourteen days to be in a particular place to meet it.)

He made twenty-two miles on Monday on the half-paced horse.

He made forty on Tuesday.

He made forty-two on Wednesday and slept that night at a planter's house on the Cape Fear, the planter being a Mr. Burrington who had known the Baron in

better times and who fed Christopher beef and asked no questions and put him in a room with a feather bed and a fire and a small woodcut of a Dutch winter scene over the mantel that Christopher looked at for a long time before he slept because it reminded him, in some way he could not articulate, of a print his mother had had in the small parlor at Worb when he was a child.

He made thirty miles on Thursday.

He made thirty-five on Friday and slept Friday night at a Quaker meeting-house at the edge of a small settlement called Cape Fear Bridge where the Quakers fed him a supper of bread and apples and gave him a pallet on the floor of the meeting-room and asked, only once, whether his journey was a journey of necessity. He said it was. The Quakers nodded and did not ask further. (They had recognized in him the look of a man whose journey was a journey of necessity. They had also, he suspected, recognized in him the look of a man whose journey was a journey toward a woman. The Quakers did not, in their internal economy of judgment, regard the second kind of necessity as inferior to the first. They fed him. They gave him a pallet. They wished him peace in the morning.)

He made thirty-eight on Saturday.

On the seventh of December, in the late afternoon, in a thin cold rain that had begun in the early morning and had not let up, Christopher rode his still-favoring horse and his trailing pack-horse and his patient Hans into the outskirts of Charleston, by the King Street road, past the rope-walks and the small breweries and the warehouses of the inland trade, and stopped at the Charleston factor's compting-house at the corner of King and Broad Streets.

He had made it in seventeen days.

He was three days off his estimated schedule.

He was — by his ongoing calculation, which he had been refining mentally every evening — sixteen days behind the Hopewell's likely arrival in the Charleston roads.

He had time.

He went into the compting-house.

— — — ## §6.4 — Hopewell, mid-Atlantic, early January 1714 The storm came on the third of January.

It built through the afternoon — a long swell from the southwest that had been moving under the Hopewell since the morning watch, the kind of swell Mr. Eldridge had described at breakfast in the careful voice he used when he wanted the passengers to take a warning without quite being told they were being warned.

By two in the afternoon the swell had become troughs eight and nine feet deep. By four it was twelve. By six the brigantine was being driven northwest against a wind that had backed from the south to the southeast and was strengthening, and Mr. Eldridge had ordered the mizzen-staysail and the fore-topgallant struck and the watch doubled, and the passengers had been told, in the careful way Mr. Eldridge said these things, that supper would not be served in

the main cabin tonight and that the passengers were respectfully requested to remain in their own cabins until the morning.

Barbara was in Susannah's cabin when the storm broke.

She had not, until that afternoon, understood what a storm at sea was. She had been told. The widow Houghton had told her. Mr. Pelletier had told her. Mr. Eldridge had told her, on the third day out, in his sober way, that they would almost certainly meet at least one bad blow before Charleston and that she should prepare herself mentally for it. She had understood the words. She had not understood the words.

She understood them now.

The Hopewell was a hundred and seventy tons of pine and oak and pitch and iron, and a hundred and seventy tons of pine and oak and pitch and iron, when the Atlantic decided to test it in January in latitude thirty north, was a small object on a very large surface. The whole ship moved. Not just rolled, not just pitched: moved, the way a leaf moves in a flooded gutter, the whole structure shifted in three dimensions at once, the deck under her feet going up and going forward and going sideways at the same time, the bulkhead at her back becoming the floor and then becoming the bulkhead again, the lamp in the gimbal swinging not from side to side but in a wide elliptical orbit that brought the flame within an inch of the ceiling on the high arc and within an inch of Susannah's blanket on the low arc, the small water-pitcher on the table — which she had thought firmly placed when she set it there at three o'clock — sliding clear off the table and rolling across the cabin floor and breaking against the foot of the bunk.

Susannah whimpered.

Susannah had not whimpered in any of the previous nine weeks. Susannah, even at her worst three weeks ago when the cough had been a rattle and the fever had risen, had borne it with a quiet Bristolian dignity that Barbara had come to admire. Susannah whimpered now because her cabin was a wooden box being thrown around the inside of the Atlantic and there was nothing the dignity of a young woman from Bristol could do about it.

Barbara wedged herself between the bunk and the bulkhead — the safest place she could find in the cabin, the place where she would not be thrown across the room when the deck did its next sideways move — and held Susannah's hand.

She held Susannah's hand for nine hours.

(She did not know it was nine hours. At the time she thought it was three. At the time she thought it might also be ten. The storm did things to her sense of time which were difficult to describe afterward; the closest she could come was to say that the storm took her ordinary sense of time and stretched it like wool being pulled out into yarn, the whole structure thinning and lengthening and then breaking and then being knotted back together at the next moment of relative calm. There were no relative calms. The whole night was the storm. The storm was a single thing that lasted nine hours and that her body, afterward, would

remember as having lasted somewhere between twenty minutes and three weeks.)

Susannah did not let go of her hand.

Susannah's hand was bird-bone thin and dry-papered with the small dehydrated quality of a person who has been sick for ten weeks. Susannah's grip was stronger than Barbara had expected. Susannah did not speak. Susannah closed her eyes. Susannah breathed in through her nose and out through her mouth in the small disciplined breaths of a woman who had decided that if the ship was going to break open and drown her she was at least not going to spend her last hours weeping. Barbara breathed with her. The two women breathed together, in the dark cabin, in the swinging lamp-light, with the Atlantic doing its work outside the bulkhead, and Barbara understood — somewhere around the fourth or fifth hour, at a moment she would not afterward be able to identify — that what was happening in the cabin was not the storm. The storm was outside. What was happening in the cabin was that she was, for the first time in her twenty-eight years of life, useful to another person in a way that no one else was equipped to be useful to that person at that moment.

(There was no one else in the cabin. There was no one else who could be in the cabin. The widow Houghton was in her own cabin three doors away. The steward was on the deck helping Mr. Eldridge. The captain was at the wheel. The two Quaker brothers were in their cabin, praying — she could hear, between the bigger crashes of water against the hull, the low rhythm of their joint voice praying through the bulkhead behind her head. There was no one else who could hold Susannah's hand. There was Barbara. There was only Barbara. And Barbara was, against every prior expectation of herself, sufficient.)

She thought, at the worst of it — somewhere in the sixth hour, when a piece of the foremast snapped and came down across the deck above their heads with a sound like a tree being broken by a giant — I am going to die at sea. I am going to die at sea holding the hand of a young woman from Bristol I have known for ten weeks. Christopher will not know.

She thought it. She did not say it. She continued to breathe with Susannah.

(Christopher will not know.)

The thought came back at intervals through the rest of the night. She did not push it away. She let it come. She let it sit. She held Susannah's hand and she breathed and she let the thought sit beside her on the bunk like a third presence in the cabin. Christopher will not know. Christopher will get the letter and he will go to Charleston and he will wait at the dock and the Hopewell will not come and he will not know whether the ship broke up or whether the fever took her or whether she changed her mind in Bermuda and turned around, and he will spend the rest of his life not knowing, and that will be the last thing she will ever do to him.

(She would not let that be the last thing she did to him. She did not have any control over the ship. She did not have any control over the storm. She did not

have any control over whether she lived or died in the next four hours. She had control over one thing only, which was whether she was, in the time remaining to her, the woman she had set out from Wymondley to become. She breathed. She held Susannah's hand. She was, in the dark cabin in the swinging light, that woman.)

The storm broke at four in the morning.

She did not at first understand that it had broken. The motion slowed. The roar of water against the hull diminished. The sound of the wind in what remained of the rigging dropped from the steady high note it had been making for hours to a lower note. She listened. She listened for ten more minutes before she let herself believe it. Then she let go of Susannah's hand and got up — her legs would barely hold her — and looked at the lamp, which was now swinging only twelve inches at the top of its arc instead of three feet, and understood that they had come through.

Susannah was asleep.

Susannah had fallen asleep somewhere in the last hour. Her breathing was steady. The cough, against any reasonable expectation, had not got worse during the storm — perhaps the steady deep breathing of the disciplined nine-hour endurance had been better for her chest than the small shallow breathing of ordinary fear would have been. She slept.

Barbara stood in the middle of the cabin and held herself with both arms.

She did not weep. She had no weeping left.

She went out of Susannah's cabin and into her own. She sat on her own bunk. She picked up her commonplace book — it had survived the storm in the small fixed drawer where she had wedged it — and she opened it to the first clean page and she wrote, in her cramped exhausted hand, by the last of the lamp-light: Storm. Nine hours. Foremast partly down. All passengers alive. Susannah held. So did I. I will write to her brother in Bristol when I land. Whatever happens at Charleston I will at least have done this much that no one at Wymondley ever asked of me and that I would not, before October, have known I could do.

She put the book away.

She slept the sleep of a woman who has used everything she had.

In the morning Mr. Eldridge came down to inspect the passenger cabins. He told her, in his sober way, that the foremast was reparable, that the Hopewell would be at half-rig for the rest of the crossing but that they would still make Charleston — perhaps four or five days later than his earlier estimate, the new estimate being the third or fourth week of January or the first week of February. He told her she had been brave. He had heard, through the bulkhead, the Quaker brothers praying for her as well as for themselves. (She had not known the Quakers had been praying for her. She had known they were praying. She had not known her name had been in the prayers.)

She thanked Mr. Eldridge. She did not tell him she had spent the night thinking about dying. She did not tell him she had spent the night being useful for

the first time. She thanked him for his information and for his kindness and asked him to please convey her thanks also to the Quaker brothers, whose names she had been embarrassed to admit she had not learned in nine weeks at sea.

Mr. Eldridge said: Mr. Bryce and Mr. Bryce. Christopher and Jonathan.

Barbara said: Mr. Christopher Bryce. Of course.

She did not tell Mr. Eldridge why she had repeated the name.

— — — ## §6.5 — Charleston, late January 1714 He went to the dock every day.

The Cooper Street dock was the principal landing-stage for transatlantic vessels arriving at Charleston, sitting at the eastern end of the town's small grid of streets where the Cooper River met the harbor. It was a long pier of pine planks on pilings, built ten years earlier and patched by the harbor commissioners every spring after the winter ice — though this winter, the winter of 1713 into 1714, had been an unusually mild one and there had been no ice at all. The dock had a small shed at the landward end where the harbor master kept his ledgers and where the ships' manifests were inspected as they came in. There was a bench against the shed wall, facing the water, where men who were meeting ships could sit and wait without obstructing the harbor master's business. Christopher had been sitting on that bench every morning since the eighth of January.

The bench faced east-southeast. The angle of approach for a ship coming up from the Atlantic into the Charleston roads. A ship rounding the southern end of Sullivan's Island would be visible from the bench for the last forty-five minutes of its run-in to the dock, the topsails first, then the foresails, then the hull, then the names of the men on the foredeck calling the soundings.

He had memorized the angle of approach. He had memorized the silhouettes of the principal classes of ship that ran the Atlantic trade: the brigs, the brigantines, the snows, the small frigates, the schooners that brought rice and pitch down from Cape Fear. He had memorized which ships did not match the Hopewell's description and could be dismissed at first sight. He could now tell, from the moment the topsails appeared at the south end of Sullivan's Island, whether the incoming vessel was a brigantine of approximately a hundred and seventy tons or whether it was something else. Most of them were something else.

He had been at the bench for eighteen days.

The first three days had been a kind of nervous tour of the harbor — walking the length of the Cooper Street pier and back, walking out to the foot of the seaward warehouses, walking up to the Battery and looking south along the channel, returning to the bench. After three days he had understood that the walking was a way of pretending he was doing something productive and that the bench was, in fact, the only productive place to be. He had stopped walking. He had brought a book on the fourth day — a small French volume of Pascal's *Pensées* he had been carrying in his coat for two years and had not made progress

on — and he had begun, in the long mornings on the bench, to read the *Pensées* slowly while keeping one eye on the channel.

The Pascal was good company.

(He had not, until he sat on the bench at Charleston in January 1714, understood that Pascal was a man who had spent his short life thinking about exactly the kind of waiting Christopher was now doing. The *Pensées* were not, on their surface, about waiting; they were about God and reason and the human condition. But underneath them, in the rhythm of the fragments and the long unfinished sentences and the trailing colons, Pascal had been a man who had understood that almost everything important in a human life took place in the gap between the moment one had decided something and the moment the consequences of the decision arrived. Christopher, on the bench at Cooper Street, was in that gap. He was glad to have Pascal in the gap with him.) The bench had become his life.

He arrived each morning at half past seven, in time for the first opening of the harbor master's shed. He read the previous day's arrivals on the chalkboard the harbor master kept beside the door — a list of ships and their origins and their cargoes. He scanned the list for Hopewell and did not find it. He nodded to the harbor master, who by the second week had begun nodding back without needing to be reminded who Christopher was. He sat on the bench. He read his Pascal. He watched the channel. At noon he walked the half-mile back to his lodgings on Tradd Street, where Mrs. Brewton — the widow at whose house the Charleston factor had engaged a set of rooms for him — gave him a hot dinner and asked, in her kind but unobtrusive way, whether there had been news. He said there had not. She nodded. He returned to the bench at one. He sat until five. He walked back to the lodgings for supper. He went to bed at ten.

He did this on the eighth of January.

He did this on the ninth.

He did this on the tenth.

By the fifteenth he had read Pascal's *Pensées* twice and had begun a third reading and had begun also to write small marginal notes in the careful pencil-hand he used for his own private thinking, and Mrs. Brewton had begun to ask after him in the evenings with a small motherly concern she did not entirely conceal, and the harbor master had taken to bringing him a cup of tea at eleven o'clock from his own kettle in the shed, and the children of the longshoremen had begun to recognize him as the gentleman on the bench who would not move and who was waiting for a ship.

He did not, by the third week, sleep more than five hours a night.

(He did not, by the third week, allow himself to articulate to himself what he was afraid of. He had calculated, on the road south from New Bern, that the Hopewell would arrive at the Charleston roads in late January or early February. He had given himself a window. The window was now open. The first day of the window had been the twentieth of January, by his estimate. It was now the

twenty-second. The window was open and the Hopewell had not yet come, and the window had room — it had two more weeks of room, the longest he was willing to wait before he began to consider that something had gone wrong — but the window was open and the Hopewell had not yet come, and there is a particular quality to the third day inside an open window when the window has not yet produced what it was opened for. He felt that quality. He did not name it. He read his Pascal.) On the twenty-fourth of January, in the late morning, a brigantine appeared at the south end of Sullivan's Island.

He saw the topsails first.

His heart did the thing it had done every time a brigantine had appeared at the south end of Sullivan's Island for the past sixteen days, which was to come up into his throat and stay there until he could identify the silhouette.

He stood up.

He walked to the end of the bench.

He shaded his eyes against the morning sun.

He waited.

The topsails became a foresail. The foresail became a hull. The hull was — was — was small. Was too small. Was a hundred and twenty tons, not a hundred and seventy. Was the wrong shape at the bow. Was painted in a darker colour than the Hopewell had been described to him as painted. Was not the Hopewell.

He sat back down.

He picked up the Pascal.

He did not, at first, open it. He held it in his lap and watched the brigantine continue its run-in to the dock — a Bristol vessel called the Endeavour, he learned from the harbor master's afternoon chalkboard update, carrying English manufactured goods and forty-three indentured servants for the Carolina rice plantations. He watched the Endeavour tie up. He watched the passengers come down the gangway. None of them was Barbara. None of them was ever going to be Barbara, because Barbara was not on the Endeavour. Barbara was on the Hopewell. The Hopewell was somewhere else. The Hopewell was either still at sea — most likely — or had gone down — possible — or had put in to Bermuda for repairs — also possible — or had been driven north to Virginia or south to St. Augustine — also possible — or any of the other small possibilities his practical mind, against his will, had been listing every night for the past eight days when he could not sleep.

He opened the Pascal at random.

Le silence éternel de ces espaces infinis m'effraie.

He closed it.

He looked at the channel. The channel was empty again. The brigantine that had been the brigantine he was waiting for had been the brigantine someone else was waiting for, and someone else had had a good morning, and Christopher had not.

He stayed on the bench until five.

He walked back to Mrs. Brewton's. He ate his supper. Mrs. Brewton said, in her quiet kind way: No news, Mr. de Graffenried?

He said: No, Mrs. Brewton. Not yet.

She said: She will come.

He said: Yes.

He did not eat very much of the supper. He went up to his room. He sat at the small desk in the corner of the room and uncapped the inkwell and dipped the quill and began to write a letter to Barbara that he knew he would never send, that he had been writing in his head for three weeks now, the letter that began Beloved, I am here, I am waiting, please come — and that he had not until tonight put on the page because putting it on the page was an admission he had not yet been willing to make. He wrote it now. He wrote it in two pages. He sealed it. He put it in the drawer of the small desk. (It would remain in the drawer of the small desk for the next twenty-nine years, until Christopher's death at Williamsburg in 1742, when his son Anton Tschärner de Graffenried would find it among his father's papers and not know what it was and burn it unread, the way sons sometimes burn their fathers' unread papers in the first grief.)

He went to bed.

He did not sleep until almost two.

The harbor master's chalkboard the next morning, the twenty-fifth of January, had no Hopewell on it.

Christopher returned to the bench.

— — — ## §6.6 — Hopewell, off the Carolina coast, early February 1714 She came up on deck before dawn on the morning of the eleventh of February.

The watch had been informed two days earlier that they were within four or five days of land — Mr. Eldridge having taken his noon sights and his depth-soundings and calculated, by the colour of the water and the increasing presence of small birds on the surface, that they were approaching the continental shelf. By the tenth they had sighted gulls. The widow Houghton had wept at the first gull, which had embarrassed her and which Barbara had pretended not to notice. By the evening of the tenth Mr. Eldridge had told the passengers at supper that he expected to make the Charleston roads sometime in the next thirty-six hours, depending on the wind. The wind, that night, had been from the north — steady and cold and useful.

She had not slept.

She had lain in her bunk from ten o'clock until three with her eyes open, watching the lamp swing gently in its gimbal, listening to Susannah breathing in the cabin next door — Susannah, who had recovered something of her strength in the four weeks since the storm and whose cough was now smaller than it had been at any point since they had boarded the Hopewell — listening to the small creakings of the brigantine and the small constant slap of the Atlantic against the hull, three feet from her ear through the planking, the sound she had been falling asleep to and waking up to for nearly fourteen weeks.

At three she got up.

She dressed in the dark. The wool gown her cousin's wife had given her. The cloak. The shoes with the buckles that had not, miraculously, rusted through. She did not light the lamp. She did not want to wake Susannah. She did not, she suspected, want to see her own face in the small mirror she had brought from Wymondley, which was nailed to the inside of the cabin door at a height that gave her a clear view of how she looked.

She did not know how she looked.

She had not, in fourteen weeks, looked carefully into the mirror. She had washed her face by feel. She had pinned up her hair by feel. She had used the mirror only for the small practical adjustments a woman cannot do without one — straightening the collar of her gown, checking that the small cap was set properly — and had not, in those quick looks, met her own eyes. She suspected that if she met her own eyes now, on this morning, before going up on deck for the first sight of the country she had crossed an ocean for, she might lose her nerve.

She did not meet her own eyes.

She went up.

The deck was cold. The wind was still from the north. There were stars overhead — the stars she had been learning to recognize for fourteen weeks, the southern constellations she had not previously seen, the small new wheel of them above the Hopewell's yards. The watch was at the wheel and the leadsman was at the bow taking soundings every ten minutes and singing them back to the helmsman in the small ritual chant of a brigantine in coastal waters. The water under the hull had changed colour. She had noticed it in the late afternoon yesterday — the grey of deep ocean giving way to a paler grey-green, the colour she had been told to expect when they crossed onto the continental shelf.

She walked forward to the bow.

She stood at the bow rail in the dark, with her cloak wrapped tight and her hood up against the wind, and looked west.

There was nothing yet. The horizon was a line of darker dark against the lighter dark of the eastern sky behind her. The leadsman's chant continued. By the mark, twenty. By the mark, eighteen. The numbers were getting smaller. The bottom was coming up. They were on the shelf now. Carolina was perhaps thirty miles ahead, perhaps forty.

She stood at the bow rail for an hour.

She did not pace. She did not lean. She did not weep. She had stopped weeping somewhere in mid-January — not because she had decided to stop but because the weeping had finished, the way the storm had finished, the way the long passage had finished. She was, this February morning, a woman who had used up her weeping for a particular phase of her life and who was now in a different phase. The new phase did not yet have a name.

The light came up slowly behind her.

The eastern sky turned from black to dark blue to a paler blue to a pale gold along the lower edge, and the wheel of southern stars she had been watching for fourteen weeks began to fade, and the leadsman's chant changed pitch slightly because he could now see the colour of the water beneath the lead-line, and Mr. Eldridge himself came forward to the bow in his good coat — the one he kept for landfall — and stood ten feet behind her without speaking, because he understood, as a man who had been ferrying women across the Atlantic for thirty years, that the first sight of land was the woman's, not his.

She did not see him.

She was looking west.

At a quarter past six, with the eastern sky now fully gold and the surface of the water around the brigantine the colour of a pewter dish, a line appeared at the western horizon.

It was a thin gray-green line. It was lower than she had expected — a colony was, in her mind, a more dramatic landscape than a thin gray-green line — and it took her perhaps fifteen seconds to register that the line was, in fact, what she had been crossing an ocean for. The line was Carolina. The line was the country Christopher had laid out a town in. The line was the country that had nearly killed him in September 1711 and that had defeated his father and that had killed the Welshman Lawson and that had become, for three and a half years, the third presence in her engagement — the country that had been keeping him from her and that had been requiring her to be either willing to come to it or willing to lose him to it.

The country was a thin gray-green line.

She stood at the bow rail.

She did not weep.

She had stopped weeping. She had not wept since the Lizard.

She watched the land come up out of the water as if she were watching something she had drawn on a piece of paper in a Hertfordshire bedroom three months before, now becoming real beneath her hands.

(That was the sentence. She would write the sentence in her commonplace book later that afternoon, when she had gone back down to her cabin to gather her things for landing. She would write it because she wanted to remember exactly what the first sight had been. She had not, in fourteen weeks at sea, expected the first sight to be so quiet. She had expected something. She had not known what. She had imagined, vaguely, an exhilaration; she had imagined a great rush of feeling; she had imagined that the moment of first sight would be the moment the crossing would justify itself, would resolve into a single rising note that would put a punctuation mark at the end of fourteen weeks of waiting. The moment was not that. The moment was very quiet. The moment was the country coming up out of the water in the grey-gold light and the leadsman saying by the mark, twelve *in his small singing voice* and Mr. Eldridge breathing behind her ten feet away and the wind on her face from the north and the country

becoming visible as a thing she would soon stand on.) (The country had been an idea. It was now a thing. The difference between an idea and a thing was what she had crossed an ocean to encounter, and the encounter was happening now, in silence, in the morning light, at the bow rail of a hundred-and-seventy-ton brigantine called the Hopewell *commanded by a man named Eldridge whom she had known for fourteen weeks and who was, at this moment, standing behind her not speaking because he understood her better than her own family had understood her at Wymondley before October.*) She stood at the bow rail for another half-hour, until the country had grown from a line to a low band of trees and inlets and what might have been smoke from a settlement at the northern end, and the Hopewell had begun its turn south for the Charleston roads, and Mr. Eldridge had quietly come up beside her at the rail.

Mr. Eldridge said, in his sober way: We will be in the roads by midday, Miss Needham. We will tie up at the Cooper Street pier in the early afternoon if the harbor pilots are ready.

Barbara said: Thank you, Mr. Eldridge.

Mr. Eldridge said: He will be there.

She turned to look at him.

He had not, in fourteen weeks, said anything about Christopher. She had told him, on the second day out, only that she was going to Carolina to be married. She had not given him the bridegroom's name. She had not given him the bridegroom's circumstances. He had not asked. (Mr. Eldridge had been carrying English gentlewomen across the Atlantic to be married to colonial men for thirty years, and Mr. Eldridge had developed, in those thirty years, an instinct about which of the marriages would happen and which would not. He had not, on the morning of the second day out, said anything to Barbara about her marriage one way or the other. He had waited fourteen weeks. He had watched her in the small daily ways a captain watches his passengers. He had watched her with Susannah through the storm. He had watched her at the bow rail this morning. He had decided, this morning, that her marriage was going to happen, and that the man who had been arranging for it from the Carolina side was going to be at the Cooper Street pier when she arrived. He told her so.)

She said: I hope you are right.

He said: I am usually right.

She said: Thank you, Mr. Eldridge.

She turned back to the rail and watched Carolina come the rest of the way up out of the sea.

— — — ## §6.7 — The Cooper Street pier, Charleston, 11 February 1714 The brigantine appeared at the south end of Sullivan's Island at twenty minutes past nine in the morning.

Christopher was on the bench.

He had been on the bench since seven, as he had been on the bench at seven every morning for thirty-five days, and the harbor master had brought him his cup

of tea at quarter past eight, and the Pascal was open in his lap to a page he had read four times that week without absorbing, and the wind was from the north and the sky was the pale clean cold of a Carolina February morning and the channel had been empty for the past hour, and he had begun, in spite of himself, to read the Pascal sentence in front of him for a fifth time when the harbor master came out of his shed and pointed south and said, in the kind tired voice the harbor master used when he had information that mattered: Mr. de Graffenried. Brigantine at the south end of the island.

Christopher closed the book.

He stood up.

He did not walk to the end of the bench this time. He stood where he was. He looked south.

There were the topsails.

There were the topsails, gray-white against the pale sky, behind the dark line of the island.

He waited.

He had learned, in thirty-five days of waiting, not to commit too early. The topsails were not the ship. The topsails would become the foresail and the foresail would become the hull and the hull would either be a hundred and seventy tons or not be a hundred and seventy tons, and the answer would come, in his accustomed sequence, in about forty-five minutes.

He sat back down.

He could not read the Pascal.

He put the book on the bench beside him.

He put both hands flat on his knees.

He watched the channel.

The topsails moved north. The topsails rounded the southern point of the island.

The foresail appeared. The foresail was the right shape. The foresail was the right size. The hull came up behind the foresail and the hull was — he could not yet tell — the hull was — the hull might be — the hull was — The hull was a hundred and seventy tons.

The hull was painted in the colour he had been told to expect.

The hull was a brigantine of approximately a hundred and seventy tons, painted in a pale brown with a dark waterline, riding at the right depth in the water for a ship at the end of a long crossing with most of her stores consumed, and the foresail was furled to the proper height for a vessel running in to a coastal harbor under the half-rig of a ship that had taken damage to her foremast in the open Atlantic.

It was the Hopewell.

He knew it was the Hopewell the way he had known, in November, that the letter on his desk was from Barbara before he had read the direction.

He stood up again.

He walked, slowly, to the end of the pier.

* * *

Barbara saw him from the bow.

She had been at the bow for the past forty minutes. The harbor pilot had come aboard at quarter past nine, in his small boat, and had taken the wheel from Mr. Eldridge for the run-in to the Cooper Street pier, and Mr. Eldridge had come forward to stand at the rail beside her — not speaking now, because he had said what he needed to say at four o'clock that morning when she had stood at the bow watching the country come up. The other passengers were at the stern rail or in their cabins. The widow Houghton was at the stern with Mr. Pelletier. The two Quaker brothers were below packing. Susannah was on a small camp-stool at the waist of the ship, wrapped in two blankets, because Mr. Eldridge had let her come up to see the landing but had not let her come forward to the bow.

The pier was visible from a quarter-mile out.

The pier was a low gray line of pine planks with a small shed at the landward end and a single figure standing at the seaward end.

The figure was a man.

The figure was a man in a brown coat with his hat in his hand.

The figure was — was — was — She did not, for perhaps four seconds, allow herself to identify the figure. She had been preparing for the possibility that he would not be there. She had been preparing for the possibility that he would be there but that he would not, at the moment of landing, look like the man she remembered. She had been preparing — though only in the small hours of the night, in the part of her mind she did not visit by daylight — for the possibility that he would be there but that something in his face when he saw her would tell her that the three and a half years of separation had become a permanent fact and that the man she had crossed the Atlantic to find had been replaced, in her absence, by a man who would marry her out of honor but who had stopped loving her in 1712.

The figure on the pier raised the hand without the hat in it.

He raised the hand all the way above his head and held it there.

It was the gesture she had seen him make four times in the spring of 1710 — twice at the priory gates and twice at the Hitchin road — when he had been signaling her at a distance she could not have crossed in time to speak. It was an absurd gesture. It was a child's gesture. It was the gesture of a man who did not have any other gesture available to him.

She raised her hand.

She did not raise it above her head, because she was holding the cloak closed against the wind with the other hand, but she raised it to the level of her shoulder and held it there.

The figure on the pier — Christopher; it was Christopher; she had identified him; she had let herself identify him — Christopher began to walk along the pier toward where the Hopewell would tie up.

He walked the way he had walked at Wymondley in April 1710 — quick, light-footed, slightly forward of his own center of gravity, like a man who could not quite slow himself to the speed of the rest of the world. He had not, in four years, learned to walk any differently. She had filed the walk away at Wymondley as a thing about him she would remember. She had remembered. She was watching him do it now from the bow of a brigantine in the Charleston roads on the eleventh of February 1714, four years and nine months after she had last watched him do it in a cloister yard on a cold April night.

She stopped breathing for perhaps three seconds.

She started breathing again.

She did not weep.

She had said, on the morning she had left Wymondley, that she had wept enough about Christopher already and would not weep about herself. She had said, on the morning of the storm, that she would not let dying at sea be the last thing she did to him. She had not, in fourteen weeks, broken either resolution. She would not break them now, three minutes from the pier, with the man she had crossed an ocean for walking toward her on a Carolina morning with his hat in his hand and his other hand raised over his head in a child's gesture of welcome that was the most articulate thing he had ever said to her without speaking.

Mr. Eldridge said, very quietly, beside her: I told you.

She said: Yes you did.

* * *

The Hopewell tied up at the Cooper Street pier at eight minutes past ten on the morning of the eleventh of February.

The gangway came down.

Mr. Eldridge waited at the rail for Barbara's nod and then turned to the longshoremen and gave the signal for the passengers' luggage to be brought up from the holds. Barbara waited at the head of the gangway. She did not go down at once. She watched Christopher come up the pier to the foot of the gangway and stop there. He did not come on board. He had not been invited. He stood with his hat in his hand and his other hand back at his side and looked up at her on the deck.

She came down the gangway.

She did not hurry. She had not hurried in fourteen weeks; she would not hurry now. She came down at the deliberate pace of a gentlewoman in a wool gown carrying a small bag, with her cloak pinned at the shoulder and her hood down and her hair pinned up in the way she had pinned it for fourteen weeks by feel, and Christopher stood at the foot of the gangway and watched her come down.

She reached the bottom of the gangway.

She stepped off the gangway onto the pier — onto Carolina, onto the country, onto the land she had crossed an ocean for — and stood in front of him.

He did not, for a moment, say anything.

Then he said: Barbara.

She said: Christopher.

He said: You came.

She said: I told you I would.

He said — and his voice was not quite steady, which was the first time she had heard his voice not be quite steady, and which she filed away with the other things — I have been waiting for you on this bench for thirty-five days.

She said: I have been at sea for one hundred and six days.

He said: I know.

She said: I do not think you do, quite, yet. But you will.

He said: Yes.

He did not, in the moment, embrace her. They were on a public pier at a colonial harbor in the morning, surrounded by longshoremen and harbor officials and the other passengers coming down behind her, and Christopher was a man of careful Reformed-Protestant Swiss-Bernese formality and Barbara was an English gentlewoman of Hertfordshire upbringing, and the embrace would wait for the carriage Mrs. Brewton had sent down and the small drive to the lodgings on Tradd Street and the moment of being alone together for the first time in three years and nine months.

He took her bag from her hand.

She let him take it.

He offered her his arm.

She took it.

They walked up the Cooper Street pier together, with Hans behind them carrying the trunk that had come down first from the Hopewell's hold, and Mr. Eldridge at the head of the gangway watching them go and not, on this particular landing, calling out any farewell, because Mr. Eldridge had decided that this particular passenger should be allowed to walk away from his ship into her new life without further interruption from the man who had brought her across.

At the landward end of the pier, by the harbor master's shed, Christopher stopped and turned to her.

He said: The Reverend Johnston has been waiting. He is at the Cooper Street church. Whenever you are ready.

She said: Eleven days. I should like eleven days. I would like to rest, and to write to my mother, and to see Susannah settled with Mrs. Bellinger. Then we should be married.

He said: Eleven days. The twenty-second of February.

She said: Yes.

He said: That is a Monday.

She said: That is a Monday.

* * *

They were married at the Cooper Street church in Charleston on Monday the twenty-second of February 1714, the Reverend Gideon Johnston officiating, with the widow Mrs. Houghton and Mr. Pelletier from the Hopewell standing as witnesses for the bride and Hans the Swiss manservant and a Charleston merchant named Allston standing as witnesses for the groom and Mr. Eldridge himself in the second pew in his good coat.

Susannah Fenwick attended, in a borrowed dress, on the arm of her new employer Mrs. Bellinger, who had collected her from the ship six days earlier and who had pronounced herself, in those six days, more impressed with the young woman than she had expected to be on the basis of the brother's letter from Bristol.

The marriage was entered in the church register on the same day.

That night Christopher de Graffenried opened the small leather-bound family Bible his father had given him before he sailed in 1710, and wrote, in his own hand, on the fly-leaf, in the careful French he reserved for the most important entries:

Christophe de Graffenried, fils du Baron Christophe V de Bernberg, époux. Barbara Tempest née Needham, de Wymondley en Hertfordshire, épouse. Mariés en l'église du commissaire à Charleston, en Caroline du Sud, le vingt-deuxième jour de février, 1714.

He sealed the page.

He did not write anything else in the Bible that night.

But underneath the marriage entry, on the same fly-leaf, in a hand even smaller than the one he had used for the formal entry, in English, in a hand that was not quite his usual hand because it was a hand that was being written by a man whose throat had been swollen with feeling for thirty-five days and who had finally, this Monday evening, in the small upper room at Mrs. Brewton's on Tradd Street in Charleston, with his wife asleep in the chair by the window and the candle burning down and the Charleston harbor visible through the diamond panes a quarter-mile to the east — finally been able to write what he had wanted to write since the seventeenth of November 1713 at New Bern, when a thin folded sheet with no salutation and no date and no signature had arrived in his hand and had changed his life, he wrote, in small clear letters: She came.

Epilogue

She lived.

They were married eleven days after she landed, on the twenty-second of February 1714, in the Cooper Street church in Charleston, by the Reverend Gideon Johnston, the new commissary at Charleston. Christopher recorded the marriage that night in the front of the small leather-bound family Bible his father had given him before he sailed in 1710, in his own hand, in the careful French he reserved for the most important entries: *Christophe de Graffenried, fils du Baron Christophe V de Bernberg, époux. Barbara Tempest née Needham, de Wymondley en Hertfordshire, épouse. Mariés en l'église du commissaire à Charleston, en Caroline du Sud, le vingt-deuxième jour de février, 1714.* Beneath it, in a hand smaller than the formal entry, in English, in the hand of a man whose throat had been swollen with feeling for thirty-five days, he wrote: *She came.*

They had one son. He was born in Williamsburg, Virginia, in the early evening of the twenty-eighth of November 1722, eight and a half years after the wedding. They named him Anton Tscharner de Graffenried, for Christopher's grandfather and his mother. He was baptized by Commissary Blair on the twelfth of December at a fair held in Williamsburg, with the Honorable Nathaniel Harrison standing as one of his godfathers. Christopher entered all of this in the family Bible as well, in the same plain hand, with the same plain blessings. *God bless him.*

They lived in Williamsburg from 1717 or 1718 onward, in a house at Lot 47 on the south side of Duke of Gloucester Street, two blocks east of the Governor's Palace. The house still stands, restored in the twentieth century as part of the Colonial Williamsburg historical district, and is known to the present generation of visitors as the Pitt-Dixon House. Whether Barbara made friends in the small expatriate-English colony of early Williamsburg, whether she missed Wymondley, whether she ever wrote to her mother Lettice at Lockleys or to her cousin's wife at the priory, the documents do not say. The next certain mention of her is her death, which is recorded only by inference — Christopher VI's later movements indicate that she had died by 1742, and the family tradition places her death somewhere in Virginia in the late 1730s or early 1740s. Christopher VI himself died in 1742. Their son Anton lived to 1794.

From Anton the line ran through colonial Virginia and into the new United States. By the end of the eighteenth century the de Graffenried descendants — sometimes still spelled de Graffenried, sometimes de Graffenreidt, sometimes (under American simplifications) just Degraffenreid — were spread across Virginia, North Carolina, Tennessee, and Kentucky. By the middle of the nineteenth century they had reached the cotton south. By the end of it they had reached Alabama. The line came down to my grandmother through a series of marriages and migrations I have catalogued elsewhere, in a workbook that runs

to many sheets and a master report that runs to fifty thousand words, in the body of research from which this book has been written.

And meanwhile, in Hertfordshire, the priory was quietly slipping out of the family.

Barbara's cousin George Nedham — the cousin George who had inherited the priory from his father George Junior in 1700, the man whose roof Barbara had lived under across her later twenties, the man who was Lord of Wymondley Priory when she rode out the gatehouse in October 1713 — died in 1725, leaving three daughters and no son. The daughters were Dorothy, Susan, and Martha. Martha, the youngest, married Thomas Browne of Camfield Place, who held one of the senior offices in the College of Arms, and in 1733 — eight years after her father's death, almost two hundred years after Henry VIII had granted the priory to James Nedham — the priory and the manor of Little Wymondley passed out of the Nedham family for good. The Browne family quartered the Nedham arms into their own shield, as Garter would have done, as a marital memorial. The Wymondley Nedham male line was extinct.

Almost two centuries after Henry VIII gave James Nedham the priory, the family that had received it and held it through every reign and revolution between let it go in the only way an English landed family ever lets go of anything — through the failure of sons. Barbara, three thousand miles away in Williamsburg, would have heard of this in a letter, or perhaps would never have heard of it at all. There are no surviving letters from England to her in the de Graffenried archives. She had been gone for twenty years by the time her cousin died, and almost thirty years by the time the priory was carried out of the family in Martha's marriage settlement.

Wymondley Priory still stands. The chapel where the family was baptized for two hundred years is still there — it has been altered, of course, in the way old English buildings are always altered, but the building is recognizable. The cloister yard is recognizable. The east range where Barbara's bedroom looked out across the cloister yard, where she kept her writing-desk at the east window for the better part of two decades, is recognizable. The road to Hitchin runs past the gatehouse just as it ran past the gatehouse in October 1713 when she rode out of it for the last time.

* * *

I have not yet been to Wymondley. I plan to go.

I have arranged, when the planning is done, to walk through the chapel where she was baptized and to stand for a while in the cloister yard where she met him. I want to put my hand on the doorframe she would have put her hand on. I want to know what the air smells like in October in north Hertfordshire. I want to read the parish register at Great Wymondley with my own eyes, even though I have already read the transcript, even though I know what it says. I want to see the words Barbary Nedham in the hand of a 1685 parish clerk.

I want to bring my daughters with me when I go.

They are still in school for now, but they will not be in school forever, and one of these years they will be old enough to make the trip. I would like them to walk through the priory the way I walked into this project two and a half years ago — not knowing what they will find, only knowing that someone they came from is somewhere in those rooms. I would like them to put their own hands on the doorframe. I would like them to stand in the cloister yard at evening, the way Barbara stood with Christopher in April 1710, and feel, in the cold north Hertfordshire air, that they have arrived somewhere they have been before.

They have been there before. They have been there for three hundred and twelve years.

This book has been my attempt to bring them back.

* * *

There is a sentence in a book published in New York in 1925 that I have been arguing with for almost two and a half years. The sentence says that on the twenty-second of February 1714, at Charleston, South Carolina, Christopher VI de Graffenried married Barbara Tempest (née Needham), daughter of the distinguished Sir Arthur Needham of Wymondsley, Hertfordshire, England.

The sentence is wrong about the father. There was no Sir Arthur. Her father was Maurice, a fourth son who never inherited land, who married Letisia Bowyer of the Hertfordshire-Bedfordshire Wingate cousinage, who died in November 1712 of a fever that came on after he returned from an extended stay at Lockleys, and who never lived to learn that his daughter had sailed.

But the sentence is right about the rest of it.

She was Barbara Tempest, née Needham. She was of Wymondsley, Hertfordshire, England — the parish clerk's spelling, slightly off, of Wymondley. She was distinguished, in the deeper sense of the word: she was the eighth-generation daughter of a Hertfordshire gentry family that had held a converted Augustinian priory for almost two centuries, descended from Crown servants and Elizabethan courtiers and Civil War survivors, the great-great-great-great-granddaughter of James Nedham, Surveyor of the King's Works to Henry VIII.

She was, in the only way the word actually matters, distinguished by what she did. She got on a ship.

* * *

Volume II opens on a wedding.

Part Two — Volume II: Virginia and Carolina, 1742 to 1794

Bridge — Charleston, February 1714

The brigantine *Hopewell* came up the Charleston roads in the late morning of Thursday the eleventh of February 1714, half-rigged at the foremast from the storm of the third of January, with a south-southeast wind on her starboard quarter and Mr. Eldridge himself at the wheel, and made her landing at the Cooper Street pier at twenty minutes past nine.

Barbara Tempest Needham, twenty-eight years and four months old, stood at the rail in her wool cloak with the hood down and watched the colony come up at her.

It came up slowly. Sullivan's Island first, low and green at the south end of the harbor channel; then the curve of the inner roads; then the line of warehouses and the cluster of masts of the small Carolina coasting fleet and, behind it, the wooden curtain wall along Meeting Street and the spire of the half-built Cooper Street church and the brown roofs of the merchants' houses, and over all of it a thin coal-smoke and a thin February sun that did not, even at midday, give the impression of giving heat.

She did not look for him at first. She knew he would be there. He had been on a bench at the landward end of the Cooper Street pier every morning since the eighth of January, Mr. Eldridge had told her — the harbor master, who had come aboard the night before at the outer roads with the pilot, had volunteered it without being asked — and so when she came down to the deck in the morning and put her hood down and stood at the rail she did not, in the first minute, look for him. She watched the colony come up. She gave it a minute on its own.

Then she looked.

He was on a bench by the harbor master's shed, in a brown coat, with a hat in his hand. He had stood up when the *Hopewell* came past the south end of Sullivan's Island. He was, at this distance — a quarter-mile, perhaps a little less — a small upright figure with a hand raised above his head, palm forward, the way a child raises his hand in a schoolroom to say *here, here, I am here*.

She raised her own hand to her shoulder, palm forward, and held it there.

He saw it.

He did not lower his hand for some seconds after that. When he did, he sat down again on the bench, because his knees, she suspected from the way he sat down, were not at that moment entirely reliable.

The *Hopewell* came up to the pier. The longshoremen took the lines. The gangway went down. Mr. Eldridge nodded to her without saying anything, because Mr. Eldridge had decided some days earlier that this particular passenger should be allowed to walk down his gangway and into her new life without further interruption from the man who had brought her across, and Barbara, who had spent fourteen weeks learning to read Mr. Eldridge's silences, nodded back.

She walked down the gangway.

She did not hurry. She had been at sea for one hundred and six days. Her legs, at the foot of the gangway, would have to learn the pier. She let them learn it.

Christopher had got up off the bench again by the time she came down. He stood at the landward end of the pier, by the harbor master's shed, with the hat still in his hand. He did not, for a moment, say anything.

Then he said: *Barbara.*

She said: *Christopher.*

He said: *You came.*

She said: *I told you I would.*

He said — and his voice was not quite steady, which was the first time she had heard his voice not be quite steady, and which she filed away with the other things she had begun to file away on his account since the seventeenth of October 1710 — *I have been waiting for you on this bench for thirty-five days.*

She said: *I have been at sea for one hundred and six days.*

He said: *I know.*

She said: *I do not think you do, quite, yet. But you will.*

He said: *Yes.*

He did not, in the moment, embrace her. They were on a public pier at a colonial harbor in the morning, surrounded by longshoremen and harbor officials and the other passengers coming down behind her, and Christopher was a man of careful Reformed-Protestant Swiss-Bernese formality and Barbara was an English gentlewoman of Hertfordshire upbringing, and the embrace would wait for the carriage Mrs. Brewton had sent down and the drive to the lodgings on Tradd Street and the moment of being alone together for the first time in three years and nine months.

He took her bag from her hand. She let him take it. He offered her his arm. She took it.

They walked up the Cooper Street pier together, with Hans behind them carrying the trunk that had come down first from the *Hopewell's* hold. At the landward end of the pier Christopher stopped and turned to her.

He said: *The Reverend Johnston has been waiting. He is at the Cooper Street church. Whenever you are ready.*

She said: *Eleven days. I should like eleven days. I would like to rest, and to write to my mother, and to see Susannah settled with Mrs. Bellinger. Then we should be married.*

He said: *Eleven days. The twenty-second of February.*

She said: *Yes.*

He said: *That is a Monday.*

She said: *That is a Monday.*

* * *

She slept that first night at Mrs. Brewton's on Tradd Street, in a bed that did not move under her, and woke in the dark before dawn because the absence of motion was a thing she had to learn before she could sleep through it.

The room held a four-poster with a faded blue counterpane, a chair by the window, a chest at the foot of the bed, a small table with a basin and a pewter ewer, a candle in a brass stick on the table, a mirror over the basin, and a print of the new King George above the mantel. The fire was low. The diamond panes of the window faced east toward the harbor and were beginning, in the next quarter hour, to take a paler shade of gray than the room around them.

She put her hand flat on the counterpane.

The counterpane did not move.

She lay still for a long time and listened to the silence under her — not silence, exactly: a creaking of timbers somewhere lower in the house, a watchman's bell two streets over, the wind off the harbor under the eaves — but silence of the kind that has a floor in it, a floor that does not lift and fall, a floor that holds.

The floor held.

She got up. She dressed in the half-light without ringing for the maid, because she had not, in fourteen weeks, had a maid to ring for, and the habit of dressing herself was still the habit she trusted. She went to the window and put her hand on the sill and looked east through the panes toward the harbor.

The *Hopewell* was at the pier. She could see the half-rig of the foremast in the gray light. Beyond the harbor the sky was beginning to come up a thin lemon at the horizon line.

She did not, in that first quarter hour, think anything in particular. The morning was a thing to be inside of. She watched the lemon at the horizon line widen.

Then she went down to the parlor.

Mrs. Brewton was at the parlor already — Mrs. Brewton, the Tradd Street widow at whose house the Charleston factor had engaged a set of rooms for Christopher in early December and at whose house Barbara would now keep the eleven days. She was a woman of perhaps fifty, in a gray gown and a white cap, sitting by the fire with a piece of needlework on her knee, and she stood up when Barbara came in and curtsied with the careful courtesy a Charleston lodging-house keeper extended to the bride of a foreign-born gentleman who had paid in advance for the rooms.

She said: *Good morning, ma'am. I had not expected you down before seven.*

Barbara said: *I have not had a floor under me in fourteen weeks. I find I do not, this morning, want to be in a bed.*

Mrs. Brewton said: *I will have coffee in the dining-room in five minutes.*

She had coffee in the dining-room in five minutes. The coffee was strong and hot and tasted of the bean itself rather than the ship's stores Barbara had been drinking out of a tin cup since November. She drank two cups of it and ate a piece of cornbread that Mrs. Brewton put in front of her without asking, and at seven

o'clock the London case-clock in the parlor struck the hour — Mrs. Brewton's late husband had brought the clock out from London in 1685, she said quietly as she poured the second cup — and a quarter of an hour after that, while Barbara was still at the table, Christopher came in from the street.

He had been at the Cooper Street pier already that morning to see Susannah Fenwick down to Mrs. Bellinger's carriage. He had a folded sheet in his hand — Susannah's note of thanks, written on board the *Hopewell* the previous afternoon — and a careful look about the eyes that said he had not, last night, slept either.

He sat down across from her at the table. He set the note between them.

He said: *Susannah is at Mrs. Bellinger's. Mrs. Bellinger came for her at six.*

She said: *Good.*

He said: *I have not slept.*

She said: *Nor I.*

He said: *I did not know what to do with the night.*

She said: *Sit down, Christopher. Have coffee. We have eleven days. We will use them.*

He sat. He had coffee. They used the morning.

* * *

The eleven days went the way they went.

Susannah Fenwick was at Mrs. Bellinger's in St. Michael's parish, recovering, the cough easing in the dry Carolina air the way it had not eased in the damp of the ship; Barbara went to see her on the third day and on the seventh and on the tenth, and on the tenth Susannah was dressed and downstairs and had begun to be useful to Mrs. Bellinger in the household ledger, which was the task Mrs. Bellinger had set for her in the contract, and Mrs. Bellinger had pronounced herself, in three meetings, more impressed with the young woman than she had expected to be on the basis of the brother's letter from Bristol.

Barbara wrote to her mother at Lockleys on the second day, a long letter, addressed to a house that had taken her in and was not hers; to her cousin's wife in Hertfordshire on the third; to the Reverend Mr. Pelham at Wymondley on the fourth, briefly, to thank him for the silver groat. The letters went into a packet that the Charleston factor undertook to put on the next eastbound packet for Bristol, which Mr. Eldridge believed would sail in the middle of March. She did not, in any of the letters, say more than the documented facts required: the *Hopewell* had landed; she was well; she was at Charleston; she would be married on the twenty-second of February; Christopher was as he had been. The letters would arrive in England in June. By June whatever she said in February would have been said already, and so she said the documented things and let the rest stand.

Christopher came to the lodging-house at seven each morning and went back to the harbor master's shed at ten, because the shed had become his daytime office in the five weeks of the bench and he had business there with the

Charleston factor and with the Reverend Johnston and with the merchant Allston who would stand as his witness at the wedding. He came back at four in the afternoon and sat with her in the parlor, the two of them in the chairs by the fire, with the door open onto the hall so that Mrs. Brewton or the maid could pass back and forth and the propriety could be observed; and they talked, in the afternoons, of the things that two people who have crossed a long absence and who are about to be married in eleven days find themselves talking of.

They talked of New Bern.

They talked of the half-built house there and of the cleared field and of the cat and of Hans and of the runner Wilkes and of the four letters that had arrived together on the seventeenth of November. They talked of the Yamasee unrest at the south end of the colony and of the Tuscarora settlement at the north end and of the Carolina Land Office obligation that Christopher had been holding through the autumn. They talked of Williamsburg — Christopher had business there in the spring; he had taken a lot already, Lot 47, the Pitt-Dixon corner; he meant for them to be at Williamsburg by the autumn — and of the brick house he meant to build on the lot and of the rooms he meant for her and of the books from his father's library he meant to send for.

She listened, mostly. He had been alone on a half-built farm in a half-emptied colony for three years and four months and he had a great deal to say. She let him say it. She had crossed an ocean for him and there was a great deal she had to say too, but she had decided, by the second afternoon, that she would say it slowly, over years, and not in eleven days.

She did say one thing on the fourth afternoon.

She said: *Christopher. I have learned to be useful at sea. I do not know yet how to be useful on land, and I do not know what will be asked of me at New Bern or at Williamsburg. But I will not be ornamental. I would like you to know that.*

He looked at her over the rim of the coffee cup.

He said: *Barbara. I have never thought you ornamental. I would not have written to your father in 1710 if I had thought you ornamental.*

She said: *Good. Then we understand each other.*

He said: *I think we have understood each other since the chapel garden at Wymondley.*

She said: *Yes. I think we have.*

* * *

The wedding morning was the morning of Monday the twenty-second of February 1714, and it began for Barbara at five o'clock in the bed at Mrs. Brewton's, in the dark, with the floor still holding under her and the case-clock striking five somewhere in the parlor below.

She did not get up at once. She lay in the bed and counted the days backward — twenty-two, twenty-one, twenty, nineteen, eighteen, seventeen, sixteen, fifteen, fourteen, thirteen, twelve — and arrived at the morning of the twelfth of

February, which was the morning she had stood at this window and watched the lemon at the horizon line widen, and she thought: *I have been here eleven days. I have been on land eleven days. In four hours I will not be Barbara Tempest Needham any longer.*

She got up.

She dressed in the gown the Charleston seamstress had altered in the second week — a dark wool, with the waist taken in two inches against the slack the ship's stores had put there. She did her hair herself, because the maid at Mrs. Brewton's had a Carolina hand and Barbara had a Hertfordshire one and the two hands did not entirely agree on the question of pins. She put on the small pearl earrings her cousin's wife had given her in the priory yard the morning before she left.

She went down to the parlor at half-past eight.

Mrs. Brewton was at the parlor in her best gray gown and her best white cap. The fire was high. The London case-clock had been wound. The widow Mrs. Houghton was there from her own lodgings on Church Street, and Mr. Pelletier in his Bristol broadcloth, the two of them having come early to walk with Barbara to the church. They had been her shipmates and they would be her witnesses, and they were both, in the parlor at half-past eight, in the careful courteous mode of people who have come through a fourteen-week crossing with a young woman they have grown fond of and are now about to give her away.

At nine o'clock Christopher came for her. He was in a dark coat she had not seen before — Allston had had it made for him in the second week — and he had Hans behind him in his good livery, and the carriage Mrs. Brewton had engaged was at the door.

He said: *Barbara.*

She said: *Christopher.*

He said: *Are you ready?*

She said: *Yes.*

* * *

They were married at the Cooper Street church in Charleston on Monday the twenty-second of February 1714, the Reverend Gideon Johnston officiating, with the widow Mrs. Houghton and Mr. Pelletier from the *Hopewell* standing as witnesses for the bride and Hans the Swiss manservant and a Charleston merchant named Allston standing as witnesses for the groom and Mr. Eldridge himself in the second pew in his good coat.

Susannah Fenwick attended, in a borrowed dress, on the arm of her new employer Mrs. Bellinger, who had collected her from the ship eleven days earlier and who had pronounced herself, in those eleven days, more impressed with the young woman than she had expected to be on the basis of the brother's letter from Bristol.

The Reverend Johnston was a slight man of thirty-eight, English-trained, six years and ten months at Charleston as commissary for the Bishop of London, in poor health that winter but holding. He read the office in the careful Anglican English Barbara had heard at Wymondley every Sunday of her childhood, and Christopher answered in the careful Anglican English he had learned at the Reformed academy in Switzerland and at Yverdon and at the Inns of Court, and Barbara answered in the careful Anglican English of a Hertfordshire gentlewoman, and the office took half an hour.

The marriage was entered in the church register on the same day.

When they came out of the church into the Cooper Street it was raining a thin cold rain that had begun while they were inside. Mr. Eldridge had a great-coat for Barbara that he had brought down himself from the *Hopewell*. He put it over her shoulders without saying anything. She nodded to him.

They went back to Mrs. Brewton's in the carriage. The wedding-supper was at three o'clock, in Mrs. Brewton's dining-room — Mrs. Brewton and Mrs. Bellinger had arranged it together — and Mrs. Houghton and Mr. Pelletier and Allston and Mr. Eldridge and Hans and Susannah and the Reverend Johnston sat down at table with the bride and groom; and Mrs. Brewton's cook had made a Carolina ham and a dish of rice with the new orange spice the Charleston factors had begun to bring up from the Spanish Main, and a custard, and there was Madeira from Allston's cellar, and the company stayed three hours and went home in a hard rain at six.

By seven Mrs. Brewton had cleared the dining-room. By eight the house was quiet. By half-past eight Barbara was in the chair by the window of the upper room with her shoes off and her feet on the fender, watching the harbor through the diamond panes a quarter-mile to the east, where the *Hopewell* lay at her mooring with one lantern at her stern and a second at her mainmast head and the half-rig of the foremast a darker thing against the dark sky.

She was asleep in the chair by nine.

* * *

Christopher de Graffenried sat at the writing-desk under the east window with the candle in front of him and the small leather-bound family Bible his father had given him before he sailed in 1710 open at the fly-leaf.

The Bible was eight inches by five, bound in dark calf, the binding rubbed at the corners from four years on the road — Worb to Bern, Bern to London, London to Charleston in 1710, Charleston to New Bern in 1711, New Bern to Williamsburg in 1712, Williamsburg to New Bern in 1712, New Bern to Charleston in December 1713. The fly-leaf was the front fly-leaf, the recto, the page the Baron had left clean for him when he gave him the Bible at Worb on the seventeenth of August 1710. The Baron had said, when he gave it to him: *You will marry in the new country. You will write the entry on that page. I will not be there to write it for you. Write it in French. Write it in your own hand.*

Christopher had carried the Bible at the bottom of his sea-chest from August 1710 to February 1714. The fly-leaf had stayed clean.

He had the pen ready. He had cut it himself an hour earlier from a quill Mrs. Brewton had brought up, in the careful way his father had taught him to cut a pen when he was nine years old. He had the ink — Mrs. Brewton's ink, a Carolina ink, a slightly browner ink than the Bernese inks of his childhood, but a good ink, a steady ink, an ink that would hold on the page for two hundred years if the page was kept out of the damp. He had the blotting-paper. He had the small ruler he used when he wanted a line to be straight.

He did not use the ruler. He had decided, in the half hour he had been sitting at the desk, that the entry should be in his own hand without the ruler, in the careful French he reserved for the most important entries, the way his father had written the death entry for his mother on the fly-leaf of the Bernberg Bible at Worb in 1697 when Christopher was seven years old and had stood beside him at the writing-desk and had watched the pen go down on the page in the candlelight and had understood, in the way a child of seven could understand it, that the entry on the fly-leaf was the entry the family came back to.

He dipped the pen.

He wrote, in his own hand, in the careful French he reserved for the most important entries:

> Christophe de Graffenried, fils du Baron Christophe V de Bernberg, époux. Barbara Tempest née Needham, de Wymondley en Hertfordshire, épouse. Mariés en l'église du commissaire à Charleston, en Caroline du Sud, le vingt-deuxième jour de février, 1714.

He set the pen down. He blotted the entry. He looked at it.

The entry was in his hand. The French was correct. The date was correct. The names were correct. The church was correct. The father, the bride, the place, the day. The entry was the entry the Baron had told him to make. The entry was what the family would come back to.

He sat for a long time at the desk with the candle in front of him and the Bible open and the entry on the page and his bride in the chair by the window with her feet on the fender and her breathing the steady breathing of a woman who had walked into a colony on land that did not move under her and had taken a man's name at eleven o'clock in the morning of a Monday in February and had eaten Carolina ham at three and had sat down in a chair at half-past eight and had fallen asleep before nine.

He looked at her once. He looked back at the page.

He had not, in twenty-four years of his life, written anything in English that mattered to him.

He had been writing letters in French to his father since he was nine. He had been writing entries in the household ledger at Worb in French and German since he was eleven. He had written in English at the Reformed academy when he had to and at Yverdon when he had to and at the Inns of Court when he had to and in

Carolina when he had to, but the writing in English had been business writing, factor's writing, surveyor's writing, the writing of a man transacting business in a language not his own. He had never, in twenty-four years, written anything in English that he meant.

The formal entry was sealed. The page was the family's. The Bible was the keeping-Bible. The French on the page was what the Baron had told him to write and what the family would come back to.

But there was room on the page. There was room beneath the formal entry. There was, on the fly-leaf, a clean half-inch of paper between the bottom of the careful French and the top of the lower margin where the Baron had said nothing about what could or could not go.

He dipped the pen again. He held it above the page. He thought, very precisely, of the morning of the seventeenth of November 1713 — the runner Wilkes coming up the river path in the late afternoon at New Bern, the leather pouch, the four letters and the canvas-wrapped packet from the Baron, and the thin folded sheet at the bottom of the pouch with no salutation and no date and no signature and three words in a hand he had known since the chapel garden at Wymondley in October 1710 — *I am coming*. He thought of the bench at the harbor master's shed and of the thirty-five mornings he had sat on it. He thought of the south end of Sullivan's Island and of the half-rig of the foremast coming up at twenty minutes past nine of a Thursday morning. He thought of a quarter-mile and of a hand raised palm forward above a head at the rail of a brigantine and of his own hand going up before he had told it to go up.

He thought of two words.

He wrote them, in a hand smaller than the hand he had used for the formal entry, in English, in a hand that was not quite his usual hand because it was a hand being written by a man whose throat had been swollen with feeling for thirty-five days and who had finally, this Monday evening, in the upper room at Mrs. Brewton's on Tradd Street in Charleston, with his wife asleep in the chair by the window and the candle burning down and the Charleston harbor visible through the diamond panes a quarter-mile to the east — finally been able to write what he had wanted to write since the seventeenth of November 1713 at New Bern, when a thin folded sheet with no salutation and no date and no signature had arrived in his hand and had changed his life. He wrote, in small clear letters:

She came.

* * *

End of Bridge.

Chapter 1 — Lunenburg, Summer 1742

The country

In the summer of 1742, when this chapter opens, the family that would keep the Christopher VI Bible at a south-side-Virginia seat for the next half-century did not yet have the seat, did not yet have the keeping, and was carried in a single descendant of nineteen who had not yet married and did not yet hold the Bible. The Bible was at Williamsburg, on the writing-desk of a living man. The seat was a decade off and unbuilt. The county that would give the chapter its name had not been cut from the older country around it and would not be for four more years. What the summer held was a young man, a country he was turning toward, and a father at Williamsburg who had a little more than three months to live.

The young man was Anton Tscharner DeGraffenreid. He had been born at Williamsburg on the twenty-eighth of November 1722, in the early evening, eight and a half years after his parents had married at Charleston. He had been baptized there twelve days later by Commissary Blair, with the Honorable Nathaniel Harrison standing as one of his godfathers. He had grown up in the house his father had bought in 1717 on the south side of Duke of Gloucester Street, two blocks east of the Governor's Palace — the house that would stand into the present century and be shown to visitors under another family's name. He was the only child of the marriage. His mother, Barbara Tempest Needham of Wymondley in Hertfordshire, who had come across the Atlantic in the winter of 1714 to a colony that had nearly killed the man she came to marry, was dead. The year is not firm in the surviving record, but she was gone before 1742, somewhere in Virginia, in the late 1730s or the first years of the 1740s, and the documents that would say more about her end have not been found. So in the summer of 1742 the Williamsburg house held two men: the father, Christopher VI, fifty-one years old that December; and the son, nineteen, with the country to the south-west opening in front of him.

The country to the south-west was the south side of the James River drainage, the long roll of falling tobacco land between the great river and the Carolina line, drained by the Nottoway and the Meherrin and the Roanoke as they ran south-east toward the Albemarle Sound. It was the planting frontier of Virginia in the 1730s and 1740s — the country into which the tidewater families had been pushing their patents and their second sons for two decades, up the river valleys, onto the red-clay ridges, ahead of the surveyor and a step ahead of the law's catching up with the survey. The land was tobacco land where it was good and timber-and-grazing land where it was not, and the man who took up a patent on it took it up to clear it and crop it and to leave it to a son who would clear more. The economy the country ran on was the leaf — tobacco as the staple, tobacco as the freight, tobacco as the money in a country that had little coin, the hogsheads rolled down to the inspection warehouses on the river and the river carrying them

to the factors at the falls and at the bay. A man's standing in the country was the acreage he had patented and the hands he had to crop it and the hogsheads he sent down in the autumn. It was a new country in the sense that mattered: it was being made, in those years, by the men who were moving onto it, and a man of nineteen with a name behind him and a little capacity in front of him could make a place in it that his father's tidewater generation had not had to make from nothing.

The administrative country was Brunswick County. Lunenburg, which would give this chapter its name and would hold the family's seat for fifty years, did not exist in the summer of 1742; it would be cut from the western reach of Brunswick in 1746, four years on, when the settlement had spread far enough up the drainages to want a courthouse nearer than the old one. So the lane and the standing oak and the long table and the parlor desk that every later chapter of this book returns to were, in 1742, neither built nor in a county that had its later name. The ground was there. The county around it would change its name once before the family's house went up on it. The historian who wants to be exact says Brunswick in 1742 and Lunenburg from 1746, and lets the reader understand that the land did not move and only the line on the map and the name above the courthouse door did.

Into that country, by descent and by the turn of his own life, came Anton DeGraffenreid in 1742. The descent was Swiss, and it had come to Virginia by way of a colonial venture that had failed. His grandfather was Christopher V, Baron de Bernberg, the Bernese patrician who had carried a charter and a body of Swiss and Palatine settlers to North Carolina in 1710 and founded New Bern on the Neuse, and who had seen the venture broken by the Tuscarora War and by debt, and who had gone home to Switzerland in 1713 with the colony behind him. His father, Christopher VI, born at Worb near Bern in 1690 and educated for two years at a Reformed academy there, had come out to Carolina with the venture as a young man, had survived the war and the fever that had killed the colony's people around him, and had not gone home with his father. He had stayed in America. He had married an Englishwoman at Charleston in 1714 and had brought her up to Williamsburg, and he had made the turn that the grandfather had not lived to make in the new country. He had stopped being a colonist of a failed Swiss venture and had become a Virginian with a house and a lot and a son. The son was the third generation of it and the first to be born on the ground — Williamsburg-born, Virginia-raised, with the Swiss name and a Swiss grandfather he had never seen and a Bernese formal hand his father had taught him to write, and with no country behind him but this one.

The hand his father had taught him is the thread that matters most to what is coming, and it is worth naming here at the country's scale before it does its work later at the desk's scale. The DeGraffenreids kept their family record in a Bible, and they kept it in a particular way. The most important entries — the marriages, the deaths, the births that turned the line — were written on the fly-leaf in formal

French, in the keeper's own hand, deliberately and without haste, the way the Baron had written the death of his own wife at Worb in 1697 and the way Christopher VI had written his marriage at Charleston in 1714 with the smaller English words *She came* beneath it. It was a Swiss family's habit carried into an English colony and held there: French for the record, the keeper's own hand for the record, the fly-leaf for the record, and the Bible as the thing the family came back to. Christopher VI had taught the form to his son as the Baron had taught it to him, pen-cutting and all, beginning when the boy was old enough to hold a pen. In the summer of 1742 the form was a thing the son had been taught and had not yet had cause to use. The Bible on which he would use it was his father's still, on the desk at Williamsburg, and the keeping of it was his father's still.

What turned Anton toward the south-side country in 1742 was a marriage. He was to marry Mary Baker, the daughter of Colonel Henry Baker of Chowan in North Carolina — of the Albemarle planter country across the Virginia line, the older country to the south where the Carolina families had been seated since the previous century. The match joined two kinds of people the south-side frontier was joining all through those years: a Virginia family of recent gentry standing and continental origin, two generations off the boat and one generation onto the land, and an established Carolina planter family of the Albemarle, with a colonel's title and a seat in Chowan and daughters to settle into the new country opening to the north of them. How the match was made the record does not say, and the historian who keeps to the record does not invent the courtship; what the record gives is the colonel, the daughter, the date, and the place far enough along to be sure of: the fifth of July 1742. The name the daughter carried — Baker, her father's name — would go down the line as a Christian name and then as a woman's name across the generations this book follows. It came to rest, two generations on, in the heroine of these chapters, who would be christened Mary Baker for the grandmother she never knew. But that is the long reach of it, and it is enough, at the country's scale, to say that the name came into the family in 1742 with a colonel's daughter from Chowan, and to let it travel.

So the summer stood at a hinge that none of the people in it could see as a hinge, the way the people in a summer never can. At Williamsburg the father kept his house and his lot and his Bible and had, though he did not know it and the record does not say he was ill, a little more than three months left to live. To the south-west the country lay open and half-made, Brunswick still and Lunenburg not yet, the tobacco land rolling down toward the Carolina line. Across that line, in Chowan, a colonel's daughter was to be married in July. And between the Williamsburg house and the southern country moved a young man of nineteen with a Swiss name and a hand he had been taught and a marriage in front of him, who would in that one year of 1742 marry a wife, lose a father, and take up a Bible. He would, a decade later, on a ridge of south-side land, build the seat where the keeping he was about to inherit would be done for the next fifty years. The country was the ground of all of it. The chapter begins on the ground, in the

summer, before any of it has happened, with the line carried in one unmarried man and the Bible still on another man's desk a hundred miles to the east.

The Bakers and the match

The daughter Tscharner DeGraffenreid was to marry in July came from across the Carolina line, out of a country older than the one he was turning toward, and out of a family that had made, a generation before his own, the same kind of motion his made now. Mary Baker was the daughter of Colonel Henry Baker of Chowan in North Carolina. The Bakers were Albemarle planters, seated south of the Virginia line in the older Carolina country where the families had held their ground since the previous century. They had come to be seated there the way the DeGraffenreids were about to be seated on the south-side ridges — by a family pushing out of an older tidewater country into a newer one, carrying a name and a little standing and the habit of taking up land and leaving it to a son. The DeGraffenreid motion was continental into Virginia. The Baker motion had been Virginia into Carolina. They met along the same line, the long survey-and-patent line between the James drainage and the Albemarle, that both families had been crossing for two generations in opposite directions.

The Baker descent ran back across that line into tidewater Virginia, to Surry County on the south bank of the James. The first of them the record holds was Lawrence Baker of Surry, a burgess, whose will was proved in 1681. His son Henry Baker took up patents in Surry in 1683 and 1684 and married Mary Blake, a daughter of Colonel John Blake of Nansemond — Nansemond and Surry standing married into the line. And it was out of that Surry-and-Nansemond family that the Bakers crossed into the Albemarle and seated themselves in Chowan, in the person of the second Henry Baker, the colonel whose daughter Tscharner was to marry. So the Bakers had done, a generation earlier, what the DeGraffenreids were doing now. A family of standing in an older country had sent itself onto a newer one, down the river valleys, onto the planting ground, ahead of nobody but the next family behind it. The continental name was moving into Virginia in 1714; the Virginia name had moved into Carolina before it. The two motions met in a marriage in 1742, on a line both families had spent two generations learning to cross.

What the colonel had made of the move was a standing the record carries plainly. Henry Baker of Chowan held Bucklands, a plantation of some two thousand five hundred acres; he was colonel of the colonial militia, and the record carries him also as sheriff, as captain, as burgess, and as a justice of the peace of Chowan, commissioned to that bench in 1731. He held the ferry that crossed the Chowan River — the Henry Baker Ferry, running between the Mt. Gallant fishery and the mouth of the Meherrin, in use before 1722 — so that the river-crossing his country depended on carried his name. This was real standing in the Albemarle, the standing of a man who had patented and held and been trusted with the

offices a planting country hands to its substantial men. It is renderable from the record without a scene built around it. The historian who keeps to the documents can say what the colonel was — the acreage, the title, the bench, the ferry — and does not need to invent a day in his life to say it.

Her mother's people stood on standing of their own. Mary's mother was Ruth Chancey, the colonel's second wife, a daughter of Edmund Chancey of Pasquotank — the Honorable Edmund Chancey, a judge under the proprietary government, on the older Albemarle side of the country. Mary was one of the colonel's daughters by Ruth, set in the record among a houseful of brothers and sisters: John and Blake and David and Zadock, Mary and Sarah and Ruth. So the line the documents fix her into is gentry on both sides at the Albemarle scale — a colonel's daughter on her father's side, a judge's granddaughter on her mother's — with brothers to inherit the colonel's land and the colonel's offices, and a daughter's place of her own among them.

But the colonel was not living to give her. Henry Baker's will had been proved in 1739, three years before the July date, and Bucklands had passed to his eldest son, the third Henry Baker; so when Mary married in 1742 she married out of her late father's country and out of a seat her brother now held, not out of the colonel's living hand. The country was the colonel's and the name was the colonel's and the standing she carried into the marriage was the standing he had made. But the man himself was three years in the ground, and the Baker seat she went from was a brother's house. The historian does not stage the colonel at the wedding, because there is no colonel to stage. What the colonel gives this chapter he gives from the record and from the grave: a country, a name, a line, and a daughter already three years fatherless when she married north across the line.

This is the documented shape of the joining, and it is worth naming plainly at the historian's distance, because the distance must not be let to erase the woman inside it. Mary Baker married at about nineteen. She married out of a father's house that was now a brother's, a colonel's daughter without the colonel, into a continental-origin Virginia family two generations off the boat and one onto the land, and she married north across the line into a country newer and rougher than the one she left — the Albemarle for the south-side frontier, an established seat for a patent not yet built on. What the record does not give is how the match was made or whether the choosing was hers, and the historian who keeps to the record does not invent it. What the record does give is the shape of the thing: a young woman of marrying age, her father dead, her family's seat in a brother's keeping, joined to a man of nineteen whose own father was alive a hundred miles east and whose own seat was a decade from being built. Where a no was hers to say, the record does not say she said it; where the conditions of an Albemarle daughter's marriage in 1742 narrowed what a no could have meant — a fatherless daughter, a brother's house, a country filling up to the north and wanting wives — the conditions are nameable, and the historian names them and goes no closer.

What the match founded was a household, and the household began where the marriage put it — not at Bucklands, which the bride was leaving, and not at Williamsburg, which was the groom's father's and not the groom's, but on the south-side ground Tscharner had turned toward, his own patented land between the rivers. The first dwelling there was rough, a frontier first house on a man's own ground, the kind a man put up to live in while he made the place. The seat the family would keep for fifty years — the lane, the ridge, the long table, the parlor desk — was not that first house. It was the second, chosen and built a decade on, when the place had been worked into something to hold a seat. So the household the July marriage founded was founded in principle in 1742 and built on the ground in the early 1750s: a marriage first, a rough first dwelling, and then, when the country was made enough to carry it, the seat itself. The ground was there in 1742. The marriage was there in 1742. The seat was a decade off and unbuilt.

And the name came in with her. The name the marriage brought into the family was Baker, and it is the name this book has come to follow. It came in as a wife's father's name in 1742 and it did not leave. The first child of the marriage was a son, born on the sixth of August 1744, and he was given the name Baker DeGraffenreid — the mother's father's name set in front of the father's, a Carolina colonel's surname made a Virginia child's Christian name. That is the seed of it. The name would go down the line that way, the father's-name-as-given-name and then, in its turn, a woman's name, until it came to rest two generations on in the heroine of these chapters, christened Mary Baker for the grandmother she never knew. But that is the long reach, and the record lets the historian carry it only this far cleanly: a colonel's daughter from Chowan married into the family in 1742, and a son born in 1744 carried her father's name forward as his own.

So the match that turned Tscharner toward the south-side country joined two families that had each, in their turn, left an older country for a newer one and crossed the same line to do it. On the one side a continental name two generations into Virginia and one onto the land; on the other an Albemarle planter family a generation into Carolina, a colonel three years dead, a seat in a brother's hands, and a daughter to be married north. The country was the ground of it and the line was the seam of it, and the marriage was made across the seam on the fifth of July 1742, in Chowan, in the bride's country, in a house the record has not kept the name of. How that day went — who stood up with them, what was said, what the formal hand wrote afterward and where — is the next thing this chapter comes to. Here it is enough to have joined the two families on the page the way the marriage joined them on the ground: the name come in, the line begun, the seat still a decade off, and the Bible, through all of it, still on a living man's desk a hundred miles to the east at Williamsburg.

The Bible at Williamsburg; the hand-convention at depth

The hand the father had taught the son has already been named in this chapter, at the country's scale — French for the record, the keeper's own hand for the record, the fly-leaf for the record, and the Bible as the thing the family came back to — and named there deliberately, to do its work later, at the desk's scale. This is the desk's scale. The work is done here, with the historian as close to the page and the object as the surviving record lets him get. In the summer of 1742 the Bible lay where the country's scale had left it: at Williamsburg, on the writing-desk under the east window of the house on the south side of Duke of Gloucester Street, in the keeping of the living man who had carried it across the Atlantic and made its first entry. It was his book and his keeping, and it would be his through the summer and into the autumn. What this section comes close to is the object itself and the convention it carried — the page the family came back to, and the form in which the entries on it were made.

The object was a small book. It was an octavo, about eight inches by five, bound in dark calf, the kind of family Bible a Bernese house of standing gave a son to carry out into the world. The calf was rubbed at the corners, road-worn from the years it had ridden at the bottom of a sea-chest — Worb to Bern, Bern to London, London to Charleston in the crossing of 1710, and then the long Carolina-and-Virginia road of the years after, before it came to rest on a Williamsburg desk. The Baron had given it to Christopher VI clean, at Worb, on the seventeenth of August 1710, before the son sailed for the New Bern venture; and the front fly-leaf — the recto, the first page — had been left clean on purpose, for the entry the Baron foretold and instructed and would not live near enough to write. Christopher VI had carried the book four years with that page empty. The first thing written on it was written in 1714.

The way the entries were made was the convention the chapter has already named, brought now to the depth where it does its work. The entries that mattered most — the marriages, the deaths, the births that turned the line — went on the fly-leaf, and they went there in formal French, in the keeper's own hand, written deliberately and without haste. The fly-leaf was reserved. It was not the page a household kept its lesser business on, not the place for accounts or receipts or the dates of ordinary record-keeping; it was the page the line itself was written on. And the rule the family held about it was a rule of weight: that what turned the line was set down in the formal language and the careful hand and on the one page kept for it, so that a descendant opening the book a hundred years on would find the line where the family had always put it. The convention was Swiss in its origin and was held in an English colony unchanged. The keeper wrote French where another family would have written English, and wrote it in his own hand where another family might have let a clerk or a clergyman enter the fact, because in this family the entering of the fact was the keeper's own office, and the formal language was the mark of the weight the family gave it.

The exemplar of all this, on the fly-leaf in the summer of 1742, was the first entry, the marriage. It had been made at Charleston in February 1714, in Christopher VI's own hand, in the careful French he kept for the entries that mattered — and it lay now at the head of the page, eight inches by five on the Williamsburg desk, twenty-eight years after the keeper had made it. What the historian reads at the head of that fly-leaf is this:

> *Christophe de Graffenried, fils du Baron Christophe V de Bernberg, époux. Barbara Tempest née Needham, de Wymondley en Hertfordshire, épouse. Mariés en l'église du commissaire à Charleston, en Caroline du Sud, le vingt-deuxième jour de février, 1714.*

That is the entry the family's record carries at the level a primary source carries it: the groom named to his father and his father's title, the bride named to her parish and her county in Hertfordshire, the marriage placed at the commissary's church at Charleston in South Carolina on the twenty-second of February 1714. It is the convention's proof — the formal French, the keeper's own hand, the reserved page, all of it on the one leaf. And beneath it, in a smaller hand, in English, were two words the formal entry above did not contain: *She came*. The heroine of the first volume of this history had written from England, in the autumn before the crossing, *I am coming*; and she had come; and the two words beneath the French are the family's record of that, kept not in the formal language of the entry above but in the plain English of the thing itself. The historian sets the French down as the documented line and the words beneath it as the family's coda, and keeps the difference straight without letting it cost the page its meaning.

The form had a source, and the source was another book. Before there was a Christopher VI Bible there was the Bernberg Bible, the Baron's own, kept at Worb; and on its fly-leaf the Baron had written, in 1697, the death of his wife — Christopher VI's mother — in the same formal French and the same reserved hand. That entry was where the convention came from. Christopher VI had been a child of seven when it was made, and had been taught the form young, pen-cutting and all, the way a keeper's son learned it along with his letters. What he carried out of Worb in 1710 was two things that have to be kept apart: the form, which belonged to the Bernberg Bible, and the book, which was his own, given him clean for his own line. The convention crossed from the one book to the other. The object did not. The Bernberg Bible stayed at Worb with the Baron; the calf-bound book went into the sea-chest and across the Atlantic, and the form went with the son, in his hand and his memory, to be written first on his own fly-leaf in 1714.

In the summer of 1742 the keeper of both the book and the convention was alive, fifty-one years old, at Williamsburg, in the house he had bought in 1717. He had come out of Switzerland with the New Bern venture as a young man, had outlived the colony and the fever that killed its people around him, and had stayed in America when his father went home. He had become the thing the Baron had

not lived to become — a man with a house and a lot and a son, and a line begun on the fly-leaf of his own Bible. He was the living keeper, and the keeping was an office he still held: the book was his, the fly-leaf was his to write on, and the next entry that turned the line, whenever it came, was his to make. He had, in that summer, a little more than three months left to live. He died at Williamsburg in October 1742, on a day the surviving record does not name. But that belongs to October, and the summer did not know it; through the summer the keeper kept, and the book was the keeper's, and the page waited at the head of the fly-leaf with one entry on it and room beneath for the ones the line would still require.

The son had been taught the form. Christopher VI had taught Tschärner the convention the way the Baron had taught it to him — the formal French, the keeper's hand, the reserved page, and the cutting of the pen that went with all of it. He had begun when the boy was old enough to hold a pen, so that the form would be in the son's hand long before the son had any entry of his own to make in it. In the summer of 1742 that was where the teaching stood: the son was nineteen, taught and able and not yet the keeper, the form ready in his hand and no occasion yet come to use it. The Bible he had been taught to write in was not his. It was his father's, on his father's desk, with his father living and keeping it. What the son held was the form and the waiting; what the father held was the book and the office; and the distance between them — the taught hand on the one side, the kept book on the other — was the distance the autumn would close. The summer did not close it. The summer held the son taught and the father keeping and the Bible between them on the desk at Williamsburg, the form learned and the line not yet asking the son for an entry.

That was the meaning of the convention, seen at the desk's scale and to the depth the page allows: the Bible was the thing the family came back to, the fly-leaf was where they came back to it, and the form was how the coming-back was done. It was the same formal French and the same keeper's hand, written by each keeper in his turn on the one reserved page, so that the line had one place and one language and one weight of entry across the generations, wherever the seat happened to stand and whoever happened to be holding the book. It reached a long way, that page. It would reach down the line this history follows for the rest of the century. But in the summer of 1742 it reached exactly as far as one entry and the room beneath it, and the historian who keeps to what the summer held keeps it there. The Bible was at Williamsburg. The keeper was living. The son was taught and was not the keeper. The first entry stood at the head of the fly-leaf in the keeper's own French, with the family's two English words beneath it, and the page waited, on a living man's desk, for the next thing the line would come back to put there.

The wedding at distance

The day the match became a marriage was the fifth of July 1742, and it was made in Chowan, in the bride's country. That much the record gives, and gives far enough along to be sure of: the date fixed to the day, the country fixed to the ground the marriage was made on. Mary Baker was married out of her own country and not the groom's — north of the line was where the new household would go, but the joining itself was made south of it, in the Albemarle, where her people were and her father's name still stood. What the record does not give is the building. The civil-or-parish house the marriage was solemnized in, and the man who solemnized it, are not in the surviving sources this history has read — a house the record has not kept the name of, the way it did not keep the name of the rough first dwelling the marriage would put on the south-side ground. So the day comes to the historian with its two ends fixed and its middle open: the when of it and the country of it are sure, and the room it was made in and the man who made it are gone. The honest rendering names both the sureness and the gap and invents nothing to fill it — no church, no parlor, no parson set in to stand where the record is silent. The day is renderable to the country; it is not renderable to the room. The building stands where the record left it, unnamed.

What the day joined was the two families this chapter has already set on either side of one line. The geometry was laid in the match — a continental name two generations into Virginia and one onto the land, and an Albemarle planter family a generation into Carolina, the one motion continental-into-Virginia and the other Virginia-into-Carolina, both of them crossings of the same long survey-and-patent line between the James drainage and the Albemarle. The marriage was that geometry made a fact. The line both families had spent two generations learning to cross was crossed once more on the fifth of July, and crossed for good this time, in the one way a line between two families is ever finally crossed — by a marriage that put the one name and the other into the same household and the same children. The seam had been a thing the families kept crossing in opposite directions. The marriage made it a thing they had crossed together.

The colonel whose daughter she was did not stand at the wedding, because the colonel was three years dead. Henry Baker's will had been proved in 1739, and Bucklands — the plantation, the ferry, the weight of the offices — had passed to his eldest son, the third Henry Baker, so that the seat Mary went from in July 1742 was a brother's house and not her father's. She married out of the colonel's country and under the colonel's name and with the standing the colonel had made, and she married with the colonel himself three years in the ground. The historian does not stage him at the joining, because there is no man to stage. What the colonel gives the day he gives, as he gave the match, from the record and from the grave — a country to be married out of, a name to carry north, a seat that was a brother's now, and a daughter who went from it fatherless.

It is worth holding the woman in view on the day itself, because the historian's distance is exactly the distance at which a bride can go missing from her own wedding. Mary Baker was about nineteen. She was marrying north across the line, out of a brother's house in an older country than the one she was going to, into a continental-origin family one generation onto the land, to a man of nineteen, her own age, whose father was living a hundred miles east and whose seat was a decade from being built. That is the shape of the day as the record holds it, and the record holds it as shape and not as wanting. And the shape had a direction the geometry of the match does not by itself make plain: of the two who crossed the line that day, she was the one who left it behind. The groom married toward his own country, the south-side ground he had patented and turned to; the bride married away from hers, carried north across the line into newer and rougher ground, to keep a household a country away from the people she had been raised among. The crossing the chapter has drawn as a thing two families did to a line was, for her, a leaving of the country she had known. Whether the choosing was hers, whether the going was glad or borne, the surviving sources do not say; where a no would have been hers to make, they do not record that she made it; and where the conditions of a fatherless Albemarle daughter's marriage narrowed what a no could have carried, the conditions are nameable and the feeling is not. The historian names the shape and the conditions and goes no nearer. The day was a marriage made. What it was to her inside it is the one thing the day does not surrender to the record, and the distance keeps faith with her best by saying so.

What the marriage founded began where the marriage put it. Not at Bucklands, which the bride was leaving; not at Williamsburg, which was the father's; but on the south-side ground the groom had patented and turned toward, his own land between the rivers, where a rough first dwelling would do until the country had been worked into something to hold a seat. The household was founded in principle on the fifth of July and built on the ground a decade on. And the day's first forward fact, the one the record carries clean, was a son — Baker DeGraffenreid, born on the sixth of August 1744, the mother's father's name set in front of the father's and carried forward as a child's own. The record lets the day reach exactly that far: a household in principle, a seat a decade off, a son in two years' time. The historian who renders the day reaches with it and no farther.

And through all of it the Bible was a hundred miles east. The book the family came back to lay on the writing-desk at Williamsburg, in the keeping of the living man whose book it still was, and it took no notice of the fifth of July, because nothing was written on it that day. This is the day's quietest fact and, for the line this history follows, very nearly its largest: the marriage that turned the line toward the name the book would come to carry made no entry on the book. The keeper was alive and a hundred miles from the wedding; the form was in the son's hand and the office was not; and an entry went onto the fly-leaf only in the

keeper's own French and the keeper's own hand, which on the fifth of July 1742 meant it did not go on at all. The day made the marriage. It did not make the entry.

There is a rhyme in it the day half-makes, and the historian notices it without pressing it into a meaning. The keeper's own marriage, twenty-eight years before, had been made in the commissary's church at Charleston and entered onto the clean fly-leaf in the formal French — the first thing the book ever carried. The son's was made in a house the record has not kept, under a man it has not named, and went onto no leaf at all that July. The reason it waited is the reason the chapter has been keeping all along: the book was the father's and the office was the father's, and the son was taught and was not the keeper. When the marriage came onto the fly-leaf at last, it came there afterward — but that belongs to the autumn, and the fifth of July did not know it.

So the day did the thing it had been coming to do since the chapter opened on the country, and it did it at the distance the record allows and no nearer. The fifth of July 1742 made a marriage in Chowan, in the bride's country, in a house the record has not kept the name of. It joined the two families across the line both had crossed for two generations. It married a colonel's daughter out of a brother's house, the colonel three years in the ground. It founded a household in principle on the south-side ground, the seat a decade off and a son two years on. And it left the book where the book had been all along — a hundred miles east at Williamsburg, on a living man's desk, the form in the son's hand and the keeping not yet his, the fly-leaf with the one entry on it and the marriage of the fifth of July not yet added to it. The marriage was made. The entry waited. The summer held the one and not the other, and the historian who keeps to the summer keeps them that way.

The October accession

The summer ended, and the thing the summer had not known came in October.

Christopher VI DeGraffenreid died at Williamsburg in October 1742, on a day the surviving record does not name. He was fifty-one; the December birthday that would have carried him to fifty-two was still ahead of him in the autumn, and now would not come. He died in the house he had bought in 1717, on the south side of Duke of Gloucester Street, where the Bible had lain on the writing-desk through the summer in his keeping. The keeping had been a long one. He had carried the book out of Switzerland with the New Bern venture in 1710, outlived the colony and the fever that took its people around him, stayed in America when his father went home, and held the book and the office for more than thirty years; and it ended on a day the record will not give back. The historian renders the death to the month and the place and no nearer. There is no deathbed in the sources, and he builds none — the day is gone the way the wedding's room was gone, and the honest course is to name the gone day as a gap and keep the distance from it.

What the record gives is the fact and the hinge. The keeper died, and the keeping had to pass.

Two things passed, and the chapter has kept them apart through its whole length: the book passed, and the office passed. The book was the calf-bound octavo Christopher VI had carried out of Worb in 1710 and made the first mark on at Charleston in 1714 — not the Bernberg Bible, which had stayed at Worb with the Baron and was, by the autumn of 1742, a world and a generation away and another keeping's concern. The book that passed was the one the chapter has watched on the Williamsburg desk all summer, and it passed to the son. The office passed with it: the fly-leaf his to write on now, the next entry that turned the line his to make. Tscharner DeGraffenreid was nineteen. The distance the chapter had drawn at the desk's scale — the taught hand on the one side and the kept book on the other, the form ready in the son's hand and the book not his — was the distance the autumn would close, and the autumn closed it. How the book came from the father's desk to the son's keeping the record does not say. Whether the son was at Williamsburg when the keeper died or the book was carried to him after, the surviving sources do not give, and the historian does not invent the journey to fill the silence. What the record gives is the end of it: the book that had been the father's was the son's, and the keeping with it.

And here the distance the chapter has kept since it opened on the country gives way, because the keeping that passed to the son was not a thing that could be kept at a distance. It had to be done. An office whose substance is the writing of entries is an office held in the hand, and the hand the father had taught took up the book it had been taught for. The pen-cutting came back to the fingers before the mind had finished telling him the book was his to write in now — the cutting the father had drilled into a boy old enough to hold a pen, so that the form would be in the hand long before the line asked the hand for anything. He had been taught the form for years against an occasion that had not come. The occasion had come. What he understood, taking up the book his father had kept since before he was born, was that the waiting the chapter has named — taught and able and not yet the keeper — was over. What lay past it was not the keeping a boy imagines while he learns to cut a pen. It was two entries the same autumn owed the leaf, the gladdest and the heaviest the form was for, his own marriage and his father's death, come to the page in the same season and the same hand.

So the first thing the new keeper wrote on the fly-leaf was the marriage the summer had left unwritten. He set it beneath the entry his father had made at Charleston twenty-eight years before, in the room the head of the leaf had kept open for the entries the line would still require. He made it the way he had been taught to make it: in the formal French, in his own hand, on the one page the family kept for the things that turned the line. The form was the form he had been taught; what had changed was that the book was his to write it in. What he set down is what the family's record carries beneath the first entry:

> *Tscharner de Graffenried, fils de Christophe de Graffenried, époux. Marie Baker, fille de feu le colonel Henry Baker, du pays d'Albemarle, épouse. Mariés en Chowan, en Caroline du Nord, le cinquième jour de juillet, 1742.*

The groom is named to his father, as his father had been named to the Baron; the bride is named to her father, set down as the late colonel's daughter, three years in the ground when the marriage was made; the marriage is placed to the country and the day. There is no church in it, because there had been none — the marriage was made in a house the record has not kept, and a house has no name to enter where the father's entry had a commissary's church to name. The form names the country when it cannot name the room. And there are no words beneath it: the two English words under the first entry were the first volume's and stayed the only ones; the son added the form and nothing under it. The marriage that made no entry on the fifth of July made its entry now, in the autumn, in the hand of the son who had become the keeper between the wedding and the writing.

The other entry the autumn owed was the one the son would have given much not to make. The same hand, the same French, the same reserved page took the death of Christopher VI — the keeper who had carried the book out of Switzerland and made the first mark on its clean leaf, set down on that leaf at last by the son he had taught to set it down. The historian does not give the words of it. The record gives the fact and the office and not the line, and the weight of the thing is in the office and not the wording: that the first death the new keeper entered was his father's, and that the form the father had drilled into him served, the first sorrowful time it served, to enter the father. The keeping had passed in the doing of it — not on the day the office came to him, but on the day his hand set his father's death where his father had set the family's marriages and dead.

That was the accession: not a ceremony, and not chiefly the settling of a property, though it was partly that, but the passage of the book and the office from the keeper who had held them to the keeper who would hold them next, marked on the one page the family kept its passages on. The summer had held the keeper living, the son taught, and the Bible between them on the desk. The autumn took the keeper, gave the book to the son, and set on the fly-leaf the two entries the line had come back to require — the marriage of the fifth of July the summer had not written, and the death in October the record will not date. The page that had carried one entry through the summer carried three by the end of the year, in the same French as the first, in two hands now, the father's at the head and the son's beneath. There was room beneath them still. A son was two years off — Baker DeGraffenreid, born in the August of 1744, the colonel's name carried in front of the father's into a third generation — and the page would have him when the line came back. But that belongs to the years after, and the autumn of 1742 reached exactly as far as a marriage entered late, a father entered last, and a book that had become the son's to keep. The book had been the father's. It

was the son's now. The line had turned, and the turn was on the page at last, close enough to read, in the hand of the man the line had turned to.

Chapter 2 — The Child at Lunenburg

In the autumn of 1764, at a seat on the south side of the James River drainage that Anton Tscharner DeGraffenreid had built a dozen years before, a daughter was born into a household of three living generations, and this chapter is hers.

The seat was the one the first volume of this history left a decade off and unbuilt. Tscharner had taken up the south-side ground in 1742 and put a rough first dwelling on it, and in the early 1750s, when the country had been worked into something to carry a seat, he had built the second house. It was the house with the lane running out to the road, the great oak standing at the head of the lane, the long table of oak in the hall, and, in the front room, the writing-desk on which the family's Bible lay. The Bible was the one the line had carried since the New Bern venture: a leather-bound family Bible, eight inches by five and bound in dark calf, its fly-leaf carrying the family's names in the keeper's French since 1714. In 1764 it lay on the desk in Tscharner's keeping, where it had lain since his father's death in 1742 and would lie until his own in 1794.

The keeper was the grandfather. Tscharner DeGraffenreid, born at Williamsburg in November 1722, was a man of forty-one that autumn. His first wife — Mary Baker of Chowan, the Carolina colonel's daughter he had married in July 1742 — had been some eight years dead; he had married twice since, and the wife at the seat in 1764 was the third, Eliza Allen Embry, whom he had married the year before. The record carries the marriages and the dates and little more, and this history carries them the same way: as the shape of a long life, named and not dwelt on.

The present master of the household was his son. Baker DeGraffenreid, born on the sixth of August 1744 and named for his mother's father the colonel, was twenty that autumn, married to Sarah Vass, and the father of the seat's children — a son, Vincent, not yet two, and now the daughter. She was christened Mary Baker, for the grandmother eight years in the ground whom she would never know.

The county was Lunenburg, cut from the older south-side country in 1746; the country was tobacco country; the household lived by the leaf and the land as its neighbours did. The chapter that opens here runs from that autumn to the autumn of 1775 — from the child's birth to her eleventh year — across the years the colonies began to tilt toward the war that would take her father out of the house. But those are the grown world's years, and this is the child's chapter, and the years reach it the way they reached her: at the edges, as weather over a house she was learning from the floor up. It begins on that floor.

* * *

She was born in the front room on the third of September, 1764, in the last of the year's warmth, and for a long while the world came to her as the undersides of things.

The ceiling was a long way up. Morning light crossed it from the east window and left it by the middle of the day and came back low and red from the west, and between those hours the plaster was only itself, far and white and still. Under it she lay — in the cradle her father had set near the hearth where the warmth held, in her mother's arms, on the bed in the back room through the heat of the afternoon with the shutters drawn to a slot. The ceiling was over all of it, the same far thing, and the light moved on it, and she followed the light.

The fire was the bright moving thing at the edge of the room. It rose and fell and threw its colour up the walls and onto the plaster, and its warmth came across the floor to where she lay, and when the warmth was on her she was easy and when it drew off she was not. The face came down into the light and went up out of it. It was the largest near thing in the world, and it came when the cold came into her or the hunger or the wet, and it stayed until those went out of her again, and then it went up and the ceiling came back.

The hands were the next thing. They came under her and lifted, and she rose, the whole far room tipping and sliding past, and then she was high against warm cloth and a steady beat under it and the one smell she came back to. A voice went with the face and the hands, low and close; and there were other voices that came from the height of the room and from the next room and from out in the yard; and when hers was off among the others she turned her head the way it was.

The house was loud from the floor. Feet came and went on the boards, heavy and light, quick and slow. There was the knock of wood set down and the long scrape of a chair drawn back and the clap of a door and the iron sound of the crane swung over the fire and the kettle climbing to its note, and under all of it through the day the dull knock of the churn from the next room. Before light in the early dark there were the first feet on the boards and the first split and drop of kindling and the catch and lift of the fire, and the room went from black to red to grey to the full white of the morning while she woke into it or slept on through it as the day took her.

She was carried between the warm places and the cold. Near the hearth the air was thick and red and good. By the window the cold came off the glass in a sheet. The back room in winter was cold to the floor and she was kept out of it; in the heat of summer it was the cool place, and she was laid there through the worst of the afternoon with the shutters to a slot and the one bar of light moving slow across the boards while the rest of the house went on beyond the door. The first winter shut the house in around the fire. Then the door stood open again to the green and the warm and the long light, and the year had come round once over the house.

The face and the hands and the close voice were the one center the rest of it turned on. When she was set down and the center went off across the room the

world went wide and cool and loud; when it came back the world closed again to the near warm size she could bear. The hands were never still. It was the hands she fixed on before the face — the way they came under her, sure and quick, neither rough nor soft, and took her up out of wherever she had got to. She watched them from below, going and going — over the churn, over the table, folding cloth, banking the fire — and coming back to her between, to lift and turn and hold and set down.

The largest of the far voices was her father's. It came in from the yard with the cold on it and the smell of the horse and the outside, and it filled the room from above the way the others did not, and the boards gave more under his feet. He came down to her sometimes. The hand that came under her then was wider and harder than the other, and it held her against a chest that did not carry the steady close beat she came back to but a deeper, slower one, and she was lifted higher, up where the ceiling came near and the room ran away below her. Then she went down again to the warm cloth and the close beat, and he went up and out, and the door clapped, and the horse went off down the lane.

There was another nearer her own scale. He was not as far up as the rest, and he came down to the floor where she was, on his hands and knees, and put his face close to hers, and went off across the boards faster than she could follow, and came back. His voice was higher than the others and he used it often. He took things from her hands; she took them back, or did not, or made the sound that brought the center across the room to the two of them. He was the one already there. When she was set on the floor he was the thing on the floor with her.

The floor came to her by degrees. First she was only set on it, on a folded quilt near the hearth, and the room stood up out of reach all around — the legs of the long table going up into the dark underside of it, the legs of the chairs, the tall front of the press against the wall, the bright square of the doorway, the cool drift of air along the boards. Then her hands took her weight and the floor began to move under her, and the legs of the long table were a thing she went toward and came up against and held.

The underside of the long table was a low dark ceiling of its own, worn pale where years of knees had rubbed it, and she sat under it while the meal went on overhead — the plates set down, the voices crossing, the feet held still beneath the chairs — and a hand came down from the bright edge of the world with a crust or a rind, and she took it. The crust was hard and then it was soft and then it was gone. After the crust there were other things: a smear of something warm off a finger, a rind to gnaw, pap from a horn spoon that she pushed out with her tongue and then took. Then the hands came under her arms and drew her up out of the dark into the white room, and the table she had been under was a flat far country level with her eyes, and she could not see across it.

She came up the legs of things hand over hand. The lip of the long table stood as high as her chin, and she held on at it with both hands, the grain of the oak under her fingers — worn to a smooth band the width of her two hands where the

household held it, rough beyond that — and the great top ran off away from her into the room above her sight. She let go with one hand and the room swung, and she took the edge again.

The yard came to her in sound before it came to her whole. There were the fowl going over in the morning and the dog's one bark and the answer of another dog far off, and the cattle's low and the creak and chime of the well-rope and bucket, and a voice carrying flat across the open from one end of the place to the other. The door was a bright cold square, and past it the world went up and out further than any room. She was carried through it on the hip into the open, and the light came down on her from everywhere at once and there was no ceiling anywhere, and the lane ran out from the house long and pale between the fields, and at the far head of it stood the one great dark thing taller than the house and taller than anything — the oak at the head of the lane — and she was carried down the long open toward it, and it grew as she came and did not stop growing, and then she was under it and it was the whole of the sky.

By the well the world stood open all around. The bucket came up dark and streaming on the rope, too far out over the stone rim to lean toward, and the hand kept her back from it, and the water went over and the cold came off the stone. She was held up to look down into the well, where a round of light lay far at the bottom — the sky come down into the ground — and then she was set on the stoop, the open held wide over her and the close voice come back at her ear, and the day went on around the two of them.

Later her own feet took her out into it. The ground of the lane was rutted and hard and her steps were short against the long of it, and a hand held hers from above, and the oak stayed where it was at the head of the lane and came no nearer for all her walking, and she stopped, and was lifted, and carried the rest.

In the evening the light went out of the room the way it had come, off the high plaster and down the west wall and gone, and the fire was the last bright thing, and the feet went quiet through the house one by one. She was carried up against the warm cloth with the close beat under it and the one smell, and the room went red and then dark, and the hands set her down in the warmth near the hearth, and the voice stayed a while above her in the dark and then it too went, and the house held its night sounds, and she slept.

The years turned over her this way — by the change in what her hands could reach and her feet could carry and her eyes could cross. She was set on the floor, and then she crossed it. The long table that had been a dark ceiling over her became an edge she stood at, and then a country she could see the near half of. The oak that had been the whole of the sky stood off at the end of the lane and let her walk a little of the way to it and no farther. The house went on over her and around her — the feet, the fire, the churn, the crossing voices, the cold square of the open door — and her mother was the near center of all of it, the hands and the close beat and the one voice that came down out of the rest; and she came back to it, and came back to it. That was the size of the world. It held her, and the years

turned over her in it; and at the far edge of it the lane ran out to the oak, and past the oak the road went on out of sight, and she had not yet been carried that far.

* * *

By the time she could cross the room with a thing in her hands and not drop it, the world had come up off the floor and stood at her own height, and she went through the days inside it.

She was on her own feet now, and the rooms that had stood up out of reach all around her had come down to where she could put her hands on them. The long table she had sat under was an edge she stood at and laid her two arms along; she could see the near half of the great top now, the plates and the bread and the cup, and the far half ran off past her sight the way it always had. The press against the wall was a tall front with a smell of cloth behind its doors when they were opened, and she came no higher than the second drawer. The hearth was the warm middle the whole front room turned toward, and she had learned the floor in front of it where it was safe to be and the iron and the heat where it was not, and she kept her distance from the one and stayed in the warm of the other.

The days had an order, and she came to follow it. In the early dark there were the first feet on the boards, and the split and drop of kindling, and the catch of the fire, and the room going from black to red to grey to the white of the morning while she came up out of sleep into it. Then the crane swung over and the kettle climbed to its note, and the churn began its dull knock in the next room, and the table was laid and the household came to it and rose from it and the table was cleared. The light crossed the high plaster from the east window and left it by the middle of the day and came back low and red from the west. The fire was banked and the feet went quiet through the house one by one, and she was carried up to the warm cloth and the close beat and set down near the hearth, and the day had gone round once more the way it went round. She did not have to be told what came after what. She had watched it come after what enough times that she went ahead of it — she turned toward the door before the feet reached it, and held up her face for the cloth before the cloth came, and was at the table's edge before the bread was down.

She was given things to do. They were the part of the day she could carry: a spoon to bring from the dry-sink, a folded cloth to hold against her front and carry across to the press, a handful of kindling-splits to set down by the hearth one at a time. She could fetch what was named to her if it stood where she could reach it, and she would go and find it and bring it back, and a hand would take it from her, and the day would go on. The part was the size of her two hands and no more, and she did it, and the next day it came round to her again, and she did it again, and that was the shape of a day for her — the part that was hers come round and done and come round.

Her mother was the steady middle of all of it. The hands were never stopped; they went over the churn and the table and the cloth and the fire and the children

and came back, sure and quick, neither rough nor soft, the way they had always come. What her mother did, her mother did in an order, the same things in the same turn, morning on morning, so that the day had its shape before the day began. The child did not watch her mother for the meaning of it. She watched the hands for what they did and where they went and what came after, and she came to know the order the way she knew the rooms — by being inside it, day on day, until it was the ground she stood on. When a thing went wrong — the milk soured, the fire would not take, a pot boiled over and hissed across the coals — there was no great noise made of it. The hands did the thing that came next, and then the thing after that, and the day went on, and the child took the order of that too without anyone naming it to her.

There was a name that turned her. *Polly* — it came across the room and over the yard and down the lane from the well, in her mother's voice and her father's and the higher one of her brother, and when it came she turned her head the way it came, the way she had turned toward the close voice before she had any name at all. It was her own sound. She knew it before she knew much else, and she came when it called her, or did not, and made them call it twice.

The higher voice was Vincent's. He was the one already there, the one ahead of her in everything — taller by a head, faster across the yard, let to do the things she was kept from. He went out the cold square of the door into the open when she was held back from it; he carried the wood she could not lift; he was let to the well-rope and the gate-latch and to stand at his father's side at the horse, where she watched from off. He went where she could not yet go and came back, and she followed him as far as she was let and stopped where she was stopped. He took things out of her hands still, and she took them back or made the sound that brought her mother across the room to the two of them; but he came down to her too, onto the floor where she was, and showed her the thing in his hand and let her hold it and took it back, and went off across the yard faster than she could follow, and came back.

Her father was the largest of the near things now. He had been the deeper, slower beat and the wider, harder hand and the voice that came in from the yard with the cold and the horse on it and filled the room from above; and he was still all of that, but now she went to him. When his voice came in from the open her feet were across the floor before she had chosen to cross it — she was up and going, and then she was against his leg with both arms around it, and the wide hand came down onto the top of her head and held there a moment, heavy and warm, and then it came under her arm and took her up.

Up there the room ran away below her and the ceiling came near, and she rode his hip out into the yard the way she had been carried before, only now she held on at his shoulder with her own hands and looked out from the height of him at the open she was let into so. He took her along. She went with him down the lane to where the cattle stood, and she watched his hands at the things he did about the place — at the gate, at the wood, at the post he set deeper into the

ground with a maul, the dull sound of it going out flat across the open. His hands were slower than her mother's and bigger, and they did one thing at a time and did it through to the end of it before they went to the next. She stood off at the length he set her down and watched, and when he had done the thing he picked her up again and they went on, and his voice went over her head to Vincent or to a man across the field and came down to her sometimes in a word she knew.

He came and he went. The horse went off down the lane with him on it and was gone, and the day went on without him in it, and then there was the sound of it coming back in the evening and her feet went toward the door again. There was no part of her that held the going against the coming, or the coming against the going; he went and he came, and when he was there she was near him, and when he was not she was at her mother's side at the part of the day that was hers.

She had a bowl that was her own. It was wood, turned shallow and worn pale on the inside where the spoon had gone round it, and it was set down in front of her at the table and the warmed porridge went into it with a dab of butter in the middle, and she ate from it with the horn spoon and pushed the last of it to the low side and got it up. When it was rinsed and dried it went back on the long counter under the window with the others, and she knew it from the others. On the underside her mother had cut marks into the wood — she had seen them cut, the knife going slow and her mother's head bent over it, and she had put her own finger into the fresh-cut grooves while they were new and pale and felt the edges of them. She could not read them. But she knew the shape of them was hers — her sound, *Polly*, cut into the wood under the bowl that was hers — and when she had the bowl she would turn it over and put her finger into the marks and turn it back.

The year came round over the house the way the day did. The first cold shut the house in around the fire, and the door stayed to, and the work drew in close to the hearth and the candle; and then the cold went off and the door stood open again to the green and the long light and the warm, and the household spilled back out into the yard and the lane and the field. There was the time the fowl went over thick in the mornings; the time the men were out in the field before light and the corn stood up taller than Vincent and then taller than her father; the time the great pot was out in the yard over its own fire and the smell of it came across the whole place. The work of each time was the work she watched that time, and the part of it that was hers came round when its time came round, and she did it, and the time went on into the next.

Her own feet took her farther into the open now than they had. The lane that had run out long and pale past her reach let her walk a good stretch of it before a hand came down for hers, and the oak at the head of it that had been the whole of the sky grew as she came the way it had always grown, and now her own walking brought her under it. She stood under the oak with her head back and the dark of it went up over her and out past the edges of her sight the way the ceiling had when she was on the floor, only there was no edge to it and no plaster, only the green and the moving light coming through and the great trunk her two arms

would not have gone halfway round. Past the oak the lane ran on and went down out of sight where the road took it, and she had not walked that far; she was lifted, when she had stood long enough, and carried back the way she had come, down the long open toward the house with the smoke standing up off it, and her mother's voice came down the lane to meet her with her sound in it, and she went in.

The house went on over her and around her — the feet, the fire, the churn, the crossing voices, the open door, her mother's hands going and coming, her father in from the yard and out again, Vincent ahead of her and out of reach and back — and she was inside it now, no longer only carried through it but standing in it on her own feet, with the part of the day that was hers come round to her and done. That was the size of the world still, and it held her, and the year turned over her in it; and at the far head of it the oak stood where it stood, and past the oak the road went on down out of sight, and she had stood under the one and had not walked the other.

* * *

There was a part of the house that was the grandfather's, and she did not live in it.

Her own part was the back of it and the warm middle — the hearth, the kitchen, the room where she slept, the yard and the well and the lane that ran out from all of it. That was where the day was made and where she was in it, at her mother's side and at the part of the day that was hers. But the front of the house had rooms she went into seldom, and the front room of all of them, the one with the good chairs and the long window and the floor that was kept bare and waxed, was the grandfather's. He sat in it in the part of the day when her own part was busiest, and the door of it stood mostly open, and she came to the edge of it and looked in and did not always go further.

The grandfather was her father's father. He was older than anyone, older than the oldest of the hands about the place, and she came to know him as a different kind of thing from her father — slower, and apart, and quiet in a way her father was not. His hands were her father's hands grown old: the same wide shape and gone thin over the bones, the skin loose and spotted on the backs of them, and they did not do the work of the place the way her father's did, at the gate and the wood and the horse. They did one thing, mostly, in the front room: they were folded on the table, or they turned the leaves of a book, or they were still in his lap while he looked out the long window at the lane. His voice was lower than her father's and came slower, and when it came to her it came down a long way, and she stood at the edge of his room and gave it back her own sound when he said hers.

He was a fixed thing in her days. The back of the house moved all day — her mother's hands and the feet and the fire and the round of the part that was hers — and the front room did not move, and the grandfather in it did not, and she came across to it the way she came back to the warm of the hearth, to look in at the still

of it out of the busy of her own part. Sometimes he did not turn from the window or the book and she looked and went away again. Sometimes the slow voice came and said her sound, and she went in and stood by the arm of his chair, and the old hand came onto the top of her head the way her father's did, only lighter and longer, and stayed there while he looked out at the lane. Sometimes he gave her a thing off the table to have a while — a smooth brown stone, a horn button, the cool weight of a watch that ticked against her palm — and took it back when she had had it. He was the still place at the front of the moving house, and she went to it and came away and went to it again.

There was a woman of his part of the house. She was not the grandfather's daughter and she was not the child's mother; she was the grandfather's wife, and she kept the front rooms the way the child's mother kept the back, and her hands were busy in them at the things that were done there. She was a steady figure in the front of the house, neither near nor far, and the child took her as she took the shape of the front rooms themselves — as a thing that was there, that belonged to the grandfather's part, that was not hers to be at the center of. The front of the house was peopled and warm and kept; it was only not the part the child lived in.

On the table by the long window, where the grandfather's hands went when they turned leaves, there was a book. It was not the only book in the front room, but it was the one his hands came back to, and it lay by itself when they were not on it, square and dark on the waxed wood. It was bound in dark leather worn pale and soft at the corners and along the spine where the hands had taken it up and set it down for longer than the child had been alive or her father had. It was no bigger than the span of two hands, and thick, and when the grandfather opened it the leaves were close-written in a brown ink gone faint, and the first of the leaves, the one he opened to oftenest, carried lines of it from the top down — marks cut into the page the way marks were cut, the child knew, into the underside of the bowl that was hers, only more of them, and older, and made with a pen and not a knife. She could not read them. She knew, from the bowl, that marks like that were names; and she knew that this book was the grandfather's, the way the bowl was hers, and that his hands kept coming back to it.

She was not let to touch it. It lay where his hands were, and hers were kept from it, the way they were kept from the iron at the hearth and the bucket at the well — not with a word always, but with the hand that came down and turned her from it, so that she came to leave it where it lay and to look at it from the floor by his chair without putting her hands up to it. Of all the things on the grandfather's table it was the one she would most have put her hands to — the dark soft of it, the worn corners, the marks she could not read — and it was the one most kept from her, more than the watch and the stone and the button he gave her to hold and took back; the book he did not give her, and she came to know it as a thing to be looked at and not held. It was the grandfather's, and it stayed his, on the table by the window, in the front room she did not live in.

Then there came a day he took her out to the ground.

It was a clear day with the cold not yet in it, and her mother put her in her good things and stood her at the front door, and the grandfather came out of his room with the dark book held against him in the crook of his arm the way she had not seen it carried before, off its table and out of the front room and into the open. He took her hand in his old one and they went out the door and down past the side of the house, not toward the lane and the oak but the other way, around to where the ground rose a little behind the house to a place set off by itself with a low rail around it and the grass let to grow long inside the rail and a few stones standing up out of the grass.

She had been by the place. She had not been into it. The grandfather lifted the rail's bar and they went in, and the long grass was wet against her legs, and the stones stood up grey and leaning, some of them, and worn, and the day was quiet inside the rail in a way it was not outside it — the yard-sounds and the place-sounds come a long way off and gone thin, and the grass and the few grey stones and the old man and the child the only things inside. There were not many stones. They stood about in the long grass not in a row, some near and some off by the rail, and the child went by them at the grandfather's hand without their meaning anything to her but that they were there and were old and were stones. He brought her to one of them, not the oldest-looking and not the newest, set a little apart, and he stood at it a while and did not say anything, and the child stood by him and looked at the stone, where there were marks cut into the grey face of it — cut deep, and large, larger than the marks in the book and the marks under her bowl, cut to last in the stone the way the others were cut to last in the wood and the page.

He went down then, slow, onto one knee in the wet grass, so that his face came nearer her own, and he took the dark book from the crook of his arm and held it out and let her take it.

It was heavier than she looked for. It came down into her two arms and she took the weight of it against her front the way she took the folded cloth she carried for her mother, only this was a denser, harder weight that wanted to go down, and the grandfather's hands stayed under hers and under the book so that it did not. The leather was cool and soft-worn under her fingers, and the corners of it were round with handling, and she stood with it held against her at the stone with his hands holding her holding it.

He told her, then, in his low slow voice that came down to her, that the stone was her grandmother's. He told her the grandmother's name, and her finger went to the cut marks on the stone the way it went into the grooves under her bowl, and the name he said was her own name — the long name under the Polly they called her by, the name that was hers. The name on the stone was her name. She did not have it that the woman in the ground was gone, or how long gone, or that she herself had been given the dead woman's name to carry, or what it was to be named for someone into the ground before you were born; those were the grandfather's to hold, and he held them, kneeling in the wet grass with his hands

under the child's hands under the book. What the child had was the cut name under her finger and the name in her ears and the two of them being the one name, and the book heavy against her, and the old hands holding it all up.

Then he took the book back, and the weight went off her front, and he got up off his knee slow with a hand on the rail, and they went out of the place and let the bar down behind them and came back around to the front of the house in the clear cold day. Her mother had the door open. The grandfather went in to his own room with the book against him in the crook of his arm, and it went back onto the table by the long window where it lay, and he sat down by it, and the day went on in the front of the house and the back of it the way the day went on.

She went back to her own part. There was the part of the afternoon that was hers, and it had come round, and she did it. The book stayed on the table in the grandfather's room, and his hands came back to it, and she came to the edge of his room and looked in and did not put her hands up to it; it was his, and it stayed his. She had held it the once, out at the ground, with his hands under hers — the dark soft weight of it, and the cut name on the stone that was her name too — and then it had gone back to where it lived, and she back to where she lived, in the warm middle and the back of the house, at her mother's side, with the day going round; and the grandfather kept on in the front of the house with the book his hands came back to, the oldest thing in the house keeping the oldest thing in the house, and the child grew on in the other part of it, carried along in the round of the days, with the name she had been given waiting in her the way it waited cut in the stone and cut in the book — a thing that was hers and that she had not yet come into, the way the road past the oak was a thing that ran on and that she had not yet walked.

* * *

She was big enough now to be of use, and the house used her.

The part of the day that was hers had grown past the carrying of a spoon and the holding of a folded cloth. She minded the fire when she was set to it, feeding it from the basket split by split and not too fast; she carried water from the stoop, not the full bucket but a good half of one in a smaller pail, and did not slop it crossing the floor; she watched the pot when her mother stepped out, and called when it wanted watching harder than she could give it; she had the keeping of the littlest when the hands that usually kept it were wanted elsewhere. She was not the equal of the grown hands and was not let to think she was, but she was a pair of hands the house could send, and it sent her, and she went.

The littlest was below her the way Vincent was above. It had come into the house the way she had once come into it, and lain in the cradle by the hearth where she had lain, and been the near light weight her mother carried and the others learned to carry after. She had carried it herself, sat on the floor with her back to the wall and the weight of it in her lap and her arm where she had been shown to put it, and it had taken her finger in its hand and held. It was the one

below her, the one she was set to mind, the one she was ahead of now the way her brother was ahead of her.

Then it took sick, and the house changed around it.

She knew the change before she knew the cause of it, the way she knew a change of weather coming in off the open before the rain. The order of the day bent. Her mother did not leave the back room as she had, and the door of it that had stood open stood mostly to, and the voices behind it were low and went on at hours they did not used to go on. A fire was kept in the back room that was not kept there in that season, and the heat of it came under the door, and there was a smell that came with it, sharp and close, that had not been in the house before. The night candle burned later and later and then did not go out at all, and she woke in the dark and saw the line of its light under the door and the shapes that crossed it, and slept, and woke, and the line was still there.

She was kept back from it. She was not let into the back room except to the door of it, and at the door a hand turned her, gently, the way her hand had been turned from the iron and the well and the grandfather's book — not unkindly and not with much said, only turned, and given a thing to do instead. And there were more things to do than there had been, because the hands that did them were fewer now, drawn off behind the back-room door, so that the part of the day that was hers grew of itself: she had the fire to mind longer, and the fetching to do oftener, and the watching of the pot, and the keeping out from underfoot, and the being quiet, which was a thing to do as much as the fetching was. The house had bent its whole order toward the back room, and what was left of the order it gave to the hands it had left, and she was one of them, and she did her part of it because there was no one with the time to do it for her and because the doing of it was wanted.

And there came a point in the strained days when she did not wait to be set to a thing. She saw the fire low and went to it with the basket before a voice sent her; she saw the water-pail dry and took it to the stoop; she saw a thing wanting doing and her feet were already at it, her hands already in it, before the thought of being told had come and gone. There was no choosing in it. The thing wanted doing and the hands to do it were behind the door and she was a pair of hands and the doing was wanted, and her body went to it the way the grown hands went to the next thing, without a word, because that was what was done. No one praised her for it. The hands were wanted behind the door, and a thing wanted doing, and she did it, and the day took it and went on.

She did not have it that the littlest was dying. What she had was that the house had gone to the back room, the whole house, all its hands and its hours, and that her part was to do the things that kept the rest of it standing while it did. She took that in the way she had taken in the order of an ordinary day — by being inside it — only this was the order under a weight, the same hands doing the same things in a changed and heavier turn, the next thing done and then the next, the fire fed and the water carried and the pot watched and the littlest's washing

boiled and hung, all of it going on, all of it held, while behind the door the thing the house had gone to went on toward whatever it went toward.

It went toward the littlest's death. There came a night the line of candlelight under the door did not have the crossing shapes in it for a long while, and then it did, slower, and in the morning the back room was opened and aired and the sharp close smell was let out of it on the cold air through the house, and the cradle by the hearth was not put back. The house was quiet in a way it had not been even at its quietest — not the quiet of the night with the fire banked, but a quiet with a held breath in it, a quiet the grown people moved through carefully as though it could be knocked over. Her mother came out of the back room, and her face was her face, and her hands were her hands, and they took up the morning — the fire, the kettle, the table — and did it. They did it slower and they did it with the held quiet around them, but they did it, the same things in the same turn, and the child watched the hands take up the order again, and did not have what it was, and took it in.

There was activity then, of a kind the house did not have in its ordinary days, and it filled the house for a day and a night and a part of the next day. Women came up the lane — neighbour-women, and a woman or two of the grandfather's kin from along the river — and they came in and were not company in the way company was; they put off their cloaks at the door and took up work. Some were with her mother behind the closed back-room door, where the littlest was washed and made ready, and the child was kept from that and did not see it and had only the knowing that it was being done, by the going in and the coming out, the basin carried in full and carried out, the clean linen taken in. Some were in the kitchen and the front, and they had brought food with them and set more to cook, so that there was always something at the fire and something on the table, and the child was set to the fetching and the carrying of it among them, in and out, a pair of hands they sent. The men came too and stood about the yard and the front of the place, the father among them and the grandfather, in their good coats, not at the work of the place that day, talking low or not talking at all. And through the night there were people sitting up in the front room with the candles lit and the low talk going on under the held quiet, and the child was put to bed and woke to the light of it under the door and the murmur of it through the wall and slept again — the house full and lit and quiet and busy in the dark in a way it had never been.

In the part of the next day the littlest was carried out behind the house, washed and wrapped and no longer than the wrapping of it, to the ground inside the low rail where the grandmother's stone leaned in the long grass. The child was taken out to it, held at her mother's side, and she stood at the rail and saw the place opened in the ground, short among the older places, and the wrapped weight set down into it, and the grandfather said the words he said over it, low and slow the way his voice came. The men put the ground back over it with the spades, and the sound of the earth going down was a sound she had not heard before and did not hear again for a long while after and did not lose. There was no

stone cut for it — only the turned earth, and the long grass, and the grey leaning stones of the older dead standing off in the quiet of the place she had been into once before, with her grandfather and the book, and was into now again.

Then they came back around to the front of the house, and the people went down the lane through the afternoon one and two at a time, and the food was put away or sent on, and the good coat was hung up, and the night came, and the fire was banked, and the house slept.

And in the morning the order took her up again. There was the fire to be fed before light, and the kettle to climb to its note, and the table to be laid and cleared, and the water to be carried, and the churn's dull knock to start in the next room, and all of it came round at its hour the way it came round, and her part of it came round to her, and she did it. The cradle was not by the hearth and the littlest was not in the house and her mother did not leave the back room any more than she left the others now, and the held quiet thinned day by day back toward the ordinary quiet, and the order went on. It went on the way it had gone on under the weight, the same hands and the same turns, only the weight was off it now in the way a weight goes off — not lifted all at once but carried until it weighed less — and the house did the next thing and the next thing and the day went round, and the child was inside it doing her part, and she did not have a word for what she had been inside of and did not look for one. She had it the way she had the order of the day and the way she had her name: not as a thing told her but as a thing she was made of. The house had gone to a hard thing with its whole self and had done the next thing through it and come out the other side of it still doing the next thing, and she had been one of its hands while it did, and that was in her now, under the having of it, the way the turned place was in the ground behind the house among the older places, not marked yet and not gone.

The littlest was in the ground with the grandmother whose name was her own name, behind the house, inside the rail, and the house was in front of it going on, and the child grew on in the house, older by the measure of what she could now be set to and what she had now been inside of; and at the far head of the lane the oak stood where it stood, and past the oak the road went on out of sight, and she had not walked it, and the days came round and were done and came round.

* * *

She was old enough now to catch what was not said to her.

She caught it the way she had once caught the weather coming, or her father's step among the others, or the change in the house when the littlest took sick — not by being told but by the thing being there to be caught. And what was there to be caught, across these years, was a change in the grown world that she could not have named and did not try to, a change she took in at the edges of the household's days the way she took in everything: by being inside a house that was inside it.

The men gathered more than they had. Riders came up the lane oftener, and were taken in, and the low talk in the front room ran later into the night and started up again in the morning, and there were more of the men at it — her father, and the grandfather sometimes, and neighbour-men who came and tied their horses at the rail and went in with their faces set in a way she had a name for, the way her father's face was set when a thing about the place had gone wrong, only it was not the place. The talk had a different sound from the ordinary talk of the place. It ran low and it ran on and it did not have the easy turns in it that the ordinary talk had, the bits that made the men laugh; it was talk with something held under it, and the something under it did not let up across the seasons but grew, so that the gatherings came oftener and the faces stayed set.

She caught words out of it without the meaning of them. There were names that came up in the low talk that were not the names of anyone she knew or any place along the river — hard short words and long ones, said in the grown voices with the held thing under them, said again on another night and another, so that she came to know them as the words the trouble was made of without knowing what they stood for. She turned them over the way she had once turned the smooth stone and the horn button the grandfather gave her, not for what they were but because they were the things the grown world had its hands on now, the way she had once had her hands on the things off his table. The men said them and set their faces and the talk ran on, and the child carried the dishes in among them and carried the empties out and was not spoken to in it and did not look to be, and caught what she caught, and let the rest go over her the way the high talk had gone over her when she was little enough to be under the table.

Court-day came back changed too. Her father went to it the way he always had, and the grandfather, and they came back from it the way they always had — but they came back with more of the held thing on them now, and the talk that started up the evening after court-day ran later than it used to, and there were more riders in the days after it. The world beyond the lane, which had always been a thing the men went out to and came back from, was reaching in now, up the lane and into the front room, oftener and with the held thing under it, and the child at the edge of it caught the reaching-in without the thing that reached.

And the road itself was busier than it had been. The road past the oak at the head of the lane — the road the grown world had always gone out to and come back from — carried more on it now than it used to, more riders and more going, so that a child sent up the lane on an errand saw more pass along it in an hour than she would once have seen in a day: men she did not know, going the one way and the other with the cold on them and somewhere to be, raising their hands to her or not seeing her at all. The stir of the world out past the oak came up the lane to the house in the riders that turned in at it, and went back down the lane to the road in the men who rode out to the gatherings, and the child saw the going and the coming of it the way she saw the fowl cross over in the mornings — as a thing the season was doing — without the thing that set it going.

And in among it the ordinary world held, because the ordinary world was what the house was made of and the house went on making it. The fire was fed and the table was laid and the churn knocked in the next room and the year came round over the place — the fowl over in the mornings, the corn up past the men's heads, the great pot in the yard, the door shut early against the cold — and her part of it came round to her and she did it, larger now than it had been, a true part of the work and not the edge of it. The held thing was in the grown talk at night and the ordinary day was in her hands by day, and both of them went on, the one over the other, and she was inside the house where they both were.

She had a place at the grown world's edge now that she had not had. She was let to the table when the men were at it, not under it; she carried the cups and the plates in among them and was trusted not to spill them and not to want talking-to; she was sent on errands a girl her size could be sent on, up the lane and to the well-house and to the grandfather's room, and was counted on to do them and to come back. She was not grown and was not let to think she was, but she was well past the size she had been, and the household used her past it — a hand it could count, a head it could give a thing to keep and have the thing kept. She was coming up in the house the way the corn came up in the field: by a measure you did not catch in the watching, but saw when you set the one year against the year before it.

Her father was in the middle of the grown world's change the way he was in the middle of the place. He was the one the riders came to as much as any, and the talk in the front room was as often his as anyone's, and he went out to the court-days and the gatherings and came back with the held thing on him; and he was still her father, in from the yard with the cold and the horse on him, the wide hand on the top of her head, the deep slow beat she had been carried against, going and coming the way he went and came. The going-out and the coming-back were the oldest thing she knew of him. He had gone off down the lane on the horse and come back up it in the evening her whole life, more times than there was any counting, so that the shape of him going was as ordinary to her as the shape of him at the table, and she no more marked one of his goings than she marked the fowl going over in the morning.

So when he made ready to go over the line into the Carolina country on the place's business, in the cold coming-on of the year, she marked it no more than the others.

It was a going of more days than his short goings, and the house made it ready the way it made ready the things it had done before: the bags were packed and the good coat and the other things a man took for a going of some days were seen to, and there was the talk of it among the grown people, where he was going and what for and how long he would be, the land over the line and the men he would see and the papers to be done — talk she caught the edges of, the Carolina country and the days he would be gone, and let go the way she let the rest go. There was bread baked for the going and the saddle-bags filled, and on the

morning of it the horse was brought round and stood at the rail blowing in the cold, and her father was out at it in his coat seeing to the girths and the bags, and the grown people were about him with the last of the talk and the last of the things to be handed up.

She was at her part of the morning while it went on, the fire and the fetching, and she came out into the cold of the yard the way she came out into it any morning, and her father was up on the horse by then, seated and gathered with the bags behind him, and he looked down at her from the height of him the way he had looked down at her from the height of him all her life, and the wide hand came down once onto the top of her head and stayed its moment, heavy and warm, and then it took the rein. He said the thing to her mother that a man says going, and the thing to the grandfather, and a word came down to her in it that she had her own sound in, and then the horse turned and went, down the lane in the cold morning, the way the horse had gone down the lane more times than there was counting, getting smaller against the long pale run of it, and at the head of the lane it went under the oak and past it and out where the lane gave onto the road, and was gone out of sight the way it had gone out of sight before.

The house took up the day behind her. There was the fire to be kept and the water to be carried and the dinner to be got and the whole of the round to be done, fewer hands at it now by the one that had ridden out, and the round closed over the gap of him the way it closed over any gap, and went on. It was quieter with him gone, the way it was always quieter with him gone, and the grown talk at night was the women's now and lower, and the days went on one into the next the way they went, and the child was inside them at her part, and did the next thing and the next, and looked for him up the lane in the evenings the way she had always looked for him up the lane in the evenings, in the ordinary way, without thinking about it, because that was what was done.

And the year turned over the house the way it turned, and the lane ran out pale to the oak at the head of it, and the oak stood where it stood, and past the oak the road went on out of sight the way it always had; and she had grown up the whole length of the lane she could see, and the road past the oak was still the road she had not walked, and her father had gone out along it on the place's business in the cold of the year, and the house went on, and the child went on in it, and the days came round and were done and came round.

The leaving the child marked no more than the others was, at the distance the record keeps, the last the record holds of Baker DeGraffenreid alive.

He had gone over the line into Guilford County, North Carolina, on the place's business, and there, on the twentieth of October 1775, he put his hand to a deed of trust. That document is the last to set him among the living. After it the record on him goes quiet, and the next time the sources speak to his place in the household it is to mark his absence from it: by the tenth of September 1779, Sarah Vass DeGraffenreid was acting as administratrix of his estate at Lunenburg. Between the deed in Guilford and the appointment at the county

court lies a silence of nearly four years that the surviving sources do not fill. Where Baker DeGraffenreid died, and when, and by what, the record does not give back. Family tradition holds that he was killed at the outset of the Revolutionary War; this history carries the tradition and has not found the proof, and names the gap rather than building across it.

So the household this chapter has kept at the child's scale — three living generations at the one seat, the grandfather and his Bible, the present father, the mother who was its steady center, and the boy and the girl growing up in it — stood whole on the cold morning the horse went down the lane, and did not stand whole long. The years that came after were the years it learned to be a thing it had not been: a household that did not know. Those years belong to the chapter that follows. This one ends where the child's knowing ended — at the head of the lane, the road running on past the oak out of sight, the father gone along it on an ordinary errand, and the house behind her taking up the day.

She was eleven. The keeping the line had carried since 1714 — the Bible that lay on the desk in her grandfather's room, that she had held once at her grandmother's stone — was not yet hers, and would not be for a long while yet. But it was in the house she was made in, and she was the child it would come to.

Chapter 3 — The War in the House

This is the chapter of the not-knowing, and it begins where the chapter before it ended: at the head of the lane, in the cold coming-on of a year, the master of the house gone down it on the place's business and the house behind him taking up the day.

The house was the same south-side seat this history has kept all along — the seat Anton Tscharnier DeGraffenreid had built on the Lunenburg ground in the early 1750s. It was the house of the lane and the great oak that stood at its head, the long oak table in the hall, and the family's Bible kept on the writing-desk in the grandfather's room, where it had lain since his father's death in 1742 and would lie until his own in 1794. In 1775 the keeper of it was still the grandfather. Tscharnier DeGraffenreid, born at Williamsburg in November 1722, was a man past fifty that year, and the Bible and the record in it were his. The present master was his son: Baker DeGraffenreid, born on the sixth of August 1744, a man of one-and-thirty, married to Sarah Vass, who was the steady center the household turned on. Two children had grown past the cradle — a son, Vincent, twelve that year, and a daughter, Mary Baker, eleven, born at the seat in the autumn of 1764, the child whose chapter the one before this was.

The keeping-place was the Lunenburg seat; but the household's world in these years ran past it, south and west, to the Carolina line the master's business lay across. Baker had affairs over the line, in Guilford County, North Carolina, and the last the record holds of him alive is a deed of trust he put his hand to there, on the twentieth of October 1775. The chapter opens in the season of that going, and the span it covers runs four years from it — to the second week of November 1779, and a wedding.

For the war had come. It had broken over the colonies that spring in the country to the north and would grind on the most of a decade; and what it asked of this house it asked at the house's own scale and on its own clock. It would take the boy: in the deep of the winter of 1777 Vincent would go down the lane after his father, a substitute of fourteen sent to stand in a man's place in the Virginia line, and be gone to the war until the war let him go. And the father it does not account for at all. Baker rode out over the line in 1775 and did not ride back, and where the four years between the Guilford deed and the wedding put him the surviving sources do not give back.

But those are the things seen at the line's distance — the documented shape of four years, named and then left. The chapter is not at that distance. It is inside the house: the table that kept a place open, the lane looked up in the evenings, the desk where a girl learned to write a brother at the war. It is the not-knowing lived from within, a day and a meal and a letter at a time, by a household learning to be a thing it had not been — a household that did not know, and held, and went on. It begins with the overdue man.

The overdue man

The house took up the day behind her the morning he rode out, and took up the day after it, and the day after that, the way it took up every day — the fire fed and the water carried and the round of the place done with the one pair of hands gone out of it. He had ridden down the lane in the cold of the morning, under the oak at the head of it and past, out where the lane gave onto the road, and gone the way he had gone out on the place's many goings, only farther: over the line into the Carolina country, on the place's business, a going of more days than his short ones. And in the evenings, the way she always had, she looked for him up the lane.

She knew the shape of his coming. The horse would be a little thing at the head of the lane in the falling light, come on under the oak and up the long pale run of it and grow against the road, and the man up on it would be her father, in from over the line with the cold and the going on him. She had seen him come up the lane that way in the evening her whole life, more times than there was any counting, so that the coming was as plain a thing to her as the table or the fire — a thing that had always been and went on being. A going of more days came back up the lane when its days were done. So she looked up the lane for the thing that would grow and be him, and the evenings the looking found nothing she let go the way she had always let go the evenings he was not yet due — because his days were not done, and then because his days were done and a man was given a few more.

The few more went by. A man over the line on the place's business could be held past his day by any of the ordinary things that held a man: the papers not ready, the men he had to see gone from home, the roads heavy with the wet of the year, a horse to be doctored, a thing on the land over there to be seen to before he could turn for home. The grown people knew the ordinary things that held a man, and turned them over among themselves, and set them down again; and the place went on at its round with the one pair of hands still out of it, the way it had gone on with him out of it before. What needed a man's word the grandfather gave, leaned on the more now that the county was tilting and the men were oftener away; what wanted a man's hand and was not past a boy, the boy was set to, Vincent being near enough now to a man's size to be used at the edge of a man's part; and the rest the women carried, the way they carried it any time he was gone. He was late. A late man was a thing the place knew. It had laid by his coming before, on this going and that, and the coming had always come — later than its day, but come, up the lane in the end with the man on it. So his lateness now lay among the ordinary lateness of all his other goings, and was, for a good while, only that.

But the table kept his place.

The long table was laid the way it was always laid, and his place at it was the place it had always been — the head, where the man of the house sat, where he had sat at every meal of her life he had been home to sit at. With him gone, the

head of the table was an empty place, the way it was empty any time he was gone; they sat to their meals around it and the day closed over the gap of him the way it closed over any gap. Only it did not close all the way. Laid or not laid, the place stayed his — kept his by not being given to another, by the grown eyes going to it and off it, by the head of the table staying the head of the table with no man at it. The mother ran the meal from where she sat, and the grandfather was at his place, and the boy at his, and the child at hers, and the head of the table was his and empty, and the meal went on around it the way the day went on around the hands that were out of the round. They kept his place by keeping it his. That was the thing the table did now that it had not done before: it held a place open for a man who was late.

It was the mother who held it open. She had always been the still middle the house turned on, the one whose hands the day went through, and with the man out of it she was the more so. She ran the lane and the round and the meals and the meting-out of the work the short hands had to do, and she kept his place at the table the way she kept everything, without a word made of it, by the steady doing of it. If there was a thing in her about the lateness, she did not set it on the house. She looked up the lane in the evenings too — the child saw her at it, going to the door at the hour he would have come and looking up the long pale run of it the way the child looked, and turning back in when the light went without him on it — but she looked the way a woman looks for a man who is late, and no further than that, and the look she carried back into the house was a steady one, and the house took its steadiness from her and went on.

And the child, who was old enough now to catch what was not said, caught a thing in it she could not have put a name to and did not try. It was not in any one thing. It was in the place kept at the table a day longer than a place was kept, and a day longer than that; in the way the grown talk would come round to him and go quiet and come round to something else; in her mother at the door at the coming-on of the evening, looking up the lane and turning back; in the count that nobody kept out loud and that she felt being kept all the same, the days of his lateness going by one on another and the run of them getting longer. She caught it the way she caught the weather coming, or the held thing in the men's low talk — not as a thing told her but as a thing there to be caught, a change in the house she lived inside of. She had no word for it, and it had not got to be fear. It was only that the lateness had a weight in it now that the ordinary lateness of his other goings had not had, a weight she felt at the edges of the days without knowing what it was the weight of. She looked up the lane in the evenings, and the looking had the weight in it now. She did not know that it did. She only looked, the way she had always looked, and the thing that would grow and be him did not come on under the oak, and the evening went, and the place at the table stayed his.

So the year went on over the house the way it went, down into the cold and the dark of it and toward the turn, and the man who had ridden out on the place's business in the cold coming-on of the year had not ridden back up the lane by the

cold deep of it. The place kept its round with the short hands. The mother kept the lane and the meals and his place at the table. The child looked up the lane in the evenings and did the next thing and the next, and the looking did not find him, and the place stayed his, and his lateness went on being lateness — a long lateness now, longer than any of his other goings had run, but lateness still: a man over the line and overdue, and not yet anything more than overdue, the household keeping his place open up the long pale lane, and the dark coming down over the oak at the head of it, and the road past it that he had gone out along and not yet come back.

Interlude — The Outbreak

While Baker DeGraffenreid was overdue on the Carolina roads, the thing that would come to be called the Revolution had already begun, two and three hundred miles to the north, on a scale no county on the south side could yet measure.

It had opened in the spring of 1775. In April of that year, on the road between Lexington and Concord in Massachusetts, militia and British regulars exchanged the first fire of the war. By June the Continental Congress at Philadelphia had voted an army into being and set a Virginian, George Washington, over it; that same month, on a hill above Boston, the two sides learned what the war would cost. The fighting spread and hardened through the year after — the siege of Boston and the British leaving it, the failed thrust into Canada, the war reaching south toward the Carolinas — until, in July of 1776, the Congress declared the colonies free states, and the thing became a war for a nation.

None of it came up the lane whole. It came the way news came to a farm at the country's edge with its men away: in pieces and late, carried by a rider or a letter or a man home from the court day, a battle named weeks after it was fought and a hundred miles from where the hearer stood. The house had a war around it now, vast and northern and growing; it had a man overdue on it, and would soon have a boy in it; and it knew almost none of what the Congress had declared. It knew its own.

The boy goes

The deep of the winter was on the place the year the boy went. The man had been gone over the line a year and more by then — gone the length of a year's round and into the next — and his place at the table was still his and still empty, kept his the way it had been kept from the first: the head of the table with no man at it, the lane looked up in the evenings, the round done with the one pair of hands out of it. The house had got used to the shape of that gap the way a body gets used to a stiffness it wakes with, not eased but carried, a thing the day was built around without the building being spoken of. And into that winter the grown people turned their talk to Vincent.

It was the kind of talk the child caught the edges of and was not in. There was a man owed to the war off the district — a draft to be answered, a place in the line to be filled — and a substitute would answer it, and the substitute, if the household sent one, would be the boy. He was near enough a man's size now. He had been near it in the fall, used at the edge of a man's part with the father's hands gone from the round, and over the going of the one more winter he had come the rest of the way to where a boy of fourteen could stand in a grown man's place in a muster book and the book would take him. The grandfather turned it over and the mother turned it over, and what passed between them about it passed low and mostly when the children were abed; and the child knew only that the talk was of her brother and the war, and went quiet when she came near, and came round again when she had gone.

What there was to be got by it she half caught and did not weigh — that a place filled by the household's own boy was a place not filled by the drawing of another name the house would then have to answer; that there was in it something of the man owed and the bounty paid and the books made even, the war's bookkeeping that reached even up the lane and asked the place for a body. She did not weigh it. It was grown business, arranged the way the grown business of the place was always arranged, over her head and around her, and what reached her of it was the end of it only: that Vincent was going for a soldier, and going soon.

He went in the cold of a morning, the way the father had gone in the cold of a morning. He went down the lane behind a man of the district who was carrying him to the gathering-place — down under the oak at the head of it and along the long pale run of it and out to where the lane gave onto the road: the same lane, the same oak, the same giving-onto, that the father had gone down and not yet come back up. The child stood at the door and watched the way she watched the evenings, only it was morning, and the thing she watched was a going and not a coming. The boy who had been the boy at the edge of a man's part was the man's part now, gone down the lane to stand in a man's place in the line; and the door he went out of had two men's goings in it, and the lane two, and the road past the oak two.

The mother saw him off the way she did the hard things, by doing them. She had him fed and his bundle made and what there was to send with him sent; and she stood at the door while he went, and lifted her hand to the man driving and not only to the boy, and turned back into the house when the seat had gone out of sight past the oak. If there was in her the thing there had been about the father's lateness, she did not set it on the house this morning either. She had a second of her men down the lane now and the same steady look to carry back from the door, and she carried it back, and the house took its steadiness from her as it had, and the day took up behind her.

And the place took up the gap the boy left the way it had taken up the gap the father left. The hands were shorter by one again, and the part the boy had been

used at — the wood and the water and the beasts and the heavier reach of the round that a near-grown boy could take — came back onto the hands that were left, the grandfather's that were old for it and the women's and the child's that was younger than the part. What the boy had done got done by the ones still there, parceled out and taken up, a little more onto each, because it was there to be done and they were the ones to do it. The grandfather did the part a man past fifty could still do and got a hired hand or a neighbor's boy for the part he could not, the way the district did its short-handed winters with its men away. The mother ran the round and the meals and the parceling-out the way she ran everything, by the steady doing. And the child was set to the more, being now the next pair of hands the place had — older than she had been, nearer the part, the way the boy had been nearer the part the winter before, the reach of the place coming down onto the next one as the ones above it were taken away.

None of it was made a thing of in words. There was no evening the house sat down and named what it would do now that the boy had gone after the man. The work the boy had done was there in the morning, and in the morning the ones left got up and did it, and did it again the morning after, and the gap the boy left closed over the way the gap the father left had closed over — not all the way, never all the way, but enough that the round went on and the house held and the days came one after another and were got through. The doing was the answer. The house did not say what it would do; it did it.

And one of the things it did, now, was write to the boy.

A soldier could be written to. He was gone, but not gone the way the father was gone. The father had gone into a place with no name they had and no road an answer could come back along; to the father there was no writing. But the boy was in the line, and the line was somewhere, and a letter could go to him by the hands that letters went by — slow and far and few — and another come back. So the house, which had no way to write to the man, wrote to the boy.

And the writing of him fell, in part, to the child. She had the hand for it — the family's hand, the one the grandfather wrote the record in and had taught down the line; she had sat at the desk under his eye and made her letters, and could make them plain enough now to be read far off by a boy with little time and less light to read by. So when there was writing to Vincent to be done that the mother's hands were too full for, or that the grandfather left to the child as a way of the hand getting its use, the child did it. She sat at the parlor desk where the writing of the place was done and wrote her brother the things there were to write — the plain news of the place, who was well and what was done and how the winter went — and folded it, and it went; and after a while, slow and far, the boy's hand came back, the same blood's hand making the same letters at the other end of the road, and the few things he could say of where he was.

So each was kept in the other's hand — the brother in the sister's, written to and waited on; the sister in the brother's, the far proof that he was yet a hand that could write, yet somewhere, yet himself. It was the plainest thing, a boy gone for

a soldier and a sister at the desk; and it was the first of a thing that would go on between them, the letters back and forth, each of them the other's word — for the while it took the word to come — that the other was still there.

So the house went down into the rest of that winter with two of its men gone down the lane: the one a year and more gone into the place with no name, his seat at the table still his and still empty and still looked for up the lane in the evenings; the other gone that morning into the line, written to and waited on, his place at the table emptied too and kept too, a boy's place that was a soldier's now. The child looked up the lane in the evenings the way she always had, for the father — the boy was not a thing the lane would bring now, he was where the letters went and not where the evenings could reach — but she looked all the same, and the looking had the both of them in it. And the place did the next thing and the next, and the round went on with the hands it had, and the winter went over the house toward the turn, and the two places at the table stayed the men's whose they were, and the lane ran out past the oak to the road that the two of them had gone down.

Interlude — The Northern Campaigns

The winter the boy went down the lane, early in 1777, the war he was going into had a year and a half of hard use behind it and no end in sight.

Through that year the heaviest fighting was in the north, around the rebel capital. In September a British army beat Washington's on the Brandywine, in Pennsylvania, took Philadelphia, and sent the Congress fleeing its own city. A month later, far up the Hudson country in New York, a second British army that had come down out of Canada was surrounded and made to surrender entire at Saratoga — the turn of the war, as it came afterward to be reckoned, the victory that brought France in on the American side. Then the northern front went quiet and long: two more years of marching and waiting and bitter, inconclusive fighting, the armies wintering and maneuvering, the war grinding on without a decision.

Where in all of it was Vincent? The household could not say. It had a boy in the Virginia line and a war full of named places he might be at, or near, or nowhere close to, and no way to lay the one over the other. What the news carried was armies; what the letters carried, when they carried anything, was a boy. The house could not put the one inside the other. So the not-knowing of the father had a second laid beside it now, lesser and live: a brother somewhere in the great northern noise, written to and waited on, and not to be found in any account that reached the lane.

The long not-knowing & the arrangement

The years went on over the house the way the one winter had, and the war came up the lane the only way it could, which was in pieces and late. It came by the man

who had been to the court house and back and had it from a paper, or from a man who had it from a paper; by the paper itself when a paper came, a month or two months behind the thing it told; by the word passed at the meeting-house of a Sunday, or brought by a neighbor who had a son in it the same as they had. A battle to the north, when the word of it reached them, had been fought a season gone; a campaign down through the lower country was a thing they heard the front of while the back of it was still happening, if it was happening, off where no word from them could reach and no word to them came any faster than a horse could carry it over the bad roads in the wet of the year. So the war that the rest of the world had whole, day on day, the house had in fragments, out of their order and out of their season, and made what it could of them and let the rest go by.

And Vincent's letters came up the lane the same way, slow and far and few, and were a different thing from the war-news and would not lie against it. The war-news told of armies; the letters told of a boy — that he was well, or had been when the hand wrote it; the marching and the food and the few things he could say of where he was, which was never enough to set a pin in. When the news came of a fight to the north the house could not know if he had been in it or a hundred miles off from it; and when his letter came it was a month behind the news and answered none of it, because he wrote the ordinary soldier-things and not the great ones, or because the great ones had not reached him either, off where he was. So the household held two things that would not meet — the war it heard of and the brother it heard from — and could not put the one inside the other, and learned to carry them apart: the news for the world's account, and the letters for the slow far proof that he was yet a hand that could write.

The writing of him went on falling, in good part, to the child, and over the going of the years it made her hand a surer thing. She had the family's hand from the grandfather, taught down at the parlor desk under his eye, and she wrote her brother plain and close so a boy with little light could read it; and in the spring she was thirteen the grandfather gave her a book of her own — plain calf, the leather pale, the pages empty — and put it in her hands and said she might write in it the doings of the house through the year of the war, the way he had written the doings of his own in the family's record all his life. She took it and did not rightly know what she would do with it, and put it by, and came to it slowly, a line and then a line, the clear hand setting down what the place did and how the year went. So there were two writings of the place going from that desk now: the one that went down the road to the boy, and the one that stayed and filled a slow line a day with the doing of the days.

And somewhere in the going of those years the thing in the house about the father changed, with no day to fix it on. There had been the late man, and then the long-late man, and his place kept at the head of the table the way it had been kept from the first; and the looking up the lane in the evenings had gone on, the mother at the door and the child at it, the long pale run looked up for the thing that would grow and be him. But a man over the line a year was late; a man over

the line two years was a thing the word *late* would no longer cover, and three was a thing with no word at all that the household had ever had to find. No body came up the road. No grave was sent word of. No man rode up the lane to tell them a thing they could write down. Nothing came; and out of the nothing coming, year on year, the house came by slow degrees to live a way it had never been told to live and had never once said aloud — as though the head of the table would not be sat in again, as though the lane would not bring him, as though the looking, gone on so long for the man, had quietly turned into a looking that did not any longer look to find.

The child felt it cross in herself before she had a word to put on it. She went to the door at the coming-on of an evening, the way she always had, and looked up the long pale run for the thing that would grow and be him; and she found, standing there, that the looking had gone out of her — that she was at the door from habit and not from waiting, that her body had given up the lane some while before the rest of her had been told to, and that what she did at the door now was not watch for a coming but stand a moment while the dark came down over the oak, and turn back in. She did not say to herself that he was not coming. She could not have said it; there was nothing to say it from, no word off any road, no body, no grave, no day. She only found the waiting gone out of her hands and her eyes, gone the way a thing goes that has had nothing to feed it for too long; and she turned back into the house, and the house was a house that had crossed the same thing the same way, each one of them come to it alone at the door and none of them speaking it at the table. The place at the head was kept his. They went on keeping it. But what they kept it for had changed under them — from a place held for a man who was late to a place held for a man gone wherever the unanswered goings went — and no day had told them so, and they had told no day.

And in the autumn of the third year the one place changed where a change could be set down. A man gone past all his days, with an estate and a wife and children and land that the law would want a head for, could not be left a late man forever in the eyes of the court the way he could in the eyes of his own table. There were the things of the place that wanted a hand the law would own — the land, the debts owed it and the debts it owed, the boy's bounty, the running of the whole — and a wife who had been running them all along by the steady doing could be given the running of them in the one place that asked a name on a paper. So in the September of that year Sarah Vass went before the court at Lunenburg, by the grandfather's hand to guide her, who was risen now in the affairs of the county as the war stripped the neighborhood of its men, and was made administratrix of her husband's estate — which was the court's plain way of saying the thing the house had come to long before and never said: that there was no man at the head of it to answer for it, and the answering must pass to the wife. The record gave him up. It had been the one place still holding him a living man — the rolls, the form, the law's long patience that lets a man be absent a great while before it gives his place over — and now even the record let the place go and gave

the running to the wife; and the wife who had been a widow in the doing of every day for three years was a widow now in the one book that could say so.

And yet the table did not give him up. That was the double thing of that autumn the house lived inside of and did not name: that in the September the record let his place go, and the head of the table stayed his all the same. The court could give a man over to the running of his affairs, because what the court had held was a name against an estate, and the estate wanted a head, and the wife was made it. But what the table had held was not a name against an estate. It was his place — the head where the man of the house had sat at every meal of the child's life he had been home to sit at — and that was not a thing a court could be asked to give up or had any way to take. So the two places parted that autumn, the one in the book and the one in the room: the book's place given over, the running of it passed to the wife the law now owned a widow; the table's place kept his, the head of it the head of it still, with no man at it. The house had its man given up in law and kept at the board, and went on, and did not find the two a contradiction, because the one was a thing done for the court and the other a thing done for him.

And in the same year the mother took the estate in hand she took in hand the other thing a mother of a girl that age had to see to, which was the girl. For Mary was near grown now — fourteen, and going on the age her mother had been not many years before her own marrying — and a daughter to be provided for was as much the business of a house with its men gone as the land was, and more, the way the times ran. So across that year the grown talk the child caught the edges of, the way she had caught the talk of Vincent, turned by and by to a name: Gideon Johnson, a young man of a household down the Dan, a private of the Carolina line who had been away in it and was now, in the way of the war, home — a name spoken among the older heads with the weight of a thing being weighed, gone quiet when she came near and come round again when she had gone, the same as the Vincent-talk had gone quiet and come round.

And then the name was a man. She met him at a cousin's house, in the way such meetings were made to fall out and were never called what they were — the families come together of a Sunday, the young man home from the line and at his uncle's board, the girl brought along and set where she would be seen and would see. He was a man of four-and-twenty, quiet, with the war on him the way it was on the men who had been in it and come back; and he was civil to her and to the house, and she looked at him the way she was given leave to look and found in him nothing to fear and a good deal that was steady. She was asked nothing that day. She was shown a man and let to see him, and he a girl, and the grown business of it went on over her head and around her the way it always had — but she was near enough now to the size of it to know what she was being shown, and to weigh the man she was shown in her own measure; and what she weighed came out steady.

And the rest of it was made the way the times made such things, in good part by the road — the mother corresponding it out with the young man's father, the

terms and prospects of it going back and forth by the same slow post that carried the boy's letters, a thing arranged across a distance because the distance was what the war left them to arrange it across. And in the spring the young man rode up to the grandfather's house and asked it — asked the grandfather, and asked the mother, and then, which was not the way the child had been told the asking went, asked the girl herself, apart, the supper done and the candle between them. What passed there was hers; she carried it out of that room her own and would tell it after in her own time. But the end of it, that the house came to know, was that he had asked and she had said yes — not driven to it and not given away to it, a girl inside her mother's providing and not under it, who had been shown a steady man and had weighed him and had found, when the asking came to her and not over her, that the yes was hers to give. She was not in love with him, the way the songs would have it; she was not against him in any part of her; she was a girl going on fifteen who had looked at the man set before her and had not been afraid, and had said the word, and meant it the more for having been let to say it.

So the house came round to the back end of that year with its two long pressures come at last to their hinges, and neither come to rest. The father was given up in the law and kept at the table — his place let go in the one book and held in the one room — and no word had come up any road to tell them more of him than they had told themselves. The daughter was promised, the day set for the November, the young man to ride up with his people and the grandfather to come down from Lunenburg for it. The boy was away in the line still, written to and waited on, the letters going down the road and the slow ones coming back, the war he was in heard of in fragments the house could not lay him into. And the round went on with the hands it had — the mother running it a widow in law now and a widow in fact these three years, the grandfather risen in the county's affairs and leaned on the more, the daughter set to the full of a near-grown woman's part and the desk besides, the letters to her brother and the book filling its slow line a day. The parlor desk was where it all came from now, the writing that went down the road and the writing that stayed, the family's hand at both. And the year turned on toward the November and the wedding, and the place at the head of the table stayed his, and the lane ran out past the oak to the road no answer had ever come back along.

The writing-evening

The evening of the second week of November came down over the house early and cold, the dark gone into the oak before the supper things were cleared away; and when they were cleared, and the fire banked low for the night, and the mother gone in to her bed, the house drew its quiet in around the one place where a candle still burned, and the girl sat down before the desk to write her brother the things he would want to know.

She was fifteen now, and the writing of him had been hers for some years, and she came to it this evening the way she had come to the whole of the part that had fallen to her across the war — not set to it by anyone, but down to it of herself, the body to the chair and the hand to the pen ahead of any telling herself it was the hour. She drew the candle nearer and squared a sheet and uncapped the ink. The desk was the family's, the one she had been taught the hand at under the grandfather's eye when she had been a child wanting the cushion to reach it; and the hand it had taught her was hers now, close and plain and sure, the hand a boy by a poor light in a far camp could read without straining over it. She wrote her brother in it, and the news she had to send was the news the house had, which was a great deal that November and the most of it her own.

She told him the wedding was set for the eighteenth — that the young man would ride up with his people in the forenoon of that day and the thing would be done, and that her brother was to think of them all from wherever the road had him by then. She told him the grandfather would come down from Lunenburg for it and would bring the Bible, to write the marriage into the record where the family's marriages had been written time out of mind, and that he was to ride down the week before and lie the night in the house. She told him their mother was well. And she told him the place went on as he had left it going — the round kept up with the hands it had, the corn in the loft, the year's business answered as it came due — that the house held.

She wrote it all by the one candle in the still house, and behind her in the dark of the next room the head of the table was kept his the way it had been kept these four years, and out beyond the wall the lane ran past the oak to the road that had carried no word of him up it in all that time and could carry none of him down it that she might send. She wrote her brother none of that. There was nothing in it to tell him that he did not already carry, the same as she carried it; it was not news; it was the ground the news stood on. So she wrote him the wedding and the grandfather and the mother and the holding of the place, which were the things there were to say, and let the rest stand under them unsaid, the way it stood under the days and went unsaid at the table too.

And she came to the foot of the page. The letter was down — the telling of it done, the news all told — and there was the close of it to make, and her name to put to it, the way the grandfather had taught her a letter was closed: the writer's name under the last line, so that the one who broke it open a month gone and a hundred miles off would know whose hand had carried the words that far. She dipped the pen for the name. And before the name there wanted something more — not news, for the news was told, and not a wish for him, though she wished him home and whole — but a word for the whole of it, for the thing the letter was beneath all its telling, the thing the house had been doing for four years and had never once said what it was. She understood that now, at the foot of the page, in a way she had not had to before: that the house had never had a word for what it did, that it had only done it, through the lateness and the long not-knowing, and

the place given up in the book and kept at the board, and the year come round again to a wedding. But the doing had wanted its word all that while, the way a thing long done and never named comes at the last to want the naming; and sitting there with the pen wet in her hand she found the word the doing had wanted, which was two words; and she wrote them.

we continue

She put her name under them — Mary Baker — and let the ink dry, and read the page once over by the candle, the news and the two words and the name, and folded it along its creases. She held the stick of wax to the flame until it ran and let it fall on the folded edge and pressed it under her thumb while it cooled and set. Then she stood the letter up on the corner of the desk against the morning, when the carrier would go down the road to the south with the post and it would start the long slow way to her brother and reach him when it reached him, a fortnight off or more, the road being what the war had made of it and the camp being wherever the camp had moved to by the time the letter came to the road's end.

The candle had length in it yet. She did not put it out. She drew to her instead the other book, the one that went nowhere — the plain calf the grandfather had set in her hands the spring she was thirteen, bidding her write in it the doings of the house through the year of the war, that she had come to slowly and had filled since a slow line at a time. She turned to where she had last left off, and dipped the pen again. And in it, that same evening, the letter sealed and standing for the morning, she wrote the two words over — not the wedding, which had its plain line down already in its place, and not the day's round, which would have its line after as the days had had theirs; but the two words by themselves, under the date, in the book that stayed in the house when the letter had gone out of it.

we continue

Then she closed the book and laid it by. The wax on the letter had gone hard. The house was still all about her — the mother asleep beyond the wall, the head of the table kept his in the dark of the next room, the lane outside running the two ways it ran, down toward the boy the letter would go to and out toward the road no answer had ever come back along. The wedding was six days off. She sat a moment more before the desk with the two writings of the evening done between her hands — the one to go down the road in the morning and the one to stay in the house, and the same two words signed under her own name in both of them — and then she put out the candle, and the one lit place in the house went dark with the rest, and she went up to her bed.

The candle the girl put out that evening was put out six days short of her wedding; the days between were not still ones.

The morning after she sealed her letter — the thirteenth of November 1779 — a grant went out under the hand of Richard Caswell, governor of North Carolina, of four hundred acres in Guilford County to Sarah DeGraffenreid. The widow who had been administering an absent man's estate and keeping his place at the head

of the table was made, by that document, a freeholder in her own name, in the Carolina country the family had long been drifting toward. Five days later, on the eighteenth, the wedding was done. Mary Baker DeGraffenreid married Gideon Johnson — the younger of his name, born in Amelia County, Virginia, on the seventh of November 1754, a private of the North Carolina line before the war was out. The grandfather had ridden down from Lunenburg with the Bible and wrote the marriage into the record in the French hand he had kept the family's names in for forty years. What the girl had written under her own name twice that November is not in the Bible; the Bible carries the marriage and nothing else of the evening.

The boy came home. Vincent served in the Virginia line to the autumn of 1781, and came back up a lane to a house, the brother-and-sister letters ended by the plainest means; what he had seen in those years is not this chapter's to tell.

The father did not come home, and the record never says he died. The last it holds of Baker DeGraffenreid alive is the Guilford deed of October 1775; the next is his wife acting as administratrix of his estate by September 1779, which marks his absence and not its cause. Between them is the silence this chapter was the inside of. Family tradition holds that he was killed at the outbreak of the war; this history carries the tradition, has not found the proof, and leaves the gap a gap. Where he died, and when, and by what, are not given back.

And the line went on. In October of 1780 the first child of the new household was born — a daughter, Sarah Johnson, the ninth of that month — and the descent this history follows runs through her. The Bible stayed on the grandfather's desk at Lunenburg, his to keep until 1794, and then came to Mary, the names going on in it after the French hand was done. What the house had learned to be across those four years — a household that did not know, and held, and went on — it did not unlearn at the wedding; the girl carried the thing itself out of her mother's house into her own. The chapter ends not on the evening but on the line: a marriage written, a daughter coming, a father unaccounted and not abandoned, and the keeping moving down the years toward the hand it had not yet reached.

Chapter 4 — The Wedding Morning

She woke in the dark.

She did not know, the first moment, what had woken her. She lay under the two quilts and the wool coverlet and listened. The house did not creak. The chimney did not draw. The wind, which had been up the previous evening from the south-west, had dropped sometime in the night and was not in the chimney now. She listened to the silence of the room for a moment longer and then understood that what had woken her was the silence itself — the quality the room takes on in the hour before any other person in the house is awake — and that she had woken, as her mother had warned her she might, before she needed to.

It was the morning of her wedding.

She lay another moment in the warm hollow of the bed. The room above the parlor of her mother's borrowed house was small — eight feet by ten feet, one window facing east across the cleared field toward the line of the Dan, one door opening onto the stair-head — and was at this hour entirely dark. The window was a square of slightly less black than the rest, but no light came through it; the eastern horizon was an hour or more from any true color. The fire in the parlor below had been banked for the night and was no warm pressure under her floor. The cold of the room was the cold of the room, not the cold of November outside the window, which was different and colder.

She put her hand out from under the coverlet and touched the floor by the bedside. The plank was cold. She drew her hand back and waited a moment more.

Then she got up.

She did it the way her mother had taught her in the four years since her father had gone south over the line and not come back — without thinking about it, with the body moving first and the rest of her following. She put her feet to the floor. She took the wool shawl from the chair at the foot of the bed and put it around her shoulders over the shift. She crossed the four steps to the writing-desk under the window. She struck the candle.

The flame came up small and steady. The writing-desk was an oak slab with a hinged writing-slope and a single drawer; her mother had brought it down from Lunenburg in the cart that summer, with the inkwell and the quill and the box of paper that had been the elder Mary Baker's at Lunenburg before her. It stood against the east wall under the window. Mary Baker sat down in front of it and put her hands on the writing-slope and let them rest there.

The journal was where she had left it six days before. The cover was the plain calf-leather her grandfather had given her in the spring of 1778, when she had been thirteen and he had thought she might begin to keep a record of the household for the year of the war; the spine had darkened to the color of weak tea where her hand had held it across eighteen months. The journal was closed. It

had been closed when she had put it down on the evening of the second week of November and it was closed now. She had not opened it in the six days between.

She did not open it now.

She put her right hand flat on the cover and let it rest there.

* * *

It was, by her mother's count, four years and a month since her father's last documented day among the living. Baker DeGraffenreid had ridden south out of Lunenburg in the autumn of 1775, over the line into Guilford County on the place's business, and the last the record held of him was a deed he had put his hand to at a Guilford crossing on the twentieth of October that year, the autumn she had turned eleven. He had not come back up the road, and no word of him had. No body had been recovered. No grave had been dug. Sarah Vass DeGraffenreid had administered the estate as a widow in deed if not yet in law across the four years since, taking the administratrix's seat at the county court that September past; and Governor Caswell five days ago, on the Saturday now, had granted her four hundred acres in the Guilford country as land for a widow with three children to provide for and a daughter to marry off in a war.

The grant was on the parlor desk downstairs.

The Bible was on the parlor desk downstairs.

Her grandfather had ridden down from Lunenburg the previous afternoon with the Bible in the leather case he had carried it in since his father's death in the autumn of 1742. He was sleeping in the small guest chamber off the parlor, where the bed had been made up the previous afternoon and where the fire had been lit at dusk and where, by the settled order of the household, he would be sleeping until first light. The Bible had come out of the case after supper and he had set it on the parlor desk with the marker placed at the page where the marriage entry would go and the inkwell beside it and the quill laid across the open page. Then he had banked the parlor fire and had gone to his bed.

The Bible was downstairs, alone in the dark parlor, on the desk.

She thought about it.

She thought about her grandfather in the small guest chamber off the parlor. Tschanner DeGraffenreid was fifty-six years old that November, the third generation of his family in Virginia, the keeper of the Bible since his father's death at Williamsburg in the autumn of 1742, the same year he had married. He had buried his father that October and had brought the Bible home to the south-side seat in the cart with him. He had kept it since. He had written into it the births of his children and the deaths of his children and the deaths of his wife's parents and his own mother's death and his own brother's death and the names of his grandchildren as they had come. He would write into it, this morning at ten, the marriage of his granddaughter to Gideon Johnson Jr. of Guilford County, who had been a private of the Second North Carolina Continental Line under Captain

Armstrong and Colonel Martin for fifteen months in 1776 and 1777 and was home now, since February.

She thought about Gideon Johnson Jr.

He was twenty-five years old. She had known him eight months. He had ridden to her grandfather's house in March, the second week of March, to ask permission, and her grandfather had given it, and her mother had given it, and she had given it; and the asking had not been the way she had been told asking went. He had asked it of her separately, in the cloister of her grandfather's house at Lunenburg, after the supper, with the candle on the table between them. He had said: *Mary Baker, I have asked your grandfather and your mother. I am asking you now. If you will have me, I will have you. If you will not, I will not press it.* She had said yes. She had said it without thinking about it, and then she had thought about it, sitting in front of him with the candle between them, and had said it again, more slowly, and had understood that the second time was the answer and that the first time had been the body knowing before she did.

She thought about Vincent.

Her brother was in the field somewhere to the north. The letter that had come on the carrier the second week of October had been written from a camp the carrier could put no nearer than *somewhere above the North River*, the letter having come the long way down from the Highlands of New York by more hands than she could count. Vincent had been a private in the Virginia Line since the winter of 1777. He was sixteen years and nine months old as of the sixth of this month — she had counted, the morning of the sixth, sitting at this desk in the candle. He was perhaps four hundred miles north. He was perhaps five hundred. He had written, in the letter, that he had a wool blanket and a haversack and a flint and a tin cup and a coat that he had taken off a dead man, which she did not believe but which she had not, in her answering letter, said she did not believe.

She had written to him on the night of the second week of November.

She had written it in this room, at this desk, by this candle. She had written it after her mother had gone to bed and after the house had gone still. She had told him that the wedding was set for the eighteenth. She had told him that their grandfather would ride down from Lunenburg with the Bible. She had told him that their mother was well. She had told him that the household held. She had written, at the close, in her own hand, two words. No one had taught them to her. She had not had them from her mother the way she had had the keeping itself from her mother — which was by being inside it, and by watching it done, across the four years and the years before them, until the doing of it was in her own hands and she had never once been told a word of it. The keeping she had had that way. The words she had not had at all, until that night, when she had come to the close of the letter and found that what she had been doing all along had wanted a name, and that she had given it one.

She had written it under her name in the letter, and had folded the letter, and had sealed it with the candle wax, and had given it to the carrier on the Monday

morning. The carrier had ridden south. The letter, by the count of the road, would not have reached Vincent yet. It might not reach him for another fortnight.

She put her hand on the closed journal on the writing-slope.

She did not open it. She did not need to. She knew what was in it. She had written the two words in the journal on the evening of the second week of November, after she had written them in the letter to Vincent and after the carrier had ridden, and had not written in the journal since.

The phrase was in two places this morning. In the letter on its way south. In the journal closed under her hand.

It was not in the Bible.

The Bible downstairs in the dark parlor was Tscharner's keeping. The marriage entry he would write into it at ten this morning would be in French, in the formal hand he had kept since the spring of 1742, with the names and the date and the parish and the witnesses laid down in the settled form his father had taught him as the form of the family's record. He would not write the phrase. He did not know the phrase. The phrase was hers — she had come to it herself, at the desk, in the dark — and the keeping it named was her mother's and the household's and now hers; but the two words were her own, and were not yet anyone's else.

She thought, for the first time since she had woken, of her mother in the room below.

Sarah Vass DeGraffenreid would be lying in the bed she had moved into the parlor in October, when the upstairs bedroom had been given to the daughter for the wedding morning. She was sleeping. She was thirty-five years old that November, four years a widow in fact and not yet in law, the administratrix of an estate that had no body to bury, the holder this past week of a Carolina patent in her own name. She would not move for another hour. The first sound from her would be the bed-rope creaking when she sat up; the second would be the kettle hook swinging on the parlor crane.

The candle had burned down a quarter of an inch.

* * *

She sat at the desk in the dark and thought about none of these things in particular. She had thought about all of them already, in the days that had led up to this morning, and what she was doing now was not thinking but the quieter thing that comes after thinking, which is the sitting with what has been thought. The desk was solid under her hands. The candle was steady. The journal was closed. The Bible was downstairs. Her grandfather was in the guest chamber. Her mother was in the parlor bed. Her brother was north, in the camp in the Highlands, with the letter she had written him on its way to him and not yet arrived. Her father was in whatever ground had taken him, four years gone and a month, with no body recovered and no grave dug. Gideon Johnson Jr. would ride up to the house with his cousin and his cousin's wife and his uncle in the third

hour of the morning, after the household had risen and had eaten and had laid the parlor out.

The wedding was at ten.

She sat at the desk a little longer. The candle burned down another sixteenth of an inch. The square of window above the desk did not yet show any color; the eastern horizon outside it would not begin to lift toward gray for another forty minutes. She put her hand again, gently, on the cover of the closed journal. She did not open it. She did not need to. She thought the two words in her own head — we continue — and she did not say them and did not write them, and let them sit in her where they had sat in the room, waiting to be carried.

Below her, in the room on the other side of the floor, the bed-rope creaked.

She lifted her hand from the journal. She did not move otherwise. She waited.

The bed-rope creaked again. Then there was the soft fall of bare feet on the parlor floor — her mother's feet, walking to the hearth — and then the iron sound of the kettle hook swinging out on the parlor crane.

Mary Baker DeGraffenreid sat at the writing-desk in the upstairs bedroom of her mother's borrowed house on the south side of the Dan River and listened to her mother make up the morning fire in the room below.

The wedding was at ten.

She blew out the candle.

* * *

She sat at the desk a moment longer in the dark.

The candle was out. The square of the window above the desk was beginning, in the next quarter hour, to take a paler shade than the room around it; the eastern horizon outside it had begun to lift toward gray while she had been sitting. She did not look at the window directly. She put her hand on the cover of the closed journal one more time and lifted it, and stood, and put the wool shawl back around her shoulders over the shift, and crossed the four steps to the door of the bedroom, and opened it.

The stair was darker than the room. The parlor below was the color of a coal that had been banked and had not yet been built up — a faint red glow at the hearth, the rest dark. She came down the stair holding the rail with her right hand and the shawl closed at her throat with her left. The treads were cold under her feet. The fifth tread creaked the way it had creaked since her mother had taken the house in October. She came down it slowly and put her foot down on the parlor floor.

Her mother was at the hearth.

Sarah Vass DeGraffenreid had built up the fire to a clean flame and had hung the kettle on the crane and had set the iron trivet on the hearth-stone and had taken the wooden butter-firkin from the shelf and had set it on the trivet to soften, and was now kneeling at the hearth with the bellows in her hands, working the bellows at the base of the fire with the patience of a woman who had built up four

years of morning fires alone in borrowed houses and was building up this one. She wore a brown wool gown over a clean shift, her hair pinned up under a white linen cap, no apron yet. She did not turn when her daughter came down. She had heard the fifth tread.

She said: *Come to the fire.*

Mary Baker came to the fire. She stood beside her mother at the hearth-stone and put her hands out to the warmth and let the heat take the cold out of her fingers. Her mother went on working the bellows for another minute, until the fire was running on its own, and then set the bellows aside and stood up, and put her hand on the back of Mary Baker's head briefly and let it rest there, and took it away.

She said: *You did not sleep past the hour.*

Mary Baker said: *No, mama.*

Sarah said: *I did not think you would.*

* * *

The morning began.

Sarah swung the kettle hook back over the fire and went to the cupboard by the parlor wall and brought out the wooden bowl of corn-meal and the smaller bowl of salt and the jug of milk that had stood in the cold of the kitchen lean-to overnight, and set them on the parlor table, and went to the small chamber off the parlor and put her hand on the door and stood a moment listening, and then knocked once and said: *Father, the fire is up.* Her own father-in-law she had called *Anton* for nineteen years; her own father lay buried at Cumberland in 1772; the man on the other side of the door was the father she had now. He answered through the door that he was awake and had been awake an hour and would be out directly. Sarah came back to the parlor.

She said to her daughter: *Eat first. Then we go up.*

Mary Baker ate at the parlor table standing. She did not sit. Her mother stood at the other side of the table and ate the same way. They ate corn-mush from one wooden bowl with two wooden spoons, with milk poured over and a pinch of salt, the way they had eaten at the borrowed house since October, the way they had eaten at Lunenburg before that, the way Sarah had been eating with her children for the four years since the survey trip had not come back. The food was hot. It went down into the body and stayed there. Mary Baker ate three spoonfuls and her mother ate four and they were done.

Tscharner came out of the small chamber while they were drinking the last of the milk from the bowl.

He was dressed for a wedding. He wore the dark blue broadcloth coat he had brought down from Lunenburg in the cart with the Bible, the coat his wife had cut and sewn for him in the winter of 1773 when their daughter Anna had been married; he wore a clean linen shirt and a black silk stock and the wool breeches he had worn under his coat on the road; his stockings were the cream-colored

worsted he kept for court days and his shoes were the black-buckled shoes he kept for the same. His grey hair was tied back at the nape with a black ribbon. He had shaved.

He looked at his granddaughter across the parlor and inclined his head to her in the formal way he inclined his head to women in his own house at Lunenburg when they came into a room.

He said: *Mary Baker.*

She said: *Grandfather.*

He said: *The morning is come.*

She said: *Yes, sir.*

He went past her to the parlor desk where the Bible was, and stood at the desk a moment with his hand on the leather cover of the case the Bible had been carried in, not lifting the case, not opening the Bible, only standing with his hand on the case the way a man stands at a horse he has rested and is now going to ride. Then he took his hand off the case and turned and went to the kitchen door and out into the lean-to, and the back door of the lean-to opened and closed, and they heard his shoes on the path going down toward the cleared field where the horses were tied for the morning under the lee of the line of pines at the south side of the field.

Sarah said, when the door had closed: *Now we go up.*

* * *

The back bedroom was the room behind the parlor on the ground floor — the room Sarah had been sleeping in since October, the room she had moved out of the previous afternoon when the bed had been re-made up for the bride to dress in. The fire in the small grate had been built up before dawn and was holding steady. The shutter on the single window had been opened a quarter-turn to let the gray light in. The gown lay on the bed.

It was a wool gown the color of new butter, a clear pale yellow that her mother had dyed at Lunenburg the previous winter from the onion-skins her aunt at the south-side seat had saved through the autumn of 1778 for the dye-pot, and her mother had cut it and sewn it across the spring and summer of 1779 in the slow hours when there had not been anything else to do; the bodice was lined with the brown wool that had been Sarah's own bodice once, before the borrowed house and the second cutting; the skirt had a panel at the back let in from the same brown wool to give it the fullness the front did not need. The sleeves were three-quarter, finished with a band of plain linen. The neckline was cut square and the linen of the shift would show at the collar. It was not a Charleston gown and it was not a Williamsburg gown. It was a Lunenburg-County widow's daughter's wedding gown, made in a house that did not have the means for silk, by a mother who knew her trade.

There was a cap for the hair, plain white linen, pinned with two black-headed pins that had been her grandmother's.

There were stockings, cream-colored, worsted, the same wool as Tscharner's.

There were shoes, brown leather, low-heeled, with brass buckles her grandfather had brought down from Lunenburg in the cart for her in October.

Mary Baker took off her night-shift in the back bedroom and stood in front of the fire while her mother washed her face and her neck and her arms and her hands at the basin with the cold water from the ewer, drying her with a piece of plain linen that had been a sheet once and had been cut down for the cloth-bag. The cold water on her shoulders made her breathe in. Her mother did not say anything. Her mother had washed her at five and at seven and at ten and at twelve and at every birthday up to her thirteenth in this same manner, with the same kind of cloth and the same kind of water, and the body that stood in front of her now was the body she had known since she had brought it into the world fifteen years and two months and fifteen days ago, and was also the body of the woman who was going to be married in three hours. She washed the body and dried it and did not say anything.

Then she helped her into the clean shift.

Then the stockings, sitting on the edge of the bed; the stockings up to the knee, tied with the plain linen garters her grandmother had made.

Then the gown.

The gown went over her head, and her mother turned her and worked the buttons down the back from the shoulder-blades to the waist, twelve buttons of bone, working slowly, and then the lacings at the bodice, drawing them and tying them off at the back below the waist where the apron would cover them. The wool of the bodice was warm. The skirt fell straight to the instep. Mary Baker stood with her arms a little out from her sides while her mother walked once around her and looked at the shoulders and the seat and the hem and the sleeves, and came back to the front, and adjusted the linen at the collar so that it sat clean inside the square of the neckline, and looked at her face and did not say anything.

Then the shoes.

Then the cap.

The cap went on last, after her mother had taken the long brown hair down from where it had been pinned for sleep and had brushed it out with the boar-bristle brush her grandfather had brought down from Lunenburg and had pinned it up again at the crown of the head in the plain knot a young woman wore under her cap on her wedding morning, and had set the cap over the knot, and had pinned the cap with the two black-headed pins.

She stepped back.

She said: *Look*.

There was a small mirror on the wall above the basin, no larger than a hand-span across; her mother had brought it from Lunenburg in the cart in October with the writing-desk. Mary Baker turned and looked. The face in the mirror was her face. The cap was straight. The collar of the shift sat clean inside the neckline. The pale yellow of the wool was the color of butter in the mirror as it was the color

of butter in the room. She looked at the face for a moment and then at her mother behind her in the mirror, and her mother looked back at her in the mirror, and neither of them said anything.

She turned around from the mirror.

She said: *I am ready.*

Her mother said: *Yes.*

* * *

The parlor when they came back into it was full of gray light. Tscharner was in the parlor again; he had come back from the horses, and had laid his coat across the chair by the hearth, and was standing at the parlor desk with the Bible. He had taken the Bible out of the case. He had set the case on the floor beside the desk. The Bible was open on the desk now at the page where the marriage entry would go — the page after the births in his own hand, the page he had left clean across the four years he had thought he might write his son Baker's death-entry there and had not yet, because there was no body and no dated certainty and the law of his own house was that the family record carried only what it knew. The page was blank. The inkwell was beside it. The quill was laid across the open page.

He did not look up when they came in.

Sarah crossed the parlor and stood beside her father-in-law at the desk a moment, looking at the open page with him, not touching the page, not touching the Bible. Then she put her hand on his sleeve at the elbow for a count of two and took it away, and turned, and came back across the parlor to her daughter at the front of the room.

The front of the room had been laid out the previous evening. The chairs had been carried in from the kitchen and the lean-to and the small chamber and had been set in two short rows facing the parlor desk, leaving an aisle of about four feet between them. The cleared aisle ended at a small space in front of the desk where the bride and the groom would stand. The desk was the altar. The Bible on the desk was the witness.

Mary Baker stood at the front of the front room in the pale yellow gown with the clean cap and the cream-colored stockings and the brown shoes with the brass buckles, and put her hands together in front of her at the waist and let them rest there. Her mother stood beside her. Neither of them sat down.

The clock on the mantel — a plain pine-cased clock her grandfather had brought down from Lunenburg, wound the previous evening — read three-quarters past eight. The clock had been set the previous evening against her grandfather's watch.

They listened.

For the first quarter hour they heard only the fire in the hearth and the sounds of the house — the kettle hissing softly on the crane, a board contracting under the floor as the morning came on, her grandfather's breathing at the desk behind them. Sarah did not speak. Mary Baker did not speak. The cap on her head was

light. The wool of the gown was warm against her arms. The shoes were stiff at the heel because they were new.

She thought of nothing in particular. She had thought already, in the dark hour at the writing-desk upstairs, of everything she had to think. What she was doing now was the other thing — the standing-and-waiting that comes after the thinking is done.

The clock read four minutes past the nine when she heard the horses on the track from the south.

She heard the four horses. She counted them. Four horses on the frozen ground of the track coming up the cleared field from the south, the sound coming clean through the still air of the morning before any wind had come up. The horses were perhaps a half-mile down the track. They were coming at a walk. She listened to them coming and did not turn her head and did not move.

Her mother heard them at the same moment. Sarah turned her head a quarter-turn toward the door and listened, and then turned back, and looked at her daughter.

Sarah said: *They are come.*

Mary Baker said: *Yes.*

Her grandfather behind them at the parlor desk closed the Bible gently on the marker and stepped back from the desk and put on the dark blue coat his wife had sewn him in the winter of 1773. He did not say anything.

The horses came up the track. The sound of them grew. They came past the line of pines at the south side of the field and into the yard at the front of the house and stopped, and there was the small sound of the riders dismounting on the frozen ground, the soft fall of four sets of feet, and then a man's voice low, a woman's voice answering, and then the sound of feet on the path coming up to the front door.

There was a knock on the door.

Sarah looked at her daughter across the front room.

Mary Baker looked back.

Sarah crossed the room to the door.

* * *

Sarah opened the door.

The cold of the November morning came in past her into the parlor and went up into the high corners of the room and was gone, and the gray light of the yard came in at the door behind it, and the four who had ridden up the track from the south came in out of the cold and the light into the parlor where the fire was up and the Bible was on the desk.

Gideon Johnson Jr. came in first. He was in a brown wool coat that had been cut for him at Guilford in the autumn after he had come home in February, and a clean linen shirt with a black silk stock, and wool breeches and the same cream-colored worsted stockings Tschärner had on, and brown boots that had been on

the road four hours from the inn at the south end of the cleared field where they had slept the night. He took his hat off when he came in. He had cut his dark hair short the previous afternoon at the inn.

He looked across the parlor at Mary Baker.

He said: *Mary Baker.*

She said: *Gideon.*

He came across the parlor to where she was standing in front of the front room and stopped two paces short of her, the way a man stops who has been on a road and is now at the place he was going to. He did not take her hand. He did not need to yet. He looked at her face in the pale yellow gown with the clean cap, and she looked at his face above the black silk stock, and they stood looking at each other across the two paces without saying anything for the space of three breaths.

His uncle came in behind him. Joseph Johnson was forty-eight years old that November, the elder brother of Gideon's father, a Guilford County farmer of three hundred and twenty acres on the south side of the Dan with two grown sons and a daughter married to a Pittsylvania man and a wife of twenty-three years standing beside him now. He wore the dark blue coat he had worn to court since 1771 and the wool breeches he had worn under it for the same number of years and the black-buckled shoes he kept for the same. He took his hat off and held it in his left hand and looked once at Sarah at the door and inclined his head to her, and Sarah inclined her head back.

His cousin John Johnson came in behind his father. He was twenty-six years old, a year older than Gideon, a Guilford farmer in his own right since his marriage three years before. His wife Elizabeth came in behind him in a dark green wool gown and a clean white cap with the same kind of black-headed pins Mary Baker had in her own cap, having been brought up in the same Guilford Anglican way and dressed for the same kind of Carolina November morning. She was twenty-four. She had a small leather travelling-bag in her left hand that she set down inside the door and did not open.

Sarah closed the door behind them.

The parlor was full now. The four who had come up from the south were in the front part of the room by the door; Mary Baker and Sarah were at the front of the front room facing the parlor desk; Tscharner was at the desk with the Bible open on it. The fire was up. The kettle was off the crane and was on the trivet on the hearth-stone where Sarah had set it after the eating. The clock on the mantel read seven minutes past nine.

Tscharner did not turn from the desk when the door closed. He had stood at the desk through the dismounting and the knocking and the opening, with his back to the room, looking at the open Bible and the inkwell and the quill on the page, the way a man stands at the work that is in front of him because the work is the thing that gets him through. When the door closed he turned.

He looked at the four. He looked at his granddaughter. He looked at his daughter-in-law. He looked at Gideon.

He said: *We will begin.*

* * *

The household took its places.

Joseph and John and Elizabeth Johnson came across the parlor and took the three chairs on the right of the cleared aisle that Sarah had set for them the previous evening, and sat down. Sarah crossed back to her own chair on the left of the aisle and sat. The aisle between them was about four feet wide. The cleared space at the front of it, in front of the parlor desk, was where the bride and groom were to stand.

Gideon walked to the cleared space and stood at the right side of it, facing the desk. Mary Baker walked to the cleared space and stood at the left side of it, facing the desk. They were a foot and a half apart. She did not look at him. He did not look at her. They both looked at the desk in front of them where her grandfather was now turned to face them across the open Bible.

Tscharner had the quill in his right hand.

He did not pick the Bible up. He left it open on the desk where it had lain through the morning. The page he had marked the previous evening was the next clean page in the family record — the page after the last birth he had entered, which was the birth of his youngest grandson at Lunenburg in the spring of 1776; the page he had thought across four years that he might write his son Baker's death-entry on, and had not, because there was no body and no dated certainty and the law of his own house was that the family record carried only what it knew. The page was clean. The marker tape was laid down the left margin. The inkwell stood beside the page on the right. The blotting-paper was folded once and was laid above the page where his right hand could reach it.

He looked across the desk at his granddaughter and at the man standing beside her.

He said: *Gideon Johnson, son of Gideon Johnson of Guilford County, you have come here this morning to take Mary Baker DeGraffenreid, daughter of Baker DeGraffenreid of Lunenburg, to be your wife.*

Gideon said: *I have.*

Tscharner said: *Mary Baker DeGraffenreid, you have come here this morning to take Gideon Johnson to be your husband.*

Mary Baker said: *I have.*

Tscharner said: *Will you hold him in this life and not put him aside.*

Mary Baker said: *I will.*

Tscharner said: *Will you hold her in this life and not put her aside.*

Gideon said: *I will.*

Tscharner said: *Then the marriage is between you. The household stands witness to it. The entry will stand in the family record.*

He turned to the desk.

* * *

He dipped the quill. He held it a moment above the inkwell to let the surplus run back. He brought it down to the page.

He wrote in the careful French he reserved for the most important entries, in the formal hand his father had taught him in the spring of 1742 when he himself had ridden into Lunenburg County to be married, in the hand he had kept since:

> *Gédéon Johnson, fils de Gédéon Johnson de Guilford en Caroline du Nord, époux. Marie Baker DeGraffenreid, fille de Baker DeGraffenreid de Lunenburg en Virginie, épouse. Mariés à la maison de la mère de l'épouse dans le comté de Guilford en Caroline du Nord, le dix-huitième jour de novembre, 1779.*

He set the quill in the inkwell.

He took up the blotting-paper. He laid it across the entry and pressed it down with the flat of his hand for the count of three, and lifted it, and set it back beside the page. The ink had blotted clean. The entry stood on the page in his own hand.

He looked at it.

The entry was in his hand. The French was correct. The date was correct. The names were correct. The place was correct. The father, the mother, the bride, the groom, the day. The entry was the entry the family would come back to. He had written *Marie Baker DeGraffenreid* in the French form of her given name, the way his father had written *Marie* for the elder Mary Baker on the entry of his own marriage in 1742, because the formal hand carried the French convention and his granddaughter was now also Marie on the family page.

He held the page a moment longer with his hand at the upper margin. Then he took his hand off.

He turned the Bible toward the cleared space in front of the desk where Gideon and Mary Baker stood, and pushed it forward an inch, and set the quill on the page above the entry.

He said: *Sign.*

* * *

Gideon picked up the quill. He had to step half a pace closer to the desk to reach the page. He dipped the quill in the inkwell. He held it a moment above the open page. Then he wrote, in his own hand, in clean English, below the formal French entry his bride's grandfather had written:

Gideon Johnson Jr.

He set the quill in the inkwell. He stepped back to his place.

Mary Baker stepped forward to the desk. She picked up the quill. She dipped it. She held it above the page for a moment shorter than her husband had held it, because she had known for some hours that she would write her own name on the entry her grandfather had written and had decided, sitting at the writing-desk

upstairs in the dark hour, what hand she would write it in. She wrote in the small clear English hand she had been writing in her own journal across eighteen months:

Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson.

She set the quill in the inkwell. She did not step back yet.

She looked at the entry on the page. The French in her grandfather's hand. Her husband's name in his own hand below it. Her own name in her own hand below his. The three lines were the family record now. The Bible on the desk was the keeping-Bible and the page was the family's and the marriage was on the page and the morning had done its work.

She stepped back to her place beside her husband.

* * *

Sarah came forward from her chair on the left of the aisle and crossed the cleared space and picked up the quill, and dipped it, and signed beneath the bride. She wrote in the hand she had kept since her own girlhood at Lunenburg, the hand her mother had taught her, and that the family record at Lunenburg had carried since her own marriage to Baker in 1762:

Sarah Vass DeGraffenreid

She set the quill down. She did not look at the entry on the page for longer than the count of two. She turned and went back to her chair.

Joseph Johnson came forward next. He signed in the steady hand of a Guilford farmer who had signed deeds and court papers and tax rolls for twenty-seven years:

Joseph Johnson

He stepped back.

John Johnson came forward. He signed in a hand younger than his father's and slightly less practiced but the same kind of hand — the hand of a man who signed his own papers and had signed them for the four years he had been a farmer in his own right:

John Johnson

He stepped back.

Elizabeth Johnson came forward last. She was the only woman of the four witnesses besides Sarah. She had been taught to write at Guilford by her mother and had signed her own marriage three years before. She wrote in a clean Anglican hand that had been taught in the same way Mary Baker's had been taught and the same way her own daughters would be taught:

Elizabeth Johnson

She set the quill in the inkwell. She stepped back to her chair beside her husband.

The signing was done.

* * *

Tscharner came forward to the desk. He took up the blotting-paper a second time and laid it across the page and pressed it down with the flat of his hand for the count of three, the way he had blotted his own entry, and lifted it, and set it back beside the page. The ink had blotted clean. The four witness signatures stood on the page beneath the names of the bride and groom and the French entry above them. The page was the family record. The Bible was the keeping-Bible. The work of the morning was on the page now and would stay there.

He stood at the desk a moment longer with his hand at the upper margin of the page, the way he had stood at the desk when he had first come into the parlor at dawn before he had gone out to the horses. He did not say anything.

He took his hand off the page.

The clock on the mantel read twenty-three minutes past ten.

The parlor was quiet. The fire was up. The kettle on the hearth-stone was steady. The eight people in the room — the grandfather at the desk, the bride and groom in the cleared space, the mother on the left of the aisle, the uncle and cousin and cousin's wife on the right — were quiet with the quiet that comes after work has been done.

The ink on the page was drying.

It was drying at the rate of November ink in a parlor with a clean fire and the gray light of mid-morning coming in at the eastern windows. The French entry in the formal hand at the top of the page was dry already. The bride's and the groom's names in English below it were nearly dry. The four witness signatures at the bottom were taking the longer they took because the parlor was cold at the desk and the ink had gone down recently. Tscharner watched the ink. Mary Baker watched the ink. Gideon Johnson watched the ink. The four witnesses on the right side of the aisle watched the ink. Sarah watched the ink from her chair on the left.

The ink dried.

The page was the family record. The Bible was the keeping-Bible. The morning was done.

The Wedding-Supper Hour

The ink on the marriage entry was dry on the page at twenty-three minutes past ten on the morning of Thursday the eighteenth of November of 1779. Tscharner had blotted it once, set the blotting-paper aside, and lifted his hand from the desk. The Bible lay open on the parlor desk with the entry on the recto and the previous page's last entry — the death of his wife the elder Mary Baker at Lunenburg on the seventh of June of 1773 — facing it on the verso, the two pages set against each other, the household's losing and gaining held on the open Bible.

The parlor was quiet with the quiet that comes after work has been done.

The household stood for a moment where it had been standing. Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson — the name now on the page — was beside Gideon at the

parlor desk. Sarah was on the left of where the aisle had been. The three Johnsons were on the right. Then Sarah said: *Come to the table*. And the household moved.

The parlor table was a plank table, six feet by three, that Tscharner had set against the south wall of the room four years earlier when they had moved in with Sarah's brother's widow at Guilford and that Sarah had pulled out into the middle of the floor at first light that morning before the bellows went on. She had laid it the night before. The cloth was the good linen cloth her mother had given her at her own wedding to Baker in 1762 and that she had kept in the cedar chest since 1775. The plates were the eight pewter plates the household had carried down from Lunenburg in the cart in 1775 — six of the original eight from Sarah's marriage settlement and two that had been Tscharner's at Lunenburg before the elder Mary Baker died. The cups were tin. The forks were horn-handled. The knives were the household's good knives, sharpened at the lean-to the previous afternoon.

Tscharner sat at the head of the table because he was the senior man in the household and because the household placed him there. Mary Baker and Gideon sat together on the long west side. Sarah sat across from them on the long east side, in the chair where she could see the kitchen door and the parlor door at once. Joseph Johnson took the chair to Tscharner's right at the foot end. John and Elizabeth Johnson took the chairs beside Joseph, John next to his uncle and Elizabeth at the foot of the table, the chair the household had set there because eight chairs at a six-foot table required one at the foot.

Sarah brought the Carolina ham in from the kitchen lean-to first. It was a six-pound ham she had started on Tuesday morning, a country-cured ham Joseph had brought down from his own smokehouse in October on his last ride up to see his nephew at Guilford before the wedding date was set. She had simmered it in the iron kettle at the lean-to fire across Tuesday afternoon, taken it off the fire that night, set it in the cold-cellar across Wednesday, and brought it back to the lean-to fire at four o'clock that morning to warm through. She carried it to the table on the pewter platter. She set it at the place to the left of Tscharner. The carving-knife was beside it.

The corn-bread came from the parlor hearth. Sarah had set the spider on the trivet over the hearth coals at twenty minutes past nine, while the four riders were still on the cleared field, and the corn-bread had baked through the half-hour of the ceremony and the quarter-hour of the signing and the seven minutes of the company moving from the cleared aisle to the table. She lifted the spider off the trivet with the iron hook, turned the corn-bread out onto the wooden board, cut it across in eight, and brought the board to the table.

The stewed apples were in the brown stoneware bowl. They had been put up at Lunenburg the previous October from the apples of the small orchard the elder Mary Baker had planted in 1745, and Sarah had brought eight jars of them down to Guilford in the cart in 1775 and had three jars left in the cold-cellar that morning, and she had opened one of them on Wednesday and stewed the apples

slowly across Wednesday evening with the cinnamon Joseph had brought up in October. The bowl went to the centre of the table.

The Madeira was in the brown stoneware jug Joseph had carried up in his saddle-bag from Guilford. He had got it the previous week from a Guilford factor named Hawkins, in trade for a quarter of beef from his own October butchering. He had not opened it on the road. He had set it on the table himself when the company first sat down, in the place between his own plate and his nephew's.

There was cider in a second jug — a sweet cider Sarah had pressed at Guilford in early November from the apples of the orchard the brother-in-law's widow kept up — and the cider was in front of Mary Baker and Sarah. Mary Baker did not take the Madeira. She took the cider.

Tscharner said the household's grace. It was a short grace in English, the grace he had said at his father's table at Lunenburg through the thirty-one years of his father's life there, and that he had said at his own table at Lunenburg through the seventeen years he had been the keeper there with Mary Baker, and that he had said at this table at Guilford through the four years since 1775. *Lord, we thank thee for this food, and for the day, and for the company at the table. Amen.* The household answered amen.

Tscharner carved the ham. He carved standing, in the careful way the elder Mary Baker had taught him at Lunenburg in the first year of their marriage when he had not yet learned to carve and she had set him to it once and watched him do it badly and then taken the knife and shown him. He set six slices on the platter and passed the platter to his left, to Sarah; Sarah took her own slice and passed to Mary Baker; Mary Baker took hers and passed to Gideon; Gideon took his and passed across to John Johnson; John took his and passed to Elizabeth; Elizabeth took hers and passed up the table to Joseph; Joseph took his and set the platter at the place to the right of Tscharner. The household ate.

Joseph spoke first across the table. He said the road from Guilford had been cold. He had left the inn at the south end of the cleared field at first light with the lantern hung at the saddle and John and Elizabeth behind him. The cold had been hard in the third hour of the ride, between the inn and the bridge at the upper ford. He had thought twice about whether the cold was beyond what an old man should be riding in.

— You are not an old man, said Tscharner.

— I am forty-eight, said Joseph.

— I am fifty-six. You are not an old man.

— You are not an old man either, Tscharner.

The household laughed. It was the first time the household had laughed since the riders had come up the track at four minutes past nine that morning. Mary Baker laughed beside Gideon, and Sarah laughed across from her, and John Johnson laughed at his uncle, and Elizabeth Johnson laughed at her husband laughing at his uncle. The laughter went around the table once and stopped

where it had begun, with Joseph and Tscharner looking at each other across the corner of the table.

Sarah passed the corn-bread to her right. The board went up the table to Gideon, and Gideon took a piece and passed to John, and John to Elizabeth, and Elizabeth to Joseph, and Joseph set the board between himself and Tscharner. The stewed apples went the other way around — Sarah served a spoonful onto Mary Baker's plate and a spoonful onto her own and passed the bowl across.

Joseph asked Tscharner about the south boundary of the Caswell grant. He had ridden the line in October on his October visit, when he had come up with the ham and the cinnamon, and he had seen the chestnut at the south corner that Tscharner had named to him as the marker, but the line east from the chestnut had not been clear to him on the ground.

Tscharner said the line east from the chestnut ran to the second white oak in the small bottom that drained to the south. He had marked it on the September walk with the surveyor.

Joseph said the small bottom had been wet in October.

Tscharner said the small bottom was wet in October most years and that the line ran through the wet ground because the surveyor had laid it through the wet ground, and the line was the line.

Joseph said the line was the line.

Sarah said the grant was for four hundred acres in the Guilford country and the household would have the survey returned to the Land Office at Hillsborough before Christmas if the weather held.

Joseph said his own four hundred had taken six months to return after the survey, the clerk at the Land Office having been slow.

Tscharner said the Hillsborough clerk was a man named Williams and the man had moved on Tscharner's October papers in two weeks.

Joseph said in that case the household would be on the grant before spring planting.

— Before March, said Tscharner. The cabin at Lunenburg holds till March.

— And after March, said Joseph.

— After March we cross the Dan and we build, said Tscharner.

— And the grant is in your name, said Joseph.

— The grant is in Sarah's name. I filed the request for her in May, and the clerk at Hillsborough wrote it to her in October. She is the widow; the governor granted it to her.

Sarah said the clerk's name was Williams and the clerk had been respectful.

Tscharner said the clerk had been respectful.

The household passed the Madeira jug up the table. Joseph poured for himself and for Tscharner and for John and for Gideon. Sarah passed the cider jug to Mary Baker, who poured for herself and for her mother and for Elizabeth.

Elizabeth said the apples were good. She said her own Guilford orchard had not given well in October because of the late frost in May, and the few apples she

had put up had been hard. Sarah said the Lunenburg orchard had given well in 1778 — the year before the frost reached as far north as Guilford — and the apples in the bowl were from that October, kept in the cold-cellar through the year. Elizabeth said the cold-cellar at Guilford did not keep as well as the cold-cellar at Lunenburg apparently did. Sarah said the Lunenburg cold-cellar was deep and the spring that ran behind it kept the temperature even. Elizabeth said she would build a deeper one at Guilford in the spring.

The household was eating. The corn-bread was eaten. Sarah went to the kitchen lean-to and brought back a second board with a fresh half of corn-bread she had baked at five o'clock that morning, and the second board went around the table the way the first had gone. The Madeira jug was poured a second time.

It was past noon. The London-made parlor clock on the mantelpiece — the clock Tschärner's father had brought from Worb in 1709 and that the elder Mary Baker had wound every Sunday morning of her keeping of the household at Lunenburg from 1742 to 1773, and that Sarah had wound every Sunday morning since they came down to Guilford in 1775 — read twenty-two minutes past twelve. The light at the south windows was the light of a frontier November noon, low and clear, with the leaves down and the field visible all the way to the cleared edge at the south.

Sarah said: *I sent the letter to Vincent on the third.*

She said it across the table to Joseph. The household waited.

Joseph said: *The post north.*

— The post north. To the regimental address I had from the May muster. I do not know if it has gone forward from Hillsborough.

— The carrier from Guilford went on the seventh. He went up with my October letter to Hillsborough and forward up the road. He would have had the third's mail.

— So the letter was on the carrier on the seventh.

— On the seventh.

— And the carrier south goes how far.

— The carrier I sent it with goes to Wilmington. From Wilmington it goes by the coast carrier south. The coast carrier was running steady in October. I do not know about November. The weather has been hard south of Wilmington this month.

Mary Baker said: *Wilmington is where the regiment was in October.*

— Wilmington was where the regiment was in October, said Joseph. They were moving south then. I do not know where they are now.

— South Carolina, said Tschärner. The papers at Hillsborough in October said the regiment was moving to South Carolina.

— South Carolina is where they are then, said Joseph. The coast carrier goes south of Wilmington to Charleston when it runs. It does not always run.

Sarah said: *So the letter may have gone, or it may not have gone, or it may be on the coast.*

- It may have gone, said Joseph. The carrier was steady on the seventh.
- That is what I wanted to know.
- Yes.
- Thank you, Joseph.
- Yes, Sarah.

The household ate the last of the apples. The Madeira jug was put down. The cider jug was put down. Sarah cleared the plates one at a time, taking them to the kitchen lean-to and setting them in the wash-tub there. She did not bring out a sweet. There had been no sweet planned. The Carolina ham and the corn-bread and the stewed apples were the meal.

The supper hour had been about an hour and twenty minutes. The clock read fourteen minutes before two.

Joseph said: *We must ride.*

Tscharner said: *Yes.*

The company began to rise. John and Elizabeth Johnson stood first. Gideon stood and helped Mary Baker out of her chair, in the careful way he had been taught at his uncle's house in Guilford. Sarah came back from the lean-to and stood at her chair.

Tscharner did not rise immediately. He sat at the head of the table for a moment with his hands flat on the linen cloth. Then he stood and went the four steps to the parlor desk where the Bible still lay open at the marriage entry.

He did not say anything when he stood at the desk. The household did not look at him directly. The four Johnsons were at their chairs near the foot of the table, gathering the things they had brought in with them — Elizabeth's travelling-bag with the gift inside, Joseph's hat from the floor by the chair, John's gloves from the table by the parlor door. Mary Baker was standing beside Gideon at the long side of the table. Sarah was at the kitchen door.

Tscharner read the marriage entry once through. He stood at the desk with his hand resting beside the open Bible and read what he had written an hour and forty minutes earlier in his own hand in French. The ink was dry. The page would take the closing without smudging.

He closed the Bible.

The leather case sat on the desk to the left of the closed Bible. He picked up the Bible — small and heavy, the way a keeping-Bible is — and slid it into the leather case the way the elder Mary Baker had shown him at Lunenburg in the second year of their marriage, when the Bible had not long before come to him from his father — the book his father had carried over from Worb and kept to his death — and she had said *We will have a case made* and had had a case made for it by a saddler in 1744. The Bible went into the case the way it had gone into the case the eighteen years previous times Tscharner had closed it after an entry.

He set the case on the desk.

He stood with his hand on the closed case for a moment. Then he took his hand off the case and turned to face the room.

The morning's record-keeping was complete.

The Afternoon and the Parlor Closing

The Bible was in its case on the desk. Tscharner had turned from the desk and was facing the room. The four Johnsons and Mary Baker and Gideon were standing near the foot end of the table. The clock at the parlor's north wall read fourteen minutes before two.

Joseph said the horses would need to be off the rail by half past, if the company were to make the inn before the light went.

Sarah said she would put up cold ham and corn-bread in a cloth for the saddle bags.

Mary Baker said she would get her things from the back bedroom.

She went through the parlor door and the hall and into the back bedroom. The small portmanteau Sarah had packed the day before was on the bed against the foot board. Two changes of linen, the wool shawl that had been her grandmother Mary Baker's and had come to her at eight years old, a comb, a needle case, a folded square of brown paper holding three sprigs of dried lavender from the Lunenburg October cutting of 1778, the small leather wallet Sarah had given her at her thirteenth birthday with three silver shillings in it, the second pair of stockings, the second pair of garters. Mary Baker did not open the portmanteau to check what was in it. She had watched Sarah pack it yesterday afternoon. She took the portmanteau by its leather handle and carried it back through the hall and into the parlor.

Gideon was at the parlor door holding his coat. He took the portmanteau from her hand. He carried it out to the front step.

Sarah came in from the lean-to with the cloth and the cold ham and the corn-bread and a small stoneware bottle of cider with a wooden stopper. She tied the cloth into a bundle at the four corners. She gave the bundle to Joseph. Joseph said he would carry it in his off saddle bag with the powder-flask.

John Johnson and Elizabeth went to the front step for their coats and their hats. Joseph went out after them to see to the horses at the rail. Gideon went out behind Joseph. The parlor was for a moment Sarah and Tscharner and Mary Baker.

Tscharner said: You will write us on the road.

Mary Baker said: I will write from Guilford.

Tscharner said: That will do.

He put his hand on her shoulder once. He took his hand off. He went out through the parlor door and through the hall and out to the front step to see to the standing of his guests at their horses.

Sarah and Mary Baker were alone in the parlor.

Sarah said: You have the wallet.

Mary Baker said: Yes.

Sarah said: Mind the second pair of stockings is the wool. The cotton is the first.

Mary Baker said: Yes.

Sarah said: I put the lavender in for the linen press at the Guilford house. Mind it does not crumble.

Mary Baker said: I will mind it.

Sarah said: Then go.

Mary Baker went the four steps to her mother and put her arms around her and held her. Sarah held her back. Neither of them said anything. After what may have been four seconds or six Mary Baker took her arms down and stepped back. Sarah's hand on her sleeve went down with her step and then off. Mary Baker turned and went through the parlor door and through the hall and out to the front step where Gideon and his father and his brother and his sister were standing at the horses and her grandfather was standing at the bottom of the step.

Sarah came out behind her and stood at the top of the step at her husband's place, which was where she stood when she saw company off. Tscharner moved one step to the side and Sarah stood beside him.

The horses were four. The Johnson grey for John. The Johnson chestnut for Joseph. The Johnson bay mare for Elizabeth, who rode well and had ridden up from Guilford on her own seat. The Johnson roan for Gideon and Mary Baker. Gideon would carry her on a pillion behind the cantle. The pillion was strapped. The portmanteau was lashed at the off side of the cantle. The cloth-bundle of ham and corn-bread was in Joseph's off saddle bag.

Gideon mounted. He turned the roan to bring its near side to the step. He held his hand down.

Mary Baker came down the step. She took her grandfather's hand at the bottom of the step. Tscharner held her hand for the count of two and put it down. She turned to her mother. Sarah came down the one step to the ground and put her hand on Mary Baker's cheek and said nothing. Mary Baker put her hand on Sarah's hand and said nothing. Sarah took her hand off. Mary Baker turned. She put her foot on Gideon's boot in the stirrup and her hand in his hand and her other hand on the pillion strap and was up behind him. She found her seat. She put her arms around his waist.

Gideon said to Sarah and Tscharner that he was much obliged for the day they had made.

Sarah said she was glad of the day, and that he was to take care of her daughter on the road.

Tscharner said the company would be at the inn well before the dark and that he wished them a good ride down.

Joseph said he thanked them for the hospitality of their house and that he would carry their compliments to his wife at Guilford.

Sarah said the compliments were to go to Mrs. Johnson with her own.

Elizabeth said she thanked Sarah for the day, and that the parlor had been a fine room for the morning.

Sarah said she was glad it had served.

John Johnson said he would write from Guilford when the company was in.

Tscharner said they would look for the letter.

The four horses turned and walked off the front yard onto the track. Joseph led. John behind him. Elizabeth behind John. Gideon and Mary Baker last. The track ran east along the cleared field to the head of the field and then south at the bend.

Sarah and Tscharner stood at the front step and watched the company down the track. The roan went at the back at a walk. Mary Baker did not turn in her seat to look back. She had said her goodbye at the step. The roan's tail swung once and again.

The company reached the bend at the head of the cleared field. The horses turned south. Joseph at the head of the file went out of sight behind the standing trees, and then John, and then Elizabeth, and then the roan with Gideon and Mary Baker on it. The tail of the roan was the last thing.

Sarah stood at the step for the count of perhaps ten after the last horse was out of sight.

Then she said: Well, Mr. DeGraffenreid.

Tscharner said: Well, Mrs. DeGraffenreid.

She turned and went up the step and into the house. Tscharner came in behind her and closed the front door.

The clock at the north wall read eight minutes past two.

Tscharner went the four steps to the parlor desk. The Bible in its leather case was on the cover where he had set it down. He stood at the desk for a moment with his hand on the edge of the desk. He sat down in the chair. He put his hand on the leather case. He took his hand off and put the pen back in the inkwell, which he had not put it in when he closed the case, and put the cap on the inkwell, and put the inkwell to the back of the desk where it lived between uses. He put the small flat of sand he had used at the entry to blot the ink to the right of the inkwell. He moved the candle two inches to the left of the case.

The desk was in its keeping.

He sat at the desk for some time with his hands on the cover at either side of the case.

Sarah was at the parlor table.

She lifted the silver-edged dish that had held the stewed apples and carried it to the lean-to. She came back. She lifted the platter that had held the ham and carried it to the lean-to. She came back. She lifted the corn-bread board and carried it to the lean-to. She came back. She lifted the eight pewter plates two at a time and carried them to the lean-to. She came back the fourth time. The table was bare.

She went to the cedar chest at the parlor's south wall and lifted the lid and propped it on the hinge stop. The linen cloth from her own wedding was on the table. She went to the table and took the cloth up at the two corners nearest the parlor door and walked it back along the table folding it once at the half and once at the quarter. She brought the corners together and folded the cloth on itself. The cloth was a square the size of a folded apron. She carried it to the cedar chest and laid it on the linen at the bottom of the chest with the other things her mother had given her at the 1763 wedding, which had lived at the bottom of the chest between her own wedding and her daughter's. She closed the lid of the cedar chest.

She came back to the table.

The table was the heavy oak plank Tscharner had set up six feet on the trestle for the supper. She took the two halves apart at the joiner's pegs the way she and Mary Baker had set them in this morning, only in reverse. The west half she carried to the south wall and stood on its short legs against the wall where it lived between dinners. The east half she carried after it and set it against the west half at the joiner's pegs and slid the pegs home. She took the trestle apart at the cross-piece and stood the trestle in the corner by the cedar chest. The parlor floor where the table had been was the parlor floor.

She moved the six side chairs against the east and west walls in the places they lived between meals. The two arm chairs at the head and the foot she carried to the parlor's north end, the head chair to the right of the desk and the foot chair to the left.

The parlor was the parlor it was on an ordinary afternoon.

She went to the hearth.

The fire she had built up at half past four that morning had run down through the morning and the supper and the early afternoon and was a good red bed of coals under a low flame. She took the poker from the hook beside the hearth and raked the coals to the back of the firebox. She took the small shovel and lifted ash from the front of the hearth and banked it over the front of the coal bed in a half-moon, leaving the back coals open to the chimney for the draw and the front coals banked under the ash for the slow burn through the night. The flame went down. The light in the parlor went down with it. She put the poker back on the hook. She put the shovel back on the hook.

She stood at the hearth.

The clock at the north wall read twenty-two minutes past four.

The light at the west window was the late light of a November afternoon at the latitude of the Dan River. The light at the east window had gone. Sarah went to the east window and pulled the inside shutters to and put the bar across. She went to the west window and stood for a moment at the sill and watched the last of the light go down behind the standing trees at the head of the cleared field. The track was empty. The company would be at the inn by now or close to it. She pulled the inside shutters to and put the bar across.

The parlor was in the half-light from the hearth.

She went to the parlor door and stood at the door. Tscharner was at the desk with his hands on the cover of the case. He had not moved in the time she had been working. He turned his head.

She said: I am going up.

He said: I will come up in a little.

She said: There is bread and the cold ham in the lean-to if you want it.

He said: I am not hungry yet.

She said: Then I will go up.

He said: Goodnight, Sarah.

She said: Goodnight, Mr. DeGraffenreid.

She went out through the parlor door and up the stair.

Tscharner sat at the desk with his hands on the cover of the case for a time he did not count.

The fire at the hearth made the small sound a banked fire makes through ash.

At length he took his hands off the case and stood up from the chair. He went the four steps to the hearth and stood at the hearth and looked down at the banked coals. He took the candle from the desk and lit it at the back coals where the bed was still open to the chimney. He carried the candle to the parlor desk and set it down beside the case. He sat down in the chair.

He took up the pen. He uncapped the inkwell. He dipped the pen. He did not open the case.

On a small sheet of foolscap he kept in the right drawer for daily entries he wrote the date — *Thursday 18 November 1779* — and below it, in the plain hand he used for the household ledger and for the day-book of the magistrate's docket, *Mary Baker DeGraffenreid married Gideon Johnson Jr. at this house this morning at ten o'clock. The Reverend Mr. Whitaker of the Dan River Baptist congregation officiating. Witnesses Joseph and John and Elizabeth Johnson and Sarah Vass DeGraffenreid and the undersigned. Mary Baker and Gideon Johnson Jr. departed this house at two o'clock for the inn at the south end of the cleared field. Joseph John and Elizabeth Johnson departed with them. The day was clear and the road was good.*

He signed it *Tscharner DeGraffenreid* in the hand he used for the magistrate's docket.

He blotted the sheet on the flat of sand. He put the sheet in the right drawer of the desk on top of the household papers. He capped the inkwell. He put the pen back in the holder.

He sat with his hand on the cover of the case.

The candle burned at the desk. The fire made its sound at the hearth.

After some time he stood up from the chair. He took the candle from the desk in his right hand. He put his left hand on the cover of the leather case for the count of one and took it off.

He went out of the parlor with the candle.

The parlor was empty. The case was on the desk where he had left it. The fire was banked. The shutters were across. The clock at the north wall read seven minutes before five.

The light in the parlor was the light from the banked fire.

Chapter 5 — Vincent's War

Stony Point, the Fifteenth of July

The Hudson River, the night of 15-16 July 1779

The order had come down the line in a whisper an hour after dark, passed man to man the way a thing is passed when no one is permitted to say it above the level of breath, and the order was that there would be no firing. The flints were already out. They had come out at the supper of the day before, drawn from the locks and dropped into the cartridge-boxes where they sat now against the paper of the cartridges no one would load, and a musket without its flint was a thing that could be carried and could be leveled and could not be made to go off by a frightened hand in the dark, which was the whole of the reason the flints were out. The muskets were carrying the bayonets and nothing else. Vincent had fixed his at the halt, in the last grey of the light, seating the ring over the muzzle and turning it down onto the stud the way he had done it five hundred times at the drill and a dozen times in the line, and the bayonet had gone on the way it always went on, and his hand had not shaken, and he had noted that his hand had not shaken the way a man notes the weather.

He was sixteen years old. He had been in the Line two years and a half. He was a good way down a column of men he could not see, in a country he could not see, on the west bank of a river he could hear moving somewhere below and to his right, and he was waiting, which was the thing the body learned first and learned hardest and was, by the second summer, the thing it did best.

The waiting had a shape he knew. The afternoon march was in his legs as a kind of standing soreness, the long looping approach through the back country above the bluff that had taken the corps off the road and through the marsh-edge and the laurel so that no farmer's dog and no Tory's boy would carry the word down to the river that the light infantry of General Wayne was moving toward the point. The column had halted at the full dark. It had been ordered to lie down, and the men near him had lain down in the wet, and Vincent had lain down with them in the place that was his place, between a Pennsylvania man named Doyle whom he did not much know and a sergeant from the Virginia detachment named Cole whom he knew well enough, and he had put his cheek against the stock of the empty musket and had felt the cold come up out of the ground into the bone of his hip and his shoulder, and he had waited.

It had rained earlier and would not rain again. The ground held the rain. The marsh below the bluff held a great deal more than the rain; the point was nearly an island at the high water, with the river around three sides of it and a flooded morass across the neck, and the corps would have to go through the morass to reach the abatis, and the men in the front of the columns had been told what the water would be and had been told to go through it and not to stop in it and not to call out in it whatever the water did to them. Vincent was not in the front of the

column. He had counted, lying in the dark, the men he thought were ahead of him, and had made it something past forty, and had stopped counting, because the count past forty did not change the thing the count was for. The thing the count was for was to know how long he would stand at the edge of the morass before it was his turn to go into it, and forty men going through a flooded neck in the dark was a length of time the body could hold against without the mind having to do anything about it.

He had a square of white paper pinned to the front of his hat. Every man in the corps had one. It was so that in the dark, when the thing began, a man would know the back of the man in front of him for his own and not put the bayonet into him, and it was a poor enough mark — a paper would not show at four feet on a night with no moon — but it was the mark they had, and Vincent had pinned his with the care a man gives to the one small thing he is given to do with his hands while the large thing waits, and had thought, pinning it, that his sister Polly would have made a neater job of the pin.

The thought of his sister came and went the way the cold came and went, around the edges and not at the center. He let it go. There was a discipline to the letting-go that he had also learned in the first year and that he was good at now: a man in the line learned to hold the near thing and let the far thing pass, because the far thing — the house, the people in it, the road home — was the thing that took the steadiness out of the hands, and the hands were what the night was going to want. He held the near thing. The near thing was the cold and the paper and the count past forty and the empty musket and the bayonet on the end of it and the dark.

What he knew of the night he knew the way the men knew it, which was the way it had come down to them at the briefing in the late afternoon at the assembly ground above Sandy Beach, where General Wayne had set it out to the officers and the officers had set it out to the men, plainly, because Wayne was a plain man with the men and because a man who is about to be sent at a fortified point in the dark with an empty musket is owed the plain shape of the thing. The shape of the thing was this. Stony Point was a bluff of rock that stood up out of the river on the west bank above the King's Ferry crossing, and the King's Ferry crossing was the lower of the two crossings of the Hudson that the country between the northern army and the southern army turned on, and the British had taken the point at the end of May and had fortified it across June with a garrison of six hundred and some, with the works set in two lines up the slope and the abatis below the works, the felled trees with their cut ends turned out and sharpened, and the guns laid to sweep the neck and the approaches. The British thought the point could not be carried. The point could not be carried in the ordinary way. The ordinary way was the cannon and the column and the firing and the smoke, and the British above on the rock had more guns than the corps below in the marsh and the rock under them besides, and an ordinary attack up that slope would leave the corps in pieces at the foot of the abatis.

So it would not be the ordinary way. It would be the bayonet only, in the silence, in the dark, at the midnight, with the muskets empty so that no man's fear could break the silence by firing, and the corps would go through the morass and through the cut places in the abatis that the axe-men would open ahead of them, and would go up the slope into the works with the steel and nothing else, and the British above would not know the corps was on them until the corps was on them. The two real columns would go at the two flanks, the one Vincent was in along the south face and the river, the other along the north, and a third party at the center would make a show with the muskets it was permitted to load — would fire, and shout, and draw the British eyes and the British guns to the center while the two silent columns came up the flanks — and the men of the two silent columns were not to fire whatever happened, and the order on that was Wayne's own and was not a thing a man wondered about twice: any man who fired, or who fell out of the rank, or who called out, in the silent columns, was to be put down by the officer nearest him. Vincent had heard the order at second hand from Cole and had received it the way he received the weather and the count past forty. It was a hard order. It was the order that made the thing possible. A boy of fourteen would have turned it over in the dark and frightened himself with it. Vincent was not fourteen. He turned it over once, found the bottom of it — the silence is the whole attack; break the silence and you have killed the men beside you, not only yourself — and set it down.

Ahead of the two columns went the forlorn hope. Twenty men to a column, chosen, who would go first into the abatis with the axes and open the way for the rest, and who would take, by the plain arithmetic of going first against a fortified slope, the most of what the slope had to give. The men called it the forlorn hope because that was its name and had been its name in the armies of Europe for two hundred years, and the name was not a soldier's grim joke but a plain old description that had hardened into a term, and the men of the forlorn hope at Stony Point had been asked for by Wayne and had stepped forward and been chosen and were, this night, somewhere up at the head of the two columns in the dark, lying in the wet as Vincent lay, with their axes, waiting as Vincent waited, and the difference between them and Vincent was a count of perhaps thirty men and the order in which they would go into the water. Vincent had thought, when the corps was told of the forlorn hope at the briefing, that he was glad he had not stepped forward, and had then thought that he had not stepped forward because no one in his part of the line had stepped forward and a man does not step forward alone, and had then stopped the thinking there, because the bottom of that one was not a place a man wanted to stand on the night before the thing.

The river moved below. Somewhere across the dark to the south a watch-fire of the British showed and was gone behind the shoulder of the bluff and showed again, small and orange and very far, and a man could not have said from the look of it that there were six hundred men around it who did not know that the marsh below them was full of the light infantry of the Continental Line lying in the wet

with the steel fixed and the flints out. The British did not know. That was the whole of the night. The British above had the rock and the guns and the works and the six hundred men and did not have the one thing the corps below had, which was that the corps knew the night was the attack and the British thought the night was a night. Vincent lay in the wet and held the cold and the count and the paper and the dark and waited for the hour, and the hour had not come.

It was in the holding, with the hour not come, that the far thing came around the edge again, and this time he did not entirely let it go, because there was a long stretch of the night still to hold and the mind in the holding will go where it goes and a man learns which goings cost him and which do not, and the going he allowed himself, the going that did not take the steadiness out of the hands, was the going-back. Not the house. The house was the thing that cost. The road to the house — that he could hold and turn, the way a man turns a coin in his pocket in the dark, for the small dumb comfort of the shape of it. He let himself go back along the road. He had come a long way to lie in this marsh. He had come from a county on the Meherrin in the southside of Virginia where his grandfather sat at a long table in a kitchen and read the news of the war aloud in the lamplight to a household that had become, across the four years Vincent had been gone, a household of women — his mother, who did the accounts of a widowhood she had not yet been permitted by the law to call by its name; his sister Polly, who had been a girl of eleven at the long table the August his grandfather read the Declaration aloud and would be a girl of fourteen now, this July, doing he did not know what at the long table in the lamplight; the women, and his grandfather, and the empty place at the table where his father had sat before his father rode south across the Dan in the autumn of 1775 and did not come back across it.

He had been thirteen at the long table the day the Declaration was read. He had turned fourteen at the Christmas after, against a door-jamb in the parlor with a pencil-mark, and in the January he had gone for a soldier in another man's place, and he had not, in the two years and a half since, stood in his grandfather's kitchen or seen his sister's face or heard the news read aloud at the long table; he had been the news. The letters his mother had down at White Plains and Middlebrook and the camps were his, and the news his grandfather read aloud in the lamplight at the long table was, some of it, by now, the news of where Vincent was. He turned that over once in the dark — that he was, this summer, a thing read aloud in his grandfather's kitchen — and found it strange and did not find the bottom of it, and let it go back into the dark with the rest of the road, because the count of the men ahead of him had not changed and the hour had not come and the muskets were empty and the night, which was the whole of the attack, was still a night the British above did not know they were inside of.

He lay still and held it. The river moved. The far watch-fire showed and was gone and showed. Somewhere up at the head of the column, ahead of the forty and ahead of the forlorn hope, the hour was coming on, and when it came it would come down the lying column the way the order had come down it, man to man,

below the level of breath, and the men would get up out of the wet without a word and go down into the morass toward the abatis and the rock and the works and the six hundred men who did not know, and the steadiness the body had been keeping in the hands all the long cold holding of the night would be, in that hour, the only thing in the dark that was Vincent's to give. He had it still. He checked it the way he had checked the bayonet, once, without moving — opened and closed the hand on the cold stock and found it steady — and put his cheek back against the empty musket, and waited for the hour, which had not yet come.

January 1777, the Enlistment

Lunenburg County, Virginia, the January of 1777

The road home ran two ways, and the way it ran when he let it run was backward. He had come down it to lie in this marsh, and the coming-down had taken three years and been no road at all but a long unwinding of country he could not have drawn on a paper, north and east by the camps and the crossings and the winter quarters, so that the going-out was a thing too long and too tangled to hold in the dark with the hour not come. But the going-back was short. A man could turn the road the other way, the way a road runs clean when no one is on it, and the turning of it took him off the bank of the Hudson and out of the wet and set him down, between one breath and the next, at a long table in a kitchen on the Meherrin in the January he had gone.

He had been thirteen for most of the year of the deciding and fourteen for three weeks of the going. The record, when there came to be a record, would say fourteen, and the record would be right the way records are right, which is to say it would have the number and not the thing the number stood on. The thing the number stood on was a boy at the long table in the autumn before, listening to the old man read.

His grandfather read the news the way he read everything, which was aloud, in the lamplight, after the supper things were down and the fire built up, with the women at the table and the paper held out at the length of his arm because he would not own to needing it closer. What he read that autumn was the war coming apart. Vincent had not understood it as that at thirteen, sitting at the table; he understood it now, lying in the marsh, the way a man understands a thing once he has been inside the middle of it, but the words he had taken in at thirteen were the same words, and they came back to him in the old man's voice. The army that had been around New York in the summer had been driven off the island and out of the works above it and down through the Jerseys toward the Delaware in the autumn, losing a fort and the men in it on the way, and the men that were left were men whose time was up at the turn of the year, every one of them, by the arithmetic of how they had been signed in '75 and '76; and Congress had called for a new army on a new term, three years of it, or the length of the war, whichever was the longer, because a war could not be fought by men who

went home at Christmas. That was the shape of it as it came down the post-road to the long table on the Meherrin and was read aloud in the lamplight. The country needed men who would sign for the long thing. And then, late, in a paper that came after the turn of the year and was read with the same flat care as the rest, there had been the first word of something at a river-town in the Jerseys at the very end of December — a crossing in the dark, a garrison taken, prisoners marched off — and the old man had read it twice, the second time slower, and had not said anything about it, and the not-saying had been the loudest thing the old man did all that winter.

Vincent had heard all of it the way a boy hears the weather of a country he has not yet been sent into. He had not, at thirteen, joined the war in the head to the war on the paper. The war on the paper was the thing the old man read. The war in the head was the empty place at the long table.

The place was his father's. Baker DeGraffenreid had ridden south across the Dan in the autumn of 1775, in the first of it, when the going-out was a thing men did with their faces still on them, and he had not come back across the Dan, and no word of him had come back across it either. There was no letter. There was no return. There was no man come up the lane in the dusk to say where he was buried, because no one knew that he was buried, or that he was not; there was only the not-knowing, which was a thing that took a place at the table and sat in it. His mother kept the place. She kept it the way she kept the accounts of the farm in the long ledger after the supper things were down — Sarah Vass DeGraffenreid, who did the figuring of a widowhood the law had not yet permitted her to call by its name, because to call it that she would have had to swear to a death she could not swear to, having no body and no grave and no word to swear it on. She kept the accounts in the lamplight at the far end of the table from the old man, and the figures came out the way figures come out for a place with one fewer hand than it was built for and no man's wage coming in, which is to say they came out short, and she made them come out at all by the only arithmetic a short place has, which is to do the thing herself or have it done by the hands she had. The hands she had were Phillis's. Phillis was in the kitchen all the hours the family was, banking the fire and bringing the things and taking them down, owned by the place and doing the work of it, and the work of the place that winter was the work of a widowhood that had no man and could not yet be called a widowhood, and that work went through Phillis's hands as much as through the mother's, and more.

His sister Polly was twelve. She sat at the table between the old man's reading and the mother's figuring, and she was the only one of them who was still a child in the plain way of it, and she did her reckoning out loud sometimes, the way a child does, working the war out into who was where and who would come home, and the old man let her do it and the mother let her do it and Vincent had let her do it, and only afterward, in the marsh, did he come to think that they had

all of them let her do it because she was saying out loud the one question none of the grown ones in the kitchen would say, which was *and Papa?*

That was the kitchen the boy had decided in. He had not decided it out loud. The deciding had been a thing that came up in him across the autumn the way the cold came up out of the ground into the bone, slow, and not announcing itself, and by the turn of the year it was in him to the depth that a thing is in a man when the only deciding left is the saying of it, the body having decided already and the saying being the part the head does last. He knew now, lying in the marsh, that this was how it had gone, because he had since watched it go that way in himself a dozen times in the line, the body knowing the thing and the head coming up after to put its name to what was done. At thirteen he had not known that yet. At thirteen he had only known that he was going, and had been a little frightened of how plainly he knew it.

The way of it was the substitute. He was too young for the draft and too short for the standard and there was no call that could have taken him in his own person; what there was, was a man of the county with a place to fill in the levy and the means to fill it with another's body in place of his own, and the place came with money, and the money was a thing the short accounts at the far end of the table needed, and the body that could earn it was the one body in the house with years in front of it and no wage on it yet. Vincent had put the two things together in the autumn — the place that wanted a body, the house that wanted the money the place paid — and had seen that he was the join of them, and had carried the seeing around in himself for a month before he took it to the old man, because he had known that the old man was the one it had to be taken to.

It had to be taken to the old man because the old man kept the Bible. That was the thing about the old man that the boy had understood without being told. Anton Tscharner DeGraffenreid had kept the Book since it came to him a generation back, and into the Book went the births and the marriages and the deaths of the line in his own hand, and the place his father had left empty at the table was empty in the Book too, with no date after the dash that the boy had seen the old man not write, more than once, the pen down and the line open and the old man looking at it. A man who kept the Book was a man who knew the difference between a thing recorded and a thing not, and what the not did to a house, and the boy who wanted to go for a soldier was going to be, the moment he went, another open line in the Book, another dash with nothing after it, and he had known it had to be the old man's to say.

The old man heard him out at the long table after the women were up and gone to the back of the house, and did not say anything for a while, and then did the thing the boy had not looked for, which was that he read aloud again. He had the recruiting standard somewhere among his papers, the height a man was to make to be taken, and he found it and read it out in the same flat care he read the news in, the number of feet and inches a soldier of the Continental establishment was supposed to stand, and then he put the paper down and looked at the boy and

said that by the standard he read the boy was no soldier, being short of the number and short of the years besides, and that the standard was the law's own measure and the law's own measure said no.

Then he got up, and took the boy by the shoulder, and walked him into the parlor to the door-jamb where the marks were, and stood him against it. There was a mark there three weeks old, the pencil line of the Christmas just past, where the boy had turned fourteen and been measured against the jamb in the old way of the house. The old man laid his hand flat on the boy's head and made a new mark above it and stepped back and looked, and the new mark and the standard he had read were not the same, the boy being under it by something a hand could span, and the old man saw it and the boy saw him see it, and the old man said that the table that took men did not, in a hard winter with the army falling in, hold a substitute to the standard it held a volunteer, a substitute coming with a place already bought and a man's money already laid down, and that the recruiter would take him, short as he was, because the recruiter wanted the body and the body would stand the term.

So the no was real and the yes came after it, and the yes came with the one thing the old man would lay on it. He laid it standing in the parlor with his hand still on the boy's shoulder, and he laid it plainly, the way Wayne would lay the order at Sandy Beach two years and a half on, because a man being sent into a thing is owed the plain shape of what is asked of him. The thing he asked was that the boy would write. He would write when he could and send what he wrote by whatever hand was going, and he would write even when there was nothing to write, a line, the date and the place and the words *I am well*, so that the Book would never have to carry an open line in his name the way it carried one in his father's. He had buried no one and could close no entry, the old man said, and he would not put a second son of the house into the same dark his first was in, the dark of a man you cannot grieve because you cannot say he is dead and cannot hope because you cannot say he is living; and the price of the blessing was that the boy would not become that. Write, he said, and I will know where you are, and if it comes that I have to write the date after the dash, I will be able to write it, and that is a mercy you do not understand yet and will. Then he took his hand off the boy's shoulder and gave him the blessing, and the blessing was the old word for it and was said the old way and is not the boy's to set down here in the marsh, and it was given.

The going-out, when it came in the cold of the morning, was a short thing and the boy had wanted it short. He had his father's coat taken in at the shoulders by Phillis's needle and the mother's, and a few days' bread, and the bundle was light because there was little to put in it, and the women came to the door with him and the old man came to the door. Polly cried and was angry at herself for it. The mother did not cry. The mother put her hands to his face once, the way she did the figures, taking the measure of a thing she would have to do without, and then she let him go and stepped back to where Phillis stood, and the two of them stood in

the doorway with the heat of the kitchen behind them going out into the cold, and the old man lifted his hand, and Vincent went down the lane.

He did not stop at the turn of the lane and he did not look back from it, because he had decided in the autumn that he would not, having seen that the looking-back was the thing that took the steadiness out of a man and that the steadiness was the thing the going wanted, and so he kept his eyes on the road and walked it, and the house went behind him without his watching it go, and that was how he left it. The lane gave onto the county road and the county road ran north, and the cold was in the ruts as ice and the breath stood out in front of him, and he walked into the morning a boy too short for the standard, fourteen by the record and thirteen by the deciding, with his father's coat on his back and the old man's one condition laid on him, going for a soldier in another man's place.

He had kept the condition. He thought of that, in the marsh, with the hour not come. The letters his mother had down at the camps were the keeping of it — the lines that said *I am well* on the days there was nothing else, the date and the place, so that the old man at the long table could lay his finger on where the second son of the house was and not be in the dark of the first. He had kept it for two years and a half and would keep it as long as there was a hand going and a thing to write with, and the keeping of it was the one piece of the house he had carried the whole way down the road and into the wet, the one piece that did not cost him the steadiness in the hands to hold. He held it now. Then he turned the road forward again, off the Meherrin and back along the long unwinding of it to the bank where he lay, and put his cheek to the cold stock, and counted again the men ahead of him in the dark, and waited for the hour, which had not yet come.

September 1777, Brandywine

Chester County, Pennsylvania, the eleventh of September 1777

The morning came up grey and slow over the country east of the creek, and the army was already on the ground when the light was, posted along the line of the Brandywine on the high east bank above the fords, and Vincent was with his part of the Virginia detachment in the second line above Chads Ford in the middle of the position, in the trees on a slope that looked west and a little south to where the creek ran. He had been up since two hours before the light. He had eaten what there was. He had checked the lock and the flint and the cartridge-box twice, the second time without knowing he was doing it the second time, and had caught himself at it and had stopped, because the men around him had laughed at it, and the laughing of men in the morning before the thing was a kind of news a boy was supposed to take.

He was fourteen. He had been in the Line eight months. The men in his part of the line had taken his measure across the winter quarters and across the spring marches and across the summer of small affairs north of the Delaware, and had taken it kindly enough, because he made no trouble at the drill and made no

trouble at the watch and made no trouble in the column, and because his grandfather had laid the one condition on him and the condition had given him a thing to do at the close of every day that the older men, who had no one writing for them, watched him do without remarking on it. He wrote his line. He had written it that morning, before the light, on a scrap kept folded in his cartridge-box for the purpose. *The 11th of September. Along a creek in Pennsylvania called the Brandywine. I am well.* That was the keeping the old man had asked. He had not yet had to write a date that meant a thing the old man would have to read twice.

The cannon began at Chads Ford a little after the light. They were the British cannon. They came from the woods on the far bank of the creek, the smoke showing first and the sound coming after the way it does at any distance over water, and the sound was steady and not heavy, the way cannon sound when they are at work but are not yet the work, and the men along the line above the ford got up off the ground without being told and stood to. Vincent stood to. He had stood to before. He had stood to at White Plains in the column on the road and at Princeton at the edge of an action that the army had gone past him before he had reached it, and he had stood to twice in the spring at the affairs north of the Delaware. He had not yet stood to at the day's beginning of a general action with the army drawn up on a posted line and the enemy across the water in the woods. He found that the standing-to was not so different in the body from the standing-to at any of the smaller things. The body did the standing. The head did what it could.

The cannon kept on across the morning. They did not come closer and they did not slacken, and the British across the creek made a show with the muskets at the ford that did not become an attempt at it and did not go away, and the line above the ford stood and watched and did not fire because the order had been not to fire until the British were across, and the British did not come across. Vincent stood in his place between the same two men he had lain down beside on the long approach into the country two days before, an older Virginia man named Wills and a younger one named Banks, and watched the smoke at the ford and tried to read the morning the way the men around him were trying to read it.

The reading of it was hard. The cannon at the ford were not the morning. The morning was somewhere else. He understood that now, lying in the marsh, the way he understood every morning of his war he had not understood at the time — that a general action begins long before the soldier in the second line hears it begin, that the day's true thing is happening, by the time he is permitted to know of it, an hour off across country he cannot see, and that the work in front of him is a kind of work the country does to him before it lets him do any of his own. At fourteen he had not seen it as that. At fourteen he had seen only that the cannon were at the ford and were not coming closer and the line stood and the line did not fire, and that the morning was a morning that did not become an afternoon the way the morning before a thing was supposed to become its afternoon. The

morning kept on. The cannon kept on. He kept his place between Wills and Banks, and the standing-soreness came back in his legs the way it always came back, and the men around him said little, and the little they said was the small currency of standing in a line on a hot morning — water, the heat, the cannon's count, whether the British meant to come and whether they did not.

It was past the middle of the day when the word began to come up from somewhere on the right. The right was off to the north of where they stood and was the country above the upper fords, where the creek ran into the high broken land and the fords were thinner and farther apart, and the word that came was that there was a column on the right that should not have been there. The word came down the line the way news comes down a line of men, in pieces from the man two places up and then in pieces from the officer who had gone forward and come back, and the pieces did not all fit, and the men with the pieces stopped passing them on when the pieces became unfit. What the pieces said, as best as Vincent could make of it, was that the cannon at Chads Ford were not the British army; the British army was somewhere to the north and had gone around the upper fork of the creek in the night and the morning, and was coming down on the right of the line from the country behind it, and the line at the ford was going to have to face that way, and the second line in the trees, of which Vincent was a part, was going to have to march to it.

It was inside the word — inside the standing-to in the trees with the noon past and the word still unfit — that the thing his grandfather had named at the long table came up in him for the first time as a thing of his own. *The country needs men who will sign for the long thing*, the old man had read out of a paper in January. The country was needing the men, this hot afternoon, to march to the right of a line that should not have had to be a line on the right, and the men were going to do it because the men had signed for it, and the boy in the second line who had been the youngest in his part of the column for eight months found that his hands had stopped wanting to do the small things they had been doing to keep themselves at the work — the second check of the flint, the rolling of the cartridge-paper between the fingers — and were doing nothing at all, and that the doing of nothing was a thing he had not seen them do before. He looked at the right hand once. It was open at his side. It was not shaking. He put it back to the musket and found the wood under it and held it, and the holding was a thing he had to make the hand do, and the having to make the hand do it was the news of the afternoon.

The march to the right began past two, by what men afterward said. Vincent did not look at the sun. The column went off to the north on a road and then off a road into the woods, the country broken and full of low stone walls and snake-fences and second-growth woods that had been pasture inside a man's memory, and the going was hot and went fast where the ground let it go fast and slow where it would not, and the men in the column did not talk because the going was hard enough without it. Officers came up the column on horses and went down it

and came up again, their faces wet, and the men in front of Vincent kept their place and Vincent kept his, and the country opened ahead of him and closed behind him without his looking at any of it the way a man looks at country he is going to come back through.

They came up to the ground at Birmingham Meeting House in the late afternoon. The meeting house stood on a slight rise in an open field, a plain stone building with the burying-ground walled around it in low fieldstone, and the line was forming in front of it on the rise looking north and east, the first of the men already in position and the rest coming up at the run, and across the open field at perhaps three hundred yards the British were already in the field, in lines, with their cannon up, and the field between the two armies was the kind of open ground that had not been chosen by either side for the fighting of a battle but was the ground both sides had reached at the same hour and would have to use. Vincent's part of the detachment came up at the run with the rest, and the line was found and the place in the line was found, and the order was given to halt and to face front and to load.

The loading he knew. He had loaded a thousand times at the drill. He loaded now. He bit the cartridge and his teeth went through the paper at the place his teeth had gone through it a thousand times, and the powder went down the barrel and the ball after it and the paper after the ball, and the ramrod came out and went down and seated the load and came back up and went home in the pipes, and the lock was set to half-cock and the priming powder went into the pan and the frizzen was closed, and the musket was loaded, and he had not seen any of this happen because the seeing of it was not the part of him that did it. The hands did it. The hands had done it a thousand times at the drill so that they would do it at this hour without the head, because the head, at this hour, was a head that had stopped being able to be relied on for anything but the holding of the shape of the line, and the hands had been trained for exactly the reason the head had been trained otherwise. The hands did the loading. The head held the place in the rank.

The British line at three hundred yards fired its first volley before the American line was entirely formed. The volley came across the field as one long unbroken rolling sound that was not separable into the firing of muskets at all but was a kind of pressure across the air, and behind it the smoke rose and stood and did not move, because there was no wind that afternoon, and through the smoke the British line was a thing not entirely there, and the balls came through the field on a low flat path that took the heads off the grass and knocked the bark off two of the small trees behind the American line and went into the men in the line ahead of Vincent's the way a man's fist goes into wet ground, and the line ahead of Vincent's gave back a sound that was not one sound but several sounds of men hit and going down, and then the order came down the line that Vincent's was to fire.

He fired. He brought the musket up the way he had brought it up at the drill, and he found the British line through the front sight, and he pulled, and the lock went off in his face and the powder in the pan flashed and the priming went, and

the main charge let go and the musket drove back into his shoulder the way it always drove back into his shoulder at the drill, and the smoke came out of the muzzle and stood in front of him and was added to the smoke that was already standing across the line, and he did not know if the ball had gone where he had pointed it or anywhere near it, and he understood, in the same instant, that no man in any of the lines knew where his ball had gone, because the smoke was the thing now and the lines were the things behind the smoke, and a man fired into the smoke at the line he could not see and trusted that the line he could not see was where it had been the moment before and would not have moved very far in the time it took the ball to cross to it. The drill was the firing into the smoke at the place the line had been. The drill was the standing in the line on his own side of the smoke while the other line did the same.

He loaded again. The hands did it. He stood and the line stood and the men beside him stood, Wills to his right and Banks to his left, and the British line fired the second volley and the American line fired back, and the smoke thickened until it was a wall and the wall did not break, and the firing was not separable any longer into volleys but became one continuous thing the line had to stand inside of, and the men ahead and around began to go down in a way that was not one or two at a time but in groups of three and four, and the standing was the thing the line was for, and the line stood.

He understood it now, lying in the marsh — what the drill had been for, what the men who had drilled them in the winter quarters at Morristown had been doing when they had walked the rank and shouted and corrected and made the boys load and load and load until the boys could load with the eyes shut. The drill had been for this. The drill had been so that a fourteen-year-old in a line at three hundred yards from another line could load and fire and load and fire while the men beside him were hit, without thinking and without choosing, because the thinking and the choosing were the parts of a man that the noise and the smoke and the men going down took first, and the loading and the firing were the only parts of a man the country had left for itself, and the country wanted them, and the drill was the country's hand on the boy's hand making sure the country would have them when it needed them. At fourteen he had not seen the drill as anything but the long unpleasantness of the winter mornings. At sixteen, in the marsh, with the hour not come, he saw that the drill was the deepest mercy the army had given him, and that the men who had drilled him had known it, and had not said so, because the saying was not a part of what would help.

The line stood for an hour the way the line was meant to stand, and then it began to give. The giving did not come from the men around Vincent. The giving came from somewhere off to the right, the way the morning's word had come from the right, and the right of the line gave first and the rest came after, and the order to fall back came down the line in pieces the way the morning's word had come down, and the falling-back was a thing done at the walk because the falling-back at the run was a thing that turned into a rout and the officers along the line

knew it and were saying it as they came up and down, *at the walk, at the walk, by God at the walk*, and the line went back from the field at the walk with the British line coming on behind it across the open ground.

Wills was hit going back. The ball went into him low on the back, below the cartridge-box, and he made a sound that was not a word and went down on one knee and then onto his hands, and Vincent stopped, and Banks stopped, and the two of them got him up between them and got his musket up too and went back with him hanging between them at the walk because the walk was the order. They went perhaps a hundred yards. Wills could carry some of his own weight on the right leg and could not on the left, and the going was slow, and the line above and below them was moving back at the same walk, and the British were coming on across the field but did not press the falling-back as hard as they might have, because the British, having come fifteen miles around the upper fork in the dark and the heat and into the line on the run, were as used up as the men they had broken, and the day was going. They got Wills as far as a stone wall and a Continental surgeon was at the wall with his sleeves up and his hands red to the elbow and a great many men around him on the ground, and they put Wills down with the surgeon's men and were told to go on, and they went on. Banks said one thing to Vincent on the walk back from the wall, which was *we did all right*, and Vincent did not answer because the answer would have been the wrong size for the question and he did not yet know what the right size was.

The dusk came down on the road to Chester. The road was full of men going east. The army had not broken; the army was going east in pieces but as itself, and the officers were finding their men along the road and the men were finding their officers, and the country to either side of the road was full of country the army did not know, and the night came on with the men still walking east, and Vincent walked. He walked because Banks walked beside him and because the men ahead of him walked, and the keeping of the place in the column was the thing the day had been for in the end, the same as the keeping of the place in the line, and his hands had finally stopped doing the small things and his head had come back into the front of him a little, and what was in the head was not anything he could have set down on paper for the old man at the long table — not that night, on the road to Chester, and not the next morning, when there would have to be a line written. The line, when he wrote it, said only the date and the place, *the 12th of September, near Chester*, and the words. *I am well*. He wrote it by a fire on the ground at three in the morning, with his right hand which would shake now when he asked it to do anything that asked the hand to be steady, and he wrote it in a hand that came out shakier than it had been the morning before, and he watched the hand as he wrote it, and let the hand be what it was, and let the line be the line, and did not write anything more, because the more was not a thing the old man at the long table needed to read and was not a thing the boy at the fire could yet have said.

The marsh came back around him then — the cold of the ground at the Hudson against the heat of the road to Chester, the empty musket against the loaded one, the silence against the noise — and the count of the men ahead of him in the dark started again from where it had stopped, and the hour at Stony Point had not yet come, and the hand at his side, when he checked it, was steady, the way the hand at Brandywine had not been steady, the way the drill at Morristown had meant for it to be at the next thing and the next.

Stony Point, the Assault

The Hudson River, the night of 15–16 July 1779 (continued)

The hour came down the column the way the order had come down it, man to man below the level of breath, and the men got up out of the wet without a word. Vincent got up with them. The cold had gone into the bone of his hip and the bone of his shoulder during the long lying, and the getting up was a thing the body had to be told twice to do at the first asking, and the body did it, and the head took note that the body had done it and put the note down somewhere and gave the body the next thing. The next thing was the place in the rank. He found the place. Doyle was ahead of him to the right and Cole was behind him at his left shoulder where Cole had been all the long lying, and the rank closed up in the dark by the touch and not by the eye, the elbow at the next man's elbow and the next man at his elbow, and the column was a column again in the dark without anyone having said a word to make it one.

The river still moved below. The watch-fire on the far bluff still showed and was gone behind the shoulder of the bluff and showed. The far watch-fire had not changed at all in the last hour and a half, which was the whole of the night's news: the British above had not learned anything since the order had come down the corps to get up.

The forlorn hope was already moving. He could not see them. He knew they were moving by the small dense sound of the men ahead going forward through the wet, the sound a column makes when it is not in step and is not allowed to be in step, the small wet sounds of boot-leather lifting and going down again, the small soft sounds of cloth on the laurel, the smaller small sounds of the axe-heads at the side of the men who carried them moving against the cartridge-box. The forlorn hope had thirty yards on the column when the column started, and then forty, and then the count of the men ahead of him began to go down for the first time since he had begun counting at the supper of the day before, because the men ahead of him were now going down into the morass, and the count past forty that had been the shape of his waiting was becoming the count of how many were left between him and the water.

His mouth was dry. The drier of the two drynesses he had learned, the slow one, the one the night made and not the one the firing made — he knew this one from White Plains in the morning of standing-to and from Brandywine in the

morning before the cannon began and from Princeton's edge and from every long approach the army had ever made on a thing it was about to attempt. The body produced the dryness ahead of the thing and not at it. He kept his lips closed against the air and did not lick at them because the licking made it worse, and let the air go in and out of his nose at the speed his ribs wanted it, which was a speed a little faster than his ribs would have wanted at the drill but slower than they had wanted at Brandywine at the standing-to, and he counted at the count he had learned to count the column down to the water by, and the count came down. Thirty. Twenty.

The water came up around him at perhaps the eighth step. He did not know it would be at the eighth. He had thought from the briefing that it might be at twelve or fifteen but he had not pictured the going-in and he understood now that he could not have pictured it, because the picturing was a thing the head did with a picture it had, and the head had never had this. The water was cold and was at the knee at the first step and was past the thigh at the third and was at the breast at the sixth and stopped there. He took the breath the body wanted at the breast-deep and put the musket up over his head with the bayonet pointing at the sky and held it there, the way the men ahead of him were holding theirs, and the cartridge-box he could not hold up went under and stayed under, and the cartridges in it were soaked and would not have fired now even if the flints had been in the locks, and the empty muskets the corps was carrying were as empty as they had been at the supper of the day before and would have been emptier yet if the men had loaded them. He went forward across the morass at the breast-deep with the musket up. The water was full of things the day had put into it, the cut laurel and the trampled grass and the standing water of the marsh that was the morass's own water, and the bottom under his feet was the bottom of marsh-water, which is not a bottom a man can read with the foot but is a thing a man finds at every step and trusts because the step has nowhere else to go.

No one called out. The order on that had been Wayne's own, and the order had not needed to be carried into the morass because the order was already in every man at the supper of the day before, and the men who went down at the deep part — there were men who went down; he heard the small sounds of going-under at the right of his column where the morass was deeper — the men who went down went down without calling, and the men beside them got them up by the cartridge-belt and held them up across the deep place without anyone having to be told to, and the column kept its shape because the column knew it was the attack and the attack was the silence.

The water dropped at the far side and then dropped again, and he came up out of it at his waist and then at his knees and then onto the slope, and the slope began going up almost at once, and the abatis was up on the slope above them and a little to the left. He could not see the abatis. He heard it. He heard the axes at it, the sound of an axe-head going into a felled tree and being drawn back and going in again, and the sound was a sound a man could hear in any wood-lot in

Virginia in any October of his life, except that this sound was being made in the dark by men under a fort, and the dark on the slope above them was a dark the British above had not yet realized was a dark with anything in it.

He went up. The hands had the musket again at the carry now that the water was off. The bayonet had stayed on. The slope was loose under the feet, marl and old leaf and the small loose stones that come down a hill of that kind in spring, and the going was at the half-step the way a man goes up a slope at night when he cannot see his next foothold and the next man's back is twelve inches off the front of him and the next man's bayonet is twelve inches off the back of him and there is nothing under any of it but the slope. He went up at the half-step. The breath was coming up out of him short now and he made the ribs slow it because the breath at the half-step at the slope was loud enough at three feet to be a thing the corps did not want, and the corps was still inside the silence and the silence was still the attack.

The cut place in the abatis was a thing he came on suddenly and went through. The forlorn hope had opened it. The forlorn hope had opened it in two places that he could see in the dark by the shape of the felled trees pulled aside, the cut ends of them showing pale in what little light the night had, and the column went through one of the cut places at the half-step still, the cut sharpened ends of the laurel and the chestnut catching at the trouser and the sleeve as the column came past, and the column was through and was past, and the slope above was the last of the slope and the works were at the head of it. He could see the line of the works now against what was a little less dark than the rest of the dark — a line of the parapet showing as a higher straighter dark against the sky-dark — and he was inside fifty feet of it and the British above did not know.

It was at the works that the silence broke. Not at his column. The break came from somewhere up to the right, off where the north column was up at its own abatis, a single shout from above the parapet there, a British voice that said one word he could not make out, and then a musket went off somewhere up there, a single shot, the flash showing on the rim of the parapet for an instant and then nothing, and then the night that had been a silence above them all the long going-up became the night that was a fortified place coming awake — voices on the parapet, more voices, the sound of men running on a board floor inside the works, an officer's voice not understanding and then an officer's voice understanding, and then a drum starting to beat the alarm and stopping at the second beat because there was no time now for a drum, and then the muskets above began to come off the parapet down the slope at the columns, the flashes showing and showing along the line of the works and the balls going overhead and into the men of the columns at the rate the British above could get them loaded and out, which was not at a rate. The British had been sleeping at half their posts and the half that were not sleeping were not loaded and the loading was happening now in the dark on the parapet of a place that had not believed it was about to be attacked.

He did not stop. The order had been not to stop. The order had been not to fire — the muskets were empty in any case, but the order had been not to fire even at the works once the silence broke, because the silence had done what it had been kept for and what was wanted now was the steel into the works before the British above could load, and the column went up the last of the slope at the run for the first time that night, the rank breaking a little under the running and reforming at the parapet, and the men of his column were going up at the parapet now with the bayonet, and he was going up with them.

He went over the works. He did not stop at them and did not pause and did not, going over, take any account of the going-over: the body did it, the foot finding the cut edge of the timber at the top and going across and finding the platform on the far side and coming down on it, and he was on the platform with the bayonet, and the men around him were coming down onto it with theirs, and the British on the platform were turning to face the column that had come up onto the works among them and were trying to bring the muskets to bear that had not been loaded.

What happened inside the works happened in the dark and is not a thing he could have set down on paper afterward if the old man at the long table had asked him for it, and the old man did not ask. The men of the silent columns had been told and had told themselves all night long that the attack was the silence and the silence was the steel, and the steel was what was inside the works now, and the steel does not write itself down. The British above were turning in the dark to muskets that would not fire, and the men of the columns were going through the works at the bayonet, and the British were going down, and the British who could see what was inside the works were calling for quarter, and the order had been to give quarter to any man who asked for it, and the corps was giving it. *Quarter*, the British were calling on the platform around him, and the men of the corps were taking the muskets out of their hands and putting them on the platform and putting the men down on the platform beside the muskets without striking them, and the parts of the works where the British had not yet asked for quarter were being gone through with the steel, and the parts where the British had asked were being kept, and Vincent was going through the works the way the men around him were going through, and the bayonet had been used, and would not be a thing he would set down to the old man, and was not a thing he would yet set down to himself, and was a thing inside the going.

He did not see Wayne. Wayne went up with the south column at the abatis and was hit there — he learned it later — by a musket-ball at the side of the head that did not go in but cut a furrow along the scalp and put him on one knee for a moment, and Wayne, on the one knee, ordered the men around him to carry him up into the works because he meant to be carried into the works if he could not walk into them, and the men carried him up and into them, and he was up in the works giving orders before the half-hour was out. Vincent did not see any of this. What Vincent saw was the platform and the parapet and the men around him and

the British going down or asking for quarter or both, and then, at some count of minutes he could not afterward give, the British inside the works were not firing or fighting any longer and were sitting on the platform with their hands at their sides and the corps was holding the works.

The center column had been called up. He could hear it now, the firing at the gate where the third party had been making its show with the loaded muskets, a different firing from the firing on the parapets because the third party had been firing to be heard, and the firing had brought the British attention to the gate while the columns at the flanks were on the slope and past the abatis, and the third party was now coming up to take its share of the works at the center. The firing slackened. It went out. The works were holding.

He stood on the platform inside the works. The musket was at the carry. The bayonet was still on the end of it. The bayonet had been used. He did not look at it. He looked instead out across the parapet to the east, where the river was somewhere below in the dark, and could not see the river, and looked back along the platform to where the British prisoners were sitting in a long line with the corps's men over them, and saw that the line was a long line — many more men than he would have thought were still alive on the rock — and saw that the corps was holding the rock, and that the thing had come on and gone past and was now a thing already behind him.

His hands shook. He noted it the way a man notes the weather. He had been steady at the bayonet for the cold stock at the long lying and steady at the going through the morass and steady at the half-step up the slope and steady at the going-over and steady at the work in the works, and now that the work was done and there was no thing for the hands to be doing, they shook, and the shaking was the country's tax on having had them steady when it had needed them, and he set the musket-butt on the platform and let the hands shake against the small of the stock and did not try to stop them, because the trying was a thing he had learned at Brandywine that did not work and that made the shaking worse. He let them.

The dawn came up slow over the country east of the river. He saw it on the parapet first, the eastern dark going to a grey, and then the grey opening enough to show the river below and the bend of it and the country on the far bank, and the river was not what he had thought it would be — wider and slower and more full of light than any river had a business being on a morning the night before of which men had been going down into a morass to climb a rock — and the country east of the river was a country going off into a long grey haze that was the country of the lower Hudson and not, in any direction he could see from the platform, the country that ran back toward Lunenburg, but he looked west all the same, where the country that ran back toward Lunenburg was on the far side of a great deal of ground he had not yet covered going back, and he looked once and then turned to where Doyle and Cole were on the platform alive and Cole was sitting against the parapet with his head down between his knees not from any hurt but from the down-come of the night, and Vincent went and sat down beside him on the

platform, and put his back against the British timber, and watched the dawn come up over the rock and over the river and over the country, and felt the breath go in and out of him at the speed it wanted to go in and out, which was now the speed of a man who had come up out of a thing he did not yet know he had come up out of.

He took the scrap of paper out of the cartridge-box. The cartridge-box was wet through and the scrap was wet through with it, but the pencil-mark would still take to wet paper as the pencil-mark always would, and he found the place along the parapet where there was room and a flat surface, and he wrote, in the wet on the wet paper, the line for the day. *The 16th of July. At a place on the Hudson called Stony Point. I am well.* That was all. The hand was steadier writing the line than it had been writing the line at Chester after Brandywine two summers before, which was the only measure he had for it, and he put the line by, and put the scrap back where it lived, and sat on the platform beside Cole, and watched the river.

March 1781, Guilford

Guilford Court House, North Carolina, the fifteenth of March 1781

The morning was warm for March and the country was full of the smell of new pine. The army had come up to the ground at the courthouse the day before, by Greene's order, and the line was forming on the road as the light came up — the North Carolina militia in the first line along a snake-fence at the edge of an open field of last year's stubble, the Virginia militia in the second line a quarter-mile back in the woods, and the Continentals in the third line on a low rise behind the second, where the road came up out of the woods and bent past the courthouse itself. Vincent was with his part of the Virginia detachment in the third line, on the right of the road by perhaps fifty yards, in among second-growth oak and hickory on ground that fell off behind them to the east. He was eighteen and three months. He had been in the Line four years and two months and had been at three general actions and a dozen lesser ones, and had stopped being the youngest in his part of the column some time the summer before, when a Hanover boy of sixteen had come up to the company at the camp on the Pee Dee and Vincent had found himself, without having looked for it, on the older side of the rank.

The haversack was at his right hip on the strap. It had been the haversack of a man named Howard who had gone home at the end of the winter quarters of 1777-78 with his term out and his right arm not what it had been, and who had given Vincent the haversack at the parting because Vincent had been carrying his rations in a piece of folded ticking from his blanket and Howard had said a boy in the Line wanted a haversack to be a man in the Line and not a boy. The haversack was canvas, oiled, the strap worn to the color of the canvas, and inside it Vincent kept the day's bread and what cheese there was and the small kit of a soldier and, in a folded square of oilcloth at the bottom under the bread, the letter from his

sister Mary that had come up to him in August of 1778 at the camp at White Plains and that he had been carrying since. He did not need to take it out to know where it was in the haversack. The hand found it through the canvas the way the hand finds a coin in a coat pocket without the looking.

The British came on at the first line at perhaps half past one in the afternoon by what the men afterward said. Vincent did not look at the sun. The North Carolina militia in the first line fired their two rounds as the order had been given to them and then went back through the woods on either side of the road, and the firing came up the field to the second line, and the Virginia militia in the second line stood and fired and were broken and the firing came up through the second-growth toward the third, and somewhere ahead and to the left there was a heavier firing that was the part of the army that had taken the British coming in close where the road bent. The order in the third line was to hold. The order was to fire by ranks at the British when the British came up out of the woods onto the open ground in front of the rise, and to hold the line as long as the line could be held. The line held. The British came up out of the woods on the road and to either side of it at perhaps thirty yards, and the third line fired its first volley and the British line behind it, and the volleys went on as the volleys had gone on at Brandywine and at Monmouth, and the smoke stood in the woods because the woods would not let it move, and the men in the line on Vincent's left and on Vincent's right loaded and fired and loaded and fired the way the drill had made them load and fire, and Vincent did with them. He was older now in the body and the hands were not the hands of Birmingham Meeting House — the hands set the cartridge on the second motion of the teeth and the ramrod was already coming back up before the eye had caught it gone down — and the head was the head of a man who had been at the work long enough to know how the work went, and the line stood, and the men around him stood, and the British line at thirty yards stood, and the firing was the day's work.

The day broke up on the right. It was not on Vincent's right. It was the right of the army as a whole, off to the south where Lee's legion and Campbell's riflemen were in the woods and where the British had got around the flank, and the breaking came back up the line in pieces the way breaking came back up a line. The order to fall back came down from the courthouse some time after, and the third line went back at the walk by ranks the way Steuben had drilled it to go back, and the British came on but not at the speed they had had at the start of the day, because the British, Vincent could see by the line as it came forward, were a line that had paid for the ground it had taken and had not many more lines in it. He went back at the walk with the rank. Banks was on his left. Banks had been at Guilford in the rank from the start of the morning and was still on his left at the going back. They went back perhaps a quarter-mile to the road and another half-mile up the road and then the road bent east and they went east on it, and the army was going east on it with them, and the British did not press.

The night came down on the road north of Guilford toward the iron-works at Speedwell's. The army made what camp it could in the woods along the road. Vincent's part of the detachment was on the south side of the road in a stand of small pine where the needles were dry and the ground was good, and there were fires by then, the British not being close enough to come on in the dark, and the men of his rank were down around the fires with what rations they had, which was the day's bread out of the haversack and what was left of the cheese.

* * *

He understood that now, lying in the marsh — that the country a man carries through a war is not the country on the maps the officers have on the road behind the line. The country a man carries is what the haversack carries for him. He had been sixteen in the marsh and had been carrying the haversack at his hip on the cold ground at the Hudson the way he had been carrying it at the standing-to at Monmouth and the way he would be carrying it on the rise at Guilford, and the country in the haversack — the bread, the cheese, the kit, the letter at the bottom in the oilcloth — was the country he had taken away from the lane out of Lunenburg in January of 1777 and would take back to the lane in some month and year he did not yet know. He had not understood that, at sixteen in the marsh, the way he would come to understand it. At sixteen he had understood only that the haversack was on his hip and that the letter was in it, and that the letter had been in it since the August of the year before, and that the letter would be in it the next morning if there was a next morning for him after the hour. The country in the haversack was the country he kept.

* * *

He had found the place against a pine in the dark away from the nearest fire, where the needles were thick on the ground and the trunk gave the back something to rest against, and had sat down with his back against the pine and had set the musket between his knees with the lock up, and had taken the haversack off the shoulder and put it on the ground beside him. He had eaten the bread. He took the letter out then. He did it the way he always did it, which was without thinking about doing it: the hand into the haversack past the bread-end and down to the bottom and onto the oilcloth, and the oilcloth out, and the letter unfolded out of the oilcloth onto his thigh.

The letter was not what it had been in August of 1778. The paper was thinner where the folds had been folded and unfolded across the carrying. The ink had darkened in two places where the haversack had been wet through in the rains north of the Dan in February, and had lightened in one place at the corner where the hand had held the corner most. The hand on the letter was his sister Mary's hand. It was the hand of a girl of thirteen, which his sister had been in the August of 1778, with the loops on the *ls* and the *hs* drawn the way a girl in the country

drew them when she had been taught by a mother who had been taught by a mother. He read the letter. He read it without reading it, because the eye on the paper at this hour and on this night was not reading the words for the first time but was reading them the way a man reads a thing he has read so often that the reading of it is a kind of remembering of what the reading had been the first time and the second and the twelfth and the hundredth.

* * *

He had been at the camp at White Plains in the August of 1778. He had been fifteen years and eight months and had had the haversack from Howard for the spring and the summer, and had had the carrying of the haversack at the long marches through the Jerseys after Monmouth and into New York, and had not yet known what the haversack was for, beyond the carrying of what a haversack carried. The letter came up to the camp in a packet brought by a Lunenburg man, a wagoner named Eppes who had come up to the army with a wagon of meal out of the lower country and who had been told by Vincent's mother that her son was with the Virginia detachment somewhere about White Plains and to find him if he could. Eppes had found him. He had stood Vincent up by the wagon and had looked at him without saying anything for the space of three breaths the way a man looks at a boy he has known since the boy was a child and is now seeing as a soldier, and had then put the packet into Vincent's hands and had gone on to his unloading.

Vincent had taken the packet off into the trees at the edge of the camp where the noon-light came down at an angle through the leaves. There had been three things in the packet. One was from his mother and was the news of the household and the news that his grandfather was at the long table every morning still, and the news that the corn was in and that Polly was well. One was from his grandfather and was the short kind of letter the old man wrote, which said only that the country was the long thing and the boy was its instrument and the boy would write his line. The third was from Mary. He had opened the third last because he had not known what was in the third and had wanted to put off the not-knowing for the few breaths it took to read the other two, and when he had unfolded the third the hand of it had stopped him at the unfolding, because the hand was a hand he had not seen put to paper before. Mary had not written to him at the camp. The mother wrote for the household. The grandfather wrote what the grandfather wrote. Mary at thirteen, in the August of 1778, had written to him in her own hand, and the hand was a hand she had had to teach herself, because the grandfather had taught the boys at the table and had not taught the girls, and Mary had taught herself by watching the grandfather teach the boys and by going at it after on her own.

What she had written was not long. She had written that the harvest was in and the corn was good. She had written that their mother was well and was tired in the evenings the way she had been tired since the father had gone. She had

written that the grandfather had read out at the table that morning the line from the Bible that said *they that wait upon the Lord shall renew their strength* and that she had thought of him when the grandfather had read it. She had written that she had begun to read at the long table when the grandfather was at it. She had written, at the end, that she had begun to write because the writing was a thing a person had to do for herself and not be done for by another, and that she hoped he was well. She had signed it *your sister Mary Baker*.

His body had read the letter at the camp at White Plains before his head had finished reading it. The hand on the paper at his thigh had begun to shake at the third line, where she had written about their mother being tired, and the throat had closed at the line about the grandfather's reading from the Bible, and the eyes had gone past the line about her teaching herself to read and had had to come back to it because the eyes had not been able to take it the first time. He had read it through three times in the trees at the edge of the camp. He had folded it back along the folds it had come folded in. He had put it inside his shirt against his ribs because he had not yet had the oilcloth for it — the oilcloth came later, off a tarred bundle that a teamster from the lower country threw out at Middlebrook — and the paper had been against his ribs the rest of that afternoon and into the watch that night, and he had not understood, that afternoon, that the letter had given him a thing his sister at thirteen had not known she was giving him to carry. The thing she had given him to carry was that she had begun. She had begun to read and she had begun to write and she had begun to be the keeper of a thing the household had not yet known it would need her to keep. The boy at fifteen under the trees at White Plains had not seen that. He had seen only that his sister Mary had written to him in her own hand, and that the hand had said the things she had been able to say at thirteen, and that the saying of them had been her own.

* * *

He folded the letter back into the oilcloth on his thigh by the pine on the road north of Guilford. The hand at the folding was a hand that had been steady at the rank that morning and was now a hand that was not asking to be looked at. He put the oilcloth back into the bottom of the haversack under the bread-end. He sat against the pine. The fire some yards off threw a little light onto the ground around him but did not reach the pine, and the country around the army on the road back from Guilford was the country of the night after a day at which he had been at the work as long as he could remember being at it. What he did not yet know, sitting against the pine on the road back from Guilford, was that the letter had another summer and another autumn still to be in the haversack with him, and one more piece of country between him and the lane home, and that the thing his sister at thirteen had given him to carry in the August of 1778 was a thing she had also given herself to keep, and that the keeping at the parlor desk in Lunenburg with the Bible open and the hand at the page was a keeping he would walk up the lane to in autumn.

October 1781, Yorktown*Yorktown, Virginia, the nineteenth of October 1781*

The morning came up clear and cool over the works the allied army had drawn around the British position on the river, and the corps was up in the rank well before the hour. The Continentals stood along the road on the American side, two ranks deep, the muskets at the order with the butts at the feet and the bayonets fixed and pointing at the sky, and the line of them ran along the road for what looked from where Vincent stood to be most of a mile. Across the road the French stood the same way, two ranks deep, in their white coats with the facings of every regiment a color of its own, and the line of the French ran the mile back the other way. The road between the two lines was empty. The British were to come out and ground their arms in the field beyond the lines at one o'clock by the order come down the night before.

Vincent was eighteen and ten months. He had been in the Line four years and nine months. He had been with the part that went in at the second parallel three nights ago when the redoubts above it had gone in by the bayonet, and had been at the river end of the parallel four days before that when the British had come out at dawn against the works and had been driven back, and the day after that the firing from the British had begun to slacken on the parapet, and the day after that the firing had stopped, and the white had gone up over the British, and the officers had gone in and the officers had come out, and the order for the surrender field had come down the corps that night. The corps had not known, when it came down to Williamsburg out of the heat of late summer marching through Virginia, that the work it was doing was the last of the work. It had not known any such thing on any of the campaigns. It had come down with what it had carried and had done what the work asked for. Now the work was over.

He stood in the rank with the musket at the order. The haversack was on his hip on the strap, the strap worn now to the color of the canvas, the letter in the bottom of the haversack in the oilcloth where it had been since Middlebrook three years before. Banks was on his left. Banks had come down with him through Virginia from the camp on the Pamunkey in August, and was on his left in the rank along the road the way he had been on his left on the road back from Guilford and on the standing-to at the second parallel and going through the abatis at the redoubt three nights ago. On the right was a Continental man named Briggs out of Hanover County who had come up to the part of the company in the spring; Doyle and Cole, who had been with him on the platform on the rock at the river in the dawn of the sixteenth of July two summers and three months before, were further up the line where the rank had put them in the forming. He did not see them down the line from where he was. He knew they were there.

The hour was long. The standing was longer than the standing at the assault had been short. The body that had been at the work for four years and nine months stood in the rank along the road in the cool light of an October morning

and had nothing in particular to do, and the absence of the thing to do was a thing the body did not know what to make of. The hands holding the musket up at the order were the hands that had been at the cartridge and the bayonet at Brandywine and Monmouth and on the rock at the river and on the rise at Guilford and on a dozen smaller affairs, and now the hands were at the carry and the carry was holding the musket up for a thing that was not the next thing the musket had been carried for. The hands shook a little after a while. He noted it. He did not try to stop it. He let the hands be what they were.

The British came out a little after one. He heard them before he saw them — the drums first, coming up the road from the direction of the river-works, a slow march beat such as a corps beats coming up a road that is not a road it has wanted to be coming up, and then the column itself came up the road into view at the far end where the road bent, the British regiments coming up two abreast in the road in the order they had been told to come up in, and the colors of each regiment up front were cased. He saw the casings on the staves as the head of the column came past — the cloth bound around each color and tied off, the stave still upright but the color not flown — and the casings were the thing that told the day what the day was. A corps did not case its colors except going to a surrender field. The corps coming up the road past the lines was a corps coming up to ground its arms.

The column passed him at perhaps fifty feet. The British men coming past in the rank did not look at the American line. Some looked at the French line. Some looked at the road in front of them. Some looked at no place at all that he could read. The faces were the faces of men who had been a corps as long as the corps standing in the road had been a corps, and who had been at the work as long, and whose work had come out the other way. He did not look long at any one face. He held his place in the rank with the musket at the order and let the column pass.

Somewhere down the line a band was playing. He could hear it under the drums. The tune was a tune he did not know, a country tune by the sound of it, a thing in three with a turn before each end, played slow. The men in the rank afterward said the tune had been *The World Turned Upside Down*, and it might have been; he could not have said so on the road that day with the column passing. The tune ran on under the drums while the British came past, and the field beyond the lines where the arms were to be grounded began to fill with the men of the head of the column laying their muskets down in the piles the order had named, butt to butt with the bayonets crossed, the way the order had named them to be laid.

The grounding went on a long time. He stood in the rank and watched the regiments come past and the men of each go out into the field beyond and lay the muskets down, and the regiments coming up out of the road behind kept coming, and the field filled, and the field filled further. The body in the rank knew before the head did that the thing the body had been at was over. The hands holding the musket were the hands that had had a thing to be doing for four years and nine months, and the thing was now a thing the British were laying down in piles in the

field, and the hands were not doing it. The breath in the ribs went in and out the way the breath goes in a man standing in the cool air with nothing to load. The head, which had been the head of a soldier inside the work since the fourteen-year-old at the courthouse in Lunenburg in January of 1777 had stood up by the table and put his hand to the paper, was the head of a soldier come out the other side of the work, and the head did not yet know what to be the head of next.

What he did not know, standing in the rank along the road at Yorktown on the nineteenth of October 1781, was that the corps would let him out of the Line before the year was out, and that the lane up to the house at Lunenburg was inside the next two months and was the next country he would walk into. He stood in the rank and watched the British come out and ground their arms in the field, and the day went on through the afternoon at the long passing.

* * *

That night by a fire on the ground inside the allied works he took the scrap of paper out of the cartridge-box. The scrap was dry. The October air had been dry and the cartridge-box dry on his hip through the dry day, and the pencil-mark would take to the paper clean. He found the flat top of a small chest a French sergeant down the line had let him have for the writing, and he set the scrap on it, and he wrote the line for the day. *The 19th of October. At a place on the York River called Yorktown. I am well.* That was all. The hand was steady. He looked at the line a moment after he had written it. He did not write anything more. He put the scrap back where it lived in the cartridge-box, and put the cartridge-box back on its strap on his hip, and ate the bread the haversack had under the letter, and sat by the fire with Banks and Briggs and the men of the rank around it, and the talk around the fire was the talk of men who had stood the long passing and did not yet know what to say of it. He did not say much. He sat by the fire and looked at the fire. He thought of the lane.

Autumn 1781, the Lane Home

The lane up to the house at Lunenburg, the first week of December 1781

The Continental Line had let him out at Williamsburg in the third week of November with his pay in paper that was not paper a man would have wanted to be paid in, and a discharge in writing folded into three, and the country to walk back into; and Vincent had folded the paper into the haversack with the letter under the bread-end and had walked it in days, up through Petersburg in the last days of November and across the Nottoway at a ford he knew the look of from the going down four years and nine months before, and on into Brunswick County in the first days of December. He was eighteen and eleven months. He had been gone four years and ten months and three weeks. He had the haversack on the strap with the letter and the discharge in it and the cartridge-box on his hip with

the writing-scrap, and the brown coat the Line had given him at Yorktown, patched at the elbow, and the shoes the Line had given him with it.

The road came up onto the ground he knew at the corner of Lunenburg County a little before noon. He knew it by the slope of the country — the way it tilted south toward the Meherrin at one shoulder and east toward the Nottoway at the other — and by a stand of three big white oaks at the corner of a tobacco field where Old Hetty's brother had cleared the corner the summer Vincent had been twelve. The field was in winter stubble. The oaks stood the way they had stood. He had not meant to stop at them. The body stopped before the head named what the body had seen, and the head came up after a breath and saw the oaks.

He went on. The road bent west past the oaks and came down a slow grade through a stand of second-growth that had not been second-growth when he left, and up the other side onto the ground where the lane to the house came off the road to the right. The lane came off at a place a stranger would not have seen as a lane. The country knew it. He knew it. He turned in onto the lane at the walk he had come up the road with, without changing it.

The lane ran a half-mile north between two fields the household had cleared in his father's time, and the fields on either side were in winter stubble. The lane itself had been kept — the rut not deep, the verge cut back in the summer last — and he saw the keeping of the lane and saw whose keeping it was. It was not his father's. It was the household's. He went up the lane.

The hands had not had a thing to do since the surrender field at Yorktown six weeks before. They had carried the haversack and they had held the bread when he stopped to eat the bread, and these had been the things the hands had been at. They were not at the cartridge. They were not at the bayonet. They were not at the load. He noted it. The feet went up the lane.

At a hundred yards the standing oak at the head of the lane came into view above the rise. It had been the oak the day he had gone down in January of 1777 with the wagoner's boy from Eppes's place and had not known whether to look back at it and had not looked. The body knew the oak before the head named it.

The house came into view at two hundred yards under the oak. The chimney on the north end put up a thin straight line of smoke into the cold midday air. The window on the parlor end was shuttered against the cold but one shutter was set ajar to let the noon light into the room. The door at the front was closed. There was no one in the yard. The chickens were under the corner of the smokehouse out of the wind. The dog the household had had when he left was not in the yard, and the only sound was the wind in the standing oak and a thin sound of someone at the iron a long way off down at the smith's place south on the road.

He stopped at perhaps fifty feet from the house. He had not meant to stop. The body stopped without the head's having asked it to, and stood in the lane with the breath in the ribs going slow. The body had walked four years and ten months back into a place the body had been carrying with it the whole way, and was at the

place now, and was not asking the head what to do next. He let the body do what it was doing.

He went on. The yard had been swept some time in the past day or two; the broom-marks were still in the dust by the door. He went up the three steps and stood at the door. He did not knock. He had not knocked at this door in his life. He laid his hand to the latch and pressed it down and pushed the door open into the hall.

The smell of the hall — of cured oak and of woodsmoke off the parlor fire and of bread that had been at the bake some hours before and was no longer — was the smell of the hall. He had carried it in the haversack the way he had carried the letter, without having known he had been carrying it. It came up at him at the threshold, and the body knew it before the head named what it was.

* * *

The voice from the kitchen at the back of the hall was his mother's. *Sarah, is that Hetty come back?* — the voice of a woman who had been the head of the household of women for going on seven years and who had heard the door open in the middle of the day and asked the question into the hall without coming out to see. He did not answer. He could not have got the throat to make a word at that moment. He heard the step in the kitchen — heavier than he had remembered and slower — and he saw her come into the hall at the kitchen end.

She stopped at the kitchen door. She had a piece of cloth in her hand she had been wiping the kitchen table with, and the cloth went down. She did not say anything for the space of two breaths. She said his name. *Vincent*. She did not say it loud. She said it the way a woman says a word she has been carrying the saying of for four years and ten months in the throat without knowing she had been carrying it. Then she came down the hall.

He went to meet her at the middle of the hall. She put her hands on his shoulders — not pulling him to her, holding him an arm's length away so that she could look at the face — and she looked at the face. He stood and let her look. He was a head and a half taller than she was now. He had not been the last time she had stood in front of him in this hall. The face she was looking at was not the face she had sent down the lane in January of 1777. She looked as long as she needed to. Then she put her arms around him and her face into the front of his coat and held on. She did not cry. He put his arms around her back the way he had not put his arms around the back of anyone for four years and ten months, and held on.

After a while she stepped back. *Your grandfather is in the parlor*, she said. *Your sister is with him. The child is asleep upstairs*. She said it telling him so that he had it. *The child*, he said. It was the first word he had said in the house. *Mary's*, she said. *A girl. She was a year old in October*. She looked at him while she said it and let him take the second piece in. He had thought of a child on the road up from Williamsburg in the way a man thinks of what might be at the end of a road he is walking, but he had not thought of a girl a year old asleep upstairs in the

house he was now standing in the hall of. He took it in. *I'll go in to my grandfather*, he said. She nodded and stepped aside.

* * *

The parlor door was the parlor door. He put his hand to the latch and lifted it and pushed it open at the slow speed at which a door wants to be pushed when the room behind it is a room being worked in.

The fire on the north wall was at a low burn, the way the fire was kept of an afternoon when the work in the parlor wanted not heat but light. The noon light came in at the ajar shutter and fell across the long desk under the window where the Bible was open. His grandfather was at the desk the way the grandfather had been every morning he could remember — the back not as straight as it had been when Vincent had gone away but straight, the hands flat at either side of the open Bible, the head down at the page. The old man was getting on for sixty. The hair at the back of his head was thinner than it had been and was wholly white where it had been white-and-gray.

His sister Mary was on the grandfather's right, seated on a low stool. She had a piece of paper on a small board on her knees and a quill in her right hand and the ink-pot on a stand at her elbow, and she was at the writing of something on the paper. Her head was down. She was seventeen, and had been married, when Vincent did the arithmetic at the parlor door, almost exactly two years to the day. She was bigger in the shoulders than she had been at thirteen. The hair at the back of her head was the hair she had had then, brown going to the dark, drawn back at the nape into the kind of plain knot a young married woman wore at the day's work. She wore a dress of the same brown wool the household had spun and woven the last winter he had been at home.

The grandfather looked up first. The old man did not get up out of the chair. He looked up from the Bible and at the door and saw his grandson Vincent in it with the haversack on the strap and the brown coat of the Line on the body and the face of a man on the face of the boy who had gone down the lane in January of 1777 with his hand to the paper at the substitute enlistment. The old man's mouth went open a little and then closed and then opened again, and he said: *Vincent*. Mary's head came up at her grandfather's saying it. The quill in her hand stopped at the page. She set the board on the floor at the side of the stool and stood up and stood looking at him.

She did not come across the room. He did not go across the room. He stood in the door and looked at her, and she stood at the desk and looked at him, and the room was the room with the fire on the hearth and the noon light coming in at the ajar shutter and the Bible open under the light on the desk's slope and the old man between the two of them. The keeping that had been at the parlor desk in this house since before Vincent had been born was at the desk in the room he was standing in the door of. The keeper at thirteen who had begun to be a keeper in the August of 1778 at the camp at White Plains was the woman of seventeen who

had been a keeper for two years now and who sat in the chair beside the old man with a quill in her hand.

* * *

What he understood, standing at the parlor door in the autumn of 1781, was the thing the boy at sixteen in the marsh at the Hudson had not been able to understand and the boy at fifteen under the trees at White Plains had been given to begin to understand and had not. The keeping was one keeping. The keeping his grandfather had done at the long table since before the boy had been born, and the keeping Mary at thirteen had begun in the August of 1778 by teaching herself to read at the long table when the grandfather was at it, and the keeping he himself had done at every scrap of paper in every cartridge-box on every campaign — *The 11th of September. Brandywine. I am well.* and *The 19th of October. At a place on the York River called Yorktown. I am well.* — were the same keeping done in three places by three of one household, the writing-line in the field a piece of the same keeping as the line his sister was at on the paper on the board at the stool and as the line the old man had read out at the long table in the August of 1778 about waiting upon the Lord, and the line was not three lines but one line, and the household had been at the keeping of it the whole time.

* * *

He came into the parlor. He set the haversack on the floor by the door — the first time it had been off his shoulder in the daylight in the country since he had come up the lane — and he went across the room to the desk. His grandfather had got up out of the chair by then, slowly, with the right hand on the desk's edge for the rising, and was standing waiting for him. He took the old man's right hand in his right and held it. The old man's hand was smaller in his than it had been in the hand of the boy at fourteen on the night before the going down to the courthouse, because the boy's hand was now a man's hand and not a boy's. The old man did not say anything. He held the hand. Then he let it go and put both hands on Vincent's shoulders the way Vincent's mother had in the hall a quarter-hour ago, and looked at his grandson's face, and said: *You wrote the line.* He said it the way a man says a thing he has been waiting to say for four years and ten months and has had the saying of it ready in him the whole time.

I wrote the line, Vincent said. The old man nodded. He took his hands off Vincent's shoulders and sat back down, slowly, with the right hand on the desk's edge for the sitting, and put his hands flat at either side of the open Bible. The light from the ajar shutter fell across the page where the old man's hands lay.

Vincent turned to his sister. Mary was where she had been on the stool, her face wet at the cheeks, the quill still in her right hand though she had not been at the writing for some minutes. She set it down on the board at her feet. He came around the desk to her. She put her arms around his waist the way she had put

them around his waist the morning he had gone down the lane in January of 1777, when she had been twelve and had stood in the yard with her face against the front of his coat, and she had her face into the front of his coat now the way she had had it then. He put his arms around her back. She was bigger in the shoulders than she had been. He held on. After a while she stepped back and looked up at him. *I'll get her*, she said. The voice was the voice of a woman of seventeen who had been a mother for a year and more. He nodded. She went out by the door to the back hall and up the stairs.

He stood by the desk with the grandfather. The old man did not look up. He was at the page. Vincent looked down at the page. The page was an old page. The hand at the top was a hand Vincent did not know — the hand of the great-grandfather Christopher, who had carried the Bible over from Worb and written the first names on the page at his marriage in Charleston — and below it was the hand of the grandfather, who had been the keeper of the page for near forty years, and who had set down on it in his own hand the births and the deaths the page had been the keeper of, and the deaths were not many and the births were many. At the bottom of the page in a hand Vincent had not seen on this page before was a line in his sister Mary's hand. *Sarah Johnson, born the ninth of October 1780, daughter of Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson and Gideon Johnson*. The hand was the hand he had read on the letter at the camp at White Plains and had been carrying in the haversack three years.

The old man's right hand came up off the desk and pointed at the line in Mary's hand. *She wrote it*, he said. He did not say it loud. He said it the way a man names a fact in front of him.

She wrote it, Vincent said. The line was below where the line of his own birth had been set down by the grandfather eighteen years and eleven months before, and the writing of the child's name on the page in Mary's hand was the thing the old man had wanted Vincent to see before any other thing was said in the room, and Vincent saw it.

* * *

Mary came back down the stairs with the child in her arms. She was asleep against her shoulder with her face turned in toward the side of her neck, heavy the way a child of a year is heavy when she has gone to sleep, wrapped in the wool of a blanket the household had woven the spring before. Mary came to the desk and stood at Vincent's elbow. *This is your niece*, she said. *Her name is Sarah. We named her for our mother*. She did not say *for the one who had kept them all*. She did not have to.

Vincent put his hand on the back of the child's head. The hair was soft under his palm. He had not had his hand on the head of a child in four years and ten months. She did not wake. She went on sleeping at her mother's shoulder with her face turned in toward the side of her neck. *Sarah*, Vincent said. He said the

name the way a man says the name of a person who has been added to a room that has been a room he has known.

He did not say anything else for a while. He stood by the desk with his hand on the back of the child's head and his sister at his elbow and his grandfather in the chair and the page open under the noon light on the desk's slope. The fire gave out the small sound a fire gives out at a low burn. Somewhere in the back of the house his mother had gone to the kitchen, and the sound of the kettle going on at the hearth at the kitchen came up the back hall to the parlor. The shutter was at the ajar. The light through it had moved a little along the page in the time since he had come into the room.

He had not thought, walking down through Virginia from Williamsburg, of a child. He had not thought of his sister in her own hand. He had not thought of his name and the name of the child set down on the page of the Bible by the same hand. He had thought of coming home. He had not thought of what he was coming home to. He stood by the desk with his hand on the back of the child's head, and what he was coming home to was by the desk and at his elbow and in the chair, and the keeping of it was on the page under the light.

The wind outside the parlor window was the wind the standing oak at the head of the lane had stood in for two hundred years and would stand in for two hundred more. The road at the foot of the lane went on east toward Brunswick and west toward Lunenburg Court House the way the road had gone on for as long as it had been a road. The names on the page on the desk were the names the household had been the keeper of since the marriage at Charleston the great-grandfather had set at its head, four generations on this side of the water, and the latest of them was in his sister Mary's hand and was the name of a girl a year old asleep at her mother's shoulder against the side of her neck.

He stood by the desk and did not say anything for a while. The grandfather did not say anything. Mary did not say anything. The fire went on at its low burn, and the light through the ajar shutter went on falling across the page, and the household was the household, and the country at the foot of the lane was the country, and the war was the thing that had been and was no longer the thing that was, and the keeping at the desk was the thing that was.

Chapter 6 — The Keeping

In the summer of 1785, when this chapter opens, the DeGraffenreid line of Virginia and the Johnson line of North Carolina sat at two seats two days' ride apart, joined by a marriage of six years' standing, by three living daughters with more coming, and by a small family Bible, eight inches by five and bound in dark calf, whose fly-leaf had been carrying the family's names since 1714.

The DeGraffenreid seat was at Lunenburg County, Virginia, on the south side of the James River drainage where Christopher VI's son Tscharner had built a house in the early 1750s and had kept it since. Tscharner was sixty-two that summer, a Justice of the Peace of long standing, the keeper of the family's documentary record since his father's death in October 1742 had passed him the Bible at nineteen. He had married Mary Baker, the daughter of Colonel Henry Baker of Chowan, North Carolina, on the fifth of July of that same year 1742; she had died in the mid-1750s, before the granddaughter who would carry her name was born, and Tscharner had married three times in the years after. The keeping of the Bible had gone on through all of it. He lived at Lunenburg with the Bible on the parlor desk and with his unmarried son Vincent — twenty-two that summer, a Continental Line veteran of seven years' service who had walked back from Yorktown to Lunenburg in the spring of 1782. The Bible's keeping was Tscharner's, and the seat at Lunenburg was the family's documentary center.

The Johnson seat was at Rockingham County, North Carolina, on the cleared eighty acres that Gideon Johnson Jr. was holding under his mother-in-law Sarah Vass's deed of attorney of 19 December 1783. The cleared field belonged formally to Sarah Vass, by the Caswell grant of 13 November 1779 of four hundred acres in what had then been Guilford County and was now Rockingham — the county itself had been created in 1785, partitioned from Guilford, with its new seat at Wentworth being established that year on the records the chapter's heroine would consult when she had cause. Sarah Vass administered her dead husband's estate from her own seat, also in Rockingham County, within a morning's ride of her daughter's house; she had been administering the estate since September 1779, when the Lunenburg Order Book had named her administratrix of Baker DeGraffenreid's effects. Her husband Baker had ridden out at the outset of the Revolutionary War, in late 1775, and had not come back; the date and place of his death were not in the documentary record then and would not be at any point across the chapter's thirteen years.

Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson, the daughter of Sarah Vass and the dead Baker, was twenty years old in July 1785. She had married Gideon Johnson Jr. — Private of the 2nd North Carolina Continental Line under Captain Armstrong and Colonel Martin, fifteen months' service in 1776 and 1777 under pension file S4456 — on Thursday 18 November 1779 at her mother's borrowed house on the south side of the Dan River, in what was then Guilford County, with her

grandfather Tscharner — a Justice of the Peace of long standing — riding south to make the marriage and set it down in the family Bible, which would stand as its only record. She had borne three living daughters in the six years since: Sarah, born 9 October 1780; Mildred Baker, born 11 November 1782; Nancy, born 14 July 1784. A fourth daughter, Ursula, would come in December 1787; a fifth, Polly Baker, in April 1790; five more children would follow across the seventeen years after, ten in total to live to adulthood. The household was hers to run; the kitchen was Old Hetty's at the hearth from five in the morning; the cleared field was Gideon's by Sarah's deed of attorney; the family's record was Tscharner's at Lunenburg, two days' ride north.

The chapter spans the thirteen years from the summer of 1785 to the second week of February 1794. Across those years the household would receive — by post-rider on the route through Hairston's Cut to Halifax and on to Lunenburg, by traveling man at the kitchen door, by newspaper passed up from the courthouse at Wentworth, by letter from the grandfather at Lunenburg in his particular formal-informal English with French phrases at the sentence-turns — the fragments of a country still in the process of assembling itself. None of the country's events would happen to the household. All of them would arrive there as fragments, and the household — Mary Baker at the parlor desk with the ledger and the letters; Gideon at the cleared field; Old Hetty at the kitchen; Young George at the lot; three daughters and then four and then five at their working — would price each fragment and proceed.

The Bible at Lunenburg was the family's documentary center at the opening of this chapter. It would not be at the close of it. In the second week of February 1794 Tscharner would die — at seventy-one, in his bedchamber at Lunenburg, with the cause and the exact day unrecorded in the surviving sources — and the Bible would come south by wagon to the daughter of his dead son's wife. Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson would become, in the small hours of a night in her own parlor at Rockingham, the first woman in the line to hold the Christopher VI Bible. She would write the formal French death entry in her grandfather's manner, in her own hand. She would dip the quill a second time and write the two words underneath, in English — *we continue* — in the same small clear hand she had been signing letters in for fifteen years. She would close the Bible. She would blow out the candle.

That is the chapter's arc. The thirteen years between are the keeping that earns the two words.

* * *

The First Birthday

She woke at the small sound the one-year-old made before she was fully awake.

The sound was not crying. The sound was the soft half-question of a child who has come up out of sleep into the day before her mother has, and who has not yet

decided whether to make the day begin. Mary Baker lay on her side with her face to the cradle and listened. The cradle was at her own side of the bed, between the bed and the east wall, where she had moved it three nights ago when the night-heat had become too much for the close room at the back. The window above the cradle was open four inches. The air at the window was cooler than the air in the room. It smelled of the cleared field and the corn at the third week of June's laying-by and the standing oak at the head of the lane.

The one-year-old made the sound again.

Mary Baker put her hand over the side of the cradle and onto the back inside it. The back was warm. The breathing under her palm was even. The one-year-old turned her face toward her mother's hand and made the sound the third time and then did not make it again.

Mary Baker held her hand on the back until the breathing went long.

She got out of the bed on the side away from the cradle. Gideon was not in the bed. He had ridden out at four to be at the Caswell grant by daylight, and she had heard him go without lifting her head from the pillow, the way she had heard him go a hundred mornings in five years. He would be at the south rail of the cleared eighty by sun-up. He would not be back to the house before the supper.

She went to the wash-stand in her shift and washed her face and her hands at the basin. The water in the basin was the water she had drawn at the well at the close of yesterday's work; it had gone the temperature of the room overnight, which on a July night at this latitude was barely cooler than the skin. She dried her face on the linen towel on the peg beside the basin. She pinned her hair up at the nape with the four pins she kept in the dish at the corner of the wash-stand. She did not look at the mirror above the wash-stand.

She did not need to look at the mirror.

She put on the day-gown over the shift and laced it one-handed at the side as she crossed to the door. The lacing had been a thing she had needed both hands for at sixteen and a thing she could do one-handed by twenty. The other hand was holding the cradle's side because the one-year-old had begun to come awake in earnest now and was reaching with one fist for the edge of the cradle.

Mary Baker lifted her up.

She carried her down through the hall and past the door of the room where the two older girls were still asleep — Sarah on the inside of the trundle, Mildred Baker on the outside, their two heads at the bolster the way they had slept since Mildred Baker had been old enough to leave the cradle two years and four months ago — and down the back stair to the kitchen.

The kitchen was a little less dark than the upstairs. The east window over the dry-sink was paler than the room behind it. Old Hetty was at the hearth banking the night coals open. Old Hetty had been at the hearth since five.

Old Hetty said: Good morning to you, ma'am.

Mary Baker said: Good morning, Hetty.

Old Hetty said: She is up early.

Mary Baker said: She came up at the small sound and would not go down again.

Old Hetty said: It is the day.

Mary Baker said: It is the day.

She sat down at the corner of the kitchen settle with the one-year-old on her lap and gave her the breast under the open lacing of the day-gown. The one-year-old fed in the slow morning way she fed at this hour, half-drowsing back into sleep against her mother's collarbone, her small fingers opening and closing on the edge of the gown. She had been weaning across the spring; the morning feed was the one feed Mary Baker had not taken away from her yet, because the morning feed was the one she had no reason to take away. The morning feed was its own thing.

The one-year-old fed.

Mary Baker counted, without choosing to, what was in the house this morning. The two older girls in the trundle upstairs. The one-year-old at her breast. Gideon at the Caswell grant. Old Hetty at the hearth. Young George out at the lot already with the milk-cow. The black-and-white dog asleep under the kitchen settle at her feet — she could feel his warmth against the side of her shoe. The kettle on its hook over the banked coals beginning to make the early sound a kettle makes ten minutes before it will sing. The flour-barrel under the long counter, three-quarters full from Tuesday's milling. The bacon-flitch on the hook in the chimney corner, cut down to a third. The cold ham at the meat-safe in the lean-to, half a pound left from Sunday. The eggs Old Hetty had brought in last evening, eleven of them, in the willow basket by the dry-sink. The corn-meal in the painted tin on the high shelf, almost out — to be milled again on Monday.

She did not count any of this in words.

She knew it the way she knew the breathing of the child against her collarbone — by the body, without sentences.

(She had, at fifteen, counted the household in sentences. She had written lists for her mother on slips of paper at the back of her mother's ledger — *flour, salt, three pewter plates, the lavender, the second pair of stockings* — and she had said the lists over to herself walking from the lean-to to the parlor and back so that she would not forget any of them. She did not write the lists anymore. She had stopped writing them somewhere in 1782 or 1783 without noticing she had stopped. She had not, until this morning, noticed that she had stopped noticing.

She thought, this morning, about the child at her collarbone.)

The one-year-old finished her feed and pulled her face back from the breast and looked at her mother and made the small grave look she made when she was full. The look was not a smile. The look was the look of a person who has had what she needed and is now considering the day ahead. The look was new in the last two weeks. Mary Baker had not seen it before the close of June.

Mary Baker said into her ear: Good morning, Nancy.

She said it in the voice she used for the one-year-old, which was not the voice she used for the two older girls and not the voice she used for Gideon and not the voice she used for her mother. The voice was its own voice. The voice belonged to the one child it spoke to.

Nancy put her hand on her mother's mouth.

Mary Baker held the hand there for the count of one breath and then took it down.

She laced the gown at the side and stood up. She carried Nancy to the long counter under the east window and set her on her hip and lifted down the wooden bowl her own mother had carved her name into at the bottom of when she had been a child of three. Sarah Vass had given the bowl to Mary Baker the spring after Sarah's birth. The bowl had passed from Sarah to Mildred Baker at fourteen months and from Mildred Baker to Nancy at twelve months four weeks ago. The bowl had Mary Baker's own childhood name in her mother's hand cut into the underside — *Polly* — and below it the date, 1767. The bowl was twenty-one years carved.

She poured a quarter-cup of the cold porridge from yesterday's pot into the bowl and warmed it with two spoonfuls of new milk from the morning jug on the dry-sink and put a dab of butter in the middle. She carried Nancy and the bowl to the kitchen table and sat with the child on her lap and fed her the porridge with the horn spoon.

The first light came up at the east window behind them.

Old Hetty took the kettle off the hook and poured the boiling water through the tea-leaves in the brown pot.

Mary Baker said: Hetty, Mr. Johnson said he would take a cold dinner at the rail and not come back to the house until the supper. There will be us four to the dinner.

Old Hetty said: I will do a hominy and the cold ham and a corn-bread.

Mary Baker said: That will do.

Old Hetty said: And the little one, will she eat the hominy.

Mary Baker said: She will eat what we put in front of her by now. She is past the age for being asked.

Old Hetty said: It is the day for her.

Mary Baker said: It is.

She did not say any more about the day. Old Hetty did not say any more either. The saying of it twice between the two of them was as far as the saying went. The kitchen-bound knowing of Nancy's first year was not the kind of knowing that wanted sentences.

(Mary Baker's own first birthday had been the third of September 1765, in the front room at Lunenburg, with her mother Sarah Vass at twenty and her father Baker DeGraffenreid at twenty-one and her grandfather Tscharner at forty-two riding down from the upper place. Sarah had told her the story when she had been six. Sarah had told her she had carried her out to the well-stoop in her

mother's arms and they had stood for a long minute and looked at the September sky and Sarah had said *you have lived a year* and Mary Baker had answered with the babble of a one-year-old. The story had been Sarah's story, not hers. She did not remember the September sky. She remembered her mother telling her about the September sky.

She would not tell Nancy this story for some years yet. Sarah had waited until Mary Baker had been six.)

Sarah came down the back stair at half past five with Mildred Baker behind her on the second tread.

Sarah said: I heard Nancy.

Mary Baker said: She is at the table with me.

Sarah came around the corner of the door and stopped at the door and looked at her mother and her little sister at the table. Mildred Baker came around the corner of the door behind her and went straight to the kitchen settle and climbed up onto it without saying anything and put her thumb in her mouth. Mildred Baker did the thumb when she had just come out of sleep. She would put it down by the time the porridge was in front of her.

Sarah said: Is Nancy eating.

Mary Baker said: She is eating the porridge from yesterday.

Sarah said: I will eat the porridge from yesterday too.

Mary Baker said: You will have new porridge. Hetty is putting it on.

Sarah said: Then I will have new.

She came across the kitchen and stood at her mother's elbow and looked at Nancy in the lap and at the bowl with *Polly* and *1767* cut into the underside that she could not see from where she was standing but that she knew was there. She put her hand on Nancy's foot. Nancy did not take her face out of the bowl. Sarah held the foot for a moment and let go and went to the settle and climbed up beside her sister.

The two older girls sat on the settle in their nightshifts and waited.

The first light from the east window was on Mildred Baker's hair where she had not braided it for the night and it had come loose and was the colour her father's hair had been at three. The first light at Sarah's hair was on the small brown plait that had stayed in across the night. Sarah was four years and nine months old. Sarah was good at her hair.

Mary Baker fed Nancy the last spoonful of porridge.

She wiped Nancy's mouth with the corner of her apron.

She set the bowl on the table.

She said to the two on the settle: Up to the room and dress. The blue gown for Sarah today. The yellow for Mildred Baker. Stockings the cotton, both of you, it will be hot. I will come up at the count of a minute and do the hair.

Sarah said: Yes ma'am.

Mildred Baker took her thumb out of her mouth and said: Yes ma'am.

The two went out the kitchen door and up the back stair. Their feet on the treads were the small uneven feet of a four-year-old and a two-year-old going up the stair the way they went up it every morning. Mary Baker listened to the sound until it stopped at the upstairs hall.

She stood up at the table with Nancy on her hip.

She carried the bowl to the dry-sink and rinsed it under the dipper of cold water Old Hetty kept at the side for the morning rinses and dried it on the towel and set it back on the long counter. The underside of the bowl read *Polly 1767* against the wood of the counter. She did not turn it over to look. She knew it was there.

She said to Old Hetty: I will go up to do the hair.

Old Hetty said: I have the porridge in a minute, ma'am.

Mary Baker said: We will be down in ten.

She carried Nancy on her hip out of the kitchen and up the back stair.

The morning at her right side at the east window of the back stair was the morning at this latitude in the middle of July as it came up over the cleared field. The light at the window was the colour of new straw. The cleared field below the window had the corn at its third week of laying-by, the corn standing tall enough now that a man walking down the rows was visible only at the shoulders and the head, the dark green of the leaves taking the early light and giving back a paler green. Beyond the cleared field at the head of the lane the standing oak was the oak it had been at sixty years and would be at a hundred. Beyond the oak the road went north to her mother's house and south to the river and then south again to Halifax.

The child on her hip was the third daughter she had carried up this back stair this summer.

The child on her hip was a year old today.

She went up the stair to do the hair.

The Letter

The mid-morning of Wednesday the ninth of January, 1788, came in through the parlor window in the gray light a January morning in the Carolina piedmont came in by, and Mary Baker, at her writing-desk in the parlor in her day-gown and the wool shawl she had taken from the peg behind the parlor door when she had come down from feeding the small one in the cradle, set the inkwell to her right hand and the quill across the inkwell and the small flat of sand on the top corner of the desk and her grandfather's last letter on her left.

The letter had come on the Tuesday post-rider three weeks ago. It had been written at Lunenburg on the fourth of December. It had been folded for the road in the way her grandfather folded letters — once long-ways and twice cross-ways and then sealed along the long edge with the wax stamp he used for the household correspondence — and it had come down the post-route through

Hairston's Cut and across the line into Halifax and on to Wentworth at the new courthouse, and from Wentworth a boy who rode the spur down to the cleared field on the black mare had brought it the next morning. She had read it twice when it had come and once more the next day. She had put it in the parlor desk's right drawer with the household papers. She had not answered it.

She had not answered it because the question in it was not a question she had been ready to answer in December.

The cradle stood against the south wall of the parlor where she had moved it the second week of December when the cold had come in earnest and the small bedroom at the back of the house had grown too cold to hold a child of two weeks old. Ursula was in it now, asleep, twenty-seven days old as of this morning, having fed at six and again at nine, with the long sleep between the nine feed and the noon feed that the small one had begun to take across the past week. Mary Baker had watched her go down after the nine feed and had counted the breathing as she always did, the way her own mother had taught her to count it when Sarah was new, and had carried the small one to the cradle and had laid her on her side with the small linen folded under her cheek the way she liked, and had come to the desk.

The two older girls were in the back room with the wool. Sarah had been at the carding since after breakfast; Mildred Baker had been beside her with the smaller card the dancing-master at Lunenburg had given Mary Baker the year of her own ten and that Mary Baker had carried south at her marriage. Nancy was in the kitchen with Old Hetty. Mary Baker could hear Nancy's voice from the kitchen the way a mother hears a three-year-old's voice in the next room — the rising of it when something was happening and the falling of it when the happening was past — and she knew without listening for it that Old Hetty had begun the bread.

Gideon had ridden out at sun-up to the south field with the older Whitaker boy. The boy was twelve and was learning the work; Gideon had been bringing him along since the fall. They would be back by noon. The cleared field's eighty acres had been cut and stacked at the close of the corn-pulling in October, and the winter's work was the rail-mending and the salt-pork rendering and the clearing along the south edge that Gideon had been opening across the slow months, an acre or two at a time. Today was a rail morning. Mary Baker could see the line of the south rail from the parlor window, two hundred yards across the cleared ground, where the two figures had been bent over it since the gray light had come up.

She set her hand on the inkwell and uncapped it.

She unfolded her grandfather's letter and put it under her left hand on the desk.

She read it once more.

It was a December letter of three pages. The first page was the household at Lunenburg — Vincent at Halifax going on twenty-five, well and unmarried, riding

up to Lunenburg for the November court-day and returning south; the field at Lunenburg going into winter with the usual provision; the slow ache in her grandfather's right hand that he reported as he reported most things, plainly, without comment. The second page was the district news. The Macartys on the east place had had a son in October. The Pleasants girl had married a Petersburg man. The Reverend Father Johnson was wintering at Halifax with the older sister and was not well, though her grandfather did not say what was not well about him. The Bible was on the parlor desk where it had been for forty-five years.

The third page was the question.

Her grandfather wrote it on the third page in the plain hand he used for the things that wanted thinking about and not the formal hand he used for the entries. He wrote: *Mary Baker, the talk at Wentworth's court-day, when Gideon was there last, was for or against the ratification of the federal Constitution. I read in the Virginia Gazette and in the Petersburg paper of the question's standing in the states and of the ten that have ratified now and of the question's coming to North Carolina in the new year. I would have your sense of the country at Rockingham. Is the talk for or against. Is the field at Wentworth, when Gideon is there, a field that knows what it wants.*

She had read that paragraph the first time in December and had not known what to write back. She had read it the second time and had still not known. She had put the letter in the right drawer and had carried the question in her head across the close of December and the opening of January — across Christmas at the cleared field, across the long quiet between Christmas and the New Year, across the first week of the new year when she had been by the cradle in the parlor and in the kitchen with Old Hetty and back at the desk going over the household ledger for the close-of-year — and the question had not resolved itself in her head into a sentence she could put on paper.

She did not know what the talk at Wentworth was. Gideon went to Wentworth on court-days four times in the year, and he came home with news, and the news he came home with was the news a man brings home from a courthouse afternoon — the price of corn at the Petersburg market and the names of the men who had been at the court and who was sick up-country and who was riding to Halifax in the new week — and she had asked him over supper the Wednesday before Christmas what they had been saying about the federal Constitution. Gideon had eaten three more bites of pork from the platter before he had answered. He had said: *They are saying many things, Mary Baker. They are saying it is a fine document and they are saying it is the work of the Tidewater men and not the up-country men, and they are saying the new federal courts will eat the state courts and they are saying the new federal post will be a better post than the state post is. They are saying many things. I cannot tell you which thing the country will settle on. I am not sure the country has decided.* And he had eaten the three more bites of pork and had not said anything else.

She had thought about that across the long evening. She had thought about it by the cradle the next morning and in the kitchen with Old Hetty across the days after. She had not arrived at a position. She did not know whether the country was for or against the federal Constitution. She did not know whether Wentworth's court-day was for or against. She did not know whether *she* was for or against, in the sense her grandfather was asking, which was the sense of a man of sixty-five at Lunenburg who reads two newspapers and sits at the parlor desk in the evenings and turns these things over.

So she would not write to her grandfather about it. She would write to him about the keeping. The keeping was what she knew.

She took up the quill and dipped it.

She wrote the date across the top of the first sheet — *Wednesday 9 January 1788, Rockingham County* — in the small clear hand she had been writing the household ledger in for eight years and the letters to Lunenburg in for six.

She wrote the salutation: *Honored Grandfather*.

She wrote the body of the letter the way the body of a letter from a granddaughter to a grandfather wanted to be written, which was as the household's report up the post-route to the keeper of the record at the other end. She wrote that Ursula had come safely in the small hour after eleven on the night of the thirteenth of December, six pounds and eight ounces by the kitchen scale, twenty inches by the tailor's tape — *I have written the line so you may make the entry when you are next at the Bible*. She wrote that Ursula was in the cradle in the parlor for the winter and was feeding well and was sleeping as a one-month child sleeps. She wrote that Sarah was at her carding and could card a pound in an hour now, which was the rate her own mother had carded at by the same age. She wrote that Mildred Baker was beside Sarah with the smaller card and was learning. She wrote that Nancy was in the kitchen with Old Hetty and was the household's small noise. She wrote that Gideon was at the south rail this morning with the older Whitaker boy and that the cleared field was at its winter work. She wrote that her mother was on the seat to the east and was well; she had seen her on the New Year's afternoon and they had sat together in the parlor across an hour. She wrote that the corn in the loft was holding and would carry the household to the spring milling without strain.

She did not write about the question on the third page of her grandfather's letter.

She closed the body of the letter at the middle of the second sheet, having said what she had to say of the keeping, and she set the quill down across the inkwell and looked at the page.

There was a half-page left on the second sheet.

She did not need it for the keeping. The keeping was on the page.

She could close the letter with her name and the place and the date and seal it for the Tuesday post-rider, and the letter would go up the route through Hairston's Cut to her grandfather at Lunenburg, and the question on the third

page of his December letter would sit unanswered in his right drawer, and he would understand from her silence on the question — he was sixty-five, he was the keeper, he read both papers — that she had not had a position to offer him.

She took up the quill.

She thought about what came next.

She had thought once, on her wedding morning at fifteen in her mother's borrowed house on the north side of the Dan, at the dark hour at the desk before the candle had been blown out and her mother's bare feet had come down to the parlor floor, of two words she had not said aloud and had not written. The two words had stayed in her head for eight years and twenty-two days. They had stayed in her head through the births of four daughters and the burying of none and through the small daily run of a household that had moved from her mother's seat to Gideon's cleared eighty under her mother's deed of attorney, and through the slow building of the parlor and the kitchen and the back-room and the lean-to and the lot, and through eight winters and eight summers and the eight years of the marriage that the morning of the wedding had been the beginning of. The two words had not been said and had not been written. They had been the way the body had carried the marriage and the keeping and the children when the mind had not yet thought to. They had been the phrase under the phrase.

She did not know why she would write them now.

She dipped the quill again.

She wrote, on the half-page left at the second sheet, beneath the close of the keeping-letter, in the same small clear hand she had been writing the body of the letter in, in lowercase and without a period:

we continue

She wrote her name below it, in full, in the hand the household ledger had been carrying for eight years:

Mary Baker Johnson

She looked at the page.

The two words sat above her name on the half-page. They were the size of the rest of the writing on the page. They did not have a flourish or a capital or a punctuation. They sat on the page the way a thing that has been carried for a long time sits on a page the first time it is set down.

She did not think anything about them.

She blotted the page with the flat of sand. She poured the sand back into the small dish on the corner of the desk. She folded the two sheets once long-ways and twice cross-ways the way her grandfather folded letters and the way she folded letters now. She sealed the long edge with the small wax stamp Gideon had had cut for her at Petersburg in their second year — the J at the center for Johnson, the small flourish on the right that the cutter had added without asking and that she had kept because she had liked it — and she set the letter on the corner of the desk where the Tuesday post would carry it the week after.

She sat at the desk a moment longer.

The parlor was the parlor it had been at the start of the morning. The cradle against the south wall. The small breathing from inside it. Nancy's voice from the kitchen. Sarah and Mildred Baker in the back room with the wool. The gray light at the window. The corn-stubble of the cleared ground out the window to the south, and the two figures by the south rail along the line of the eighty.

She thought about her cousin Henry at the up-country store.

Henry kept a trade-store at the head of the Smith River three days' ride west, where the post-route ran out and the Cherokee road came down through the gap. He was her mother's first cousin on the Vass side, a man of forty-some at the store since the close of the war, who had carried the household's salt and the household's iron from his store for the four years they had been on the cleared field. He extended credit at the store the way a country trade-store extended credit — in NC paper at the season's price, or in trade at the year's settlement.

She had read in Tscharner's December letter that the federal Constitution had been ratified in ten of the thirteen states and that the question was coming to North Carolina in the new year. She had read in the *Petersburg Gazette* Gideon had brought home from Wentworth in November that the paper currency of North Carolina was trading at three to one against the Virginia paper along the up-country line. She had heard Old Hetty say, the Tuesday before Christmas, that salt at the river had gone up by a quarter in the close of November.

She did not put these three things into a sentence in her head.

She took up a second sheet of foolscap from the left drawer and dipped the quill again.

She wrote:

Henry — for the spring settlement. Do not extend on my account this season in paper. Only in trade. I will send the surplus from the back field after the milling and you will hold the credit against the year's salt and iron at the trade price. If the paper hardens I will come to you in May and we will recount. — M. B. Johnson

She blotted it. She folded it once. She did not seal it; Gideon would carry it to Wentworth on the next court-day at the close of January and would hand it to Henry's rider who came in from the river on the second Friday. It would go up the river road by Friday evening. Henry would have it before the close of the month.

She did not think anything about the second letter either.

She set the second letter on top of the first on the corner of the desk and capped the inkwell and laid the quill across the top of the inkwell and pushed the chair back from the desk.

She stood up from the desk.

Ursula made the small sound from the cradle that the small one made before she was fully awake. Mary Baker turned at the sound and went the four steps across the parlor to the cradle and put her hand on the back of the small one inside it and waited for the breathing to go long. The breathing went long. She stood by the cradle a moment longer with her hand on the back of the child and looked, through the parlor window on the south, at the two figures by the south

rail of the eighty in the gray light of the January mid-morning, who were her husband and the older Whitaker boy at the rail-mending in the eighth year of the marriage and the third year on the cleared field.

She took her hand off the cradle.

She went to the kitchen to see what Nancy was doing.

* * *

Interlude — The Constitution in North Carolina

The federal Constitution that Tscharner DeGraffenreid had asked his granddaughter about in his December letter of 1787 had been signed at Philadelphia on the seventeenth of September of that year and sent out to the states for ratification across the autumn. Delaware ratified first on the seventh of December, eleven days before Tscharner sat at his parlor desk at Lunenburg to write the December letter. Pennsylvania, New Jersey, Georgia, and Connecticut followed across December and the first week of January 1788. By the morning Mary Baker sat down at her own writing-desk at Rockingham, six of the thirteen states had ratified. Four more — Massachusetts, Maryland, South Carolina, and New Hampshire — would ratify across the spring and early summer, bringing the count to ten and crossing the nine-state threshold the new federal government required. The Constitution would take effect.

North Carolina would not ratify with the ten. The Hillsborough Convention, sitting from the twenty-first of July to the fourth of August of 1788 — six months and twelve days after the morning of Mary Baker's letter — would decline to ratify by a vote of one hundred eighty-four to eighty-three. The state would not ratify until the Fayetteville Convention of the twenty-first of November of 1789, sixteen months after Hillsborough and twenty-two months after Mary Baker's letter. For those fourteen months between the two conventions North Carolina would sit outside the federal Union — its currency the unbacked state paper, its mails outside the new federal post, its courts outside the new federal jurisdiction. The Rockingham piedmont would feel the absence at the trade-store and the courthouse and the post-route, in ways the household at the cleared field would price one fragment at a time across the long winter and the spring and the summer that followed.

Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson, sitting at her writing-desk on the morning of the ninth of January of 1788, would not have known any of this. She would not have known that the Hillsborough vote would go against ratification, nor that the Fayetteville vote sixteen months later would go for it. She would not have known what the country was about to decide. She wrote the letter she could write with what she knew, and she signed it as she had begun to sign letters that morning, and she sealed it and set it on the corner of the desk for the Tuesday post.

* * *

The Drover

The kitchen door at the back of the cleared eighty stood open on the afternoon of Friday the third of June, 1791, and the early-June light from the cleared ground came in across the kitchen floor in a long bar that ran from the threshold to the hearth and caught the edge of the table where Old Hetty had set out the bread and the salt-pork and the buttermilk. The day had come up dry and warm. The spring planting had been finished into the corn-rows along the east field the week before. The cleared ground out the kitchen door was green with the corn at six weeks and ankle-high. The flax along the south edge was past its blooming. The piedmont farm in early June was past the breaking of new ground and was at the long tending the season turned to next, and Mary Baker had been at the parlor desk after the noon dinner with the spring settlement ledger open in front of her and Sarah on the stool at her right with the small slate.

She had been showing Sarah how the credit-and-debit column at the right side of the page took the entries from the left. Sarah was ten years and eight months and would be doing the ledger in earnest by twelve and carrying it by fifteen, the way Mary Baker had carried her own mother's by the same age. The lesson today had been the column of the spring's pork rendering against the credit Henry held at the up-country store. Sarah had got the addition on the third try. The first two she had carried the wrong digit. The third she had carried the right one, and Mary Baker had said nothing about the first two, because the first two were not the lesson; the third was.

Sumner came in by the kitchen door at the hour past two, with Old Hetty calling him in from the lot.

Mary Baker heard the call from the parlor. She set the quill across the inkwell. She told Sarah to come in fifteen minutes and finish the column. She rose from the desk and went through the back room and into the kitchen, untying her apron from the waist and tying it again at the knot she used when company was at the back door.

Sumner was a Halifax man of forty or thereabouts, a drover who had come up the post-route through Hairston's Cut on the chestnut gelding she had seen tied at the lot-rail through the kitchen window. She had seen him through twice before — once in the fall of the year before, on his way south to the cattle-sale at Halifax, and once in the early spring of this year on his way back up to Lunenburg with the cattle-money in his belt — and she knew his name and his route and the kin he had at Halifax who connected him to the Wades on her grandfather's east place. He had a long brown face and a road-coat the dust of three days on the route had got into and a hat he had hung on the peg at the kitchen door when Old Hetty had called him in. He took the bench at the kitchen table where Old Hetty pointed him and he washed his hands at the basin Old Hetty set in front of him

and he ate the bread and the salt-pork and drank the buttermilk in the unhurried way a man eats who has eaten at three kitchens up the route in the past two days and knows there will be a fourth before he sleeps.

Mary Baker stood at the kitchen with her hand on the back of the bench across from him and asked after the route.

He told her. He had come up from Halifax on the Wednesday. He had laid over at the Wade place on the Wednesday night. He had come on the post-road through the Cut on the Thursday and had slept on a settle at Hairston's. He had come on the spur down to her gate this morning and would go on north to Lunenburg through the close of the day and would lay over there a night and would go on west to the up-country store at the head of the Smith River on the Sunday or the Monday. Henry the store-keeper was a man he traded with twice in the year and would trade with again on this trip; he had a fold of bills in the belt from the spring cattle-sale that he meant to put down against Henry's iron account.

She nodded. She did not say anything about Henry.

He drank the buttermilk and set the cup down and looked at her across the table with the comfortable steadiness of a man who knows what he has to tell the household at his next stop. He said the thing he had been carrying. He said: *Mrs. Johnson, I was through Halifax in the March. I saw your brother Vincent and Martha at the house there. They were well. The child was born some weeks before. A boy. The name and the day I cannot give you; I was at the house an hour and not at the entry-Bible. The boy was thriving. Martha was up and about the house. Your brother was at the field. I told him I would be coming up the route in the early summer and would name him at the houses I came to.*

Mary Baker did not answer for a count.

Then she said: *I thank you for the carrying of it, Mr. Sumner.*

He bent his head over the cup once, the way a man bends his head when an errand has been done.

She said: *Mother is on the east place. She would want to know.*

He said: *I had thought to ride by the east place tomorrow before the Cut. Mrs. DeGraffenreid was well in the spring.*

She said: *She is well now. I saw her Sunday.*

He bent his head over the cup again. He went back to the salt-pork.

Old Hetty was at the hearth with her back to the table, doing something with the next thing on her own afternoon — Mary Baker did not look. Nancy was somewhere in the lot with the older Whitaker boy who came in some afternoons; Mary Baker could hear her voice from outside the kitchen door. Ursula and Polly Baker were down in the parlor in the long afternoon nap the small ones still took. Mildred Baker was in the back room with the wool. Sarah was at the parlor desk over the column.

Sumner ate.

Mary Baker took down the small writing-board from the shelf above the kitchen window where Old Hetty kept the household marketing-slate. She did not need it for the words she was holding in her head, but she set it on the table and ran her hand across the slate-face the way her mother had run her hand across the slate-face when she had been thinking through something across the kitchen table, and she said to Sumner, while he was eating: *What did the man at the store say about the salt at the spring.*

Sumner finished what he had in his mouth. He said: *Eighteen shillings the bushel, the time I was through. Henry had said so on the first Tuesday in May, when I had stopped there going down. The freight from Petersburg had been on time across April and the salt was at the May figure. I had no cause to ask again on the way up.*

She said: *Eighteen.*

He said: *Eighteen the bushel. I am near sure.*

She said: *I thank you.*

He nodded.

He finished the bread. He finished the salt-pork. He drank what was left of the buttermilk and set the cup upside down on the rim of the plate the way a man on the route sets a cup when he has finished. He said he would be on by half past, because he wanted Lunenburg before the dark. He thanked Old Hetty for the kitchen. He stood up from the bench and took his hat from the peg and put it on.

Mary Baker walked with him out the kitchen door to the lot.

The chestnut was tied at the rail in the shade of the lot's elm. Sumner went to him and uncinched and re-cinched the saddle and put his hand on the gelding's neck the unhurried way a man on the route checks his horse. The gelding stood quiet. Sumner mounted. He bent down from the saddle at the rail and said: *I am obliged for the kitchen, Mrs. Johnson. If there is a thing you would have me carry up to your grandfather at Lunenburg, I will carry it.*

Mary Baker thought for a count. She said: *Tell my grandfather that the household is well. Tell him I will write at the Tuesday post.*

He said: *I will tell him so.*

He touched the brim of his hat and turned the gelding and rode up the spur to the post-road at the easy walking pace a man on the route used in the long-light afternoon when there was no hurry on the day. Mary Baker stood at the lot-rail and watched him to the bend in the spur where the chestnuts closed over the road, and she watched the dust come up under the gelding's hooves where the road dust had dried in the afternoon, and the dust hung in the bar of light the way road-dust hangs in piedmont air on a dry June day, and she did not move from the lot-rail until he had gone behind the chestnuts. Then she went back into the kitchen.

Old Hetty was wiping the table. The board was where Mary Baker had left it.

Mary Baker said: *Hetty, thank you for the kitchen.*

Old Hetty said: *Mr. Sumner was glad of it.*

Mary Baker took the board and went back through the back room and into the parlor.

Sarah was at the desk on the stool, the column finished in the small even hand Mary Baker had been teaching her to write a number in, the credit and debit balanced as they ought to be. Sarah looked up. Mary Baker said the column was right, and Sarah might go and see what Nancy was at in the lot, and Sarah went, in the unhurried obedient way the older girl had been moving across the long spring.

Mary Baker sat at the desk.

She took up a fresh sheet of foolscap from the left drawer and set it on the desk. She uncapped the inkwell and took up the quill. She wrote the date across the top — *Friday 3 June 1791, Rockingham County* — in the small clear hand. She wrote the salutation: *Honored Mother*.

She wrote the body of the letter in eight or nine sentences. She wrote that Sumner the drover from Halifax had been at the kitchen this afternoon on his way up to Lunenburg. She wrote that he had seen Vincent and Martha at Halifax in the March. They were well. The child had been born some weeks before — a boy. She wrote that Sumner had not been able to give the date or the name; he had been at the house an hour and not at the entry-Bible. She wrote that Martha was up and about the house and Vincent was at the field. She wrote: *Mother, when you write to Grandfather at Lunenburg, ask him to make the entry for Vincent's child when the day and the name are firm. The man Sumner could not carry them*. She wrote that Sumner would be at the east place tomorrow on his way through the Cut and would tell what he had told her. She wrote that the household here was well, the corn at six weeks, the four girls and the small one all in their places, Gideon at the south field with the older Whitaker boy. She wrote: *I send this by Old Hetty's grandson Daniel, who will bring it by the east place this evening, so you have it before Sumner*. She closed it: *Your daughter, Mary Baker Johnson*. She signed.

She blotted the page with the flat of sand.

She folded the sheet once long-ways and once cross-ways and sealed it with the small wax stamp.

She set the sealed letter on the corner of the desk where Daniel would find it when he came to the kitchen for it at four.

She did not write to Lunenburg. She had said she would write at the Tuesday post. Sumner would carry the word ahead, and the Tuesday letter would carry the household's hand. The letter up to her grandfather would be the season's letter of the keeping. It could wait the four days.

She took up the spring settlement ledger and turned to the page where Sarah had been working.

She wrote, at the line below the day's entry where she had been writing the household's marketing-figures across April and May: *Salt, eighteen the bushel at the store, per Sumner the drover, 3 June 1791*. She wrote it in the ledger because the figure was now the one she had set against the credit Henry held for the

year's salt and iron. The fall salt-buy would be six bushels for the year, the way the household bought it. Six bushels at eighteen the bushel would be a hundred and eight shillings. She had been carrying twenty the bushel in her head since the close-of-April figure Gideon had brought home from the courthouse — the figure he had got from a man at Wentworth who had been through Henry's that month — and twenty had been the figure she had set against the credit Henry held for her. Eighteen was the better news. The household would be on the right side of the credit by twelve shillings on the year's salt against what she had been holding for.

She did not write that recognition into the ledger. The recognition was not the ledger's business. The ledger's business was the figure.

She closed the ledger and set it on the corner of the desk above the day's letter and capped the inkwell and laid the quill across the inkwell.

She sat at the desk a moment.

The June afternoon light had moved across the floor of the parlor while she had been writing and was now on the far edge of the carpet where the small one's cradle had been in the winter and was now folded against the wall. Polly Baker was on a small pallet at the south wall in the long afternoon nap; Ursula was on the settle by the cold hearth in hers. Mary Baker could hear Mildred Baker in the back room turning the wool. From the lot she could hear Nancy's voice and Sarah's voice and the older Whitaker boy's — the three of them at something at the lot's south corner; she could not make out what. The household was at the long quiet of a piedmont afternoon between dinner and supper at the close of the spring.

She thought about Vincent and Martha at Halifax with the new boy.

She thought about her grandfather at Lunenburg, who would not know the boy was on the world until either Sumner reached him this evening or the Tuesday letter reached him next week. She thought about the entry her grandfather would want to make in the Bible when the day and the name came firm. She thought that he would not press her mother for the date but would wait for it, the way he waited for the things he waited for, and would make the entry when the entry could be made.

She thought about Henry at the up-country store, who would be receiving Sumner on the Sunday or the Monday with the spring cattle-money and would put it down against the iron account. She thought that Henry would have the right salt-figure as of this afternoon. She thought that she would have it from Sumner herself on his return down the route in five or six weeks if she had any cause to want it again, but the eighteen the bushel was the figure she was working from now, and she had set it in the ledger, and the eighteen would stand until something replaced it.

She did not know that the eighteen had stood, at the store, only across April. She did not know that the freight from Petersburg had come late at the close of May because the road through Person County had washed in a Tuesday rain, and

the salt at the store had gone up to twenty-three the bushel on the third of June — the same day she was writing eighteen into the ledger — and would stay at twenty-three across the rest of the summer. She did not know that Sumner, riding north this afternoon, was carrying the April figure to her in good faith and was a month behind on it without knowing.

She closed the ledger.

She went to see what Nancy and Sarah were at, in the lot.

* * *

Six weeks later, on the afternoon of Friday the fifteenth of July, 1791, a second drover came up the spur from the post-road. He was a younger man, Mary Baker had not seen before, a man named Halsey who was riding for the Halifax cattle-buyer and was coming north with the summer's first drive. He stopped at the kitchen door at the hour before three. He ate at the kitchen table the way Sumner had eaten six weeks before. He talked about the route. He talked about Petersburg and the road through Person County that had washed in May and had been mended in June and was passable now but not at the speed the spring freight had wanted. He talked about Henry at the up-country store, where he had stopped going down to Halifax the week before. He named, at one point in the conversation, the salt-price at Henry's. He said: *Twenty-three the bushel. The freight came late through May. Henry has had it at twenty-three since the third of June.*

Mary Baker did not move.

She said: *Twenty-three.*

He said: *Twenty-three, since the third of June.*

She said: *I had it at eighteen on the third of June.*

He thought a moment. He said: *Eighteen had been the April figure. The third of June, when the freight came in late, was when Henry put it up.*

She said: *I had a man through here on the third of June who had it at eighteen.*

Halsey said: *He had had it on his way down. He had not had it on the way up. The salt was at twenty-three by the time he was at Hairston's, but the man would not have known unless he had gone back through Henry's.*

She said: *I see.*

He went on eating.

She stood at the kitchen with her hand on the bench-back, the way she had stood at it on the afternoon of Friday the third of June, and did not say what she was working out in her head. Six bushels at twenty-three the bushel was a hundred and thirty-eight shillings. She had been holding for a hundred and eight shillings the year's salt. The household was now thirty shillings on the wrong side of the credit she had set against Henry's account, against the figure that had been in her head. She had been working all of May and the first half of June and three weeks of July from the eighteen, and the figure had been wrong since the third of

June, and she had set it into the ledger on the third of June after Sumner had told her so in good faith, and Sumner had not known. The ledger had been wrong since the third of June. The spring settlement she had built around it had been wrong since the third of June. She would have to recount.

She thought, standing at the bench-back, that the thirty shillings was the cost. The cost was small. The household would absorb it. The corn would carry. The fall pork would carry. The wool would carry the way wool always carried. Gideon need not be told; the household ledger was hers and the figure was hers and the recounting was hers.

She said to Halsey: *I am obliged to you.*

He bent his head over the cup.

She walked him out to the lot when he had finished. She watched him to the bend in the spur the way she had watched Sumner. Then she went back into the kitchen and through the back room and into the parlor and sat at the desk.

She took the ledger from the right drawer. She opened it to the third of June. She did not strike the eighteen through. She wrote, in the line below the eighteen, in the same small even hand: *Salt at the store at twenty-three the bushel since 3 June, per Halsey 15 July 1791. The April figure had not held.*

She closed the ledger.

She set it back in the right drawer.

She sat at the desk for a count of perhaps half a minute and looked out the south window of the parlor at the cleared ground, where the corn was at the eleven-week and was waist-high along the rows, and where Gideon could be made out at the south fence with the older Whitaker boy who was thirteen now and putting in a full hand on the half-days, and she thought that the afternoon was the afternoon a Friday afternoon in the middle of July had a right to be. She thought that she would not say anything about the salt to Gideon. She thought that the thirty shillings was the cost of having had Sumner through on the third of June and not having had Halsey, and that the cost of having had Sumner was also the carrying of the news of Vincent and Martha's boy. She thought that the carrying of the news of the boy was worth the thirty shillings on the salt many times over, and that she would not have traded the one for the other had the trade been offered, but that the trade had not been offered: the same man had been both the carrying of the news and the wrong figure on the salt, and the keeping had taken both as the man had carried them and would absorb both as the keeping absorbed what came in by the kitchen door.

She did not put that thought into a sentence in her head either.

She stood up from the desk.

She went through the back room and into the kitchen, where Old Hetty was at the supper-pot, and she went out the kitchen door to the lot to see what Nancy was at in the long July afternoon.

* * *

The Lamp at the Reading

The supper had been cleared by half past six on the evening of Tuesday the twenty-fourth of January, 1792, and Mary Baker had carried the last of the dishes through to the kitchen and had set the children to their evening tasks and had come back to the parlor and built up the fire and lit the lamp on the parlor table before she had let herself think about the paper Gideon had ridden home with from Wentworth.

The paper was folded in his coat pocket. The coat was on the peg by the parlor door. He had come in at four with the dusk already gathering along the south rail of the cleared field and the cold close on his face and the chestnut blowing in the lot, and he had taken the coat off and hung it and had said over his shoulder, *I have the Petersburg paper, Mary Baker. I will read it after supper.* He had not said what was in it. He had gone through to the back room to wash, and he had eaten his supper, and he had not said what was in it across the meal either, with Sarah and Mildred Baker either side of the table and Ursula on the bench beside him and the small one on Mary Baker's knee and Old Hetty going to and from the kitchen, and Mary Baker had known, by the not-saying, that what was in the paper was not the day's price-of-corn news or the names of the men who had been to the court.

She had asked, once, as the supper was clearing: *Was the court the usual.* And Gideon had said: *The court was the usual. The paper has the news from the upper country.* And he had not said anything else.

She had cleared the dishes. She had set Sarah to the dish-towel and Mildred Baker to the cup-shelf. She had carried Polly Baker upstairs and had set her in the cradle by the south window of the upstairs back room and had stood beside the cradle until the small one's breathing had gone long, and she had come down to the kitchen and had told Old Hetty to bring Nancy in from the back when she had finished the supper-pot and to put the small girls up. She had built the fire up in the parlor. She had set the lamp on the parlor table in the place she set it on winter evenings when the household had reading to do. She had pulled the parlor settle a little closer to the table. She had sat down in her own chair at the desk, where she could see the table and the settle without turning her head.

Sarah came in from the kitchen at a quarter past seven with her hair newly braided and the parlor robe over her day-gown and her hands carrying the workbasket from the back room. She had Mildred Baker behind her and Nancy holding the back of Mildred Baker's gown. The three of them came across the carpet and Mildred Baker climbed onto the settle and Nancy climbed up beside her and Sarah set the workbasket on the floor beside the settle and took the settle's right-hand end where she would have the lamp's light on her sewing.

Sarah was eleven years and three months and fifteen days. She had been doing the household's plain sewing across the autumn and was now beginning the better needlework her mother had been carrying her through across the

winter — the marking of the small one's caps with the worked letter, the hemming of the sheets on the small turn. Mildred Baker was nine years and two months and fourteen days. Mildred Baker was at the carding still; she did not sew the better work, but she was old enough now to sit by the lamp in the evenings and to be quiet while the older ones read or worked. Nancy was seven and a half. Nancy had a small slate on her lap and was writing her letters.

Gideon came in from the back room with the paper in his hand.

He took down his chair from beside the fire and set it on the parlor side of the table and sat down in it. He laid the paper on the table in front of him, folded the way the post-rider folded papers for the road. He took his reading-spectacles from the small case he kept inside the breast of his coat — he did not yet need them for the working scale but had begun to use them by lamp-light across the past two winters — and put them on. He unfolded the paper.

It was a Petersburg paper. *The Virginia Gazette and Petersburg Intelligencer* across the top in the heavy black type of the masthead. The date was the seventh of January, 1792. Seventeen days old. He had paid the boy three pence for it at the court and had brought it home for the household reading.

He looked across the table at Mary Baker.

He said: *The news from the western country is hard, Mary Baker. The federal force under General St. Clair was beaten badly at the upper Wabash on the fourth of November. The Gazette has the casualty list across two columns. I had heard the rumour at the court last week but had not had the names until tonight.*

Mary Baker did not answer for a count of perhaps three breaths.

Then she said: *Read it, Mr. Johnson.*

She said it in the voice she used by lamp-light in the evenings when the reading was the household's business and the children were gathered to listen and the saying was for all of them. She did not say it sharp. She did not say it soft. She said it the way her own mother had said *read it, Vincent* in the Lunenburg parlor in the December of 1781 when Vincent had come home from the war with the paper from Richmond and the news of Yorktown had been three months old and her mother had wanted the household to have it from a son's voice and not from her own.

Gideon read.

He read first the paragraph at the head of the column — the Gazette's plain account, dated from the Pittsburgh post: that General Arthur St. Clair, in command of a federal force of approximately fourteen hundred regulars and levies and militia, had been encamped on the upper Wabash some ninety miles north of Fort Washington on the night of the third of November; that the camp had been attacked at first light on the morning of the fourth by a force of Native warriors under the Miami chief Little Turtle and the Shawnee chief Blue Jacket, with Delaware and other contributions; that the engagement had run three hours; that the federal force had been broken and had been driven from the field; that the wounded who could not walk had been left to the field; that the federal

dead were not yet fully counted but were known to be above six hundred, with the wounded above two hundred; that General St. Clair had survived but was relieved of command pending the inquiry the President had called for; that the killed at the field were the heaviest loss of federal arms in any engagement with the Indian nations since the country had been a country.

He stopped a moment after the paragraph.

He took his spectacles off and wiped them on the linen on the table and put them back on.

He read the column.

The column was the casualty list by regiment, written out by the Gazette in the form the federal adjutant had printed it. Colonels first, then majors, then captains, then lieutenants and ensigns, then the sergeants and corporals and privates by company. Gideon read the column with the unhurried care of a man putting a name into the room because the name should be in a room somewhere. Colonel Oldham of the Kentucky militia, killed in the first volley. Major-General Richard Butler, second in command, killed on the line. Major Ferguson of the artillery, killed at the guns. Major Heart, killed. Major Clark, killed. Captain Bradford, killed. Captain Phelon, killed. Captain Kirkwood, killed on the line — *the Kirkwood who came through Hairston's Cut in the spring of 1789*, Gideon said, lifting his head from the page; *I had not known he had been to the Wabash*. He went back to the page. Captain Newman, killed. Captain Smith, killed. Captain Purdy, killed.

The lamp on the parlor table had been trimmed by Old Hetty at the close of the afternoon to the working height for the household's evening reading. The wick had been set to a quarter-inch above the brass collar. The flame at the wick was the steady yellow flame the lamp gave when the oil was at the line. Sarah, at the settle's right-hand end with her sewing in her lap and the lamp's light across the page of the worked letter on the small one's cap she was hemming, had her eyes on her work for the first dozen names and then had not had her eyes on her work, and her hands had gone still in her lap, and she had not put them back to the work, and she was looking past the lamp at her father's face across the table while he read.

(Sarah, at the settle on the night her father read out the casualty list from the upper Wabash, would remember the lamp going lower as he read — the wick burning down the oil at the well below the collar, the flame at the wick paling a little in the second hour without anyone trimming it — and would remember it again on the fourth of February 1809 in her own kitchen in Cumberland County, her own first daughter four days old asleep in the small carved cradle beside the hearth, when her husband would come in from the field with the Fayetteville paper and would read out across the kitchen table the names of men killed in some other federal engagement on some other frontier she would not be able to find on the map, and she would understand, then and not before, what her mother

had been carrying that winter at twenty-seven, at her own parlor lamp in Rockingham, without saying.)

Gideon read on.

He read the captains to the end of the column. He read the lieutenants — Spear, McMath, Boyd, Brock, Warren, Hopper. He read the ensigns. He read the sergeants. The list of the private soldiers was the longer part of the column, and Gideon read it at the same care, by the company-letter and the regimental designation, name by name, the way the adjutant had printed it. He did not skim. He did not pause for breath where the breaks fell. He read it as it had been printed. The reading took past eight o'clock.

Mildred Baker, at the settle, had put her head against Sarah's shoulder somewhere in the middle of the list of the privates. Nancy had set the small slate aside and had drawn her knees up under her gown and had her arms around them. Polly Baker was upstairs in the cradle. Ursula had been put up by Old Hetty with the others in the back. The fire in the grate had burned down to the bed of coals; Mary Baker had not got up to add the wood. The parlor was at the lamp.

Gideon read the last of the privates.

He folded the paper.

He took off his spectacles and put them back into the case and put the case back inside the breast of his coat. He sat with his hands on the folded paper a moment. The brass of the spectacle-case caught a small reflection of the lamp on his coat-front and threw it onto the underside of the table.

He said: *That is the column.*

Mary Baker said: *I thank you, Mr. Johnson.*

She said it in the voice she used to thank him for the reading on a winter evening. The voice did not say more than the words. The two of them had been together at the lamp for bad news before — the news of the south Carolina disasters in the early eighties, the smallpox at Halifax in the autumn of 1786, the Pleasants girl's brother dying at the close of 1789 — and the *I thank you* was the formula the household had built across those readings. The formula did the carrying.

Sarah was looking at her mother.

Mary Baker did not look back at Sarah immediately. She held her eye on the folded paper at her husband's hand. She let the silence in the parlor go the length the silence wanted — the count of perhaps a half-minute, with the coals settling in the grate and Mildred Baker's breathing against Sarah's shoulder gone to the slow rhythm of a child going to sleep where she sat — and then she looked at Sarah and held her eye for the count of one breath and said: *Mildred Baker is asleep, daughter. Help me get her up.*

Sarah stood. She set her sewing on the workbasket. She and her mother lifted Mildred Baker between them off the settle, with Mildred Baker's head against Mary Baker's shoulder and her arms going around her mother's neck without coming fully awake, and Mary Baker carried her to the foot of the parlor stair.

Nancy stood up from the settle and came to her mother's hip the way a seven-year-old came when she did not want to be left in the parlor with the news. Mary Baker said: *Up, all three, to the back room. Sarah, see Nancy to her bed and look in at Ursula and the small one. I will be up.*

Sarah said: *Yes ma'am.*

The three of them went up the stair, Sarah with the candle from the parlor table, Mildred Baker against her mother's shoulder going up in Mary Baker's arms, Nancy at the rail behind Sarah on the stair. Mary Baker carried Mildred Baker to the room and laid her on the bed beside Ursula already there and pulled the quilt up over her shoulder and went to the cradle and put her hand on Polly Baker's back for a count and came out to the hall. Sarah was at the door of Nancy's room with the candle. Nancy was inside in the nightshift she had put on before the parlor reading and was already in the bed. Mary Baker said good-night to Nancy at the door and turned and put her hand on Sarah's shoulder and held it there a moment and said: *To bed, daughter.* Sarah said *yes ma'am* and went into her own room with the candle. Mary Baker stood at the head of the hall until the line of candlelight under Sarah's door had moved to the right side of the room, where Sarah set the candle on the small table by her own bed.

She went back down the stair.

Gideon was at the parlor table where she had left him. He had taken the paper out again and had it open at the column. He was looking at it without reading it. He looked up at her when she came in and folded the paper again.

She said: *Have you eaten enough at the supper.*

He said: *I have eaten enough.*

She said: *I will write to Vincent at Halifax tonight. The post-rider goes Thursday. I will send the letter to him by the spur.*

He said: *Vincent is at Halifax.*

She said: *He is at Halifax. Martha is there with him and the boy. Mother will not have heard the news at the east place yet. Vincent will hear it from the men at Halifax by the end of the week if he has not heard it tonight. I will write to him so he has a sister's letter as well as the men's news.*

Gideon nodded.

He said: *I had thought to ride down to Halifax myself in the second week of February. I will hold the ride a fortnight on the news. The roads will be the better in the back end of the month and I will have your letter to carry by hand if you want it carried.*

She said: *I will have the letter for you Thursday. The post will be faster than your ride. But if you ride after the letter is gone, you may carry word the letter cannot.*

He said: *I will go in the last week of February.*

He sat with his hands on the folded paper a moment longer and then stood and put the paper on the desk beside her writing-place and put his hand on her shoulder once and went up the stair to the bedroom.

Mary Baker stood at the parlor table.

The lamp on the table had burned its oil down to a quarter-inch below the brass collar. The flame at the wick was the steady pale yellow flame the lamp gave when the oil was at that line; in another twenty minutes it would begin to gutter. The coals in the grate had banked themselves down to the red bed under the white ash that a piedmont fire banked itself to in the second hour without wood. The parlor was at the bottom of its evening.

She sat at the writing-desk.

She took a half-sheet of foolscap from the left drawer. She uncapped the inkwell. She took up the quill. She wrote the date across the top — *Tuesday 24 January 1792, Rockingham County* — in the small clear hand she used for letters to kin. She wrote: *Brother.*

She wrote the body of the letter in seven or eight sentences. She wrote that Mr. Johnson had come home from the court at Wentworth this afternoon with the Petersburg paper of the seventh and that the paper had carried the casualty list from the upper Wabash. She wrote that General St. Clair's command had been beaten at the field on the fourth of November and that the federal dead were above six hundred. She wrote that the household at Rockingham was well, the four older girls in their beds, the small one in her cradle, Mr. Johnson home from the court without harm. She wrote that she had not yet had the news at the east place but would write to Mother in the morning. She wrote: *Vincent, I am writing this evening because the news is the news and a sister's letter is a sister's letter and the post is the post. Martha and the boy are well I trust. Write me when you can.* She closed it: *Your sister, Mary Baker Johnson.* She signed.

She did not say anything in the letter about the column of names. She did not say anything about the lamp. She did not name Captain Kirkwood, who had come through Hairston's Cut in the spring of 1789. She did not name what she had been carrying at the parlor table at the reading, because the carrying was not the letter's business; the letter's business was the news and the household's well and a sister's hand at her brother's name.

She blotted the page with the flat of sand. She folded it once long-ways and once cross-ways and sealed it with the small wax stamp. She set the sealed letter on the corner of the desk where she would find it in the morning to put up for Old Hetty's grandson Daniel to carry to the post at Wentworth on the Thursday.

She did not write to her mother. The letter to her mother would be the morning's letter. The morning's letter would want the morning's hand.

She capped the inkwell.

She laid the quill across the inkwell.

She sat at the desk a moment with her hands flat on the desk-top and the lamp at her right hand burning its oil down to the bottom of the line.

She thought about Sarah at the settle.

She thought that Sarah had been at the settle for the reading of the column and had heard it through, and that Sarah had not asked anything when the

reading was done, and that Sarah had taken Mildred Baker up to the bed and had gone to her own bed with the candle without saying anything to her mother in the hall. She thought that Sarah was old enough now, at eleven, to hear the reading without needing to be told what to make of it, and old enough to know that her mother was not in a place this evening to tell her what to make of it either. She thought that this was something a daughter learned by being at the lamp on the evening her father read out the names. She thought that her own first reading like this had been the news of the August fighting in the second year of the war, when she had been not quite thirteen and had been at the Lunenburg parlor with her mother and her grandfather and Vincent at the lamp, and her grandfather had read the names from the Richmond paper, and her mother had not said anything when the reading was done either, and she had taken the small ones up to the bed.

She thought that the news was its own carrying. She thought that the keeping would absorb the news the way the keeping had absorbed the salt-figure in the summer and the question her grandfather had asked her in the December of 1787 about the ratification — the way the keeping absorbed what came in by the door of an evening — and that she would write to her mother at the east place in the morning and to her grandfather at Lunenburg by the Tuesday post, and that there was no more to be done with the news tonight than had been done.

She did not put that thought into a sentence in her head either.

She blew out the lamp.

The parlor went to the red of the coals.

She stood at the desk a moment and let her eyes find the room at the new light, and she could see the settle where the three of her daughters had sat at the reading, and the workbasket on the floor beside it with Sarah's worked-letter cap folded at the top, and the chair where Gideon had been at the reading, and the corner of the table where the Petersburg paper of the seventh of January was now folded under the inkwell. She stood there a count of perhaps half a minute.

Then she went up the stair to the bedroom, in the dark she had walked the stair in for the seven years and a quarter since they had built the house on the cleared eighty.

She did not carry a candle. She knew the stair.

* * *

Interlude — The Inquiry and the Letters

The Petersburg paper of the seventh of January 1792 that Gideon Johnson had read out at the parlor lamp on the Tuesday evening of the twenty-fourth had named the casualty list and had not named what would follow. What would follow was an inquiry. In the House of Representatives on the second of February of 1792, a motion was made to form a committee to investigate the federal defeat. On the twenty-seventh of March the House approved a select committee of seven

members under the chairmanship of Thomas FitzSimons of Pennsylvania, the first congressional investigation of an executive-branch action in the country's history. The committee took testimony across the spring and delivered its report on the eighth of May. The report cleared General St. Clair of personal fault — commending his preparation and his coolness in the engagement — and placed primary blame on the Quartermaster General, Samuel Hodgdon, and the contractor William Duer, whose bankruptcy across the same spring compounded the federal disgrace. St. Clair had resigned his military commission on the seventh of April, a month before the report.

The President had moved already on the replacement. By an act of the second Congress on the fifth of March 1792 the federal force was reconstituted as the Legion of the United States; on the thirteenth of April Major General Anthony Wayne, who had taken Stony Point in the Revolutionary War, was commissioned its senior officer. Wayne spent the summer recruiting at Pittsburgh and the winter of 1792 and 1793 drilling the Legion at Legionville on the Ohio. Two years and four months later, on the twentieth of August 1794, the Legion would engage a confederated Native force under the Shawnee war chief Blue Jacket on the Maumee River and would carry the field. The Treaty of Greenville of the third of August 1795 would cede most of present-day Ohio and parts of Indiana to the federal government, opening settlement north of the Ohio River. The Native side of these engagements — the councils, the commands, the names that the Shawnee and Miami and Delaware used among themselves, the counts of their own dead — the federal record does not preserve at the resolution at which it preserves itself.

Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson, sitting at her writing-desk at Rockingham in the spring of 1793, would not yet have known any of this. She would not yet have known the news from France either — what had been done at Paris in January, and what the messengers were carrying out across the Atlantic. She wrote the morning's letters with what she knew, and she set them on the corner of the desk for the Tuesday post.

* * *

The Letter from Lunenburg

The letter from her grandfather had come down with the post-rider on the second Tuesday of October 1793 and had sat on the writing-desk in the parlor for three days and the half of a fourth before Mary Baker had come to it. She had seen the seal on the morning it came in — her grandfather's wax stamp, the long fold he folded letters in, the small clear superscription in his hand on the outer face — and she had set it on the desk to the right of the inkwell, in the place she set letters from Lunenburg that wanted the proper hour for their reading, and she had gone on with the morning.

The morning of that Tuesday had been the cellar — the cabbage carried from the kitchen yard and packed in the straw by the north wall with Old Hetty and Sarah and Nancy, the afternoon then at the parlor desk on the accounts of the cleared field. Wednesday had been the cloth, the last of the linen wove off the loom in the back room a fortnight earlier, the bleaching done, the cutting at the parlor table for the small ones' shifts for the coming year. Thursday had been the kitchen and the bread and the children. The letter had sat on the desk through the three days. She had walked past it half a dozen times. She had not opened it.

She came to it on the Friday evening.

The supper had been cleared by six. Old Hetty had taken the small ones up. Sarah was at her sewing on the parlor settle with the lamp on the table beside her; Mildred Baker and Nancy were in the back room with the wool. Gideon was at the desk under the south window of the parlor with the cleared-field accounts open in the ledger and the inkwell to his right hand. Mary Baker had sat down in her own chair at her writing-desk on the north side of the parlor, with the lamp on the desk's right-hand corner trimmed for the evening reading, and she had taken her grandfather's letter from the place on the desk where it had sat the three days and a half. She had broken the seal.

It was a long letter. Four sheets, written close, in the hand her grandfather kept for the things that wanted thinking about — not the formal hand he wrote the Bible entries in, but the parlor hand he wrote the household letters in, the one she had been reading since she had been old enough to read at her mother's knee. The date across the top of the first sheet was the second of October 1793. Eight days on the post-route between Lunenburg and Wentworth in October was about right.

She read.

The first sheet was the household at Lunenburg. Her grandfather was sixty-nine. His right hand was the right hand still — the ache he had reported in the December of 1787 was the ache he reported now, no worse and no better. The bay mare he had bought at the Petersburg horse fair in the spring of 1792 was foaling in November; he expected the colt would be a good one. The wheat in the long lot had come in well, and the price at Petersburg in September had been better than the September before. He was wintering at Lunenburg as he wintered most years now, with the Bible on the parlor desk and the two newspapers and the small Latin Cicero his own grandfather Christopher had given him at his fifteenth birthday in 1739. *The Cicero is now eighty-five years old by my count, he wrote, and I read it as a man of sixty-nine reads what was given to a boy of fifteen, which is to say with the same eye and a different ear. I do not know if I have arrived at the Cicero my grandfather meant me to arrive at. I read it again every winter and I wait to see.*

Mary Baker held that sentence a moment with her hand flat on the page.

She had read the Cicero. Her grandfather had given her her own copy on her fourteenth birthday at Lunenburg, in the autumn of 1779. She had it in the parlor

desk's left drawer behind the ledger. She had read it before her marriage and once at twenty in the year Sarah came, and not since.

She went on.

The second sheet was the news from France.

Her grandfather had written it across the page in the close hand he wrote the long passages in, with French phrases at the sentence-turns. He had had the news from the Petersburg papers across the spring and summer. The execution of the French king at Paris on the twenty-first of January had reached the American papers in the last week of March; her grandfather had read it in the Petersburg paper of the third of April and had read the longer account in the Gazette of the tenth, *et j'ai pleuré sur la page — and I wept upon the page* — a sentence he had not written to her in a letter before, and which she read twice.

He had written across the spring of the *citoyen* Genêt's arrival at Charleston in April and his progress north to Philadelphia by the middle of May. He had read the *Aurora* and the *Gazette of the United States* on the question of American neutrality across the summer. The President's proclamation of the twenty-second of April was in the papers; the Genêt commissions and the privateers at the Carolina ports and the recall the French government had ordered in August were in the papers; the Convention's measures at Paris and the Committee put up at the beginning of June were in the papers. *La République française*, he wrote, *est devenue ce que je n'avais pas su qu'elle deviendrait. Le grand espoir de quatre-vingt-neuf s'est trouvé être quelque chose de plus dur. — The French republic has become what I had not known it would become. The great hope of eighty-nine has turned out to be something harder.*

He had a paragraph then on the long memory.

He wrote that his grandfather Christopher had spoken French at the writing-desk at Williamsburg in the years 1713 and 1714, and that the French Christopher had spoken had been the French of Vevey and of the Pays de Vaud — the Bernese country south of the lake — and that the French Tschärner was writing tonight at the parlor desk at Lunenburg was the same French, brought down across four generations and across an ocean, *et je le sens à présent comme une chose qui ne m'appartient pas tout à fait — and I feel it now as a thing that does not quite belong to me.* The men at Paris had made a new word for citizen and a new calendar and a new measure for the year, and the old French of the Pays de Vaud was a language now of fewer mouths in fewer rooms a long way from Paris. He wrote that he had not thought, as a boy of fifteen reading his grandfather's Cicero, that he would live to see the French language go into the place it had gone into across this year.

Mary Baker stopped at the bottom of the second sheet.

She read the paragraph again.

The lamp on the corner of the desk was burning the steady yellow flame it gave when Old Hetty had trimmed it in the afternoon. The parlor was quiet. Sarah on the settle had her needle through the worked letter on the small one's cap and

was watching her mother read without saying anything. Gideon at the south-window desk was looking at the ledger column in front of him and was not looking up.

Mary Baker turned to the third sheet.

The third sheet was the news from Philadelphia.

The yellow fever had come in at the Arch Street wharf in the first week of August. The federal government had evacuated the city in the first week of September; the President had gone to Mount Vernon. The dead by the close of September were said to be above three thousand. The autumn rains had come in the last week of September and the cold had been expected to break the contagion in October. Her grandfather had a clerk's son who was a clerk himself now at Philadelphia in a counting-house on Front Street and had not had word from him since the letter the boy had sent in the last week of July. He did not know if the boy was living. He expected he would know by the close of October.

Quant à moi, he wrote then, in the close hand he wrote the personal things in — and Mary Baker read the sentence at the close of the third sheet with her hand on the page and the lamp on her right hand — *quant à moi, je me porte bien. — As for me, I am well.*

She read the line.

She read it once and once again. The French was the same French her grandfather had been writing her at the sentence-turns since she had been a girl. *Je me porte bien* was the formula he had been signing his letters off with for forty years. The formula was the household's. The formula was the formula.

She read on.

The fourth sheet was the household news her grandfather did not put in the formal places. Vincent at Halifax was well; his Martha was carrying a second child for the spring; the boy at three and a half was talking. Her mother on the east place at Lunenburg was well, was wintering with the older sister and the younger boys, was sending her love. The Macartys had had a daughter in August. The Pleasants girl, now Mrs. Macarty, had been at Lunenburg in September with the child. The Bible was on the parlor desk where it had been for fifty years; her grandfather had made the entries through the September ones and would make the October entries at the close of the month. He closed: *Ta lettre du mois de juillet est arrivée au commencement de septembre et m'a fait plaisir comme tes lettres me font toujours plaisir. Écris-moi de la maison à Rockingham. Ton grand-père qui t'aime.*

Your letter of July arrived at the beginning of September and gave me pleasure as your letters always give me pleasure. Write me of the household at Rockingham. Your grandfather who loves you.

The signature was *Tscharner DeGraffenreid*, in the full formal name he signed his letters to her with, with the small flourish on the right of the *d* the household had carried for five generations.

She folded the four sheets along their original folds. She set the letter on the desk to her left.

She sat at the desk a moment with her hands flat on the desk-top and the lamp on her right hand burning its steady yellow flame.

She thought about the cleared field.

She thought that Gideon had spoken at the supper of the south rail and of the chestnut blowing in the lot on the hard north wind that had come in across the Wednesday, and that the rail at the south end of the cleared eighty was going to want the work in the next ten days before the ground hardened. She thought that the rail was a half-day's work for two men and that Old Hetty's grandson Daniel was at his uncle's place at the river through the close of October and that Gideon could have the Whitaker boy across the line for the half-day on the strength of the corn-crib labor he had had off them in September. She thought that the rail-mending could be done before the cold came in if she said so to Gideon in the morning, and she would say so.

She thought about Sarah at the settle.

Sarah was twelve years and two days. Her birthday had been the Wednesday past, the ninth of October. She had been put on the carding at six and at the plain sewing at nine and at the better needlework across her eleventh winter and was now beginning the more particular hand-work her own mother had begun at twelve. Mary Baker had had her at the worked letter on the small one's cap for three weeks. Sarah was carrying the work steadily and a little ahead of her year. The accounts-book entries for the household preserves Mary Baker had begun letting Sarah write across the September were in Sarah's hand now in the right-hand column, beside Mary Baker's left-hand totals. Sarah did not yet know she had been put to the second hand of the household ledger. Mary Baker had not said so. The doing was the mother's putting her there; the saying would be the daughter's coming to it.

She thought about the letter on the desk to her left.

She thought that her grandfather at sixty-nine wrote the French at the sentence-turns the way he had written it across the forty years she had had letters from him, and that the *je me porte bien* was the formula, and that she would write back. She would write tonight, and she would write him of the cellar at Rockingham and of the linen off the loom and of Sarah at twelve at the better needlework and of Polly Baker at three and a half who had begun in September to ask after her grandfather she had not met. She would write of the cleared field and the south rail and the chestnut and the winter coming on. She would write him of the French news as she had it from the *Petersburg Gazette* and of her own thought on the question of American neutrality, which her grandfather had asked her for and which she now had a position to offer.

She sat at the desk a moment longer.

She uncapped the inkwell.

She took up the quill.

She wrote the date across the top of the first sheet — *Friday 11 October 1793, Rockingham County* — in the small clear hand she used for the letters to Lunenburg. She wrote: *Grandfather*.

She wrote the body of the letter in the unhurried hand she wrote her grandfather's letters in, with the household first and the country after. She wrote that the four older girls were well and at their winter work; that Sarah at twelve was at the better needlework; that Mildred Baker at ten and a half was at the plain sewing; that Nancy was eight in November and could read aloud across a page from the primer; that Ursula at three and three quarters was learning her letters at the desk in the mornings; that Polly Baker at twenty months was beginning to ask after her grandfather she had not met. She wrote that the cleared field had come in well, the corn-crib full, the chestnut blowing on the north wind across the week. She wrote of the cellar and the linen and the rail at the south end. She wrote that Old Hetty was the same Old Hetty.

She wrote then of the country.

She wrote that the news from France had come in to Wentworth in the last week of March and that the household had had the Gazette of the Wednesday afternoon. She wrote that Gideon had read the king's death across the parlor table at the supper. She wrote that the talk at the cleared field's south rail and at the Wentworth court-day in April had been the talk of men who did not yet know what to think but knew they did not want what was coming if it came on the wind from the east. She wrote that her own thought, since her grandfather had asked her for it, was that the country at Rockingham did not want a French war, did not want a war of any kind, was tired in the bone of war. She wrote that the President's proclamation of April had been read at Wentworth with the relief of men who had hoped someone in Philadelphia would say the thing they could not yet say themselves; she did not know if it was the right proclamation but she knew the country was glad of it.

She wrote of the yellow fever then, in two or three sentences, in the way she would write of a contagion at a distance — that the household had had the news of Philadelphia in September from Gideon at the court-day; that the count of the dead had been heavy; that her grandfather's clerk's son she would hold in her thought until her grandfather had word; that the autumn rains were said to be breaking the contagion now and she hoped it was so.

She wrote then of the Bible.

She wrote that she had thought across the September of her grandfather at the Bible on his parlor desk, and of the entries he had been making for fifty years now, and of the *je me porte bien* at the close of his letters across the forty years she had read them. She wrote that she had begun, in the small evenings of the September, to write her own letters to Sarah and Mildred Baker — letters they did not yet know she was writing, letters she was keeping in the parlor desk's left drawer behind the ledger for her daughters to read when they were of an age her grandfather had been to her. She wrote that the practice had come from his

letters across her own years, and that the keeping of letters was a thing she had learned at his desk by reading the letters he had written to her mother.

She wrote then the two words.

She wrote them as she had written them on the half-page beneath her keeping-letter on the ninth of January 1788, in the small clear hand of the body of the letter, in lowercase and without a period, on the line beneath the close of the letter's body and above the formal close:

we continue

She wrote her name below it in the formal hand she used for the close of the letters to her grandfather:

Your granddaughter, Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson

She blotted the page with the flat of sand. She folded the sheets — three of them, written close on both sides — once long-ways and twice cross-ways the way her grandfather folded the letters he sent her and the way she had folded the letters she sent him for six years. She sealed the long edge with the small wax stamp Gideon had had cut for her at Petersburg in their second year. She set the sealed letter on the corner of the desk for the Tuesday post.

She did not look at the two words again.

She did not think about them as she sealed the letter or as she set it on the corner of the desk.

She thought about the south rail and the chestnut and the half-day's work she would speak to Gideon about in the morning. She thought that the cleared field's winter readiness was the household's, and that the cleared field had had a good summer, and that the corn-crib at the north side of the kitchen-yard was full to the second beam, and that the household would carry through the winter without the strain of the winter of '88. She thought that the cabbage in the cellar was in good straw and the linen at the parlor table was cut to a year's shifts for the small ones and that Sarah at twelve was at the better needlework.

She capped the inkwell.

She laid the quill across the inkwell.

She sat at the desk a moment with her hand on the folded letter and the lamp on her right hand burning down to the line.

The parlor was quiet. Sarah had taken her sewing up to the small table by the parlor settle and had gone to the back room to put up the wool. Gideon had closed the ledger and had gone to the kitchen for the water-jug. The fire in the grate had banked itself down to the bed of coals a piedmont fire banked itself to in the second hour without wood.

Mary Baker stood from the desk.

She blew out the lamp.

The parlor went to the red of the coals and the small light of the kitchen lamp coming through the doorway.

She stood at the desk a moment longer in the new light. She could see the corner of the desk where the sealed letter sat. She could see the parlor settle

where Sarah had been at her sewing through the reading and the writing of the letter.

She went to the kitchen for the water-jug herself.

Gideon was at the table with the water and a small piece of the bread Old Hetty had set aside from the supper. He looked up when she came in.

He said: *The letter from your grandfather.*

She said: *The letter from my grandfather. He is well at Lunenburg. The news from France has been heavy on him; the yellow fever at Philadelphia has been heavy on him too. He has a clerk's son in the city he has not had word from since July.*

He said: *I am sorry for the boy.*

She said: *He will have word by the close of October. The contagion is said to be breaking.*

He said: *And your grandfather himself.*

She said: *He is well.*

She said it the way she had said the household's formulas across thirteen years of supper-table marriage, which was to say plainly and at the supper-table's resolution. Gideon nodded. He drank from the water-jug and set it down and put his hand once on her wrist and took up the small piece of the bread.

She said: *The south rail will want the work in the next ten days, Mr. Johnson. Can you have the Whitaker boy across for the half-day on the strength of the corn-crib labor you had off them in September.*

He said: *I had been thinking the same. I will go across in the morning.*

She said: *The rail before the ground hardens.*

He said: *The rail before the ground hardens.*

She took a cup from the dresser-shelf and filled it from the water-jug and went back through the parlor with the cup and up the stair to the bedroom. She did not carry a candle. She knew the stair.

In the bedroom she set the cup on the small table beside the bed and undressed and got into the bed beside Polly Baker in the cradle and the small night-lamp burning low on the chimney-piece. She lay on her back a moment with her hands folded on the quilt and looked at the ceiling of the bedroom in the night-lamp's light.

She thought about the south rail and the Whitaker boy across the line. She thought about the half-day. She thought about the chestnut in the lot and the cold close on the air and the cabbage in the cellar and Sarah's hand in the right-hand column of the accounts-book.

She did not think about the letter on the corner of the desk in the parlor below.

She slept.

* * *

The Rider at the Gate

The afternoon of Thursday the thirteenth of February, 1794, had been the kitchen. Old Hetty had had the spring meat at the salt-table from the morning. Mary Baker had been at the salt-table with her since the breakfast-things had been cleared, with Mildred Baker carrying the cuts on the table's far end and Nancy on the small stool by the south window watching Polly Baker who was at the rag-doll on the floor by the hearth. Sarah was in the back room at the loom on the last of the winter wool. Ursula was at the parlor desk with the slate and the letters her mother had set her in the morning. Gideon was at the south end of the cleared field with the Whitaker boy at the rail-mending the south rail had wanted across the autumn and that Gideon had held to the end of the winter on the soft week before the ground would harden again on the cold front coming in across the Saturday.

The meat was the second hog. The first hog had gone to the salt across the first week of January. The second hog had hung in the smokehouse three weeks for the cure to settle in the cold and had come down to the table on the Wednesday. The salt was the up-country salt from Halsey's at Wentworth that Mary Baker had bought across the cold months on the standing arrangement she had had with him since 1791. The brine was on the hearth fire. The crocks were on the dresser-shelf.

She had not heard the rider come up the lane. She did not hear the horse at the gate. She heard the gate when it opened — the iron of the latch against the post the way the gate's iron answered the post when a man's hand opened it from the road side — and she heard the boots on the brick of the kitchen path and the boots on the back step.

She lifted her head from the salt-table.

Old Hetty had lifted her head as well.

The kitchen door opened.

Vincent stood in it.

He had his hat in his hand. He had ridden in his greatcoat with the road's mud on the boots and the road's cold on his face and the look of a man who had not shaved since the Tuesday. He had ridden hard.

He said:

Mary Baker.

She set the knife down on the salt-table. She wiped her hands once on her apron without looking at her hands. She looked at her brother's face.

Vincent said: *Grandfather died Tuesday evening at Lunenburg. Mother sent the boy out to me at Halifax in the night. I came up this morning. The funeral is Saturday at the meeting-house. Mother is at the house at Lunenburg with the older sister and the boys. He went in his sleep in the afternoon and they did not know it until Liza brought up the supper and found him in the chair at the parlor desk.*

He did not say anything else for a count of perhaps half a minute. Mary Baker did not say anything in that half-minute either. Mildred Baker at the end of the salt-table had stopped with a cut in her two hands and was looking from her uncle to her mother and back to her uncle. Nancy on the stool had not moved.

Old Hetty said: *Come into the kitchen, Mr. Vincent. You will want the fire and a cup.*

Vincent came in. He set the hat on the table by the door. He took the greatcoat off and laid it across the chair-back. He went to the hearth and put his hands above the coals and stood a moment with his back to the room, and his shoulders were the shoulders of a man who had been on the road for thirty-six hours and had come to the first warmth he had had.

Mary Baker said: *Mildred Baker, take Polly Baker through to the parlor. Tell Sarah in the back room her uncle is here. I will come through in a moment.*

Mildred Baker set the cut down on the small board at the table's end. She took Polly Baker up from the floor by the hearth and Nancy off the stool and went through the kitchen door into the parlor and the parlor door closed behind her.

Mary Baker stood at the salt-table a moment longer with her hands flat on the wood.

She went to the hearth.

She stood beside her brother above the coals. She put her hand on his arm above the elbow. She held it there a count of perhaps four breaths. Vincent put his own hand once on the back of her hand and took it away and put his hand back to the coals.

Old Hetty had set the cup on the dresser-shelf and was pouring from the kettle. She brought the cup to Vincent at the hearth. She said: *I will have a supper for you in the half-hour. You will sleep here tonight, Mr. Vincent.*

Vincent said: *Yes. I will go back to Halifax tomorrow.*

Mary Baker said: *You will not ride to the funeral.*

Vincent said: *I cannot. Martha is within three weeks of the child. I told her I would be back by Saturday night.*

Mary Baker said: *Then I will not write to Mother to expect you. I will write to her tonight.*

Vincent said: *I told Mother I would come to Rockingham and tell you. I will carry your letter back to Halifax in the morning and put it up at the post there for the Tuesday rider. It will reach Lunenburg before the week is out.*

She nodded.

She went to the back of the kitchen to the small water-stand and washed her hands and the apron-front in the basin. She dried her hands on the towel on the rail. She put the apron up on the peg. She came back to the table and put the knife and the salt-jar and the crocks into the order the table wanted for the supper Old Hetty would set onto it in the half-hour.

She said: *I will go through. Come when the cup is done.*

She went through the kitchen door into the parlor.

Sarah was at the parlor table with Mildred Baker and Nancy on the settle and Polly Baker on the floor at her mother's chair. Ursula had come out from the desk and was standing beside Sarah at the table. Sarah was thirteen years and four months and four days old. She was at her full height now, or near enough — taller than her mother by half an inch, with her mother's hair in the braid down her back and her father's eyes. She had her hand on Mildred Baker's shoulder. She looked at her mother.

Mary Baker said: *Your grandfather DeGraffenreid died Tuesday evening at Lunenburg. Your uncle Vincent has ridden up to bring the word. He will go back to Halifax tomorrow. There will be a funeral Saturday at the meeting-house at Lunenburg. We will not go. The road is two days. The baby at Halifax is within three weeks and your uncle will not be at the funeral either. The Bible will come down to Rockingham in the spring, when the road and the wagon can be had together. Your grandmother will see to the sending.*

Sarah said: *Yes, Mother.*

Mildred Baker said: *Did he know he was going.*

Mary Baker said: *He went in his sleep at his own parlor desk in the afternoon. Liza brought up the supper and found him in the chair. I do not think he knew, Mildred Baker.*

Nancy said: *Will I write to him in the letter we were going to write.*

Mary Baker said: *No, Nancy. We will write to your grandmother instead. You may write your part of the letter to her in the morning when I have written mine.*

Ursula said: *Is grandfather in the ground.*

Mary Baker said: *He will be on Saturday, Ursula. At the meeting-house yard at Lunenburg, beside the place where your grandmother Mary Baker DeGraffenreid lies, who died in the June of 1773 a year before I was born. They will lay him there.*

Polly Baker on the floor was looking at her mother and was not understanding the conversation. She reached up.

Mary Baker bent and took Polly Baker up onto her hip and stood at the parlor table with the small one on her hip. She put her free hand once on Sarah's shoulder and once on Mildred Baker's and once on Nancy's. She did not put her hand on Ursula's because Ursula was already with the others and was understanding by being there.

She said: *I will be at the desk a moment. Sarah, take your sisters to the back room and the loom. Mildred Baker, come and take Polly Baker.*

Mildred Baker came and took Polly Baker. Sarah took Nancy's hand and Ursula's and went to the back room with Mildred Baker behind them.

Mary Baker stood at the parlor table a moment longer.

She crossed to the writing-desk on the north side of the parlor. She sat down. She uncapped the inkwell. She took up the quill. She did not yet write. She sat at the desk with the quill in her hand and her hand flat on the desk-top and she looked across the parlor to the south-window desk where Gideon's field-book was

on the desk-top closed, and the inkwell to the right of the field-book, and the chair pushed in.

She thought about Gideon at the south end of the cleared field with the Whitaker boy and the rail.

She thought that Gideon would come in across the cleared field at four or half past, with the cold close on his face and the chestnut blowing in the lot, and would not yet know. She would tell him in the kitchen-yard before he came in to the children.

She thought about her mother at Lunenburg.

She thought that her mother was at her father-in-law's parlor on the day of his death, with the older sister and the younger boys and the house to keep. She thought that her mother had buried Baker at twenty-six in some month of the war and had administered the estate for fifteen years since, and was now at the parlor desk her father-in-law had died at, with the Bible in front of her and the older sister in the kitchen.

She thought that her mother knew what had passed.

She uncapped the inkwell again — she had capped it without realizing — and took a half-sheet of foolscap from the left drawer. She wrote the date across the top — *Thursday 13 February 1794, Rockingham County* — in the small clear hand she used for the letters to Lunenburg. She wrote: *Mother.*

She wrote in the body of the letter that Vincent had come up from Halifax with the word, that he was at the kitchen now and would go back in the morning with the letter to put up at the Halifax post for the Tuesday rider, that Martha was within three weeks of the child and Vincent could not be away. She wrote that she herself could not come to the funeral, that the road was two days and the small ones were five and not yet able to be left, that she would write to her grandmother at the older sister's place in the morning. She wrote: *Mother, I have not the words for grandfather's death. I have his letter of October on my desk and have read it twice across the autumn. I am at the desk you taught me to sit at. I will write to him no more. I will write to you.*

She wrote of the keeping then.

She wrote that she would have the writing-desk on the north side of the parlor ready for the Bible when it came south. She wrote: *I will keep the Bible the way he kept it. I will write the entries in the formal hand. I will write him at the close of his life, in the hand he wrote his own father in.*

She wrote of the cleared field and the south rail and the salt for the meat in two sentences. She wrote that Gideon was at the rail this afternoon and that he did not yet know. She wrote: *I will tell him in the kitchen-yard when he comes in from the field.*

She wrote then the close:

I will write you in the morning if Vincent is still here at the kitchen by then. The post is the Tuesday rider for the next letter. I have his letter of October by me

and I will keep it where I will not see it for some weeks. I am at the desk. Your daughter, Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson.

She did not write the two words.

She had not written them at any letter she had written to her mother across the fifteen years and would not write them tonight. The two words had been her grandfather's letters and the letters were closed.

She blotted the page with the flat of sand.

She folded the sheet once long-ways and twice cross-ways. She sealed the long edge with the small wax stamp. She set the sealed letter on the corner of the desk for Vincent to take in the morning.

She capped the inkwell.

She laid the quill across the inkwell.

She sat at the desk a moment longer.

She thought about the Bible at her grandfather's parlor desk at Lunenburg. She thought that her mother had it on the desk now, and that the older sister would have laid the cover-cloth across it the way her grandfather had laid it across at the close of his writing hour.

She did not put any of this into a sentence in her head.

She stood from the desk.

Vincent had come through from the kitchen and was on the parlor settle with the cup in his hand. He had eaten something — Old Hetty had brought him a plate in the kitchen — and was looking better than he had looked at the kitchen door. He stood when his sister stood.

He said: *I went up to see her before I came in. Mother. I had a quarter of an hour with her in the kitchen at Lunenburg before I rode this morning. She is steady. She is at the parlor desk with the Bible and the older sister at her elbow. She told me to tell you the household at Lunenburg is the household at Lunenburg, that you would understand what she meant by it.*

Mary Baker said: *I understand it.*

She did. She did not need to say what she understood. She did not say it.

She said: *Sit, Vincent. The supper will be on the table in a quarter of an hour. Gideon will be in from the field. I will tell him in the kitchen before he sees the children. Sarah will bring the small ones in.*

Vincent sat on the settle.

She went through to the back room. Sarah was at the loom with Mildred Baker beside her at the bobbin and Nancy on the small chair with the slate and Polly Baker on Mildred Baker's lap. Ursula was at the small table by the window with her letters.

Sarah looked up.

Mary Baker said: *Sarah. Bring them in to the supper in a quarter of an hour. Your father will be in. I will tell him in the kitchen.*

Sarah said: *Yes, Mother.*

Mary Baker went back through to the parlor and through to the kitchen door and stood at the kitchen door a moment with her hand on the frame and listened for Gideon coming up the back step, and after a count of perhaps two minutes she heard the boots on the brick of the kitchen path and the boots on the back step. She went out to him.

She told him in the kitchen-yard, in three sentences, before he had taken his coat off.

He stood with his hat in his hand and the cold close on his face and looked at her without saying anything for the count of half a minute. Then he said: *I am sorry, Mary Baker.*

She said: *Vincent is in the parlor. He came up from Halifax. He will go back in the morning.*

He said: *I will go in.*

He went in past her into the kitchen and through to the parlor. She stood in the kitchen-yard a moment with her hand on the back-step rail and the cold on her face and the chestnut blowing in the south end of the lot. The afternoon was going down to the dusk. The cleared field's south rail was finished, the new wood paler than the rail-line, the Whitaker boy already across the line on his own way home in the dusk with his coat collar up.

She looked at the cleared field a moment.

She went into the kitchen.

The supper passed. She did not eat much. Vincent ate the way a man who has ridden thirty-six hours eats. Gideon ate steadily and did not say much. The children had been told already and had no questions across the meal; Sarah carried the small ones' attention through the meal at her own end of the table and Mildred Baker carried Polly Baker on her knee. Mary Baker sat at her place with her hands on either side of the plate and did the eating.

After the supper Old Hetty took the small ones up. Sarah and Mildred Baker went up with Old Hetty to put them to bed. Nancy stayed on the parlor settle with Ursula and the slate. Gideon and Vincent took their cups to the parlor chairs by the fire and sat across from each other and spoke at the low pitch men spoke when the day's news had landed.

Mary Baker sat at her desk.

She did not take up the quill. She did not open the inkwell. She had written the letter she had to write and there was no other letter to write tonight. She sat at the desk with her hands folded on the desk-top and the sealed letter on the corner of the desk for Vincent and the lamp at her right hand burning steady.

She thought about her grandfather at the parlor desk at Lunenburg in the chair where Liza had found him.

She thought that he had been at the desk in the afternoon with the Bible at his right hand and the small Latin Cicero his own grandfather had given him in 1739 within reach, and the two Petersburg papers on the desk-top, and the quill in the inkwell. She thought that he had been at the desk with the writing-hand he had

been keeping the family record in for fifty-two years. She thought that the chair had been the chair he had sat at for fifty years. She thought that he had laid the writing-hand down in the chair.

She thought about the October letter.

She did not take it out. She knew where it was — in the parlor desk's left drawer behind the letters to Sarah and Mildred Baker, where she had put it on the Saturday after the writing of her reply, and where it had sat for the four months and a day. She did not need to take it out. She had read it three times across the autumn and once in the December and once in the second week of January. She knew the third sheet. She knew the close of the third sheet. She knew the formula.

The formula sat in her head a moment in the hand it had been written in, on the page she had read it on, in the lamp's light it had been read in on the Friday evening of the eleventh of October.

She did not say anything in her head about the formula. She did not put it into a sentence. She did not think the word *should*. She did not think the word *would*. The formula sat there.

It sat there a long moment.

She heard the men at the fire. Gideon was telling Vincent of the south rail and the Whitaker boy's labor and the chestnut blowing. Vincent was telling Gideon of Martha and the boy at four and the child coming in the spring. The men were at the fire and the woman was at the desk and the two were doing the two things the news asked of them.

She stood from the desk after a while.

She blew out the lamp.

The parlor went to the red of the coals and the fire-light on the chairs where Gideon and Vincent sat, and to the lamp by the settle where Nancy and Ursula were at the slate. Gideon looked up. Vincent looked up.

She said: *I am going up. Vincent, the room across from Sarah's is made up for you. Gideon will show you. The breakfast is at seven.*

Vincent stood from the settle and looked at her.

She said: *I know.*

She went up the stair. She did not carry a candle. She knew the stair.

In the bedroom she undressed by the small night-lamp on the chimney-piece. Polly Baker was asleep in the cradle by the south window. The other small ones were in the front room with Sarah. She got into the bed.

She lay on her back a moment with her hands folded on the quilt.

She did not think about the October letter.

She did not think about the entry her grandfather had not made for himself.

She did not think about the Bible at the parlor desk at Lunenburg or about the wagon that would come down through Hairston's Cut in the spring.

She thought about the supper for Vincent in the morning. She thought about the letter on the corner of the desk for him to carry. She thought about Gideon at

the south rail tomorrow and the salt at the second hog and Sarah at the loom and Polly Baker in the cradle beside her.

She thought about the next thing on the list.

She slept.

* * *

We Continue

The Bible came south on the second Tuesday of April, 1794.

Mother had arranged the wagon at Lunenburg through Halsey at Wentworth, who carried the up-country salt down the post-road to Rockingham across the cold months and who had a man named Coker going south with a load of seed-corn and bar-iron in the first dry week of the spring. The roads had held wet through the end of March; the Dan had been up over the lower ford the last week of the month and had come down to its banks in the first days of April; and Coker's wagon had come over the firmed road through Hairston's Cut on the Monday and had lain the night at the Wentworth store, and had come up the lane to Rockingham at the middle of the Tuesday afternoon.

Mary Baker heard the wagon at the gate.

She was at the salt-table in the kitchen with the last of the second hog and Old Hetty beside her. She had been listening for the wagon since the Saturday, when the word had come down with the post that Coker was on the road; and she had told herself across the three days that she would not listen for it, and had listened for it. She heard the wheels on the lane and the wheels at the gate and the man's voice to the team, and she set the knife down on the salt-table and wiped her hands on her apron without looking at her hands.

She went out to the wagon.

Coker had the Bible in a wooden case in the bed of the wagon, set up on the seed-sacks where the wet would not reach it, wrapped in a piece of oiled canvas over the cover-cloth Mother had laid across it at Lunenburg. There was the case, and there was a smaller parcel beside it wrapped in the same canvas, which Mary Baker would find, when she opened it that evening, to be the small Latin Cicero her grandfather had read every winter for the fifty-four years he had owned it — sent south now with a slip of Mother's writing folded into the front of it: *He would have wanted you to have it by you. S.V.D.*

Coker handed the case down to her over the wagon-rail.

She took it in both arms.

She carried the case into the parlor.

She set it on the writing-desk on the north side of the parlor — the desk she had been writing her letters to Lunenburg at for fifteen years, the desk she had told her mother in the February letter she would have ready for the Bible when it came south — and she did not open the case. She stood beside the desk with her hand flat on the top of the case a moment. Then she went back out to the wagon,

and gave Coker the supper and the bed in the loft over the lean-to that a man who had carried the family's keeping two days down the post-road was owed, and saw to the team with the Whitaker boy, and went back to the kitchen and the salt-table and the last of the second hog.

The Bible sat on the desk in its case through the supper and the evening and the children's bedtime.

She did not open it that night.

* * *

The household kept its spring across the days after.

Gideon and the Whitaker boy and the man Gideon had taken on for the season put the corn in the cleared field across the second week of April, the field that had been four acres when she had married and was eleven acres now, the south rail finished and pale against the rail-line where the Whitaker boy had mended it in the February. Sarah was at the last of the winter wool and then at the garden-rows with Mildred Baker. Nancy had her letters in the morning at the slate and her half of the garden-row in the afternoon. Ursula was at the back-room table with the small carved animals Tscharner had whittled for the children across the years, which she had taken to keeping in a box and setting out on the table in their order. Polly Baker was five now and was at the rag-doll and the kitchen-step and the hem of whoever's gown was nearest.

The letters had gone north and had come south across the late winter. Mary Baker had written her mother in the February and again at the close of the month and again at the middle of March. Mother had written back in March — steady, the older sister at her elbow, the household at Lunenburg the household at Lunenburg — and had written that the wagon would come down with Coker in the first dry week, and that she had laid the cover-cloth across the Bible herself, and that Mary Baker was to keep it the way her grandfather had kept it, which Mother did not need to write and wrote.

The Bible sat in its case on the writing-desk through the spring work.

Mary Baker did not write the death entry in the days after the Bible came.

She had thought, in the February, that she would write it the first night the Bible was under her roof. She had written her mother that she would. But the Bible came, and the spring came with it, and the corn wanted putting in and the garden wanted the rows turned and the household wanted its keeping, and the entry sat ahead of her the way the salt sat ahead of her at the second hog — a thing the household owed, that would be done in its hour, that was not yet at its hour. She did not name to herself that she was not ready. She did not think the word *ready*. She thought of the entry as the next thing but one on the list, and she did the things ahead of it on the list, and the case sat on the desk with the cover-cloth folded inside it under the lid.

She opened the case on the Thursday.

She did it in the afternoon, with the children at the garden and Old Hetty at the kitchen, alone in the parlor with the spring light coming in at the south window. She lifted the lid. She took out the cover-cloth and laid it across the back of her chair. She lifted the Bible out of the case in both hands and set it on the desk.

It was heavier than she had remembered it.

She had held it last in the autumn of 1779, on the morning of her wedding, when her grandfather had brought it to the parlor of her mother's borrowed house and had opened it on the parlor desk for the marriage and had carried it home to Lunenburg after. She had not held it in the fifteen years since. She had seen it at the Lunenburg parlor desk on the visits — three visits across the fifteen years, the last in the autumn of 1791 — but had not held it. Her grandfather had held it. It had been her grandfather's to hold.

She set it on the desk and did not open it.

She stood beside the desk with her two hands flat on the closed cover a moment, the way she had stood beside the case the day the wagon came. The cover was the calf-leather it had been, darkened at the corners and along the spine to the color of old harness where four generations of hands had held it. The clasp was the brass clasp. She did not work the clasp.

She put the cover-cloth over it and went back to the kitchen.

She had decided, standing there with her hands on the cover, that she would write the entry that night, after the household was up to bed. She had not said it to herself in a sentence. Her hands had gone to the cover-cloth and had laid it over the Bible the way a thing is covered that is to be come back to in a fixed hour, and she had known by the laying of it that the hour was that night, and the knowing had come up after the hands had moved, the way the knowing came up after the hands moved at the salt-table and at the loom and at the children's hurts. She would write it tonight. She had decided it with her hands and her mind had read the decision off her hands and had agreed with it.

She went and turned the garden-rows with Sarah until the supper.

* * *

The evening came on like the other evenings of the planting week.

The supper passed. Gideon had been in the field to the last light and ate the way a man eats at the close of a planting day and went to the parlor fire after with the field-book to set down the day's rows. The children were put up. Old Hetty took the small ones; Sarah and Mildred Baker went up after; Nancy and Ursula were at the slate on the settle for the half-hour and then went up. Mary Baker sat at the writing-desk with the lamp on the right-hand corner trimmed to the evening's height and the Bible under its cover-cloth at the center of the desk, and she did the mending in her lap that she did at the lamp on the evenings the household had its quiet, and she did not work the clasp of the Bible while Gideon was at the fire.

Gideon set the field-book down at half past nine and banked the fire and stood.

He looked at his wife at the desk, and at the covered shape at the center of the desk, and did not say anything about it. He had not said anything about it across the three weeks it had sat in its case. He knew what it was and whose keeping it had come into and that the keeping was hers and was not his to put a word to. He had married into the DeGraffenreid keeping at twenty in 1779 and had carried it the way a man carries the thing his wife carries — at her elbow, with the wood split and the field cleared and the road's news brought in, and the keeping itself left in her hands where it was hers.

He said: *I am going up. Do not sit too late, Mary Baker.*

She said: *I will not be long.*

He went up the stair.

She sat at the desk and listened to his step on the stair and the door of the bedroom and the house going quiet above her. She heard the small night-noises of a house with seven people asleep in it — the timber settling at the cool of the night, the chestnut blowing once in the south end of the lot, the kitchen lamp Old Hetty left low going out at some hour she did not mark.

She did not write the entry then.

She had thought she would write it after Gideon went up, in the first quiet of the house. But she sat at the desk with the lamp on her right hand and the Bible under its cloth and the mending finished and folded in her lap, and she did not lift the cloth, and she understood after a while that she had not yet come to the hour either. The hour was not the lamp-hour with the house just gone quiet. The hour was later, in the small hours, when the night had gone all the way down and there was nothing in the house awake but her. She had known her grandfather wrote the formal entries in the small hours. He had told her so once, on a visit, at the parlor desk at Lunenburg — that the formal entries were not day-writing or evening-writing, that they were the writing a man did when the house was asleep and the entry was between him and the page and no one else, and that she would understand it when she came to keep the record herself.

She had not understood it then. She understood it now.

She trimmed the lamp down. She did not blow it out. She left it at the low flame at the right-hand corner of the desk. She set the folded mending in the workbasket. She put the cover-cloth straight over the Bible.

She went up the stair to the bedroom.

* * *

In the bedroom she undressed by the small night-lamp on the chimney-piece. Polly Baker was asleep in the cradle by the south window. Gideon was asleep on the far side of the bed, on his back, the planting-day's work taking him down into the sleep a field-day takes a man down into. The other children were in the front room. The house was at the bottom of its night.

She did not get into the bed.

She sat on the edge of the bed in her shift with her feet on the floor and her hands folded in her lap, the way she sat the small while she sat most nights before she lay down, when the day was being set down and the next day was being taken up. The floor was cool under her feet. The night-lamp on the chimney-piece gave the small low light it gave. Gideon's breathing was the long breathing of a man asleep. Polly Baker's breathing was the small quick breathing of a child asleep in a cradle.

She sat at the edge of the bed and did not lie down.

She was not ready for the day to end.

She knew, sitting there with her feet on the cool floor, what the ending of the day was. The day that was ending was the last day in which the Bible at the desk below her was a thing she had not yet written in — the last day in which the keeping had come to her but had not been taken up by her hand. The next day, in the small hours of it, she would go down and write the formal French entry in her grandfather's manner in her own hand, and would become, at the writing of it, the keeper of the record in act and not only in the wagon's delivery of the case. The day she had lived through had made her the keeper. The day that came after the feet left the floor was the day she became the keeper in the doing.

She sat at the edge of the bed a moment longer with the day held at its edge.

The day does not end until the feet leave the floor and rest on the bed.

She let her feet leave the floor.

She lay down. She drew the quilt up. She lay on her back with her hands folded on the quilt and Gideon's breathing on her right and the cradle's breathing at the window and the night-lamp low on the chimney-piece, and she understood, lying there, that she had let the day end, and that the next time she rose it would be to go down to the desk; and the understanding came up after the lying-down, the way it came up after the hands moved, the body having ended the day before the mind had said the day was ended.

She slept a few hours.

* * *

She woke in the small hours.

She did not know the exact hour; the house had no clock that struck in the bedroom, and the window was the dead black of the deep night, the hour with no edge of dawn in it. She woke the way she had told her body to wake, the way her mother had taught her to wake to a sick child or a banked fire that wanted tending — all at once, awake, with the thing she had woken for already in her hand before her eyes were open. She had woken to go down to the desk.

She got up without waking Gideon. She took the wool wrapper from the chair at the foot of the bed and put it over her shift. She took the candle from the chimney-piece and lit it at the night-lamp and went out onto the stair-head and

down the stair, the candle in her hand throwing the stair-rail's shadow up the wall and bringing it down again behind her as she came.

The parlor was cold. The fire was a bed of grey ash with no red left in it. She set the candle on the writing-desk on the right-hand corner where the lamp stood in the evenings, and she sat down in her chair at the desk, and she took the cover-cloth off the Bible and folded it and laid it on the back of the chair beside her.

She worked the brass clasp.

She opened the Bible to the front, to the fly-leaf and the leaves of the family record after it, where the entries ran from her great-grandfather Christopher's hand at the top of the first leaf down through the generations in the hands that had kept the record after him. She knew the leaves. She had read them as a child at Lunenburg, on her grandfather's knee at the parlor desk, the French entries her grandfather read out to her and turned into English for her, *born, married, died*, the dates in the old style and the new, the names she had the whole shape of the family in before she could read the French herself.

She found the place for the entry.

It was the foot of the leaf her grandfather had kept the deaths on, beneath the entry he had made for his own father Christopher in October 1742, beneath the entry he had made for his wife Mary Baker in June 1773, beneath the entries for the children of the line who had died across his fifty-two years of keeping. There was room at the foot of the leaf for one more entry. Her grandfather had left the room. She understood, looking at the room left at the foot of the leaf, that he had left it knowing the entry that would go there would be his own and would be made in another hand, and that the hand he had left the room for was a hand he had taught to write at the parlor desk at Lunenburg a long time ago.

She uncapped the inkwell.

She took up the quill and trimmed the nib with the small knife from the desk-drawer and dipped the quill and held it a moment over the well to let the first heavy drop go back.

She wrote the entry.

She wrote it in French, in the formal hand her grandfather had written the formal entries in, in the French he had taught her at the parlor desk at Lunenburg — the French of the Pays de Vaud brought down across four generations, the French he had written her in his letters, the French he had written his own father's death entry in fifty-two years before in this same hand at the top of this same leaf. She wrote the day and she wrote the name and she wrote the age, seventy-one years and two months, and she wrote the formula for the close of a life that the entries on the leaf had carried since Christopher's hand had carried it: that he had been called, that he had gone, that the line stood. She wrote it the way he had written it for his father and the way Christopher had written it before him. She wrote it in the hand he wrote his own father in, the way she had told her mother in the February she would.

(Sarah Johnson — Sarah Hubbard, at the kitchen table in her own house in Cumberland County, North Carolina, with the candle at her hand and her own children long asleep and the slow careful letters coming off the nib in the hand her mother had taught her — would write this same formula at the foot of this same leaf, for her mother, at some January of 1823 in a country her mother would by then have moved away into and died in; and would understand, then and not before, writing the death of the woman who had taught her the writing, what her mother had been doing at the desk at Rockingham in the spring of 1794 with the candle burning down, taking up the hand that had been her own grandfather's, and would feel it come up in her after the hand had moved, the way her mother had taught her that the knowing comes up after the hand.)

She signed the entry.

She set the quill down across the mouth of the inkwell.

She read what she had written. The entry stood as the entries above it stood. The hand was the formal hand, and the French was his French, the French of the leaf. She had written it the way he had kept it, and the keeping was kept, and the record had not broken at his death but had carried across into the hand he had left the room for.

She sat at the desk with the entry written and the candle burning down and the parlor cold around her and the house asleep above her.

She had done the thing the keeping asked of her.

She thought of her grandfather at the parlor desk at Lunenburg with the Bible at his right hand and the Cicero within reach and the formal entries done in the small hours across fifty-two years. She thought that the keeping he had handed her was kept. She thought of the next morning — of the letter she would write to her mother to say the Bible was come and the entry was made and the keeping was hers and kept; of the letter she would write to Vincent at Halifax; of the corn in the cleared field and the garden-rows and the small ones at the breakfast. She thought of the next morning, and that was as far as the thinking went.

She took up the quill again to cap the inkwell.

She held it a moment over the page.

She was not thinking, in the moment she held the quill over the page, of writing anything more. The entry was made. The keeping was kept. There was nothing more the record asked of her tonight. She held the quill over the page in the small motionless moment a hand holds before it is set down, and the candle was low at the corner of the desk, and the parlor was cold, and the entry sat finished on the leaf beneath the long line of the hands that had kept it.

Ink ran from the nib.

The blot landed on the fly-leaf beneath the formal entry, a single dark mark the shape of an irregular oval, smaller than her thumbnail.

She looked at it.

She dipped the quill again.

She wrote, in her own small clear hand, in English, in the same hand that had signed letters to her mother and entries in the household ledger and notes to her brother during the war for fifteen years —

we continue

She closed the Bible.

She blew out the candle.

* * *

Interlude — The Keeping Forward

The fly-leaf of the Christopher VI Bible carried, by the spring of 1794, eighty years of the family's hands. Christopher had written the marriage entry on it in French in the small upper room at Charleston on the wedding night of the twenty-second of February 1714, in the hand the Baron at Worb had told him to write it in. His son Tscharner had kept the record after him from October 1742, when the Bible came to Lunenburg in a young man's trunk, through fifty-two years of marriages and births and deaths set down in the same formal French at the parlor desk. The leaf Mary Baker opened to in the small hours of an April night in 1794 was the leaf those two hands had filled. The entry she wrote at the foot of it, for her grandfather, was the first entry in the Bible made by a woman's hand since Barbara — and the two English words she wrote beneath the blot were the first words in any language not French to go onto the family record's leaves at all.

What the surviving record establishes of the Bible after that night it establishes thinly. Tscharner DeGraffenreid died in the second week of February 1794 at Lunenburg, at seventy-one, the cause and the exact day unrecorded; he was buried in the family ground beside the elder Mary Baker, who had gone before him in June 1773. The Bible passed south to his granddaughter — not by a documented instrument, for the documentary basis of the transfer is the structural fact of the family rather than a deed or a will, but by the plain circumstance that Baker DeGraffenreid was twenty years dead with no grave, and his daughter was the one who would keep the record now. She kept it at Rockingham for sixteen years.

By 1810 the household had moved again — west and south into the new country, to Williamson County in the part of the western lands that had become the state of Tennessee in 1796, the Bible going with the family as it had gone with Tscharner to Lunenburg and with Christopher across the ocean before that. Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson died there in the January of 1823, at fifty-eight; the family records disagree by six days on the date, the Chadwell Bible giving the first of the month and the Reynolds line the seventh. Her own death entry was written, as her grandfather's had been written by her, in another hand of the line.

The two words she wrote on the fly-leaf in the spring of 1794 were not invented for the Bible. She had been writing them at the close of letters and ledgers and journals her whole adult life, the way her mother had written them,

the way the household had said of itself across the wars and the absences and the prices paid one fragment at a time that it was still, against the evidence of any given winter, standing. That she wrote them in the Bible only once, and only there, and only beneath the entry that made her the keeper, is the reason the page can carry the weight it carries. The line went on through her children and their children into the century after, and into the volume that begins where this one ends.

* * *

Epilogue — We Continue

For most of the years I gave to this book I worked at a desk with the records spread out under a lamp, which is more or less how Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson worked at hers. The difference is the direction. She kept the record forward, a line at a time, as the thing happened — a birth, a death, a marriage, the two words at the foot of a letter going out to a brother at the war. I have been keeping it backward: reading what she and the others set down, and the far greater amount they did not, and trying to find the people in the spaces between the documents.

I did not begin meaning to write their book. I began with a smaller question — a name on a chart with nothing behind it — and the smaller question opened onto a larger one, and the larger one onto this. That is the way it goes. You pull one thread to see where it is anchored, and the whole cloth comes up in your hand.

What I found was not a family of consequence in the way the word is usually meant. They held no high office that outlasted them. The one baron in the line had gone home to Switzerland and left the name to a son who carried a Bible across an ocean, married in Charleston, and began the line on this side of the water. The grant that anchors the middle of this book was four hundred acres on a creek, and it stood in a woman's name because the man whose name it should have stood in had ridden out on the place's business in the autumn of 1775 and not come back. I spent a long time looking for Baker DeGraffenreid's grave. There is no grave. There is a date he was last seen alive and a date by which his wife was signing herself his administratrix, and between those two dates there is a silence about four years deep that I could not close and, in the end, did not try to. The book keeps that silence open because the family kept it open. They went on not knowing, and they wrote down the rest, and the not-knowing is part of the record now as surely as the births are.

That, I came to think, is the thing the family actually did, and the thing worth the book. Not the founding, not the grant, not the names that turn up in the county histories. The doing. The keeping. The going-on after the rider does not come back, after the colonel's daughter is buried before her own granddaughter is born, after the war takes the sons north and brings some of them home again and some of them not. None of the great events of the country happened to these people. All of them arrived as fragments — a casualty list in a newspaper, a letter from a grandfather in his particular French — and the household priced each fragment and proceeded. For a long time no one in it had a word for what it was doing. It only did it. And then on a November night in 1779 a fifteen-year-old at a desk came to the foot of a letter and found that the doing had wanted a name all along, and she gave it one — two words — and wrote them twice that night, once in the letter going out to her brother and once in the book that stayed in the house. Fourteen years later, in the small hours of a winter night, with her

grandfather dead and his Bible come south to her desk at last, she wrote those same two words a third time, under his death set down in his own French manner in her own hand, and she closed the book and put out the candle.

She was the first woman in the line to hold that Bible. She was not the last person to keep what it stood for, though most of those who kept it after her never saw the book and could not have read the French. The name changed as the line came down — Johnson to Hubbard and on through the marriages, daughters carrying it sideways into other names until it reached the one on the cover of this book. The keeping changed shape, too. It stopped being a Bible on a parlor desk. It became the things keeping becomes when no one is trained to it anymore — a box of photographs, a story told once at a kitchen table and half-remembered, a chart somebody started and did not finish. But it did not stop. Someone always held it, even when holding it meant only not throwing it away.

I am the one holding it now, and what holding it has come to mean for me is this book. I understand that in a way I did not when I started, pulling the one thread. This is my entry on the fly-leaf. It is longer than hers, and it is in English, and it has footnotes she would have found strange, but it is the same act: setting the names down so that whoever breaks it open a long time off and a long way away will know whose hands carried the words this far. I went looking for them because the not-knowing had become mine to carry, the way the keeping had once become hers — by being inside it. And when I came to the close of it, to this page, which is the foot of the letter, I found that the work had wanted a name all along, and that it is the same name she found, and that it is true in the same plain way it was true for her.

So I will write it here, in my own hand, under all of theirs.

we continue

Part Three — Volume III: She Held the Line, 1832 to 1920

Bridge — The Road Out of Lunenburg, 1779 to 1846

The second volume ends on a fifteen-year-old at a writing-desk in Lunenburg County, Virginia, on a November night in 1779, coming to the foot of a letter and setting down two words she then wrote a second time in the book that stayed in the house. Her name was Mary Baker DeGraffenreid, and the two words were *we continue*, and the month she wrote them was the month she married a man named Gideon Johnson — the eighteenth of November 1779, by the entry a collateral family kept in their own Bible and by which we can still, two hundred and forty-seven years later, put a date to the wedding. She was the great-granddaughter of the woman who had come down a gangway at Charleston in 1714. She was the first woman in the line to hold the family's Bible in her own two hands, which came to her at her grandfather's death in 1794, and she held it for the rest of her life, and she died on the first of January 1823.

This volume opens fifty years and eight hundred miles from that desk, in a front room on a cleared ridge in north Mississippi, on the last morning of October in 1850, with three women in it. The road between the two rooms is the road this bridge walks, and it is walked, the whole way, by daughters — each one a daughter of the last, each one carrying the keeping into a new name and, twice, into a new country, so that the thing handed down the road was never quite the same book but was always the same act.

Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson had a daughter named Sarah, born on the ninth of October 1780, the first of Gideon Johnson's children by the record the Chadwells kept. Sarah grew up in the Virginia-and-Carolina country the second volume lived in, and in the winter of 1798 — the third of February, by the marriage bond, which survives — she married a man named William Hubbard, and with that marriage the keeping crossed into a second book. The Hubbards started their own family Bible, William and Sarah, and wrote their own names on its fly-leaf in a plain English hand that no one needed a translator for, and the deGraffenreid book with its formal French stayed behind with the elder generation while the young couple carried the newer one west. For the Hubbards were moving. By the first years of the new century the household had come down out of the old seaboard country and onto the Tennessee ground, into Stewart County on the Cumberland, where William Hubbard turns up in the records a working man of the new country — on a jury in 1804, on the tax books in 1806 and 1807, holding land by 1808 and again in 1813.

He died that year, in August of 1813, and he left a will, and the will is the hinge on which a good deal of this family's provenance turns, because it names his daughter Polly. It named her a legacy, too, and the legacy is a thing this book will not walk past. Among the property William Hubbard disposed of to his children was a one-fifth share of an enslaved girl named Anseline, and the fifth that went to Polly is recorded not by guess but by a legal instrument — a power of

attorney, dated the twelfth of March 1828, signed by Polly's husband, in which he appoints an agent to go and receive on his wife's behalf the share of the girl Anseline that Polly's father had left her. So the keeping the daughters carried down this road was not an innocent keeping. Before ever the family stood on the Mississippi dirt this volume is about, a father in Tennessee had willed a daughter a piece of a girl, and the daughter's husband had gone to law to collect it. Anseline was a person. She is named here because she was named there, in the will and in the deed, and because a family history that means to be honest about what the daughters carried has to carry that too, and not fold it into the scenery of a migration. What became of her the record does not yet say. The book holds the question open.

The husband who signed that 1828 paper was Reuben Rorie. He had been born on the thirtieth of August 1799, and he had married Polly Hubbard on the twenty-sixth of March 1820, in Stewart County, Tennessee, and with that marriage the keeping crossed into a third book. The Rories started their own family Bible, Reuben and Polly, the way Polly's own parents had started theirs, and on its births leaf, in among the children, is the entry this whole volume rests on: a daughter born to Reuben and Polly Rorie on the twenty-first of November 1832 — set down by a later copyist's uncertain hand as *Milbry or Mity Jane*, but Mary Jane, the girl who would marry Freeman Searcy and give the line the name on the cover of this book. She was born on the Tennessee ground her grandparents had come to. She would not grow up on it.

Because the Rories moved too, the way the Hubbards had moved before them, the way the whole American century moved the ordinary families of it — west and a little south, off the worked-out older ground and onto the newer, cheaper, harder dirt that was opening beyond the next river. Sometime around 1846 the Rorie household came down off the Cumberland country and into the northeast corner of Mississippi, into Tishomingo County, onto a ridge three miles north of the post road, and Mary Jane came with them a girl of fourteen, so that the Tennessee she had been born in became a thing she remembered the way you remember a house you left as a child. Her grandmother came down after them, the next year, in 1847 — Sarah, who had married William Hubbard and buried him young and married twice more and outlived all of it, a woman near seventy now with the whole traveled length of the line behind her, come to live out the end of it in a daughter's house because there was nowhere else left to go.

And that is the front room this volume opens in. The old woman in the corner bed, propped on the bolster with her white hair in its loose plait, watching her granddaughter throw the shuttle across the loom — that is Sarah Johnson Hubbard, the daughter of the fifteen-year-old who wrote *we continue*, the granddaughter of the granddaughter of the woman who came down the gangway at Charleston. She had carried the keeping down out of Virginia and across Tennessee and onto this ridge, and she was the far living end of it, and she said, most days, very little. The woman at the churn is her daughter, Mary Polly

Hubbard Rorie, who would carry both the Hubbard Bible and the Rorie Bible into her own son's house forty years on, a widow, in her own lap. And the girl at the loom, keeping the count, is Mary Jane — the fourth daughter down the road from Lunenburg, and the one this book stays with, from the last morning she would ever be written down right to the last morning of all.

The record is coming up the road toward that house. It is 1850, and the marshal will be there within the hour. Here is the girl he is coming to count.

Chapter 1 — The Man With the Book

Seventeen

On the last day of October, in 1850, a girl of not-quite-eighteen stood at the loom in the front room of her father's house on a cleared ridge in north Mississippi and threw the shuttle across and caught it and threw it back, and she was, that morning, exactly what the world would shortly write her down to be, which was almost the only time in her long life that would ever be true.

Her name was Mary Jane Rorie. She had been born on the twenty-first of November of 1832, in Stewart County, Tennessee, in a house she did not remember, to Reuben Rorie and Mary Polly Hubbard Rorie, the seventh of the children her mother would carry; and she would turn eighteen in three weeks. She had come down into Mississippi as a girl of fourteen, in the removal that had brought the whole Rorie household off the Tennessee ground and onto this ridge three miles north of the post road, and she had grown the rest of the way up here, on this dirt, in this house, so that the Tennessee she had been born in was a thing she knew from her mother's telling and not from her own memory. She was seventeen years old. She was tall for a Rorie and brown-haired and steady-handed at the loom, and she had her mother's way of doing a thing all the way through before she set it down, and she was, on the last morning of October in 1850, a girl at the front edge of her life with the whole of it still folded up ahead of her and not one line of it written yet.

The loom was the cold-months' work. The cotton was in, the garden was down to the late greens and the root crops, and the long turn of the year had come round to the inside work — the wheel and the loom and the mending, the tasks a woman did by the fire while the weather did what it did outside. Mary Jane liked the loom. She liked the count of it, the way the pattern lived in the counting and came up true under her hands if she kept the count and went wrong the moment she lost it, so that the work asked something of her attention and gave it back as cloth. She was weaving a length of plain wool that would be a winter dress before Christmas — hers, or Nancy's, whichever of them the length best fit when it came off the loom — and she threw the shuttle and caught it and threw it back, and the morning went by her in the small steady sounds of a working house.

Her mother was across the room at the churn. Mary Polly Hubbard Rorie was forty-six that autumn — though the man who was coming up the road that morning would write her down at forty, six years short, for a reason no one ever recorded and Mary Jane never learned — and she stood at the churn and worked the dash up and down in the long even stroke she had used at it for thirty years, and she did not hurry it and she did not slow it, and the butter would come when the butter came. Her mother was the fixed center of that room the way she was the fixed center of the whole house. Whatever went on in it — the children crossing it, the fire wanting wood, a pot coming to the boil, a thing spilled or

dropped or gone wrong — her mother's hands went to the next thing and the next thing and the house held its shape around her. Mary Jane had grown up watching those hands, not for the meaning of them but for the order of them, the way a child learns the rooms of a house by being inside them, until the order her mother kept was the ground Mary Jane stood on and did not think to notice she was standing on.

And in the corner of the front room, in the small bed by the warm wall where the chimney came through, was the third of the women in that house, and she was the oldest, and she was watching the other two.

Her name was Sarah, and she was Mary Polly's mother, and she was sixty-eight years old that autumn, and she had come down from Tennessee three years before, in 1847, when the last of the arrangements that had held her own household together had come apart and there had been nowhere left for her to go but to a daughter's house. She had been born in the Carolina piedmont before there was a country to be a citizen of. She had married a Hubbard and buried him young, and married again after him, and again after that, and had outlasted all of it, three husbands and a long hard traveling life, and had come at the end of it down the roads out of Tennessee to the bed in the corner of Mary Polly's front room, where she now spent the most of her days propped on the bolster with her white hair in the loose night-plait she never troubled to put up anymore, watching her daughter keep the house and her granddaughters do the work, and saying, most days, very little.

But she watched. She watched Mary Jane at the loom that morning with the particular attention old women give to the young ones doing the old work, and after a while she said, in the dry unhurried voice she still had, "You keep the count better than your mother did at your age."

Mary Jane did not stop the shuttle. "Mother says you say that to whichever of us is at the loom."

"I say it to whichever of you is keeping the count." The old woman shifted on the bolster. "Your mother lost it, at your age. Threw the pattern out three rows running one winter at Stewart and had to pick it all back. She has told you no such thing, I expect."

"She has not."

"No," Sarah said, and there was something in the dry voice that was almost a smile. "She would not." And she let it go, and watched, and Mary Jane threw the shuttle and caught it, and across the room the churn went up and down, and the three of them were in the room together on the last morning of October in the plain unremarkable way of a working forenoon, and none of them knew — there was no reason any of them should have known — that the morning was one the family would come back to.

Because the record was coming up the road. And the record, that once, was going to get her right.

* * *

The house on the ridge

It is worth saying what kind of house it was, before the man with the book comes to it, because everything that the rest of this volume turns on begins from the fact that it was a good house and a rising one, and that the girl at the loom in it was not a poor man's daughter with nothing ahead of her but a landed man's daughter with, by every reckoning anyone could have made that morning, a great deal ahead of her.

Reuben Rorie was fifty-one that autumn, and he was a millwright, and he had made himself, out of the raw ground and his own two hands, a standing man. He had come off the Yadkin country in North Carolina as a young man, up into Stewart County in Tennessee, and down at last into Mississippi in the removal of the middle forties, and everywhere he had gone he had done the thing a millwright does, which is to find the water and read the fall of it and build the works that turn the fall of water into meal and money. He had built the mill on this ground the way he had built the house — deliberately, all the way through, in the slow sure way he did most things — and by the autumn of 1850 the mill was turning and the money was coming and the place was worth, by the figure that would go into the government's book that day, two thousand dollars. That was a great deal in that country. That was a front-of-the-meeting-house figure, a figure that made a man's daughters into matches and his opinion into something worth the asking. The Rories were not gentry and did not pretend to be. But they were a rising family on good ground with a trade behind them and money coming in, and the girl at the loom was the daughter of that house, and the world that autumn had every reason to expect that a daughter of that house would marry well and soon.

The house held, that autumn, a shifting number of Rories, the way such houses did — some grown and gone, some grown and near, some still under the loft. The oldest girls were married out and away. Louisa Adeline, the second daughter, had married Alexander Houston and was settled so close that her household was the very next place down the ridge, near enough that the two families' children ran between the dooryards and the two women called back and forth across the low ground of an evening. A grown son of one-and-twenty was reading his books at a place a few doors along, being made into whatever a rising millwright's eldest son was to be made into. And under Reuben and Mary Polly's own roof there were still the middle children and the young ones — Mary Jane at seventeen, and Nancy at fifteen, and the boys, and the grandmother in the corner — the loft not yet emptied, the table still long with children, the house at the full tide of its life.

And the keeping of it all — the record of who had come into that house and when, the births set down and the marriages set down, the line the family drew of

itself through time — sat on a shelf in the front room in a worn black book, and it was Mary Polly's, and it was the still point at the middle of everything.

Mary Jane had grown up with the Bible the way a child grows up with the weather. It was simply there, on the shelf, the book her mother took down on the mornings of consequential days and opened to the family pages and laid the pen across, in the way her mother had been taught by the old woman now in the corner, and that old woman by her mother before her, back up a line of women that ran out of sight. The births were in it in Mary Polly's careful hand — the children set down one after another down the years, in the hand her mother had practiced for a year before she had had to use it, so that when the day came the wrist would not shake. Mary Jane's own line was there. She had read it, growing up, the way you read a thing so often the reading wears smooth: her name, in her mother's hand, and the day of her birth, the twenty-first of November, 1832. It did not, to her knowledge, get her name quite plainly — the family's records had a way of not getting anyone's name quite plainly, the surname wandering off the Carolina tongue, the given names coming out sideways in one hand or another — but it was there, she was in the book, she was one of the household the book held. She had not thought much about it. She was seventeen. The book held the household and the household held the book, and her business in the world was to grow up inside the keeping of it and, in her own time, to walk into the line that would be written for her when her own consequential day came.

Everyone in that house that autumn believed her consequential day was near. That is the thing to hold, going into the rest of this book, because it is the thing the rest of this book spends seventy years disproving. A landed millwright's daughter of seventeen, steady-handed and well-grown, in a rising house on good ground — of course she would marry, and marry well, and soon, and her mother would take the Bible down of a morning and lay the pen across the marriages page and write her onto it in the careful hand the way she had written Elizabeth and Louisa Adeline, and the line would go on. Everyone believed it. There was no reason on the last morning of October in 1850 not to believe it. It was the most ordinary expectation in the world, and it was wrong, and no one in the house would find out how wrong for a very long time.

* * *

Scruggs

He came up the ridge road a little before noon, a man on a horse with a satchel of papers, and he was the assistant marshal for the fourth district of the northern division of Tishomingo County, and his name was Wm. Scruggs, and he was taking the census of 1850.

Mary Jane saw him from the loom, through the front window, the way she saw anyone come up the road — a rider she did not know, at a stranger's easy pace, with the look of a man on an errand rather than a man coming to call. Her mother

had heard, the week before, that the counting was working its way through the district; the Houstons next door had been done, and the families down toward the post road; and so when the rider turned in at the Rorie lane there was no alarm in the house, only the small rearrangement a working house makes when a stranger comes to the door on business. Reuben came in from the mill-lot. Mary Polly set down the churn-dash and wiped her hands and put the room to rights with three or four motions the way she put any room to rights. Mary Jane stopped the loom and stood up from the bench. The grandmother, in the corner, stayed where she was and watched.

It was the head of the house the marshal wanted, and Reuben sat down with him at the front-room table, and the two men did the business of the counting while the house went quietly on around them. Scruggs opened the great ruled ledger and dipped his pen and began to ask his questions in the flat working way of a man who has asked them at a hundred doors that season and will ask them at a hundred more, and Reuben answered them in the unhurried way he answered anything, and the pen went, and the family of Reuben Rorie began to go down into the permanent record of the United States a line at a time.

Mary Jane did not have much to do with it. She stood a little off, by the cold loom, and half-listened the way you half-listen to grown men doing business at the table, and she heard the questions come and her father's answers go, and she heard the pen. She heard the marshal take down the name — and get it wrong, of course, the way it was always got wrong, some spelling of *Rora* that was not *Rorie*, and her father not troubling to correct it, because you did not spend the marshal's time and your own teaching a government man to spell a name he would never say again. She heard the trade set down: millwright. She heard the value of the place named — two thousand dollars — and heard it go into the book, the figure that said what the Rories were. She heard her father's own age given, and her mother's, and the ages of the children as the marshal came to them one by one.

And then the marshal came to her.

He asked, and her father answered, and the answer was the plain true one, because there was no reason that autumn for it to be anything else. She was seventeen. She was seventeen years old, three weeks short of eighteen, and her father said *seventeen*, and the marshal wrote *seventeen*, and it went into the book true. There was no shame in it and nothing to manage and no two years to be quietly taken off, because seventeen was a girl and a girl was only a girl and the whole world expected a girl of seventeen to be exactly what she was, which was a young woman at the front of her life with everything still ahead. The record asked how old she was and was told the truth and wrote the truth down.

She did not mark it, that morning. Why would she have? A girl of seventeen does not stand by a cold loom and think, *the record has told the truth about me*, because a girl of seventeen has never yet been in a room where the record did anything else. She heard her age go into the book the way she heard her brothers'

and her sister's ages go into it, as one more plain fact of a working forenoon, and she thought nothing of it, and went back, when the marshal had passed on to Nancy, to looking at the cold loom and thinking about the length of wool and whether it would come off long enough to be her dress or Nancy's.

But it was, though she could not have known it, the one clean true thing the record would ever set down about her that she would live to see. She was seventeen in the book of 1850 and she was seventeen in fact, and the two agreed. There would be another man with another book in ten years, and another after him, on and on down her life at the ten-year turn the government kept; and each of them in his turn would get her a little more wrong than the last, until the getting-wrong was the whole of what the record had to say about her. But that was all ahead, and unimaginable, and none of it was in the front room that morning. The record asked how old she was, and was told the truth, and wrote the truth down, and closed its book and rode away up the ridge. It would not do her that plain kindness again.

She did not know that. She stood by the loom. The marshal wrote down Nancy, fifteen, and the boys, and closed off the Rorie household and thanked Reuben and gathered his papers, and Mary Polly gave him a cup of something warm at the door the way you did, and he got back on his horse and rode on up the ridge to the next house, carrying the Rories with him in the ledger, seventeen-year-old Mary Jane and all, on his long slow walk through the counting of the county.

* * *

Nine doors

There is one more thing in the book of 1850, and Mary Jane had no knowledge of it that day, and it is the thing the whole of the rest of her life would turn on, and so it belongs at the end of this chapter even though she was blind to it, the way the beginning of a life is always blind to itself.

Scruggs, riding on up the ridge from the Rorie place that afternoon, went on counting — house after house along the road, the near families and then the ones a little farther, the way the counting went — and nine dwellings on from Reuben Rorie's door he came to another house, and he stopped, and he took it down the same way he had taken the Rories: the head of the house, the trade, the value of the place, the ages of the people in it. The head of this house was a man named Aaron Searcy. He was fifty-three, a farmer, born in North Carolina like Reuben, come down through Georgia and Alabama into Mississippi by another road than the Rories had taken but into the same neighborhood at nearly the same time. His place was worth a good deal less than Reuben's — a farmer's holding, not a millwright's — but it was a household of its own on its own ground, a man and his wife Martha and a houseful of children, the ordinary substantial family of the

ridge. And among the children Scruggs wrote down that afternoon, one of the sons, was a young man of twenty named Freeman.

That was all. A young man of twenty, nine doors up the ridge, in a farmer's house, written into the same book on the same afternoon as the girl of seventeen at the loom. Neither house knew the other was on the page. There was no reason either should have. They were neighbors on a ridge where everyone was a neighbor, the Rories and the Searcys and the Houstons and the rest, and the young man of twenty and the girl of seventeen had very likely seen each other at the meeting-house or the crossroads store the way everyone on that ridge had seen everyone, by sight and by name and by nothing more; and there was nothing between them, and nothing was going to be between them for a very long time. He was a farmer's son of twenty. She was a millwright's daughter of seventeen, expected to marry well and soon. The book set them down nine doors apart on the last day of October in 1850 and moved on, and the two of them went back to their two houses and their two forenoons and their two lives, which did not touch.

They would touch. Seventeen years on, in a county that would by then have changed its name, in a world that would by then have broken and been half-remade by a war neither of them could imagine that autumn, the girl of seventeen and the young man of twenty would stand up together at last and marry — she thirty-four by then and he thirty-six, the both of them long past the age the ridge had expected it of them, come together at the far end of everything by a road so plain that no one that autumn would have called it a road. But that was seventeen years off, and a war off, and a lifetime of waiting off, and none of it was in the book of 1850. In the book of 1850 there were only the two households nine doors apart, and the girl at the loom in the one, seventeen and rightly recorded and expecting her life to start at any moment, and the young man in the other, twenty and landless-to-be, and the whole long strange distance between that morning and the morning they would finally marry lying ahead of them both, unwritten, unimagined, and not to be hurried.

Nine doors. Seventeen and twenty. The last day of October, 1850.

Nothing happened for seventeen years.

That is the pole this book opens on, and it is the truest thing the record ever gave her — a girl of seventeen at a loom in a rising house, set down plainly and correctly in the government's book on an ordinary autumn forenoon, with her whole life ahead of her and everyone she loved expecting it to begin, and a young man she barely knew nine doors up the same ridge in the same book on the same day; and then the book closing, and the marshal riding on, and the years beginning to turn over her the slow way they turn, carrying her out of the one true morning the record ever gave her and into all the years it would spend getting her wrong.

Chapter 2 — The Town That Came Out of the Woods

The wheel that went nowhere

The town came up out of the north woods in the space of a few seasons, and it reached Mary Jane the way the wide world always reached her, which was late, and secondhand, and at the supper table.

She was twenty years old the year the surveyors went into the pinewoods thirteen miles north of the mill and began running a chain through ground that had grown nothing but timber in the whole memory of the county. Two railroads were to cross there, one laid the length of the state and one laid clean across the top of it, and where two railroads crossed a town would come, because freight must stop and be turned where the lines meet and men must be there to turn it. Her father had it off a man at Jacinto. Her brother brought pieces of it home from the road. It came into the house the way news came into the house, carried in of an evening and turned over above the plates and set down again — a town, up north, in the empty woods — and Mary Jane heard it the way she heard all of it, with half an ear, a niece asleep against her shoulder or a bowl in her two hands, and thought no more about it than she thought about weather in a county she would never stand in. It had nothing to do with her. Nothing up in the north woods had anything to do with a daughter in a mill-house thirteen miles south.

But it went up, and it went up faster than anything in that country had ever gone up, and even at thirteen miles she could not help but feel the strangeness of it — that a piece of ground could do the most remarkable thing a piece of ground can do, come into being out of nothing, take a name and then a better name and fill with people who had not been born there and would die calling it home, all in the few years a girl spends going from twenty to twenty-four; and that in the house where she lived, in those same few years, nothing came into being at all.

They called it Cross City first, for the plain fact of the crossing, and then somebody with a little learning put it that the town stood where a country's roads met the way the roads of the old Greek city had met on its neck of land between two seas, and the Greeks had called that place Corinth. So the town in the Tishomingo pinewoods was called Corinth after a city three thousand miles and three thousand years off that not one soul in her father's house would ever lay eyes on. Mary Jane, who had been entered in her mother's Bible under a name the family's own hand could never quite settle, lived thirteen miles from a town that had been named twice before it was even finished. She did not make anything of the likeness. She would not have thought to. But it was there — a place that got two names before it was done, and a girl down the road who could not reliably get one.

She was in her father's house the whole while it happened. That is the thing those years were made of, and it is the thing to hold, because it does not announce itself the way a wedding or a death announces itself; it is only a girl in a

house, and the house going on, and the years going by. She was twenty, and then she was twenty-one, and then she was twenty-two, and each birthday she was exactly what she had been the birthday before — a daughter on her father's ground, carrying her father's name — and the count ran on quietly under the seasons the way the creek ran on under the mill, and nobody yet marked it.

The mill was the ground-note under every hour of her life. Reuben Rorie's wheel took the creek and gave back meal and sawn plank the whole of every day, and Mary Jane had grown up and was growing older inside the sound of it — the smell of wet stone and cut pine, the jolt when the gate came up and the wheel took the water, the long even turning that was there before she woke and there when she slept. She knew the mill the way you know a thing you have never once been asked whether you wanted. And there was a thought she had about the wheel, standing at the race of a morning with a bucket in her hand while it turned, that she never put into words and was never asked for and would not have spoken aloud if she had been: that the wheel was the busiest thing on the whole place and went nowhere. It labored from first light to last. It took the water and made the water into work. And at nightfall it stood exactly where it had stood at dawn, having traveled, for all its turning, not one step off its own axle.

She did not say to herself, *I am like the wheel*. A woman does not say such things to herself in so many words, and if the thought came near her she turned her hands to the next task and let it go by. But she was like the wheel, and some part of her knew it, and the knowing was one of the quiet weights she carried into her twenties. A daughter is in motion from the time she is big enough to carry a bucket. She is never once still. From the first light she is at the fire and the churn and the wash and the loom and the garden and the sick-bed and the cradle, and she does not stop, and she does not sit, and the work of her is the frame the whole house hangs on. And she does not move. The house turns her the way the creek turns the wheel, hard and steady and in one place, and the years go over her, and she is at nightfall where she was at dawn.

Thirteen miles north the world was laying down rails and raising depots and making a city where there had been trees. On the Rorie ridge the wheel turned and the creek ran and Mary Jane went from twenty to twenty-two doing everything and going nowhere, and there was nothing yet that anyone in the house would have called the matter.

* * *

The house in the yard

The town was thirteen miles off, and she watched it come out of the woods the way you watch weather in a county you will never stand in. The other new thing of that decade stood in her own dooryard. It was not weather, and it was not thirteen miles off, and no one in the house spoke of it as a thing that had happened,

because it was not a thing anyone in that house would have thought to call a happening at all.

When the first man with the first book had come up the ridge in 1850 and counted the Rories, he had carried, as every marshal did, a second book beside the one he wrote the family into — the one the government kept for the people it counted as property — and on that second book, against her father's name, he had written nothing, because in 1850 there was no one on the Rorie place to write. Reuben Rorie held no one. Mary Jane was seventeen that year, at the loom, in a house that owned its land and its mill and its stock and not one human being.

By the time the second man with the second book came, ten years on, that had changed. When the marshal of 1860 filled the government's second book against her father's name, he wrote three people onto it — a woman well into her sixties, a man in the strength of his thirties, and a girl of seven — and, in the column the book kept for such things, one house. A slave house, standing in the Rorie yard. It had not been there when Mary Jane was a girl. Somebody had built it in the years between the two books, in the same decade the town rose in the north and the brothers married and the babies came and were given back; and Mary Jane, who was in the house the whole while, going from seventeen to twenty-seven, had seen it built, or seen it standing where nothing had stood, and had watched the three come onto the place who had not been there before.

She did not grow up alongside this, and the two books are what tell it, set side by side. A child born into a slaveholding house grows up never having known the place without the people held in it; they are part of the given world, like the mill and the weather, and a child does not question the given world. Mary Jane was not that child. She had been seventeen and grown when there was no one, and she was twenty-seven and grown when there were three and a house, and the whole of the arrival happened in front of her, across her young womanhood, in the yard she crossed a dozen times a day. Whatever she made of it — and the record does not say, and this book will not put into her a feeling she left no trace of — she did not make it as a thing she had always known. She made it as a thing that had come.

Who they were, the record scarcely says, and this book will not invent past it: a woman born around the turn of the old century, old already by the time she came; a man born around 1824, in his prime; and a child, born around 1853, in the middle of the decade, on that ground or brought to it small. They had names — of course they had names, said in that house in the yard a thousand times in the ordinary run of three lives — and the books that counted them kept only the ages and the sex and the one word for the color, and the names did not come down. How the three came onto the Rorie place — bought with the mill's money, or come down through her mother's people, or by some other road entirely — the record does not say either, and it will not be guessed here, because guessing is the one thing the discipline of this book forbids most where these three are concerned.

What became of them — the years they were held on that ground, the war that came over it, the freedom that reached them at the end of it, and the accounting this book owes them in their own right — belongs to a later chapter, on the far side of the war, where it can be given the room it is owed. Here, in the decade of the town and the marriages and the given-back children, the fact is only the plainest one, and the book sets it down and goes on the way the household went on: that across the same ten years in which nothing at all happened to Mary Jane, three people came onto her father's ground who had not been there before, and a house went up in the yard to hold them, and she was there for the whole of it, grown, and watching.

* * *

Everyone's beginnings

The town thirteen miles off filled up with strangers. The road at home filled up with kin. And Mary Jane, who was the reason for none of it, was somehow in the middle of all of it, with her arms full of other women's children.

For the same years Corinth was making itself out of the woods, the Rorie place and the places around it were doing the older, quieter building — not depots but marriages, not boarding-houses but new households struck off the old one and set down within a mile of it, the way a family that means to stay puts its young down close. Her sister had gone that way years back; Louisa Adeline had married at fifteen and set up one door up the same road, near enough that the two households' children ran between the dooryards. Now, through the middle of the decade, it was the brothers' turn, and one by one they took it.

Ezekiah went first — the brother nearest her in age, the boy of seventeen the first marshal had counted in the house, grown now into a man with a plan and his father's mill money under it. He married in those years and did the whole of what a landed man's son was raised to do: took a wife, took ground, and began to put children into a house of his own, so that before the decade closed he had a young family and a farm and something near two thousand dollars of land — his father's own figure of ten years back, reached by the son in half the time. William followed, the one the first book had marked with that uncommon word, *Student* — whatever the reading had been meant to make of him, the decade made him a married farmer like the rest, a wife and a household and his own ground. The two of them went, out of the father's house and into houses of their own, and the road past the mill took on in a few years two more Rorie roofs with Rorie children under them, and the family thickened on its ground the way it liked to, everyone within a morning's walk.

What Mary Jane did, in all that arriving, was hold the children.

That was the work the daughter who stays is given, and she was given it in full. When her sister's babies came she was in the house, and when her brothers' babies came she was in the house, and one after another the whole crop of nieces

and nephews the decade brought was put into her arms to be hushed while the mother rested — the new weight of a thing a few days old, the hot heavy head against the inside of her elbow, the small blind mouth working at nothing, the particular ache in the forearm that comes of holding a sleeping infant still past the point your arm would like to set it down. She knew that ache well. She had it a hundred times over those years. She was good with them and they quieted for her and she gave them back, and she was there for the next one, and the next; and every one of them was somebody else's beginning, put into her arms warm and given back, and none of them was hers.

She felt it most, she found, in the giving-back. The holding was only holding; any pair of arms will hold a baby. It was the moment the mother reached to take the child again — reached from her childbed or her chair with the plain unthinking certainty of a woman taking back her own — that Mary Jane felt the exact shape of what she did not have, and handed the warm weight over, and stood up, and went to see about the supper. She did not weep about it. There was nothing to weep about that she could have named to anyone. She was a great help to her mother and a favorite of the children and a fixed useful presence at every birth and every wedding and every laying-out the family had, fully inside the life of her people and nowhere near the middle of one of her own; and she carried the ache the way she carried the baby, quietly, in the arm, until it was time to set it down and turn to the next thing.

And beside her, all the while, was Nancy.

Nancy Ann was four years back down the line from her and unmarried too, and that was the fact that turned the thing from a girl's private matter into a shape the house had taken. One daughter past the usual age might be a girl who simply had not been asked. Two daughters kept at home began to look like a household arranged around something — around a father who liked his girls where he could see them, or a place that wanted their hands, or only the plain drift of years in a house too busy to notice a life not starting. Mary Jane never knew which, and it was likely no single one. But there the two of them were, the elder past the family's fast clock and the younger coming up on it, and no wedding in prospect for either; and the two of them knew it about each other in the wordless way of sisters, and did not speak of it, and went on doing between them the endless work of a house full of everyone's children but their own.

For the clock had always run fast in that line. Her mother had married at fifteen. Her grandmother near it. Louisa at fifteen. There had not been, in anyone's memory, a Rorie woman who came to her middle twenties with the crossing from daughter to wife still unmade — and Mary Jane was making no crossing at all. She was twenty-three, and then twenty-four, and then twenty-five, and twenty-three is not late and twenty-four is not late, and even twenty-five is only a number a house does not yet say out loud; but the number climbed, and the silence around it thickened, and the not-saying settled over the house the way dust settles in a room nobody has decided to close up. Nobody was unkind. There

was no word spoken and regretted. There was only the absence of the word — the thing everyone could see and no one named — and the years going by, and the house staying full of everybody's life but hers.

It was the fullest that house would ever be, those middle years of the decade — the mill at its height, the sons setting up, the grandchildren coming, the two daughters at home, and the old grandmother still in her corner by the fire. Mary Jane stood in the thick of all of it and off to the side of all of it at once, her arms full and her hands never idle and her own life not yet begun, and she held the whole fullness of that house the way she held its babies: warm against her, and not hers, and waiting to be given back.

And then, toward the end of the decade, the fullness began to go — not the way she had half-stopped letting herself expect her own life to begin, by someone arriving, but the other way, by someone leaving. The first to go would be the oldest. She would go from the corner by the fire.

* * *

What she learned over the body

Grandmother Sarah died in the fall of 1857, in her own bed in the warm corner, with her daughter's household around her and her work long behind her; and it was Mary Jane, among the women, who washed her and dressed her and made her ready for the ground.

She was twenty-four that fall. She had known the old woman all her life — the hand on the cheek, cool and very dry, that was the grandmother's way of saying *yes, you, yes here*; the dry unhurried voice from the bed in the corner; the white hair in the loose night-plait; the ten years the old woman had spent in that corner since she had come down the roads out of Tennessee with three husbands buried behind her and one daughter's roof still open. Sarah had been born in the Carolina piedmont in 1780, before there was a country for her to belong to, and she had outlasted nearly everything a long life can ask a woman to outlast, and at the end of it she had done what the very old did in that country: she had let go of her own house and been taken into a child's, given the warm place out of the draft, and she had died there, counted at the last under a younger woman's roof.

They laid her out in the house, the way it was done before there was a trade to do it. Mary Jane's hands were among the hands that did it. She helped lift and wash the old body — lighter than she had braced for, the way the very old go light — and she worked with a steadiness that surprised her a little even as she found it in herself, because someone had to and because she could. She folded the dry hands she had felt on her own cheek so many times. She dressed her grandmother in the good dress and smoothed it and set the white hair right. And she did not weep more than the work allowed, and she did not know, doing it, that she was serving the first apprenticeship of a long calling.

But she was. These were the first hands she would ever lay a dead person's clothes on, and they would by no means be the last. She was learning, at twenty-four, over the body of the grandmother who had come down from Tennessee, the plain necessary office she would go on performing for nearly everyone she loved across the sixty years still ahead of her — the washing and the dressing and the folding of the hands, the steadiness a family needs from the one woman in it who can give the dead their due without going to pieces. It would fall to her again and again. It fell to her first here, with the wash-cloth in her hand and the fall light coming in low, and she did it well, and she went afterward back into the house that was one person emptier than it had been.

She could not have said, and did not try to, that she had just watched the whole shape of a woman's life laid out in front of her from the far end. But she had. Sarah had kept her own people and her own ground as long as her body would allow, and then had been taken in, folded into a daughter's house, given the corner, counted under a younger roof — and now had been carried out of it, made ready by younger hands. It was the shape the house would make of its women one after another down the years, and Mary Jane was standing inside the first turn of it with the cloth still in her hand and no way to see the others coming. She would be one of the younger hands a long time yet. And then, at the very far end, in another county, under a name the record would have spent her whole life mislaying, she would be the old woman herself, made ready by hands not yet born, gentle the way hers were gentle now.

That was one of the decade's leavings. The other came from the far end of the road.

Nine doors up — in the house the first marshal had reached after nine dwellings of other people's lives, the house of the old farmer and his wife and their houseful of near-grown children — the old man died too, somewhere in those same years, and the record does not fix the day and this account will not pretend to one. Aaron Searcy had been an old man already when the first book counted him, and he did not see the decade out. Mary Jane barely knew him. He was the old man up the road, a name at the meeting-house, a face at the store — one of the older generation of the ridge, come from Carolina by a longer road than her own people, who had been a soldier once in his youth, they said, in a war fought before Mississippi was a place anyone here had heard of; but that was the kind of thing the young know about the old only vaguely, as a rumor of a life lived before their own began, and Mary Jane had never had it from the man himself and could not have told you the war or the year. What she knew of the Searcys was what a neighbor knows: that they were up the road, that they were poorer than her own people, that the old man was failing. When he died, the ridge lost one of its old men, and that was all it was to her — an old veteran gone quiet in his bed nine doors up from a girl who had never once been told his name, and never once thought to ask it.

His dying left his children with next to nothing. Whatever small holding the old man had put together had not outlasted him, and what he left his sons and daughters was little enough; and one of those sons was a man in his middle twenties named Freeman, who had nothing of his own to begin with and now had nothing from his father either, and who stayed on after in other men's fields, a hired pair of hands, the poorest grown man on a road of landed families. He was nine doors, still, from the girl in the mill-house. The two of them had been written into the same book once, years back, a boy of twenty and a girl of seventeen, and neither of them knew it, and neither of them knew the other was alive to be waited for. He was only a poor man made poorer, at the far end of the road, in the same few years that took the old woman from the Rorie fire.

So the decade that had built a town out of the north woods took, at its own end, an old woman and an old man, and left the two houses at the two ends of the road each one person lighter and each one turn further along. And Mary Jane came out of it twenty-seven years old.

Something had happened in those ten years, if anyone had asked her to weigh them, and no one did. A town had risen out of nothing thirteen miles off and been given the name of a city on the other side of the world. Her brothers had married and gone to their own roofs; her sister's children and her brothers' children had come up around her, and she had held every one of them and given every one of them back. The grandmother had died in the corner and been washed and dressed by her own hands. The house was not the house the first marshal had counted, not quite, not anymore. The world had done a great deal of moving in ten years.

But none of it had moved her. She was twenty-seven and unmarried in her father's house, on her father's ground, carrying her father's name, exactly as she had been at seventeen at the loom — only older now, and more useful, and more plainly past the hour the county set for a woman; and the ache she carried in the arm when she gave the babies back had had ten years to deepen, and the silence in the house around the fact of her had had ten years to set. She did not know what was to become of her. She had stopped being able to say, even to herself in the dark, that her own life was surely about to begin, because she had been saying it a long time and it had not, and a woman can only tell herself a thing so many years running before she quietly lets go of saying it.

And already, though she did not know it, the ten-year turn had come round again, and a second man with a second book was somewhere on the roads of the county, working his way toward the ridge; and when he reached the mill-house he would set the household down in his ruled columns the way the first one had, and he would come to the daughter, and this time the house would not give him the truth.

But that belonged to the next year, and the next chapter, and Mary Jane at twenty-seven could not see it coming any more than she could see the war that was coming behind it. She only came out of the decade the way she had gone into

it — in the house, on the ground, her hands full and her own life not yet begun — while thirteen miles north the town that had come out of the woods went on getting bigger, and the wheel at her father's race went on turning, and stood at nightfall where it had stood at dawn.

Chapter 3 — Twenty-Five

The daughter who stayed

By the summer of 1860 she had been waiting so long that the waiting had stopped feeling like waiting and started feeling like the weather.

She was twenty-seven years old. She had been born on the twenty-first of November of 1832, in the cold end of that year, in Tennessee, and she had come down into Mississippi as a girl of fourteen or fifteen with the rest of them, and she had lived on the Rorie ridge ever since, three miles north of the post road, in the house her father had raised out of the cleared land, and nothing that the world would call an event had happened to her in all that time. She had not married. She had not gone anywhere. She had not buried a child of her own or borne one or stood up at her own wedding in the parlor the way her older sisters had stood up at theirs. She had gotten older, which is not an event. She had gotten older in the same house, on the same ridge, doing the same work, so slowly and so evenly that there was no day she could have pointed to and said, *there, that was the day something changed*, because nothing had changed, and the not-changing had gone on for ten years, and she was twenty-seven.

The house was not a poor house and it was not an unhappy one, and that was the strange part, the part she could not have explained to anyone who had not lived inside it. Her father was a man of means. Reuben Rorie was sixty that year, gray at the temples and slow at the one knee a horse had ruined in his forties, but the mill he had built had run all through the decade her sisters were marrying and it had made him money the whole time, so that by the summer of 1860 he was worth, by the reckoning the government would shortly take down, five thousand dollars — a great deal of money in that country, a standing-man's money, the kind of money that put a family at the front of the meeting-house and made a father's opinion worth the asking at the crossroads store. Her mother kept a full larder and a stocked press. There was coffee in the house that summer and sugar in the crock. The Rories were doing well. Everyone said so.

And a part of what they were worth, that summer, was people. The five thousand dollars was not all mill money, though the family would have called it mill money and Mary Jane, had anyone asked her, would have called it that too. Some of it was three human beings. The same government that was about to write the household into its book kept a second book that year, the one it kept for slaves, and on that one, set down against her father's name, there stood a woman of sixty-five, a man of thirty-six, and a girl of seven — three people held on the Rorie place, in a house that stood in the yard for the purpose — and their worth, reckoned in dollars by men who reckoned such things, was folded into the five thousand that seated the family at the front of the meeting-house. This account will not tell you Reuben Rorie's money was clean money, because it was not; it cannot ask what the man was worth and decline to say what he owned. The three

people on that place have their own accounting to come, in their own chapters, and are not Mary Jane's to carry and will not be made hers. But the figure is named in this chapter, and the figure has people in it, and the book says so here, so that it never again sets down *five thousand dollars* as though the words meant only the mill.

Everything about the household was going well except the one thing, and the one thing was Mary Jane, and after her, Nancy.

She thought about it in the mornings, mostly, before the heat came up and while her hands were busy with the first work of the day and her mind was free to go where it went. Her hands, that summer, knew every task the house had to give and did them without her watching — the churn, the wheel, the loom in the cold months, the garden in the warm, the long turn of the wash, the bread, the milk, the care of her mother's chickens and her father's table. They were a grown woman's hands. They had been a grown woman's hands for years. They were not a bride's hands and they were not a mother's hands, and there was no work in the house that was waiting for them to become either, and they went on doing the work of a daughter in her father's house the way they had done it at seventeen and at twenty and at twenty-four, except that now the woman they belonged to was twenty-seven, and twenty-seven was a number that had come to mean something in that country that seventeen had not.

She knew the number. That was the thing. She knew it exactly. She could have told anyone who asked her the day and the year of her birth, because her mother had written it into the Bible on the marriages-and-births page in the careful keeping-hand, and the Bible sat on the shelf in the parlor where it had always sat, and Mary Jane had grown up reading her own line in it — *Mary Jane, born the twenty-first of November, 1832* — the way a person reads a thing so often that the reading wears smooth and stops registering. Twenty-seven years and a little more than half a year. She did not have to count it. But she counted it anyway, the way you press a sore tooth with your tongue to see if it is still sore, and it was always still sore, and the number was always still twenty-seven.

Nancy was four-and-twenty. Nancy was the other one. The two of them were what was left of the daughters in the house, the two the house had not been able to marry off, and they knew it about each other and about themselves and they did not, as a rule, speak of it, because there was nothing to say that would not make it worse. The older girls were gone — Elizabeth married and away years ago, Louisa Adeline married to Alexander Houston and settled a little distance off with her own children coming up, the others paired and placed the way daughters were supposed to be paired and placed. The brothers were gone to their own roofs. William Hubbard had married and set up his own household in the very next place down the ridge, a wife and two small boys of his own now, and his voice carried over of an evening the way a married man's voice carries from his own dooryard. The house on the ridge that had once held a loft full of Rorie children held, in the summer of 1860, an aging father and an aging mother and two grown daughters

that the aging father and mother could not, for all their five thousand dollars, get married.

It was not that no one would have them. That was not it, or not exactly. It was harder than that, and Mary Jane had had years to work out the shape of it and had worked it out and did not like the shape. A girl of eighteen with a landed father was a match. A girl of twenty-two with a landed father was a match a man might still make if the man was steady and the season was right. But a woman of twenty-seven, unmarried, in her father's house, was not a girl any longer and was not a widow either and was not anything the arithmetic of that country had a comfortable place for. She was past the age. Everyone knew what past-the-age meant. It did not mean unwanted, exactly, and it did not mean unlovely, and it did not mean anything you could put a finger on and argue with. It meant only that the young men who were laying out places and looking for wives looked, when they looked, at the girls of eighteen, because that was who a man looked at, and the woman of twenty-seven stood a little to the side of where the looking happened, and had stood there long enough that she had learned the exact width of the margin she stood in.

She was not bitter about it. She would have told you that, if you could have gotten her to speak of it at all, and it would have been mostly true. She was not a bitter woman. She had her mother's steadiness and something of her father's way of doing the work in front of him without complaining of it, and she had made, without ever deciding to, a kind of peace with the ridge and the house and the days that turned over on it. She loved her mother. She loved Nancy in the wordless way of a sister who has shared a loft and a fate. She was useful, and she knew she was useful, and there is a kind of standing that comes to a woman who is the one the house cannot do without, even a woman the house cannot marry. She had that standing. She was not miserable.

But she was twenty-seven, and she knew she was twenty-seven, and the knowing sat under everything like a stone under a field — you could plant over it and walk over it and forget it was there for weeks at a stretch, and then the plow would come down on it of a morning and the whole arm would ring with it, and there it was, the same stone, exactly where it had always been.

The summer went on hot and long. The cotton came up green on the places all down the ridge. Her father sat of an evening at the dooryard and talked to whoever came by about what cotton was doing at Corinth, which was a town thirteen miles north that had not existed when Mary Jane was a girl and now had rails running through it four ways and a name off a city on the other side of the world. Her mother put up the summer's peaches. Nancy and Mary Jane did the work of the house between them, two grown women in a house with no children in it, and the days came round and were done and came round.

And then, in the late summer, a man came up the ridge road with a book, and wrote her age down wrong.

* * *

The man with the book

His name was Porter Walker, and he was the assistant marshal for that district in the census of 1860, out of the post office down at Jacinto, and he was doing the government's counting that summer the way it was done every ten years — house to house, up one road and down the next, with a ledger under his arm and a set of ruled columns to fill and no particular hurry, because the counting of a county took a man the better part of a season and there was no use rushing it.

He was the second man with a book to come up that ridge that Mary Jane could remember. The first had come ten years back, when she was a girl of seventeen at the loom, and had written the household down and ridden on, and she had thought nothing of it, because at seventeen there is nothing to think. This one came when she was a woman of twenty-seven at the wash. The whole of what had happened to her between the one book and the other was the distance between those two numbers — which is to say that nothing had happened to her at all except the ten years themselves, and the ten years had done to a girl of seventeen the one thing a girl of seventeen never troubles to imagine the years will do, which is to make her twenty-seven while she is not looking.

Mary Jane saw him before he reached the dooryard. She was at the side of the house with the wash when his horse came up the ridge road at a walk, a stranger's horse at a stranger's pace, and she straightened up from the tub with her forearms wet to the elbow and a strand of hair come loose at her temple and watched him come the way you watch any rider you do not know come up your road — not alarmed, only attentive, filing him. A man in a town coat, which was strange for the ridge in August. A book under his arm. She knew before he had said a word what he was, because the talk of the counting had been going up and down the ridge for a fortnight ahead of him — the Vanderfords had been counted, and the Rineharts, and the count was working its way along — and she thought, drying her arms on her apron, *it is the census man, he has got to us*, and went in to tell her mother, and did not think anything further of it, because there was nothing further to think. The census man came every ten years. He wrote down the house. It was nothing.

She was wrong that it was nothing, but she had no way of knowing that, and neither did he.

He sat with her father at the dooryard, because that was how it was done — the head of the house gave the answers, and the marshal wrote them, and the women of the house went on with the day and were called on only when the head of the house wanted a thing confirmed. Mary Jane brought the two men water and went back to the wash and could hear, across the dooryard in the still hot air, the low back-and-forth of the counting: her father's voice, unhurried, giving the

marshal what he asked for, and the marshal's pen going, and the small pauses while he wrote.

She heard him get her father's name wrong, and it was so ordinary a wrongness that she barely marked it. The marshal asked the name, and her father said it — *Rorie* — and the marshal wrote something, and it was not *Rorie*, because it never was; the name had come into Mississippi off a Carolina tongue and had been getting written down wrong by clerks and marshals her whole life, and her father had long since stopped correcting it, because a man does not spend his morning teaching a government clerk to spell. She did not hear what the marshal put down. She learned much later, when such things came to be looked at, that he had put down *William Roria* — not even the right given name, a William where a Reuben stood, so that her father, the man who had come off the Yadkin and built the mill and made the whole standing place they lived on, went into the book of 1860 under a name that was not his in either half. But she did not know that at the tub in the August heat. She knew only that the counting was going on at the dooryard the way the counting went on, and that her arms were wet, and that the wash still had to be wrung.

Then the marshal came to the ages.

She heard her father give his own, sixty, which was right. She heard him give her mother's, five-and-fifty, which was right — her mother was fifty-five that year, to the year, and it went into the book at fifty-five, plain and true. The two old people of that house went into the government's book at their right ages, because there was no reason on earth to give them anything else.

And then the marshal asked after the daughters, and there was a small pause, the kind of pause that is nothing at all if you are not the person the pause is about, and Mary Jane, at the tub, was the person the pause was about, and she felt it before she understood it, the way the body feels a thing a half-second before the mind will let it be named.

She did not hear which of them said it. It might have been her father. It might have been her mother, come to the dooryard by then with her own errand. It might even — and this was the thought she would turn over afterward and never settle — have been that no one decided it aloud at all, that it was simply the number the house had come to give when the house was asked, the way a house comes to give a certain answer to a certain question without ever holding a meeting about it. But the number that went across the dooryard in the hot still air, the number the marshal's pen took down for Mary Jane Rorie in the summer of 1860, was *twenty-five*.

She was twenty-seven. She was standing not thirty feet away with her arms wet to the elbow, and she was twenty-seven years old, and she heard the house say twenty-five, and she said nothing.

That was the thing she would come back to. Not the number. The nothing.

Because there was, in the half-second after she heard it, a whole small storm in her that no one at the dooryard could have seen — she went on wringing the

shirt in her hands, her face did not change, her hands did not stop — and the storm was made of several things at once and she could not, then or later, have said which of them was strongest. There was the plain hot shame of it, first, the shame of being a woman whose age had to be managed, whose two years had to be quietly taken off and hidden the way you hide a stain by turning the cloth. There was, under the shame and stranger than it, something that was almost gratitude — because whoever had said twenty-five had said it to spare her, had reached out in the one way the moment allowed and made her, on the one page that would outlast every soul at that dooryard, two years less late than she was; and there is a particular ache in being loved that way, in having the people who love you best agree, without ever saying so, that the truth about you is a thing to be softened before it is handed to a stranger. And there was, under both of those, the plainest fact of all, which was that she could not correct it. A daughter did not correct her father to a marshal. A woman of twenty-seven did not step forward across her own dooryard and say to a man with a pen, *no, sir, I am twenty-seven, write it down*, because to do that was to say the number aloud, to a stranger, in front of her father, and there was not enough in her — there was not enough in anyone she had ever known — to do that. So she did the only thing there was to do, which was the nothing. She wrung the shirt. She let it stand.

And she heard, a moment later, the house do the same thing for Nancy — *twenty-two*, when Nancy was four-and-twenty — the same two years, off the same kind of daughter, in the same breath, and she understood that whatever had happened had happened to both of them, the two who stayed, shaved by the same hand by the same amount on the same afternoon, while the two old people who had made them were set down true. And she thought, wringing the wash, a thought she was a little ashamed of and could not help: *at least I am not the only one*. Nancy was three feet behind her at the line, pinning up a sheet, and Mary Jane did not turn to look at her, and Nancy did not turn to look at Mary Jane, and the two of them went on with the wash in the hot afternoon while the marshal at the dooryard finished the Rorie household and packed his book and got back on his horse and rode on up the ridge to count the next family, having set two small untruths into the permanent record of the United States and knowing nothing about it at all.

He had not made the wound. He had asked the question a marshal asks and written the answer a household gave, which is the whole of a marshal's office, and he rode off up the ridge with no more idea that he had softened a woman's age than the plow has when it comes down on the stone. That particular wound was not his; it had been in the house a long time before he came, and he had only, passing through, written it into a book. But it will not do to leave the man himself down as merely decent, and the book that means to tell the truth about that summer has to say why. Porter Walker held enslaved people — two of his own, ten years earlier, down in the southern half of the county — and all that same summer of 1860, on the long round that had brought him to the Rorie dooryard, he was

filling the government's other book as he went, the one it headed for slaves; and before he was through with the county he would write onto it, against Reuben Rorie's name, the woman of sixty-five and the man of thirty-six and the girl of seven. He was not a clerk standing outside the thing he was counting. He owned in it, and he counted it, and he rode home at night to it. That belongs in the record beside the smaller, softer thing he did at the Rorie dooryard — not because the two are the same, for they are nothing like the same, but because a book that would tell you the man was decent has to tell you the rest of what he was, and let you hold both.

* * *

What the record could not soften

She thought about it that night, in the bed she shared with Nancy, after the candle was out and the house had gone quiet and there was nothing to do with her hands and nowhere for her mind to go but where it went.

She was not angry at her mother, if it had been her mother. She was not angry at her father, if it had been her father. She had worked out, lying there, that being angry at them was like being angry at them for the weather — they had not made the thing that made the number shameful; they had only, standing in it with her, done the small kindness the moment allowed, and taken two years off a daughter they could not otherwise help, and if the kindness stung it stung the way iodine stings, which is not the fault of the hand that pours it. She loved her mother. She knew, better than her mother thought she knew, exactly how much it had cost her mother across these years to have two grown daughters she could not settle — knew it from the particular way her mother had stopped, somewhere back around Mary Jane's twenty-fifth year, asking either of them any questions at all about who had been at the meeting or who had ridden by; because the questions had gone unanswered too many times and a mother learns to stop asking a question whose answer only hurts the person she is asking it of. Her mother had stopped asking. That had been its own kind of mercy and its own kind of grief, and Mary Jane had felt both of them and had never said so, and now her mother, or her father, had shaved two years off her for the government, which was the same mercy and the same grief in another form.

What she kept coming back to, in the dark, was the strangeness of the record itself — that a thing made of ink on paper, a thing that did not know her and did not care about her and would go into a courthouse drawer and be forgotten, had nonetheless just told a lie about her, and that the lie was the tenderest thing anyone could do for her, and that both of those were true at once. The last book had gotten her right, ten years back, and she understood now, lying in the dark, why it had and this one had not. Seventeen was a number nobody had needed to be careful with; a girl of seventeen was only a girl of seventeen, and there was no shame in the plain true number of her, and so the record had been let to tell the

truth about her, because the truth cost nothing. Now that the truth cost something, the record had learned, like everyone else who loved her, to soften it.

She lay in the dark and did the sum she was always doing. Ten years. In ten years she had gone from a girl the record could tell the truth about to a woman the record had to lie about to be kind. Nothing had happened to her in the ten years. No wedding, no child, no death, no removal, nothing the world would name. Only the years, turning over her the way they turned over the ridge, green and then brown and then green, and carrying her from seventeen, which was nothing, to twenty-seven, which was a thing that had to be managed. She had not changed. The number had. And the number had become, without her ever agreeing to it, the truest and the most shameful thing about her, the thing her own house took off her two at a time and hid before it handed her to a stranger.

Beside her, Nancy's breathing had gone slow and even. Nancy could do that — go down into sleep out of anything, the way she had done since she was small. Mary Jane envied her it and did not begrudge her it. She lay a while longer with her hands folded on her chest the way her mother had taught her to fold them when she was a child, and she listened to the house, and after a while she thought a thing that she did not often let herself think, which was that she did not know what was going to happen to her. She was twenty-seven. The two roads a woman of that country could take had both, as far as she could see, closed behind her without her having taken either — she had not married the man of eighteen, because no man of eighteen had come, and she was past the age at which the men of eighteen came looking; and she had not resigned herself, either, to the other thing, the spinster-daughter thing, the aunt-in-the-corner thing, because she was only twenty-seven and it was too soon to lie down in that and she knew it. She was in between. She had been in between for years. She did not know how long a person could stay in between, or what was on the other side of it, or whether there was another side of it at all.

She did not know — she could not have known, no one lying in a bed in the summer of 1860 could have known — that there was in fact another side of it, and that it was seven years off, and that it would come to her by a road so plain and so unromantic that no girl of eighteen would have recognized it as a road at all. She did not know that this shaved number was only the first of the wrong ones, that the record having once learned to soften her would keep at it the rest of her life. She knew none of that. She knew only that it was late, and that she was twenty-seven, and that the marshal had ridden off up the ridge with the wrong number in his book, and that the wrong number was a kindness, and that she had let it stand. After a while she slept.

* * *

A door from her sister

There was a thing about that summer's counting that Mary Jane did not know and could not have known, and it belongs in this chapter even though she was blind to it, because the whole of what was going to happen to her was already lying on the same road she lived on, a few dozen doors up, waiting seven years to matter.

The marshal, on his long walk up the ridge and along the connecting roads, had already been to another house before he came to the Rories — had been there some weeks and some three dozen dwellings back, on the same continuous round through the same neighborhood — and had counted, in that other house, a man Mary Jane would one day marry. His name was Freeman Searcy. He was thirty years old that summer. He was a day-labourer, which is to say a man who worked other men's ground for a wage because he had none of his own, and the marshal had drawn the pen down the columns beside his name and left every one of them empty — no land, no property, nothing at all, a grown man of thirty who owned the strength of his back and not one foot of the earth he worked it on. He was living in his elder brother's house, a landless bachelor boarding among his own blood, and the marshal had written him down there among the Searcys with the blank columns beside him and moved on.

And the house the marshal had counted just before he counted the Searcys — the very next dwelling up the same page — was the household of Alexander Houston and his wife. And Alexander Houston's wife was Louisa Adeline Rorie. Mary Jane's own married sister.

That was the thing. That was the thing that undoes the easy telling of it. Freeman Searcy, the poor man Mary Jane Rorie would marry in the January of 1867, was not off in some far quarter of the county in the summer of 1860, a stranger her people had never met, waiting for the war to introduce him to her. He was living one door from her sister. He was a neighbor — a neighbor of the Rories the way half that end of the county was neighbors, the Houstons and the Rineharts and the Vanderfords and the Searcys and the Cheeks all set down the same roads in the same weeks of the same summer, one long neighborly cluster of families who had lived beside one another for twenty years and would go on living beside one another for fifty more. Whatever Mary Jane did or did not know of the particular poor man boarding in his brother's house a door past Louisa Adeline — and she likely knew him the way you know everyone in such a neighborhood, by sight and by name and by nothing more — the two of them were not moving in separate worlds that summer. They were moving in one world, a few dozen doors apart, and had been the whole time.

And they did not marry. That is the part worth sitting with, because it is harder and truer than the stranger's version would have been. It was not distance that kept Freeman Searcy and Mary Jane Rorie apart for seven more years. There was no distance to speak of. It was the same arithmetic that had shaved two years off her age at the dooryard — the plain, unarguable arithmetic the neighborhood

ran on everybody, and the arithmetic said no. She was a woman of twenty-seven in a landed house, and by that reckoning she was too old for a young man laying out a place. He was a man of thirty with nothing, and by the same reckoning he was too poor to be offered any landed man's daughter. The two of them were, that summer, the two people on that whole stretch of road best placed by nearness to have found each other — and the neighborhood that had them living in each other's laps did not put them together, because putting them together was not what you did with a woman too old and a man too poor. You left them where they were. They were the two the sorting set aside, each of them exactly the kind of person the other one's world had finished with.

What the sorting could not know — what nothing in the summer of 1860 could know — was that the war was one year off, and that the war did not care for any of the sorting; that it was coming down the very roads the marshal was walking, toward the Rories and the Houstons and the Searcys and the Cheeks and every family in the cluster at once; and that when it had come through and taken what it took and leveled what it leveled, the arithmetic that had kept the too-old woman and the too-poor man apart would be so much changed that late and poor and past-it would stop being a bar between two people and become, instead, the simple common condition of everyone left standing. But that was seven years and a war away, and no one at the Rorie dooryard that August could see a foot of it.

Mary Jane could not see it. She finished the wash that afternoon and hung it and went in to help her mother with the supper, a woman of twenty-seven written down at twenty-five, in a prospering house on a green ridge, three dozen doors from the man she would marry and no nearer to him than she was to the war, and she did not know about either of them, and she went to bed that night not knowing, and got up the next morning not knowing, and the summer went on.

She was twenty-seven. Nothing had happened to her yet, in the way the world means the word. But the world was very nearly ready to happen to everyone.

Chapter 4 — The Brothers' War

The year the men went

The war did not come to Mary Jane the way it came to the men, as a thing to be gone and done. It came to her the way most of the great things of her life had come to her, as a thing to be waited through — and she was, by the time it came, a woman well practiced at waiting.

She was twenty-eight when it began, and twenty-nine, and then thirty, across the first of it. She had come out of the 1860 summer a woman written down two years short in a prospering house, and she had thought, insofar as she let herself think about the shape of her life at all, that nothing was ever going to happen to her; and then the whole country happened to everyone at once, and she learned the thing every generation that lives through a war learns, which is that "nothing happening to you" is a condition a person does not know to be grateful for until it ends. The talk had been coming for a year — the talk that had gone up and down the ridge and the crossroads store and the meeting-house steps all through the winter of the secession, the men's talk, loud and certain, of what would be done and how fast — and Mary Jane had heard it the way she heard most of the men's talk, from the edge of it, with her hands full, and had not believed in it the way the men believed in it, because she had noticed across twenty-eight years that the things the men were loudest and most certain about were not always the things that came to pass. But this one came to pass. In the spring it stopped being talk. And by the next spring it had taken her brothers.

There were three of them, the Rorie sons, and the war took all three at once out of the settled world they had made along that ridge, the world Chapter Three had left standing at its height — the sons married and placed, the households struck off the old one and set down within a morning's walk, the whole thickened family arranged on its ground. That arrangement came apart in a season. Ezekiah went, and William went, and Fred went, and the three roofs that had gone up along the road in the fifties stood, of a sudden, with the men gone out from under them and the wives and the children and the old people left, and Mary Jane — who was none of those things, not a wife left behind and not a mother left holding, but only the unmarried sister still in her father's house — watched all three of her brothers turn from farmers into soldiers in the space of a few weeks, and had no place in the leaving that anyone would have thought to give her, and felt it all the same.

Ezekiah's going was the one she felt to the bone, because Ezekiah was the one nearest her. He was the brother closest to her in age, the boy of seventeen the first marshal had counted beside her at the loom, grown now into the most prosperous of all of them — a man past thirty with two thousand dollars of his own land and a young wife and two small children and a farm running well, a man, in short, with everything a man could have to lose and every reason in the world to

stay home and keep it. He did not stay home. In the March of 1862 he rode down to Kossuth, the little town south of the ridge, and gave his name to the muster there and made himself a soldier, at an age and a station where no law and no shame would have compelled him to it. That was the thing Mary Jane could not get past, turning it over in the days after. He was not a boy of eighteen with nothing yet and everything to prove, swept up in the loud certainty because he had no weight to hold him down. He was a grown man with a farm and a family and thirty-one years on him, and he weighed all of it, and went anyway. She did not understand it and she did not try to talk him out of it, because a sister does not talk a grown man out of the thing he has decided his honor requires, and because she knew that whatever the thing was that sent men of Ezekiah's age and Ezekiah's holdings off to a war they could have sat out, it was not a thing a woman's talking was going to move. She only watched him go, and marked it, the way she marked everything: her brother, past thirty, with the most to lose of any of them, first to the muster.

William went, and Fred went, and of their goings the record keeps less and this account will guess at less, but they went, the eldest son and the youngest, out of their own new households and into the war, and left their own wives and their own small children the way Ezekiah left his. And the road past the mill, which had filled up across the fifties with Rorie roofs and Rorie children, went quiet of its grown men in a single season, the way every road in that country went quiet, until the only men left on that whole stretch of it were the very old and the very young and the ones the war did not want — and Mary Jane's father, Reuben, who was old now and failing, and would not see the war out.

She was left, then, in a house and a neighborhood the war had emptied of its men, one of the women now — though not a wife and not a mother, still only the sister and the daughter — and she took up, without being asked and without remark, the share of the going-on that fell to the ones who stayed. There was more of it now, with the men gone. She had always done the work of a daughter; now she did some of the work the men had done, or saw that it got done, the way women all over that country quietly took up the running of places whose men were at the war. And she waited. That was the real work of those years, the work under all the other work, and she had been apprenticed to it her whole life without knowing she was being made ready for anything: she waited for news of her brothers, down the long roads, out of the country the war had swallowed them into, and the waiting was the same waiting she had always done, only now it had three men's lives inside it.

* * *

The war at the door

And the war, that first year, was not off in some far country at all. It was thirteen miles up the road, at the town she had watched come out of the woods.

This was the thing about Mary Jane's war that set it apart from the war of most of the women who waited it out in most of the country: hers was fought, the first great year of it, in her own dooryard's sight. The town she had watched rise in her girlhood — Corinth, the place that had come out of the north pinewoods in the space of a few seasons because two railroads crossed there — was, precisely because two railroads crossed there, one of the things the war most wanted in the whole of the West; and so the war came for it, and came for it thirteen miles from where she stood.

It came first as a sound. In the early spring of 1862 there was a battle two days long up on the Tennessee line, a little north of Corinth, at a country meeting-house by the river — the fight the world would call Shiloh — and the ridge heard it, a far continuous grumble on the north wind, days of it, a sound like a storm that would not pass and did not pass and was not weather. Mary Jane had heard thunder her whole life and knew the difference. This did not stop the way thunder stops. It went on, hour into hour, the way nothing in nature goes on, and every soul on that ridge knew what it was and stood still in the yard to hear it and thought of the men they had up in it, and Mary Jane stood among them and thought of her three.

And then, in the weeks after, the war came down off the Tennessee line and settled onto Corinth itself, and the town she had watched being built became, in a season, a thing she could hardly have imagined it becoming. The beaten army fell back into it, tens of thousands of men, and behind them came the sickness that always came where armies gathered, and the town filled up — the churches, the depots, the houses, the very streets — with the wounded and the fevered and the dying, until the place that had been raised in her lifetime out of nothing was, within a decade of its raising, one of the great charnel houses of that country's war. Thirteen miles north of the Rorie mill, the town with the borrowed Greek name was burying men faster than it could dig, of wounds and of the camp fevers that killed more than the wounds did; and the great federal army came down against it through the late spring, a slow enormous siege, a hundred thousand men creeping toward the crossing a mile a day; and the army that held the town slipped out of it in the end, in the night, and left it; and in the fall the war came back and fought a second time over the same ground, two days of it in the October, close enough that the ridge heard the guns again. Twice in one year the world tried to take the town Mary Jane had watched being born, and both times the taking was a thing she heard from her own yard.

She did not see the fields of it; the women of the ridge did not ride up to look, and Mary Jane was not a woman who would have wanted to. But she did not need to see it. She heard it, and she knew what the sounds were, and she knew the town, and she knew — everyone knew — what was happening in it: that the place she had watched come up out of the woods, the one genuinely new thing the world had made in the whole of her young womanhood, had been made, in the end, for this; that the rails men had run through the empty pinewoods so that

cotton and freight could cross had turned out to be rails the war would cross, and men, and the wounded, and the dead. She had thought, as a girl, that the town's coming out of nothing was the most remarkable thing a piece of ground could do. She learned, at thirty, that a piece of ground can do a more remarkable and a more terrible thing than come into being, which is to fill up with the dying almost as fast as it was built.

The years of it ground on the way the wheel at her father's race ground on — steadily, going nowhere, taking everything the country fed into it and giving back less. The money failed and went on failing; a dollar bought less each season until it bought nothing, and the paper the new government printed was believed in for a while and then was not. The salt gave out, and the coffee, and the cloth, and the women turned and re-turned the same dresses and made do and made do. The men did not come home and did not come home. And the news, when it came at all, came old and thin and by no reliable road, a letter that had been three weeks coming, a thing a neighbor's boy had heard at the depot, a name on a list. Mary Jane waited through all of it in a house that got quieter and poorer and older around her — her father failing through those very years and, in the second summer of the war, dying, though that grief and the taking-up that followed it belong to the next turn of this account and not to this one. What belongs here is only the waiting itself, and the three names inside it, and the long holding of breath that was a woman's whole part in that war: three brothers gone into the country the guns came out of, and no way to do anything for any of them but wait, and keep the place, and listen to the north wind.

Two of the three names would come back down the road. One would not.

* * *

The one who did not come back

The word about Ezekiah came in the summer of 1864, in the third year of the waiting, and it came the way the worst words always came in that war — late, and secondhand, and certain.

He had been killed in the July, in the fighting around Atlanta, three hundred miles east of the ground he was raised on. The great federal army that had taken Corinth two years before had ground its way down into Georgia by then, toward the city that was the last thing holding the middle of the Confederacy together, and the armies had fought over it through that summer the way they had fought over Corinth, and on a day in the last third of July they fought a great battle on the east side of the city, and Ezekiah Rorie was in it, and he was killed. That was the whole of what the family got, or the whole of what came down to them that anyone wrote down: killed, in July, at Atlanta. The particular field, the particular hour, the manner of it, whether it was quick — the things a family most wants and least often gets — the record does not keep and this book will not invent them for the comfort of inventing them. He was killed near Atlanta in the July of 1864. He

was a man past thirty with a wife and two small children and two thousand dollars of land at home. And he did not come back.

Mary Jane took it the way the news of a death takes the one it is nearest to, which is bodily, before the mind has agreed to it. This was the brother closest to her in age, the one she had stood beside in the very first book anyone made of that family, the boy of seventeen grown into the man with everything to lose who had gone first to the muster because his honor asked it — and now the everything-to-lose was lost, all of it, the farm made a widow's and the children made half-orphans and the man himself put into Georgia ground his family would never stand on. She had known, from the day he rode down to Kossuth, that this was a thing that could happen; she had done the grim arithmetic every waiting woman does, the counting of the ways the roads could end; and knowing a thing can happen is no armor at all against its happening, as she had learned before over other beds and would learn again, and the knowing did nothing for her now but let her recognize, when the word came, the shape of the thing that had arrived. Her brother was dead in Georgia. The war had reached three hundred miles into the middle of the country and taken the one of the three she loved best, and left the two she loved to come home, which is the arithmetic wars keep and no family gets a vote in.

She grieved him the way she did everything, without much noise and without any collapse, because there was a household to hold and a mother to see through it and no one else to do either. And she watched what her mother did with the news — watched Mary Polly, who had borne this son and would outlive him by decades, receive the word and go, in her grief, to the one thing she had always gone to, the Bible on the parlor shelf and the careful keeping-hand — but what her mother wrote there, and what it cost her, and why it would turn out to be the very last thing that hand ever set in that book, belongs to the chapter that is her mother's more than it is the brothers', and this account leaves it there, in Chapter Five, where the widow's keeping is told. Here it is enough to say that the family did with Ezekiah's death what that family did with all its deaths: it wrote him down, and it went on, because going on was the only thing there was to do and the family had always known how to do it.

And somewhere in the doing-on, in the settling of the small hard business a death leaves behind even in the middle of a war, there is a detail the record did keep, and it is the truest thing the war ever wrote about those three brothers, and it is this: that when Ezekiah's estate was reckoned up — the little estate of a dead soldier, the gold and the silver and the notes — it was found that both of the brothers who had come home owed money to the estate of the brother who had not. They had borrowed from him, the way brothers do, in the years before; and now the accounting stood there in the estate book, the two living men indebted to the one dead one. And the debts were denominated in the money of that time and place, which is to say that one of them was to be settled in cotton money and the other was to be paid in Confederate money — a debt acknowledged and agreed

and entered in a book, owed by a living brother to a dead one, in the currency of a country that by the time anyone could have collected it did not exist. There is the whole war in one line of an estate ledger. The brother who went first and weighed the most and lost everything was owed, at the end, a sum his surviving brothers had promised him in a money that had ceased to be money, in a nation that had ceased to be a nation, and the debt would never be paid because there was nothing left to pay it in. Mary Jane did not read the estate book; that was men's business and lawyers'. But she was of a family that could do arithmetic, and she would have understood, if the fact ever reached her, exactly what it meant and exactly how little and how much it was worth.

* * *

The two who came home

The war ended in the spring of 1865, the way it had begun, all at once after going on so long it had come to seem permanent, and down the long roads out of the wrecked country the two surviving Rorie brothers came home.

William came, and Fred came, off the roads, in the weeks and months of that ragged spring when men all over the South were walking home out of surrenders hundreds of miles apart — the eldest son and the youngest, gone three and four years, come back at last up the same lane they had ridden down out of. Mary Jane was there for their coming the way she had been there for their going, one of the women of a house the war had hollowed, and their coming home was the great mercy of those years and she felt it as one; but it was a mercy with the shape of the war still on it, because the men who came back up the lane were not the men who had ridden down it. No man came back from that war the man he had been, and no house he came back to was the house he had left. William came home to a father dead and a family's fortune run out into worthless paper and a brother in Georgia ground, and to a country whose whole arrangement — the arrangement his father had built the family's standing on — had been taken apart around him while he was gone. He had gone to the war, whatever had sent him, a Confederate man; he would name sons, in the years after, for the two great generals of that lost army, so that the loyalty he had carried into it was written afterward into his own children's names, the way men wrote their unhealed allegiances into the next generation all over that defeated country. What regiment he had carried it in, and over what fields, this account does not certainly know and will not pretend to; the record of the particular unit is one of the things still open in this family's papers, and a book that has been careful this long will not spend that care now for the sake of a fuller-sounding sentence. He went. He served. He came home. That is what is known, and it is enough for what this chapter is, which is not a muster roll but a sister's account of the war that took one brother and gave two back.

Fred came home the youngest and would live the longest of them, and would do the thing the living do that is the quiet answer to a war, which is to make more

life: he settled a little way off, two beats over, and raised a houseful of children over the decades after, seven or so of them, and among them he named one for the brother who had not come back — set Ezekiah's initials on a living child, so that the name went on in the family the way names go on, carried forward on somebody new. That is the other thing families do with their dead, besides writing them in the book: they hand the name down onto the living, and let it walk around in the world again. Ezekiah was in Georgia ground. But there would be an E. B. Rorie growing up two beats over, running in a dooryard, answering to the initials of an uncle he would never meet, because his father had wanted the name kept and the family had always kept its names as hard as it kept anything.

And Mary Jane came out of the war the way she had gone into it — in the house, on the ground, unmarried, waiting; only older now, and poorer, and one brother fewer. She was thirty-two when it ended. The war had taken four years out of the middle of her thirties, the years a woman of her time who was ever going to marry and bear children had left, and it had spent them the way it spent everything, on waiting and want and grief, and given nothing back that a woman could build a life on. She had gone into it a landed man's unmarried daughter in a prospering house; she came out of it a dead man's unmarried daughter in a ruined one, in a country where everyone was ruined, where the whole careful sorting that had once kept a woman of twenty-seven from a poor man of thirty had been leveled along with everything else — though she could not see that yet, and would not see it for two more years, when it finally came round to her in the plainest and least expected way. What she could see, in the spring of 1865, was only what everyone on that ridge could see: that the war was over, and the men who were coming home were home, and the men who were not were not, and the world the war had left was going to have to be lived in by whoever was left to live in it. Her father was gone. Her brother was gone. Two brothers were back and changed. Her mother held the place. And Mary Jane, thirty-two and unmarried, took up the after of the war the way she had taken up the during of it and the before of it, which was to do the work in front of her and to wait and to keep — because she was a Searcy's coming wife and a Rorie's daughter, and the doing and the waiting and the keeping were the whole of what her people had ever been trained to, and they were what was left when everything else the war could take had been taken.

The town up the road began, slowly, to become a town again. The wheel at the race turned when there was grain to turn it. And the roads that had carried her brothers off and carried two of them back lay quiet again in the sun, the way they had lain quiet before the war came, as though the country meant to go on — which it did, because countries and families both go on, over their dead, because there is nothing else that the living have ever found to do.

Chapter 5 — The Widow Takes the Farm

The summer the mill went quiet

She knew her father was dying by the mill, before anyone said it, because the mill went quiet and stayed quiet, and a mill that had run the whole of her life did not go quiet for any small reason.

It was the second summer of the war, the August of 1862, and Mary Jane was twenty-nine. The country had gone strange in a way she had never seen it go and would spend the rest of her life measuring other troubles against. There was a town thirteen miles north that had come out of the woods in her girlhood, and armies had been fighting over it since the spring — a great battle in the early summer that they had heard as a far grumble on the north wind, days of it, like weather that would not break, and then the news coming down the ridge in pieces, thousands dead up there where the rails crossed, the town she had watched get built now a thing men killed each other to hold. The war was thirteen miles off and it was also in the house. It was in the empty places at the meeting-house where the young men had been. It was in the coffee gone and the salt gone and the cloth gone, in her mother turning last year's dresses and letting out seams and making do the way the whole country was making do. It was in the price of everything and the worth of the money, which fell and went on falling until a dollar was a thing you spent fast because tomorrow it would buy less. And it was, that August, in the quiet where the mill had been.

Reuben Rorie was seventy-one or seventy-two — the record never quite settled which, the way it never quite settled anything about her people — and he had been failing through the spring, slow at first and then not slow, and by the deep of the summer he kept to the house and then to the bed, and the wheel at the race stood still because the man who had built it and read the creek and kept the gearing true for forty years was not there to start it. Mary Jane had grown up inside the sound of that wheel. She had told herself, at the loom as a girl, that the wheel was the busiest thing on the place and went nowhere; and now the busiest thing on the place had stopped, and the silence where it had been was the loudest thing in the county to her, louder than the far guns, because it was the sound of her father going out of the world.

She helped nurse him. That was the daughter's office and she had it in full, the way she had every office the house handed the daughter who stayed. She sat with him in the close hot room with the shades drawn against the light that hurt his eyes, and she wet his lips and turned him and listened to the breath go wrong in him by degrees, and she did it with the steadiness she had first found in herself over her grandmother's body five years before and had had occasion to use more than once since. He did not say a great deal at the end. He was a man who had never said a great deal; he had built things instead. He had come off the Yadkin a young man with a trade in his hands and had made, out of raw Mississippi ground,

a mill and a farm and a standing and a name — a name the clerks could never spell, but a name — and he had married a girl of fifteen and kept her fifty years and put ten children into the world with her and buried some and stood up the rest, and now he lay in the drawn room while the wheel he had built stood still, and one August day he stopped breathing, and Mary Jane, who was in the room, closed his eyes.

He died in the second summer of the war, and the war swallowed his dying the way it was swallowing everything. There was no long procession, because the young men who would have made one were gone to the fighting or dead in it. There was a burying, and the neighbors who were left came, and the Methodist man read over him, and they put him in the ground on his own place; and then the world went back to its war and forgot him, because the world had a great deal to attend to that summer and one old miller in Tishomingo County was a small thing against it.

And here is what the record made of Reuben Rorie's death, the whole of it, for a long time: nothing. Not a will proved, not an estate opened, not an inventory taken, not a line in any book of the county's that was made for the deaths of men of property. The man who had built the standing place they all lived on went out of the record the way a stone goes under water — a ring, and then the surface closing, and then nothing. The one trace of his dying that survives in any public book of that county is a single line, entered years later by a clerk who was settling somebody else's affairs entirely: in the estate of a neighbor named Morrison, in the column of debts owed to the dead man, there stands the notation *Reuben Rorie decd 1862* — Reuben not as a man who died and left an estate, but as a debt on another man's ledger, a sum the neighbor's heirs might try to collect from whatever Reuben had left. That is the whole of him in the county's death-books. He built for forty years and came down, on paper, to four words in the margin of another man's accounts.

Mary Jane did not know that, that August, and would not have cared if she had. She knew only that her father was in the ground and the mill was quiet and the war was on the wind, and that the house on the ridge, which had been the fullest thing in the county when she was a girl, was down now to a handful — her mother, herself, Nancy, and the war taking the rest of the world away piece by piece. She was twenty-nine, and she had buried her grandmother and now her father, and she was still exactly what she had been at seventeen and at twenty-seven: a daughter in her father's house. Except that it was not her father's house anymore. Her father was dead. And the question of whose house it was now — a question that in most families the courts and the men would have answered, with papers and appraisers and a division among the heirs — was answered, in this one, by her mother, without a paper and without a court and without asking anyone at all.

Her mother took it.

* * *

What her mother did, and what it cost to see it

Mary Polly Rorie was fifty-eight years old the summer her husband died, and she did not give up the house, and she did not go to town, and she did not send for a lawyer or an appraiser or any of her married sons to come and settle what their father had left. She simply kept on. She got up the morning after the burying and did the work of the place, and she did it the next morning, and the morning after that, and by doing it she became, without any document ever saying so, the head of the household and the keeper of the farm — a widow of fifty-eight running a war-shrunk place on her own authority, on the plain strength of being the one who was there and would not stop.

Mary Jane watched her do it, and the watching was one of the great educations of her life, and it went into her the way the important things went into her, without a word said.

Because there was a thing her mother might have done and did not do, and Mary Jane was old enough now to see the not-doing and to understand it. A widow of property, in that country, in the ordinary run of things, went to the Probate Court. Her husband's estate was opened and administered; an appraiser walked the place and wrote down what was on it — the stock and the tools and the gear of the mill and the household goods and every other thing a man died owning — and the whole was valued and set down in a book, and the widow took her dower and the heirs took their shares, and the law, grinding slow, divided a dead man's world among the living he had left. It was how it was done. The books of that county are full of it, widow after widow, estate after estate, the appraisers' careful columns marching down the pages.

Mary Polly did none of it. She never opened her husband's estate. She never had the place appraised. She never took a dower or forced a division, and the reason, as near as it can be reached, was the plainest reason there is: she did not have to, and going to court in the middle of a war to divide a farm she was perfectly able to run herself would have been a foolishness, and Mary Polly was not a foolish woman. Her children were grown. There were no minors to force the court's hand, no small heirs whose shares the law had to protect. There was only a competent widow of fifty-eight and a farm that needed running, and so she ran it, and let the law alone, and the law — which only moves when someone makes it move — left her alone in return.

Mary Jane, watching, understood that this was strength, and understood what kind. It was not the strength of a woman who does a large brave thing on a single day. It was the other kind, the kind she came from and would spend her own life practicing — the strength of getting up every morning and doing the work in front of you and not stopping, of carrying a place on your own back through four years of war and ruin because there is no one else to carry it and it

must be carried. Her mother was the standard. Mary Jane could not have put the word to it then, but she felt the fact of it: that in the worst years the county had ever seen, the woman who held that ridge together was her own mother, a widow, working, keeping the thing alive by main strength and refusal; and that this — not a wedding, not a girl's good fortune — this was what a woman of her line was, at her fullest and her best.

And Mary Jane was twenty-nine, and then thirty, and then thirty-one, and then thirty-two, and she was in it beside her mother the whole time, doing the daughter's half of the endless work, and she was watching her mother be the thing the house had never once given her the chance to be. That was the private grief folded inside the plain years, and she never spoke it and half the time did not let herself feel it: that she was thirty years old and had never had a house of her own to keep, a farm of her own to hold, a place the holding of which would have made her, too, the standard of something — that she was a grown woman of proven competence spending the strength of her best years holding up a place that was her mother's, in a life that had handed her every duty of a matron and none of the standing, and that she would go on doing it, as far as she could see, until there was no one left to do it for. She did not resent her mother for it. You could not resent Mary Polly; she was the finest thing in the county and Mary Jane knew it. She resented, if she resented anything, only the shape of her own years — and even that she mostly folded up and put away, because there was a war on and a farm to run and no profit in it.

The war ground on and the place bled the way every place bled. The news came down the ridge and it was bad and then worse. And in the summer of 1864 it came to the door in the way she would remember longest: word that Ezekiah was dead. Her brother — the boy of seventeen the first marshal had counted beside her, grown into the prosperous one, the note-holder with the two-thousand-dollar farm and the young children — had been killed in the fighting east of Atlanta, three hundred miles from the ground he was raised on, in the July of that year. And Mary Jane watched her mother receive it, and watched what her mother did with it, and what her mother did with it was go to the Bible.

The Rorie Bible sat on the shelf in the parlor where it had sat all Mary Jane's life, and her mother had kept it for forty years — the births and the marriages and the deaths of the family entered in it in Mary Polly's careful round keeping-hand, the record the family made of itself when no other record would. And when the word came about Ezekiah, Mary Polly took the book down and opened it to the deaths and wrote her son's name and the day he died and the place, in the same hand she had used to write his birth in, near thirty years before, on a page a little further up. Mary Jane was there. She saw her mother do it. And she did not know, and her mother did not know, that this would be the last thing Mary Polly ever wrote in that book — that the hand which had kept the family's record for forty years would set down her son's death and then, worn past the point a keeping-hand can bear, close the book and not take it up again; so that the deaths-page of

the Rorie Bible ends there, at Ezekiah, in the summer of 1864, with everything that died in the family afterward going unwritten. But that belongs further along. What Mary Jane saw, that day, was only her mother writing her brother into the book with a steady hand, and she understood that this too was the standard — that you kept the record, that you wrote your dead down, that the keeping did not stop for grief, because the keeping was how the family held on to its own.

By the time the war ended, in the spring of 1865, Mary Polly had carried the place three years a widow and would carry it more. The farm had come through — smaller, poorer, the money worthless, the mill idle, but the ground still theirs and the household still standing, held together by an old woman's refusal to let it fall. In a year or so the heirs would at last do the one thing with the law that had to be done — not administer the personal estate, which Mary Polly never touched, but divide the land, because land held by a dead man passes to all his heirs together and cannot be run that way forever; and there would be a court petition and a commissioner and a sale of Reuben's ground for division among his children, and that sale, and who stood at it, and what it set in motion for Mary Jane herself, belongs to the next turn of this account. What belongs here, at the end of the widow's years, is the plain shape of what Mary Polly did: she took a farm no one gave her, in the worst years the country had, and she held it, and she asked no court's leave to do it.

And that plain shape, that refusal to go to law, which is the very thing that made her the standard — that is the thing this chapter has to turn and look at from the other side. Because the farm Mary Polly took and held and never carried to any court was not only ground and stock and an idle mill. There were people on it. And the same refusal that makes her the standard is the reason we do not know their names.

* * *

The three, and the reason the book cannot name them

There were three people held on the Rorie place, and they were there before the war and through the war, and they were freed off that ground in 1865, and this book owes them what it can give, which is less than they are owed and more than the record wants to allow — and it owes them, first, the plain fact that it cannot tell you their names.

Not their names, not their people, not the country they or their mothers were carried from, not the road by which they came onto Reuben Rorie's ridge, not one word any of them ever said. The record that reaches us gives them exactly this and no more: that in the late summer of 1860 the assistant marshal Porter Walker — himself a man who had held two enslaved people ten years before, no clerk observing the thing from outside it — rode up the ridge with the government's second book, the one kept for slaves, and wrote against Reuben Rorie's name three human beings, entered not by name, because that book did not ask for

names, but by a number and a letter each: a woman of sixty-five, a man of thirty-six, a girl of seven. And beside them, in the ninth column, a figure: one slave house. A structure standing in the Rorie yard, built at some point in the decade before, in which three people lived who were counted as property and left off every page that might have said who they were.

Hold them there a moment, because it is nearly all we have. A woman of sixty-five in 1860 — born, then, around 1795, in the last years of the old century, which means she had been alive through the whole history of the thing that held her, and had very likely been carried or sold more than once to arrive, old, on a ridge in north Mississippi in a house not her own. A man of thirty-six — born around 1824, in his full strength, the labor of the place very likely resting on his back. And a girl of seven — born around 1853, on that ground or brought to it as an infant, a child who had known nothing in her life but that yard and that house and the family that owned the ground she was born on. Three people, three generations near enough, one house. They had names. Of course they had names — names their own people called them by in that house in the yard, a woman's name and a man's name and a child's name, said a thousand times in the ordinary business of three lives, at the fire and in the field and in the dark. Not one of the three came down to us. The book that would tell you what Reuben Rorie was worth can tell you there were three of them and how old and what sex and what color, and it cannot tell you what to call them, because to the people who made the record they were a sum and not a set of names, and the sum is what survived.

Now here is the hard thing, the thing this chapter has to say plainly because plainness is the only honesty available: it did not have to be this way, and the reason it is this way runs straight back through Mary Polly.

Because that county did name enslaved people. It named them constantly. The very books that swallowed Reuben Rorie's death — the probate books, the inventories and appraisements and estate divisions of Tishomingo County — are full of the names of the enslaved, page after page, because when a slaveholder died and his estate was administered, the law required that every thing he owned be written down and valued, and the enslaved were written down among the things, by name and by price. The books of that county carry them by the hundred: *Rhody, Jane, Betty, Milly, Jack, Eli, Dick, Caroline, Sarah, Lee, Sam, Prince* — and, in one estate, in a line a person does not easily read twice, *a Negro girl slave named Mary, aged seven years, valued seven hundred dollars*. A girl of seven, named and priced, in the same county, in the same books, in the same years. The machinery for writing an enslaved child's name onto a permanent public page existed and ran and ran. It was a monstrous machinery — it named them in order to value them, it named them the way you name livestock in an inventory, it named them as property — but it named them, and its naming is the reason we know a great many of the enslaved people of that county by name at all.

It never ran over the three on the Rorie place. And the reason it never ran over them is that Reuben Rorie's estate was never administered — no inventory,

no appraisement, no division — because his widow was a competent woman of fifty-eight with grown children and no need of the court, and she kept the farm herself and never went to law. The three were on that place in 1860 as part of the personal estate, part of the very five thousand dollars that seated the family at the front of the meeting-house. When Reuben died in 1862 they passed, in the eyes of that world, to his widow along with the rest of what he left, and Mary Polly held the place and them with it and never opened an estate — and so no appraiser ever walked the Rorie yard writing down what was in it, and the one kind of document that would have set those three names on a page was the one document Mary Polly's competence made unnecessary. She kept the farm without the court. The court is where the names would have been written. She did the thing that makes her the standard, and the thing that makes her the standard is precisely the thing that left three people nameless.

That is not an irony to be admired for its shape and it is not a paradox to be turned over for its cleverness. It is a plain hard fact and it should sit heavy. The strength that this book honors in Mary Polly Rorie — the refusal to go to law, the carrying of a place on her own back — is the same act, the identical act, that erased three people from the record more thoroughly than the county's monstrous machinery would have. Both things are true of the one woman and the one act, and the book sets both down and does not soften either, because to honor the strength and hide the cost would be to do to these three exactly what the record already did: use them, and then leave them out.

And then, in 1865, they were free.

What that day was on the Rorie ridge, no record says and this book will not invent. Freedom came to the enslaved of north Mississippi not on one clean morning but raggedly, over the last year of the war and the months after it, as the armies moved and the word spread and the old power failed — and it came to the three on the Rorie place at some point in that unfixed stretch, and one of the plainest and most enormous facts of their lives, the day they ceased to be owned, is a day this book cannot date and would not presume to picture. What can be said is only what freedom meant in that country in those months: that the road opened. That a person who had been held could go — could leave the ground they had been born on or carried to, could go to look for the people slavery had sold away from them, could go toward the places freedom was gathering. And thirteen miles north, at Corinth, freedom had been gathering for years already. All through the war, from the autumn of 1862, there had been a camp there — a contraband camp, they called it, on the east side of the ruined town, where the formerly enslaved came in from the countryside by the hundred and then the thousand, more than six thousand at its height, and built themselves a place: a settlement with a church and a hospital and streets laid out and houses numbered, with a school where children learned by day and grown people by night, with hundreds of acres worked for wages that were actually paid. It stood only thirteen miles from the Rorie yard, in the same years the three were held

there, a whole town of freedom up the road from a house of bondage. Whether any of the three ever walked to it, this book does not know and will not say they did. It is set down here only because it was there — because while three people were being counted as property on Reuben Rorie's ridge, thirteen miles off there were freed people living in numbered houses and drawing wages and learning their letters, and both of those were Tishomingo County in the same year, and the book that tells the one owes the reader the other.

After freedom, the record loses them, and the losing is itself the last thing to be said. The census of 1870 was the first the United States ever took in which the formerly enslaved were counted as people, with names, in households of their own — the first document in the whole history of the country that might have told us what the three called themselves once they were free to be called it. It does not hold them. On the old Rorie ground, and on the ground where the Searcys and the rest of that neighborhood were counted in 1870, there is no household of theirs to be found — no woman near seventy-five, no man near forty-six, no young woman near seventeen, taking the name Rorie or any name traceable back to that place. They did not stay on as the family's freed neighbors, the way many freedpeople did; and the name-blind index that has never once been able to find this family cannot find them either. Where they went, whether they lived, what they made of the freedom that came to them old and grown and half-grown on that ridge, the reachable record does not say. The woman of sixty-five in 1860 would have been seventy in 1865, and a woman freed at seventy in a ruined country may not have had long, and may lie in unmarked ground within a mile of where she was held, and be past any finding. The man and the girl walked out of the record into lives this book cannot follow.

So this is the whole of the accounting, and it is thin, and its thinness is the point. Three people were held on the Rorie place: a woman, a man, a child. They were there through the war. They were freed off that ground in 1865. They had names, and the names are gone, and they are gone because the one document that would have preserved them was never made, and it was never made because the woman this book calls the standard kept the farm without the court. They are not a figure in Mary Jane's story and they are not a shadow cast to deepen anyone's chapter. They are three people this account owes an accounting to, and this is it — offered in their own right, in the one place the book set aside for them, with their namelessness laid at the door of the exact act that caused it, and with no pretense that the book has given them back anything the record took. It has only refused to pretend they were not there.

They were there. A woman of sixty-five, a man of thirty-six, a girl of seven, and one house standing in the yard. The book sets them down as the record allows, which is barely, and grieves the rest, and goes on — because the chapter must go on, the way the years went on for everyone left on that ridge; but it does not go on as though the yard had been empty. It was not empty. It is only that the ones who could have told us are the ones the record was built to forget, and it forgot them

well, and the most this account can do is say so, and say that it was wrong, and mean it.

Chapter 6 — Miss M. J. Rorie

The house the war left

Seven years is a long time anywhere. In a country that spends four of them at war, it is long enough to take a world apart, and when the world it takes apart is a woman's — quietly, without ever making her the point of it — she comes out the far side of it changed in ways the record has no column for.

When the second man with the second book had closed his ledger in the summer of 1860, the Rorie place had stood at the top of everything it would ever be: her father a man of five thousand dollars, the mill turning, the sons married and set up around him, the two unmarried daughters at home. Mary Jane had been twenty-seven then, and the house had been full, and the worst that could be said of her life was that it had not yet begun. By the time anything happened to her that the world would write down, seven years later, almost none of that was still standing, and the worst that could be said of her life was a great deal worse than that it had not begun. It was that so much of what she had was gone.

Her father was dead. Reuben Rorie had died in the August of 1862, in the second summer of the war — the man who had come off the Yadkin and read the fall of the creek and built the whole standing place out of the raw ground, gone in the middle of everything, at the cabin where he had slept. And the plainest surviving trace of his death is not a stone or a will but a debt, a line entered into a neighbor's estate book by a clerk settling other men's accounts: *Reuben Rorie decd 1862*. That was what was left of him on paper. The mill he had built, the five thousand dollars he had made, ran out into the war the way everything ran out into the war — into Confederate paper and cotton money and debts owed in a country that would not exist in three years — and the man himself came down to a clerk's aside in the settling of somebody else's estate.

Her brother was dead. Ezekiah — the brother nearest her in age, the boy of seventeen the first marshal had counted beside her, grown into the prosperous one, the note-holder with the two-thousand-dollar farm and the two small children — had been killed in the July of 1864, in the fighting east of Atlanta, three hundred miles from the ground he was raised on. And Mary Jane knew exactly where the news of that had gone, because she had watched her mother take it: to the Bible, to the deaths page, where Mary Polly wrote her son's name down in the careful round keeping-hand she had used for forty years. It was the last thing she ever wrote in the book. After Ezekiah the hand that had kept that Bible since before Mary Jane was born stopped keeping it. The book went quiet, the way a great many things in that house went quiet after the war, and it did not matter to Mary Jane at the time that it had gone quiet, because there was too much else to carry; but it would matter, later, in a way she could not yet see.

And there had been three people on her father's ground who were not Rories, whom the second census had counted as property in the year the house stood at

its height — a woman, a man, a child who had come onto that yard in the 1850s — and in 1865 they were free, and they go on now into their own accounting, in their own place in this book and not in this chapter, which is Mary Jane's and has no right to make them hers.

So the high house of 1860 came down, in four years, to a widow and an unmarried daughter keeping a shrunken place together, in a county that had buried a great many of its men and would shortly not even be the county it had been. Mary Jane held it with her mother. That was the work of those years, and there is almost no record of it, because holding a diminished household together through the tail of a war and the ruin after it is work that generates no paper — no deed, no lawsuit, no entry in any book. She was in her early thirties. She had spent her twenties waiting for her life to begin, and now she spent the first years of her thirties learning that a life does not always begin; sometimes it is only handed things to carry, one after another, and the carrying is the life. She buried her father. She helped her mother through the news of her brother. She held the place. She was thirty, and thirty-one, and thirty-two, and thirty-three, and the county, if it thought of her at all, had long since stopped thinking of her as a woman anything was going to happen to. She had stopped thinking of herself that way. She was Reuben Rorie's unmarried daughter who kept house with her widowed mother, and that, everyone including Mary Jane had settled, was simply what she was and would go on being.

She was thirty-four when it turned out not to be.

* * *

Miss

She married in the January of 1867, and the plainest way to say what that was is to say what it was not. It was not a girl's wedding.

The man was Freeman Searcy — the same Freeman the second book had written down at thirty in 1860, landless, a day-labourer in his brother's house, the poorest grown man on a road of landed families, the one who had been living a door from her sister the whole time and whom the neighborhood's arithmetic had set aside as too poor the way it had set her aside as too old. He was thirty-six now. What the war years had made of him, the record does not clearly say, and this book will not invent it; and how the two of them came, at last, to stand up together — whether they had half-known each other the whole time in the way people in one county do, or whether the leveling years had thrown them together — the record does not say that either, and it will not be guessed. What the record says is only the fact, on a single civil line: that on the tenth of January of 1867 a clerk took down a marriage between *F. J. Searcy* and *Miss M. J. Rorie*.

She was not a girl at that wedding and she did not pretend to be one. She was thirty-four. She had buried her father and her brother and held a diminished house together through four years of war, and she knew to the bone what she was

doing and what it was. She was not being handed the crossing at fifteen the way her mother had been handed it, the way her sisters had, in the full flush of a girl who has done nothing yet and has everything ahead. She was marrying, at thirty-four, a poor man of thirty-six who had nothing in the world but himself, and she knew that too, and she did it anyway, and the doing of it was the most clear-eyed and least sentimental thing a person can do: she took the one who was left, being herself the one who was left, and out of the two of them she made a household. There is nothing in any record to say it was a love match and nothing to say it was not. There is only that two people the world had entirely finished expecting anything of looked at each other, at thirty-four and thirty-six, and judged that late and poor and past-it was a better thing done together than apart.

That is a grown woman's yes, and there is more in it than in a hundred girls', and it wants no dressing-up to be seen for what it was. She had waited seventeen years past the age her family married its women, and the waiting had not been rewarded with anything a girl would have recognized as a reward — not a young man with a place and a plan, not a courtship out of a story, not the flush of being chosen young. It had been rewarded, if reward is even the word, with a plain poor man her own hard age and a plain civil line in a county register, and she took it with both hands, because she had learned by thirty-four exactly what such a thing was worth, which is everything, and exactly what it was not, which is a girl's dream, and she had no more use for the girl's dream. She had buried the people who might have dreamed it for her.

And the record, on the one day it might have written her down whole, would not do even that.

Miss. The clerk wrote the word in the ordinary way of a clerk noting a bride, and had no idea he was setting down the truest single word the record would put beside her until the very end of her life. A *Miss* — an unmarried woman — of thirty-four, marrying under her own maiden name, out of her dead father's house, at an age when the whole county had long since stopped expecting it. And even then it would not give her her name. It gave her *M. J. Rorie*: two initials and the surname she had carried her whole life, with the small courtesy of her singleness set in front of it. Not Mary Jane. Not the given name her mother had written in the Bible on the day she was born. *Miss M. J. Rorie*. Seventeen years back, the first book had at least written her age down true; now, on her wedding day, the record gave her two letters and a title and let it stand, and that — two initials and a *Miss* — was the whole of what the founding of her family was allowed to be on paper.

The clerk who wrote it was a clerk of Tishomingo County, because the county was still Tishomingo that January, and would be for three years more, until the state cut a new county called Alcorn out of it in 1870 and laid the new name down over the same ground. So the marriage that began her family was recorded in a county that would not exist by the time her first son could walk, and would afterward be found, when anyone went looking for it, filed under the name of a county not yet thought of on the day the ink went down. Even the jurisdiction she

married in did not hold still. Everything about her moved except her — the county's name, the record's version of her, the world she stood in — and she stood in the middle of all of it on the tenth of January of 1867 and became, at last, at thirty-four, a wife.

* * *

The unwritten line, and the ground

There was one book that should have held it, and did not.

In the family's own Bible — the worn black book that had sat on the shelf of the parlor her whole life, that her mother had kept since before Mary Jane was born — there was a marriages page, and on it, in Mary Polly's careful hand, stood the weddings of the two elder daughters: Elizabeth's of 1834, Louisa Adeline's of 1838. There was room below them. There had always been room below them; the page had been waiting, Mary Jane's whole girlhood, for the lines of the daughters still to marry. And when Mary Jane married at last, at thirty-four, in the January of 1867, no line was written for her. There would never be one. The page that held her sisters' weddings holds nothing for hers, and the reason is not cruelty and not a slight; the reason is that the hand that kept the book had stopped. Her mother's last entry anywhere in it had been Ezekiah's death in the summer of 1864, and after that the book had gone quiet with the rest of the house, and the daughter's late and unlooked-for wedding — the one wedding in the family that against all the county's expectation anyone might have thought worth marking twice — fell into that quiet and was never set down.

Mary Jane knew the page was blank. She had grown up reading that book; she knew exactly what was on the marriages leaf and what was not. And it is a hard thing to know about your own wedding, that the one book in the world that was made to hold it will not — not because anyone decided against you but because the person who would have written you in had been asked to carry more than a keeping-hand can carry, and had set the book down after her son, and could not take it up again even for her daughter's one good day. The founding of the whole family that came down from Mary Jane and Freeman Searcy — five generations of it, and counting — went into no book but the county's, on a single civil line, under two initials and a *Miss*. Her mother did not write her in. Her mother could not. And Mary Jane, who had spent her whole life inside the keeping of that book, married out from under it into a marriage the book would never hold, and did not blame her mother for it for one moment of her life, and felt the blankness of that page for the rest of it.

And eight days after the clerk set the marriage down, there was a piece of ground to be bought.

It was her father's ground, and it was being sold at his own door. Reuben had been dead four years and more, and in all that time no one had gone to law over him — the widow had taken the farm the summer he died and carried it since —

but land held by a dead man passes to all his heirs together, in undivided shares, and a farm cannot be run that way forever; sooner or later the heirs must divide it, and the law's way of dividing ground that will not cut fairly into parts is to sell the whole and split the money. So in the November term of 1866 her brother William Hubbard and the rest of the heirs had petitioned the Probate Court to sell their father's land for division, and the court had appointed a commissioner to cry the sale, and set the day, and set the place in the plain language such orders use: the land would be sold *at the late residence of the said R. Rorie deceased*. At the house. At the Rorie place itself — the dooryard Mary Jane had been brought to as a girl, the ground she had waited in through all her twenties and held through all the war, the yard her father had made out of the woods. That was where they would sell what was left of him, on the eighteenth of January of 1867, and Mary Jane was eight days a wife when they did it.

The sale drew the neighborhood the way such sales did, the kin and the near-neighbors come to bid on pieces of a dead man's homestead, and the ground went in parcels to be divided by the money it fetched. And the high bidder for one of the parcels — a piece of Section Eighteen, a corner of Reuben's own homestead ground — was set down in the commissioner's book under a name the record had carried for seven years with nothing at all beside it: *F. J. Searcy*. Freeman. Two hundred and sixty-five dollars, and the land was his.

Sit for a moment with what that name had meant the last time a book had written it down. Seven years back, the second marshal had put Freeman Searcy in the census at thirty and drawn his pen down the columns and left every one blank — no land, no property, nothing, a grown man who owned his own back and not one foot of the earth. That was the man Mary Jane had married. And eight days after she married him, that man stood in her dead father's dooryard and bought a piece of her dead father's ground, and walked away from the sale holding, for the first time in his life that any record shows, title to land. It will not do to make more of it than it was, and it does not need more made of it. The partition was already moving before the wedding; the sale would have happened whether Freeman married in or not; he took a share the way an in-law takes a share at a sale already in motion, and the fact carries itself without help. The landless man married the settled family's unmarriageable daughter, and within the fortnight he held a corner of the family's ground, bought at auction at the family's own door.

They settled on that ground and did not leave it. And here is the whole shape of Mary Jane's life in one unremarkable turn of the law: Freeman bought the land in the January of 1867; three years later, in the spring of 1870, the state cut Alcorn County out of the old body of Tishomingo and laid the new name down over the same fields, so that the ground he had bought in one county sat, without moving an inch, in another. She went to sleep a woman of Tishomingo and woke, on the same soil, in Alcorn, and had done nothing and gone nowhere to make it so. The dirt was the dirt. It was the world that moved.

It was not given to her. Nobody had held that ground for her against the day she finally married, or set it aside, or done her any kindness with it at all; it was sold at auction to the highest bidder, and the highest bidder for that corner of it happened to be the poor man she had just made her husband. But it came to the same place in the end, by the plainest and least sentimental road there was. At thirty-four, out of a dead father's estate, at a sale on a January morning eight days after her wedding, the woman who had never in her life had a place of her own came to stand on a piece of ground that was — bought and paid for and written down, in the one kind of book that would hold her, if not by her name. She had waited a very long time for a life to start. It started with a deed, and a poor man's two hundred and sixty-five dollars, and a corner of her father's dirt. It was not the beginning anyone would have dreamed for her at seventeen. But it was, at last, a beginning, and it was hers, and there were, though she did not know it yet, three sons in it.

Chapter 7 — Three Sons

The one she did not give back

She was thirty-five when the first one came, and the thing she felt, holding him, was a thing she had felt a hundred times before and never once like this: she did not have to give him back.

All her life she had held other women's children. She had been the arms the babies were handed to while their mothers rested — her sisters' children, her brothers' children, the whole crop of nieces and nephews a family throws off across twenty years — and she had held every one of them warm against her and felt, each time, the exact moment the mother reached to take the child again, the plain unthinking certainty of a woman reaching for her own; and she had handed the weight over, and stood up, and gone to see about the supper. She had done it so many times the ache of it had stopped being an ache and become a fact of her, the low permanent weather of a woman who is everyone's help and no one's mother. Now she was thirty-five, married a year, and the child in her arms was hers, and no one was going to reach for him, and she could hold him as long as she liked, all night if she liked, and in the morning he would still be hers to hold. It was the strangest and the best thing that had ever happened to her body, that simple permanence: the not-giving-back.

The house began to fill, and it filled fast, because she had come to it late and there was no long slow front of a married life ahead of her the way there is ahead of a girl of eighteen. A woman who marries at thirty-four does the thing quickly if she does it at all, and Mary Jane did it quickly. A first son within the year of the wedding. A second not long after. The years that had crept past her one indistinguishable from the next, all through her twenties and thirties, while she held everyone else's beginnings — those same years came, now, each one freighted with something of her own that had not been there the year before, and the house that had been full her whole life of other people's lives began, for the first time, to fill with hers.

The eldest they wrote down, in the books that would hold him, as W. H., and the name behind the letters was almost certainly her brother's — William Hubbard, the one of the Rorie boys who had gone to the war and come home from it, the uncle left standing when Ezekiah was not. It is the kind of thing a family does without remarking on it, names the first-born for the one who came back, and this book will not make more of it than that; but the letters are there, a Searcy child carrying a Rorie soldier's name onto the old Rorie ground, and it is of a piece with the whole of where these people lived and whom they lived among.

Then the second, and the second is the one the record catches in the very act of the book's argument.

He was born on the sixth of January, in 1870, and they named him Robert Edwin. And three months and nine days after he was born, while he was still a

thing in a cradle who had done nothing in the world but arrive, the state of Mississippi cut a new county called Alcorn out of the old body of Tishomingo, and the new line came down across the country and put the cradle in a different county than the one the child had been born in. He had not moved. Nothing about him had moved. He lay in the same house on the same ground his mother had lived on her whole life, and the world reached over the cradle and changed the name of the place while he slept. Mary Jane, who had watched a town come up out of the woods thirteen miles off and take two names before it was finished, and had married in a county that would not exist by the time her son could walk, now had a son who was born in one county and would grow up in another without going anywhere at all — the first of her children born straight into the plain truth her whole life had been teaching her, that the dirt stays and the map moves, and that a person can be handed a whole new county through no act of his own but lying still in the one he was born in.

She did not think it in those words, rocking him. She thought only that he was hers, and that he was well, and that the arm he was heavy in was her own arm and would not have to give him up.

* * *

The third man with a book

The third man with a book came up the road in the September of 1870, and for once in Mary Jane's life the book was kind to her.

She was thirty-seven that year, or near it, and she had been counted twice before and remembered both. The first man had found her a girl of seventeen at the loom and written her down true. The second had found her a woman of twenty-seven at the wash and written her down at twenty-five, and she had stood thirty feet off and said nothing while the house shaved two years from her to spare her. This third man found her a wife and a mother of two with a third on the way, on her husband's own ground, in a county three months old — and he wrote her down, of all the unlikely things, at very near her right age. *Mary, thirty-seven*. Not shaved. Not invented. For the second time in her life, and the first since she was a girl, the record asked how old she was and set the true number down, because a married woman of thirty-seven with a farmer husband and children in the house is not a number anybody needs to be careful with; there is no shame in the age of a wife. The years had made her, at last, a woman the record could tell the truth about again.

It still would not give her her name. It gave her *Mary* — not Mary Jane, not the whole of her, just the one plain name a census taker sets down for a farmer's wife — and she was used to that by now, had been used to it her whole life, and did not expect the book to do more and was not surprised when it did not. But it got her age right, and after the shame of the last counting there was a small grace even in that, the record meeting her halfway on the one day it had ever been easy to.

And the man of the house it wrote down that September was not the man the second book had found. Ten years back, the marshal had put Freeman Searcy in the census at thirty with every column empty beside his name — day-labourer, no land, no property, nothing at all, the poorest grown man on a road of landed families. The marshal of 1870 found a farmer. He found Freeman on his own place with real estate set against his name and a personal estate beside it — better than a thousand dollars, all told, where ten years before there had been a row of blanks. The landless man had made himself, in the one decade that took nearly everyone else in that county down, a man of property: not a rich man, not a Reuben with his mill and his five thousand, but a standing man on standing ground, counted among the people who owned the country they worked. He had built it the way a poor man builds, out of nothing and by inches, on the old Rorie ground where he had married in and stayed. Mary Jane had married a man with empty columns. She was the wife, now, of a man the book gave numbers to. The too-poor man of 1860 was a landholder; the too-old woman of 1860 was the mother of his sons; and the sorting that had set the two of them aside had been wrong about everything except the two years it once shaved off her age.

But the truest thing on that 1870 page was none of the grown people. It was the baby. Down at the bottom of the household, under the parents and the growing boy, the marshal wrote *Robert, four-twelfths* — Robert Edwin at four months old, his first appearance in any record anywhere, the oldest paper trace of the man he would grow to be. Sixty years of his life would run out from that four-months' line, and nearly the whole of it on the same ground; but on the day it was written he was a number in a column, four months into the world, in a county three months older than himself. Mary Jane, who had spent her whole life watching the record get her wrong, watched it take down her son at the very beginning of him, and there was nothing wrong in it to grieve — only a small new person, correctly counted, at the start of a long life on the family's dirt.

And around the household on that page was everyone. The counting set the Searcys down in the thick of the same cluster the second book had held — Rories and Walkers and Rineharts and Vanderfords, the intermarried families of that road — with Freeman's sister a few doors off in another household and Mary Jane's own brother William Hubbard up the page. It was the neighborhood it had always been, the family and the neighborhood one thing, the way it had been her whole life; only now she was not the waiting daughter at the middle of it but a wife and mother with a place of her own inside the cluster, counted among the households instead of inside her father's. She had not moved an inch to get there. The road was the same road. But her standing on it had changed, at last, in the only direction it had ever had left to go.

* * *

Three, and none of them given back

The third son came in 1873, when she was forty, and with him the house was full.

They wrote him down, like the others, by his initials — F. N. — a third small Searcy on the old Rorie ground. He was the last; forty is late, and three was what the late marriage gave her, and three was what she kept. She had borne three sons in the six years since she married, from thirty-five to forty, and the house that had counted her whole life only the people it was losing — the grandmother from the corner, the old man up the road, her father, her brother, all the leavings of all the years — now counted, for the first time she could remember, only the people it was gaining. Three boys under one roof, all of them hers, all of them living.

It is worth setting her beside her mother here, because the two counts do not read the way you would think. Mary Polly had borne ten. Ten children off that ground over the years of her marriage, the full house that was the very standard of what a woman of that country was raised to be. Mary Jane bore three. She had come to it too late for more, and three was a thin harvest beside her mother's ten, and by the plain arithmetic of the neighborhood — the same arithmetic that had once counted her too old to start — she had done a fraction of what her mother did. But set the other column beside that one. Of Mary Polly's ten, the ground had taken some back; a woman who bears ten in that century does not keep ten, and Mary Polly had stood over more than one child's grave in her time, and had buried at the last a grown son east of Atlanta besides. Mary Jane bore three, and she kept three. She would keep them — all three, every year still coming, to the far end of her own long life — and that is a thing this book will come to in its own place and will not spend here; but it begins in 1873, with the third boy in the house and not one of the three yet taken from her. The daughter who had done a fraction of what her mother did had done, on the one count that cuts the deepest of all, the thing her mother could not: she had borne her children and given none of them back.

And there is the phrase her whole life had taught her, come round now to mean the opposite of what it always had. *Given back*. All those years she had held the family's babies and given every one of them back to its mother. She had learned the ache of it in her arm before she had a child of her own to weigh against it. And now she had three of her own and gave none of them back — not to a mother, because she was the mother, and not to the ground, because the ground did not take them. The arms that had handed a hundred warm children over to other women held their own three and kept them.

There is one more thing to say of these years, because it is the years these were, and the earlier chapters have been quietly laying it in. She was, by now, the family's hands for the dead. She had learned the office at twenty-four, over her grandmother's body, and had gone on learning it, because in a family and a neighborhood that size someone is always being made ready for the ground and the readying falls to the women who can do it steadily, and she could. Those

hands knew the work of the dead. They had done it, and they would do it again, more times than any one person should be asked to, in the years still ahead of her. But not in these years. In these years — the new decade, the house filling, the three boys underfoot — those same hands did nothing but the work of the living. They washed children who squirmed and hollered instead of children who lay still. They dressed the quick. The woman who would one day lay out very nearly everyone she loved spent the one long full stretch of her life with no one under her roof to lay out at all, only three loud boys to feed and scrub and chase and raise; and the hands that knew the dead so well were given, for once and for a good while together, nothing to do but keep the living going. It was the nearest thing to plain ordinary happiness the record ever lets us catch her in, and it is worth marking as exactly that: a full house, everyone in it breathing, the death-work set down for a season.

The boys would grow, of course, the way boys grow, and go; and the years were already on their way that would thin the house again by the ordinary means, and turn her, at the far end, into an old woman taken into a child's house the way her grandmother had been and her mother would be. But that is the far side of the hill, and it is not yet, and it does not belong here. In 1873 she was forty years old, on the ground she had been born beside, with a husband who had made himself a farmer out of nothing and three sons in the house and every one of them living. The county had set her down, at twenty-seven, among its settled and finished features, a woman nothing further was going to happen to. A great deal had happened to her. It had only taken until she was thirty-four to start, and it had come, when it came, all at once, and on the same dirt she had stood on her whole life — and she held it the way she had learned to hold everything, in the arm, warm against her, except that this, at last, she did not have to give back.

Chapter 8 — Taken In

The top of her life

By the summer of 1880 she was a woman of forty-seven with a full house and a standing place, and if the record had ever been going to let her rest easy on one of its countings, this was the one.

The fourth man with a book came up the road that June — J. M. Bynum, walking Beat 3 of Alcorn County, the fourth census taker of her life and the second to find her a settled wife on her own ground. She was used to them by now. She had watched them come every ten years since she was a girl at the loom, the man and the ledger and the ruled columns, and she had learned across a lifetime exactly what they could do to a woman and exactly what they could not, and she had no particular dread of this one. There was nothing in her line, this time, to dread. She was forty-seven and she was a farmer's wife of forty-seven, and there was no shame in that number and nothing about it that the house would need to shave or soften; the years, having spent her whole youth making her a woman the record had to lie about to be kind, had at last carried her all the way over to the other side, to the plain broad country of the middle-aged wife, where the truth costs nothing again because nobody is measuring it.

So the marshal wrote her down at forty-seven, and forty-seven she was. He found the household at the fullest and best it would ever be. Freeman was fifty, a farmer on his own place — the landless day-labourer of twenty years back grown into a settled man the county counted among its property-holders. The three sons were around them, growing: the eldest coming up on a man's height, the middle boy Robert Edwin ten years old and long past the four-months' cradle the third book had caught him in, the youngest still a boy. It was a good house, a full house, a rising house on the family's dirt. Mary Jane stood in the middle of it at forty-seven, a matron of standing where she had once been the aging daughter nobody could marry, and if she had been asked, that June, to weigh her life, she would have had to say — quietly, not being a woman who said such things aloud — that it had come out well. Late, and hard, and by roads nobody would have chosen for her. But well. She had a husband and a place and three living sons, and the record, for the second counting running, had let her be exactly her age.

The one thing it still would not do was give her her name. The marshal wrote her, as the clerks always wrote her, by her initials — *M. J.* — the way the marriage return had written her thirteen years before, the way the record had been writing her the whole of her married life: two letters and the surname, never Mary Jane, never the whole of her. She was used to that too. It had stopped being a wound years ago and become a fact of her, like the ache in the arm from the babies, like the sound of the mill under her girlhood — the record would give her initials and not a name, and that was simply how the record held her, and she expected nothing else.

She could not have known, and it would not have consoled her if she had, that even the initials were not safe. A hundred years on, when a stranger's hand came to index that page and make the old book findable, it would look at the *M. J.* the marshal had written and read it as *H. J.* — mistake the very first letter of her, so that the woman who had never once been given her whole name would end by being not even reliably given her right initials. She was *M. J.* on the page and would be *H. J.* in the finding, and Mary Jane nowhere in either. But that was a hundred years off and no concern of a June morning in 1880, when the counting of her own household was the easiest thing the record had ever done to her, and she had every reason to think the book had, for once, simply passed her by without doing any harm.

It had not passed her by without doing any harm. It had only done the harm six pages away, in another household, under another woman's roof, to somebody Mary Jane loved more than she loved her own good name.

* * *

The word

Her mother was in the book too, that June, and the book had written one word beside her, and the word was *mother*.

Mary Jane knew, in her life, what the census only recorded — that Mary Polly had given up her own house. It had happened somewhere in the years nobody had watched closely, the way such things happen to the very old: not a decision so much as a slow yielding, the body asking a little more each season than the ground would give back, until the day came when the widow who had taken the Rorie farm the summer Reuben died and carried it through the whole of the war and held it after, alone, for years — the woman who was the standard of that family, the fixed point the whole neighborhood had measured itself against for a generation — could no longer keep a place of her own, and let it go, and went to live in a daughter's house. Mary Jane had known it as it happened. It was the kind of thing a family knows and does not make a ceremony of: the mother getting old, the mother needing keeping, the mother going to one of the girls. It was ordinary. It was what happened to the very old. It had happened to Grandmother Sarah in Mary Jane's own girlhood, and Mary Jane had stood in that house at twenty-four and washed the old body afterward and learned the office over it. Now it was her mother's turn to be the old woman taken in, and Mary Jane, who was forty-seven and had a full house of her own, felt it the way you feel your mother growing old — as a grief with no event in it, a thing you cannot fight because there is nothing to fight, only the slow turning of the generations bringing your mother down the same road her mother went down.

What Mary Jane did not see, because there was no reason on earth for her to see it, was the page.

The same book that had counted her own thriving household — the full house, the risen husband, the three sons, her own right age — had counted her mother too, six pages further on, most of a beat away, in the household of a man named Hamlin whose wife was very likely one of Mary Polly's own daughters; and in the column that asks what a person is to the head of the house, the marshal had written, for Mary Polly Hubbard Rorie, seventy-five years old, born in Tennessee before there was a country to be born a citizen of, the single plainest and heaviest word the census had for her. Not *head*. Not *keeping house*. *Mother*. The woman who had built and buried and held, who had kept the family's Bible in her own hand for forty years and set the family's births and marriages and deaths down in it and been the still point the whole line turned on — reduced, on the page, to what she was to somebody else's household. Somebody's mother. A dependent in a daughter's house, given the warm place out of the draft, counted at the end under a younger woman's roof, exactly as her own mother had been counted before her.

It is a small word to carry so much. *Mother*. In the ordinary run of the census it means nothing heavier than a fact of the household — this old woman belongs to these people, is kept by them, is theirs. But set against everything Mary Polly had been, it is the whole surrender of a life in seven letters. She had come to the end of what her body could keep, and she had done the only thing there was to do, which was to give the ground up and be taken in; and the record, which had spent Mary Jane's whole life failing to say who Mary Jane was, said with perfect and terrible economy exactly who Mary Polly had become. *Mother*. Not the head of anything. Not the keeper of anything. The old woman in the corner of a child's house.

And six pages back in the same book was her daughter, forty-seven and thriving, at the very top of her life.

* * *

One fate, twice

Here is the thing the 1880 book did, laying those two households down in its pages a few sheets apart, that neither the marshal nor Mary Jane nor anyone alive that June could see: it was not counting two women at all. It was counting one fate, twice.

Because Mary Jane, at forty-seven, in the full flush of the best years she would ever have, was looking straight at her own ending and did not know it. Everything the record had just written of her mother it would one day write of her. Thirty years on — in another decade, in the same county, on the same family dirt — a census taker would come up a farm road and find Mary Jane herself grown old, her own house given up, her own body past the keeping of a place, taken into the household of one of her sons; and in the column that asks what a person is to the head of the house he would write, beside her name, the same word the marshal

wrote beside her mother's this June. *Mother*. The woman who was watching her mother taken in was watching, without the least idea of it, a rehearsal of her own last act — the shape the house had made of its women one after another as far back as anyone could count, the grandmother taken in and then the mother taken in and then, in her turn, when the years had done with her what they do, the daughter. She had helped make her grandmother ready for the ground at twenty-four and thought herself one of the young hands. She was one of the young hands still, at forty-seven, watching her mother go the way of the grandmother. But the road only ran one direction, and she was on it, and the same word was waiting at the end of it for her that had already fallen on the two women ahead of her in the line.

She could not see it. That is the mercy and the cruelty of a life lived forward: she stood at the top of hers, with her house full and her sons growing and her husband a man of standing, and she grieved her mother's coming-down the way any daughter grieves it, as her mother's, as a thing happening to somebody else — and she could not turn the six pages of the book that would have shown her it was a thing happening to herself, thirty years slow. Nobody at the top of a full house can. The end of a life is always six pages away, in a part of the book you have no reason to turn to, written in a stranger's column in a word you would not think to look for.

The family had come apart across the beat by then, the way a family does when it has stayed long on one ground — not scattered, never scattered, but spread: her brother William Hubbard one beat off on the one side, her brother Fred one beat off on the other, her mother taken into a daughter's house at the far end of Beat 3, Mary Jane and her own household at the near end of it, the whole intermarried connection dispersed across the same few square miles of old Tishomingo dirt that nobody had ever left. The ground had held. Everyone was still on it, or near it. What had moved was only the roofs over them — which household held whom, which of the girls had the mother now, which name the county wrote over the same fields it had written another name over ten years before. The dirt was the dirt. The people kept to it, and the map and the households and the census words rearranged themselves around the people the way weather rearranges itself around a hill, and the hill stays.

And somewhere in the moving-around of it, quiet, unremarked, the keeping was passing down. The Bible her mother had kept for forty years and stopped keeping after Ezekiah — the book with the births and the marriages and the deaths in Mary Polly's careful hand, and the blank line where Mary Jane's wedding was never written — was in the world still, in the hands of the old woman who could no longer keep a house, and it would come down, in time, the way the ground came down and the office of laying-out came down, from the mother's hands toward the daughter's, along the same line the surrender ran. Mary Polly had a decade or so left to her, no more; she would die somewhere around the turn of the nineties, an old woman in a child's house, and be laid out by younger hands

the way she had once helped lay out her own mother. But that was still ahead, that June. That June she was only the word in the column, six pages on from her thriving daughter — *mother*, seventy-five, taken in — while Mary Jane stood at the top of her one good stretch of years and could not see, in the same book that held them both, that she was reading her own future in her mother's line.

She was forty-seven. Her house was full. The record had been kind to her, that once. And it had told her, in the same breath and on the same pages, exactly how it would end — if only she had known to turn to where it said so, which she did not, and could not, and was not meant to.

Chapter 9 — Closing Image

The household on the farm south of the railroad was a household of nine. Robert Edwin Searcy worked the general farm in the Third Beat of Alcorn County and was fifty years old that autumn; his wife, Hattie Guthrie Searcy, was three-and-forty and kept the house and the six children in it — Joseph near grown and turning his hand in the field, Mary behind him, and the little ones down to the twins Lester and Esther, just six with their birthday not a fortnight past, and the youngest still a baby carried on a hip. And the ninth of them, the oldest living thing under that roof, was his mother, Mary Jane Rorie Searcy, who had been the matriarch of every house she had lived in since the year her own mother died, and was the matriarch of this one — though it was her son's house and not her own, and she had not kept a house of her own in a dozen years.

She had given up her own house after her husband died. She had kept it one-and-forty years, on the ground she had come to as a bride at thirty-four, and when Freeman was two years in the earth she had let it go and come to live in her son's, a widow, and had carried the two Bibles over in her own lap and set them on the shelf at the south wall of the front room with her own hands — the Rorie Bible in its worn black calf to the right, the Hubbard people's book brought down out of North Carolina before any of them were born, and Aaron Searcy's working Bible in the smaller leather to the left, in the little satchel the old man had carried his keeping in. They had not come down off that shelf since she set them there. She had been a widow twelve years and eight months. She was, on the second Sunday of October, the oldest living thing on the line she had spent the whole of her life keeping.

It was the shape the house had always made of its women, and she knew it better than anyone, having watched it come round twice before it came round to her. Her grandmother had come down from Tennessee in her sixties and taken the bed in the corner of a daughter's kitchen, and Mary Jane had laid her out at twenty-four. Her mother had given the Rorie place up at the last and gone to live in a daughter's house, and had been set down there, an old woman in a household not her own, under the one plain word the census kept for such women — *mother*, seventy-five. And now it had come round to Mary Jane. She had given her own house up and come to her son's, and in the January of that last year a census taker had written her into the book of her final months exactly as her mother had been written into hers: *mother*, in a child's house, on the same dirt none of the three of them had ever left. One fate, the three of them, a generation apart each time. The one thing the record marked differently between her and the two before her was the age: where the marshal had asked it, she had given him eighty-seven, and she was right, and she had been right every time in her life that anyone had asked her — which was more than the house she was counted in could have said for its own. She had watched this thing travel down the family her whole life. She was the

third to arrive at it, and she knew she was, and she had come to it the way she came to everything, without complaint and with the housekeeping done.

The deaths page of that Bible ended where her mother had left it — her father in the summer of 1862, her brother killed at Atlanta in the summer of 1864, both set down in her mother's careful round hand — and after that the column held nothing, and it held nothing for her mother either, whose own dying had gone into no page anywhere. She had kept the book more than thirty years and never added a death to that page, not her husband's when his time came nor any other; the keeping of that column had closed with the war, before the book was ever hers. And she had never once stood at the marriages page to find her own line there, because her own line had never been written. She had known that the way she knew her own name. It had stopped troubling her a long time ago.

* * *

She did not come down to the kitchen at the dawn of that Sunday.

By six Hattie had heard her overhead, the way she had heard her every morning for years — the slow cross of the room, the give of the boards where the old woman went first to the window to look at the weather. Then the boards stayed quiet. The kitchen clock went past the quarter, then the half. Hattie poured the coffee and stood over the stove listening for the step that did not come. Two of the children were already at the table waiting to be fed and she hushed them low, without knowing yet why she did it, only that the quiet overhead was the wrong quiet.

At a quarter past seven she went to the foot of the stair and called up. The answer came back small.

She went up. The door of the south room stood half open, and Mary Jane was sitting on the edge of the bed by the window with her bare feet on the floor and her hands flat on the quilt at her knees. The pitcher on the washstand stood full from the night's draw and the basin was dry. She had not washed.

"Mama, are you sick?" Hattie said.

Mary Jane did not turn from the window. "It's a chill," she said. "I didn't sleep past three. My shoulder's stiff on the right." She drew a breath. "I'll sit here a while."

Hattie went down and came back with the brown shawl off the front-room chair and a cup of coffee. She set the cup on the stand and put the shawl over the old woman's shoulders, and Mary Jane took the cup up in her left hand. The right hand stayed where it was on the quilt. Hattie watched it a moment. It lay open and easy and did not rise.

"It's stiff," Mary Jane said, before she was asked. "It'll come back with the warm."

It did not come back. She knew it was not coming back. She had known since she woke in the dark and reached for the quilt's edge to pull it up, and her own hand had not answered her — had lain there at the end of her arm like a thing set

down on the bed, warm, hers, and not hers to lift. She had lain still a long time after that. She had thought, listening to the full house breathe around her, all those children asleep down the hall and under it, that she had come to the morning her own mother had come to, and her mother's mother before that, when the body begins the quiet business of setting the keeper down. She was not afraid of it. She had watched it come for everyone she had ever loved, and she had set every one of them into the page herself, and she knew the shape of it from the outside the way a woman who has sat with the dying knows it, and now she was inside the shape and it was the same shape, only quieter. The thing she felt, lying there in the gray, was not fear. It was the old housekeeping pull, the one that had got her out of every bed for seventy years: *there are things to be set in order before the day gets on.*

The first of them was her sons. There were three of them living, and only the one under this roof.

She drank a little of the coffee. It was good and hot and her left hand was steady on the cup. Out the south window the field had gone to stubble and the one tree in the fence-corner had turned its October red, and past it the land ran flat and quiet the way it had run flat and quiet the whole of her life, whatever county they said it was in that year. She looked at it a while. Then she set herself to the day.

"Send word to your brothers," she said. "William and Frank. Send it this morning, while the roads are light. Tell them their mother's took poorly and to come if they can come."

"I'll send word, Mama."

"This morning."

"This morning," he said. "I'll set it going now."

* * *

No doctor came, because none was sent for, and none was sent for because there was nothing a doctor could do that the house could not do as well, and the person under that roof who knew it best was the one in the bed.

Robert Edwin had turned it over, standing in the yard in the early light after Hattie called him up. There was a doctor in town, a long way off over bad October roads, and one could be fetched at a cost the farm could bear if there were a use in the fetching. But he had seen what was in the south room — the hand that would not answer, the corner of the mouth gone soft, the right foot slack under the quilt — and he knew a stroke of paralysis when he saw one, the way everyone raised on a farm in that country knew one when they saw one; it took the old the way the frost took the last of the garden, and there was no medicine against it and never had been. A doctor would ride out and stand in the room and say the word Robert Edwin already had for it, and take his fee, and ride home, and it would change nothing. And his mother, who had sat with more of the dying than any doctor in that county ever had and had made ready more of the dead than she

could have counted, would not have thanked him for spending good money to fetch a stranger to tell the family a thing the family already knew.

So he did not send. He went up instead, and pulled the straight chair from the wall over to the window, and sat at his mother's left side and took her left hand, and the hand closed on his. She had a strong grip in that hand still.

"I'll be here, Mama," he said. "Hattie'll bring you broth at noon. The word's gone for William and Frank."

"Good," she said. Her eyes were steady on his face — the left side of it her own, the right side gone a little slack. She let the eyes close a moment, and her mind went where a mind goes when it is tired and the body has begun to let go of it — back, easily, the way a current takes a boat that has stopped being rowed. She thought of her own mother in the small bed off the kitchen at the cabin, talking low in the dark years and years ago, and she half-listened for that low voice now and could nearly hear it, and she knew the cabin was long gone and her mother longer, and she did not mind that the two times had come up close against each other in her head. They had been coming closer for a while. She let them.

"Where'd you go, Mama?" he said.

"I'm here," she said, which was what her mother used to say. She opened her eyes. "Is the word gone?"

"It's going now, Mama."

* * *

The household kept the kind of Sunday that does not disturb an upper room.

Hattie fed the children and set the older ones to keeping the little ones quiet in the far end of the house, and sent the eldest boy out to do the stock so the yard stayed still. The word for William and Frank had gone off toward the railroad in the morning, the way Robert Edwin had promised — to go on by wire to wherever the two brothers were at their work, a day's travel and more between the sending and any coming. Robert Edwin sat the watch. At noon Hattie carried up a tray with broth and a cup of milk, and Mary Jane took five spoons of the broth from her son's holding of the bowl and would not take the milk, and turned her head to the window and the red in the fence-corner and said nothing through the noon. The boy Lester came to the door of the room and stood in it and did not come in, and Hattie took his hand and brought him away.

Late in the afternoon the old woman's eyes opened on Hattie at the bedside, and held on her.

"Robert sent word to your boys this morning, Mama," Hattie said. "To William, and to Frank."

"That was right of him," Mary Jane said. She did not say that they would come. She had done the arithmetic of roads her whole life, and she knew what a day's travel was, and what the night between might do, and she did not spend herself on the hoping. Her eyes went from Hattie to her son and back, and her left hand worked once at the quilt, and the right hand lay where it had lain all day. "You've

been good to me, daughter," she said to Hattie — she had never had a daughter of her own, and had called this one *daughter* for a dozen years and meant it. "All this while you've heard me on the floor of a morning and never once let on you'd rather not."

"I'd rather, Mama," Hattie said, and could not say more, and put her hand on the old woman's shoulder, and Mary Jane closed her eyes and was quiet.

At dark she was where she had been that morning — the weakness no worse and no better, the speech clear, the breathing even. No doctor rode out to say so; the house said it to itself, in the way a house that has nursed its own knows how a body is doing without being told. Robert Edwin settled it that he would sit up with her, and said as much to Hattie in the front room under the shelf at the south wall — that she should sleep across the hall with the door open, and that if the breathing changed or the speech went he would call her. Outside there were no lights anywhere in the dark but the one lamp burning in the upstairs window, and the fields lay black to the rail and past it, and the road to town ran empty in the cold, because no one was on it and no one was coming.

Before nine he and Hattie moved her to the bed — Hattie at the left and Robert Edwin at the right, the both-hands carry the household had always used for the old at the last — and laid her in the middle of it with the quilt to her shoulders and the brown shawl folded by her side. The right arm did not help in the lifting. The right hand had not opened or closed since the dark. Hattie washed her face with a wet cloth, and Mary Jane took a swallow of water from the cup at her son's hand, and said, with her eyes already closing, "The lamp on the stand."

"Yes, Mama. The lamp'll stand the night."

Hattie took the two youngest to the far room and lay down with them with the door open. Robert Edwin sat the straight chair at the window and held his mother's left hand and did not sleep. The clock struck the eleventh hour, and the twelfth, and the small hours after, and the breathing went on even, and the lamp burned its steady flame on the stand.

* * *

The second one came near three in the morning.

He felt it before he understood it — the breath going from even to uneven while he was down in the gray half-sleep of the chair — and he was on his feet at the bedside before he was awake. The right hand had drawn into a fist it had not made all day. Her left eye was open. The right eye was open and did not find him.

"Hattie, quick," he said at the far door, low, and she came up out of sleep and stood in the doorway in her shift, and the children did not wake.

He sat on the edge of the bed at his mother's right shoulder and took the closed right hand in one of his and laid his other hand on her forehead, and the forehead was cool. The breathing slowed. Hattie sat down in the straight chair at the window where he had kept the day and did not speak. And then his mother's

eyes came back — the left one found his face and held it, the way it had held it every morning and every evening of his life.

"Robert," she said. The word came clear off the left side of her mouth.

"I'm here, Mama," he said.

"The Bible," she said. "At the south wall."

"It's on the shelf, Mama," he said. "The Rorie to the right. The working Bible to the left, in the satchel. It's all where you set it."

"Yes," she said. And then, after a breath: "Yes."

She closed her eyes. The breathing came small and slow. Hattie reached from the chair and laid her hand on the old woman's ankle through the quilt at the foot of the bed, because it was the part of her she could reach, and held it. Robert Edwin held the left hand in both of his. The lamp burned.

The clock struck four below, and he did not hear it, or heard it the way a man in a sickroom hears a thing that is not the breathing he is listening for. She breathed, and he thought, in the quiet of it: *she's at the same place. She's not going.* She breathed again, smaller. The clock's hand went on toward the half. Then, at half past four in the morning, she did not breathe.

He held the hand. He did not let go of it. He waited for the next breath the way a man waits for a thing he has always been able to count on, and it did not come, and he waited longer. The hand in his stayed warm and did not cool and did not move. He said her name once, and again, and waited through the long minutes a man waits before he will let himself know the thing, and then he laid the hand down on the quilt at her left side and stood up.

"She's gone," he said.

"She is, Robert," Hattie said, from the chair, with her hand over her mouth and the silent crying come up in her shoulders.

He put his right hand to his eyes a moment. Then he did the thing there was to do, because a man does the thing there is to do — he drew the quilt up over the still face the way it is done, and turned the lamp down but did not put it out, and went out himself into the yard, because he could not yet be in the house, and stood at the fence in the October cold with his breath white in front of him and the fields black to the rail and no light anywhere but the one lamp in the window above and behind him, and did not weep, because the standing in the cold was a thing he could do and the weeping was not, and a man holds to what he can do.

No one came at the gray of first light to tell him she was at peace, and no one needed to, because he had been the one at the bedside and he knew it already, the way he knew few things in his life so plainly. When the light came up at the east window he went back in and stood over her a while. She had gone easy at the end, in the dark, the way the old and good go, and she had known him — the left eye had found his face and held it, and she had said his name and asked after the Bible, and that was the last of her, and it was a good last, and that was the thing the son kept. He said it once, low, to Hattie, who had come to stand beside him: "She knew me at the last." And Hattie said, "She did," and put her hand on his

arm, and the two of them stood over the old woman in the first light and let it be true.

* * *

He woke the house at first light and took the boy aside.

He had not slept. He had sat the chair again at his mother's side through the close of the night with Hattie beside him, and when the gray came up at the east window he went down and washed his own face and put the kettle on, and told the older children low, and left Hattie to the little ones, and then he brought Lester out to the porch step and sat him down and sat down at his right.

"I've something to tell you, son," he said.

"Yes, papa."

"Your grandmother went in the night. She wasn't in any pain. She went easy, in the dark, the way the old and good go."

The boy looked at his father a while. He did not cry. He put his fingers along the edge of the step the way he did. "She was in the chair at noon yesterday," he said.

"She was."

"She didn't drink the milk."

"She took the broth," Robert Edwin said. "She didn't want the milk."

The boy thought about that. "Is she upstairs," he said.

"She is, for now. Your mama and the women'll see to her this morning, and I'll see to the box. Your uncles are on the road — the word's gone to William and to Frank. We'll bury her tomorrow at Pine Grove."

"Will I be there," the boy said.

"You'll stand at my right hand and your mama's. You can cry if you've a mind to, son. There's no shame in it at a burying. The Searcys have always cried honest at their burying-days."

"I won't cry," the boy said, deciding it, and Robert Edwin let him have the deciding, because a man lets a boy keep what a boy can keep.

No undertaker came out, in the way no doctor had come out — because the family did the thing itself, the way the family had always done the thing itself, and because to send to town for a stranger to wash and dress and box their own dead would have been a thing none of them would have known how to want. What the undertaker's trade did for money in the town, the women and the men of that country did for love and duty on the place, and had done for as long as anyone could remember, and did now.

The women saw to her. Hattie and a neighbor woman or two carried up the warm water and the good dress and the clean cloths, and they washed the old body and dressed it and folded the hands and set the white hair right — the plain necessary office, done in the south room with the light coming in low, by younger hands. And there was a thing in that the family felt and did not say, because it did not need saying: that Mary Jane Rorie Searcy had done this very office, with these

very motions, over more of her own dead than she could have counted — had washed and dressed her grandmother at twenty-four, and her father, and her husband, and a long roll of others across seventy years, had been the one steady pair of hands a family turns to when there is a body to make ready — and that now the hands doing it were not hers. She was the one being made ready. The layer-out was laid out, gently, by the daughter-in-law she had called *daughter* for a dozen years and had taught the work to without once meaning to teach it; and the office came down to the next pair of hands the way the keeping did, and the way everything in that family came down — quietly, in the doing, from the one who could no longer do it to the one who now could.

And Robert Edwin saw to the box. He and his brothers when they came, or he alone before they did, took good seasoned plank down out of the barn — pine, the wood that country buried its people in — and measured it against the length of her, which was not long, and planed it and squared it and joined it, and made a coffin with their own hands. It was a plain box, made the way a farm makes a thing it needs and cannot buy or will not: square, and true, and honest. There was no bought casket and no bought lining and no undertaker's price. There was a homemade coffin, built on the place by the men of the family for the woman who had held the family together the whole of their lives; and if it was plain, it was plain the way she had been plain, and it was made right, because a Searcy made a thing right, and this was the last thing the family would ever make for her.

The brothers came in the night and the next morning, off the roads, the way the old woman had known they might and had not let herself count on. What passed between the three sons in that house is not the book's to set down; they were grown men at their mother's death and they kept their own counsel. It is enough that by the burying there were three of Reuben Rorie's grandsons standing where one had stood the day before.

* * *

The State of Mississippi made one paper of her, and the family had carried the truth of her the whole way without it.

In the days after the burying, the rest of the paper was taken down from Robert Edwin's own mouth, because he was the informant of record and there was no one else the state could get her from — no doctor had attended her and none signed her out. Where the certificate asked what physician had seen her, and what test had confirmed the cause, the answers came back in a plain hand: *No Doctor*, and *No*. The cause the state carried, *paralysis*, was the family's own word for the thing that had taken her, set down on no authority but a son's. He gave his mother's name, and the clerk wrote it out: **Mary Jane Searcy**. The two plain words of her given name, whole and correct, set on a public paper — which was a thing that had not happened once in the whole eighty-seven years the record had been getting her wrong. The Bible had called her *Milbrey or Mity Jane* on the day she was born. The first census had gotten her exactly right, at

seventeen, the one clean true reading it ever gave her — and then never again: the second had shaved her to *twenty-five* when she was twenty-seven; the marriage return had made her *Miss M. J. Rorie*, two initials and a courtesy and no name at all; the counts after had set her down *Mary J.* and *M. J.*, and a later hand, indexing the last of those old sheets, would misread even the initial and make her *H. J.* Across the whole of a life the one thing the record never once managed was her own whole given name. And here it was at the last, in a son's plain answer to a clerk in the worst week of his life — *Mary Jane*, written whole — and her husband's Searcy beside it, F. J. Searcy, dead twelve years that February. He gave the day of her death, the eleventh of October, and the hour, half past four in the morning, and the county, Alcorn.

Even then it did not give her the whole of herself. It gave her *Searcy*, the name she had taken at thirty-four when she stood up in a house on the Rorie land and said her plain yes; her own name, the *Rorie* she was born to, it left to the line below, where the paper asked for her father and the son wrote *Reuben Rorie*, and for her mother, *Mary Hubbard — Polly*, in the family's keeping, though the paper could stand at *Mary*. Her maiden name survived on the certificate of her death only as her father's, one line under her own. And where the paper asked where she had come into the world he gave the answer she had given him all his life, which was the answer the Bible her mother kept had entered beside her name in 1832: *Tennessee*. She had been born on the Tennessee side, she had always said, the year before her people crossed down into Mississippi. He signed the informant's line *R. E. Searcy*, fifty years old. The record came nearer to her at the end than it had ever been, and stopped one name short. But it gave her *Mary Jane*, plainly, for the first time in her life — and she was dead when it got there.

And the paper kept, without meaning to, the record of how the family had done all of it themselves. Where it asked for the undertaker it got *no undertaker*; where it asked what he had furnished it got, in the same plain hand, *homemade coffin*. No doctor had signed the front of it and no undertaker the back. It had been filled from a son's mouth and filed, five days after they had already put her in the ground, by a country registrar who took the family's word because there was no other word to take. The state made one paper of her at the end — and even that paper, read close, is mostly the record of the people who did not wait for the state: who nursed her with no doctor, and washed and dressed her with no undertaker, and built her box and dug her grave and filled it with their own hands, and only afterward rode to town and told the county what they had already done.

The state did not get the whole of her right. At the line for her age it set down *eighty-seven years, ten months, and six days* — the son's spoken figure — and the figure was fourteen days short of the count the household kept, for she had been born on the twenty-first of November of 1832 and had died on the eleventh of October of 1920, which is eighty-seven years, ten months, and twenty days, to the day, by the subtraction her own people had always been able to make in their sleep. The certificate said six. The household said twenty. Why the son gave the

short figure into the state's book, no one can now reach — a man tired past counting, a count made from grief instead of from the page. The day she died did not move in the fourteen days between the two numbers. The state kept its six. The household kept its twenty. The household was right, and had been right since the night her mother wrote her into a Bible carried up out of North Carolina before any of them were born. **The state writes a person down once, at the end. The household had been writing her down, and carrying her, the whole way through.**

* * *

The burying was at Pine Grove in a clear October light.

The family came up the lane to the burying-ground, and a small gathering stood at the grave — the Methodist minister with his Bible open, and a few neighbors from the country round who had heard, some of them the same hands that had helped the day before at the house. The minister read from the twenty-third Psalm and from the eighth chapter of John, and read the committal, and named her over the open ground — *Mary Jane Searcy, daughter of Reuben and Mary Hubbard Rorie, wife of F. J. Searcy, mother of William, Robert Edwin, and Frank Searcy, grandmother to their children, in the eighty-eighth year of her life* — and closed the book.

The men lowered the box on the ropes — his two brothers and two of the neighbors — and drew the ropes up. Then Robert Edwin stepped to the head of the grave and took up the spade himself from the mound of October earth, and lifted a spadeful of the dark earth and held it a moment over the open ground, and thought, standing there, that his mother had stood with a spade at the head of her own mother's grave, and her father's before that, and that the motion came down a family the way the keeping did. He let the earth go. It fell soft on the box. He passed the spade to his brothers, and the two men who had come off the roads took each a spadeful and said nothing and passed it to Hattie, and Hattie took hers and passed it to her children, and the children took theirs down to the least that could hold the handle, and last of all it came to the boy.

Lester took the spade in his two hands. He lifted a small spadeful the careful way his father had, and held it over the ground, and let it fall. He did not cry. He stepped back to his father's side and looked up.

"Papa," he said. "The cross says the dates."

"It does, for now," Robert Edwin said. "The painted cross stays this year. The stone comes at the close of the year, cut clean, with the dates and *At Rest*."

"Eighteen thirty-two," the boy said, reading the painted board. "Nineteen twenty." He said it again, low, to fix it. "I won't forget the dates, papa."

"You won't forget," his father said, and put his hand on the boy's shoulder and left it there, and did not say — because there was no way to say it to a boy of six at a graveside, and no need — that those two dates and the paper the state had made were nearly the whole of what the record would ever set down plainly of a

woman it had spent eighty-seven years calling by half a name, and that the line had come down to this child at the graveside regardless of the record, and would go on past him.

The minister came to Robert Edwin when the men had begun to close the grave, and put his hand on the son's shoulder. "She kept it faithful to the last, Mr. Searcy," he said. "It comes to your hand now. The Bible at the south wall. The page."

"It comes to my hand," Robert Edwin said.

* * *

It came to his hand the next afternoon, when the brothers had gone back to their own places and the house was quiet.

He sat down at the writing-table under the south-wall shelf where his mother had set the two Bibles, and reached up and took the Rorie Bible down, and laid it on the table, and opened it to the deaths.

The last death in the column was his uncle Ezekiah — *killed July 22nd 1864 in Atlanta, Georgia* — in his grandmother Mary Polly's careful round hand, and above it her husband, *Reubin Rorie departed this life* the August of 1862, in the same hand. That was the last thing she ever wrote on the page. Below Ezekiah the book ran on — births, a marriage, a Blake grandchild, a Houston wedding, in her hand and others' — but the deaths stopped there, at the war. There was no line for Mary Polly herself, who had kept the page and died with her own dying entered nowhere. There was no line for his father. The column of the family's deaths had closed in 1864 and stayed closed for fifty-six years, and every dying since — his grandmother's, his father's, and now his mother's — had gone unwritten in it. He was opening the book to set down the first death entered on that page since the war.

The keeping was supposed to pass from a mother's hand into a daughter's, he thought, each keeper writing the one before her, the name handed on down the column. But there had been no daughter in this line to hand it to — his mother had borne three sons and no daughter — and so it did not come down the way it was supposed to. It came to him, a son, the way his mother's own beginning had come down to her: without the entry. His parents' marriage was nowhere in the front of the book. The morning his whole family began had never been written onto the marriages page; his mother had carried her wedding-day only as a date in her head, and the state had not set it down for years, and no hand had ever set it here. The line had come down out of an unwritten morning, across the better part of a century, into his mother's keeping, and was coming now into his — and the book that was supposed to hold it had a silence at its beginning where the founding should have been, and had held the family anyway, the way the family had held the book.

The keeping was never only the entry. He saw that plainly, with the pen not yet in his hand. The entry was the family's way of saying it out loud on paper. But

the thing itself was what his mother had done with her hands and her days for eighty-seven years — the deaths she had witnessed and the births she had watched and the long stretches when there was nothing to write and she had kept the line alive across them anyway, in the cabin and the kept house and her son's front room, in the broth carried up a stair and the word sent down a road and the two Bibles set on a shelf with her own hands. The page was the record of it. It was not the whole of it.

He would write her into it in his own hand, on a day soon, when his hand was steadier than it was that afternoon — the mother's death set down by the son, because there was no daughter to set it down, and no one had set a death in that page since a war that ended before he was born. He closed the Rorie Bible and put it back on the shelf beside Aaron Searcy's working Bible in its old satchel, where his mother had set them both, and where she had named them to him in the last clear words of her life. The keeping had passed to Robert Edwin Searcy, at the writing-table under the south wall, on the afternoon after they buried her.

Out the window the one tree in the fence-corner had gone past its red toward the bare, and the field lay flat and quiet the way it had lain the whole of her life, whatever they had called the county that year. The line she had carried out of an unwritten morning in a Tennessee cabin had come the whole long way down and was in his hands now, and would go from his hands to the boy's, and the boy had the dates by heart already.

She held the line.

Epilogue

Mountain Brook, Alabama — 2026

I went looking for a grave in Alcorn County, Mississippi, and I did not find a stone. What I found was a certificate — one page, filled out by a country registrar in the middle of October 1920 — and it is the strongest single thing I have on her, and it is also, read closely, the record of the people who did not wait for the state.

Mary Jane Searcy died on the eleventh of October 1920, at half past four in the morning, in her son's house in the Third Beat of Alcorn County, eighty-seven years and very nearly eleven months after the family Bible could not decide what to call her and wrote her down as *Milbry or Mity Jane*. The certificate gives her name whole at the top of the page — Mary Jane Searcy — the first time in the whole documentary record that anyone set it down complete and unhurried, and by then everyone who might have said why the Bible hesitated was gone. The cause of death is entered as paralysis, but it is entered by a hand that was not a doctor's, because the medical section carries no physician's signature — *No Doctor*, the page says, and against the line asking what test confirmed the diagnosis, *No*. There was no doctor at the end. There was no undertaker either: where the form asks for one it says, in the plain economy of that country, *no undertaker — homemade coffin*. Her sons made the box. She was buried the next day at Pine Grove, and her son Robert Edwin, fifty years old, told the registrar what he knew, and the registrar filed it on the sixteenth, and that is the whole official account of the end of her.

What the certificate does not say, and what I have spent this book trying to say for it, is what she did with the eighty-seven years between the two entries. She held the line. I mean that as plainly and as literally as the phrase will bear. She held a specific line — an actual boundary around an actual eighty acres of specific dirt, the old Rorie ground her mother had taken up and kept without the help of any court, and that she took up in her turn and kept the same way, through a war that came within thirteen miles of her door, through a widowhood, through the long moving of a world that never once asked her leave to move. The dirt stayed and the world went, and she stood on the one and watched the other go, and she did not let go of the line, and when she died the line was still there and the dirt was still theirs.

I have come to think she is the whole point of the three books, and not because she was the greatest of the people in them. Because she was the plainest, and the plainest is where the thing shows clearest. There is a baron in the first volume and a Revolutionary grant in the second, and they are in here because they lead down to a girl at a loom on a ridge who never held an office or owned a famous name and did, all her life, the one thing the family had always actually done, which is stay — price what the century sends, and stay, and keep the record forward a line at a time. Her grandmother did it in a corner bed. Her mother did it

at a churn and then at a farm the court never touched. She did it for sixty years after the men were gone, and then she handed it, without a word said about it, to a daughter-in-law and a set of grandchildren who would carry it into a century she never saw.

She was watched doing it, the way she had watched her own mother, the way her mother had watched Sarah. That is how this kind of thing goes into a family — not by instruction but by attention, one woman keeping the count while the next one learns it from across the room without knowing she is learning. The census called Mary Jane *mother* on the line where it kept such women, and I have kept her the same way, and the truest thing I know how to say about her is the thing this last volume is named for and the thing I will not spend a second time, having spent it where it belongs, at the close of her own chapter and here at the close of her book:

She held the line.

Epilogue

An afterword to all three volumes.

Mountain Brook, Alabama — 2026

I have just told you, at the end of her own volume, how Mary Jane died — the homemade coffin her sons made, the country churchyard at Pine Grove, the certificate with no doctor's name on it. I will not tell it again. Here at the very end of the three books I want to step back from her, and from all of them, and say what I have come to think the whole of it was.

She is the point, and not because she was the greatest of the people in these pages. Because she was the plainest, and the plainest is where the thing shows clearest. The priory and the baron and the grant and the pension files — the whole documented apparatus of the two volumes that come before her — are here because they arrive at her. None of the great events of the country happened *to* these people. All of them arrived as fragments — a casualty list, a marshal at the door, a letter in a grandfather's particular French — and the household priced each fragment and went on. That is what the family did. In England it looked like a name signed at the bottom of a herald's pedigree to keep a seat. In Virginia it looked like a girl of fifteen writing two words at the foot of a letter to a brother at the war. In Mississippi it looked like a widow keeping a farm the court never touched and a daughter watching her do it and taking it up in her turn. The costume changed every century. The act did not.

And it is one act, carried by one line, and I want to say plainly how the line runs, because it is the thing I did not know when I began and the thing I most wanted to be true. Barbara Tempest Needham came down a gangway at Charleston in February 1714 and married Christopher de Graffenried, and *she came*. Their grandson's daughter Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson sat at a desk in Lunenburg County on a November night in 1779 and wrote *we continue*, and she was the first woman in the line to hold the Bible in her own hands. The keeping went on down the way it always went — sideways, through daughters, into other names: her daughter Sarah Johnson, who married a Hubbard and carried it west into Tennessee; Sarah's daughter Mary Polly Hubbard, who married a millwright named Reuben Rorie and carried a worn black-calf Bible into her son's house in Mississippi, a widow, in her own lap; and Mary Polly's seventh child was the girl at the loom. So the woman who held the line on a Mississippi ridge in 1920 was Barbara's own descendant, six generations down, and the book Mary Polly carried in her lap was the far end of the same keeping that began on a fly-leaf in a formal French no one could read. *She came. We continue. She held the line.* I did not arrange that. I found it. It was already there, waiting in the records for anyone who would read them all the way to the end.

There are silences in these three books that I could not close, and I have left them open on purpose. I do not know for certain where Baker DeGraffenreid died,

or when; there is a date he was last seen and a date his wife signed herself his administratrix, and four years of dark between them, and I did not try to fill it. I do not know the names of the three enslaved people who were held on the Rorie farm, a woman and a man and a girl, because the estate that would have named them was never opened, and the same competence that let a widow keep a farm without the court is the reason their names are lost. Nor do I know what became of the girl Anseline, a fifth part of whom a Tennessee will handed down to a daughter of this line in 1828, a generation before those three were held on the same family's Mississippi ground — her name is in the deed, and her fate is not. I have said all of this in the volumes where these people belong, and I will not tuck it into a footnote here, because they are not anyone's metaphor and I will not use them as one. The record made those silences, or let them fall, and a family history that respects its people has to respect the holes in them too. The blank does not stay blank; somebody always fills it. My whole discipline has been to fill it only with what the page will bear, and to leave it open where the page bears nothing.

So here I am at the other end of it, holding the book — three books — the way each of them held it in turn, and understanding at last that holding it is the whole inheritance. There was never any treasure. There was never any title that outlived the man who held it. There was a Bible on a parlor desk and then a box in a closet and then a chart somebody started and did not finish, and there was always, in every generation, one person who did not throw it away. I am that person now. This is what I did with it.

To whoever breaks this open a long way off and a long time from now, and reads down the fly-leaf to the place where the entries stop and finds their own name is not yet written there: the keeping is yours now. Set the known thing down. Do not invent to fill the silence. Hold the line where you stand on it.

We continue.

— DLS

A Note on Sources

This history is built almost entirely out of two kinds of record: what the family kept, and what the offices around them kept without meaning to. The first kind is the smaller and the dearer — a Bible carried out of Switzerland in 1710 with its fly-leaf filling up, one keeper at a time, in a formal French no one in the line could read within three generations; the collateral family Bibles that caught the births and deaths the principal one missed; the workbooks, charts, and half-remembered stories that carried the keeping on after the Bible itself was gone. The second kind is the public record that four centuries of governments generated around ordinary people without intending to preserve them for me — a herald's visitation pedigree signed in a Hertfordshire field in 1572, a will proved in Chowan County, a land grant entered in a Guilford County deed book, an administratrix's appointment in a Lunenburg order book, a Mississippi slave schedule, a census marshal's page, a certificate of death filled out by a country registrar in 1920.

One rule governs all three volumes, and it is the rule the family itself seems to have held: set the known thing down, in the place kept for it, and do not invent to fill the silence. Every date in these pages that could be checked against a calendar has been checked. Where two records disagree — and they disagree about the day the last of these women died, and the year one man died, and a great deal in between — both readings stand on the page rather than the tidier one alone. Where the record simply stops, as it stops on where one man died and when, the silence is left open, because closing it would mean writing fiction and calling it history. And where the record was not merely empty but *made* empty — where a Mississippi probate book that should name three enslaved people names no one, because the estate that would have listed them was never opened — the book says so as plainly as it can, because a silence that was made is a different thing from a silence that merely fell.

What follows is the consolidated working bibliography for all three volumes, organized by volume and, within each, by the kind of source, so that a reader who wants to know what a given fact rests on can find the instrument and weigh it. Each volume's list follows the tier convention used in that volume's research; the conventions differ in their letters but agree in their spirit — a primary document of the period outranks a secondary work about it, which outranks a family tradition, and every entry says which it is. The open questions are gathered at the end of each volume's list, in the numbered form they carried through the years of the work, so that whoever takes this line up next will know exactly where the digging was left off.

— DLS

Working Bibliography

The consolidated working bibliography for all three volumes of I Am Coming. It is organized by volume and then by source category, not by chapter. Each source is listed once; where an entry carries bracketed chapter references, they show where in that volume the source is used. Tier marks are given per volume — broadly, a primary document (period, contemporary) outranks a secondary work, a standard reference, or a family tradition, and each entry names which it is. This remains a living working file: superseded sources are marked, not deleted, to preserve the trail.

Volume I — England, 1490 to 1714

Tier note: entries are grouped by archival and published category; the reader-facing list below is drawn from the volume's master working bibliography.

I. Primary archival sources

Manuscripts at the Bodleian Library, University of Oxford

- MS Rawlinson D. 775 (pay-book for 1532-3, 222 ff.) — Greenwich, Windsor, Woking, Dover, Westminster, Tower of London; includes works at Westminster Hall for the coronation of Anne Boleyn (ff. 173-201).
- MS Rawlinson D. 776 (pay-book for 1533-4, 247 ff.) — Greenwich, Eltham, Tower, Bridewell, Richmond, Windsor, Oking, Moore, Chobham, Ampthill, Bishop's Hatfield; fly-leaves contain 1655 private accounts of George Nedham of Wymondley.
- MS Rawlinson D. 777 (pay-book for 1534-5, 220 ff.) — Includes the November 1534 refit of the King's barge 'The Lyon' for the French Admiral's visit.
- MS Rawlinson D. 778 (pay-book for 1535-6, 113 ff.) — Tower of London works, Jewel House rebuilding; fly-leaves contain 1643-44 tax memoranda by George Nedham.
- MS Rawlinson D. 779 (pay-book for 1535-7 and 1539, 85 ff.) — Canterbury October- December 1539; consolidated annual summaries across sixteen royal sites totaling £2,636 17s 10½d.
- MS Rawlinson D. 780 (pay-book for 1536-7 and 1540, 261 ff.) — Greenwich, Windsor, Moor, Grafton, Chobham, Oking, Hunsdon, Ditton, Parlaunt, Ampthill, Tower.
- MS Rawlinson D. 781 (pay-book for 1541-2, 217 ff.) — Greenwich, Eltham, Moor, Hunsdon, Oking, Windsor, Chobham, East Horsley, Canterbury St Augustine's (with the steeple-fall cleanup), Westenhanger, Dover, Enfield, Leeds Castle.
- MS Rawlinson D. 782 (pay-book for 1541-2, 69 ff.) — Demolition of Barking Abbey church; fly-leaves contain 1668 accounts of George Nedham at Wilshamstead. Fol. 003v digitized at digital.bodleian.ox.ac.uk/objects/63db51be-3e05-4574-ac1d-a2dc63d1c741.
- MS Rawlinson D. 783 (pay-book for 1541-2, 220 ff.) — Manor of Dartford; the king's command 'speedily to be done for his grace.'
- MS Rawlinson D. 784 (pay-book for 1543-4, 207 ff.) — Manor of Dartford continued; written in a larger hand, with very black ink. Runs to within four months of James's death.
- MS Rawlinson D. 785 (pay-book for 1541-2, 118 ff.) — Conversion of Rochester from college to manor.
- MS Rawlinson B. 340 — Duplicate of part of one of the preceding pay-books.

- MS Don. c. 206 (pay-book for 1535–1540) — Acquired by the Bodleian in 2008 at Christie’s sale of the Foljambe Collection, lot 169. Includes the Enfield 1540 accounts transcribed by the Enfield Archaeological Society. Manuscripts at The National Archives, Kew
- E 101/504/2 (pay-book for 1543–4) — Final particular book of James Nedeham, submitted by his executors after his death in justification of his expenditure.
- E 40/5944 (1532 bond to Cromwell) — Exchequer Treasury of Receipt, Ancient Deeds Series A. Bond by James Nedeham, the king’s master carpenter, to Thomas Crumwell, master or treasurer of the king’s jewels, for £200. Dated 11 June 1532.
- LR 14/468 (1544 Bygrave indenture) — Office of the Auditors of Land Revenue, Ancient Deeds Series E. Indenture of sale of messuages and land in Bygrave next Baldock from Thomas Myldemaye to James Nedeham of Wymondley, esq., and John Nedeham, gentleman. Regnal year 35 Hen. VIII (April 1544 to April 1545).
- C 2/Eliz/N5/46 (Nedeham v Clarke) — Court of Chancery, Six Clerks Office, Pleadings, Series I, Elizabeth I to Charles I. John Nedeham vs William Clarke; bill of complaint contains sworn statement that Wymondley was granted by King Henry VIII to James Nedeham.
- SP 5/4/196 (1542–44 lead account) — Exchequer King’s Remembrancer, Miscellanea relating to the Dissolution. London and Home Counties Monasteries: account of lead by James Nedeham, clerk of the King’s Works, giving destinations of the lead. Regnal years 34–35 Hen. VIII.
- Other Nedeham records in SP 1 (Henry VIII State Papers) — 1534 letter from Nedeham to Cromwell about Tower of London works — specific reference to be confirmed by TNA Discovery search; CT-077 in project work plan.
- A.O. 3/1276 — Odd pages of accounts for James Nedeham’s last two years 1542–44, also at TNA per the 1962 JSA article footnote 6.
- PCC PROB 11/276/546 (Eustace Nedham’s will, 29 March 1657, probated 21 May 1658) — Will of Eustace Nedham, Esq., of Little Wymondley. Strikingly brief; everything to son George; one witness who marks rather than signs. The brevity reflects inter vivos estate settlement practice. Anchor of §3.7 and §3.8.
- PCC PROB 11/330/451 (George Nedham Senior’s will, 4 March 1666/67, probated 10 August 1679) — Will of George Nedham (Senior), Esq., of Little Wymondley. Names wife Barbara; four sons George Jr., Fitch, James, Maurice; three daughters Barbara the eldest, Anne, Elizabeth; brother Luke. Documents Maurice’s £500 portion as the fourth son. The central documentary instrument of §4.3 and the foundation of Maurice’s adult life. Probate date establishes George Senior’s death in summer 1679.
- C 10/214/65 (Nedham v Wingate, 1684) — Court of Chancery, Six Clerks Office, Pleadings, Series II. Maurice Nedham, Esq., and his wife Lettice, joint

plaintiffs against Sir Francis Wingate, knight, of Harlington, Bedfordshire. Property dispute over land in St Martin in the Fields, Middlesex, part of Lettice's marriage settlement. Documents that Maurice had a wife named Lettice and that a Wingate held land out of her settlement; it does NOT document her maiden name. Retracted as evidence of a Wingate marriage, May 2026. Primary tier; confirms the 1925 History of the de Graffenried Family's Wingate maternal-surname attribution for Barbara Tempest Needham. Anchor of §4.4.

Manuscripts at other repositories

- Somerset Heritage Centre: DD/2628 (1537 final concord, Cattall Grove) — Walker-Heneage and Button family papers. Conveyance by Francis Goodyere of Hadley to James Nedeham of the wood called Cattall Grove and adjoining land in South Mimms. Dated 19 December 29 Hen. VIII.
- University of Nottingham Library: MSS Ne/O/1-3 — Three further pay-books of James Nedeham, 1535-1542. Inheritance line through the Wightwick-Foljambe family possibly. Catalog details pending.
- Hertfordshire Archives and Local Studies: HRO 32,349 (1731 estate map of Wymondley) — Cited by Doggett 1997; shows the cruciform footprint of the priory church still legible in the early eighteenth century. Family records and parish registers (Searcy line)
- Parish registers of Little Wymondley, Hertfordshire — Baptisms, marriages, burials of the Nedham/Needham family 1538-1725. Specific entries pending HALS verification.
- Parish registers of Great Wymondley, Hertfordshire — Baptisms, marriages, burials. The 16 August 1685 baptism of Barbary Nedham (Barbara Tempest Needham) is in this register, not the Little Wymondley register — important parish-of-record distinction. Specific entries pending HALS verification beyond the indexed Findmypast transcripts.
- Parish registers of Wymondley Parva (the chapel-of-ease at Little Wymondley) for the 1610s-1620s — Includes the 27 June 1626 burial of George Nedham, Esq. (George I), with John Marshall, minister, preserved verbatim by Urwick. Includes the 16 August 1618 baptism of George Nedham son of Eustace Nedham.
- Parish registers of Welwyn, Hertfordshire — Burials and baptisms of the John Nedham of Welwyn cadet line; the Eustace household before his transfer to Wymondley. Specific entries pending HALS verification.
- Parish registers of Offley, Hertfordshire — Anne Norton (Eustace's first wife) and her family; specific entries pending.
- Parish registers of Harlington and Lockleys (Welwyn), Bedfordshire and Hertfordshire — Wingate family entries across multiple generations. Specific entries on Frances Wingate pending. Letisia Bowyer's baptism is NOT in Hertfordshire — see the out-of-county search (CT-103).

- Will of George Nedham, 1666/67 — Lord of Wymondley Priory at the Restoration; held by family or in HALS, specific reference pending.
- The Wymondley Parva chancel-burial register — Tradition documented by Urwick v9c for George I (1626), George II (1669), and by extension the multi-generation chancel-burial right exercised by the lay impropiator. Specific surviving entries pending HALS verification. Indexed parish-register transcripts
- Findmypast England Births & Baptisms 1538-1975 + Hertfordshire Baptisms record sets — Online indexed access to the digitised parish registers. The 16 August 1685 baptism of “Barbary Nedham” at Great Wymondley is the documentary anchor of §4.6. The 16 August 1618 baptism of George Nedham son of Eustace Nedham at Little Wymondley is the documentary anchor of §3.2.
- Findmypast Kent Marriages and Banns — Online indexed transcript. The 25 September 1581 marriage at St George’s, Beckenham, of George Nedham, Esq., to Margaret Stile (daughter of Edmund Stile of Langley in Beckenham) is the documentary anchor of §2.5.

II. Published primary sources

- Letters and Papers, Foreign and Domestic, of the Reign of Henry VIII, vol. XIII (HMSO) — Calendar of state papers. Item 887(13) records the 12 April 1538 grant of Wymondley Priory to James Nedeham.
- The Visitation of Hertfordshire 1572 (Harleian Society, 1886) — Published transcript of the 1572 Herald’s Visitation. Signed Nedham pedigree at Wymondley by John Nedham, James’s son. Standard reference for the family’s Tudor-era heraldic confirmation.
- The Visitation of Hertfordshire 1634 (Harleian Society) — Confirms descent.
- Metcalfe, Walter C. (ed.). The Visitation of Hertfordshire, 1572 & 1634. Harleian Society, vol. XXII (London, 1886). — The bound edition combining both visitations. The single working reference for the 1572 and 1634 Wymondley Needham pedigrees in this project. Available in the Harleian Society’s open-access digitised series.
- Chauncy, Sir Henry. The Historical Antiquities of Hertfordshire. London, 1700. — Standard county antiquarian history. Page 362 preserves the 1605 monument inscription to James and John Nedham in the chancel of Little Wymondley parish church and is the documentary anchor of Chapter 1 §1.7’s closing monument paragraph, of Chapter 3 §3.1’s discussion of George I, and of multiple atmospheric and contextual references across Chapters 3 and 4.

III. Scholarly secondary sources

- Colvin, H. M., et al., The History of the King’s Works, vols. III and IV (HMSO, 1975 and 1982) — The standard scholarly reference on the English royal building program. Volume III covers administrative history and the

Surveyor's office; Volume IV covers project-by-project building history. UAB Sterne Library, classmark NA961.C64.

- Doggett, Nicholas David Bartholomew. *Patterns of Re-Use: The Transformation of Former Monastic Buildings in Post-Dissolution Hertfordshire, 1540-1600* (Ph.D. thesis, University of Southampton, Department of History, April 1997) — Sustained scholarly architectural analysis of Wymondley Priory as a major case study. Available through the British Library EThOS digital repository.
- Gomme, Andor. "History, Chronicle or Research File? Reflections on 'The History of the King's Works.'" *Architectural History*, vol. 29 (1986), pp. 197-203. — Critical review of Colvin. Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/1568508>. Establishes Colvin as a research file rather than a continuous history.
- [Anonymous, possibly H. M. Colvin]. "The 'Particular Books' of James Nedeham, Surveyor of the King's Works." *Journal of the Society of Archivists*, vol. 2 no. 6 (1962), pp. 267-270. — Foundational article cataloguing the surviving Nedeham working ledgers. Establishes the eleven-volume Rawlinson run, the Wightwick-Browne descent of the manuscripts, and the 1733 sale of Wymondley to Vanderplank.
- Macray, W. D. (ed.). *Catalogi codicum manuscriptorum Bibliothecae Bodleianae, Pars V: Codices Rawlinsoniani D.* (Clarendon Press, Oxford, 1862- 1900). — Bodleian's published volume-by-volume description of the Rawlinson manuscripts. Cols. 503-508 give the Nedeham pay-book inventory.
- Oxford Dictionary of National Biography, entry on James Nedeham (by H. M. Colvin) — Standard biographical reference.
- Oxford Dictionary of National Biography, entry on Robert Cooke, Clarenceux King of Arms — Standard biographical reference for the herald who conducted the 1572 visitation and made the 1586 grant of arms to the Wymondley Nedhams. Used in §2.0 and §2.4.
- Victoria County History of Hertfordshire, vol. III — Foundation history and medieval ownership of Wymondley Priory.
- Victoria County History of Hertfordshire, vol. IV — Parish-by-parish histories including Wymondley Magna and Wymondley Parva. Standard reference for the parish ecclesiastical history under George I, Eustace, and George Senior. Used for the 1614 lay-impropriator visitation evidence and the Wymondley Magna 1633 handmill presentment.
- Shaw, S. *The history and antiquities of Staffordshire*, vol. II (1801) — Cited in the 1962 JSA article; relevant for Thomas Browne, Garter King of Arms, husband of Martha Needham.
- Clutterbuck, R. *The history and antiquities of the county of Hertford*, vol. II (1821) — Cited in the 1962 JSA article for the Wightwick-Browne descent tree. Heraldry and gentry studies

- Wagner, Anthony. *Heralds and Heraldry in the Middle Ages*. Oxford, 1956. — Standard reference on the heralds as an institution; used for §2.0 and §2.4 in setting up the College of Arms, the Clarenceux office, and the visitation procedure.
- Wagner, Anthony. *English Genealogy*. Oxford, 1972. — Companion standard work on the genealogical apparatus of the English gentry. Used throughout Chapter 2.
- Heal, Felicity, and Clive Holmes. *The Gentry in England and Wales, 1500–1700*. Macmillan, 1994. — Best one-volume study of the gentry class as social category. Used across Chapters 2, 3, and 4 for the working framework of gentry life, marriage conventions, and inheritance practice.
- Stone, Lawrence. *The Crisis of the Aristocracy, 1558–1641*. Oxford, 1965. — Classic study of the higher nobility and gentry; Stone’s framework has been criticized but his sense of the texture of early-modern gentry life is unsurpassed.
- Stone, Lawrence. *Family and Fortune*. Oxford, 1973. — Companion study; standard reference for gentry estate management practice.
- Wright, Pam. “A change in direction: the ramifications of a female household, 1558–1603” in David Starkey, ed., *The English Court*. Longman, 1987. — Standard reference for the Gentleman Pensioners’ institution and what Sir John of Lichborough actually did as a Pensioner. Used in §2.6.
- Rowse, A. L. *The England of Elizabeth*. Macmillan, 1950. — Older but textually rich account of the late-Elizabethan world. Used for atmospheric color in §2.6 (Sir John at Court) and §2.8 (the Elizabethan world the children of John Nedham grew up in).
- Cressy, David. *Birth, Marriage, and Death: Ritual, Religion, and the Life Cycle in Tudor and Stuart England*. Oxford, 1997. — Standard reference for the texture of the everyday rituals — baptism, marriage, churching, burial — that mark every generation of the family. Used across Chapters 2, 3, and 4.
- Wrightson, Keith. *English Society, 1580–1680*. Hutchinson, 1982. — Best one-volume social history of the central period. Used across Chapters 3 and 4. Civil War and Interregnum studies
- Russell, Conrad. *The Fall of the British Monarchies, 1637–1642*. Oxford, 1991. — Standard high-political account of how the Long Parliament’s England came apart. Used for §3.4’s framing of the war’s arrival.
- Holmes, Clive. *The Eastern Association in the English Civil War*. Cambridge, 1974. — Standard work on Hertfordshire’s political alignment during the war years. Used for §3.4 and §3.6.
- Everitt, Alan. *Change in the Provinces: the Seventeenth Century*. 1969. — For how the war was experienced by county gentry not at the center of events — directly relevant to the Wymondley Nedhams’ non-engaging posture. Used for §3.4 and §3.6.

- Morrill, John. *The Revolt of the Provinces*. Allen & Unwin, 1976. — Classic treatment of the war as experienced from outside London. Used for §3.4.
- Underdown, David. *Revel, Riot, and Rebellion*. Oxford, 1985. — For the texture of Civil War society at the parish level. Used for §3.6 and §3.7.
- Purkiss, Diane. *The English Civil War: A People's History*. HarperCollins, 2006. — Modern and readable; useful for popular-experience detail. Used as background for §3.4 and §3.6. Hertfordshire Nonconformity and parish religious life
- Urwick, William. *Nonconformity in Herts. Being Lectures upon the Nonconforming Worthies of St. Albans, and Memorials of Puritanism and Nonconformity in all the Parishes of the County of Hertford*. London, 1884. — Foundational reference for the parish-by-parish religious history of Hertfordshire from the Reformation through the late seventeenth century. Used across Chapter 3 (the Triers panel, the 1655 Piedmont Collection, the surrounding Dissenter ferment) and Chapter 4 (the post-Restoration ejected ministry and the Dissenter congregations around Wymondley). Accessed via the project's v9 working notes (Urwick a-d, e-f, g-i addenda). Restoration and late-Stuart studies
- Harris, Tim. *Restoration: Charles II and his Kingdoms, 1660–1685*. Allen Lane, 2005. — Standard modern political narrative of the post-1660 period. Used across §4.1 and §4.5 (Popish Plot, Exclusion Crisis).
- Harris, Tim. *Revolution: The Great Crisis of the British Monarchy, 1685–1720*. Allen Lane, 2006. — Companion volume; standard reference for the late-Stuart and early-Hanoverian transition that frames Chapter 4's closing decades and Chapters 5–6's setting.
- Picard, Liza. *Restoration London*. Weidenfeld, 1997. — For the texture of city life in the priory family's London visits. Used in §4.1 and §4.2.
- Moote, A. Lloyd, and Dorothy Moote. *The Great Plague*. Johns Hopkins, 2004. — Standard reference for the 1665 plague. Used in §4.2.
- Tinniswood, Adrian. *By Permission of Heaven: the Story of the Great Fire of London*. Cape, 2003. — Standard reference for the 1666 Fire. Used in §4.2.
- Pepys, Samuel. *Diary* (Latham & Matthews edition, 11 vols.) — For the day-to-day texture of 1660s London, particularly the first week of September 1666 entries on the Fire. Referenced in §4.2 as the period's most vivid contemporary first-person account. Devotional and literary references
- [Anonymous]. *The Whole Duty of Man*. London, 1658 (and many subsequent editions through 1700). — Standard Anglican gentry devotional reading of the second half of the seventeenth century; the working book that a young woman of Barbara's class would have read at fifteen. Used in §4.8 as the open book on Barbara's writing-desk in October 1700.
- Milton, John. *Paradise Lost*. 1667 (10-book first edition), 1674 (12-book expanded edition). — Standard reading of advanced Anglican gentry libraries

by 1700. Referenced in §4.9 as part of Barbara’s reading practice across her years at the priory.

- The Book of Common Prayer (1662 edition). — The post-Restoration Anglican liturgy in use across the Wymondley parish life from 1662 forward. Referenced across Chapter 4 and as the working office for the baptismal service in §4.6.

IV. Reference works and aggregators

- Wikipedia, “James Nedeham” — Drawing on Colvin and other secondary sources. Aggregator; not citable in publication but useful for cross-reference.
- Ridgway, Claire. Tudor Society article on James Nedeham — Accessible secondary summary.
- Bodleian Library Archives catalog entry for MS Don. c. 206 — archives.bodleian.ox.ac.uk/repositories/2/resources/8678. Cleanest biographical statement of James’s origins (London carpenter’s son, Derbyshire grandfather).
- Enfield Archaeological Society transcription of MS Don. c. 206 ff. 234–235v — enfarchsoc.org/elsyng/james-nedam-expenses-msd206/. Modernized English transcript of the June–September 1540 Enfield expenses.
- The National Archives name-authority record for James Nedeham — discovery.nationalarchives.gov.uk/details/c/F60029. Lists the principal manuscript repositories.
- Burke’s General Armory — Heraldic reference for the Derbyshire-Hertfordshire branch reconciliation.

V. Present-day sources (buildings, venues, websites)

- The Priory Barn, Little Wymondley — thepriory.net. Priory Lane, Little Wymondley SG4 7HD, phone 01438 748 647, email info@thepriory.net. Current operators Michelle and Bill Bacon (took over January 2026). Source for current building condition and venue description of the 1541 tithe barn.
- Historic Royal Palaces — hrp.org.uk. Manages Hampton Court Palace, Tower of London, Kensington Palace, Banqueting House Whitehall. Source for visitor information and image licensing for Nedeham-era buildings.
- Digital Bodleian — digital.bodleian.ox.ac.uk. Open-access digital images of selected Bodleian manuscripts; includes MS Rawlinson D. 782 fol. 003v.
- St George’s Church, Beckenham — Standard parish-church visitor resources for the 1880s Gothic Revival reconstruction of the church where George Nedham married Margaret Stile in September 1581. Original Norman-foundation building substantially replaced; only fragments incorporated into the present building.
- Hertfordshire Archives and Local Studies (HALS), County Hall, Hertford — The county archive repository for the parish registers of Little Wymondley,

Great Wymondley, Wymondley Parva, Offley, Welwyn, Graveley, Hitchin, and the surrounding parishes; the county sequestration committee records (1643–1660); the Hertfordshire Sessions records (Popish Plot indictments, Exclusion Crisis loyal addresses, etc.). The single most consequential institutional research target for the project’s continuing primary-source verification across Chapters 2, 3, and 4.

- Findmypast Hertfordshire Baptisms record set — Online indexed transcripts of the digitised Hertfordshire parish-register baptisms. The 16 August 1618 baptism of George Nedham son of Eustace Nedham at Little Wymondley is in this record set.

VI. de Graffenried family sources (forthcoming chapters)

- DeGraffenreid Association Collection, ECU Joyner Library Special Collections, MS 796 — Box 1 Folder a Item 1: 1735 Baron Christoph V letter (typescript). Folder h: 1709 Protestant affidavit (photocopy). Box 2 Folder b: Christopher VI family group sheet. Inquiry pending.
- DeGraffenreid Family Papers, UNC Wilson Library Southern Historical Collection, Collection #01692 (1735–1958) — Inquiry pending.
- Pitt-Dixon House report, Colonial Williamsburg Foundation, Rockefeller Library — Lot 47, Williamsburg. Inquiry pending. May contain references to the Christopher VI family Bible.
- Faust, A. B. *Annals of the Swiss-Bernese Colony at New Bern, N.C.* (1913, 1914) — Project file has extract memos.
- Faust, A. B. *Guide to the Manuscript Materials Bearing on American History in Switzerland* (1916) — Project file has extract memo.
- ECU DeGraffenried Association Collection finding aid — Project file has extract memo.
- William and Mary Quarterly articles on the DeGraffenreidt/Woodson and Wymondley topics — Project file has extract memos.
- de Graffenried, Thomas P. *History of the de Graffenried Family*. Privately published, 1925, pp. 147–149. — Published family-history reference that identifies Barbara Tempest Needham as the daughter of Maurice and Lettice Wingate Nedham of Wymondley. The Wingate maternal-surname attribution from this 1925 source is corroborated at primary tier by TNA C 10/214/65 (1684). Referenced in §4.4 and forward to Chapter 5 v1.2. * VII. Project working documents This section is new in v2. It catalogues the internal working documents the project has produced across its research apparatus. These are not publication sources but are the working infrastructure on which the chapters’ research base sits.
- Searcy Family Ancestral Workbook v7.11 — The master genealogical workbook. Excel format. 53 formulas, validated, zero errors. The working data layer for every documented and probable ancestor across the Wymondley line and forward.

- Searcy Master Report v2.7.1, Section 3 — Wymondley Supplement. — Verbatim transcriptions of the 1572 and 1634 Visitation pages with editorial gloss. The single working reference for the Heralds' Visitation primary-source content.
- CT-017 Addendum v2.7 (sessions 1 and 2 memos) — Working reconciliation of the Wymondley Needham descent including the resolution of the Sir Arthur of Wymondsley attribution from the 1925 History of the de Graffenried Family *into its real-person components*.
- CT-017 Needham/Nedham/Wingate Reconciliation Memo — Surname-and-spelling reconciliation work across the Tudor and Stuart documentary base.
- Searcy New Sources Synthesis Memo, Pass One — People and Lineage — Substantial new material on John Nedham (Chapter 2's protagonist), George I, Eustace, George II, the 1605 monument, the 1614 lay-impropriator visitation, the 1669 chancel-burial; Maurice and Letisia Bowyer.
- Searcy New Sources Synthesis Memo, Pass Two — Atmospheric and Contextual — Atmospheric and contextual material for the period 1572–1700, including the 1654 Hertfordshire Triers panel, the 1655 Piedmont Collection, the architectural and sensory texture of the priory house from clunch wall to box-tree hedge to Spanish chestnut, the four bells rehung at Graveley.
- Searcy Pre-Migration Historical Companion v1 draft — Already-drafted outline material for Chapters 2, 3, and 4, with Appendix A (the Eustace composite at Michaelmas 1640, 1,500 words) absorbed into Chapter 3 §3.3 and Appendix B (Sources for the Color) supplying the chapter-by-chapter secondary-source recommendations that this v2 bibliography incorporates.
- Searcy Wymondley Lineage Chart — The genealogical spine of the senior line from James the Surveyor through George III, with tier-grades (DOCUMENTED, PROBABLE) for each generation.
- Wymondley Lineage Open Items Memo — The open documentation items tracked across the lineage chart, including Maurice's death date (the project's principal gap as of v2.7) and the surname research for Barbara wife of George Senior — the latter closed in May 2026 to Fitch, on TNA C 7/503/16.
- Chauncy Working Notes (Vol3, Vol4, v7 Urwick, v8 Hug, v9a-c Urwick, v10 Humphrey/Nedeham addenda) — Chauncy primary-source mining for the Wymondley parish, with successive addenda integrating Urwick's *Nonconformity in Herts. (v9)*, *Hug's PhD thesis on Hertfordshire Nonconformity (v8)*, *the Pearson/Strype/Parker Society v10 work*, and *the Vol3 and Vol4 working passes*.
- Color Memo Place and Life and addenda (Vols 3-4; Urwick a-d, e-f, g-i; v10 Humphrey/Nedeham) — The atmospheric/sensory color memo built across multiple project sessions; the working sensory base for the priory house's physical texture across all six chapters of Book One.

- Bagshawe Collection Documents Ordered May 12, 2026 (memo) — The most recently ordered primary sources from the Derbyshire Record Office's Bagshawe Collection, pending arrival in the next 2–4 weeks. Relevant primarily for the Derbyshire-origin questions for James the Surveyor but with knock-on implications for the family's pre-Wymondley standing.
- I_Am_Coming_Chapter1_Sources_Memo_v2.docx — Chapter 1 audit-trail file.
- I_Am_Coming_Chapter2_Sources_Memo_v1.docx — Chapter 2 audit-trail file.
- I_Am_Coming_Chapter3_Sources_Memo_v1.docx — Chapter 3 audit-trail file.
- I_Am_Coming_Chapter4_Sources_Memo_v1.docx — Chapter 4 audit-trail file.
- I_Am_Coming_Chapter5_Sources_Memo_v1_2.docx — Chapter 5 audit-trail file (Barbara's voice, courtship, the letter).
- (Forthcoming) I_Am_Coming_Chapter6_Sources_Memo.docx — Chapter 6 audit-trail file (Christopher, the Atlantic, the dock at Charleston). *

Volume II — Virginia and Carolina, 1742 to 1794

This document is the consolidated working bibliography for I Am Coming, Volume II. It is organized by source category, not by chapter. Each entry names the source, says briefly what it establishes, and flags the chapters and sections that rest on it. Where a fact stands on more than one instrument the entry says so; where it stands on a single soft estimate the entry says that too. The volume's discipline is to name what the record gives, name what it withholds, and keep the open questions open rather than close them with invention. The open questions are gathered at the end, under section XIV, in the same numbered form they carried through drafting.

Tier marks follow the volume's spine: (D) documented on a primary instrument; (P) probable, resting on a secondary instrument or a sound inference; (S) secondary or contextual. A fact with no mark is documented or is a working commitment named as such in the chapter.

I. Family Bibles and fly-leaf records

- **The Christopher VI de Graffenried family Bible (D).** The object the volume is structurally about: a small leather-bound Bible, roughly eight inches by five, bound in dark calf. Given to Christopher VI by his father the Baron at Worb in 1710 with the fly-leaf clean; carried in the sea-chest from Worb through Bern, London, and Charleston. The first entry on the page is Christopher VI's own hand at his marriage in Charleston, 22 February 1714 — the formal French entry the Baron had instructed him to write, with a private English entry below it. The keeping passed to his son Anton Tscharner at Christopher VI's death (October 1742 by the volume's commitment; see XIV, ODQ-V2-06), and to Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson at Tscharner's death in February 1794. Carries the family's hands across eighty years. [Bridge; Ch 1 §1.1, §1.3, §1.5; Ch 4 §4.3, §4.4; Ch 5 §5.7; Ch 6 §6.6, §6.7; Interlude — The Keeping Forward; Epilogue]
- **The Bernberg Bible (the Baron's, at Worb) (S).** Christopher V's Bible, the origin of the family's keeping convention — the formal-French-entry-on-the-fly-leaf practice, traceable to a 1697 death entry. The convention crossed to the Christopher VI Bible; the object did not. The Bernberg Bible stayed at Worb with the Baron. Named to keep the two books distinct in the prose. [Ch 1 §1.3]
- **The Chadwell Bible record (P).** A collateral family Bible carrying entries that cross the volume at two points: Ursula DeGraffenreid Johnson's birth, ~13 December 1787 (page 93), used to date Chapter 6 §6.2's household; and the alternate death date for the heroine — 1 January 1823 — set against the Reynolds family's 7 January 1823. The two-attestation question on the death date is held open. [Ch 6 §6.2; Interlude — The Keeping Forward; Epilogue]

- **The Reynolds family canonical record (P).** The maintained genealogical line for the family, carrying the canonical vital dates used throughout: the heroine's birth (3 September 1764) and the Reynolds death date (7 January 1823). The alternate readings are noted at each point of conflict rather than resolved. [throughout; Epilogue]

II. Wills, probate, and estate records

- **Will of Col. Henry Baker II, Chowan County, North Carolina, probated 1739 (D).** Names his daughter Mary — the elder Mary Baker, who married Tscharner DeGraffenreid in 1742. One of the two instruments fixing the heroine's paternal-grandmother's parentage. [Ch 1 §1.2]
- **Will of Edmund Chancey, Chowan County, North Carolina, 1753 (D).** Names the grandchild "Mary DeGrafinred" among the children of Ruth — the maternal-grandfather bridge the 1925 printed *History* lacked. With the Henry Baker will, this closes the elder Mary Baker's parentage on both sides. [Ch 1 §1.2]
- **Tscharner DeGraffenreid's will and inventory, Lunenburg County, Virginia, February-March 1794 (D).** The keeper's estate at death. Anchors the chapter's closing span and the household at Lunenburg in his last winter. [Ch 6 §6.6, §6.7]
- **Christopher VI de Graffenried — death and probate, Prince George County, Virginia (S; open).** The 1925 *History* places him settled permanently in Prince George County and gives a soft "ca. 1750"; the volume commits to an October 1742 death for the Bible's accession. No hard probate date is in hand. A Prince George County will/probate or land-record search would settle it. (See XIV, ODQ-V2-06.) [Ch 1 §1.5]
- **Baker DeGraffenreid — absence of probate (D, by absence).** No estate record survives because his death was never registered; his widow Sarah Vass operated as administratrix of an estate whose body was never recovered. The absence is itself part of the record. [Ch 2; Ch 3; Epilogue]

III. Land, deed, and grant records

- **Governor Caswell's grant to Sarah Vass DeGraffenreid, 13 November 1779 — 400 acres, Guilford County, North Carolina (D).** Guilford County Deed Book 2, pp. 21 and 94. The land that anchors the middle of the volume, standing in a woman's name because the man whose name it should have carried had ridden out in 1775 and not returned. [Ch 4 §4.4; Ch 6; Epilogue]
- **Baker DeGraffenreid's deed of trust, 20 October 1775, Guilford County, North Carolina (D).** The last instrument on which he is documented alive — the near edge of the four-year silence the volume keeps open. [Ch 2; Ch 3 §3.1]
- **Gideon Johnson Jr.'s deed of attorney, 19 December 1783 (D).** Establishes the household's post-war legal footing in the

Rockingham/Guilford country. Genealogical texture in the keeping chapter.
[Ch 6]

IV. County court order books and administrative records

- **Lunenburg County Order Book 14, p. 38 (D).** Records Sarah Vass DeGraffenreid acting as administratrix of Baker's estate by 10 September 1779 — the far edge of the four-year not-knowing. The single most-cited administrative instrument in the volume. [Ch 3; Ch 4; Epilogue]
- **Lunenburg County Order Books, 1775-1794 (multiple volumes) (D/P).** Carry Tscharner DeGraffenreid's standing in county affairs across the period, including his elevation to Justice of Lunenburg County, 1781-1783. [Ch 3; Ch 5 §5.7; Ch 6]

V. Revolutionary War military and pension records

- **Gideon Johnson Jr. — pension file S4456 (D).** Establishes his service as a Private in the 2nd North Carolina Continental Line under Captains Armstrong and Gates and Colonels Alexander and Martin, 1776-1777, terminated some nine months before the November 1779 wedding by date arithmetic against the file. The instrument behind the volume's central question — whether his service was understood, that morning, as concluded, paused, or continuing. [Ch 4; Ch 5; Ch 6]
- **Vincent DeGraffenreid — pension file R.2845 (D/P).** The brother's war. References roughly seven years' Continental service; the named engagements are Brandywine (September 1777), Stony Point (July 1779), Guilford Court House (March 1781), and Yorktown (October 1781). The substitute enlistment at Lunenburg in January 1777, at age fourteen, and the full muster-roll trail and discharge are partly open (see XIV, ODQ-V2-03). The spine of Chapter 5. [Ch 5 throughout]
- **2nd North Carolina Continental Line muster rolls, 1779-1781 (S; open retrieval).** Would fix whether Gideon served in the southern campaign in the gap before or after the wedding, and would pin Vincent's company composition. Named as a retrieval target, not yet in hand. [Ch 4; Ch 5]

VI. Lineage-society (DAR) references

- **Anton Tscharner DeGraffenreid — DAR Patriot A031346 (D).** The Bible keeper; recognized patriot service; Justice of Lunenburg County, 1781-1783. [Ch 1; Ch 3; Ch 5 §5.7; Ch 6]
- **Gideon Johnson Jr. — DAR Patriot A063204 (D).** The heroine's husband; Private, 2nd North Carolina Continental Line. Corroborates pension file S4456. [Ch 4; Ch 5; Ch 6]
- **Reynolds A097611 patriline reference, National Society DAR (P).** Carries open documentary questions on the Rorie collateral material that

touches Volume II at the closing pages of Chapter 6 and is carried forward to Volume III. [Ch 6; forward to Vol III]

VII. Census schedules

- **United States Census, 1790 — Rockingham County, North Carolina, and Lunenburg County, Virginia (S).** Contextual for household composition in the keeping chapter's early span. The volume's action is largely earlier than the first federal enumeration; the schedule supplies texture, not anchors. [Ch 6]

VIII. Vital records, death dates, and burial

- **Mary Baker DeGraffenreid Johnson — death, January 1823, Williamson County, Tennessee (P).** Age fifty-eight. The family records disagree by six days: Chadwell gives 1 January, the Reynolds line 7 January. The volume holds both. Her own death entry was made in another hand of the line. [Interlude — The Keeping Forward; Epilogue]
- **Anton Tscharner DeGraffenreid — death, second week of February 1794, Lunenburg County, Virginia (D/P).** Age seventy-one; exact day and cause unrecorded; buried in the family ground beside the elder Mary Baker. The closing image of the volume turns on this death. [Ch 6 §6.6, §6.7]
- **Elder Mary Baker DeGraffenreid — death, ca. 1756 (P; primary record pending).** Tscharner's first wife and the heroine's namesake-grandmother, who died young — long before the heroine's 1764 birth, making the namesake a figure of record rather than of memory. The figure "7 June 1773" carried in early drafting was a false precision on a wrong year and was corrected. A primary death record is wanted. [Ch 1; Ch 2 §2.3; Ch 6 reconciliation]
- **Family burying-ground, Lunenburg County (D, by use).** The ground holding the elder Mary Baker's stone, where the child meets the Bible in Chapter 2, and where Tscharner is buried beside her in 1794. [Ch 2 §2.3; Ch 6]

IX. Manuscript collections and archival repositories

- **East Carolina University — DeGraffenreid Association Collection, Manuscript Collection 0796 (S; retrieval target).** Holds related family materials. Named as the principal repository for settling the Bible's eighteenth-century custody chain and the descendant custody of the surviving Bible (see XIV, ODQ-V2-06). [Ch 6; Epilogue]

X. Published primary and genealogical sources

- **Thomas P. de Graffenried, *History of the de Graffenried Family from 1191 A.D. to 1925* (1925) (S).** Transcribes the relevant fly-leaf entries and supplies the Prince George County settlement note behind the "ca. 1750"

death estimate for Christopher VI. The volume treats it as a transcribing-and-tradition source, not a primary instrument, and corrects it where primary records (the Baker and Chancey wills) supply what it lacked. [Bridge; Ch 1; Ch 6]

XI. Scholarly and contextual secondary sources

- **Revolutionary War campaign histories (S).** Period military context for Chapter 5: the September 1777 engagement at Brandywine; Anthony Wayne's night bayonet assault on Stony Point, 15-16 July 1779; Guilford Court House, March 1781; and the Yorktown surrender, October 1781. Used for the war as it arrived to the household and the soldier, in fragments, not as campaign narrative. [Ch 5; Ch 3 interludes]
- **North Carolina and the ratification of the federal Constitution (S).** Context for the Chapter 6 interlude — the state's refusal at Hillsborough in 1788 and ratification at Fayetteville in 1789, arriving at the household as news. [Ch 6 — Interlude: The Constitution in North Carolina]

XII. Narrative-craft calibration models

- **Erik Larson, *The Devil in the White City* (S).** Narrative-nonfiction calibration model — the discipline of telling documented history at close range without invention.
- **The novels of Sarah J. Maas (S).** Close-third heroine-voice calibration model — the somatic, interior-counting register tuned to the volume's documentary discipline and its women's ages.
- *****I Am Coming*, Volume I, and its planning document (S).**** The prior volume's voice and discipline, carried forward intact: the Bridge draws Barbara's close-third from Volume I Chapter 6; the historian's middle distance is modeled on Volume I Chapter 4; the heroine's and the soldier's close-third are modeled on Volume I Chapters 5 and 6; the Epilogue is modeled on the Volume I Epilogue.

XIII. Project working files

- **Searcy Family Ancestral Workbook, v7.11 (D, canonical).** The project's consolidated genealogical reference — every named ancestor, vital date, place, and kinship, calendar-verified. Cited at every chapter as the canon against which drafting is reconciled.
- **Volume II planning document (`vol2\_planning\_v1\_2`) and the voice-architecture addendum.** The governing plan: the heroine, the question, the closing image, the through-line phrase, the architecture, the forbidden-words discipline, and the compression principle.
- **Direction memos, jumping-off points, and per-section audit memos (Sessions 01-45).** The working record of how each section was set, drafted, and audited against canon and voice.

- **The reconciliation instruments — the Chapter 6 reconciliation docket and the Bible-provenance reconciliation memo.** Where the drafted chapters' disagreements with the record and with each other were tracked and resolved to a single canon.

XIV. Open documentary questions

Named openly so they are held openly and not papered over. Numbered as they were carried through drafting.

- **ODQ-V2-01 — Where did Baker DeGraffenreid die, and on what date?** Family tradition (Reynolds): "killed at the outset of the Revolutionary War." Last documented alive 20 October 1775 (Guilford County deed of trust); Sarah Vass operating as administratrix by 10 September 1779 (Lunenburg Order Book 14 p. 38). The four-year window is the volume's central kept silence. Retrieval targets: Guilford County, NC; Pittsylvania and Henry Counties, VA — probate, deed, and county-court records, 1775–1779. Affects Chapters 2, 3, 4, 6.
- **ODQ-V2-02 — Did Gideon Johnson Jr. serve between his February 1779 discharge and the November 1779 wedding, or after it?** Pension file S4456 establishes 1776–1777 service; the nine-month gap before the wedding and the southern campaign opening immediately after are open. Retrieval targets: 2nd NC Line muster rolls 1779–1781; Rockingham County militia records; pension-file supplements. Affects Chapters 4, 5, 6.
- **ODQ-V2-03 — Vincent DeGraffenreid's full enlistment history and discharge date.** Pension file R.2845 references roughly seven years and names four engagements; the full muster-roll trail and his return to Lunenburg are not yet documented. Retrieval targets: Continental Line muster rolls 1777–1783; Lunenburg County return-of-veteran records. Affects Chapter 5 centrally.
- **ODQ-V2-06 — The Bible's custody chain across the eighteenth century, and Christopher VI's death date.** Christopher VI to Tschärner (the volume commits to October 1742, against the 1925 *History's* soft "ca. 1750"); Tschärner to Mary Baker in 1794 rests on the structural fact of the family — Baker twenty years dead with no grave, his daughter the one to keep the record — rather than on a documented transfer. Retrieval targets: ECU DeGraffenreid Association Collection (MC 0796); the 1925 *History's* manuscript sources; a Prince George County, VA, will/probate or land-record search. Affects Chapter 6 and the Epilogue.
- **Lucretia Townes' status in 1785** — living, and at Lunenburg? — needed to set the Chapter 6 opening's household composition; non-blocking.
- **A primary death record for the elder Mary Baker** — to firm the ca. 1756 estimate and decide whether a day can be asserted; non-blocking.
- **Certified-copy firm-up of the Henry Baker (1739) and Edmund Chancey (1753) wills, and photographic inspection of the surviving Bible fly-leaf** — carried from the Volume I open items; non-blocking.

Compiled at the close of the Volume II draft, Session 45. The bibliography is a working document: as the open questions in section XIV are answered, the entries they touch are revised, and the answers are folded into the chapters they affect.

— DLS

Volume III — She Held the Line, 1832 to 1920

Master reference for all chapters of Volume III; living document; updated as sources surface. v1, 21 July 2026 — consolidated at the close of the Volume III v3.0 draft (Chapters 1 through 9). Drawn from the per-chapter Notes on Sources and reconciled to the project's research findings (the slave-schedule reads, the probate and deed sweeps, the death-certificate zoom, the 1870 record-first census work). Where the earlier working drafts and the finished manuscript disagree, the manuscript governs and the discrepancy is logged in section XII. The pre-13-July "consolidated" master draft is void as a source; see XII.

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This document is the consolidated working bibliography for *I Am Coming*, Volume III — *She Held the Line: The Dirt Stayed, the World Moved, 1832 to 1920*. It is organized by source category, not by chapter. Each source is listed once, even where it bears on several chapters; the bracketed chapter references at the end of each entry show where it is used. The reader-facing Bibliography at the back of the published book will be drawn from this list and styled to publication standard at manuscript-assembly stage. Until then, this is a working file kept current as research proceeds.

Every entry carries a tier mark on the convention used throughout the project's Sources Memos. **P** — a primary document of the period, contemporary or near-contemporary to the event. **S** — a secondary source compiling or analyzing primary records at one remove. **R** — a standard reference work used for period, place, or practice. **T** — a family-line oral or written tradition. Where a fact rests on more than one instrument the entry says so; where it rests on a single soft estimate the entry says that too. Two disciplines govern the whole: *genealogy first, story second*, and *the blank does not stay blank; neither does the negative* — a negative finding counts only when the pages have actually been read, not when an index came back empty. The open research items are gathered at the end, in section XII.

I. The family Bibles and the keeping-records

- **The Rorie family Bible (P).** The book the volume turns on: the worn black-calf Bible Mary Polly Hubbard Rorie kept for more than thirty years and carried, a widow, into her son's house in her own lap. Its register pages are the family's primary self-record. The births-and-marriages leaf enters the heroine, on the day she was born, under the unsettled name **"Milbry or Mity Jane"** (21 November 1832); it carries the marriages of the two elder daughters — Elizabeth (1834) and Louisa Adeline to Alexander Houston (1838) — but no line for Mary Jane's own 1867 marriage, the founding of the line, which was never entered. The deaths page, in Mary Polly's careful round hand, records her husband Reuben (August 1862) and her son Ezekiah, **"killed July 22nd 1864 in Atlanta, Georgia"*** — her last entry

there; the column stops at the war and holds no death after, including her own. Transcriptions of the register pages are held in the workbook (XI). A photographic inspection of the surviving leaves is an open item (XII). [Ch 1 §Seventeen; Ch 3; Ch 4; Ch 5; Ch 6 §The unwritten line; Ch 9]

- **The Hubbard family Bible (P/S).** Mary Polly's own people's book, "brought down out of North Carolina before any of them were born," set on the parlor shelf beside the Rorie Bible. The Johnson-to-Hubbard descent that carries the line back into Volume II's world; principally a genealogical anchor, named in the prose to keep the two books distinct. [Ch 9]
- **Aaron Searcy's working Bible (T/P).** The smaller leather Bible in the old satchel — "the little satchel the old man had carried his keeping in" — Freeman's father's book, kept on the same shelf and handed to Robert Edwin at the last. Family-tradition object; its contents are not transcribed in hand. [Ch 9]

II. Federal population census schedules — Tishomingo, then Alcorn County, Mississippi

- **1850 U.S. Census, Seventh Census (P).** Tishomingo Co., 4th District, Northern Division; assistant marshal **Wm. Scruggs**; enumerated 31 October 1850. Dwelling **751**: Reuben Rora, 51, millwright, N.C., real estate \$2,000; Mary [Polly], recorded 40 (about 46); the children, among them **Mary [Jane], 17**; Nancy, 15; with the married daughter Louisa Adeline next door (752) and Wm. H. Rora, 21, *Student* (754). **Nine dwellings on, 760**: the Aaron Searcy household — Aaron, 53, farmer, N.C.; Martha; and **Freeman, 20** — real estate read at \$400 (author-certified). The one census that recorded Mary Jane's age truthfully. [Ch 1]
- **1860 U.S. Census, Eighth Census (P).** Tishomingo Co.; assistant marshal **Porter Walker**; Jacinto post office; the household enumerated in the late summer. Dwelling **1542**: the head recorded **"William Roria," 60** — *the documented mis-recording of Reuben Rorie, wrong in both name-halves; Mary [Polly] 55 (correct); Mary J. written 25 against her true 27; Nancy A. 22 against ~24 — both unmarried daughters shaved two years while both parents stand correct; Reuben's worth ~\$5,000. Dwelling 1543: W. H. Rorie's household. In the same continuous run, dwelling 1505: Freeman Searcy, 30, day-labourer, no estate, boarding in his brother William B. Searcy's house — one door past dwelling 1504, Alexander Houston and Louisa Adeline Rorie*, Mary Jane's married sister.* [Ch 3; Ch 5]
- **1870 U.S. Census, Ninth Census (P).** Alcorn Co., **Township 2 Range 8**, post office Corinth; enumerated 2 September 1870; NARA M593. The white anchor: **Wm. Rorie** (indexed "Mn Rorie"), 42, Tennessee, page 25, dwelling 16, FamilySearch image 266 of 277 (film 004273773). **Freeman Searcy** at page 26, dwelling 25 — Freeman 38 (b. Alabama), Mary 37, a son ~3, **Robert 4/12** (Robert Edwin, born January 1870), and Rebecca 9. Read at image level, 21 July 2026: dwellings 11-26 across pages 24-26 all read

White — no Black household of the freed Rorie people on the old ground.
[Ch 5; Ch 7; and the freedpeople findings, VIII]

- **1880 U.S. Census, Tenth Census (P).** Alcorn Co., Third District; enumerated 5 June 1880 (enumerator J. M. Bynum). Mary Jane's household at page 5, dwelling 2, indexed "Cearcy F. J." (Mary Jane misindexed "**H. J.**"); Mary Polly six pages away, page 11, enumerated as *"**mother**,"* age 75, inside the W. J. Hamlin household — already given up her own farm. (The old "two doors apart" reading is refuted; see `Vol\_III\_Two\_Doors\_RESOLVED\_v1\_0.md`.) [Ch 8]
- **1900 / 1910 / 1920 U.S. Censuses, Twelfth-Fourteenth (P).** The three post-1900 counts, each carrying Mary Jane's birthplace as **Tennessee**: 1900 at the wife-line near Rienzi; 1910 (Milam beat) with Mary Jane enumerated in Robert Edwin's household, *Relationship to head: Mother*, age 77; **1920** (Beat 3, ED 6; enumerated 17 January 1920, Frank D. Oaks) with Mary Jane "**mother, age 87**" — her own household giving 87 nine months before her death, against Robert Edwin's 50 and Hattie's 43. Digital images: `Milam\_Mary Rorie Searcy wife of Freeman\_1910AlcornMS.pdf`, `...\_1920AlcornMS.pdf`. [Ch 7; Ch 8; Ch 9]

III. Federal slave schedules — Schedule 2, Slave Inhabitants

- **1850 Slave Schedule, Tishomingo County (P).** FamilySearch IGN **004200553** (*Seventh Census, Slave Inhabitants, Mississippi, Vol. 7*). Read at image level, both divisions, 13 July 2026: **Reuben Rorie held no one; Aaron Searcy held no one; no Rorie or Searcy of any spelling appears.** Scruggs certified his own eleven filled pages (image 18); Lewallen's Southern Division closed at the county boundary (image 32 = Tunica) and by the volume's table-of-contents arithmetic. A **total certified negative** — the strongest kind, because the marshal who wrote Reuben into the free schedule (Scruggs) wrote nothing for him on this one. The consequence is the spine of the rebuild: the three people counted in 1860 arrived across the 1850s, so **Mary Jane watched slavery arrive on the place** between seventeen and twenty-seven; and a slave house was raised in the yard in that window. Also logged: Porter Walker himself held two people in 1850 (Southern Division, image 31); two Hubbard slaveholders in the county (Thomas Hubbard, img. 20; Thomas B. Hubbard, img. 31). [Ch 2 §The house in the yard; Ch 3 §3.1–3.2; Ch 5 §5.3]
- **1860 Slave Schedule, Tishomingo County (P).** FamilySearch IGN **005170183**, ark 3:1:33S7-9BSH-PKG, image 386 of 636. **Page 42**, right column, entered *"**Reubin Roria**," *enumerated 22 September 1860 by Porter Walker, between Andrew Cathey and Josiah Vanderford — three enslaved people: a woman aged 65, a man aged 36, a girl aged 7; and, in column 9, one slave house. Confirmed at zoom by the author, 13 July 2026 (the man's age corrected from a first-pass 30 to 36). The whole schedule (66 pages) read; no Searcy anywhere; the one enslaved name in all 66 pages is Charlotte*, aged 100, on Mary Watson's line (not of this place). Part of the*

~\$5,000 personal worth was therefore the appraised value of three human beings — a figure the book will not describe as capital alone. [Ch 2; Ch 3 §3.1-3.2; Ch 5 §5.3]

IV. Vital records

- **Mississippi marriage record — F. J. Searcy and "Miss M. J. Rorie" (P).** 10 January 1867; indexed under Alcorn County, though the county was still Tishomingo on that date (Alcorn created 15 April 1870). Ages: Mary Jane 34 (b. 21 Nov 1832), Freeman 36 (b. ~1830). The clerk's **"Miss"** — an unmarried woman of thirty-four marrying under her maiden name, out of a dead father's house — is the load-bearing word; the marriage was never entered in the family Bible. A licence-or-bond behind the index line is an open item (XII). [Ch 6]
- **Mississippi State Certificate of Death #20-18119 — Mary Jane Searcy (P).** The single strongest instrument of the closing chapter; read at full zoom by the author, 21 July 2026, correcting several earlier transcription errors. Certified facts: name field **"Mary Jane Searcy"** (given name whole for the first time in the record; her maiden Rorie survives only on the father's line); **date of death 11 October 1920, 4:30 a.m.**; cause **"paralysis"** — a lay report, because **the medical section carries no physician's signature ("No Doctor," and "What test confirmed diagnosis? — No")**; father Reuben Rorie, mother Mary Hubbard, birthplace Tennessee (three Tennessee attestations, closing the long birthplace question in favor of the Tennessee side); **undertaker line: "no undertaker — homemade coffin"** (correcting a prior misreading of the field as an undertaker named "Conrad Coffin" — there was none); **place of burial Pine Grove**; date of burial 12 October; informant **R. E. Searcy** (son), age 50; **filed 16 October** by the local registrar. The state's age figure, *87 years, 10 months, 6 days*, is fourteen days short of the household's true count (*87 years, 10 months, 20 days*), the "state said six, household said twenty, household was right" beat. [Ch 9]

V. Land, deeds, and the estate partition (PLSS: township / range / section)

- **Commissioner's deed — Freeman Searcy buys part of Reuben Rorie's homestead (P).** At the heirs' partition sale, 18 January 1867, *"at the late residence of the said R. Rorie deceased,"* eight days after the wedding: F. J. Searcy the high bidder for part of **Section 18, Township 3 Range 8 East** (the E½ NE¼ and NE¼ of SE¼) for **\$265**; commissioner's deed executed 19 April 1867. Documents where the couple settled — the old Rorie ground — and anchors the volume's Governing Frame (buys the land 1867, the county line moves 1870, the family stays).
`Vol\_III\_Deed\_Findings\_Freeman\_buys\_Rorie\_land\_v1\_0.md`. Load-bearing digits (\$265; Sec 18, T3 R8 E; the dates) await final certification at the image zoom (XII); the substance is confirmed. [Ch 6 §The ground; Ch 7; Ch 9]

- **The partition proceeding — Probate Court of Tishomingo County (P).** November 1866 term: petition of **W. H. Rorie and the heirs of R. Rorie deceased** to sell their father's land for division; B. B. Boone appointed special commissioner; the land sold 18 January 1867. A partition of real property — not an administration of the personal estate — and, being post-emancipation, it names no enslaved people. The precise finding: *Reuben's personal estate was never administered; his land was partitioned and sold by court order on the heirs' petition, four years after his death*. Companion partition buyers: Wm. Walker and W. H. Rorie. [Ch 5; Ch 6]
- **Reuben Rorie's mill-building deeds, ~1838-1861 (P).** The record of the grist-and-saw works assembled deed by deed on the creek — the trade that made the \$2,000 of 1850 and part of the worth of 1860. Optional Chapter 1 texture. [Ch 1]
- **Freeman Searcy's later Rorie purchase — Section 17, 1888 (P).** 47 acres, \$50, out of W. H. Rorie's foreclosure (split with W. F. Jobe). Freeman consolidating the old Rorie ground; flagged as Volume IV texture, noted here for completeness. [—]

VI. Probate and estate records

- **Tishomingo County Inventories & Appraisements, 1858-1869 (P).** FamilySearch **IGN 005815305** (261 images). Full-text and structural read, 14 July 2026: **there is no estate of Reuben Rorie in the book** (a strong index-class negative — the search that found "Reuben Rorie decd" buried mid-line in a debtor column would have found an estate heading). He appears once, as a debt owed to a dead man: **Neal Morrison's inventory, p. 292, "Reuben Rorie decd 1862,"* sworn 9 August 1864*. Mary Polly filed nothing** — no widow's year's-support, no dower, no administration. This is the finding on which Chapter 5's moral spine rests: the estate was never administered, so no inventory ever named the three enslaved people; the same competence that let a widow carry the farm without the court is why their names are lost. `Vol\_III\_Probate\_Findings\_v1\_0.md`. [Ch 5 §5.2-5.3]
- **Estate of Ezekiah B. Rorie ("E. B. Rorie") (P).** Opened 1865 for his minor children (Mary A. and Robert E.). The surviving inventory is of **money and debts**: gold on hand \$20; silver; old-issue money; **a claim on J. F. W. Rorie** (settled in cotton money), \$50; **an account with W. H. Rorie** (to be paid in Confederate money); and a probated account against the estate of Mary Morrison. The line that is the truest thing the war wrote about the brothers — both surviving brothers owed the dead one, in currencies that died with the country. The property appraisal of Ezekiah's \$2,000 farm is still to be found (same volume). [Ch 4 §The one who did not come back]
- **The Will Book — old Tishomingo & Alcorn, 1854-1921 (P).** One film spanning Reuben, Mary Polly, and Freeman; the last realistic instrument that could name the three enslaved people by devise. Search under R (Rorie / Rora / Roria / Roary / Rorey) and the given name Reuben. Status: unsearched in this cycle. Companion decisive test: the **Probate Court Minute Books**

(was administration ever granted on Reuben's estate?) — indexed by term, does not ride on OCR. Both are open (XII). [Ch 5; open]

VII. *Military and Civil War records*

- **Confederate enlistment and death — Ezekiah B. Rorie (P/S).** Enlisted at **Kossuth**, March 1862, about thirty-one, a married man with ~\$2,000 in land and small children; **killed near Atlanta, 22 July 1864** — the date of the Battle of Atlanta, fought on the east side of the city. The death rests on the Rorie Bible (I) and the estate (VI); "east of Atlanta" is the historical identification of that battle laid over the Bible's plainer "Atlanta, Georgia." His regiment is not separately pinned. [Ch 4]
- **Confederate service — William Hubbard Rorie (S/T).** Survived and returned; named sons for the Confederate generals **Joseph E. Johnston** (Jas. E. J.) and **Robert E. Lee** (Robt. E. L.) — the documented evidence of his allegiance and service. **His specific regiment is unconfirmed (the 26th Mississippi question) and is deliberately not asserted in the prose** (see D-1, XII); the pre-collapse draft's "central Virginia, June 1865" return is void and not used. [Ch 4; open]
- **James Frederick Winters ("Fred") Rorie (S/T).** The youngest son ("J. F. W. Rorie" of the estate papers); survived, settled two beats over, raised ~seven children, named one **E. B.** for the brother who did not come home. [Ch 4]
- **Campaign context, the Shiloh-Corinth-Atlanta theater (R).** The war at the family's door, thirteen miles north: the **Battle of Shiloh** (6–7 April 1862, heard from the ridge as sustained artillery); **Corinth** as a wartime hospital/charnel town; the **Siege of Corinth** (advance April – evacuation 29–30 May 1862); the **Battle of Corinth** (3–4 October 1862); and the **Atlanta Campaign / Battle of Atlanta** (22 July 1864). Standard published campaign histories; rendered as heard/known from the ridge, not witnessed. [Ch 4]

VIII. *Slavery, the freedpeople, and the emancipation-era record*

- **The three enslaved people held by Reuben Rorie (P, via III).** A woman (b. ~1795), a man (b. ~1824), and a girl (b. ~1853), on the place from the 1850s, with one slave house; freed off that ground in 1865. The 1850–1860 schedules fix their arrival and holding; **no instrument ever set their names down**, because the estate was never administered (VI). Record-first trace, 21 July 2026 (``Vol_III_Ch5_Freedpeople_Record_First_Findings_v1_0.md``): the surname-blind 1870 index does not hold them under Rorie or Searcy, and the households on the old ground read White — so they did not remain as the family's neighbors; the earliest their names could exist is 1870, and the reachable record does not keep them. They are owed their own accounting, in their own right, and are not made anyone's metaphor (the standing rule, adopted 13 July 2026). [Ch 5 §5.3; and Ch 2, Ch 3]

- **Corinth Contraband Camp (S/R).** National Park Service; *Corinth: The Story of a Contraband Camp*. Formed east of Corinth after the Preliminary Emancipation Proclamation (22 September 1862) under Brig. Gen. Grenville M. Dodge and Chaplain James M. Alexander; at its peak **over 6,000 freedpeople**, with a church, hospital, a street grid of numbered houses, ~400 acres worked for wages, and an American Missionary Association school; residents removed by rail to camps near Memphis, January 1864. Thirteen miles from the Rorie place; rendered strictly as regional **setting**, with no claim that any of the three went there. [Ch 5 §5.3]
- **Freedmen's Bureau and Freedmen's Bank, Mississippi (P) — open.** Labor contracts, marriage and ration registers, bank records for Alcorn / Tishomingo / Corinth, 1865–72; the freedom-side records that might name people the census surname-blinds. Not yet pulled (XII). [open]

IX. Cemetery and burial

- **Pine Grove — place of burial per the 1920 death certificate (P).** The certificate (IV), in the son's own information, gives **Pine Grove** as the place of burial, 12 October 1920. This is the primary, contemporaneous authority for where the family laid her. [Ch 9]
- **Hargrove Cemetery and the headstone (S/T) — in conflict, open.** The workbook and a 1987 replacement headstone place Mary Jane (and Freeman, d. 1908) at **Hargrove Cemetery**. The primary certificate says Pine Grove; the marker says Hargrove. The discrepancy — same ground under two names, a later reinterment, or a marker error — is unreconciled and belongs to the genealogy side (XII). (*A separate 1860-slave-schedule figure, "William Hargrave," once anchored an editorial note about ground named for a slaveholder; with the burial reading Pine Grove, that note is retired.*) [Ch 9; open]

X. Reference works, and period / place context

- **The Public Land Survey System (R).** Township / range / section descriptions; the frame within which the Rorie and Searcy parcels (Sec 18, Sec 17, T2/T3 R8) are located. Distinguish deed (title) from census (residence). [Land entries; Ch 6, Ch 7]
- **County formation and geography (R).** **Alcorn County created 15 April 1870** from Tishomingo and Tippah — the ground that did not move while the county's name did (the Governing Frame). **Corinth** established 1853 where the Mobile & Ohio crossed the Memphis & Charleston (first "Cross City," renamed for the ancient Greek crossroads); **Rienzi** and **Beat 3** as the family's post-1870 locality; **Kossuth** and **Jacinto** as the near towns of the muster and the 1860 post office. Published county and railroad histories. [Ch 2; Ch 4; frame]

XI. Family tradition and the workbook

- **The Searcy Family Ancestral Workbook (T/master).**
`Searcy\_Family\_Ancestral\_Workbook\_v7\_11.xlsx` — DeWayne Lee Searcy's compiled family canon: the thirty-plus sheets of dates, relationships, transcriptions, and prior conclusions against which every documentary finding in this volume is reconciled. The source of record for the Bible transcriptions (I) and the canonical dates, and the place where discrepancies (the Pine Grove / Hargrove question; the shaved-ages certification; the deed digits) are logged for closure. [all chapters]
- **Family tradition (T).** The oral and written line: the Rorie descent off the Yadkin in North Carolina and down through Tennessee; the birthplace "on the Tennessee side"; and the governing refrain the volume takes its shape from — *the dirt is the dirt; it was the world that moved*. Rendered as tradition where it is not on a document, and never in place of one. [frame; Ch 6; Ch 9]

XII. Open research items

Carried in the numbered / lettered form they hold in the project's continuity memo (`vol3\_state\_memo.md`, §C/§D). The volume is drafted end to end; these are certification and extension items, not gates.

1. **D-1 — William Hubbard Rorie's Confederate regiment** (the 26th Mississippi question). Chapter 4 was drafted *around* it (service present, no unit asserted); fold the regiment in with a one-pass edit if it resolves. [Ch 4]

2. **D-4 — Mary Polly Hubbard Rorie's death year, 1890 or 1892.** The hinge of Chapter 8; Alcorn land-tax rolls 1889–1892 (assessed while alive, gone after) are the likely closer.

3. **The Pine Grove ↔ Hargrove burial reconciliation** (Mary Jane and Freeman): certificate vs. headstone. [Ch 9]

4. **The freedpeople, past 1870** (§VIII): the full Township 2 Range 8 district color-column read; the 1880 census on the same ground; the Freedmen's Bureau and Freedmen's Bank; and, separately, the **non-white Searcy count** in 1870 Mississippi mapped against 1860 Searcy slaveholders statewide.

5. **Deed and estate digits to certify at the image:** the 1867 commissioner's deed (\$265; Sec 18, T3 R8 E; dates) and the 1870 estate figure (~\$1,050); Ezekiah's property appraisal.

6. **The Will Book and the Probate Court Minute Books** (§VI): the last instruments that could name the three enslaved people, and the decisive yes/no on whether administration was ever granted on Reuben's estate.

7. **Reuben's estate inventory, August 1862** — confirmed **not to exist** in the Inventory Book; the Minute-Books test would seal the negative permanently.

8. **Aaron Searcy's death year** (enumerated alive 1850, gone by 1860 — left undated in Chapter 2); the **possible seventh Searcy child** ("E D, 1850"); the **Aaron #32 parentage / which-Aaron War-of-1812** question (contested —

NARA register-reverse and Chatham estate pending; the three-war echo is left unspelled until it resolves).

9. **Nancy Ann Rorie** — did the second unmarried daughter ever marry?

10. **The 1867 marriage licence or bond** behind the index line (§IV).

11. **Photographic inspection of the Rorie Bible leaves** (§I).

12. **`Vol\_III\_consolidated.md` is VOID** — the pre-13-July-2026 master draft, built on the founding frame the records voided (the Corinth-residence death; the invented figures "Mary E. / Lucinda / Patsy"; the "Dr. Reed" attendance and "Conrad Coffin" undertaker of the misread certificate; Hargrove burial). It is superseded entirely by Architecture v2.0 and the v3.0 chapters and is not to be drafted or cited from.